AN ANALYSIS OF CONTROVERTED TOPICS

Second Edition

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1) 1 Samuel 13:1 and the preservation of the Hebrew Text

When I was a new student in my ThM program, one of the prime movers in the Majority Text vineyard was in his last year, and we worked together in the Seminary kitchen. Our tongues wagged about as fast as our hands moved; we did a lot of talking, mostly about things text-critical and theological. In those pristine years, he was a firm believer in the divine preservation of both the Hebrew and Greek Testaments, to the letter. In due time I came to Brazil as a missionary, and he continued in his teaching career. Every furlough (back then field terms were usually five years) I would touch base with him and compare notes. On one of those occasions (I forget which one), when the subject of divine preservation came up, he opened a Bible to 1 Samuel 13:1 and affirmed that the original wording of that verse had been irretrievably lost—bye-bye preservation.

Well now, what he did to me, someone else had done to him, and so on into the night. I rather imagine that this verse has come to represent a difficulty in the thinking of not a few people who would like to believe in the divine preservation of the Text, but…. Since I still believed in preservation at that time (and continue to do so), his gesture gave me pause—could he possibly be correct? So I sat down and studied the situation (including an inquiry to the local synagogue). Here is my conclusion.

The NKJV renders 1 Samuel 13:1-2 like this: "Saul reigned one year; and when he had reigned two years over Israel, Saul chose for himself three thousand men of Israel. Two thousand were with Saul in Michmash and in the mountains of Bethel, and a thousand were with Jonathan in Gibeah of Benjamin. The rest of the people he sent away, every man to his tent." In the NIV the first verse is quite different: "Saul was

[thirty] years old when he became king, and he reigned over Israel [forty-] two years." A footnote informs the reader that the bracketed words are not in the Hebrew Text. An uninitiated layperson who compares the two could easily conclude that they are translating completely different texts, but such is not the case. The Hebrew text is one, without variants—the problem lies in the interpretation.

An interlinear, morpheme by morpheme, rendering of the first verse looks like this: "Son-of-a-year Saul in-his-reigning and-two years he-reigned over-Israel" (except, of course, that Hebrew is read from right to left). The confusion arises in that this became a formula used in the summary statement about a king's reign: a son of X years was Y in his reigning (= when he began to reign), and he reigned Z years … The formula usually occurs at the end of a king's history, but sometimes at the beginning. Of course, any attempt to apply the formula in 1 Samuel 13:1 is ridiculous. Obviously Saul could not have been one year old when he began to reign, and just as obviously he reigned more than two years. Unfortunately, NIV and others have insisted on imposing the formula on this verse, inventing the 'thirty' and 'forty-' so as not to have complete nonsense. (This also has the unfortunate effect of contradicting Acts 13:21, that affirms that Saul reigned 40 years, not 42.) I suppose they have convinced themselves that the original numbers have disappeared from the Text, having been irretrievably lost during the process of transmission.

But let us look carefully at the context of 13:1. To begin, Saul being the very first king of Israel, such a formula would not yet be in use—there had been no occasion to write of the beginning and length of reigns. Then, in the context this is not the place for a summary statement; it is neither the beginning nor the end of the history of Saul's reign. In 1 Samuel 10:24 he was publicly installed as king—since he was the first, there

was no precedent, no established procedure. In Chapter 11 Saul defeats the Ammonites and is confirmed in the kingship (verse 15). In chapter 12 Samuel defends his ministry and gives a lesson in history. Chapter 13 resumes Saul's story and starts by saying when he established a standing army—in the second year of his reign.

I invite special attention to the concluding statement of verse two, "The rest of the people he sent away, every man to his tent." To be 'sent away' they had to be there. Be where? In Gilgal (11:15), where Samuel's discourse (chapter 12) also took place, as part of the occasion. According to 11:9, Saul had mobilized 330,000 men against the Ammonites, and I imagine that most of them had accompanied Samuel and Saul to Gilgal. So 13:1-2 is a continuation of what happened at Gilgal, and verse one **CANNOT** be a summary statement about Saul's total reign. Of the 330,000 that had been mobilized against Ammon, Saul chose 3,000 to be a standing army and sent the rest home. Perhaps the lack of a standing army had encouraged the Ammonites to get frisky; the news that Israel now had one would serve as a deterrent.

I take the point of 13:1 to be that Saul had a full year behind him, so these events at Gilgal took place during his second year. Hebrew is not my forte, but I would paraphrase our verse something like this, "Saul had reigned for a full year over Israel, and it was during his second year that he chose for himself three thousand men…"

I reject as unfounded the allegation that some of the original wording of 1 Samuel 13:1 has been lost. The NIV does a considerable disservice to the Kingdom of God here.

2) Abiathar is not Ahimelech

Mark 2:26 X 1 Samuel 21:1

Some of my readers may be aware that this verse has destroyed the faith of at least one scholar in our day, although

he was reared in an evangelical home. He understood Jesus to be saying that Abiathar was the priest with whom David dealt, when in fact it was his father, Ahimelech. If Jesus stated an historical error as fact, then he could not be God. So he turned his back on Jesus. I consider that his decision was lamentable and unnecessary, and in the interest of helping others who may be troubled by this verse, I offer the following explanation:

> "How he entered the house of God (making Abiathar high priest) and ate the consecrated bread, which only priests are permitted to eat, and shared it with those who were with him."

My rendering is rather different than the 'in the days of Abiathar the high priest' of the AV, NKJV and NIV. We are translating three Greek words that very literally would be 'upon Abiathar high-priest' (but the preposition here, επι, is the most versatile of the Greek prepositions, and one of its many meanings/uses is 'toward'—the standard lexicon, BDAG, lists fully eighteen areas of meaning, quite apart from sub-divisions). When we go back to the Old Testament account, we discover that David actually conversed with Ahimelech, Abiathar's father, who was the high priest at that moment (1 Samuel 21:1-9). Within a few days Saul massacred Ahimelech and 84 other priests (1 Samuel 22:16-18), but his son Abiathar escaped and went to David, taking the ephod with him (1 Samuel 22:20-23; 23:6). That David could use it to inquire of the LORD rather suggests that it had to be the ephod that only the high priest wore, since only that ephod had the Urim and Thummim (1 Samuel 23:9-12; cf. Numbers 27:21, Ezra 2:63).

That ephod was to a high priest like the crown was to a king; so how could Abiathar have it? The Text states that David's visit filled Ahimelech with fear, presumably because he too saw Doeg the Edomite and figured what would

happen. Now why wasn't Abiathar taken with the others? I suggest that Ahimelech foresaw what would happen (Doeg probably took off immediately, and Ahimelech figured he would not have much time), so he deliberately consecrated Abiathar, gave him the ephod, and told him to hide—he probably did it that very day (once the soldiers arrived to arrest Ahimelech and the other 84, it would be too late). Abiathar escaped, but carried the news of the massacre with him; only now he was the high priest.

Putting it all together, it was David's visit that resulted in Abiathar's becoming high priest prematurely, as David himself recognized, and to which Jesus alluded in passing (which is why I used parentheses). But why would Jesus allude to that? I suppose because the Bible is straightforward about the consequences of sin, and David lied to Ahimelech. Although Jesus was using David's eating that bread as an example, He did not wish to gloss over the sin, and its consequences.

Recall that Jesus was addressing Pharisees, who were steeped in the OT Scriptures. A notorious case like Saul's massacre of 85 priests would be very well known. And of course, none of the NT had yet been written, so any understanding of what Jesus said had to be based on 1 Samuel ("Have you never read…?"). If we today wish to understand this passage, we need to place ourselves in the context recorded in Mark 2:23-28. The Pharisees would understand that if Abiathar was in possession of the ephod with the Urim and Thummim, then he was the high priest. And how did he get that way? He got that way because of David's visit. It was an immediate consequence of that visit.

Some may object that 'making' is a verb, not a preposition. Well, the 'in the days of' of the AV, etc., though not a verb, is a phrase. Both a pronoun and an adverb may stand for a phrase, and a preposition may as well. TEV and Phillips

actually use a verb: 'when… was'; NLT has 'during the days when… was'. Where the others used from two to five words, I used only one.

3) A 'crumb' for a 'puppy'

Matthew 15:21-28 and Mark 7:24-31[a].

Matthew 15:—**21**Going out from there Jesus withdrew into the region of Tyre and Sidon. **22**And then, a Canaanite wo-man coming from those parts cried out to Him saying: "Have mercy on me, Lord, Son of David! My daughter is severely demonized." **23**But He answered her not a word. So His disciples came and urged Him saying, "Send her away, because she is crying out after us". **24**But in answer He said, "I was not sent except to the lost sheep of the house of Israel".[a] **25**So she came and worshipped Him saying, "Lord, help me!" **26**But in answer He said, "It is not good to take the children's bread and throw it to the little dogs". **27**So she said, "Yes, Lord, yet even the little dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters' table". **28**Then Jesus answered and said to her: "O woman, great is your faith! Let it be to you as you desire." And her daughter was healed from that *very* hour.

Mark 7:—**24**Then He got ready and went from there into the region of Tyre and Sidon. He went into a house and did not want anyone to know it, but He could not escape notice. **25**In fact, as soon as she heard about Him, a woman whose little daughter had an unclean spirit came and fell at His feet. **26**Now the woman was a Greek, a Syro-Phoenecian by birth, and she kept asking Him to cast the demon out of her daughter. **27**But Jesus said to her, "Let

[a] Although His ultimate mission included the whole world (see the Great Commission in Matthew 28:19-20), His earthly ministry was directed to the "house of Israel".

the children be filled first; it is not good to take the children's bread and throw it to the little dogs". **28**So she answered and said to Him, "Yes, Lord, yet even the little dogs under the table eat from the children's crumbs". **29**So He said to her, "Because of this saying you may go; the demon has gone out of your daughter". **30**She went away to her house and found that the demon was gone and the daughter had been placed on the bed. **31**Again, departing from the region of Tyre and Sidon, Jesus came to the Sea of Galilee by way of the Decapolis region.

Here we have a moving account of faith, determination and humility; perhaps it will have some practical lessons for us. My discussion will attempt to follow the actual sequence of events.

1) To begin, we observe that Jesus left the Jewish Galilee and went to the Gentile Tyre and Sidon. Now why do you suppose He did that, since He would presently say, "I was not sent except to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (Matthew 15:24)? In that case, what was He doing in Tyre? Well, maybe He just wanted to get away and rest a bit; upon arriving "He went into a house and did not want anyone to know it, but He could not escape notice" (Mark 7:24). A group of thirteen foreigners would tend to attract some attention, even if they tried to keep a low profile. Still, the Text plainly says that Jesus tried to avoid being noticed. How then did the 'puppy' know that Jesus was coming before He even arrived?!

2) From Mark's account one could assume that the woman appeared after Jesus was in the house, but Matthew's account tells us something else. Notice verse 23: His disciples came and urged Him saying, "Send her away, because she is crying out after us" (Mark does say that she kept asking, verse 26). They were still on the road, and the woman was following them. Further, she addressed Him as the Jewish Messiah: a Canaanite woman coming from those parts cried out to Him

saying, “Have mercy on me, Lord, Son of David! My daughter is severely demonized” (Mathew 15:22). “Son of David”—as a Canaanite she appealed to the Jewish Messiah, upon whom she had no claim. But how did she know that? I suspect there is more to this story than meets the eye. The only explanation that I can see is that the woman received divine orientation; she was told where to go and what to say. In that event, helping that woman may have been the purpose for the trip.

3) The woman began with, “Lord, Son of David”, to which Jesus returned no answer, since she had no claim upon Him in those terms. However, since she would not stop, and did not keep her voice down, she was ‘blowing their cover’. So the disciples appealed to Jesus for relief, to which He replied, “I was not sent except to the lost sheep of the house of Israel” (Matthew 15:24). The Lord spoke loudly enough for her to hear, since His answer was as much, if not more so, for her as it was for the disciples. So she came and worshipped Him saying, “Lord, help me!” (Matthew 15:25). She got the message, because she now dropped the appeal to the Messiah. Mark 7:25 tells us that she “fell at His feet”, so either Jesus had stopped or she had run ahead so she could stop Him.

4) Now we come to an unusual conversation. Our Lord’s choice of terms would probably strike most readers as being unexpectedly harsh. “It is not good to take the children’s bread and throw it to the little dogs” (Matthew 15:26, Mark 7:27). Dear me, Jesus called her a dog (and a ‘little’ one at that)! To be sure, at that time Jews commonly referred to Gentiles as ‘dogs’, but why would Jesus follow suit? I imagine that He was testing her humility, since she had already, as I believe, received a special dispensation of grace. (One is reminded of Cornelius.) And she passed the test! So she said, “Yes, Lord, yet even the little dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters’ table” (Matthew 15:27). Big dogs would not be in the house, so these would be little house pets, or

perhaps puppies. Then Jesus answered and said to her: "O woman, great is your faith! Let it be to you as you desire. Because of this saying you may go; the demon has gone out of your daughter" (Matthew 15:28, Mark 7:29).

5) "She went away to her house and found that the demon was gone and the daughter had been placed on the bed" (Mark 7:30). The verb 'place' is perfect passive; evidently the child was too small, or too weak, to have gotten there by herself.

6) "Departing from the region of Tyre and Sidon, Jesus came to the Sea of Galilee" (Mark 7:31). We are not told whether Jesus did anything else while in that region. If not, He apparently went there just to help that woman. But why would He do something like that?—it involved time and inconvenience. Well, consider 2 Chronicles 16:9. "For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him" (NKJV). God's 'search' covers the whole earth, so is not limited to nation or place, and not to time either. Cornelius is a biblical example, but there have doubtless been many others down through history. So if you are needing some 'strong' help, here is the key—the language of the Text indicates that God is just waiting to give that help. How about another doxology!

This episode always moves me. In effect, Jesus called the woman a 'dog' (that is what Jews called Gentiles), and she accepted the classification. She was determined to get her 'crumb', and she did! And she left us a great example of humility, faith and determination!

4) A desperate woman

Matthew 9:20-22, Mark 5:24-34 and Luke 8:42^{b}-48.

Matthew 9:—**20**And then, a woman who had been hemorrhaging for twelve years came from behind and

touched the hem of His garment. [21]For she kept saying to herself, “If only I may touch His garment, I will be healed”. [22]But Jesus, turning around and seeing her, said, “Take courage, daughter; your faith has made you well”. And the woman was healed from that *very* hour.

Mark 5:—[24]A large crowd was also following Him, and they were pressing around Him. [25]Now a certain woman —who had been bleeding for twelve years, [26]and had suffered many things under many doctors, and had spent all that she had, yet instead of getting better she grew worse—[27]when she heard about Jesus, she came from behind in the crowd and touched His garment. [28](She had kept saying, “If I can just touch His clothes, I will be healed”.) [29]Immediately the flow of her blood was dried up, and she knew in her body that she was healed from the affliction. [30]And instantly Jesus perceived within Himself that some power had gone out of Him, and turning around in the crowd He said, “Who touched my clothes?” [31]So His disciples said to Him, “You see the crowd pressing around you, yet you say, ‘Who touched me?’?” [32]But He kept looking around to see who had done it. [33]So the woman, fearing and trembling, knowing what had happened to her, came and fell down before Him and told Him the whole truth. [34]And He said to her: “Daughter, your faith has saved you. Go into peace and be healed from your affliction.”

Luke 8:—Now as He was going, the crowds were pressing against Him. [43]And a woman—suffering with a flow of blood for twelve years, who had spent her whole livelihood on physicians, but could not be healed by any— [44]approaching from behind touched the border of His garment; and immediately the flow of her blood stopped! [45]So Jesus said, “Who touched me?” When all denied it, Peter and those with him said: “Master, the people are

pressing against you and crowding in, and you say, 'Who touched me?'?"[a] **46**But Jesus said, "Someone did touch me, because I noticed power going out from me". **47**Now when the woman saw that she could not hide, she came trembling, and falling down before Him she told Him in the presence of all the people the reason why she had touched Him, and how she was healed immediately. **48**So He said: "Courage, daughter, your faith has healed you. Go into peace."

Here we have a moving account of faith, determination and perseverance; perhaps it will have some practical lessons for us. My discussion will attempt to follow the actual sequence of events. Matthew's account is abbreviated, so I will depend mainly on the other two.

1) The street was presumably not very wide, and both Mark and Luke inform us that it was filled with a crowd that was pressing around and against Jesus. Indeed, Mark 5:31 and Luke 8:45 reinforce the observation. Obviously this represented a problem for the woman; how could she get to Jesus through that crowd, the more especially if it was made up mostly, if not entirely, of men? For any woman to push through a crowd of men would be unacceptable, but she had an added problem.

2) From Matthew 9:1 and the context we may conclude that this episode transpired in Capernaum, which really was not all that big a town. The point is, that woman would be a known person. The available space was packed with people, the crowd was on both sides of Jesus, as well as behind, so she would have to force her way through. However, this represented a difficulty beyond just being rude. According to Leviticus 15:19-27, any discharge of blood made a woman

[a] Perhaps 1.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, omit "and you say, 'Who touched me?'?" (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.).

'unclean', and verse 25 deals with prolonged hemorrhage—anyone who touched her, or even her clothes, became 'unclean' as well. So everyone she touched on her way through the crowd became 'unclean'! Now she and her problem were well known, so the people she touched were NOT happy. She no doubt got plenty of dirty looks, and maybe a few elbows, as well as some choice expressions. It would have been easy to give up, but she kept repeating her expectation to herself (Matthew 9:21) to keep up her courage, and she was desperate.

3) So why was she desperate? She "had been bleeding for twelve years, and had suffered many things under many doctors, and had spent all that she had, yet instead of getting better she grew worse" (Mark 5:25-26). In other words, she was at the end of her financial resources and of any medical hope. Mark almost seems to be accusing the doctors of malpractice. Luke, himself a doctor, is more cautious: "a woman suffering with a flow of blood for twelve years, who had spent her whole livelihood on physicians, but could not be healed by any" (Luke 8:43). No wonder the woman was desperate, but then "she heard about Jesus" (Mark 5:27), and all of a sudden, she had hope!

4) Well, she managed it. She wormed through the crowd and "touched the hem of His garment" (Matthew 9:20). "Immediately the flow of her blood was dried up, and she knew in her body that she was healed from the affliction" (Mark 5:29). Note that all she had to do was touch; this sort of thing, people getting healed just by touching His clothes, happened repeatedly during the Lord's earthly ministry. Jesus could have let the incident pass, but He chose not to. He stopped and turned around.

5) "Instantly Jesus perceived within Himself that some power had gone out of Him, and turning around in the crowd He said: Who touched my clothes?" (Mark 5:30). When Luke

writes that “all denied it” (8:45), we may understand that it was by their silence; no one spoke up. But Jesus insisted, “He kept looking around to see who had done it” (Mark 5:32). When the disciples protested that He was being ‘touched’ all the time by the jostling crowd, Jesus said, “Someone did touch me, because I noticed power going out from me” (Luke 8:46). He was referring to a purposeful touch. The woman had evidently withdrawn into the crowd, and may even have been hidden behind others. But Jesus did not let her get away with it.

6) “Now when the woman saw that she could not hide, she came trembling, and falling down before Him she told Him in the presence of all the people the reason why she had touched Him, and how she was healed immediately” (Luke 8:47). That was not easy, in front of the crowd, but Jesus gave her no choice. Was He just being mean? No, He was doing her a big favor. The people knew who she was, and about her physical problem; Jesus was declaring her healing, and therefore her cleansing, to the assembled multitude, and by implication those who had been ‘contaminated’ by the woman could relax on that score.

7) Then Jesus said to her: “Courage, daughter, your faith has saved you. Go into peace and be healed from your affliction” (Mark 5:34, Luke 8:48). That is what the Text says, ‘into peace’ not ‘in’. To go ‘in peace’ is to leave on good terms, no hard feelings. But what might going into peace be? I would say that you take the peace with you; you live within an atmosphere of peace. Now that is a proper ‘blessing’! Sovereign Jesus never said ‘go in peace’; He always said “go into peace”—He was giving the person a new life. How about a doxology!

5) Are we to handle snakes?

Mark 16:18

In the NKJV, Mark 16:18 reads like this: "they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover."[a]

The NIV renders 'they will pick up snakes with their hands', the 'with their hands' being based on just over 2% of the Greek manuscripts. As we know, there are those who take this translation literally, and believe that they must handle poisonous snakes in obedience to God. I respect their sincerity, but believe they have been misled by a faulty translation.

I would say that this particular statement of the Lord's has been generally misunderstood. The verb in question covers a wide semantic area, one of the uses being to pick up the way a garbage man picks up a bag of trash—he does so to get rid of it (hence 'remove'). I believe Luke 10:19 sheds light on this question. In Luke 10:19 the Lord Jesus said: "Behold, I give [so 98% of the Greek manuscripts] you **the** authority to trample on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall by any means hurt you." The Lord is addressing the Seventy, not the Twelve, and others were doubtless present; further, this was said perhaps four months before His death and resurrection. It follows that this authority is not limited to the apostles, and there is no indication of a time limit. The Lord Jesus affirms that He gives us **the** authority over all the power of the enemy. In Matthew 28:18 He declares that He holds "all authority… in heaven and earth", and so He has the right and the competence to delegate a portion of that authority to us. We may have any

[a] Since only three Greek MSS (really only two) omit Mark 16:9-20, against at least 1,700 that contain them, there can be no reasonable question as to the genuineness of those verses. For more on this subject please see item 59) below.

number of enemies, but the enemy is Satan. The phrase, “all the power”, presumably includes his works, followed by their consequences.

Returning to Luke 10:19, the Lord gives us the authority to “trample snakes and scorpions”. Well now, to smash the literal insect, a scorpion, you do not need power from on High, just a slipper (if you are fast you can do it barefoot). To trample a snake I prefer a boot, but we can kill literal snakes without supernatural help. It becomes obvious that Jesus was referring to something other than reptiles and insects. I understand Mark 16:18 to be refer-ring to the same reality—Jesus declares that certain signs will accompany the believers (the turn of phrase virtually has the effect of commands): they will expel demons, they will speak strange languages, they will remove ‘snakes’, they will place hands on the sick. (“If they drink…” is not a command; it refers to an eventuality.) But what did the Lord Jesus mean by ‘snakes’?

In a list of distinct activities Jesus has already referred to demons, so the ‘snakes’ must be something else. In Matthew 12:34 Jesus called the Pharisees a ‘brood of vipers’, and in 23:33, ‘snakes, brood of vipers’. In John 8:44, after they claimed God as their father, Jesus said, “You are of your father the devil”. And 1 John 3:10 makes clear that Satan has many other ‘sons’. In Revelation 20:2 we read: “He seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is a slanderer, even Satan, who deceives the whole inhabited earth, and bound him for a thousand years.” If Satan is a snake, then his children are also snakes. So then, I take it that our ‘snakes’ are human beings who chose to serve Satan, who sold themselves to evil. I conclude that the ‘snakes’ in Luke 10:19 are the same as those in Mark 16:18, but what of the ‘scorpions’? Since they also are of the enemy, they may be demons, in which case the term may well include their offspring, the humanoids. See the

next item, “As were the Days of Noah”. I am still working on the question of just how the removal is to be done.

6) “As were the days of Noah”

Mathew 24:37—“Just as were the days of Noah, so also will be the coming of the Son of the Man”[a]—spoken by the Lord Jesus Christ.

According to Ezekiel 33:6-7, a watchman who sees danger approaching has the obligation to warn the populace. I believe that God has designated me as a watchman with reference to the matter in hand—most unpleasant but terribly serious—so I consider that I am obligated to sound the alarm. Unfortunately, I myself have taught error on this subject in the past (in Portuguese, if not in English).

The Fact

1. Sovereign Jesus declares that at the time of His second coming the situation in the world will be similar to what it was in Noah’s day (Matthew 24:37-44, Luke 17:26-35). Many of us believe that the Second Coming is upon us, so let us consider the reality of our day.

2. The people were completely evil and perverse: “Jehovah saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intent of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually” (Genesis 6:5). If a person <u>is</u> as he thinks in his heart (Proverbs 23:7), then in Noah’s time a majority (evidently) of the people practiced only evil, were incapable of doing good. And what about our day? 2 Timothy 3:1-5—

[a] That is what the Text says, “the Son of the Man”, which appears to be a phrase coined by the Lord Jesus to refer to Himself; the phrase does not make very good sense in English, at first glance, but if “<u>the</u> man” refers to pristine Adam and “<u>the</u> son” to an only pristine descendent, it makes great sense. It seems to indicate a perfect human prototype, like Adam was before the fall—the human side of the God-man.

“Now understand this: In the last days there will be grievous times; because people will be self-lovers, money lovers, boasters, arrogant, blasphemers, disobedient to parents, ungrateful, unholy, without family affection, unforgiving, slanderers [or, ‘devils’], without self-control, brutal, despisers of good, betrayers, reckless, conceited, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God; wearing a form of godliness while having denied its power! You must avoid such people.”[a] Now is that not a faithful picture of our present-day society at large? (See also Romans 1:28-32.)

3. Sovereign Jesus affirmed that marriage would be similar. So how was that marriage? “The sons of God saw the daughters of men, that they were beautiful; and they took wives for themselves of all whom they chose” (Genesis 6:2). The phrase, ‘the sons of God’, is a translation of the Hebrew phrase, *bene-haelohim*, that in the other places where it occurs—Job 1:6, 2:1 and 38:7—clearly refers to angelic beings, apparently of high rank. The inspired commentary in the New Testament, Jude 6-7 and 2 Peter 2:4-7, makes clear

[a] Note that the order is to avoid such people. But, wait a minute—how can we evangelize them if we are ordered to avoid contact with them? Could it be that they have passed a point of no return, or might they be a type of being that is not an object of salvation? Matthew 7:6 comes to mind; this verse may be a chiasmus, ab,ba. But just who are 'the dogs' and 'the pigs'? A pig will sniff the pearl and perhaps think it a stone—it not being edible the pig will ignore it and it will get trampled into the mud. So a 'pig' is someone who is incapable of recognizing or appreciating the 'pearl' (perhaps a materialist with a completely closed mind)—the reaction will be one of total indifference. So do not waste your time. In contrast a 'dog' reacts in an aggressively hostile manner against what is 'holy'. So a 'dog' is presumably someone who is committed to evil and will therefore attack what is holy. So do not innocently offer what is holy to a 'dog'—you will get chewed up! Anyone who has sold out to Satan will almost certainly have a resident demon, and we have the authority to bind such.

that they were in fact angelic beings, albeit in rebellion against the Creator.[a] (In Luke 20:36 the Lord Jesus said, with

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[a] Jude makes clear that the phrase in Genesis 6:2 is not an exception. "And the angels who did not keep their proper domain but deserted their own dwelling He has kept bound in everlasting chains under darkness for the judgment of the great day. So also Sodom and Gomorrah and the surrounding towns—who gave themselves up to fornication and went after a different kind of flesh [Greek ετερος] in a manner similar to those angels—stand as an example, undergoing a punishment of eternal fire" (Jude 6-7). The author, inspired by God, affirms that the people of Sodom did what certain angelic beings had done; they wanted sex with a different kind of flesh. Recall that the men of Sodom, old and young, from every quarter, wanted to rape the angels that were with Lot (Genesis 19:4-5). Whatever kind of flesh an angel has (when he materializes), it is not human flesh; it is precisely "a different kind of flesh". The parallel text in 2 Peter 2:4-6 links the crime of those angels to the Flood. (In Matthew 22:30 [Mark 12:25, Luke 20:35-36] the Lord does not say that angels do not have a sex/gender. Evidently no baby angels are born [whether good or bad], but if angels are of only one gender, then they cannot reproduce in kind. In the Bible, whenever an angel materializes it is in the form of a man, not a woman.)

The argument that 'the sons of God' would be a reference to the male descendants of Seth, while 'the daughters of men' would be a reference to the female descendants of Cain, is totally unfounded. Genesis 6:1 says that the men (Hebrew *haadam*, 'the man' or 'Adam', but in 5:1 we find *adam* twice without the article, referring to 'Adam' and 'the man' respectively) began to multiply, which included daughters. It should be obvious that the reference is to the human race as a whole, not just to the descendants of Cain—surely, otherwise there would be no male descendants of Seth to take the female descendants of Cain (on that hypothesis). Verse 2 goes on to say that 'the sons of God' saw those daughters of men (Hebrew *haadam*, just as in verse 1)—if *haadam* in verse 1 refers to the human race as a whole, then the identical vocabulary item in verse 2 ought to have the same meaning. Further, in verse 3 Jehovah declares that He is not going to strive with man (*adam*) forever and in verse 7 further declares that He will destroy man (*haadam*) from the face of the earth. It is clear that the Flood destroyed the descendants of Seth just

reference to the resurrected, that "they are equal to angels and are sons of God".) Note that the fallen angels acted on their own initiative, taking 'whom they chose'. And what was the result of those 'marriages'? "There were giants [Hebrew *Nephilim*] on the earth in those days, and also afterward,[a] when the sons of God came in to the daughters of men and they bore children to them" (Genesis 6:4). A race of 'human-oids' was born, half-breeds of demon and woman, beings that were totally perverse, malignant, and of impressive size. And what about our day? Is our society at large not replete with beings that are totally perverse and malignant? The impressive size is lacking, but I think I can explain why.

4. An objection will probably be raised: "But, but, but, didn't Jesus say that angels don't marry?" Let us check it out; the text is: "When they rise from the dead, they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels in heaven" (Mark 12:25; see also Matthew 22:30 and Luke 20:35-36). Jesus was answering the captious question posed by the Sadducees, who denied the existence of resurrection; He affirms that in

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as much as those of Cain. So then, the Hebrew word *haadam* refers to the human race as a whole. (Will anyone argue that the female descendants of Seth were not also 'daughters of men'?)

[a] Unfortunately, I once taught all over Brazil that apparently God had changed the rules after the Flood, with the result that we no longer see that happening; at least we no longer have giants, and although demons are certainly having sexual relations with women, we do not hear of anything being born as a result. But, just a minute, how would I know that no offspring of demons were being born? In Brazil we have a great many single mothers (and presumably that is not just here), and are they going to trumpet to the world that their baby's father is a demon? How can we know? [And what about the babies found in the trash or in the brush; might they be demonic offspring that the mother did not want?] But the Text is clear, "and also afterward", and I am to blame for having ignored this plain statement.

Heaven marriage, as we know it, does not exist; once there we will no longer procreate (since no one will die, there will be no need to produce new people to replace the old). In Heaven the angels do not procreate either, but that could be the consequence of there being only one sex (Jesus did not say that angels do not have gender, or a sex). Whenever an angel materializes in the appearance of a human being in the Bible, it is always as a male or man, never as a woman.[a] The lack of females among them could explain why angelic beings are fascinated by the female of our species (see 1 Corinthians 11:10, that I will discuss below).

5. Before proceeding, let us go back to the "and also afterward" to check out what happened after the Flood. Based on Deuteronomy 2:10-12 and 20-21 we may understand that already in Abraham's day, and even before, other mongrel races had appeared, and of impressive size. Deuteronomy 3:11 states overtly that Og, king of Bashan, was the last of his race, the *Rephaim*, that were similar to the *Anakim*; it states further that his bed was some 4½ meters in length, which allows us to deduce that Og himself was around four meters tall. Thirty-eight years before, the spies, wishing to badmouth the land, spoke of a number of giants, sons of Anak, that are overtly called *Nephilim* (Numbers 13:33). Four hundred years later David still had to face Goliath, and others of his race (1 Chronicles 20:4-8), but his height was 'only' three meters, no longer four (1 Samuel 17:4).

As soon as God promised the land of Canaan to Abraham, it was entirely predictable that Satan would attempt to louse things up.[b] So much so, in fact, that although all the fallen

[a] The women in Zechariah 5 are part of a vision, not materializations; what Zechariah saw was women, not angels. In contrast, the Text says plainly that it was an angel who was talking with him.

[b] And with the reappearing of Israel as a nation in that land, will anyone suppose that Satan is doing nothing?

angels who married women before the Flood had been confined in Tartarus (2 Peter 2:4), which would have been a rather severe warning to the rest, Satan obliged (so I imagine) a number of others to repeat the stunt. The severity used by God in the case of Sodom and Gomorrah indicates that the level of perversity there had reached uncommon proportions —Genesis 13:13 affirms that "the men of Sodom were exceedingly wicked". Although the Text does not make direct mention of giants in Sodom, we may deduce that yes there were, because Deuteronomy 2:10-12 says that Moab, that occupied what was left of the area controlled by Sodom and Gomorrah (that was not under the Dead Sea), took the area away from the *Emim* (who were the same size as the *Anakim*—it becomes evident that there were several mongrel races). God's severity with reference to the Amalekites, commanding Saul to annihilate them, including babies and even animals (1 Samuel 15:3), is probably to be explained by a massive demonic infestation of some sort. Just as we destroy animals and poultry to keep an epidemic from spreading, perhaps the contamination of the Amalekites was such that the only solution was destruction. (Cancerous cells cannot be recovered, returned to normal; they need to be destroyed in order to save the organism as a whole.)

6. And now about the size: why do we not have giants in our day? To begin, the phrase 'sons of God' evidently referred to angelic beings of high rank. Next, in Noah's day the women would have numbered in the thousands, or tens of thousands, certainly not more than hundreds of thousands; but there are over 50 million fallen angels (Revelation 12:4 and 5:11).[a]

[a] We understand that 'the dragon' (12:3-4) refers to Satan. The term 'star' frequently refers to an angel, and in the context it should be obvious that the reference cannot be to literal luminaries—since the stars are many times larger than our planet, just one would have blown it to smithereens, and the Text refers to a third of them.

There simply were not enough women to go around! So then, it seems to me to be perfectly logical that it would be the biggest/strongest demons that got the women. However, all that gang was imprisoned in Tartarus as punishment for their incredible crime; so all of a sudden thousands of high-ranking demons are removed from the scene, which would open up the opportunity for the lesser ones. I cannot prove it, but it seems to me logical that the size of the offspring would reflect the size of the 'father', just as with us. (However, everything was bigger before the Flood than after—people, animals, plants—so the pre-Flood women were much larger than women today.) In any case, Goliath was certainly smaller than Og, who was probably smaller than the *Nephilim* destroyed by the Flood. Although the Text is silent, it would not be strange for God to keep on sending to Tartarus any other high-ranking demons that perpetrated the same crime. Since Satan needs his high-ranking subordinates for other purposes, he himself would tell them to stop.[a] It could be that lesser demons are allowed to escape, and their offspring would not

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Therefore we understand that Lucifer managed to recruit a third of the original angels to join him in his rebellion against the Creator. In 5:11 the Greek Text says that the angels around the throne of God numbered ten thousand times ten thousand and thousands of thousands. Well, 10,000 X 10,000 = 100,000,000 (one hundred million), but there were more than that. It follows that if the two thirds that remained true to the Creator number a hundred million, then the one third that went with Satan must number over 50 million. What a calamity!

[a] There is another possibility. Jude 6 affirms that the *bene-haelohim* of Genesis 6 "deserted their own dwelling". The idea of deserting or abandoning implies that there is no return. It may be that those fallen angels, in order to be able to procreate with women, had to make an irreversible choice. Upon taking on human form they could never return to their former condition. Following this hypothesis, again Satan would command them to stop, since he needs his high-ranking subordinates for other purposes.

be of abnormal size. Further, with the return of Christ bearing down upon us, God may be permitting a renewing of that activity. In any case, based on the declaration of the Lord Jesus, something similar to what precipitated the Flood must exist in our world today. He who hath an ear, let him hear!

Implications

1. Consider Jude 18-19: "In the end time there will be scoffers who live according to their own godless desires; these are the division-causers;[a] they are soulish [characterized by soul], not having a spirit." That is what the Text says. Our Bibles generally read, "not having the Spirit", but there is no article with 'spirit' in the Greek text; translators have supposed that the reference is to the Holy Spirit, and in that event the 'soulish' people would be the unconverted. But the description of such persons that occupies verses 8-16 is almost violent—they are totally perverse. One is reminded of Genesis 6:5 and 2 Timothy 3:1-5. The crucial question is precisely this: would the offspring of a demon have a human spirit? The Sacred Text informs us that the human spirit is transmitted by the sperm of the father, in which event that hybrid race would have lost the human spirit, and presumably the 'image of God' as well. Let us check it out.

In Genesis 5:3 the Text affirms that Adam "begot a son in his own likeness, after his image", that reminds us of Genesis 1:26. "Then God said: Let us make man in our image, according to our likeness." In all the genealogies it is always the man who begets; women conceive and gestate. I take it that Hebrews 7:9-10 is clear enough. "Even Levi, who receives tithes, paid tithes through Abraham, so to speak, for he was still in the loins of his father when Melkizedek met him." When Abraham paid the tithe to Melkizedek, not even Isaac had been begotten, much less Jacob and Levi. Still, the

[a] The 'divisions' they cause would be in the society at large, not in the church.

inspired author affirms that the person of Levi was in Abraham's reproductive system. It follows that it is the sperm of the man that transmits the human spirit and the image of the Creator. That is why Romans 5:12-21 teaches that Adam's sin was transmitted to all his descendants, and death as well.[a] As David explains, "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin my mother conceived me" (Psalm 51:5). (It should be obvious that the reference is not to the reproductive process itself, since the Creator Himself commanded them to "be fruitful and multiply"—Genesis 9:1.)

Consider also Genesis 38:8-10. The Text affirms that God killed Onan. Why? It was not because he did not want to perpetuate his brother's name—even under the more stringent demands of the Law of Moses the penalty for that was 'only' public humiliation, not death (Deuteronomy 25:5-10). In Onan's day there was no Law of Moses. Up to that point only one crime carried the death penalty, precisely murder (Genesis 9:6). Since the life is in the seed, when Onan spilled the seed on the ground, before having intercourse with the widow, he was deliberately killing the human life in the seed—it was murder. And God exacted the penalty![b] We may add

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[a] When Eve sinned, she sinned alone. When Adam sinned, we did too, because we were in his reproductive system. It was Adam who degraded the race.

[b] To be sure, the life latent in the sperm is only set in motion when a spermatozoon joins an ovum. Since a man produces many billions, if not trillions, of spermatozoa during his life, almost all of them are wasted, one way or another. It is mainly a perverse intention that the Creator punishes. However, if I am not badly mistaken, He is not pleased when people go after pleasure without assuming the accompanying responsibility.

Leviticus 18:6-30 prohibits certain practices because they contaminate the earth, and the situation can reach a point where the earth 'vomits' the people. Now there is a dramatic picture for you: the very ground gets nauseated at the people that walk it! And what are those practices? Every kind of incest (verses 6-17), sex with a woman in

Exodus 21:22-23 here as well. A human fetus is a person, and whoever caused the death of a fetus was liable to the death penalty.[a] It is the seed of the man that transmits the human spirit; so the offspring of a demon will not have one. The essence of a woman being her soul, the offspring has the mother's soul. Not having spirit, it most probably will not have any conscience either.[b] Here in Brazil, where I live and work, the papers and newscasts are full of cases where the criminals appear to have no conscience at all—they say they would do

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menstruation (verse 19), adultery (verse 20), human sacrifice (verse 21), homosexualism (verse 22) and sex with an animal (verse 23). Verse 29 decrees the death penalty for all those practices. Leviticus 20:1-22 is a parallel passage. The Text states plainly that innocent blood shed without punishment contaminates the ground, and God demands the death penalty for murderers. But why does the Creator react the same way to the practices listed above? I suppose for the following reason: sex with an animal, anal sex and sex with a menstruating woman destroys the man's seed, and it is the seed that transmits 'the image of God', human life. So they are kinds of homicide—remember the case of Onan. Human sacrifice is obvious murder. Incest and adultery degrade the seed. In short, the Creator attaches considerable importance to His 'image'!

[a] In verse 22 the correct rendering is a premature birth, not a miscarriage. The baby lives. In verse 23 the baby dies.

[b] Down through the years many Christian writers have affirmed that every human being has a 'space' in the soul that only the Creator can fill. Analogously, humanoids probably have a demon-specific 'socket', being open to demonic influence at any moment. Modern medicine informs us that each person has the father's blood, not the mother's; so the mixed race mentioned in Genesis 6:4 had demonic blood in their veins, not human. Had Satan succeeded in contaminating everyone, the Messiah, the second Adam, could not have been born, and Genesis 3:15 could not have been fulfilled. The maneuver that Satan devised against God's plan was so incredible, and came so close to succeeding, that the response was to destroy everything and start over, using eight human beings not yet contaminated.

it again, and with pleasure![a]

2. 1 Corinthians 11:9-10—"Nor was man created for the woman, but woman for the man. For this reason, the woman ought to have authority upon her head, because of the angels." Our Bibles generally add 'a symbol of' before 'authority'—there being nothing of the sort in the Text, it is an unwarranted addition. The woman needs the protection of male authority, precisely because of the angels. In Numbers 30:3-15 Jehovah makes clear that the man exercises spiritual authority over the woman. Recall that in Genesis 6:2 the angelic beings simply took the women that they wanted, at their own initiative. A woman without male protection is an easy target. In our day, the feminist women who peremptorily reject any semblance of male authority are asking for a demon (and what little demon is going to object?). [It would not surprise me in the least if 100% of such feminists have a demon.] And what about the lesbians that want sex, but without a man—are they not an open invitation? Well, and so what? Well, our society ought to be full of single mothers, and many of the children would be humanoids.[b] I understand that the return of Christ is upon us, and He Himself declared that things would be like they were in Noah's day. In that event, a significant percentage of the population today is probably

[a] Please note, I am not suggesting that every perverse and violent individual is a humanoid. Persons who turn themselves over to Satan grow progressively worse. And then, there are the 'robots', people who voluntarily and deliberately turn themselves over to the complete control of a demon; they become under 'remote control'. Over fifteen years ago I was informed that at that time there was a network of thousands of 'robots' distributed around the United States (we also have them in Brazil). I must confess that I never troubled myself to study the problem and find a way to neutralize such 'persons'—it would be a welcome asset toward the subject in hand.

[b] Of course married women can also produce humanoids.

made up of humanoids, that mongrel race of demon with woman. All of a sudden, we are faced with an urgent necessity—we need to be able to distinguish the imitation. We need the gift of discerning spirits! On the way, let us think about the probable characteristics of such beings.

The females, not having a spirit, will be very sensual, and will be used by Satan to ruin men. A human male who has sex with one of them will certainly be demonized, and if he marries her he will be tormented; he can never be happy, and any children will be perverse. As for the males, without a spirit, they will also be sensual, as well as given to violence, to lying and to corruption. The Lord Jesus affirmed that Satan is a murderer and a liar (John 8:44), as well as a thief and a vandal (John 10:10).[a] The description of Lucifer in Ezekiel 28:13 includes musical instruments, and I think it is obvious that Satan uses music as a favorite tool to destroy young people. Some time ago there was a rock group called KISS (Knights in Satan's Service) whose 'music' was openly satanic, and so on. The description given in 2 Timothy 3:1-5 is precisely to the point. They will be beings without conscience, without remorse. They will kill their parents without any emotion, etc. etc.

3. "As it was in the days of Noah"—never before had I paused and tried to imagine the emotions of Noah and the other 'decent' people of his time as they saw their world being taken over by those *Nephilim*, as they watched their culture being destroyed, apparently without being able to do anything to stop, much less reverse, the trend. There would be frustration, anger, perplexity, melancholy and at last despair and panic. So how about us in today's world—are we not beginning to have the same emotions as we observe a world

[a] "Brood of vipers", "your father is the devil"—like father, like son; if the father is a 'snake', the children are too.

without the political will to confront the organized Islamic terror, organized crime running loose, violence rampant in the streets, corruption at home in all levels and all areas of society, the growing lack of shame and modesty in customs and culture, in short, a 'church' that is absent and unable to promote biblical values in the public sector and society at large?

For some time now Canada has had a law whereby if you voice a criticism of the homosexual life style you go to prison. I believe similar laws are in place in several European countries. The militant 'gay' lobby is hard at work to get similar laws in the US and here in Brazil—a similar law has been passed by the House of Representatives here and is presently being debated in the Senate. According to the proposed law, moral or religious objections to homosexualism will not be tolerated; a church would not be able to fire a pastor for being 'gay', and so on. The 'gay' lobby is openly working for an inversion of cultural values, the destruction of any moral principles left over from our former civilization. Those who study the militant 'gay' agenda are telling us that the movement is no longer concerned for the person, but rather with the pleasure derived from their destructive program itself—the pleasure of perverting what is natural, of transforming the right into wrong and the wrong into right (see Isaiah 5:20), of destroying the human being as a whole.[a] It is simply satanic.

Our turn to live Hebrews 13:12-13 is coming, something that Christians in China, North Korea, Islamic countries and those persecuted elsewhere have known for some time. "Jesus also, so that He might sanctify the people by His own blood, suffered outside the city gate. So then, let us go out to Him, outside the camp, bearing His disgrace." I doubt that even 5% of the so-called evangelicals here in Brazil are

[a] I have used material from an e-mail written by Rozangela Justino.

prepared to actually suffer physical persecution for Jesus Christ. Do you suppose that the percentage in North America will be any higher? Martin Luther wrote the following:

> If I profess with loudest voice and clearest exposition every portion of the truth of God except precisely that little point which the world and the devil are at the moment attacking, I am not confessing Christ, however boldly I may be professing Christ. Where the battle rages, there the loyalty of the soldier is proved, and to be steady on all the battlefield besides, is merely flight and disgrace if he flinches at THAT point.

Well then, I would say that the "little point" that the world and the devil are presently attacking in Brazil, and elsewhere, is the position on anal sex.

The position of the Bible is clear enough. God created two sexes, male and female, and He expects that they be respected. Homosexualism is not a work of the Creator—so much so that He decrees the death penalty for the practice (Leviticus 18:22 & 29, and to this day, Romans 1:32). Whose work is it then? Romans 1:18-32 is to the point; homosexualism is a result of denying the existence of the Creator (Romans 1:26). Since God wants adoration that is in spirit and truth (John 4:24), He will not force us to adore; when people reach the point of actually denying His existence (the ultimate stupidity), He removes His hand, abandoning them to their disgraceful passions, that Satan knows how to manipulate very well.

I believe that Hebrews 2:7 is relevant here: "You made him [man, verse 6] lower than the angels, for a little while" (quoting Psalm 8:5). The human being is superior to the angelic being in essence; we bear the Creator's image and they do not, and once glorified that superiority will be obvious, but only for the redeemed. Those who serve Satan subordinate themselves to him, and thus can never rise above him. If Lucifer's rebellion was provoked, as I suppose, by the

creation of a being superior to himself, he is doing very well at getting his 'revenge', by depriving the vast majority of humanity of that superiority [and so verse 8 would not apply to them]. Now Satan is controlled by spite; he was demoted. Since he is unable to create, he gets his satisfaction by degrading and destroying. His greatest 'pleasure' must be to drag the image of the Creator through the mire, and for that purpose anal sex is just the ticket. Since it is a man's seed that transmits the 'image', anal sex mixes the image of God with feces—a monstrous insult! The practice of anal sex is the equivalent of spitting in the face of the Creator; it is an extremely serious offense (worse than a buck private spitting in the face of a four-star general). So then, as soon as God removes His hand, Satan pushes men toward anal sex.[a]

Several years ago, Dr. James Dobson, founder and president of Focus on the Family, on the television program Larry King Live, said that he never taught that the homosexual tendency was a choice of the person. That made me stop and think. If the tendency is not a choice (just supposing), where would it come from? I see two possibilities: either someone is born with it, or he gets it from a demon. Going on from there, in a society dominated by a relativistic humanism, starting from pluralistic presuppositions, there will be no perceived basis for combating homosexualism.

But, can it be that someone is actually born with the tendency? By an act of the Creator, no. Well, how about by an act of evolution? I owe to Dr. Ney Augusto de Oliveira (a surgeon) the following observation: Even for someone who believes in evolution as an explanation of origins [even though it is

[a] Here in Brazil, people who come out of the various forms of spiritism affirm that most of the men in those groups are homosexual; Satan pushes them in that direction—they teach that anal sex gives power, and it becomes necessary for those who wish to climb the hierarchical ladder.

scientifically impossible], it would be a contradiction for the organism to evolve a homosexual gene, because that gene would condemn the organism to extinction. It should be obvious to all that anal sex will never produce life—if during 50-60 years not a single woman gave birth, our race would disappear from this planet. Bye, bye. So then, if neither God nor evolution has produced, or would produce, a homosexual gene, how can someone be born with the tendency? Only as a work of Satan, that I understand to be entirely possible.[a] Actually, the am-bush that the enemy has prepared for us is a whole lot worse than we have gotten around to imagining. Consider.

The inspired commentary links Sodom to the Flood. The Sodomites were known for their appetite for anal sex. If there was a mixture of humanoids in Sodom, as I understand (Deuteronomy 2:10), they were probably born with the tendency. It seems to me obvious that many (if not all) of the humanoids in our day will have been born with the tendency, precisely in order to create a social climate where approval for the practice becomes irresistible. Which, of course, will cause the Creator to abandon that society more and more, which will turn that society over to Satan more and more. It is a vicious cycle of evil, a downward spiral. Since we do not know how to distinguish between human beings and humanoids, the sexual acrobatics of the humanoids become part of the culture at large and influence the behavior of the real humans. Such perversity![b]

I was recently informed that soybeans (if not fermented) contain a good deal of female hormone, so that too much soy represses the masculine libido, reducing the virility. During centuries, if not millennia, Buddhist monks have taken soy

[a] See my essay, "Concerning Pathogens—Origin and Solution".

[b] Freud's theory that sex is the mainspring of human life has been, and continues to be, a most useful tool for Satan.

precisely to smother their sexual desire. There is no end of articles available on the internet telling about the bad effects of soy, that go beyond sex. (The Japanese make their soy sauce and tofu out of soy that has been properly fermented, that removes the harm.) In North America and Europe soy is sold to the public as 'health food', and the negative effects are beginning to appear.[a] Here in Brazil the vast majority of the population cooks with soybean oil, including the bars and restaurants.[b] So then, the negative effects of soy will not result in sodomites, those who take the male role in anal sex. Since soy inhibits precisely that capacity, it will be the number of catamites that increases, those who take the female role in anal sex. A catamite tendency could come from soy, rather than a demon. Obviously such a person can refuse to participate in anal sex, but it becomes difficult to blame him for the tendency (he could be the victim of an irresponsible mother).

4. Jude 22-23: "Now be merciful to some, making a distinction; but others save with fear, snatching them out of the fire."[c] The implication is clear: there is a third category, the without-mercy ('some' plus 'others' does not equal 100%; in fact, one gains the impression that the third category could be sizeable). 1 John 5:16-17 speaks of fatal sin, such that there is no point in praying for the culprit. Such culprits would presumably be among the 'without-mercy'. (See Solution,

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[a] Women who do not wish to be bothered with breastfeeding their babies and fill the poor things with soy milk do special harm to the boys. And it might be that the girls reach puberty sooner—the number of eleven-year-olds that get pregnant seems to be growing.

[b] Every so often the local press comments on a growing level of impotence among the men, now approaching 40% (which would help to explain the increase in lesbianism among the women).

[c] I confess that I do not understand how it could be possible to rescue someone who is already in the fire, but that is what the Text says.

point 5, with special attention to the discussion of Deuteronomy 7:10, Psalm 34:16 and 2 Peter 2:17.)[a] We need discernment in order to do the triage. Yes, but, what can or should we do after that. According to the Sacred Text, Jehovah the Son took on flesh and blood in order to abolish Satan (Hebrews 2:14) and to undo his works (1 John 3:8). To undo a work one needs to also undo its consequences—is that not so? If someone crumples a fender of my car, how can we undo

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[a] It may be that the 'without-mercy' category includes two types: the mortal sin in 1 John 5:16-17 is presumably committed by a human being; but the third class in Jude 22-23 may be made up of humanoids, since a major share of the letter is describing them (as I see it).

A theological question presents itself: can a humanoid without a human spirit be saved? The demons cannot be recovered; their final destiny is sealed (Matthew 25:41). So, will the son of a demon fare any better? A type of being with soul, but without spirit, would be very similar to an animal (mammal), that also has soul but not spirit. As far as I can understand the Sacred Text, when an animal dies it simply stops existing. Since a humanoid did not choose to be so born, and is not a candidate for salvation (as best I can see), would it not be unjust to condemn it to spend eternity in the Lake? The angels who fell chose to rebel against the Creator, and so have guilt. A human being has the option of submitting to the Creator and receiving salvation. But a humanoid, ... A rabid animal needs to be destroyed, for the benefit of the rest. Just as we have the option of sending a demon to the Abyss, so I understand the Text, stopping it from continuing with its evil around here, perhaps we can find a way to get rid of a humanoid as well, with the same objective, precisely. The question of discernment becomes crucial. Why waste time 'evangelizing' a humanoid? It would be like offering something holy to a dog, that will respond by attacking you (Matthew 7:6). (Actually, I believe the Holy Spirit has confirmed to me that the 'dogs' in Matthew 7:6, and possibly in Philippians 3:2 and Revelation 22:15, can include humanoids.) If there have always been humanoids, throughout human history, there must have been some in Jesus' day. In that event, it would be strange if He never touched on the subject, and dangerous for His followers. See Asides, item1.

that 'work'? Someone has to take out the wrinkles, repaint, restore the fender to its former condition. If someone kills my son, how can we undo that 'work'? Only by bringing him back from the dead, restoring his life. If someone rapes my daughter, making her pregnant, how can we undo that 'work'? I doubt that even God could restore her virginity, but the fetus could be aborted.[a] A son of a demon is an obvious work of Satan; so, how can we undo that 'work'?

A more or less literal translation of the Hebrew Text of Psalm 92:7 would be: "When the wicked flourish like grass, and all the workers of iniquity blossom, it is for them to be destroyed forever." The preceding verse speaks of persons who ignore and despise the Creator—for such there is no cure, only destruction. Since a humanoid is not a candidate for salvation, and is in this world for the sole purpose of doing evil, it is like a gangrene in the body—if the gangrene is not excised, it will kill the body. But, what if we get to the place where we can identify a humanoid with certainty? So far as I know, there is no country in the world whose civil law distinguishes be-tween human beings and humanoids. And many countries no longer have capital punishment. So then, we must find a solution in the spiritual realm. (If God removes someone, there is nothing the law of the land can do.)

Consider also Matthew 6:22-23—"The lamp of the body is the eye. So if your eye is sound your whole body will be full of light. But if your eye is evil your whole body will be full of darkness. So if the light that is in you is darkness, how great is that darkness!" Of course we have two eyes, but the Text has "eye" in the singular. I take it that the Lord Jesus is referring to the way we interpret what we see, which is our real 'eye'—

[a] If the rape was perpetrated by a demon or humanoid, might aborting the result not be an obligation to society? Why give birth to a being that will only do evil in this world, and only be extinguished in the end anyway?

two people, one pure and one vile, observing the same scene will give different interpretations to it. Someone with a malignant mind will give an evil interpretation to everything he sees, and in consequence his being will be filled with unrelenting darkness. (Cf. Titus 1:15.) Such persons reach a point where they are beyond help, beyond recovery, and should be removed, for the good of society.[a]

Solution

1. First, let us consider our incumbency, what Sovereign Jesus intends for us to do: "Just as the Father sent me, I also send you" (John 20:21)—just as. It is the Lord Jesus Christ, our Commander-in-chief, who is speaking. He is expecting, rather requiring, that we do as He did. So, **what** did He do? The Father ordered and the Son obeyed: "I have come to do Your will, O God" (Hebrews 10:7). (John 4:34—"My food is to do the will of Him who sent me and to complete His work.") Brothers, we too must experience Hebrews 10:7. An effective participation in the spiritual war begins with a total commitment to the Lord Jesus, and that needs to be renewed daily. Just like the Lord Jesus, our life must revolve around the Father's will. And what was that will, in specific terms? It is stated in Hebrews 2:14—the Son took on flesh and blood in order to abolish the devil; also to undo his works (1 John 3:8).

So then, why are we here? To give continuity to the work of Christ. He came to abolish Satan, and He succeeded, Hallelujah! (Colossians 2:15, John 16:11, Ephesians 1:20-21, John 12:31, 1 Peter 3:22, 1 John 4:4). Yes indeed, Satan has been defeated, his final destination has been decreed (Matthew 25:41), but for His own sovereign reasons the Creator still allows the enemy to operate in this world. It is up to us to 'pay

[a] Perhaps we should distinguish between two types of bad people: those who deliberately devise evil and those who gradually lost the ability to distinguish between good and bad; perhaps these might still have a chance.

to see'—we must impose the defeat on the devil, in practice (Matthew 18:18). Christ came to undo Satan's works, and since he continues to produce evil in this world, it is up to us to undo it. As soon as Jesus won the victory He returned to Heaven, leaving the undoing on our plate. Since the Church has been calamitously absent in this area, we are all obliged to live with the negative consequences of that neglect. **We are here to undo the works of the devil!**

"Just as He is, so are we in this world" (1 John 4:17)—in this world, not the next. The Church is the body of Christ, and so it is mainly through her that He deals with this world. (When you look at someone what you see is the person's body.) We are the Creator's spokes-men in this world. (That could include the Trinity!—1 John 4:13-14, Genesis 1:26.) Attention please: it is time to wake up. It is time to really understand that we represent the Creator down here, and He expects us to conduct ourselves in a manner worthy of our office.

2. Second, let us consider our competence, as stated in Psalm 149:5-9. "Let the saints exult in glory; let them sing for joy on their beds. Let the high praises of God be in their mouth, and a two-edged sword in their hand, to execute vengeance upon the nations, and punishments upon the peoples; to bind their kings with chains, and their nobles with fetters of iron; to execute upon them the written judgment—this honor is for all His saints."[a]

Here are some observations based on the Text:
a) we are looking at commands (not optional points);

[a] The type of warfare ordered in Psalm 149 is at the highest level, including against fallen angels of high rank, 'world rulers'. A woman should not attempt it unless she is under the spiritual protection of a competent man (an unbelieving or backslidden husband will not hack it; nor a pastor who does not understand the subject [and does not want to learn]). (See 1 Corinthians 11:9-10 and Numbers 30:3-15.)

b) the commands are to be obeyed in bed—the point being, presumably, that we operate in the spiritual realm;

c) the battle is allied with praise, and the praise comes first (see 2 Chronicles 20:21-22);

d) the 'honor', a consequence of the positive results of obedience to the commands, is for "all His saints". It follows that if you are one of those saints, to obey those orders is on your plate, within your competence (so they will be required);

e) since our activity takes place in the spiritual realm, the 'kings' and 'nobles' presumably refer not only to the men who occupy positions of authority but also to the fallen angels (demons) who are behind them. In fact, a thorough job must get rid of the demons, as well as the men;

f) the scope includes entire nations, whole peoples; in short, any geographic or political entity that has a ruler;

g) since the battle is part of worshipping God, the 'vengeance' and 'punishment' need to be in accord with His character. It is where norms established by the Creator are being blatantly rejected that we should concentrate our action. NB: the point is to impose the Creator's norms, not our pet peeves;

h) since we operate in the spiritual realm, the authorities we bind may not literally wind up in the penitentiary, but they will be removed from power; being bound hand and foot they cannot function;

i) there is no lack of 'written judgment'—Zechariah 5:2-4, against thieves and perjurers; Proverbs 20:10 against diverse weights and measures; Isaiah 10:1-2, against whoever makes unjust laws; Romans 1:26-32, against homosexualism and a sad list of other perversities (note that verse 32 says that they **are** deserving of death, by the righteous judgment of God; 'are', not 'were'—and this within the age of Grace, since Romans was written decades

after Pentecost). (See also 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, Revelation 21:8 and 22:15.) Since humanoids are here to do evil, they come within our jurisdiction, without doubt.

Further, 1 Corinthians 6:2-4 affirms that saints judge the world; the verb 'judge' is in the present tense (the first occurrence is ambiguous with the future, but not the second one). Verse 3 adds that our jurisdiction includes angels. Well now, if we can judge an angel, then we can judge the son of an angel. Conclusion: judging humanoids is within our jurisdiction, our competence.

3. Third, let us consider our authority and power. In Luke 10:19 the Lord Jesus said: "Behold, I give [so 98% of the Greek manuscripts] you **the** authority to trample on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall by any means hurt you." The Lord is addressing the Seventy, not the Twelve, and others were doubtless present; further, this was said perhaps four months before His death and resurrection. It follows that this authority is not limited to the apostles, and there is no indication of a time limit. The Lord Jesus affirms that He gives us **the** authority over all the power of the enemy. In Matthew 28:18 He declares that He holds "all authority . . . in heaven and earth", and so He has the right and the competence to delegate a portion of that authority to us. We may have any number of enemies, but the enemy is Satan. The phrase, "all the power", presumably includes his works, followed by their consequences. Someone with authority can forbid an action, and therefore we can stop Satan from acting in a specific case.[a]

[a] Can we command Satan to undo his own works (including those of his servants)? I know a pastor here in Brazil whose car was stolen, so he ordered Satan, by name, to return it within 24 hours, and within the stipulated time it was parked in front of his house. But what about disease, would it not be better to use God's power (Ephesians 3:20)? I gather that the Lord Jesus always used God's power (not the

I link Ephesians 3:20 to Luke 10:19. “Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to the power that is working in us, . . .” “Is working” is in the present tense; so it is valid for us today. There exists a power in us (the redeemed) that even surpasses our ability to imagine. It follows that to bring about something written should be easy.

Returning to Luke 10:19, the Lord gives us the authority to “trample snakes and scorpions”. Well now, to smash the literal insect, a scorpion, you do not need power from on High, just a slipper. To trample a snake I prefer a boot, but we can kill literal snakes without supernatural help. It becomes obvious that Jesus was referring to something other than reptiles and insects. I understand Mark 16:18 to be referring to the same reality—Jesus declares that certain signs will accompany the believers (the turn of phrase virtually has the effect of commands): they will expel demons, they will speak strange languages, they will remove ‘snakes’, they will place hands on the sick.[a] (“If they drink . . .” is not a command; it

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enemy’s), and we should follow His example. Since we have access to Christ’s limitless power, we do not need Satan’s, and should not give him the satisfaction of seeing us use it. And, recalling how subtle he is, there is the distinct possibility that he could deceive us and have us doing what we shouldn’t.

(There are those who argue that Satan was stripped of his power, based on texts like Hebrews 2:14, Revelation 1:18, Colossians 2:15 and Matthew 28:18. The cruel facts of life that surround us and fill the world would seem to weigh inconveniently against that thesis, but the Text itself goes against it—what Satan will yet do through the Antichrist and the false prophet reflects considerable power. I understand the texts above to refer to the fact of Satan’s having been demoted and deposed from his position as god / prince of this world, along with the privileges and perks that go with the office. Now he is obliged to act as a usurper, bluffing his ‘rights’.)

[a] 1 Corinthians 12:29-30 leaves clear that no gift is given to everybody; we need the community, where all the gifts should be present.

refers to an eventuality.) Your Bible probably reads “they will take up serpents”, or something similar. It happens that the Greek verb ‘take up’ covers a fairly wide semantic area, and one of the main meanings is ‘to remove’—a garbage collector picks up a bag in order to remove it, get rid of it, not to keep it (he holds on to it only long enough to throw it into the truck). I believe that is the intended meaning here in Mark 16:18, but what did the Lord Jesus mean by ‘snakes’?

In a list of distinct activities Jesus has already referred to demons, so the ‘snakes’ must be something else. In Matthew 12:34 Jesus called the Pharisees a ‘brood of vipers’, and in Matthew 23:33, ‘snakes, brood of vipers’. In John 8:44, after they claimed God as their father, Jesus said, “You are of your father the devil”. And 1 John 3:10 makes clear that Satan has many other ‘sons’. In Revelation 20:2 we read: “He seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is a slanderer, even Satan, who deceives the whole inhabited earth, and bound him for a thousand years.” If Satan is a snake, then his children are also snakes. So then, I take it that our ‘snakes’ are human beings who chose to serve Satan, who sold themselves to evil—the term could also include ‘humanoids’, who are literally devils’ children. I conclude that the ‘snakes’ in Luke 10:19 are the same as those in Mark 16:18, but what of the ‘scorpions’? Since they also are of the enemy, they may be demons, in which case the term may well include their offspring, the humanoids.[a] So then, whether as snakes or as

[a] Since a snake is more dangerous than a scorpion (usually), and since a human being is superior to an angelic one in essence, and a human being in Satan’s service can produce more damage in the world than a demon can, to associate scorpion with demon in this context is not unreasonable. I understand the Text to affirm that we have the authority to free ourselves from demons, humanoids, ‘robots’ and ‘snakes’ (human beings given over to evil).

scorpions, humanoids will be included, and therefore Luke 10:19 grants us the authority over them, explicitly so.[a]

In Matthew 8:5-13 the centurion understood about authority—he gave orders and they were obeyed, without question or delay (but only within the sphere of his competence). But the Lord Jesus said that he had great faith, to an unusually high degree—but faith in what? Faith in Jesus' spiritual authority; all He had to do was give an order and it would happen. Perhaps we should understand this type of faith as being an absolute confidence, beyond a shadow of a doubt or a fear. In Matthew 21:21 the Lord said, "Assuredly I say to you, if you have faith and do not doubt" (see Mark 11:23, "and does not doubt in his heart") you also can dry up a tree, and even transport a mountain into the sea. See also Hebrews 10:22, "full assurance of faith" and James 1:6, "ask in faith, with no doubting". Mark 5:34 and Matthew 15:28 offer positive examples, and Matthew 14:30-31 the opposite.

If an authority gives a commission to someone, he will presumably back that commission up to the limit of his capacity. Since Christ's capacity is without limit, His backing should be so as well (as far as He is concerned). In Matthew 28:18 He said: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me." Then comes the commission: "As you go make disciples . . . teaching them to obey everything that I commanded **you**"—the pronoun refers to the eleven apostles (verse 16). Very well, so what commands had Jesus given to the Eleven? Among others, "heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, cast out demons" (in Matthew 10:8—perhaps 94% of the Greek MSS do <u>not</u> have "raise the dead"). The Eleven also heard John 20:21. Knowing that we have the backing of the

[a] Yes, but the authority is to trample them; the intent is to kill or destroy. Evidently the Lord Jesus is talking about eliminating those things.

Sovereign of the universe, who has all authority and all power, we can and should do our duty with tranquil confidence.

4. Very well, we have the incumbency, the competence and the authority to face and solve the problem posed by humanoids in our world. It remains to know how to proceed, in terms both specific and concrete. I really cannot imagine that it could be God's will for His Church to be defeated or humiliated in this matter. So there must be a solution, and we need to keep calling out to God until He gives us a clear answer on this. Still, I believe that a few observations may already be made.

In the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. The Text tells us that this sword is "the ρημα of God"—ρημα, not λογος. It is God's Word spoken, or applied. Really, what good is a sword left in its sheath? However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.

In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1, 18:36, 2 Kings 1:10). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:19). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak!

The centurion did not say, "In the authority of Rome . . ."; he just said, "Do this; do that". The Lord Jesus did not say, "In the authority of the Father . . ."; He just said, "Be clean! Go!" In Luke 10:19 He said, "I give you **the** authority over all the

power of the enemy"—so we have the authority; so let us speak!! Just like Jesus!

In Luke 17:6 we have a 'contrary to fact' condition, that in a literal translation would be: So the Lord said, "If you had faith [but you don't] like a mustard seed *has*,[a] you would say [but you don't] to this mulberry tree, 'Be pulled up by the roots and be planted in the sea,' and it would have obeyed you." The second apodosis is in a past tense, whereas the protasis and the first apodosis are in the present tense.[b] It is a curious grammatical construction, but I suppose that the Lord is emphasizing the certainty of the response—if they would only speak!!

I would translate Hebrews 11:1 like this: "Now faith is a realization of things being hoped for, an evidence of things not (being) seen." The concept of 'hope' in the New Testament includes an element of certainty (it is not mere wishful thinking). To declare as fact something we do not see is difficult for many (including myself), but I believe that to be the meaning of the Text. True faith is able to declare the existence of something before seeing it. When the centurion gave an

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[a] I rather doubt that the Lord is commenting on the size of the faith; rather it is a quality of faith. But, what type of 'faith' might a mustard seed have? Although so small, it responds to the climatic circumstances without hesitation, and grows to a remarkable size. If we would respond without questioning to the nudges of the Holy Spirit, our 'climatic circumstances', we could literally transport a tree, just with our word. In Matthew 17:20 the Lord Jesus said, "If you have faith as a mustard seed *has*, you <u>will</u> say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there,' and it <u>will</u> move; and nothing will be impossible for you." That is what He said, but we just don't believe it.

(But why then did Jesus emphasize the size of the seed? However small a seed may be, it can germinate and produce. However small a person may be [or appear to be] in the Kingdom of God, if he has the faith of a seed he will produce marvelously.)

[b] Well, actually some 30% of the Greek manuscripts, including the best line of transmission, have the protasis in the imperfect tense.

order, he was declaring what was going to happen, before the fact. He spoke, and it happened.[a] Of course the Lord Jesus did precisely the same thing; He would speak and it happened. I cannot help but wonder if some day people will say about me, "Of course he did the same thing; he would speak and it happened."

5. Perhaps someone will say: "Sure, sure, we have to speak; but exactly what are we going to say, and how and when and where?" Good questions. On the way to an answer, we need to consider the following. Among all the sacrifices and burnt offerings in the Old Testament there is nothing for premeditated sin—something done with the intention of challenging or disdaining the Creator ('with a raised fist' in Hebrew), in short, rebellion. Thus, Deuteronomy 17:12 imposes the death penalty for rebellion; there was no sacrifice for that. According to Numbers 15:27-28, there was indeed sacrifice for unintentional sin, but now notice verse 30: "But anyone who sins defiantly, whether native-born or alien, blasphemes Jehovah, and that person must be cut off from his people." To insult Jehovah carried the death penalty, there being no sacrifice for that. Exodus 21:12-17 determines that those guilty of certain crimes must be executed. Notice especially verse 14: "But if a man schemes and kills another deliberately, you must take him away from my altar and execute him." Imagine that! At that time the altar represented precisely the means for expiating sins. To run to the altar was a way to plead for God's mercy and protection, but the Creator does not allow this recourse to a murderer—a murderer must be executed. People can object all they like, but the Creator is resolute—whoever deliberately kills the image of God

[a] We do well to remember, however, that it only worked, or would work, within the reach of his authority. That is why he appealed to Jesus—he himself could not heal the servant.

(without due cause) must be killed in his turn; there is no indemnity. I have already commented on Leviticus 18:6-30 and 20:1-22, where incest, adultery, human sacrifice, homosexualism and sex with an animal received the death penalty. To be sure, since it was the society that applied, or was to apply, the penalty, it would only happen in the community of God's people. Pagan peoples were ignorant of God's laws. But none of that alters the fact that there was no sacrifice for such practices.

But how about the New Testament, does not the age of Grace change the picture? To try to argue that God's grace annuls His moral law will not work. Note Romans 1:18-32, where it is clear that the application is current. In verse 32 'the righteous judgment of God' is that those who practice the things mentioned (including the list in Leviticus 18) "**are** deserving of death". "Are", not "were"—the verb is in the present tense, as in the original Text. In other words, Paul affirms that the penalty has not changed; even in the Church age, the age of grace, certain persons continue to be subject to death—by divine sentence. 1 Corinthians 10:6-12 declares that the experiences of Israel in the desert are "examples for us" and "were written for our admonition" (verse 11), and concludes with: "Therefore let him who thinks he stands take heed lest he fall." All the examples given resulted in physical death, and if they were recorded for our admonition, it is because we may face something similar. We cannot be too careful! 1 Corinthians 6:9, Revelation 21:8 and 22:14-15 were also written after the day of Pentecost. And notice Hebrews 10:26, "For if we sin willfully after we have received the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins" (see verses 26-31). We cannot be too careful!

As for blood guiltiness (see Deuteronomy 21:1-9, 19:13 and Numbers 35:33), 1 Corinthians 11:27-30 makes clear that the New Testament does not change the Creator's position

regarding it. According to verse 27, whoever drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the blood of the Lord. And what is the consequence? The answer is in verse 30: "For this reason . . . many sleep." 'Sleep' means they are dead; in other words, God executed them. The apostle Paul, inspired by the Holy Spirit, declares that with reference to "many" the Creator had exacted the penalty of blood guiltiness, literally—the culprit died. I confess that God's severity in this case surprises me, but there it is. Let no one kid himself; the Creator is still punishing blood guiltiness!

The Bible declares that God created man in His own image, and from then till now men have tried to return the favor, creating their own 'god' in their minds (of course any god you create will be smaller than you are, inescapably—totally worthless). Something similar happens to God's love, concerning which the vast majority of people, including believers, have a mistaken view. "Whom the Lord loves He chastens, and **scourges** every son whom he receives" (Hebrews 12:6; see also Revelation 3:19). [I myself have been on the business end of a horsewhip, and can assure the reader that it isn't pleasant.] In Deuteronomy 33:2-3 the "fiery law" is an expression of God's love for the people. Precisely because He is concerned for our true wellbeing, the Creator imposes the earthly consequences of our sins. The love of God **necessarily** includes hating evil, because of the consequences of the evil that will harm His 'image'.

Hebrews 1:8-9 cites Psalm 45:6-7, declaring that it refers to the Son: among other things it is affirmed that He hates iniquity. The glorified Christ Himself declares that He hates the works of the Nicolaitans (Revelation 2:6). Jehovah hates stealing (Isaiah 61:8), divorce (Malachi 2:16) and seven other transgressions (Proverbs 6:16-19). "The fear of Jehovah is to hate evil" (Proverbs 8:13; and see 9:10). In Psalm 97:10 we

have a command: “You who love Jehovah, hate evil!” Are we going to obey?

Psalm 5:5 informs us that Jehovah hates all workers of iniquity. We are in the habit of teaching that God hates sin but loves the sinner. It seems so, up to a point. But when someone decides to join Satan, and makes a point of practicing evil, he attracts God’s wrath—Deuteronomy 7:10. (See Psalm 26:5; 31:6; 101:3; 119:104, 113, 128, 163—these help us to understand David’s attitude in Psalm 139:21-22; it is because they act with wicked intent [verse 20] that he hates them.) We must learn to hate sin, evil in any and all forms, Satan and his angels—since they are beyond recovery (Matthew 25:41, 2 Peter 2:4, Revelation 20:10), we are in a war without pity, without quarter, to the death.

The Sacred Text is clear: the character of God does not change, cannot be altered. In Malachi 3:6 Jehovah Himself declares that He does not change. James 1:17 affirms the same thing in other words. Hebrews 13:8 affirms something similar about Jesus Christ. Let us give special attention to 2 Timothy 2:13. “If we are faithless, He remains faithful; He cannot deny Himself.” He cannot deny Himself—is it not obvious? He cannot go against His very nature, His own essence; it is one thing that God cannot do. He is Truth, and so cannot be unfaithful. It is precisely for that reason that He is incapable of lying (Titus 1:2).

Now let us consider Deuteronomy 7:9-10: “Therefore know that Jehovah your God is **God**; He is the faithful God who keeps covenant and mercy for a thousand generations with those who love Him and keep His commandments; and He repays those who hate Him to their face, to destroy them. He will not be slow to repay to his face the one who hates Him.” If God repays hate with destruction, and without delay,

then He does not offer salvation to that hater.[a] Obvious. Palm 34:16 reads like this: "The face of Jehovah is against those who do evil, to cut off the remembrance of them from the earth" (quoted in 1 Peter 3:12). Well now, to erase the memory of someone you must begin by erasing that someone himself. Any question? When a person chooses to become an ally of evil, he is challenging the Creator to kill him, literally. 2 Peter 2:17 affirms this about the allies of evil described in verses 9-17: "for whom the blackest of the darkness has been reserved forever".[b] We find the same expression in Jude 13. With an eternal reservation like that, what are their chances? John 3:16 declares that giving His Son was an expression of God's love for the world. So He offers salvation to those He loves, not those He hates. Whoever decides to hate God receives the hate back, and remains without salvation. In John 6:44 (and verse 65) the Lord Jesus declares, "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him", and it should be obvious that the Father is not going to draw someone whom He hates.[c] Actually, when you stop and think about it, for someone who hates God, being in Heaven would really be a sort of 'hell'.

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[a] In Joel 3:4 Jehovah expresses Himself like this: "Indeed, what have you to do with me, O Tyre and Sidon and all the coasts of Philistia? Will you retaliate against me? But if you retaliate against me, swiftly and speedily I will return your retaliation upon your own head." God demonstrates the same attitude as in Deuteronomy 7:10—He does not tolerate perversity.

[b] This darkness is associated with Satan's kingdom, because "God is light and in Him is no darkness at all" (1 John 1:5). Peter is affirming that they will share the same destiny as their boss.

[c] John 3:36 is also to the point: "The one believing into the Son has eternal life, but the one disobeying the Son will not see life, but the wrath of God remains upon him." Will the Father 'draw' someone who remains under His wrath? How? The Text declares that the person **will not** see life—not ever.

In Matthew 10:25 the Lord Jesus affirms: "It is enough for a disciple that he be like his teacher, and a slave like his owner." 1 John 4:17 says that "just as He is, so are we in this world". So then, if He hates those who work iniquity, Psalm 5:5, we have the obligation to do the same thing. To permit a malevolent person to continue doing damage in this world, when it is incumbent upon us to remove him, turns us into his accomplices. An accomplice to a crime is a criminal. In Luke 10:19, when the Lord Jesus gives us the authority to trample snakes and scorpions, it follows that He is also giving us the incumbency—otherwise, why give the authority? To 'trample' involves hostile intent. Just to step on a scorpion, even without wanting to, will crush the insect, will kill it. How much more if you do it with hostile intent! The purpose of trampling a snake is also to kill it. Conclusion: it is up to us to rid the world of 'snakes' and 'scorpions'; it is our responsibility; it is our incumbency! So, God is waiting on us —**we** are the ones who have to do it! And we will do it by speaking.

6. Conclusion: Humanoids are not candidates for salvation, do only evil, and therefore need to be eliminated, for the public good. Human beings who have chosen Satan, who have sold themselves to him to devise and do evil, are haters of God and therefore cannot be saved—they need to be eliminated for the public good. The partisans of the militant 'gay' agenda are a case in point; they are in open rebellion against the Creator and His values. Since it is their declared intention to destroy our culture, making it impossible for decent people to live in peace, we are facing a question of life or death. If we do not react adequately, we will lose the game.[a]

At least three times the Lord Jesus referred to the Holy Spirit as being "the Spirit of the Truth" (John 14:17, 15:26,

[a] I wrote this a number of years ago. It would appear that we have in fact lost the game.

16:13). It follows that to deliberately reject the Truth is to blaspheme the Holy Spirit, the unpardonable sin (Mark 3:29). It adds to our case. The enemies of God are without pardon, without salvation, do only evil, and are therefore a type of cancer or gangrene in society—if the society does not get rid of it, the society will be killed. Since the society at large does not have the slightest idea of the danger it faces, and even less of the solution, it is up to us to save the day, we who know and can. Recalling the exposition of Psalm 149 (Solution, 2.), I understand that all the texts that speak of the divine intention to eliminate partisans of evil enter the list of texts that state a 'written judgment'. And it is up to us to impose written judgment.

I invite attention to Psalm 91. The context is one of war. Since God offers protection to those who take refuge in Him, the terror, the arrow, the pestilence, the destruction come from the enemy. Verse 13 says: "You shall tread upon the lion and the cobra, the young lion and the serpent you shall trample underfoot", which reminds us of Luke 10:19. Verse 7 speaks of a thousand falling on our left and ten thousand on our right. Why the difference? Most people being right-handed, a sword is normally held in the right hand. So a soldier would normally kill more to the right than to the left.

Asides

2 Corinthians 10:4 teaches us that "the weapons of our warfare are not carnal". So we must do our duty in the spiritual realm, using God's power. I understand that this is done verbally in the presence of the Righteous Judge of the whole earth (2 Timothy 4:8, Genesis 18:25, Hebrews 12:23), citing the written judgments specifically and applying them by name to those who deserve them.

1. More than one person has asked: "If humanoids were a reality that the Christians would have to face, why did not the Lord Jesus teach about them, why did Paul not write about

them, nor any of the other authors of the New Testament?" The question is based on a false premise, that the New Testament is silent on the subject, but I will argue that it is not. Let us see.

It is a simple fact that the Bible frequently uses the term 'man' to refer to a materialized angel. In Genesis 18:2 Abraham saw three 'men', two being angels and the third Jehovah Himself (and the three ate the meal he prepared). As the story goes on, 19:1 says plainly that they were angels, but in verses 5, 10, 12 and 16 they are called 'men'. Once more in Genesis 32:24 the term 'man' refers to Jehovah Himself (see also Joshua 5:13). In Judges 13:6 Samson's mother refers to the Angel of Jehovah, who had appeared to her, as a 'man' (also in verses 8, 10 and 11). See also Daniel 3:25 and 28, 8:15-16, 9:21, 10:5 and 16, 12:5-7; Ezekiel 2:26; Zechariah 1:8-11, 2:1-3. In the New Testament angels had an important role at Jesus' empty tomb, sometimes appearing as angels, sometimes as men (Matthew 28:2-7, Mark 16:5-8, Luke 24:4-7, John 20:12-13). See also at the ascension of Jesus, Acts 1:10-11. Well now, if an angel can be called a 'man', why not, and all the more, the offspring of an angel? Quite so.

In Genesis 6:4 the hybrid race, the half-breeds, are called 'men', as also in the description that follows. Since the descripttion in 2 Timothy 3:1-5 parallels the description in Genesis 6, the 'men' here presumably includes humanoids. The same holds for the description in Jude 10-19 and in Romans 1:28-32. Consider also 1 John 2:18—"Children, it is the last hour, and just as you have heard that the Antichrist is coming, even now many antichrists have appeared, by which we know that it is the last hour." Well, the Lord Jesus was a hybrid being, Holy Spirit with woman. I do not doubt that the actual Antichrist will also be a hybrid, Satan with woman (his 'thing' is to be like God). So what about the 'many antichrists' to which John refers, what might they be? It seems to me to

be perfectly possible that they also were hybrids, precisely our 'humanoids'.

Once we start 'chewing' on this subject, I think we are obliged to conclude that humanoids themselves will marry and procreate—perhaps with another humanoid, but I imagine that the preference would be with a human. In that way the miscegenation would become increasingly diluted, and such subsequent generations would certainly be called 'men'. If we stop and think, the cultures where the parents choose a mate for their children may not be so 'stupid' as some might like to imagine. Really, to check out the lineage of a prospective mate is an important proceeding, in fact necessary (an impulsive marriage with a humanoid equals disaster).

Further, as I have already maintained, the 'snakes' in Mark 16:18 and Luke 10:19 and the 'scorpions' in Luke, presumably include humanoids. Also, I understand that the Holy Spirit has confirmed to me that the 'dogs' in Matthew 7:6 (and probably in Philippians 3:2 and Revelation 22:15) include humanoids.[a]

Over forty years ago, when I started ministering on the subject of biblical spiritual warfare, I soon realized that not a single text that treats of our 'weapons' or procedures explains how to do it. For example: Mark 3:27 teaches that we must bind Satan; but does not say how! In James 4:7 we have the command to resist the devil; but it does not say how. 2 Corinthians 10:4 says we have some great weapons; but does not identify them—if they are the gerundive clauses in verses 5 and 6, again we are not told how to do it!! I take it that God uses Satan and his angels (the demons) to test and train the successive generations of people, and if all the procedures were clearly laid out, God's people would have wiped out the enemy long since. So, it is cheerfully foreseeable that the

[a] Although the Jews were in the habit of referring to Gentiles as 'dogs', the context here calls for a different meaning.

references to humanoids in the New Testament will be veiled, none of which justifies the claim that the New Testament does not mention the subject.

2. In John 14:12 the Lord Jesus said: "Most assuredly I say to you, the one believing into me, he too will do the works that I do; in fact he will do greater works than these, because I am going to my Father. "Most assuredly" is actually "amen, amen"—rendered "verily, verily" in the AV. Only John registers the word as repeated, in the other Gospels it is just "amen". In the contemporary literature we have no example of anyone else using the word in this way. It seems that Jesus coined His own use, and the point seems to be to call attention to an important pronouncement: "Stop and listen!" Often it precedes a formal statement of doctrine or policy, as here.

"The one believing into me, he too will do the works that I do." This is a tremendous statement, and not a little disconcerting. Notice that the Lord said, "will do"; not 'maybe', 'perhaps', 'if you feel like it'; and certainly not 'if the doctrine of your church permits it'! If you believe you **will do!** The verb 'believe' is in the present tense, 2nd person singular; if you (sg.) are believing you will do; it follows that if you are not doing, it is because you are not believing. 2 + 2 = 4. Doing what? "The works that I do." Well, Jesus preached the Gospel, He taught, He cast out demons, He healed all sorts and sizes of sickness and disease, He raised an occasional dead person, and He performed a variety of miracles (water to wine, walk on water, stop a storm instantaneously, transport a boat several miles instantaneously, multiply food, shrivel a tree—and He implied that the disciples should have stopped the storm and multiplied the food, and He stated that they could shrivel a tree [Peter actually took a few steps on water]). So how about us? The preaching and teaching we can handle, but what about the rest? I once heard the president of a

certain Christian college affirm that this verse obviously could not mean what it says because it is not happening! Well, in his own experience and in that of his associates (cessationists all) I guess it isn't. But many people today cast out demons and heal. Miracles are also happening. So how about me? And you?

"In fact he will do greater works than these." Well now, if we cast out demons, heal and perform miracles, is that not enough? Jesus wants more, He wants "greater things" than those just mentioned [do not forget what He said in Matthew 7:22-23]. Notice again that He said "will do", not maybe, perhaps, or if your church permits. But what could be 'greater' than miracles? This cannot refer to modern technology because in that event such 'greater things' would not have been available to the believers during the first 1900 years. Note that the key is in the Lord's final statement (in verse 12), "because I am going to my Father". Only if He won could He return to the Father, so He is here declaring His victory before the fact. It is on the basis of that victory that the 'greater things' can be performed. Just what are those 'greater' things? For my answer, see my outline (essay), "Biblical Spiritual Warfare". Now I would add to the list 'get rid of humanoids' ('robots' and 'snakes' should also receive appropriate attention).

In verse 12 the verb 'will do' is singular, both times, so it has to do with the individual. Please note that the Lord did **not** say, 'you apostles', 'just during the apostolic era', 'only until the Canon is completed', or whatever. What He did say is, "the one believing", present tense, and so it applies to any subsequent time including the present day. To deny the truth contained in this verse is to call the Lord Jesus a liar. Not a good idea![a]

[a] One other point: to affirm that the miraculous gifts ceased when the last clod of dirt fell on the Apostle John's grave is an historical

3. In Luke 4:18-21 Jesus includes "to set at liberty those who are oppressed" (Isaiah 8:6) among the things He was sent to do. Turning to Isaiah we find that Jehovah is declaring what type of 'fast' He wants to see: "To loose the fetters of wickedness [a], to untie the yoke thongs [b]; to set the oppressed free [a], and that you break every yoke [b]." As is typical of Hebrew grammar, the two halves are parallel. "To loose the fetters of wickedness" and "to set the oppressed free" are parallel. Who placed the fetters and who is doing the oppressing? Well, although people can certainly forge their own chains through a sinful lifestyle, it seems to me that in this context it is evil beings putting the fetters on others. "To untie the yoke thongs" and "that you break every yoke" go together. First we should untie the thongs/cords that bind the yoke to the neck, and then we should break the very yokes. It seems clear to me that this text treats of the activity of Satan's servants: men, demons, humanoids. Using culture, worldview, legal maneuvers, threats, blackmail, lies, deceit and plain demonization and witchcraft, they bind individuals, families, ethnic groups, etc. with a variety of fetters and instruments of oppression.

Well, but so what? What does that have to do with our subject? Well, fasting was an important/obligatory component of their worship of God. It follows that this kind of 'fasting' is something that Jehovah overtly wants; it is His declared will. And so, whenever we see the work of Satan in someone's life, it is God's will that we undo it. If we know that it is God's will, we can proceed with complete confidence. It is also included in our commission (John 20:21).

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falsehood. Christians who lived during the 2nd, 3rd and 4th centuries, whose writings have come down to us, affirm that these gifts still existed in their time. No Christian of the 20th or 21st century, who was not there, is competent to contradict them.

Well, and what if we do nothing?

James 4:17—"Therefore, to the one knowing to do good and not doing it, to him it is sin." So, if I do not undo Satan's works, it shows up on my bill as sin, and I will have to answer for it. Ezekiel 22:30-31—"I sought for a man among them who would make a wall, and stand in the gap before me on behalf of the land, that I should not destroy it; but I found no one. Therefore I have poured out my indignation on them; . . ." The Text is clear: just one person could have made the difference, and averted the destruction. See also Malachi 1:10, that asks for just one person to act. So then, if I do not undo Satan's works, people will continue to suffer, without need. If I reject the plain meaning of the Text, I am closing my mind against the Truth, and thereby condemning myself to continue living with error and its consequences. Condemning myself and any others who depend on me or follow me. Help!

We need the gift of discerning spirits! [Note that 'spirits' is plural.][a]

7) Baptisms in the Bible

Our vocabulary item 'baptism', and its verb 'baptize', are transliterations of the corresponding terms in the Greek New Testament. I am not aware of equivalents in Hebrew, so I will base this study on the NT, including for the baptisms in the OT. Why did the translators into English choose to

[a] I regret that I must confess that during 20 years of ministering on Biblical spiritual warfare around Brazil I never taught this gift, and I never heard anyone else explain it. We must try to diminish the damage. To deny the existence of cancer, AIDS, aviary flu, etc., would be to guarantee that a solution would never be found. Analogously, to deny the existence of humanoids will carry the same guarantee. Not a valid option! To ignore the word of Sovereign Jesus can only bring negative consequences—it was He who said, "As were the days of Noah"!!

transliterate rather than translate? Probably because, as with He-brew, we have no corresponding terms that would serve for a translation. Of course, by now the transliterated terms are part of our vocabulary. I will organize this study of the baptisms under three headings: 1) during the old covenant, 2) during the transition, 3) during the new covenant.

Baptisms during the old covenant

1) In 1 Corinthians 10:2 our versions generally say that the people who departed from Egypt "were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea". I would prefer 'by the cloud and by the sea', but what is the point of the statement? The people were identified with Moses, and that identify-cation translated into dependence and obedience. Without Moses they would not have crossed the sea, and they had to obey 'blindly', as it were, no matter how improbable the situation. They were guided and protected by the cloud, but under the authority of Moses. An identification that expres-ses itself in dependence and obedience might well serve for a definition of Christian baptism, at least in part.

2) Mark wrote for a Roman audience, and in 7:3-4 he explains certain Jewish customs:

> Because the Pharisees, indeed all the Jews, do not eat unless they wash their hands in a special way, holding to the tradition of the elders. When they come from the marketplace, they do not eat unless they baptize them-selves. And there are many other things they have received and hold—baptisms of cups, pitchers, copper vessels and couches.

'The tradition of the elders' was based on the written instructions given by Moses that had to do with purification. That purification was done with water. The idea of purifi-cation is not foreign to Christian baptism.

3) Based on extra-biblical information (not in the Bible), we know that a Gentile who converted to Judaism was

baptized—it was one of the requirements that he had to fulfill. That baptism was done with water, but there is doubt as to just how it was done. However, it appears that it represented a formal declaration to the effect that the person was changing religion, or way of life. It was a procedure that carried with it significant consequences in both the social and spiritual spheres. We may understand that such a baptism served as a background for John's baptism—the people were used to the idea.

Baptisms during the transition

1) All four of the Gospels speak of the ministry of John the Baptizer. John began his ministry proclaiming and offering a baptism of repentance for forgiveness of sins[a] (Mark1:4). Matthew and Mark record that the candidates would confess their sins; of course, it was their sins that they were repenting of. All four of the Gospels record that John was preparing the way of the LORD. John himself affirmed that he baptized with water, but the Text does not clarify how he did it.

2) John baptized Jesus. This was a unique case that did not fit the declared nature of the baptism offered by John. Jesus had no sin; He had nothing to repent of; He did not need pardon. Indeed, John did not like the idea: "I have need to be baptized by You, and You are coming to me?" (Matthew 3:14). In answer Jesus said to him, "Permit it now, because thus it is appropriate for us to fulfill all righteousness." This response has given rise to a variety of interpretations, but

[a] There are those who squirm at the plain meaning of the Text—John was offering forgiveness of sins. Well, throughout the Old Testament, if you brought an animal offering, you were confessing to being a sinner, and expecting to be forgiven. As forerunner to the Lamb of God, who would provide the ultimate payment for sin, John represented a transition, from the old to the new. Should someone ask, "How could one person pay for the sins of the whole world?", I offer the following possibility: to pay an infinite debt, would require an infinite person, and Jesus was, and is, an infinite person.

upon reflection, we do not need to interpret it, since it was not a norm or an example to be followed; it was *sui generis*.

3) John 3:22, 26; 4:1 and 2 mention that the disciples of Jesus were baptizing—John 4:2 makes clear that Jesus Himself was not baptizing. The Text does not offer any details about the nature of that baptism. We may imagine that they were following John's example, helping to prepare the way of the LORD. The absolute lack of detail makes clear that this baptism did not become a norm to be followed. However, if they were indeed using John's baptism, it continued to be used, here and there, for some time, as Acts 18.25 and 19:3 make clear.

4) In Luke 12:50 Jesus said, "I have a baptism to undergo, and how distressed I am until it is completed!" When Jesus responded to the ambitious request from James and John, He referred to the same baptism (Matthew 20:22-23, Mark 10:38-39). It appears to refer to suffering within God the Father's Plan. In His response to James and John He also referred to the 'cup', the same one He mentioned in Gethsemane. As for Jesus, this baptism was fulfilled on the cross at Golgotha, which happened before the new covenant. As for James and John, they experienced this baptism later on. If my description of this baptism is correct, then it still exists today (1 Peter 4:19).

Baptisms during the new covenant

1) John the Baptizer said that Jesus would baptize "with Holy spirit and fire" (Luke 3:16). There has been no lack of interpretations for this statement, but I would say that the next verse clarifies the intended meaning: "whose winnowing shovel is in His hand, and He will thoroughly clean out His threshing floor and gather the wheat into His barn, but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire." See also Matthew 3:11-12. Now then, the 'unquenchable fire' must refer to the Lake of fire and brimstone, the second death, and in that case

the 'chaff' refers to the lost—it is the lost who will be baptized with fire.[a] In that case, the 'wheat' refers to the saved—those who are genuinely saved will have been baptized with Holy Spirit. In John 1:33 God Himself says that Jesus will baptize with Holy Spirit. But just how and when does Jesus baptize us with Holy Spirit? He does it from His position at the Father's right hand (1 Peter 3:21-22), when we believe into Him. At that point the Holy Spirit begins to indwell us, and He has a good deal to do with our 'new nature'. I take it that Acts 1:5 refers to this baptism, as does Acts 11:16; it began on the day of Pentecost.

The case of Cornelius deserves its own paragraph. Cornelius <u>really</u> wanted to know God and to please Him—he was serious! So when Peter began to expound, Cornelius hung on his every word. When Peter got to "everyone who believes into Him[b] will receive forgiveness of sins", Cornelius did! And Jesus baptized him with Holy Spirit. Poor Peter, Jesus got ahead of him, and as he later said in his defense, "who was I to be able to withstand God?" (Acts 11:17). So then Peter said to bring on the water (Acts 10:47)—please notice the order: first Holy Spirit, then water!

I understand Mark 16:16 to refer to this baptism. "The one who believed and was baptized will be saved; but the one who did not believe will be condemned." In the Text, the verbs 'believe' and 'baptize' are participles in the past tense—one could render 'the one having believed and having been

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[a] According to 1 Corinthians 3:11-15, the <u>works</u> of the saved will be tried by fire. Although John certainly said "and fire", both Matthew (according to 80% of the Greek manuscripts) and Mark omit the phrase. Why? I suppose because they were focusing on the present and near future, while the 'fire' is part of the final Judgment.

[b] The Text always says 'believe <u>into</u>', not 'in'—a change of location is involved, from being outside to being inside, which requires commitment.

baptized'.[a] There will be no lack of people who were baptized with water in Hell; baptism with water does not save. The Text says that the person who did not believe will be condemned, with no mention of baptism—it should be obvious that Jesus will not baptize someone who did not believe. Let me repeat that: it should be obvious that Jesus will not baptize someone who did not believe! It is the person who genuinely believes who receives the Holy Spirit. One needs to remember that the commission Jesus stated here in Mark was given in the evening of Resurrection Day, while the commission that He stated in Matthew, that inaugurated Christian baptism, was given weeks later in Galilee. **Here in Mark, Christian baptism did not yet exist**.

I stated that water baptism does not save; how then do I explain Acts 2:38? "Repent and be baptized, each one of you, upon the name of Jesus Christ, for forgiveness of sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit." To begin, this took place on the day of Pentecost itself, and may have been something of a transition. Then, the context is king of interpretation, and the context here is very specific, so what Peter said should not be taken as a generic standard. Verses 36 and 40 are crucial to understanding Peter. "Therefore, let all the house of Israel know assuredly that God has made Him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom **you** crucified!"[b] (verse 36). So then they asked what they should do. Peter concluded with, "Escape from this perverse generation!" (verse 40). The 'generation' in question was the one that had crucified the

[a] Unfortunately, every version that I have seen (including my own!—that I have changed for the fourth edition) puts the verbs in the present tense, which makes it easier to think in terms of water baptism.

[b] Nothing like making sure your audience gets the point! But why "both Lord and Christ"? Perhaps there were a variety of ideas about the 'Messiah' out there and Peter nails down His identity as the Lord.

Messiah. By being baptized upon the name of **Jesus Christ** they would be formally disassociating themselves from that generation, and the judgment that was coming upon it. This is the first use of the title, Jesus Christ, after the Gospels; the Lord had Himself inaugurated the title fifty days before (John 17:3)—it affirms that Jesus is the Messiah. Anyone being baptized upon that name would be publicly declaring allegiance to Jesus **as the Messiah**. Peter promised forgiveness of sin and the gift of the Holy Spirit to any who entered into that commitment. Anyone who did that would be believing into Jesus, and He would baptize them with Holy Spirit. It was not the water that saved them.

I understand that 1 Peter 3:21 also refers to this baptism; the poor verse has suffered considerably at the hands of commentators. Since there was no lack of water around Noah's Ark, interpreters have tended to carry the water over to the baptism in the next verse, but it does not follow. Consider: verses 19 and 20 mention certain rebellious angels in Noah's day, "while the Ark was being prepared, in which a few, that is eight, souls were brought safely through water". Then comes verse 21, that I would translate like this: "Its antitype[a] now saves us also, a baptism through the resurrection of Jesus Christ, 22 who is at the right hand of God, having gone into heaven, angels and authorities and powers having been made subject to Him." So just which baptism might this be? It is Jesus baptizing with Holy Spirit, from His position at the Father's right hand. Just as the Ark preserved the eight from the water, the baptism with the Holy Spirit preserves us from Satan and his subordinates. The careful reader will have noticed that verse 21 above is not complete; I did not include the parenthetical explanatory aside: "(not the removal of physical filth, but the appeal into God from a good

[a] The antecedent of 'its' is the Ark.

conscience)". I would place it at the end of verse 21, as I translated it, between 'Christ' and 'who'. Peter makes it clear that he is not talking about baptism with water.

In John's baptism, he is the agent; in Christ's baptism, He is the agent; a baptism where the Holy Spirit is the agent is different (as also where believers are the agents). In John's baptism, the substance used was water; in Christ's baptism, the substance used is the Holy Spirit. In John's baptism, the person got wet, but then dried off, so the true meaning of the procedure was a spiritual transaction; how much more then with Christ's baptism. I believe that we may link the baptism where Christ is the agent to John 4:13-14 and 7:38-39.

> Jesus answered and said to her: "Everyone who drinks of this water will thirst again, **14**but whoever drinks of the water that **I** will give him will never ever thirst; rather, the water that I will give him will become in him a spring of water, welling up into eternal life."[a]
>
> "The one believing into me, just as the Scripture has said, out from his innermost being will flow rivers of living water."[b] **39**(Now He said this about the Spirit, whom those

[a] That is what the Text says, "into eternal life". Eternal life is a quality of life, more precisely a life in communion with the Father. The picture is not necessarily of a geyser, water spouting up, but there has to be a constant flow. As our capacity increases, the flow should also increase. Of course the water must be shared with others, or we become stagnant.

[b] Just where does the Scripture say this, and why "rivers" (pl); would not one be enough? Reference Bibles will give a variety of suggestions, none of which really fit. I personally believe that the reference is to Ezekiel 47:1-12, and most especially to verse 9 where the Hebrew Text has two rivers (or torrents)—when that river got to the Dead Sea it evidently divided, so as to go along both banks at once. Living water takes life and health wherever it goes. So how much living water is flowing out of me, or you? The secret of that water is

believing into Him were going to receive,[a] in that the Holy Spirit had not yet been *given*, because Jesus had not yet been glorified.)

In other words, when Jesus baptizes you, you are regenerated, you receive a new nature, you receive the Holy Spirit.

Ephesians 4:5 refers to "one Lord, one faith, one baptism". But as we all know, there are a number of baptisms in the Bible, and even in the Church age. The only viable candidate for this 'one baptism' is the one where Jesus Christ, the 'one Lord', is the agent. Anyone who has not been baptized by Jesus is not part of the Church.

2) The main text for Christian baptism, so to say, is the Great Commission in Matthew 28:18-20:

> And approaching, Jesus asserted to them saying: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. **19**As you go,[b] make disciples in all ethnic nations: baptizing them into the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit;[c] **20**teaching them to obey everything that I commanded <u>you</u>;[d] and take note, I am

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given in verse 12: "their water flows from the sanctuary" ('their' refers to the trees). Compare 1 Corinthians 6:19.

[a] When you believe into Jesus you receive the Holy Spirit.

[b] The familiar 'therefore' is found in perhaps 5% of the Greek manuscripts, but it is a logical inference.

[c] Our Lord defines the Trinity here. According to Greek grammar the use of 'and' plus the definite article with items in a series makes clear that the items are distinct entities. So "the Father" is different from "the Son" is different from "the Holy Spirit". So we have three persons. But He also said, "into <u>the</u> name", singular, not 'names'. So we have only one name. God is one 'name' or essence, subsisting in three persons.

[d] The 'you' here refers to the Eleven (see verse 16), so they were to pass down all the commands that Jesus had given them. To be a disciple of Jesus you should do everything that Jesus had commanded the Eleven to do—this includes healing and casting out demons, as well as preaching the Gospel.

with you every day, until the end of the age!"[a]

The order is to make disciples, not just to 'win souls'. So how does one make a disciple? The two gerunds explain it: "baptizing them" and "teaching them", which should be done by those who themselves are genuine disciples. What concerns us here is the baptizing. The substance used is water, as in John's baptism, but the agents are disciples of Jesus. And this baptism is to be administered into the name of the Trinity, which represents a new revelation about the nature of God. It also represents a new 'religion', quite different from those previously known. In the OT there are veiled references, that as we look back we can associate with the Trinity, but here we have the first clear statement on the subject (see footnote 2 below). But what is the significance of being baptized into the name of the Trinity?

A person's name represents that person. To do something 'in the name of the king' means that the something was ordered by that king; the speaker is representing the king (or is claiming to do so). So then, what does it mean to be baptized into the Trinity? Well, if you are inside the Trinity, then you are protected by Them, because before anything can get to you it must pass through the Trinity. This is tremendous! However, it also calls for a marked change in behavior—sinning inside the Trinity does not sound like a good idea! So then, the true meaning of this baptism should be the following: it is a public declaration, taking a public stand, whereby the candidate is formally renouncing Satan, and the world controlled by him, and is placing himself under the protection of the Triune God. It is to change sides, or teams, or kingdoms, and this carries with it an appropriate change in lifestyle.[b]

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[a] Since the age has not ended, Jesus is still with us. Praise God!

[b] Kind reader, can you name even one local church, in the whole country, that teaches this meaning for this baptism? What a shame!

I confess that I do not understand why, to judge by the inspired accounts, the apostles were not rigorous in the manner in which they obeyed the Commission. At least, according to Acts 2:38, the baptism was "upon the name of Jesus Christ", and according to Acts 10:48, Peter commanded to baptize Cornelius and company "in the name of the Lord Jesus".[a] And according to Acts 19:5, Paul baptized those disciples of John "into the name of the Lord Jesus". But upon reflection, I suppose that the practical result would be the same—to be under the protection of Sovereign Jesus would amount to being under the protection of the Trinity.

In fact, Jesus was the ultimate revelation of the nature of God to man. As He Himself said to Philip, "he who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). "In Him all the Fullness was pleased to dwell" (Colossians 1:19), and "all the Fullness of the Godhead dwells in Him in bodily form" (Colossians 2:9). In short, as He walked this earth, Jesus represented the Trinity.

As with John's baptism, the Text does not specify how this baptism was administered. In consequence, down through the centuries, there has been argument and disagreement about it, as to how much water should be used. I see no way of settling the question, and it probably does not make any difference, at least in the spiritual realm. The important thing is the nature of the transaction in the spiritual realm, not the material substance used. But consider the baptism of Saul of Tarsus (Acts 9:18). At that time there was no plumbing in the houses; any water had to be carried into the house. In the house where Saul was staying, in Damascus, there was certainly no swimming pool, and almost as certainly, no tank of

[a] The Greek manuscripts are divided as to the name here: 35%, including the best line of transmission, have 'the Lord Jesus'; 57% have 'the Lord'; 8% have 'Jesus Christ'. None of the variants refers to the Trinity.

sufficient size to handle a grown man (and even if there was, the owner would not want to have his water contaminated). We may be certain that Ananias used a small amount of water.[a] The same can be said about the dwelling of Cornelius (Acts 10:48)—not much water for a lot of people. The same can be said about the house of the Philippian jailor (Acts 16:33)—not much water for a lot of people. In short, the important thing is the spiritual transaction, not the substance or the manner.

3) In 1 Corinthians 12:12 Paul uses the figure of the members of a body to speak of the Church, and goes on with verse 13: "For we also were all baptized into one body by one Spirit—whether Jews or Greeks, whether slaves or free—and were all given to drink into one Spirit." I take Galatians 3:26-28 to be about the same baptism: "So all of you are sons of God through the faith in Christ Jesus. 27 As many of you as were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ 28—there is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no 'male and female';[b] all of you are one in Christ Jesus."[c] I take it that Paul is saying that the Holy Spirit baptizes us into Christ. But how so? When and how would it happen?

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[a] In Acts 22:16 Paul himself mentions that experience; he cites Ananias as saying, "and wash away your sins, invoking the name of the Lord". By invoking the Lord, he was placing himself under His protection, which equals believing into Him, which was what took care of his sins, not the baptism.

[b] The Text does not have 'neither male nor female'; the formula changes, as I have indicated. I suppose that the reference is to Genesis 1:27, and to the reason for the female in Genesis 2:18. All are saved on the same basis.

[c] The reference is to the spiritual realm, not the physical—a Jew who believes into Jesus does not stop being a physical Jew, a slave who believes into Jesus does not automatically change social status, a male who believes into Jesus does not stop being a physical male. Obvious.

It would be simultaneous to the moment when Jesus baptizes a person with the Holy Spirit.

Due to a basic human limitation, language is linear—it is impossible to say everything at the same time; the relevant information must be given a piece at a time. Something complex, like the spiritual transformation of a human being, can, and should, be described from different angles or perspectives. When we believe into Sovereign Jesus we receive the Holy Spirit; but at the same time we are introduced into His 'body' here on earth, which is the Church. And it is the presence of the Holy Spirit within us that is the proof that we belong to Jesus and are part of that 'body'—Paul describes that proof as a baptism. A 'baptism in the Spirit' as being a second, or third, 'work of grace', is simply not in the Text. What there is, indeed, are repeated fillings—the more, the better.

4) Due to the limitation that language is linear, it seems to me that in Romans 6:2-4 Paul deals with yet another aspect of the spiritual transformation that we receive in Christ. He insists on the necessity of a holy life, using the argument that we were in Jesus when He died, and so we died too, and a corpse shouldn't sin. But since the physical body of Jesus was buried and then raised, we were too, and now we have access to the power of God to enable us to live differently. To cover all that Paul used the phrase, "baptized into Christ Jesus", which probably refers to what the Holy Spirit does, as discussed in the prior item. I take Colossians 2:11-12 to be parallel to Romans 6:2-4.

5) 1 Corinthians 15:29 has given no end of exercise to commentators, and also translators. Most versions just put baptized 'for the dead', but does that mean 'on behalf of the dead', or 'in favor of the dead', or 'because of the dead', or 'in the place of the dead'? The context is the king of interpretation, and the context here is the reality of resurrection. If

there is no resurrection, then our faith is in vain, we are suffering needlessly. I would say that the intended meaning is 'in the place of the dead'; that is, new converts occupying the space left by those who had died—in those days there were many martyrs. If there is no resurrection, there would be no point to becoming a Christian, just to feed the lions. The 'baptism' here could include both with the Holy Spirit and with water.

6) It remains to deal with Hebrews 6:2 and 1 Corinthians 1:17. In Hebrews 6:2 'teaching about baptisms' is included in the 'elementary teaching' (verse 1), that should be left behind so we can 'move on toward perfection'. But since that teaching is in the company of repentance, faith, resurrection and eternal judgment, truths that form an essential part of our Faith, it is not being treated as inferior. Such doctrines are part of the foundation for spiritual growth, but that growth depends on factors beyond the basic truths.

But how could Paul say in 1 Corinthians 1:17 that "Christ did not send me to baptize", since in the Great Commission Jesus commanded to do it? Once again, we must pay attention to the context. Beginning at verse 10, Paul is combating divisions based on individuals; there were 'parties', one of them following Paul himself. In an effort to reject that 'party', he argues that no one was baptized into his name (verse 13); and he goes on to thank God that he himself had baptized few people, precisely so that they could not say that he used his own name. Then comes verse 17: "Because Christ did not send me to baptize, but to preach the Gospel." Is Paul denying that water baptism is part of the Gospel? It almost seems so. Or was he distinguishing between essential and nonessential? If we define 'essential' as being the elements that are necessary for someone to be saved, then water baptism is a nonessential—it joins other elements that are relevant to

spiritual growth, to living the Christian life, and such elements are certainly important.

Conclusion

For us today, the one, all-important, baptism is the one where Jesus is the agent and the substance used is the Holy Spirit. The key is to believe into Jesus. When we believe into Him, He baptizes us with Holy Spirit. Anyone who has not been baptized by Jesus is not part of the Church.

8) Before, or after?

2 Thessalonians 2:2 X 2:7-8

In Matthew 24:44 we read, "Therefore you also be ready, because the Son of the Man is coming at an hour that you do not suppose." I take it that for there to be the element of surprise the Rapture of the Church must occur before the "abomination of desolation". When the Antichrist takes his place in the Holy of Holies and declares himself to be god, there will be precisely 1,260 days until the return of Christ to the earth. "An hour that you do not suppose" presumably requires a pre-'abomination' rapture—if the rapture is pre-wrath but post-abomination, only a fool will be taken by surprise, unless the Rapture happens immediately after the 'abomination' (2 Thessalonians 2:3-4).

We may begin with 2 Thessalonians 2:2. Some 15% of the Greek manuscripts have 'day of the Lord' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.); the 85% that have 'day of Christ' (including the best line of transmission) are doubtless correct. I remember one day in a Greek exegesis class, the professor stated that one reason he preferred the 'critical' text (that reads 'Lord' here) is that it fit better with his view of eschatology—the 'Day of Christ' is usually associated with the Rapture and blessing of the saints, while the 'Day of the Lord' is usually associated with heavy judgment upon the world and unrepentant Israel, including the outpouring of wrath just before and after the

Second Coming of Christ, when He returns in glory to establish His Millennial Reign. The perceived difficulty here would appear to be that while verses 1, 6 and 7 evidently relate to the Rapture, verses 3-4 and 8-10 evidently relate to the Great Tribulation and the Second Coming.

What to do? Look carefully at the Text. In verse 2, why would the Thessalonian believers be "disturbed"? Someone was teaching that the Rapture had already happened and they had been left behind—I would be disturbed too! So 'day of Christ' is precisely correct with reference to the content of verses 1 and 2. The trouble comes in verse 3 because a clause is elided; as an aid to the reader translations usually supply a clause, preferably in italics, to show that it is an addition, as in NKJV—"*that Day will not come*". But that would put the Rapture after the revelation of the man of sin and the 'abomination of desolation'—definitely not congenial to certain eschatological systems. An easy 'solution' would be to change 'Christ' to 'Lord' in verse 2, but that would put the Rapture within the 'day of the Lord'—also not congenial. I submit that fine-tuning our view of eschatology is preferable to tampering with the Text.

If the 'Restrainer' in verses 6-8 is the Holy Spirit, then the Rapture happens before the 'abomination', and may be viewed as its 'trigger'. I translate verse 7 as follows: "For the mystery of the lawlessness is already at work; only He who now restrains *will do so* until He removes Himself." Perhaps more literally, 'gets Himself out of the middle' (the verb γινομαι is inherently middle in voice). I would say that the Holy Spirit is the only one who satisfies the description. But if the 'Day of Christ' includes the Rapture, then verse 3 would appear to place the Rapture after the 'abomination'. So where does that leave us? Although my own training was strongly 'pre-trib', I have moved to a 'meso-trib' position. If the Rapture follows immediately upon the 'abomination',

then the 'surprise' factor remains untouched. If the 'abomination' and the Rapture happen within minutes of each other, then from God's point of view they form a single 'package', and the actual sequence is not important—for all practical purposes they happen at the same time.

One more thing: Luke 17:30-35 deals with the Rapture. If the Rapture and the Abomination are simultaneous, and if you are left behind—head for the hills!

9) Bethsaida, or Tiberias?

Luke X John

The question is: just where did the feeding of the 5,000 men take place? Matthew 14:13 and Mark 6:32 merely say that it was in a deserted spot, without identification. But Luke 9:10 says it was in "a deserted place belonging to a town named Bethsaida",[a] while John 6:23 informs us that the spot was near the town of Tiberias. Well now, Tiberias was located on the west side of the Sea, a mile or two above the place where the Jordan River leaves the Sea. But Bethsaida was at the top of the Sea, a little to the east of where the Jordan enters the Sea. What to do?

We may deduce from Mark 6:31 and John 6:17 and 24 that Jesus and His disciples started out from Capernaum, where Jesus had His base of operations. It happens that Capernaum, like Bethsaida, was situated at the top of the Sea,

[a] Lamentably, the eclectic Greek text currently in vogue, following a mere half of one percent of the Greek manuscripts (and that half made up of objectively inferior ones), says that they went "to a town named Bethsaida." This is an obvious perversity because two verses later the same text has them in a deserted place. So the editors of that text make Luke contradict himself, as well as contradicting the other three Gospels, since all agree that the place was deserted. Unfortunately, this perversity is duly reproduced by NIV, NASB, TEV, etc.

but a little to the west of the entrance of the Jordan. To go from Capernaum to Bethsaida by boat one would not get far from the shore. But John 6:1 says that Jesus "went over the Sea of Galilee," and that agrees better with Tiberias, since there is a large bay between Capernaum and Tiberias, although they are both on the west side of the Sea—they crossed close to ten miles of water. Further, after the feast, Matthew 14:22 says they went by boat "to the other side", and verse 24 has them "in the middle of the Sea"; while Mark 6:45 says that they went by boat "to the other side, to Bethsaida", and verse 47 has them "in the middle of the Sea"; and John 6:17 says that they "started to cross the Sea toward Capernaum", and verse 19 that "they had rowed some three or four miles."

Well now, to stay close to the shore is one thing, to go over the Sea is another. Further, if they were already in or near Bethsaida, how could they cross the Sea in order to get there (Mark 6:45)? It becomes clear that the miracle in fact took place near Tiberias, as John affirms. But that raises another difficulty: how could a property near Tiberias 'belong' to Bethsaida (Luke 9:10)? Either it had been deeded to the town somehow, or, more likely, it belonged to a family that lived in Bethsaida. My reason for saying this is based on the Text.

John 6:17 says that they "started toward Capernaum", while Mark 6:45 says that they went "to Bethsaida". Since the two towns were a short distance apart, at the beginning of the crossing the direction would be virtually the same. I understand that they did indeed go to Bethsaida, but spent very little time there, going from there directly to Genesaret. Indeed, the day after the miracle Jesus was already back in Capernaum (John 6:24-25). But just why did they make that side trip to Bethsaida (Genesaret lies just south of Capernaum)? I imagine the following: a property near Tiberias, but

belonging to someone in Bethsaida, would likely be deserted, a great place for a picnic. I suppose that Jesus had permission to use the place, when He wanted to get away, but no one had foreseen a crowd of perhaps 15,000 (5,000 men plus women and children). Please pardon the unpleasant consideration, but what effect would a crowd that size have on the hygiene and appearance of the place? I conclude that Jesus felt obligated to give a report to the owner, in Bethsaida.

While we are here, allow me to call attention to another miracle Jesus performed, that you will not find in the usual lists. As already noted, Matthew 14:24 and Mark 6:46 say that they were in the middle of the Sea, but John 6:19 is more precise, saying that they had gone perhaps four miles. It happens that a crossing from Tiberias to Bethsaida would involve about eight miles. And now, attention please to John 6:21, "Then they wanted to receive Him into the boat, and immediately the boat was at the land to which they were going". If the total distance was eight miles, and they had only managed half of it, then Jesus transported the boat four miles instantly. Now that was a fair-sized miracle, to transport a boat four miles in an instant! You will not find this miracle in most lists, because few people take the time to give a detailed examination to the Sacred Text.

10) Buy a ticket to Heaven?

Luke 16:9

In the NKJV, Luke 16:9 reads like this: "And I say to you, make friends for yourselves by unrighteous mammon, that when you fail, they may receive you into an everlasting home [literally, 'the eternal dwellings']." Within the context the Lord is clearly using irony, or sarcasm. In the immediately preceding verse, the owner's 'commendation' of the stupid steward is obviously sarcastic, since the steward was sacked. And verse 14 below indicates that what Jesus said was for the

benefit of the Pharisees, who were greedy. The use of sarcasm is not rare in the Bible. Getting into the eternal dwellings does not depend on 'buying' friends down here; it depends on pleasing the Owner up there. And who says someone who can be bought with 'unrighteous mammon' is going to Heaven? He would have to get there first in order to 'receive' the buyer. The whole 'scene' is patently ridiculous. Just by the way, verse 13 declares a terribly important truth. To embrace the world's value system (humanism, relativism, materialism) is to reject God. Materialistic 'Christians' are really serving mammon ('mammon' includes more than just money).

11) Buy cleansing?

Luke 11:41

In the NKJV, Luke 11:41 reads like this: "But rather give alms of such things as you have; then indeed all things are clean to you." My translation reads like this: "Nevertheless, give what is possible as alms; then indeed all things are clean to you." At first glance this statement seems difficult, but because they were filled with greed, for them to give away as much as possible would represent a major change in their values. Zacchaeus offers a case in point: the Lord Himself declared that he was saved (Luke 19:8-9).

12) 'Cainan' #2

Luke 3:36 X Genesis 11:12

"**35**of Serug, of Reu, of Peleg, of Eber, of Shela, **36**of Cainan, of Arphaxad, of Shem, of Noah, of Lamech,"

There are several spelling variations that together are attested by almost 1% of the MSS; 99% have *Kainan*. Apparently only two omit, P^{75v} and D, but no printed text follows their lead. So there is no reasonable doubt that Luke in fact

wrote that Shelah was fathered by Cainan, not Arphaxad. This Cainan has been widely used to justify treating the genealogies in Genesis like accordions—if one name was demonstrably left out in the Genesis account, then who knows how many others were also left out. This Cainan is also used to deny the validity of constructing a strict chronology based on the time spans given in the genealogies.

But where did Luke get this information? The LXX contains Cainan in Genesis 11:12, but is so different from the Massoretic text here that it looks like fiction. Recall that the LXX we know is based on codices Vaticanus, Sinaiticus and Alexandrinus, produced centuries after Luke. It is more likely that our LXX is based on Luke than vice versa. Where then did Luke get it? I understand that Luke obtained the information about this Cainan from records existing in his day, and being correct information was led by the Holy Spirit to include it in his Gospel. Just like Jude, who quoted Enoch—Enoch's prophecy must have been in existence in Jude's day, but we have no copy in Hebrew today (though Jews are reported to have used one so recently as the 13th century A.D.); similarly, we have no copy of Luke's source.[a]

This brief note was inspired by the discussion of the subject given by Dr. Floyd N. Jones in *Chronology of the Old*

[a] Let us recall Luke's stated purpose in writing: "It seemed good to me also, most excellent Theophilus, having taken careful note of everything from Above, to write to you with precision and in sequence, so that you may know the certainty of the things in which you were instructed" (Luke 1**:3**-4). Given his stated purpose in writing, Luke's account needs to be historically accurate (cf. 2:2 and 3:1). So then, I take it that the Holy Spirit guided Luke to include Cainan #2; I will argue the same for Joram below. While I am on this tack, my solution to the 'Jeremiah' problem in Matthew 27:9-10 is similar. Daniel (9:2) refers to "the books" (plural) in connection with Jeremiah the prophet. So I assume that Matthew had access to other writings of Jeremiah, of which no copy survives.

Testament[a] (which book comes close to solving all the alleged numerical discrepancies in the OT, at least as I see it). However, the explanation that follows is original with me (if anyone else has proposed it, I am unaware). Let us recall the exact wording of Genesis 11:12-13. "Arphaxad lived thirty-five years and begot Salah; after he begot Salah, Arphaxad lived four hundred and three years, and begot sons and daughters."

The verb 'begot' requires that Salah be a blood descendant of Arphaxad, not adopted. He could be a grandson, the son of a son of Arphaxad, or even a great-grandson, etc., except that in this case the time frame only has room for one intervening generation. The plain meaning of the formula in the Text, 'W lived X years and begot Y; after W begot Y he lived Z years,' is that W was X years old when Y was born, is it not?[b] I take the clear meaning of the Hebrew Text to be that Arphaxad was 35 years old when Salah was born, whatever we may decide to do about 'Cainan'.

Let us try to imagine the situation in the years immediately following the Flood. After the Flood the 'name of the game' was to replenish the earth. Indeed, the divine

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[a] *Chronology of the Old Testament: A Return to the Basics* (Floyd Nolen Jones, The Woodlands, TX: Kings Word Press, 1999, pp. 29-36). (This is the 14th edition, revised and enlarged—the 1st came out in 1993.) I imagine that many readers may feel uncomfortable with the author's very dogmatic way of expressing himself, but I would urge them to filter out the rhetorical style and concentrate on the substantial arguments, that are of extraordinary value. For example, his solution to the conundrum of the reigns of the kings on the two sides of the divided monarchy is simply brilliant, and to my mind obviously correct, leaving no loose ends. (In this connection, he debunks the claims of Edwin R. Thiele and William F. Albright.)

[b] It follows that this formula destroys the 'accordion' gambit. There were precisely 130 years between Adam and Seth, 105 between Seth and Enosh, 90 between Enosh and Cainan #1, etc., etc.

command was: “Be fruitful and multiply” (Gen. 9:1). So, whom could Noah’s grandsons marry? Obviously their cousins, Noah’s granddaughters. There would be an urgency to reproduce—thus, the girls would be married off at puberty, and the boys would not be wasting around either. The women would be giving birth as often as they possibly could. Really, the absolute top priority would be to increase the number of people.

Arphaxad was born two years after the Flood, but his wife could have been born a year or two earlier. (The Sacred Text is clear to the effect that only eight souls entered the ark, but some of the women could have conceived during the Flood.) Thus, Arphaxad could have fathered “Cainan” when he was 17/18. Similarly, Cainan could have fathered Salah when he was 17/18. In this way Arphaxad could be said to have “begotten” Salah when he was 35. Cainan could have died early or been passed over in Genesis because the time span did not constitute a ‘generation’, or both. Or, as things got back to normal, culturally speaking, the haste with which Arphaxad and Cainan procreated might have been viewed as unseemly. The expedient of omitting Cainan would make the account more ‘normal’ while preserving precision as to the elapsed time.

But Luke would be correct in saying that Salah was “of” Cainan who was “of” Arphaxad. Salah was Arphaxad’s grandson. In any case, the Messianic line was passed on by Salah. Without Luke’s record I, for one, would never have stopped to consider what must have happened immediately following the Flood—the absolute priority must have been to increase the number of people.

13) 'Censer', or 'altar of incense'?

Hebrews 9:4

What concerns us here is the Greek word, *θυμιατηριον*, that occurs only here in the NT. In the LXX the meaning of the word is 'censer', and that is plainly the intended meaning here. But unfortunately modern versions like NIV, TEV, LB, NASB, etc. render 'altar of incense', thus setting up a contradiction with the Old Testament. [What could have motivated such a perverse proceeding?] According to Exodus 30:6 the altar of incense was placed in front of the curtain leading into the Holy of Holies, and so it was in the Holy Place, not the Holy of Holies. The only reference to this particular censer appears to be in Leviticus 16:12, where it was to be used behind the second curtain to hide the Ark with smoke. Since that censer would only be used once a year (on the day of atonement), it may well have been stored just behind a corner of the second curtain (where the high priest could retrieve it without looking in) and thus the author of Hebrews would be correct in saying that the censer was behind the second curtain, whereas the altar was in front of it. In any event, evidently that censer was **used** only within the Holy of Holies, and so it would be appropriate to say that the area 'had' a golden censer.

14) Contentment

What is 'contentment'? It is to be at rest and satisfied within the situation in which you find yourself. Our purpose here is to study what the Bible says about it. I believe we will find that what God expects of us is to be content with the supply of the physical things we are given: what to eat, what to wear, and basic shelter. As for spiritual growth, usefulness for the Kingdom, and suffering, what God expects is different. These questions will be considered one by one.

Material supply: We may start with 1 Timothy 6:6-10.

> "Now godliness with contentment is great gain. 7 We brought nothing into the world and it is certain that neither can we take anything out. 8 So having food and clothing we will be content with that. 9 But those who want to get rich fall into temptation and a snare and into many foolish and harmful desires, that plunge people into ruin and loss; 10 because the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil; in their greediness some have been led away from the faith and have impaled themselves on many distresses."

Verse 7 is reminiscent of Luke 12:15-21, the parable of the rich man who only thought about amassing money. I repeat the conclusion here: "But God said to him: 'Stupid! This very night your life is being taken back from you;[a] then who will get the things you have prepared?' 21 Just like that is he who accumulates treasure for himself and is not rich toward God." "Just like that" = "Stupid!" Being rich toward God means investing in His Kingdom. That's right; nobody can take it from here, but if you belong to Jesus, you can send it on ahead, by investing in the Kingdom of God down here.

Verse 8 is reminiscent of Matthew 6:31-33, a word of Sovereign Jesus: "Therefore do not worry, saying, 'What shall we eat?' or 'What shall we drink?' or 'What shall we wear?' For the pagans seek all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need each of these things. Rather, seek first the Kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you." "These things" refers to food, drink and clothing – the basics. Jesus does not promise luxury, and not always'comfort'. Just how seeking the Kingdom first works out in practice will differ from person to person.

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[a] "Taken back" – we have our life on loan, like a trust, and an accounting will be required.

In verse 10, the love of money is just **a** root, not 'the' root. Love of money is just one of the causes that lead people to do evil. As for the 'distresses', as the Text says, "the way of transgressors is hard" (Proverbs 13:15). Remember that the Sovereign said: “You cannot serve God and mammon” (Luke 16:13). Someone who switches from God to mammon will probably never switch back. The final 'distress' will be the Lake of Fire.

Commenting on the entire passage, it should be obvious that the Text is not teaching us to do nothing. 2 Thessalonians 3:10 and 12: “If anyone does not want towork, neither let him eat!” Well now, whoever goes without eating ends up dying. To work is mandatory. Now verse 12: "We exhort by our Lord Jesus Christ that they work in quietness and eat their own bread". Of course, to eat your own bread, you have to earn it first. To earn your own bread, you will need to take whatever work available, not wait for a 'decent job'. If you don't eat while you are waiting, you will die!

By the way, it seems that God does not like lazy people. “Six days you shall labor” is in the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:9). The book of Proverbs criticizes the sluggard several times. The first one is in 6:6: “Go to the ant, you sluggard! Consider her ways and be wise.” Where I live, I myself have a constant fight with the little ants: they never stop! There are other texts on the subject, but I have commented enough.

Now consider Philippians 4:11-13.

> “I am not saying this because of lack, since I have learned to be content whatever the circumstances. 12 I know what it is to be restricted, and I know what it is to have an abundance; everywhere and in every way I have been initiated both into being well fed and into being hungry, both into having plenty and into having need. 13 I can handle anything through Christ who strengthens me.”

In verse 11 Paul says that he had to **learn** contentment, so it is not something automatic, and it's not even easy. In verse 13 Paul is not claiming to be all-powerful ('I can do all things'), but God's grace is sufficient to meet whatever comes its way. This grace is given case by case, and sometimes we have to ask for it.

See also Hebrews 13:5.

> "Your way of life should be free from the love of money, being content with what you have, because He Himself has said: 'I absolutely will not desert you; I most certainly will not abandon you'."

What a wonderful promise! The reference is to Deuteronomy 31:6 and 8. In verse 8Moses said this to Joshua, but in verse 6 Moses said it to all the people. So, the promise is valid for anyone who is living on behalf of the Kingdom.

Spiritual growth: We can start with Ephesians 4:11-13.

> 11 Yes, He Himself gave some to be apostles, some to be prophets, some to be evangelists, and some to be pastors and teachers, 12 for the equipping of the saints into the work of the ministry, so as to build up the body of Christ, 13 until we all attain into the unity of the faith and of the real knowledge of the Son of God, into a complete man, into the resulting full stature of Christ;

Verse 13 emphasizes the truth in verse 12—<u>every</u> believer is supposed to grow into full stature. Just because we do not reach a goal does not invalidate that goal. Until we reach the "full stature of Christ," we must not stop growing.

Now consider Luke 10:27.

> 25 And then, a certain lawyer stood up to test Him, saying, "Teacher, what mustI do to inherit eternal life?" 26 So He said to him: "What is written in the Law? How

do you read it?" 27 In answer he said: "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your strength, and with all your mind, and, your neighbor as yourself." 28 So He said to him, "You have answered correctly; do this and you will live!"

Notice that Jesus agreed with him. If you check Deuteronomy 6:5, it mentions only three components of the person, while here in Luke 10:27 there are four. The explanation I give is that the third Hebrew word has such a broad semantic area that in Greek it was considered necessary to use two words to cover that semantic area. What is being said is that we must love our God with all of our being, with all that we are and have. It should be obvious that this is not to stop ever.

Consider also John 14:21-23.

21 The one who has my commandments and keeps them, he is the one who loves me. Now the one who loves me will be loved by my Father; and I will love him, and reveal myself to him." 22 Judas (not the Iscariot) says to Him, "Lord, just how is it that You are going to reveal Yourself to us and not to the world?" 23 Jesus answered and said to him: "If anyone loves me, he will keep my word.And my Father will love him, and we will come to him and make our home withhim.

In verse 21 the Lord gives an important insight on spiritual growth, here: our love → our obedience → His love → His self-revelation. Can you love someone you do not know? Perhaps in theory, but not really. The more you know someone the more you love him/her (especially if they are nice). As we come to know the Lord we grow to love Him, which translates into obedience, which leads Him to reveal Himself to us, which increases our knowledge of Him, which increases our love for Him, which increases our obedience, which

increases His self-revelation, which increases our knowledge, love, obedience, and so on. It is an upward spiral which takes us ever closer to Him. But there is one 'small detail': if we stop, He does too.

Now for verse 23: Like, wow—did you get that? We have always been taught (correctly) that the Holy Spirit indwells the true believer, but here the Lord says that the Father and the Son can be at home with us as well. That is all three persons of the Trinity! There is a condition, however—we must keep Jesus' word, which is really the Father's (next verse). The indispensable evidence that we love God is to obey His word; this stimulates His love in return. There is evidently some sense in which we influence the manifestation of His love, at least. The answer to Judas' question is that the 'revealing' is one on one, and is triggered by one's obedience. So the world is out.

Now consider Matthew 13:12: "For whoever has, to him more will be given and he will have abundance; but whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken away from him." Spiritual growth is like going up an incline on a bicycle with no brakes; if you stop pedaling, you start to go backwards. We must keep learning and growing; if we stop, we start to lose.

Usefulness for the Kingdom: Our spiritual growth has everything to do with our usefulness for the Kingdom, obviously. Then, when you understand that God has a specific direction for your life, you should do what you can to prepare yourself for that function. Each life represents a potential, and the full realization of that potential can only be achieved if the life is lived for the Kingdom of Christ on earth. When someone throws away that potential by choosing an inferior road, it is a cause for sadness, not for contentment. Satisfaction is part of contentment, and we are not to be satisfied with inferior roads.

There are also texts with a general application:

1) "Seek first the Kingdom of God and His righteousness" (Matthew 6:33). 'Seeking' is a process, and it is something every Christian should do.

2) Matthew 5:13-14: "You are the salt of the earth; but if the salt becomes insipid, with what will it be salted? It is then good for nothing except to be thrown out and trampled down by the people.[a] You are the light of the world. A city located upon a hill cannot be hidden." The 'point' is that both salt and light are aggressive. If you put a pinch of salt in a pan of rice, it seasons all of it. Darkness is simply the absence of light. We have a duty to actively promote Kingdom values in all environments where we work.

3) 1 Timothy 3:1-2: "Here is a trustworthy word: if a man aspires to the position of overseer,[b] he desires a good work. 2 Now then, it is obligatory for the overseer to be above reproach, a one-woman man,[c] temperate, sensible, respectable, hospitable, good at teaching [and the list goes on]." The 'point' here is that this ambition is declared to be a good thing. The long list of prerequisites serves to prevent anyone

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[a] 'Christians' who have caved in to the world's values and life style are like insipid salt – good for nothing except to be thrown out. (Insipid salt was thrown on the road, which helped to keep down the dust.) Theimplications of this have become increasingly serious in today's world.

[b] The term here is usually rendered 'bishop', but today a bishop is one who has authority over a number ofother pastors/presbyters/elders, whereas in the New Testament these four terms evidently refer to a single office in the church.

[c] That is what the Text says, strictly speaking, emphasizing the quality—a man who has only one wife, buthas a wandering eye, would not qualify. However, the term 'woman' can also mean 'wife', and becauseof the reference to children in verse four most versions render 'wife'. The term "man" here refers exclusively to males; there is no room here for a female overseer.

from doing so out of mere personal ambition and not for the good of the Kingdom.

4) 1 Corinthians 7:20-21: "Let each one remain in the same calling in which he was called. 21 Were you called while a slave? Do not let it bother you, but if you can really become free, do so." It is not for us to be distressed because of our social condition, but if the Lord opens an opportunity to improve it, I believe that we can (and should) take advantage of it, just like the slave. This improvement is expected to translate into benefit for the Kingdom. There are other texts, but I think we can go on.

Suffering: I think it is obvious that it is hard to be content when you are suffering. Further, if it is God Himself who has sent the suffering, it is not for us to be content; it is to learn the lesson He is trying to teach us. Consider Hebrews 12:5-11:

> "You have forgotten the exhortation that instructs you as sons: "My son, do not make light of the LORD's discipline, nor lose heart when you are reproved by Him; 6 because whom the LORD loves He chastens, yes scourges every son whom He accepts." 7 If you are enduring discipline, God is dealing with you as with sons; for what son is there whom a father does not discipline? 8 But if you are without discipline (something everyone undergoes),[a] then you are illegitimate and not sons. 9 Furthermore, we have had our human fathers as correctors and respected them. Shall we not much more readily be in subjection to the Father of spirits[b] and live? 10 Now they indeed disciplined us during a short period as seemed

[a] At that time there was probably no culture dominated by relativistic humanism.

[b] "The Father of spirits"—an interesting concept. All created spirits owe their existence to Him.

best to them, but He for our profit, so that we may partake of His holiness. 11 Now no discipline seems to be pleasant at the time, but painful; yet afterward it yields the peaceable fruit of righteousness to those who have been exercised by it.

The quote is from Proverbs 3:11-12. When I was a boy my father had a horse, a gentle creature, and a proper horsewhip to go with it. I found myself on the business end of that whip more than once (more often than did the horse), and I can assure the reader that it was not a pleasant experience. So God's scourgings tend not to be very pleasant; but if we end up partaking of His holiness (verse 10), itwill be worth it. At the end of verse 11 we have the 'secret'—we must be "exercised" by the discipline; that is, we must learn whatever lesson the Lord is trying to teach us. There are notable cases, like Job's experience and Paul's 'thorn'.

There is also the problem of the consequences of sins. Everything in life has consequences; they can be either good or bad, depending on the cause. We spend our lives victimizing and being victimized. We victimize others with the consequences of our sins and we are victimized by the consequences of others' sins.That is a two-way street, but the flow is not the same in both. Obviously, some people sin more than others, and some hurt others on purpose. And the function also enters the equation: when the head of the family sins, the family suffers; when a pastor sins, the church suffers; when the mayor sins, the municipality suffers; when the governor sins, the state suffers; when the president sins, the country suffers. And there is no way to escape this suffering, unless God performs a miracle in specific cases. And there is more: sins accumulate. When the 'bucket' is finally full (Genesis 15:16), God determines the destruction of the entity, and whoever is close by suffers. The 45th chapter of Jeremiah

deals with such a case. Baruch thought he deserved special treatment, but verses 4 and 5 give us God's answer.

And then there is the matter of 'completing' the sufferings of Christ. Consider Colossians 1:24: " Now I rejoice in my sufferings on your behalf and supplement in my flesh the things lacking in the afflictions of Christ, for the sake of His body, which is the Church". Evidently the ongoing wellbeing of the Church requires suffering on our part (we cannot add to the saving work of Christ), the enduring of affliction—Satan and his minions are very active in this world. Let's also look at 2 Corinthians 1:5: "Because just as the sufferings of the Christ flow over into us, so also our encouraging overflows, through Christ." We get our share of suffering, we participate in Christ's sufferings. Evidently for God's Kingdom to increase among men, as we continue to undo Satan's works in the world, we have to suffer. 1 Peter 4:13 links this suffering to our reward: the more that we suffer forthe sake of the Kingdom, the greater the reward.

Conclusion: What is 'contentment'? It is to be at rest and satisfied within the situation in which you find yourself. What God expects of us is to be content with the supply of the physical things we are given: what to eat, what to wear, and basic shelter. Naturally He will have to supply the things necessary for us to do the work He assigns us to do. As for spiritual growth, usefulness for the Kingdom, and suffering, what God expects is different, as explained above.

15) Demonization

Strange as it may seem, our versions of the Bible mislead us on this subject. The noun 'demon' is simply a transliteration of the Greek *δαιμονιον* or *δαιμων*. I wish they had done the same thing with the corresponding verb, *δαιμονιζω*. In that event we would have the verb 'demonize'. But no, the

translators put ‘possessed’ of a demon. As a result we have tended to think of demon activity only in terms of possession. Well, so what is the problem? I suggest the following.

By ‘possession’ the translators presumably intended to connote ‘control’, but the more common meaning denotes ‘ownership’, and most people seem to take the second meaning. This has serious consequences. First, the concept is wrong, since demons do not and cannot ‘own’ human beings (although a demon will often claim that its victim “belongs” to it).[a] Second, it has fostered a misunderstanding about Christians and demon ‘possession’—since a believer belongs to God it is presumably impossible that a demon should own him as well. We need to stop using the word ‘possessed’ in this connection altogether and replace it with the more precise term ‘controlled’.

Demon control certainly exists, but it represents only a small part of the enemy’s activity against mankind, precisely the most extreme cases. (Although organic insanity does exist it would not surprise me to verify that most cases of insanity involve at least some demonizing.) The vast majority of the demons' attacks should not be characterized as control. There are less severe forms that are sometimes called oppression or obsession. They also cause physical problems. But I believe that the most frequent attacks interfere with our minds in less obvious ways; so much so that most of the time we are not even aware of it. I suggest that we use the term ‘demonization’ to refer to any and all direct interference, whether in the mind or the body. The following continuum will help us to visualize the concept:

minds | bodies | obsession | oppression | control

[a] Within Satanism there are ‘robots’, people who have turned themselves over to the complete control of a demon. For practical purposes a ‘robot’ is owned by his demon.

Note that I have not included temptation to evil in this continuum. What **is** included in the concept of demonization, however, encompasses a world of suffering.

Let us now consider some consequences of the translation “possessed”. I am not sure how far that rendering is at fault, but ‘traditional’ churches and schools scarcely touch the subject; perhaps because they think only in terms of ownership and conclude that believers are exempt. Whatever the explanation, you could attend certain churches during 20 years and never hear any teaching on Satan and the demons. On the other hand, ‘pentecostal’ or ‘charismatic’ churches and schools do at least deal with the subject, even if only partially. During deliverance sessions they tend to deal mainly with cases of control—is that not so? When does the leader of the service expel a demon? Only when it manifests itself—right? Someone begins to scream, foam at the mouth, roll on the ground or give some other evidence of foreign control, at which the leader confronts the demon and commands it to leave. But if the demon keeps still, what happens? Nothing, usually—nobody bothers it; its presence is not discerned. I know that some order the demons to show themselves, but do all obey? How do we know? Or if the manifestation is not of a type that we recognize as ‘possession’, who will identify and repel it? It seems clear to me that even in the churches where there is expulsion of demons the greater part of the enemy's activity against us goes unrecognized. They are focusing only on control.

I see another consequence that can be rather serious. When we conceive of demonic activity only in terms of ownership, and when a church teaches that a believer cannot be ‘possessed’, the following occurs. A believer is demonized. In terms of the continuum I am suggesting, it is not a case of control, yet the person knows he is being attacked. But the only terminology he knows for talking about demonic attack

is ‘possession’ and the church teaches that a believer cannot be ‘possessed’. So the person is plunged into anguish—he knows he is saved but a believer cannot be ‘possessed’; yet he is being attacked and knows it. What is the explanation and how can he escape? He cannot say anything to the church because if he admits that he is being ‘possessed’ then they will no longer accept him as a believer. He does not dare talk and so he cannot receive help. Even if he did talk, he would not receive adequate help because the leaders think only in terms of ownership. As a result of all that, the poor believer may even reach the point of doubting his salvation! The worst of it all is that such suffering is simply unnecessary. We must learn to speak in terms of demonization, understand that believers certainly are demonized, and explain the use of the spiritual weapons that are at our disposal.

16) Deuteronomy 32:8

“When the Most High divided their inheritance to the nations, when He separated the sons of Adam, He set the boundaries of the peoples according to the number of the children of Israel” (as in the NKJV). In recent decades versions have appeared replacing the last word, ‘Israel’, with ‘God’, either in the text itself or in a footnote, or both. To understand what is going on, we must look at the evidence:

‘sons/children of Israel’—Masoretic Hebrew Text, Samaritan Pentateuch, all ancient versions except the Septuagint (LXX)

‘angels of God’—LXX

‘sons/children of God/gods—Dead Sea Scrolls (DSS); so alleged by the footnotes mentioned above.

Of course the LXX has been around for a long time, but few had the courage to follow it in Deuteronomy 32:8 until the advent of the DSS, so to them I now turn.

Those who have given any attention to the DSS know that for Deuteronomy there are only fragments, most being mere scraps with a few letters on them. Of these, two have been alleged to contain bits of 32:8—4QDeut-j and 4QpaleoDeut-r. 4QpaleoDeut-r stands for a group of scraps (a. 20), one of which is said to contain bits of 32:6-8. Upon inspection, the end of verse 8 is not there, so this scrap is irrelevant to the question in hand.

4QDeut-j is a fragment containing a few letters spread over three lines: the first line has parts of three letters; the second line has five or six letters; the third line has nine letters, being *bene elohim*, 'sons of gods'. So far as I have been able to confirm, this is the sole basis for the claim that the DSS have 'sons/children of God' in Deuteronomy 32:8. (If anyone knows of something that I have missed, please send it to me.) But wait just a minute please, on what basis can anyone responsibly claim that 4QDeut-j is an honest copy of the biblical book, Deuteronomy? The Essenes had their own ideas about such things, and were not averse to writing in defense of their ideas. The scrap is scarcely sufficient for a clear, demonstrable identification. Indeed, the editors themselves say that it is from an "excerpted" document. Not only that, the scrap definitely does **not** have the biblical *bene haElohim* found in Genesis 6:2 and 4, and Job 1:6, 2:1 and 38:7. **I deny that the DSS furnish any valid evidence against the reading of the Masoretic Text in this place**.

Now I wish to say a few words about the LXX here. The LXX that we know and use is based on three Alexandrian manuscripts from centuries after Christ: Alexandrinus, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus. With reference to the New Testament, the contribution of those three MSS has been mainly

negative, and especially so on significant doctrinal questions. What possible basis could anyone have for imagining that the editors responsible for the NT in those MSS would not do similar damage to the Old Testament? If they did not like or understand 'sons of Israel', they were perfectly capable of changing it to 'angels of God'. None of which should encourage us to follow them.

Having said all of the above, we should not be unduly critical of those who have difficulty understanding this verse. How can the inheritance of the nations depend on the number of Israelites [or on the number of angels, for that matter]? I do not know; but God does! Consider the following texts:

1 Peter 1:19-20: "but with the precious blood of Christ, as of a faultless and pure lamb; who was foreknown indeed before the foundation of the world, but was revealed in these last times for your sake." God's Lamb, with blood shed, was so known before the creation of our race and planet. You cannot have blood without a body, so the incarnation and the whole Plan of redemption was in place before the Creation.

Ephesians 1:4: "just as He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before Him, in love." This one is difficult for our poor little finite minds to handle. I, Wilbur Pickering, was chosen before the world was made, so God knows who I am, and all about me. Our Good Shepherd calls us by name (John 10:3). If God knew all about me before Creation, then obviously He knew all about the "sons of Israel" also, so Deuteronomy 32:8 should present no difficulty to our understanding.

2 Timothy 1:9: "the One who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not because of our works but because of His own purpose and grace, which was given to us in Christ Jesus before time began." Repeat the comment above. Note that 'time' had a beginning.

Titus 1:2: “in hope of eternal life—which life God, who cannot lie, promised before the ages of time.” Repeat the comment above.

Acts 15:18: “All His works are known to God from eternity.” Although perhaps 5% of the Greek manuscripts omit this verse (as in most modern versions), the 95%, including the best line of transmission, are certainly correct. Of what relevance is ‘time’ to an eternal Being? It may be that ‘time’ and ‘space’ are concepts that are limited to our planet and our solar system. (Without time and space, how can you calculate speed or distance, or determine the size and age of the universe?) God knew all about the “nations” and the “sons of Israel” before Creation.

Matthew 25:34: “Then the King will say to those on His right: ‘Come, you blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom that was prepared for you at the foundation of the world.” More of the same.

Hebrews 4:3: “His works were certainly finished from the foundation of the world.” More texts could be added to this list, but I have given enough to make the point: our notions of ‘time’ do not place any limit upon the eternal God. The Text is perfectly clear; God knows what is going to happen long before it actually does. Our tiny, limited, finite minds have trouble understanding this, but that does not alter the fact. It should be equally obvious that we are totally incompetent to ‘improve’ upon a divinely inspired Text.

Vast segments of Christianity, beginning in early centuries, have been anti-Semitic, at least theologically. They consider that the Church replaced Israel as God’s people, and so on. I wonder if that anti-Semitism might have something to do with the haste with which some have jumped on the ‘sons of God’ bandwagon. But whatever one’s personal predilections, surely questions of the Text should be resolved on the basis of objective evidence.

17) Did Jesus hide?

John 8:59

In the NKJV, John 8:59 reads like this: "Then they took up stones to throw at Him; but Jesus hid Himself and went out of the temple, going through the midst of them, and so passed by." My translation reads like this: "Then they picked up stones to throw at Him;[a] but Jesus was concealed and went out of the temple, going through the middle of them; yes, that is how He got away!" The familiar "hid Himself" is not the best rendering here. Jesus did not try to hide behind a pillar, or whatever. He was surrounded by angry Jews with stones in their hands. Obviously they would have seen Him and started stoning. He became invisible and simply walked out, passing right through the middle of them. About half a percent of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality (demonstrably so), omit "going through the middle of them; yes, that is how He got away" (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.). The 99.5% are doubtless correct, and supply an important detail.

18) Did she, or didn't she—2 Samuel 6:23 X 2 Samuel 21:8

The Massoretic Text of 2 Samuel 6:23 affirms that Michal the daughter of Saul "had no children to the day of her death". The same Massoretic Text of 2 Samuel 21:8, at first glance, appears to say "the five sons of Michal the daughter of Saul, whom she bore to Adriel the son of Barzillai the Meholathite". But according to 1 Samuel 18:19, it was Michal's older sister, Merab, who was married to Adriel. What to do? The NIV and most modern versions solve the difficulty by replacing 'Michal' with 'Merab' in 2 Samuel 21:8, and NIV graciously

[a] Since certain situations demanded a stoning, there were doubtless piles of ammunition placed strategically around the temple premises.

supplies us with a footnote explaining the proceeding. “Two Hebrew manuscripts, some Septuagint manuscripts and Syriac (see also 1 Samuel 18:19); most Hebrew and Septuagint manuscripts *Michal*.” Being freely interpreted, this means that they followed the two Hebrew manuscripts against all the rest. The reason for the replacement would appear to be obvious: the copyist did not understand the Text and assumed a discrepancy, which he officiously ‘corrected’. The AV and NKJV solve the difficulty in a different way, they render 2 Samuel 21:8 as “whom she brought up for Adriel”. It remains to enquire if the Hebrew verb here can reasonably be translated in that way.

I will begin with Michal. She evidently had a mind of her own, and tried to influence her circumstances as best she could. Her father, king Saul, was using his daughters as ‘chess pieces’ in his ‘game’ to get rid of David. He started by offering Merab, the older daughter, to David, but for some reason he changed his mind and gave her to Adriel (1 Samuel 18:17-19). The next verse says that Michal loved David, and she obviously made her wishes known, because Saul cheerfully took her up. The ‘dowry’ was designed to get David killed, but he actually turned in twice the required amount. Evidently the gruesome ‘dowry’ did not interfere with Michal’s emotions, but for what-ever reasons, it does appear that she never bore any children. The list of David’s sons born in Hebron, by six wives, makes no mention of Michal. Actually, after she helped David escape, he became a fugitive, and she probably did not see him again until she was given to Palti (1 Samuel 19:12 and 25:44).

Years later, as David became king of the united kingdom, he demanded the return of Michal. (I find this difficult to understand, since he already had at least six other wives.) So Abner went to get her, and her husband, Palti/Paltiel, followed behind wailing (2 Samuel 3:13-16). To judge by Palti’s

attitude, he and Michal must have gotten along reasonably well, or he would not have been so worked up. And Michal may not have been all that thrilled at the change. Not only that, now she would be wife number seven (at least), instead of the one and only. And then there was the episode in 2 Samuel 6:16-22. Anyway, whatever the reasons, Michal never had any children of her own, which brings us to 2 Samuel 21:8.

The Hebrew verb in question here, *yalad*, is massively used in the O.T. in the sense of 'beget/bear'—'beget' when used of a man, and 'bear' when used of a woman. However, even in the O.T. it has other meanings, quite apart from the use it received outside the O.T. A Hebrew verb root can receive quite a variety of vowel pointings, producing a variety of meanings. The original Hebrew Text was consonantal, without the vowel pointings added by the Massoretes, and it is the consonants that are inspired. Aside from the central meaning, 'beget/bear', the verb *yalad* is used of midwives and of a woman who brings up someone else's children. The translation found in the AV and NKJV, "whom she brought up for Adriel", is perfectly legitimate, and most probably correct. In that time and culture, a married woman without children was a frustrated woman. Michal may have been sterile, and her sister may have been frail, needing help, and may even have died, following her fifth son. Whatever the reasons, Michal's contribution was sufficiently substantial so that she could legitimately be said to have brought up Adriel's children.

19) Did the centurion leave his house?

Luke 7:1-10 X Matthew 8:5-13

It has often been supposed that these are parallel accounts of the same incident. To be sure, both involve a centurion, in Capernaum, a sick servant, and the statement of the centurion along with the Lord's reaction are very similar.

But other details simply do not match. Evidently the Romans had an army base in Capernaum, with a centurion as commanding officer, who could be rotated. [Where do you suppose Peter sold most of his fish? And what language did he use?] Looking at the sequence of events in both Matthew and Luke, I would say that the incident recorded by Matthew happened first, and a number of months before the one recorded by Luke. Of course an incident like that would become part of the 'folklore' of the base. I assume that the centurions were different, but they certainly knew each other, so the second one knew every detail of the first incident. When his turn came, he used a different strategy to make his appeal (he was asking for a second favor), but then repeated the statement that had impressed Jesus so favorably. So, the first centurion left his house, but the second did not.

20) Did the cross kill Jesus?

John 10:18 X Mark 15:39, John 19:30, Matthew 27:50, Luke 23:46

In the NKJV, John 10:17-18 reads like this: "Therefore My Father loves Me, because I lay down My life that I may take it again. No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of Myself. I have power to lay it down, and I have power to take it again. This command I have received from My Father." Please notice: "**No one takes it from me**". That includes Pilate, etc. In Matthew 27:50 and John 19:30 the Text states that Jesus "dismissed His spirit". Now consider Mark 15:39. "So when the centurion, who stood opposite Him, saw that He cried out like this and breathed His last, he said, 'Truly this Man was the Son of God!'" Now what could convince a hardened Roman centurion? He had doubtless witnessed no end of crucifixions; he knew that the victim died of asphyxiation. Hanging from one's hands, the diaphragm is pressed against the lungs,

and the victim cannot breathe. Nailing the feet was a sadistic procedure, to prolong the agony—in spite of the pain, the victim would push up so he could get a breath, until finally too worn out to do so. (That is why the Pharisees requested Pilate to have the legs broken; then they died within minutes.) Now then, someone who is dying asphyxiated does not give a tremendous shout; but ordinary people cannot just tell their spirit to leave. So when that centurion observed that Jesus gave a tremendous shout and then immediately died, he drew the obvious conclusion: he was looking at a super-natural being. The cross did not kill Jesus; He gave His life voluntarily, for you and me. Thank you, Lord!

21) Did they hear the Voice, or not?

Acts 9:7 X Acts 22:9

In the NKJV, Acts 9:7 reads like this: "And the men who journeyed with him stood speechless, hearing a voice but seeing no one." And Acts 22:9 reads like this: "And those who were with me indeed saw the light and were afraid, but they did not hear the voice of him who spoke to me." Comparing the two accounts, we seem to have a discrepancy: did they hear the Voice, or didn't they? Comparing the verses in the Greek Text, we discover that the verb, 'hear', and the noun, 'voice', are the same in both. Looking more closely, however, we notice that in 9:7 the noun is in the Genitive case, while in 22:9 it is in the Accusative. We have here a subtlety of Greek grammar: in the Genitive 'voice' refers to sound, while in the Accusative it refers to meaning, to the words. Saul's companions heard the Voice, but were not allowed to understand the words—only Saul understood the words. A similar thing happened in John 12:28-29; the people heard the sound (sufficiently impressive that they called it thunder), but only Jesus understood the words.

22) Divorce and remarriage

The reason for divorce is to legalize or 'legitimize' another marriage. It also serves to escape from the commitment. Before proceeding, it must be made clear that a man having more than one woman did not represent adultery, as long as he maintained them all. Many men in OT had more than one wife, without being condemned for it. Men want divorce, but what is the teaching of the Bible? A basic rule of correct hermeneutics is to start with the clear texts and then look at any texts that are ambiguous, or that offer some complexity. So that is what I will do.

1) "Keep yourselves in your spirit, and let no one be disloyal to the wife of his youth. Because the LORD, the God of Israel, says that he hates divorce" (Malachi 2:15-16). Here we have a solemn declaration—the LORD hates divorce. So how could He approve it? He may tolerate it, just as He tolerates sin. In fact, I suppose there is no such thing as a divorce without sin. In the circumstances that culminate in divorce there is always sin.

2) Luke 16:18 presents us with the basic way in which God sees the issue, since it is a declaration made by Sovereign Jesus: "Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery, and whoever marries her who is divorced from her husband commits adultery." If the one who marries a divorced woman "commits adultery," it is because the first marriage still exists in the eyes of God. But the use of the word 'adultery' by the Sovereign makes the matter very serious, since in the Law of Moses adultery carried the maximum penalty (Leviticus 20:10).

3) Answering the Pharisees in Mark 10:2-5, the Lord Jesus clarified that Moses allowed men to repudiate a wife "because of the hardness of your hearts." Neither here, nor in Matthew 19:3-9, does the idea of an 'innocent party'

appear. Divorce is generally based on hardness of heart–to this day. **However**, there are cases where separation is necessary to avoid pre-mature death, but not to remarry.

4) "'For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will be turned into one flesh'… Therefore, what God has joined together, let man not separate." Mark 10:7-9). In both Mark 10:9 and Matthew 19:6, the Text says "what God has joined", not "whom God has joined". It is clear that the Sovereign did not refer to people, but to the fact of 'one flesh'. So, for someone to argue that his partner was not chosen by God, will not work. It is the fact of sexual union, not the identity of the partners, that is being discussed. See also 1 Corinthians 6:16.

It is clear that the ideal that God states is monogamy—"his wife" is singular, "the two" can only refer to one man and one woman. (It is "two", not three, four, five, etc. "The two" cannot refer to two men, a man with an animal, a woman with a demon, or whatever—it cannot.) When a man and a woman unite, they become "one flesh", and God holds that union to be sacred—"therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate". Anyone! Even the spouses themselves. Here is a clear prohibition against divorce. Even the spouses themselves cannot separate what God has joined together. In fact, it seems clear that nothing that can happen afterwards alters the fact that the union took place—"one flesh" was made, and it remains. Other eventual unions complicate the situation (sin always complicates), but are unable to make the first union non-existent. That is exactly why God calls other unions "adultery"—if the first union had been annulled, the word 'adultery' would no longer be applicable, since the word refers precisely to infidelity to a union that still exists.

5) This is what Jesus says in verses 11 and 12 (still Mark 10): "Whoever divorces his wife and marries another

commits adultery against her; and if a woman divorces her husband and gets married to another, she commits adultery." In Luke 16:18 the woman is presented as passive–she is left, then taken by another. Here (verse 12) she is presented as taking the initiative–she is the one who divorced her husband. Conclusion: whether it is the man or the woman who takes the initiative, at the moment when she is united with another, she adulterates, because the first union still exists.

6) In Matthew 5:27-28 we read this: "You have heard that it was said, 'You shall not commit adultery'. But I say to you that whoever looks at a woman to lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart." Of course, adulterating in the heart does not undo the first union, and adulterating in fact does not undo it either. Matthew 5:31-32 repeats material that we have already commented on, but adds the caveat, "except for a case of fornication." Since the caveat is repeated in Matthew 19:9 and the context there is broader, I will comment on it within the context of Matthew 19:3-10, as follows.

7) The Pharisees came to Jesus asking, "Is it permissible for a man to divorce his wife for *just* any cause?". In reply, Jesus appealed to the Creator's purpose, namely, monogamy, and repeated the prohibition against divorce, "what God joined together, let man not separate" (including the spouses them-selves, presumably). But they didn't like that and trotted out the "certificate of divorce" spoken of by Moses. Then Jesus replied: "Because of your hard-heartedness Moses <u>permitted</u> you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it has not been so." Notice, "Moses permitted", but that was not the Creator's idea, and Moses permitted "because of your hardness of heart" (no 'innocent party'). So far we have not found anything to say that God condones divorce, but let's go to the 'caveat'.

8) “And **I** say to you that whoever divorces his wife, except for fornication, and marries another commits adultery; and whoever marries a divorcee commits adultery.” The key issue is the exact meaning of “fornication”. In the New Testament, the term refers to prostitution (it would be the central meaning), premarital sex, incest and anal sex. There is no clear case to defend the meaning of ‘adultery’. In fact, in Matthew 15:19, Mark 7:21, 1 Corinthians 6:9 and Galatians 5:19, ‘fornication’ and ‘adultery’ are presented as different, distinct things and it would be surprising if the Holy Spirit were to later confuse the two. In the present case (Matthew 19:9) it would be like insulting the Holy Spirit to say that “fornication” has only the meaning of ‘adultery’—it would be to impute dishonesty to Him, or at the very least to say that He intended to confuse the reader. If the desired meaning was ‘adultery’, then the Author would have written ‘adultery’. Indeed, by saying “fornication” Jesus made clear that the marriage had not yet taken place, otherwise He would have said ‘adultery’.

That is exactly why it seems to me more likely that this is a case similar to Joseph’s dilemma with Mary, pregnant, but not by him. In the culture of that time, once promised in marriage, a woman was considered to belong to the groom, even before the actual marriage and the consummation of the physical union. If, before the actual wedding, it was proved that the bride was no longer a virgin (as a result of fornication, inevitably), normally the groom would break off the marriage, refusing to actually marry her. The bride would be repudiated, and if the man later married another there would be no adultery, for he had never been sexually united with the first one. If another man later married the repudiated bride, it would not be adultery, because although no longer a virgin, she did not get married. In fact, Matthew 19:9 does not contradict Luke 16:18 and Mark 10: 11-12; the three

passages are unanimous—God does not recognize divorce. Only death undoes the marital union. Infidelity complicates, but does not undo. That is why Jesus calls any second marriage 'adultery', because the first union still exists. It seems clear that the disciples understood it at the time. Consider their reaction.

9) "His disciples said to him: 'If that is the situation of a man with his wife, it is better not to marry!'" (Matthew 19:10). Come now, why so much despair? Obviously Jesus' word was very hard for them to assimilate. They were used to the ease that Moses allowed, although there were several positions at the time as to the type of thing that would justify divorce. But it seems that everyone agreed that infidelity justified repudiation—at least that. Multiplied thousands (if not millions) of men have accepted marriage, thinking of no way out unless (God forbid) because of the woman's infidelity, in the event—so that interpretation seems inadequate to explain the disciples' reaction. It follows that Jesus simply closed the door—there is no divorce that permits remarrying. Only death opens the door again. Consider what follows.

10) "Do you not know, brothers (for I am speaking to those who know law), that the law has authority over someone only as long as he lives? **2**For example, a married woman is bound by law to her husband while he lives, but if the man should die, she is released from the law about the husband. **3**So then, if she should 'marry' another man while her husband is living, she will be labeled an adulteress; but if the husband should die, she is free from that law, not being an adulteress if she marries another man." (Romans 7:1-3). "While her husband is living, she will be labeled an adulteress"—no 'innocent party', no divorce; as long as the first spouse is alive, the union exists, and any additional union is characterized as "adultery". Only death breaks the union. See 1 Corinthians 7:39 as well.

11) Returning to Matthew 19, let us consider Jesus' response to the disciples' despair (verses 11 and 12): "So He said to them: 'Not all *can* assimilate this word, but those to whom it has been given. **12**For there are eunuchs who were born that way, from their mother's womb; and there are eunuchs who were castrated by men; and there are eunuchs who castrated themselves for the sake of the kingdom of the heavens. He who is able to assimilate it, let him assimilate.'" Wow, what a strange thing to say. What in the world do 'eunuchs' have to do with divorce and remarriage? Well, do eunuchs have sexual relations? It seems clear—Jesus is saying that whoever separates from his wife should then live as a 'eunuch'; no new marriage until the first spouse dies.

12) It remains to comment on 1 Corinthians 7:10-17: "Now to the married I command (not I, but the Lord): a wife is not to be separated from her husband (but if she does separate herself, let her remain unmarried, or be reconciled to her husband), and a husband is not to divorce his wife" (verses 10-11). Everything is consistent—no divorce. Even in the case of separation, let them remain unmarried! This is for a believing couple, but will the rules be different for a mixed marriage? Please note that it is the Lord who orders them to remain unmarried. Then, in verse 12, Paul offers his own opinion.

13) After affirming that the believing party should never leave the unbelieving party, the apostle continues: "But if the unbeliever separates, let him separate—in such cases the brother or the sister is not enslaved, but God has called us to peace" (verse 15). If re-marriage is not allowed if a believing partner leaves (verses 10-11), with what logic can it be argued that the rule changes if the partner is an unbeliever? It simply does not follow. (Is Paul's opinion worth more than the Lord's commandment?) On the contrary, the believer is called upon to make a special effort to win the other. However, if the

unbeliever is determined to leave, an effort by the believer to go along at any cost will only prolong a climate of strife, and God has called us to peace. There is nothing in the text to justify the idea that the abandoned believer is entitled to another marriage, absolutely. So much so that the apostle closes the chapter reiterating that only death frees the survivor for remarriage (1 Corinthians 7:39).

CONCLUSION: For God, there is no divorce. It is never lawful to enter into a second marriage as long as the first spouse is alive. God takes sex seriously! So much so that He decrees the death penalty for certain abuses. Any kind of incest incurs death; anal sex incurs death; having sex with an animal incurs death; having sex with a woman in menstruation incurs death—read carefully Leviticus 20:10-21. Why does God react so severely? I suppose it is because of the following: the last three procedures destroy the seed of the man (the first one distorts it), and it is the seed that transmits 'the image of the Creator'. He did not create sex for our pleasure, except on a secondary level, but to guarantee the continuity of the race. The main purpose of the creation is to glorify God, not to satisfy the desires of men. Any argument that relates to the pleasure or convenience of men is suspect and inadequate. Humanism increasingly invades evangelical churches, but humanism is idolatry and contrary to God. There is more; even in that severity about sex, God was foreseeing the well-being of the human race. In Malachi 2:15 we read: "Did He not make them one? … And why one? He seeks godly offspring. Therefore take heed to your spirit, and let no one deal treacherously with the wife of his youth." The word translated 'one' is *ehad*, which includes plurality within the unit. I understand that the reference is to 'one flesh'. The responsible use of sex aims to avoid the debasement of the race—the fear of God serves for that as well.

All right, God never wanted divorce, but what to do in the face of the confusions and complications that already exist? Under the Law of Moses, which was given by God, adultery carried the death penalty for both participants (Leviticus 20:10). As a result, since death frees people, 'widows', surviving spouses, could remarry. When a society does not execute an adulterer, the way out that death would provide no longer exists.

1) The Bible never uses the expression 'to live in adultery'; it uses 'to commit adultery'. Even having an adulterous beginning, a second union also exists and is recognized by God. Perez entered the line of the Messiah although he was the product of the shameful union of Judah and Tamar (Genesis 38). Prostitute Rahab became King David's great-great-grand-mother despite her sordid life. The crowning example must be that of David and Bathsheba. Their union started in the most sinful and criminal way possible (adultery and murder, very cowardly, by the way), but even so God recognized it and even blessed it to the point of putting the fruit of that union, Solomon, on the throne and even allowing him to build the temple, which God honored with His Shekinah glory. That is, if someone is faithfully living with a second spouse, the phrase 'living in adultery' does not apply, even if they committed adultery at the beginning of the union. Once there is a second union, it exists as much as the first and there is no way to undo it. A second divorce does not solve anything.

2) In fact, there is a procedure that God absolutely forbids. After a woman marries a second man, she will never be able to return to the first, even if the second one dies (Deuteronomy 24:1-4). The reason given is that such a woman has already been "contaminated", and if she goes back to the first one, God considers it an "abomination". The expedient of requiring a newly converted person, who has

already gone through two (or more) unions, to return to the first spouse is sadly unbiblical—it only makes things worse.

3) I know that there are horrifying cases, even of criminal abuse by one of the spouses, where separation becomes a necessity precisely to avoid the premature death of one of the parties. Violence may justify separation, but not remarriage. In my view, one of the most wretched aspects of sin is that almost always the worst consequences fall on others, often truly innocent with regard to the sin whose consequences they are suffering. We spend our lives victimizing and being victimized. What then? Can we undo or escape? Even when the case is totally tragic, unfair, disgusting? As a rule, no. The way to go is to avail ourselves of the grace of God and "run with endurance the race that is set before us … looking unto Jesus, the Founder and Perfecter of the Faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured a cross, scorning its ignominy, and took His seat at the right hand of the throne of God." (Hebrews 12: 2).

4) Sin is sin and sin receives punishment, but it also may receive forgiveness (except for blasphemy against the Holy Spirit). The past is beyond our reach; we cannot change it, nor can we undo our sins, but the blood of Christ can cover the past and cleanse us from sin. Qualifications for service in the Church of Christ are stated in the present tense. (And who among us would score 100% on all the qualifications?) Despite the past, God deals with us in the present based on our current reality. However, there seems to be an exception.

5) There is grace and forgiveness, but they do not free us from the consequences of our sins in this life. It is certain that there seems to be a difference between deliberate sin after being converted and what was done before. Paul explains that although he came to the point of persecuting believers (even to death) [he was executing, not murdering—there is a fundamental difference], he achieved grace and a ministry

(quite prominent, by the way) because he did it "ignorantly, in unbelief" (1 Timothy 1:12-14). After being converted, he subjugated his body "lest I myself should be rejected" (1 Corinthians 9:27). Sin can disqualify you from ministry—this is clear from 1 Timothy 3:1-12, among other passages. There we find "the husband of one wife". In Malachi, "the LORD hates divorce" is part of a larger context where He is punishing the priests who divorced their wives. In Malachi 2:13-14 God states that for that very reason He no longer took notice of their offerings. Everything indicates that God wants neither a priest nor a pastor who is divorced, and will retain the blessing if they persist anyway (even worse if they divorced after being converted).

23) Do we command God?

Matthew 18:18

In the NKJV, Matthew 18:18 reads like this: "Assuredly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven." The normal meaning of this translation is that Heaven has to follow our lead (is it not?), and there is no lack of religious communities that teach this. But really now, what possible competence might human beings have to tell God what to do? We may ask, but not command. The difficulty arises from an inaccurate translation. The tense of the Greek verb phrase here is a periphrastic future perfect, passive voice (so also in 16:18). Thus, "will have been bound/loosed" not "will be bound / loosed". We are not telling God what to do; we are to apply down here that which He has already done in heaven. (What had been just for Peter is now given to all the disciples.)

In John 5:19 the Lord Jesus stated that He could only do what He saw the Father doing. Our inability to see what the Father is doing is probably one of our worst spiritual problems

—it condemns us to waste a lot of time and energy trying to do things that we shouldn't. In practical terms, when I 'bind' something and nothing happens, I conclude that it had not been 'bound' in Heaven. I tried to do something that the Father was not doing.

24) Entering, or leaving Jericho?

Luke 18:35, 19:1 X Mark 10:46 X Matthew 20:29-30

In the NKJV, Luke 18:35 and 19:1 read like this: "Then it happened, as He was coming near Jericho, that a certain blind man sat by the road begging… Then Jesus entered and passed through Jericho." Luke plainly states that Jesus healed a blind man before entering Jericho (he mentions only one, but does not say that there was only one). And Mark 10:46 reads like this: "Now they came to Jericho. As He went out of Jericho with his disciples and a great multitude, blind Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus, sat by the road begging." Mark plainly states that Jesus healed a blind man upon leaving Jericho (he names the blind man, referring only to him, but does not say that there was only one). And Matthew 20:29-30 reads like this: "Now as they went out of Jericho, a great multitude followed Him. And behold, two blind men sitting by the road…" Matthew plainly states that Jesus healed two blind men upon leaving Jericho.

Well now, entering is one thing, and leaving is another, so which was it? Strange to relate, it was both! The Jericho that Joshua destroyed had been rebuilt (at least partially), and was inhabited. But in Jesus' day Herod had built a new Jericho, perhaps a kilometer away from the old one, also inhabited. So where would an intelligent beggar place himself? Presumably between the two towns. I take it that all three of the accounts before us transpired between the two Jerichos, so Jesus was leaving one and entering the other. There is no discrepancy. Luke and Mark probably give us the

same incident, but what about Mathew? Besides stating that the men were two, he says that Jesus "touched their eyes", whereas according to Luke and Mark He only spoke. It is entirely probable that there was more than one beggar along that stretch of road, and any shouting could be heard for quite a ways. I take it that Matthew records a different incident. I suppose that Bartimaeus was healed first, and he shouted so loud that the two heard it all and knew what to do when their turn came.

25) Fire loves straw

1 Corinthians 3:13

The context is king of interpretation, so I begin with verses 11-15:

> **11**No one can lay any foundation other than what is laid, which is Jesus Christ.[a] **12**Now if anyone builds on this foundation with gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, straw, **13**the work of each will become evident; because the Day will make it clear, because it will be revealed by fire. Yes, the fire will test each one's work, of what sort it is. **14**If the work that anyone built endures, he will receive a reward. **15**If anyone's work is burned up, he will suffer loss; but he himself will be saved, albeit so as through fire.

Paul is talking about the Day of Christ wherein those in Christ will be called to account. The Text plainly states that what we have done will be tested by fire. Someone who spent most of his time living for himself rather than for Christ's

[a] I would say that the primary reference here is to leaders of local congregations, who need to be careful how they 'build' God's 'house'. But I believe it also clearly applies to anyone whose personal life is based on Jesus Christ. Each of us will give an account of how we built our lives on that foundation. Note that we are not offered the option of changing the foundation. Anyone who attempts to do so does not belong to God.

Kingdom will be surrounded by nice, dry straw (all that any fire could ask for!). So the angel aims the blowtorch at the straw—the fire is high, hot, but short-lived. The person is left standing in a pile of fine ash, somewhat the worse for the wear.

The price you pay for not living for Christ's kingdom is to lose your life. That is all it costs, just your life! Consider the words of Sovereign Jesus recorded in Luke 9:24-25. Let us begin with verse 23. “If anyone desires to come after me let him deny himself, take up his cross each day and follow me. For whoever wants to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake, he will save it. For what will it profit a man to gain the whole world but waste or forfeit himself?” What does the Lord mean when He speaks of losing one’s “life”? One does not lose one’s soul for love of Christ. Nor is the reference to being killed. Rather, Jesus has in mind the life we live, the accumulated results of our living. All that I have done up to this moment plus all that I will yet do until overtaken by death or the rapture of the Church, whichever happens first—that is the “life” that is at risk (in my own case).

Let us look at our Lord's words a little more closely. There seems to be a contradiction here—if you lose, you save; if you want to save, you lose. How can it work? The following context helps us out. In verse 26 Jesus explains verses 24-25 in terms of His second coming. The parallel passage, Matthew 16:27, is clearer. “For the Son of Man is going to come in the glory of his Father, with his angels, and then he will repay each according to his deeds.” Christ was thinking of the day of reckoning. In other words, “we will all stand before the judgment seat of Christ” (Romans 14:10) and “each of us will give account of himself to God” (Romans 14:12). “For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive his due according to what he has done while in the body, whether good or bad” (2 Corinthians 5:10).

I understand that 1 Corinthians 3:11-15 is referring to the same occasion, the day of reckoning. After declaring that Jesus Christ is the only foundation, Paul speaks of different materials that one might use in building on it: “gold, silver, precious stones” or “wood, hay, straw”. The point is, our deeds will be tested by fire. If fire has any effect upon gold or silver it is only to purify them, but its effect on hay and straw is devastating! Okay, so what?

Let us go back to the beginning. God created the human being for His glory; to reflect it and contribute to it. I suppose we may understand Psalm 19:1 and Isaiah 43:7 in this way, at least by extension. But Adam lost this capacity when he rebelled against God. For this reason the sentence that weighs against our race is that we “fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23). But the Son came into the world to restore our lost potential. Ephesians 1:12 and 14 tell us that the object of the plan of salvation is “the praise of His glory” (see also 2 Corinthians 1:20). And 1 Corinthians 10:31 puts it into a **command**: “Whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God.” Now then, the point of all this is not to ‘ruin’ our lives, to take all the ‘fun’ out of them (as many seem to think). God is not being arrogant, unreasonable, too demanding. Quite the contrary—He is just trying to save us from throwing away our lives. Surely, because the glory of God is eternal (Psalm 104:31), and when I do something for His glory that something is transformed and acquires eternal value—it becomes “gold, silver, precious stones.” Works done for the glory of God will go through the fire without harm. On the other hand, what is done with a view to our own ambitions and ideas is “straw”. We all know what fire does to straw!

So there it is. To be a slave of Christ means to live with reference to the Kingdom; it means to do everything for the glory of God. In this way the slave “saves” his life because he

will be building it with "gold and silver", which will pass through the fire at the judgment seat of Christ without loss. In contrast, the believer who refuses to be a slave of Jesus builds his life with "hay and straw", which will be consumed by the fire—and so he "loses" his life; he lived in vain; the potential that his life represented was wasted, thrown away. What a tragedy!

26) Four hundred years

Acts 7:6

Almost all of chapter 7 is occupied with Stephen's trial and defense, although it closes with his death. The high priest knows it is all a farce, but he pretends astonishment. Stephen knows he is in a kangaroo court, so he wastes no time with the ridiculous charge; he delivers a prophetic, and condemnatory, sermon. His history lesson begins with Abraham's incomplete obedience, but what concerns us here is verse 6.

> Acts 7—**1**Then the high priest said, "Can these things be so?" **2**So he said: "Men, brothers and fathers, listen: The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham when he was in Mesopotamia, before he resided in Haran, **3**and said to him, 'Leave your country and your relatives, and come into a land that I will show you'. **4**Then he left the land of the Chaldeans and resided in Haran.[a] From there, after his father died,[b] *God* moved him to this land in which you now live; **5**yet He did not give him an inheritance in it, not even a footstep. He promised to give

[a] But he took his father and a nephew along, and Haran was not that land. 'Our father Abraham'—the Jews began their history with Abraham, who started out with incomplete obedience.

[b] There went fifteen years of his life. And he took his nephew Lot along, who would be a **big** headache (he fathered the Moabites and the Ammonites—not good news—under circumstances that would not have happened had he been left in Haran).

it to him for a possession, that is, to his seed after him, though he had no child.[a] **6**Further, God spoke like this: that his offspring would be aliens in a foreign land—and that they would be enslaved and oppressed—four hundred years."

To begin, it will be observed that my rendering of verse 6 differs from every version that I remember seeing. For example, the NKJV has: "But God spoke in this way: that his descendants would dwell in a foreign land, and that they would bring them into bondage and oppress them four hundred years." The NIV has: "God spoke to him in this way: 'Your descendants will be strangers in a country not their own, and they will be enslaved and mistreated four hundred years'." And so on—the impression that all these versions give is that the descendants would spend 400 years in a single country, namely Egypt. But such an impression lands us in a quandary: 400 years in Egypt does not fit with the clear chronological statements found elsewhere in the biblical Text.

Stephen cites Genesis 15:13, which should be understood as a chiasmus, a frequent structure in the Bible:

a. his offspring would be aliens in a foreign land
  b. and they would be enslaved
  b. and oppressed
a. four hundred years.

A careful comparison of the relevant texts shows that the 400 years includes from the weaning of Isaac to the Exodus (1891 to 1491 BC). Since Jacob moved to Egypt in 1706, Abraham's descendants were aliens in Canaan for 185 years; then they were aliens in Egypt, where they came to be enslaved, for 215 years. (The Exodus was 144 years after

[a] Abraham was 100 when he begot Isaac, who was 60 when he begot Jacob and Esau. Abraham died at 175, so lived to see his two grandsons. But before Isaac there was Ishmael . . . .

Joseph's death, so the period of slave labor was presumably somewhat less, perhaps around 100 years.)

For a detailed discussion and defense of the dates and time frames given above the interested reader is referred to a book that I consider to be one of a kind: *Chronology of the Old Testament: A Return to the Basics*, by Floyd Nolan Jones, ThD, PhD. The first edition appeared in 1993; I have in hand the 14th edition, published in 1999 by KingsWord Press, The Wood-lands, Texas. The relevant discussion is on pages 58-61, but I venture to suggest that anyone who reads the whole book will consider that it was time well spent.

27) 'Gall', or 'myrrh'?

Matthew 27:34 X Mark 15:23

In the NKJV, Matthew 27:34ª reads like this: "they gave Him sour wine mingled with gall to drink." And Mark 15:23ª reads like this: "Then they gave Him wine mingled with myrrh to drink." That Mark used a generic term, 'wine', for the more precise 'sour wine' (or 'wine vinegar'), need not detain us. But what was the mixture? 'Gall' is one thing, an animal substance, and 'myrrh' is another, a vegetable substance; it was either one or the other, but which? Was Matthew influenced by Psalm 69:21? "They also gave me gall for my food, and for my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink." (Matthew wrote for a Jewish audience, and seems to have mentioned fulfilled prophecy whenever he could.) More to the point, perhaps, is Acts 8:23, where Peter says to Simon (the ex-sorcerer), "for I see that you are in a gall of bitterness" (so the Greek Text). Evidently 'gall' was used as a generic term for any bitter substance. I take it that Matthew, perhaps influenced by Psalm 69:21, used the generic term. I conclude that the precise substance used was myrrh, as Mark indicates.

28) God hates

It has always been standard procedure for Satan and his servants to attack strong arguments in favor of the truth as if they were weak and wrong. In today's world, take a hard look at any 'principle' or 'law' that Satan is using, such as 'everything is relative' or 'hate speech'. It is the opposite that will be true. The purpose of this article is to take up the question of hate. The current laws against 'hate speech' and 'hate crimes' carry the clear implication that it is wrong to hate, to hate anything (they are generally used against biblical values). Such laws represent an open rebellion against the Sovereign Creator of the universe, because He hates, and He commands us to hate.

To begin, the nature of true love is generally misunderstood. If you love someone, you have to be against anything that will harm or damage that someone. The love of God **necessarily** includes hating evil, because of the consequences of the evil that will harm His 'image', the people He loves. In Deuteronomy 33:2-3 the "fiery law" is an expression of God's love for the people. Precisely because He is concerned for our true wellbeing, the Creator imposes the earthly consequences of our sins.

Hebrews 1:8-9 cites Psalm 45:6-7, declaring that it refers to God the Son: among other things it is affirmed that He hates 'wickedness' (Psalm 45:7), while the translation into Greek has 'lawlessness' (Hebrews 1:9). The glorified Christ Himself declares that He hates the works of the Nicolaitans (Revelation 2:6). Jehovah hates stealing (Isaiah 61:8), divorce (Malachi 2:16) and seven other transgressions: "a proud look; a lying tongue; hands that shed innocent blood; a heart that devises wicked plans; feet that are swift in running to evil; a false witness who speaks lies; one who sows discord among

brethren" (Proverbs 6:16-19, NKJV). "The fear of Jehovah is to hate evil", and Wisdom hates: "pride; arrogance; the evil way; the perverse mouth" (Proverbs 8:13; and see 9:10). In Psalm 97:10 we have a command: "You who love Jehovah, hate evil!" Romans 12:9 tells us to abhor what is malignant; something malignant is aggressively evil. Are we going to obey?

Psalm 5:5 informs us that Jehovah hates all workers of iniquity. We are in the habit of teaching that God hates sin but loves the sinner. It seems so, up to a point. But when someone decides to join Satan, and makes a point of practicing evil, he attracts God's wrath. Psalm 34:16 reads like this: "The face of Jehovah is against those who do evil, to cut off the remembrance of them from the earth" (quoted in 1 Peter 3:12). Well now, to erase the memory of someone you must begin by erasing that someone himself. When a person chooses to become an ally of evil, he is challenging the Creator to kill him. (See Psalm 26:5; 31:6; 101:3; 119:104, 113, 128, 163—these help us to understand David's attitude in Psalm 139:21-22; it is because they act with wicked intent [verse 20] that he hates them.) We must learn to hate sin, evil in any and all forms, including Satan and his angels.

Consider Matthew 25:41: Then He (the Son of the Man sitting on His throne of glory) will also say to those on His left: "Go away from me, you accursed ones, into the eternal fire that was prepared for the devil and his angels." The Lake of fire and brimstone was prepared for Lucifer (now Satan) and those angels that joined his rebellion (about a third of the angelic beings—Revelation 12:4). Human beings who side with Satan (there are various ways of doing that) will also share his destiny. The basic meaning of the word translated 'angel' is 'messenger'; many human beings are Satan's messengers. Since they are beyond recovery (Matthew 25:41, 2 Peter 2:4, Revelation 20:10), we are in a war without pity, without quarter, to the death. To remain passive when someone is

determined to kill you is to ask for death. But if you are a soldier, it is dereliction of duty. According to Psalm 78:9-10, God takes a dim view of such an attitude.

The Sacred Text is clear: the character of God does not change, cannot be altered. In Malachi 3:6 Jehovah Himself declares that He does not change. James 1:17 affirms the same thing in other words. Hebrews 13:8 affirms something similar about Jesus Christ. Let us give special attention to 2 Timothy 2:13. "If we are faithless, He remains faithful; He cannot deny Himself." He cannot deny Himself—is it not obvious? He cannot go against His very nature, His own essence; it is one thing that God cannot do. He is Truth, and so cannot be unfaithful. It is precisely for that reason that He is incapable of lying (Titus 1:2). To have the mind of Christ is to think like He does (1 Corinthians 2:16), and Philippians 2:5 puts it as a command: "Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus". If Sovereign Jesus hates, we too must hate; that is to say, we must hate what He hates.

Now let us consider Deuteronomy 7:9-10: "Therefore know that Jehovah your God is **God**; He is the faithful God who keeps covenant and mercy for a thousand generations with those who love Him and keep His commandments; and He repays those who hate Him to their face, to destroy them. He will not be slow to repay to his face the one who hates Him." If God repays His hater with destruction, and without delay, then He does not offer salvation to that hater.[a] Obvious. 2 Peter 2:17 affirms this about the allies of evil described in verses 9-17: "for whom the blackest of the darkness has been

[a] In Joel 3:4 Jehovah expresses Himself like this: "Indeed, what have you to do with me, O Tyre and Sidon and all the coasts of Philistia? Will you retaliate against me? But if you retaliate against me, swiftly and speedily I will return your retaliation upon your own head." God demonstrates the same attitude as in Deuteronomy 7:10—He does not tolerate perversity.

reserved forever".[a] We find the same expression in Jude 13. With an eternal reservation like that, what are their chances?

John 3:16 declares that giving His Son was an expression of God's love for the world. So He offers salvation to those whom He loves, not those whom He hates. Whoever decides to hate God receives the hate back, and remains without salvation. In John 6:44 (and verse 65) the Lord Jesus declares, "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him", and it should be obvious that the Father is not going to draw someone whom He hates. John 3:36 is also to the point: "The one believing into the Son has eternal life, but the one disobeying the Son will not see life, but the wrath of God remains upon him." Will the Father 'draw' someone who remains under His wrath? How? The Text declares that the person **will not** see life—not ever. Kind reader, if you belong to Jesus, you need to under-stand that you are in a war, a war against an implacable foe.

Laws like 'hate speech' and 'hate crime' are merely expressions of Satan's hate for God and for all who are created in God's image. Since all biblical values are expressions of God's concern for our wellbeing, Satan hates those values and motivates his servants to work against them. In Matthew 10:22 and Mark 13:13 Sovereign Jesus said: "You will be hated by all for my name's sake". It is already the case in many places that anyone who takes a public stand in defense of biblical values is vituperated by the media—some have gone to prison in what once were 'Christian' countries. The world is no longer 'post-modern', it is becoming increasingly anti-Christian. **The other side accuses us of hate to hide the fact that they are the ones who hate, and their hate is virulent,**

[a] This darkness is associated with Satan's kingdom, because "God is light and in Him is no darkness at all" (1 John 1:5). Peter is affirming that they will share the same destiny as their boss.

bitterly hostile. They are prepared to use violence in their opposition to God's values.

So what can we do about it? Consider Luke 10:19: "Take note, I am giving[a] you the authority to trample on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing at all may harm you". The last clause is clearly about defense, about protecting ourselves. In Matthew 28:18 Sovereign Jesus affirms that He holds "all authority in heaven and on earth", so He is clearly competent to delegate some of that authority to us. Now then, just how does "authority over all the power of the enemy" work, in practice? Authority controls power. We should use our authority to forbid the use of Satan's power, with reference to specific situations—in my experience, we must be specific. We can limit what the enemy does, but not put him completely out of business, or so I deem. But just how should we go about it?

In the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. The Text tells us that this sword is "the *ρημα* of God"—*ρημα*, not *λογος*. It is God's Word spoken, or applied. Really, what good is a sword left in its sheath? However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.[b]

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[a] Instead of 'am giving', perhaps 2.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have 'have given' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.)—a serious error. Jesus said this perhaps five months before His death and resurrection, addressing the seventy (not just the twelve). The Lord is talking about the future, not the past; a future that includes us!

[b] In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1,

Now consider Ephesians 3:20: "Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to the power that is working in us". Ephesians 1:19 speaks of "the exceeding greatness of His power **into** us who are believing"—note that the verb is in the present tense; having believed yesterday won't hack it, we must believe today. This tremendous power that God pours into us, as we believe, exceeds our powers of imagination. Well now, my personal horizon is limited and defined by my ability to imagine. Anything that I can't imagine lies outside my horizon, and so obviously I won't ask for it. I sadly confess that I have not yet arrived at a spiritual level where I can unleash this power—I have yet to make the truth in this verse work for me. But I understand that the truth affirmed here is literal, and I only hope that others will get there before I do (so I can learn from them), if I keep on delaying. The whole point of the exercise (verse 21) is for God to get glory [not for me to have a good time, although if I ever get there I will certainly have a great good time!], and to the extent that we do <u>not</u> put His power in us to work we are depriving Him of glory that He could and should have.

Consider Proverbs 28:1—"The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are bold as a lion". It may have been like that in Solomon's day, but times have changed. Nowadays it is Satan's people who are bold. That is not how it is supposed to be. Sovereign Jesus said that His disciples are "the salt of the earth" and "the light of the world" (Matthew 5:13-14). Both salt and light are aggressive. If you put a bit of salt in a pan of rice it seasons the whole batch. Darkness is merely the absence of light. If you turn on the light in a dark

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18:36, 2 Kings 1:10). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:19). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak!

room, the darkness is gone. In the face of persecution, the early Christians prayed: "Now Lord, look on their threats and grant to your servants that with all boldness they may speak your Word" (Acts 4:29). And God granted their request! **The time has come for us to do the same thing.**

29) God uses Satan and his servants, angels and men

God is Sovereign over all and permits the evil in the world. I will comment on that later, but will begin with cases where God took the initiative and actively used the enemy. I will discuss them in chronological order.

1) Job: Job 1:6-8, 2:1-3.

> "Now there was a day when the sons of God[a] came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. And the LORD said to Satan, 'From where do you come?' So Satan answered the LORD and said, 'From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it.' Then the LORD said to Satan, 'Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil?'"
>
> "Again there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan came also among them to present himself before the LORD. And the LORD said to Satan, 'From where do you come?' So Satan answered the LORD and said, 'From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it.' Then the LORD said to Satan, 'Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil? And

[a] 'Sons of God' is a translation of the Hebrew phrase '*bene haElohim*', which wherever it is used in the Old Testament evidently refers to high-ranking angelic beings.

still he holds fast to his integrity, although you incited Me against him, to destroy him without cause.'"

It is clear that God took the initiative and provoked that contest with Satan, even though God Himself said that it was "without cause": Job had not done anything to deserve what happened to him. Why God would do such a thing has puzzled and troubled God's people ever since. I find the answer in Job's own words: "I had heard of You by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees You" (42:5).

By God's own evaluation, Job was the best 'pupil' He had on earth. When you are the 'best' in any area, you tend to stagnate. There is no one from whom you may learn, in order to improve, you are at the top; it is up to others to learn from you. God saw that Job had the potential to grow, to climb spiritually, but he had stagnated, he was the 'best'. It was Job's theology, his doctrinal 'package', that was stopping his growth. It was a 'package' that was shared by his three friends. So God used Satan to smash that package. It was a dreadful process, and our tendency is to feel sorry for Job, but God's purpose was vindicated. Job grew, he climbed spiritually! God moved Job up to a higher level of spiritual understanding, giving him a direct revelation of Himself. (The three friends, plus Elihu, got in on the privilege. There is a principle here: what God teaches us we should share with others.) And God gave him twice what he had before.

2) David: 2 Samuel 24:1, 1 Chronicles 21:1.

"Again the anger of the LORD was aroused against Israel, and He moved David against them to say, 'Go, number Israel and Judah'."

"Now Satan stood up against Israel, and moved David to number Israel."

So who was it; God, or Satan? Since God is sovereign, He evidently used Satan, just like He did with Job. In the context David told Joab to command the numbering, and Joab was not happy. He knew that it was a bad idea. "Nevertheless, the king's word prevailed against Joab." Since God's purpose was to punish Israel, He gave David three options; he had to choose one of the three.[a] He chose the third one, which was to have three days of plague. The Text says that God killed 70,000 men. Presumably they were men who had rebelled against God and were having a negative effect upon other people.

3) Ahab: 2 Chronicles 18:18-21.

> "Then *Micaiah* said, 'Therefore hear the word of the LORD: I saw the LORD sitting on His throne, and all the host of heaven standing on His right hand and His left. And the LORD said, "Who will persuade Ahab king of Israel to go up, that he may fall at Ramoth Gilead?" So one spoke in this manner, and another spoke in that manner. Then a spirit came forward and stood before the LORD, and said,

[a] With reference to the first option, we have an apparent discrepancy between 2 Samuel and 1 Chronicles. Samuel says "seven years of famine" while Chronicles says "three years of famine". In Chronicles there is a parallelism: three years . . . three months . . . three days; in Samuel the first 'three' becomes 'seven'. I invite attention to the precise wording of the Text. 2 Samuel 24: 13: "So Gad came to David and told him; and he said to him: 'Shall seven years of famine come to you . . . or shall you flee three months before your enemies . . . or shall there be three day's plague . . . ?'" 1 Chronicles 21:11-12 "So Gad came to David and said to him, 'Thus says the LORD: "Choose for yourself, either three years of famine, or three months to be defeated by your foes . . . or else for three days . . . the plague . . . ."'" Chronicles says that the LORD said 'three years'. Samuel says that Gad said 'seven years'. I conclude that what the LORD said was indeed 'three' years. I suppose that Gad got carried away and imported the 'seven' from the famine in Egypt under Joseph.

> "I will persuade him". The LORD said to him, "In what way?" So he said, "I will go out and be a lying spirit in the mouth of all his prophets". And *the LORD* said, "You shall persuade *him* and also prevail; go out and do so".'"

Here the LORD clearly used an evil spirit, but how could that evil spirit be in heaven before God's throne? And why does the Text refer to God's hands, right and left? How is that information relevant to the account? If God furnished that information to Micaiah, He did so for a reason. Did you know that God has a right hand and a left hand? And how can you sit on a throne without a body? When God said: "Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness" (Genesis 1:26), might that have included the body? I suggest that Matthew 25:31-33 give us the necessary clue.

> "When the Son of the Man comes in His glory,[a] and all the holy angels with Him,[b] then He will sit on His throne of glory. And all the nations will be gathered before Him, and He will separate them one from another,[c] just as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats. And the sheep He will place on His right, but the goats on His left."[d]

Verse 34 makes clear that the sheep are God's servants, and they are on His right side. Verse 41 makes clear that the goats are Satan's servants, and they are on His left side. Going back to Micaiah, I conclude that Satan and his servants, other high-

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[a] The Lord Jesus uses "the coming of the Son of the Man" to refer to both the Rapture and the Second Advent.

[b] Perhaps 4% of the Greek manuscripts omit "holy" (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.). From Revelation 5:11 it appears that the holy angels are well over 100 million.

[c] It is clear that the King is dealing with individuals here; nations are made up of people, and each person will be evaluated individually.

[d] See 1 Kings 22:19-22 (2 Chronicles 18:18-21).

ranking fallen angels (remember Job), were on God's left side, and it was one of them who offered to do the dirty work.

4) Habakkuk. In 1:2-4 Habakkuk complains that evil is rampant in Judah, and God is doing nothing about it. In 1:6 God answers that "indeed I am raising up the Chaldeans", and they will punish Judah. But Habakkuk finds that to be difficult to understand; how can God use the Chaldeans who are worse even than Judah? The answer is that God uses evil to punish evil, that will be punished in its turn.

God used Assyria to punish the northern kingdom of Israel. Then God used Babylon to punish Assyria and the southern kingdom of Judah. Then God used Medo-Persia to punish Babylon. Then God used Greece to punish Medo-Persia. Then God used Rome to punish Greece. That sort of thing, on a much smaller scale, happens all around the world, all the time.

5) Judas Iscariot: Luke 22:3-4, John 13:27,30.

> "Then Satan entered Judas (the one surnamed Iscariot), who was numbered among the Twelve. So he went off and conferred with the chief priests and officers about how he might betray Him to them." Note that Judas acted under satanic inspiration.
>
> "And after the sop, then Satan entered into him. Whereupon Jesus says to him, 'What you are doing, do quickly!' So having received the sop, immediately he went out. And it was night."

As we know from verse two, Satan had already planted the idea in Judas' head/heart, but at this point he enters the man—Judas wasn't just demonized, he was satanized! Evidently Satan required permission to do this, and giving the sop was the signal; Jesus gave him the go-ahead. Obviously Satan had to be there, in that upper room! (If he was in that

upper room, why can't he be in your church? Any Judases in your church?) I take it that Satan entered Judas to make sure that he would carry through with the plan. Although to the disciples it would appear that Jesus was addressing Judas, I rather suspect that He was actually addressing Satan, since it was Satan who would now control the man's thoughts. He orders him to get on with it; that is right, Jesus gave Satan an order, and Satan obeyed.

In John 17:12, praying to the Father, Jesus said, "I protected those whom You gave me, and not one of them was lost except the son of perdition, so that the Scripture might be fulfilled."[a] If the Scripture was being fulfilled, then it was part of God's Plan.

God used Satan to make sure that Judas played his part.

6) The Beast: Revelation 13:5-8.

> "And he was given a mouth speaking great things, that is, blasphemy; and he was given authority to make war forty-two months. So he opened that mouth of his in blasphemy against God, to blaspheme His name and His tabernacle, those who dwell in Heaven.[b] And it was given to him to make war with the saints and to conquer them. And authority was given him over every tribe and language and ethnic nation. All who dwell on the earth will do obeisance to him, whose names have not been

[a] In Hebrew usage (Jesus, a Jew among Jews, was presumably speaking Hebrew here) a 'son' of something is characterized by that something; so a 'son of perdition' is characterized by lostness; the Scripture in question would be part of the Old Testament and hence written long before the person was born. (I have not been able to locate a clear text to that effect, but there are indirect ones.)

[b] Compare 1 Corinthians 3:16. We are the 'temple' of God; those who dwell in Heaven are His tabernacle.

written in the Book of Life of the Lamb slaughtered from the foundation of the world.[a]

I take it that in verses 5 and 7 it is God who gives the authority —this is part of the Plan. Authority to conquer the saints has to come from God.

Those are the cases where God took the initiative and actively used the enemy that have occurred to me. There may be others. As I said at the beginning, God is Sovereign over all and permits the evil in the world. So why does He do that? He uses evil to punish evil, but He also uses evil to restrain evil. Why do evil people not do even more evil than they do? Because they are afraid of the consequences; if there is more than one organized crime group in a given city, they each inhibit the crime that the other perpetrates. But the prior question remains: why does God permit evil at all? I offer the following possible explanation.

While the Sovereign Creator walked this earth in the body of Jesus, He declared that the Father is looking for people who will worship Him in spirit and truth (John 4:23-24). The Father "is looking" for such people. It may be that we have here a window on the reason why God created a race such as ours—persons in His image with the capacity to **choose**. God "is looking" for something, which means that He does not have it, at least not automatically, nor in sufficient quantity. I take it that He wants to be appreciated for who He is, but to have meaning such appreciation cannot come from robots—it has to be voluntary. So He created a type of being with that capacity, but He had to take the risk that such a being would choose not to appreciate Him.

[a] 1 Peter 1:20 makes clear that it was actually before the foundation of the world. God knew what was going to happen before He created the human race, the terrible price He would have to pay, but He went ahead anyway.

Unfortunately, most human beings make the negative choice, and with that negative choice come all sorts of negative consequences. **Attention please**! For God's purpose in creating such a race not to be frustrated, both He and we must live with the consequences of our choices. God must permit the consequences of our evil choices! The consequences of sin are like a two-way street: we spend our lives being victimized by the consequences of other people's sins, and victimizing them with the consequences of our sins. (I may complain that I receive far more than I give, but that does not change the fact.)

Ever since Adam, human beings are born with an inclination toward sin, so for someone to choose to appreciate God is definitely not automatic, nor even easy. No one can reasonably accuse God of having 'stacked the deck' in His own favor, of 'buying votes'—He seems to have done just the opposite. If a human being, against his natural inclination, chooses to appreciate God, then He receives what He is looking for. "In spirit and truth" presumably means that it cannot be faked, cannot be forced, cannot be merely physical, cannot be merely emotional (though both body and emotions can, and often will, be utilized). Please see Matthew 23:8-10.

30) Goliath of Gath

Recently an article written by Kaspars Ozoliņš, "Goliath of Gath", came to my attention, wherein he claims that the Hebrew Text offers discrepancies on the subject of Goliath. He bases his claim on 1 Samuel 17:49-51, 2 Samuel 21:19 and 1 Chronicles 20:5. He then performs some interesting gymnastics in an effort to explain the situation in terms of scribal alterations. I would say that he simply failed to pay attention to the several contexts.

The obvious place to begin is at the beginning, 1 Samuel 17:49-51. The whole chapter surrounds the person of Goliath. Verses 49-51 relate that a rather young David killed a very mature Goliath. The stone in the forehead was probably fatal, but to make sure, David cut off Goliath's head. It should be evident to one and all that any sons that Goliath begot had to be begotten before he lost his head! Some of those sons may well have been as old as David, and perhaps older.

The first supposed difficulty occurs in 2 Samuel 21:19, where the Hebrew Text says that Elhanan killed Goliath the Gittite. Lamentably, some versions gratuitously insert 'the brother of' before Goliath. The article I am reviewing takes the position that this is the same Goliath as in 1 Samuel 17, and therefore we have a contradiction as to who did the killing. Did the author not read verse 22? "These four were born to the giant in Gath, and fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants." David killed the father, and his servants killed the four sons. As it happens, the four sons are named: Ishbi-Benob (v. 16), Saph (v. 18), Goliath (v.19) and the giant with six fingers and six toes (v. 20). At that time, it was standard procedure to give the firstborn son the name of his father, so the Goliath in verse 19 was presumably the first-born. In any case, he is plainly stated to be the son of the Goliath that David killed. Elhanan killed the son; there is no discrepancy.

1 Chronicles 20:5 offers a second supposed difficulty. The Hebrew Text says that Elhanan killed Lahmi the brother of Goliath the Gittite. Compared to 2 Samuel, Ishi-Benob is not mentioned, but the other two are. Verse 8 says that they were sons, but does not repeat the number four; Lahmi is stated to be a son of the first Goliath. The article I am reviewing takes the position that Lahmi replaces Goliath, but how does that

follow? Why could Elhanan not have killed both Goliath and Lahmi? Both Lahmi and Goliath are stated to be sons of the giant that David killed. If you are in the business of killing giants, you kill as many as you can. Elhanan killed two. (After Elhanan killed Goliath #2, Lahmi may have tried to avenge his brother, and Elhanan had to defend himself.)

To conclude: I deny that the Hebrew Text offers any discrepancies on the subject of Goliath. I also reject the claim that there were scribal alterations.

By the way, whenever you read an article that questions the integrity of the Biblical Text, you need to think about the author's presuppositions. More often than not, he does not believe in the divine inspiration of that Text, and he certainly does not believe in its divine preservation. It follows that his working model does not allow for the supernatural. That is a problem, because both God and Satan exist, and both were involved in the transmission of the Text. It is also certain that he did not consult the Holy Spirit as he worked, and thereby condemned himself to never arrive at a correct understanding of what actually happened.

31) Hades is not Hell

This is clear from Revelation 20:14-15—"And Death and Hades were thrown into the Lake of Fire. This is the second death, the Lake of Fire.[a] 15 And if anyone was not found written in the Book of Life he was thrown into the Lake of

[a] The first death is the physical one; the second is the spiritual one—eternal separation from the Creator, the Father of spirits (Hebrews 12:9); the essence of death is separation. In physical death, the spirit is separated from the body.

Fire."[a] Death and Hades are treated as if they were living entities. However that may be, it is clear that Hades and the Lake are distinct. So just what is this 'Lake'?

In this same passage it is stated to be 'the second death'. But consider Revelation 20:10—"And the devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the Lake of Fire and Brimstone, where the Beast and the False prophet also are. And they will be tormented day and night forever and ever." The full title, Lake of Fire and Brimstone, having been given in verse 10, in verses 14 and 15 it is shortened to Lake of Fire, but the place is the same, a place of eternal torment. (See also Revelation 21:8.) And now consider Matthew 25:41—"Then He will also say to those on His left: 'Go away from me, you accursed ones, into the eternal fire that was prepared for the devil and his angels'." In verse 46, 'those on His left' are sent into "everlasting punishment". The Lake of fire was prepared for Lucifer (now Satan) and those angels that joined his rebellion (about a third of the angelic beings—Revelation 12:4). Human beings who side with Satan (there are various ways of doing that) will also share his destiny. The term 'Hell', properly understood and utilized, stands for the Lake of Fire and Brimstone, the second and eternal death.

The name 'Gehenna' is a euphemistic metaphor for the Lake of Fire. Versions generally, and correctly, render it as 'hell'. The word occurs in Matthew 5:22, 29, 30; 10:28; 18:9 and 23:15, 33; in Mark 9:43, 45, 47; in Luke 12:5 and in James 3:6. In all but the last instance the word was spoken by Jesus Himself. In three of the references Jesus added "of fire". Strictly speaking, 'Gehenna' was the local dump outside Jerusalem—something was always being burned, and there would be plenty of worms. Notice Mark 9:43-44.

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[a] That is right; since no one can be saved by his works, the only way out is the Book of Life!

43Further, if your hand is causing you to fall, cut it off; it is better for you to enter into the Life maimed than having both hands to go away into Gehenna, into the unquenchable fire—**44**where 'their worm does not die, and the fire is not quenched'.[a]

I find the figure of an immortal worm to be rather daunting—always chewing on you, but never finishing you off! I freely confess that I prefer never to encounter such a worm! The Lord was presumably referring to Isaiah 66:24. Notice also what He said in Matthew 10:28—"And do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. But rather fear the One who is able to destroy both soul and body in Hell [Gehenna]." The destruction of both soul and body must refer to the Lake of Fire, the second death.

The Lord used other expressions to refer to the Lake. In Matthew 13:41-42 He was explaining the parable of the wheat and tares:

41The Son of the Man will send out His angels,[b] and they will collect out of His kingdom everything that is offensive, and those who perpetrate lawlessness;[c] **42**and they will throw them into the furnace of fire. <u>There</u>, there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

"The furnace of fire", where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth, is evidently a reference to the Lake. In

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[a] Perhaps 4% of the Greek manuscripts omit 'into the unquenchable fire' at the end of verses 43 and 45, and also omit verses 44 and 46 entire, to be followed by NIV, NASB, LB, [TEV], etc., except that most keep 'into the unquenchable fire' in verse 43 (but not in verse 45). (Evidently there were those who thought that saying it once was quite enough.)

[b] The angels are going to be busy.

[c] I take it that the "kingdom" here is physical (not merely 'spiritual') and includes the whole planet, because it contains "offensive" things and "lawless" people.

verses 49-50, same chapter, He said the same thing. In Matthew 8:12, 22:13 and 25:30 Sovereign Jesus used the description: "the darkness farthest away; there, there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth". See also Jude 13. Again, the reference is to the Lake, but what did He mean by the 'darkness farthest away', or farthest out? Throughout the NT the term 'darkness' is used to refer to Satan's kingdom, and the Lake is the final destination of that kingdom, and therefore the 'farthest out'. In Matthew 3:12 and Luke 3:17 the Baptizer was explaining what the Christ would do: "He will thoroughly clean out His threshing floor and gather His wheat into the barn; but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire". In sum, the term 'Hell', properly understood and utilized, stands for the Lake of Fire and Brimstone, the second and eternal death.

As demonstrated at the outset, Hades and the Lake must be distinct, so just what is 'Hades'? The word occurs in Matthew 11:23 and 16:18, in Luke 10:15 and 16:23, in Acts 2:27 and 31, in 1 Corinthians 15:55 and in Revelation 1:18, 6:8 and 20:13-14. Unfortunately, the AV (KJV) uniformly renders the word as 'hell', thereby misleading the reader and confusing the issue. Fortunately, the NKJV corrects the AV at all those points; but other versions offer a mixture of renderings. Looking at all the relevant contexts, Hades evidently refers to something that exists between a person's physical death and the Lake; it must be some sort of intermediate state or place. The closest thing to an actual description is found in Luke 16:19-31.

> **19**"Now there was a certain rich man who was dressed in purple and fine linen, living in luxury every day. **20**And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, covered with sores, who had been placed at his gate, **21**just wanting to be fed with the crumbs that fell from the rich man's

table—why even the dogs would come and lick his sores![a]
22In due time the beggar died and was carried away to
Abraham's bosom by the angels. The rich man also died
and was buried.[b] **23**And in Hades he looked up and saw
Abraham at a distance, and Lazarus very close to him. And
being in torment, **24**he called out, saying, 'Father Abra-
ham, have mercy on me and send Lazarus,[c] that he may
dip the tip of his finger in water and cool my tongue;
because I am tormented by this flame!' **25**But Abraham
said: 'Child, remember that in your lifetime you received
your good things, while Lazarus had bad things; but now
he[d] is being comforted, and you tormented. **26**And
besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has
been fixed, so that those who want to pass from here to
you cannot, nor can anyone from there cross over to us.'
27Then he said, 'I beg you therefore, father, that you
would send him to my father's house, **28**because I have
five brothers, so that he may testify to them, lest they
also come to this place of torment'.[e] **29**Abraham said to
him, 'They have Moses and the prophets; let them hear
them'. **30**So he said to him, 'Oh no, father Abraham—if
someone from the dead should go to them, they will
repent!' **31**He said to him, 'If they do not listen to Moses

[a] In fact the dogs were doing him a favor, since canine saliva is good for sores.

[b] Note the contrast. Of course the beggar's body had been buried, but the person was taken to Paradise. Here we have an explicit statement of angelic activity, which, however, is absent from the rich man.

[c] I find it to be curious that he still thought that he was better than Lazarus!

[d] The best line of transmission (30% of the Greek manuscripts here) has the emphatic pronoun 'he', rather than 'here'.

[e] I find it interesting that he was concerned for his brothers; we cannot say, "Better late than never", since it made no difference.

and the prophets, they will not be persuaded even if someone should rise from the dead'."[a]

The Text does not state that this is a parable, so most probably it is not (no parable that is stated to be such employs a person's proper name). Several things in this account invite comment. *Hades* (Greek), or *Sheol* (Hebrew), is the 'halfway house' where departed spirits await the final judgment, but the results of that judgment are already known, since the saved are already separated from the lost (see Hebrews 9:27). There is a chasm separating the two sides that cannot be crossed, but evidently one side can see and hear the other (the 'dead' are conscious and have feeling). People in prison who are waiting for their trial are already suffering.

In verse 22 the side of the saved is called 'Abraham's bosom'. This is the only passage where that phrase occurs; in Luke 23:43 the Lord Jesus called it 'Paradise'.[b] When He said to the repentant robber, "Today you will be with me in Paradise", He was not referring to Heaven. We can deduce this from Acts 2:27. Peter is proving the resurrection by citing David's prophecy in Psalm 16:8-11; Acts 2:27 translates Psalm 16:10—"You will not abandon my soul in Hades, nor will You allow Your Holy One to see decay." 'Hades' is a translation of the Hebrew *Sheol,* that I will discuss below. Jesus could not be abandoned there unless He did in fact go there. Referring to the sign of the prophet Jonah, Jesus said, "so will the Son

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[a] Abraham states a disquieting reality: people who reject God's written revelation are self-condemned. Note also that Abraham did not say it would be impossible to send Lazarus, only that it would do no good. But it is clear that the lost cannot return, or the rich man could have gone himself.

[b] The basic meaning of the term 'paradise' is a garden, and in the NT it is also used of heaven. So why did Jesus call the good side of Hades 'Paradise'? I suppose because the people there were on their way to Heaven, and were already experiencing bliss.

of the Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth" (Mathew 12:40). "In the heart of the earth"—presumably we here have instruction from the Lord on the location of Hades—it is inside the earth, somehow. Compare 1 Samuel 28:13 where Samuel (literally), returning from Hades/Sheol, comes up from inside the earth. If volcanoes can spew out molten rock, it is evidently quite hot down there.

Matthew 11:23 and Luke 10:15 are parallel, referring to Capernaum: "And you, Capernaum, who are 'exalted to heaven', will be brought down to Hades". Hades is contrasted to heaven (the Text has 'the heaven'), one being 'up' and the other 'down'. Capernaum is pictured as having a high opinion of itself, an opinion that God does not share. Comparing this with Luke 16:23, the bad side of Hades is in view. The bad side is also in view in Matthew 16:18. "And I further say to you that you are a stone, but on this bedrock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not withstand her." There is a play on words here, *petros* VS *petra*—the bedrock was obviously not Peter. The bedrock presumably has to do with the fact that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of the Living God. 'Gates' do not attack, but are the last line of defense for a walled city—it is the Church that is attacking Hades. (The normal meaning of the verb here is 'prevail', which is why versions usually render 'prevail against', as if it is Hades that is attacking the Church.) I take it that the Church is viewed as saving people from the bad side of Hades—of course it is actually Jesus who does the saving.

In 1 Corinthians 15:55 and the four cases in Revelation, death is mentioned along with Hades. I begin with 1 Corinthians 15:54-56:

> **54**So whenever this corruptible puts on incorruption and this mortal puts on immortality, then this written word will happen: "Death has been swallowed down into

victory". [55]"Where, O Death, is your sting? Where, O Hades, is your victory?"[a] [56]The stinger of death is sin, and the adjunct of sin is the law.

The first quote is from Isaiah 25:8. It is important to note that this whole paragraph is addressed to "brothers" (verse 50), those who enjoy the benefit of Christ's victory over sin and death. The second quote appears to be an interpretation of Hosea 13:14.[b] "The wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23). Sin leads to spiritual death and lands the sinner in the bad side of Hades.

In Revelation 1:18, the glorified Jesus declares His victory, in consequence of which He now holds the 'keys of Death and of Hades'. In Hebrews 2:14, the correct translation of the Greek Text is 'abolish the one who <u>had</u> the power of death'. In Revelation 6:8, a sickly pale horse is ridden by Death, 'and Hades follows with him'. The Text does not say that Hades was on a horse. John is stating a fact of human existence: Hades follows death—so it has been for 6,000 years.

I confess that the meaning of Revelation 20:13 is not clear to me. "The ocean gave up the dead who were in it, and Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them; and they were judged each one according to their works."[c] How can

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[a] Less than 2% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have 'death', instead of "Hades", to be followed by NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.

[b] The LXX is in basic agreement with the NT here, and is probably based upon it, not the opposite. The LXX we know and use is based on manuscripts copied centuries after the NT was written. A strict Pharisee like Saul of Tarsus would certainly use Hebrew manuscripts, not a translation.

[c] Twice it says that they will be judged on the basis of their works. So how can you really evaluate someone's deeds? Only by taking account of their context. Those who never heard the Gospel will be judged within the context that they lived, and the Judge will prove that even within their own context they did not measure up.

Death be holding dead that are not in Hades? And how can the ocean have a separate roster of dead? However, the context is the Great White Throne, the final judgment. And since only the lost will appear before this throne, proceeding directly to the Lake, they have presumably already been resurrected. In physical death, the spirit is separated from the body, and resurrection is the reuniting of spirit and body. Before resurrection, the spirits of the lost are in Hades; but where are their 'bodies'? The remains of those bodies are either in the sea or on land. If 'death' stands for those on land, then verse 13 could be referring to the resurrection of the lost. That is my best guess as to its intended meaning.

The observant reader may have noticed that after Luke 16 and Acts 2 all the references appear to be dealing with the bad side of Hades. Why might that be? I suggest that the good side is no longer occupied. I believe a case can be made for the understanding that when Jesus resurrected, He took all the good spirits with him, and the spirits of all the saved who have died subsequently are also with Jesus (but still without their glorified bodies).

I will now take up the meaning of the Hebrew *Sheol*. The term occurs some 65 times in the OT. The AV translates it as 'the grave' and 'hell' about 30 times each, the remainder being 'the pit'. Looking at the contexts, I see no reason for the different renderings. In my opinion, it should be transliterated as a proper name throughout. Since the inspired translation in Acts 2:27 equates *Sheol* with *Hades*, I take that to be the correct understanding. I say 'inspired translation' because Peter was doubtless speaking Hebrew, but the inspired account is in Greek.

To recapitulate and conclude, properly understood and utilized, 'Hell' refers to the Lake of Fire and brimstone, the second and eternal death. 'Sheol/Hades' refer to the halfway house where departed human spirits await the resurrection

and the final judgment. However, since the resurrection of Christ, I believe the side of the saved, 'Abraham's bosom', is now empty.

32) Harmonizing the accounts of the betrayal and arrest

1) The crowd arrives—Matthew 26:47, Mark 14:43, Luke 22:47[a], John 18:3. The four accounts state the fact, while Luke emphasizes that Judas was leading them, also implied by John.

2) Jesus knocks them down—John 18:4-9. I take this to be a 'cyst' of supernatural intervention, to make clear that the Father had not lost control of the events. I say 'cyst' because then the crowd carries on as if nothing had happened. A person delivered from demonic control often does not remember what he did while under that control; this may have been similar, only on the other side.

3) The kiss—Matthew 26:48-50[a], Mark 14:44-45, Luke 22:47[b]-48. Only three of the four accounts take up this pitiful episode. I offer the following harmonization:

> Now His betrayer had given them a signal, saying, "Whomever I kiss, he it is; seize him and take him away securely".[a] So upon arriving he went directly to Him. So Jesus said to him, "Friend, what brings you here?"[b] Judas said, "Greetings, Rabbi!" and kissed Him. So Jesus said to

[a] Why the 'securely'? Judas had seen so many manifestations of Jesus' power that he should have known better, but of course he was under Satan's control at that time. However, it appears that they expected resistance.

[b] Jesus knew perfectly well why Judas was there, so why did He call him "friend"? Perhaps to show that He held no personal animosity against him. The Plan was being fulfilled.

him, “Judas, are you betraying the Son of the Man with a kiss?”

4) They grab Jesus—Matthew 26:50[b], Mark 14:46. Judas served as guide, but I take it that Malchus was actually in charge of the operation. He may have taken the lead in grabbing Jesus, which was why Peter swung at him. This grabbing precipitated the reaction that followed.

5) Peter’s sword—Matthew 26:51-54, Mark 14:47, Luke 22:49-51, John 18:10-11. All four of the accounts take up this episode. I offer the following harmonization:

> When those who were around Him saw what was about to happen, they said to Him, “Lord, shall we strike with the sword?” Then Simon Peter, having a sword, drew it, struck the high priest’s servant and cut off his right ear. (The servant’s name was Malchus.)[a] Then Jesus reacted by saying, “Allow at least this!” and touching the man’s ear He healed him.[b] Then Jesus said to Peter: “Put your sword back into its place, for all who take the sword will die by the sword. Do you actually suppose that I cannot call upon my Father right now and He will place beside me more than twelve legions of angels?[c] But how then would the Scriptures be fulfilled that it has to happen this way? The cup that the Father has given me, must I not drink it?”

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[a] The Text has ‘the servant’, so the high priest had probably put him in charge of the operation. John probably knew him personally. Obviously Peter was not used to wielding a sword.

[b] Peter’s attack caused them to release Jesus, so His hands were free to do this. If the Lord had not healed that ear, things would probably have been nastier for Peter in the ‘courtyard’, if not already in the garden.

[c] That would be a minimum of 36,000—probably enough to handle the situation, don’t you think?

6) Jesus addresses the crowd—Matthew 26:55-56[a], Mark 14:48-49, Luke 22:52-53. Only three of the four accounts take up this episode. I offer the following harmonization:

> Then Jesus said to the chief priests, officers of the temple, and elders who had come against Him: "Have you come out with swords and clubs as against a bandit, to arrest me? I used to sit daily with you in the temple, teaching, and you did not seize me. But all this has happened so that the Scriptures of the prophets should be fulfilled. This is your hour; even the authority of the darkness!"[a]

7) The disciples run away—Matthew 26:56[b], Mark 14:50. The two accounts state the fact.

8) Jesus is taken away—Matthew 26:57, Mark 14:53[a], Luke 22:54[a], John 18:12-13[a]. The four accounts state the fact. The first three are in essential agreement, but John offers some new information. First, there was a Roman detachment, with its commander, there in the garden. The word here (*chiliarch*) refers to a commander of a thousand men (or of a cohort = about 600); this could only be a Roman officer of high rank, and there would only be one of them in Jerusalem. So how did they get him to come along? Obviously, Pilate had been informed and was participating. Second, they took Him to Annas first, because he was the father-in-law of Caiaphas,[b] who was high priest that year. A careful look at the parallel accounts makes clear that all of Peter's denials took place at Caiaphas' palace, as also all the recorded questionings, etc., so after showing Jesus to Annas

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[a] This was Satan's hour, being part of the Father's Plan; 'the darkness' refers to Satan's kingdom; 'your hour' means that they were part of that kingdom.

[b] The bigger reason was that Annas was the real high priest, according to the Law (the office of high priest was for life). He was the power behind the throne, so to say. Caiaphas was the political high priest (that year), for purposes of dealing with Rome.

they took Him on to Caiaphas. That interim was probably also used to gather the Council, who would not want to be dragged out of bed until Jesus was actually in hand—it was probably between 3 and 4 a.m.

33) Harmonizing the accounts of the burial

Matthew 27:57-61 X Mark 15:42-47 X Luke 23:50-56 X John 19:38-42

1) Joseph of Arimathea was an important man in town. He was 'rich' (Matthew 27:57) and a prominent member of the Sanhedrin (Mark 15:43). Any self-respecting governor would make it his business to know who were the important people within the area of his jurisdiction, so Pilate doubtless knew who Joseph was, whether or not he had ever met him—evidently Joseph experienced no difficulty in obtaining an audience. Joseph was 'a good and righteous man' (Luke 23:50) 'who himself had become a disciple of Jesus' (Matthew 27:57), but who had not declared himself openly 'for fear of the Jews' (John 19:38).

He had been waiting in the wings. Just as with the owner of the donkey, and the owner of the upper room, who were doubtless advised in advance that their services would be needed, Joseph had been prepared. He did not just 'happen' to have a tomb he didn't know what to do with, complete with a large stone just right for sealing. Since he had the where-withal, he had purchased the divinely indicated plot and had the tomb carved into, or out of, the sedimentary rock (Matthew 27:59, Mark 15:46, Luke 23:53). According to Isaiah 53:9, Jehovah's Servant was to have a rich man's grave, not whatever the common criminals got (the Father did not allow the Son's body to suffer that humiliation).

2) Nicodemus was a Pharisee and 'a ruler of the Jews' (John 3:1), the one who 'came to Jesus by night' (John19:39). Since he started his interview by declaring that Jesus was 'a

teacher come from God' (John 3:2), he no doubt became a disciple. Since he defended Jesus openly (John 7:50-51), his sympathies were presumably well known. He also had been prepared to assist Joseph with the burial procedure. He had purchased 'a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about a hundred pounds' (John 19:39), which represented a significant investment, and had placed them within the tomb in time to help Joseph with the body. Although the Text does not mention it, he was presumably also the one who furnished the linen strips for wrapping the body. Obviously, all preparations had to be completed before the time for the burial.

3) At the right moment, Joseph 'went boldly in to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus' (Mark 15:43). As already mentioned, he was evidently given an audience without difficulty. "Well Pilate was surprised that He was already dead; and summoning the centurion he asked him when He had died" (Mark 15:44). As soon as Jesus died, the centurion most probably had left the scene, going back to headquarters (he had probably received special instruction about Jesus). He probably felt he should inform Pilate about the unusual events, but somehow Joseph got ahead of him (but evidently not by much—had the centurion arrived first, he presumably would have been already reporting to Pilate when Joseph arrived). Well, Joseph was primed for action, watching from a distance, and as soon as Jesus dismissed His spirit Joseph headed for Pilate. "Upon the centurion's confirmation, he granted the body to Joseph" (Mark 15:45).

4) Then Joseph and Nicodemus met at the cross and removed the body. Joseph had purchased a linen sheet for the purpose, and the two used it to transport the body to the tomb (Matthew 27:59-60, Mark 15:46, Luke 23:53, John 19:39). Obviously the tomb had been prepared beforehand, as already stated. Matthew and John say that it was 'new', while Luke and John add that it had yet to be used (Matthew

27:60, Luke 23:53, John 19:41). John adds that it was in a garden near Golgotha.

5) Once within the tomb, they prepared the body for burial. "Then they took Jesus' body and wrapped it in linen strips, with the aromatic spices, according to the burial custom of the Jews" (John 19:40). How many linen strips would it take to wrap up 100 pounds of spices? The result would have looked something like a cocoon, except that it did not include the head, which was covered with a facecloth (John 20:7).

6) When they had finished their task, they 'rolled a large stone against the door of the tomb and left' (Matthew 27:60, Mark 15:46). If they rolled it, it was in the form of a wheel; there would be a track in which it rolled, with a bit of incline, so that Joseph and Nicodemus could roll it down into place, where it would stop; but it would take several men to roll it back up and away, 'because it was very large' (Mark 16:4).

7) Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Joses 'followed along', saw where the body was placed, and sat down opposite the tomb (Matthew 27:61, Mark 15:47, Luke 23:55). That is, they saw where the body was taken, but obviously had not looked in the tomb—there were 100 pounds of spices in there, with enough linen strips to tie it all in. This is clear from Luke 23:56, "Then they returned and prepared spices and perfumes; but they rested on the Sabbath according to the commandment." They evidently did not realize that the men had already done what there was to do.

8) Although subsequent to the burial itself, the guarding of the tomb is important; it is recorded in Matthew 27:62-66.

> **62**The next day, which is after the Preparation, the chief priests and the Pharisees went together to Pilate **63**saying: "Sir, we remember that that deceiver, while still alive, said, 'After three days I am going to rise'. **64**Therefore command that the grave be made secure until the third

day, lest His disciples come by night and steal Him and say to the people, 'He was raised from the dead', and the last deception will be worse than the first." **65**So Pilate said to them, "You have a guard; go make it as secure as you can!" **66**So they went and secured the grave with the guard, having sealed the stone.

Was Pilate happy? No, he was not! And maybe, just maybe, he wasn't as stupid as some might like to think. From Mark 15:44-45 we know that he debriefed the centurion, who had to explain why Jesus died sooner than expected! "Make it as sure as you can." Right. Ironically, those great champions of the Sabbath had to violate the Sabbath to secure the tomb. They thought they were being shrewd, but only played into God's hand. Their effort only made the evidence for the resurrection all the stronger. Well, for starters, who removed the stone? The soldiers would not touch a stone with a Roman seal, and they had no reason for doing it, in any case. The women were physically incapable of doing it. So who removed the stone?

34) Harmonizing the accounts of the crucifixion

Matthew 27:31-56 X Mark 15:20-41 X Luke 23:26-49 X John 19:16-37.

1) The soldiers lead Jesus away to be crucified, wearing His own clothes (Matthew 27:27-31, Mark 15:20, John 19:16).

2) On the way they conscripted Simon, a man of Cyrene, to follow Jesus, carrying His cross (Matthew 27:32, Mark 15:21,[a] Luke 23:26). The soldiers had already mistreated Jesus so badly that He probably was weakened and having trouble carrying the cross, which was probably heavy.

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[a] After carrying the cross, Simon doubtless stayed around to see what happened. In consequence he was no doubt converted, as were his two sons.

3) Only Luke mentions Jesus' message to the 'daughters of Jerusalem' (23:27-31), which I will transcribe here:

> **27**A considerable crowd of people followed Him, including women who were also mourning and lamenting Him. **28**So Jesus turned to them and said: "Daughters of Jerusalem, do not weep for me; rather weep for yourselves and for your children. **29**Because indeed, the days are coming in which they will say, 'Blessed are the barren, even the wombs that never bore and the breasts that never nursed!'[a] **30**Then they will begin 'to say to the mountains, "Fall on us!" and to the hills, "Cover us!"'[b] **31**For if they do these things in the 'green tree', what will happen in the 'dry'?"

If Jesus were still carrying the cross, He would not be able to 'turn' (verse 28), which is why I place this after the transferal of the cross to Simon.

4) They arrived at *Golgotha*, a Hebrew word meaning 'place of a skull' (Matthew 27:33, Mark 15:22, Luke 23:33, John 19:17).

5) The soldiers offered Him sour wine mixed with myrrh to drink, but He tasted it and then refused to drink it (Matthew 27:34, Mark 15:23).[c] That was a small humanitarian

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[a] For Jews to say this, things would have to get <u>really bad</u>.

[b] See Hosea 10:8.

[c] In the NKJV, Matthew 27:34ª reads like this: "they gave Him sour wine mingled with gall to drink." And Mark 15:23ª reads like this: "Then they gave Him wine mingled with myrrh to drink." That Mark used a generic term, 'wine', for the more precise 'sour wine' (or 'wine vinegar'), need not detain us. But what was the mixture? 'Gall' is one thing, an animal substance, and 'myrrh' is another, a vegetable substance; it was either one or the other, but which? Was Matthew influenced by Psalm 69:21? "They also gave me gall for my food, and for my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink." (Matthew wrote for a Jewish audience, and seems to have mentioned fulfilled prophecy whenever he could.) More to the point, perhaps, is Acts 8:23, where

gesture—myrrh is a crude anesthetic, and would deaden the pain. But Jesus refused it, so He remained fully alert on the cross and felt it all; the myrrh would have diminished the suffering.

6) The soldiers nailed Jesus to the cross and set it up. After taking care of Jesus, they also crucified two criminals, one on each side of Him (Matthew 27:35, Mark 15:24-25, 27-28, Luke 23:32-33, John 19:18). Mark specifies that "it was the third hour when they crucified Him"; he was using Jewish time, which means it was 9 a.m. With reference to the two criminals, Mark adds: So the Scripture was fulfilled which says, "And He was numbered with transgressors".[a]

7) John 19:19 says that the board with the statement of Jesus' 'crime' was put on the cross, above His head, and the time to do that would be while it was still on the ground. When the cross was placed upright, the board was already nailed on. All four Gospels mention the 'accusation', but each one gives it slightly differently (Matthew 27:37, Mark 15:26, Luke 23:38, John 19:19-22). Piecing them all together, the complete statement was: THIS IS JESUS THE NATSOREAN,[b] THE KING OF THE JEWS, and it was in three languages: Hebrew,

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Peter says to Simon (the ex-sorcerer), "for I see that you are in a gall of bitterness" (so the Greek Text). Evidently 'gall' was used as a generic term for any bitter substance. I take it that Matthew, perhaps influenced by Psalm 69:21, used the generic term. I conclude that the precise substance used was myrrh, as Mark indicates.

[a] See Isaiah 53:12. Around 11% of the Greek manuscripts omit this verse entirely, to be followed by NIV, NASB, LB, [TEV], etc.

[b] That Pilate put "<u>the</u> Natsorean" (<u>not</u> Natsarene [Nazarene]) indicates that he had researched Jesus. The reference is to Isaiah 11:1; Jesus was David's Branch, the Messiah. Pilate was making a statement. For an explanation of 'Natsorean', please see 'The Natsorean', item 84) below.

Greek and Latin.[a] John adds some important information:

> **20**So many of the Jews read this notice, because the place where Jesus was crucified was near the city; further, it was written in Hebrew, Greek and Latin! **21**So the chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate, "Don't write, 'The king of the Jews', but that the fellow said, 'I am the king of the Jews'." **22**Pilate answered, "What I have written, I have written!"

The chief priests had gotten all they were going to get out of Pilate; he was making a statement, but he was also getting back at them a little bit. (We don't know just when the Jews saw the notice, nor when the conversation took place. The board would have been prepared before the soldiers started out. It is likely that the Jews had 'observers' watching all that went on.)

8) The soldiers had to remain on the scene to prevent anyone from helping the victims, and of course they would sit down—they would be there for many hours. One of the things they did was to divide up Jesus' clothes (Matthew 27:35-36, Mark 15:24, Luke 23:34, John 19:23-24). John gives some interesting detail, so I will transcribe it:

> **23**Now when the soldiers had crucified Jesus, they took His clothes and made four parts, a part for each soldier.[b] They also took His tunic, but the tunic was seamless, woven in one piece from the top. **24**So they said among

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[a] To put all of that in three languages would require a board of fair size. But why did Pilate use <u>three</u> languages? One would have been enough (it was customary to put the crime over the victim's head). I take it that Pilate was **not** happy, having been bested by the Jews; and I think he was personally convinced that Jesus was a king. By putting 'this is the king of the Jews' he was making a statement, one that virtually any literate person would be able to read, given the three languages.

[b] This probably means that Jesus was left without any; one final bit of humiliation.

themselves, “Let’s not rip it, but toss for it, *to see* whose it will be”, so that the Scripture might be fulfilled which says: “They divided my clothes among themselves, and for my clothing they cast a lot.” That is why the soldiers did these things.

The reference is to Psalm 22:18. John seems to be affirming a cause/effect relationship. The centurion could have claimed the tunic, or whatever, but casting a lot had been prophesied. Luke 23:34 deserves special notice: Then Jesus said, “Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing”;[a] while they were dividing up His clothes by casting a lot. Only Luke records this important statement by Jesus; I take it that the Greek grammar at this point indicates that Jesus said it while the soldiers were dividing up His clothes. I suppose that Jesus was referring precisely to those soldiers; they were simply obeying orders, and had no personal responsibility for what was happening.

9) Only three of the Gospels mention the taunting by the spectators (Matthew 27:38-44, Mark 15:29-32, Luke 23:35-37). The accounts separate the spectators from the religious leaders, who evidently did most of the taunting, but the soldiers and the two criminals are also mentioned. The religious leaders were especially nasty: “He saved others; himself he cannot save!”[b] “If he is ‘King of Israel’ let him come down from the cross now and we will believe him!”[c] “He

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[a] The eclectic text currently in vogue (following less than 1% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality) places within double brackets the first half of verse 34: “Then Jesus said, ‘Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing’”. In this way they deny that Luke wrote it, surely a perverse proceeding.

[b] This was precisely true, but not in the sense they intended. To save us, He could not save Himself.

[c] This was a lie; they already knew that Jesus was the Messiah but had deliberately rejected Him. However, if Jesus had descended from the cross (as presumably He had the power to do) we would be without

trusted in God; let Him rescue him now, if He wants him; for he said, 'I am God's Son'." However, they were probably demonized at the time.

10) The criminals require special mention. Matthew writes: "Even the bandits who were crucified with Him were reviling Him in the same way", and Mark says much the same. But Luke adds an important item:

> **39**Then one of the hanged criminals started berating Him, saying, "If you are the Christ, save yourself and us!" **40**But the other reacted and rebuked him, saying: "Don't you even fear God, since you are under the same condemnation? **41**And we indeed justly, for we are receiving the due reward for our deeds; but this man did nothing wrong." **42**Then he said to Jesus, "Please remember me, Lord,[a] when you come in your kingdom".[b] **43**Jesus said to him, "I tell you assuredly, today you will be with me in Paradise."[c]

Evidently, they both started out by reviling Him, but later one of them repented—they were on the cross about three hours

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hope. The people were being satanically nasty, but Jesus was totally committed to the Father's will and thus the redemptive program was not aborted.

[a] Instead of "to Jesus, 'Please remember me, Lord'", perhaps 3% of the manuscripts have 'Jesus, remember me' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.), which seriously weakens the man's statement.

[b] I find this statement to be impressive: the man is declaring that Jesus is the Messiah and will indeed inaugurate His Kingdom. Evidently the man knew the Bible; and his request was honored!

[c] For Jesus to say 'today', He knew the man would die before sundown, so He knew the man's legs would be broken—otherwise he would most likely have lasted well into the night, which would have been 'tomorrow'. 'Paradise' here refers to that half of Hades (Sheol in the OT) reserved for the righteous dead. Hades is the 'half-way house' where departed spirits await the final judgment. In Luke 16:22 it is called "Abraham's bosom".

before the supernatural darkness, so there was time to observe Jesus, which caused one of them to change his mind.

11) Only John records Jesus providing for His mother:

> **25**Now Jesus' mother and her sister, Mary of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene were standing by His cross. **26**So Jesus, seeing His mother, and the disciple whom He loved standing by, He says to His mother, "Woman, there is your son!" **27**Then He says to the disciple, "There is your mother!" And from that hour the disciple took her into his home.

Notice that Jesus is still perfectly lucid. As Mary's oldest son, He was responsible for her well-being (we understand that Joseph was gone by now), so He passes that responsibility over to the apostle John (the author of this Gospel); and John accepts it.

12) Only three of the Gospels mention the three hours of supernatural darkness (Matthew 27:45, Mark 15:33, Luke 23:44-45). Matthew's statement will do: "Now from the sixth hour until the ninth hour a darkness came over all the land." Matthew uses Jewish time, so it was dark between noon and 3 p.m. The darkness could not have been a solar eclipse, as some have ignorantly argued. The Passover always occurs at full moon, and a solar eclipse only occurs at new moon. Further, even a total eclipse only lasts for a few minutes, not three hours. Why the darkness? I believe the Father was protecting the Son, so no one could observe His anguish as He was "made sin for us" (2 Corinthians 5:21).[a]

13) At 3 p.m., when the darkness was removed, Jesus gave a very loud anguished cry: "My God, my God, why have You abandoned me?"[b] I take it that the Father turned His back

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[a] As a side benefit, it was a mercy for the mother and close friends who were right there—how could they stand to see such suffering?

[b] See Psalm 22:1.

on the Son during those three hours—to be separated from the Father is spiritual death. For Jesus to pay for my sin and yours He had to take our wages: "The wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23)—both physical and spiritual. The Hebrew text of Isaiah 53:9 refers to His death**s**, using an intensive plural.

14) That shout gave rise to a curious situation (Matthew 27:47-49, Mark 15:35-36). Comparing the two accounts, we have an apparent discrepancy: Matthew records that others told the man to stop, while Mark records that the man told them to stop! So which is it? What I imagine is this: as both accounts state, a certain man [could it possibly have been John Mark himself?] decides to offer Jesus a drink of wine vinegar; several others, supposing that Jesus had just called on Elijah, tell him to stop; to which he retorts, "You (pl) stop!" and repeats their statement with sarcasm [anyone who really understood the language would have known that Jesus was not calling Elijah at all]. However, it does appear that the man stopped his action before Jesus could drink, since a bit later Jesus says, "I'm thirsty" (John 19:28).

15) The shout of victory is recorded by all four Gospels (Matthew 27:50-52, Mark 15:37-38, Luke 23:46, John 19:28-30), but they record a variety of details. I begin with John:

> **28**After this, knowing that everything was now accomplished so that the Scripture might be fulfilled, Jesus says, "I'm thirsty!" **29**Now a vessel full of sour wine was sitting there; so they filled a sponge with sour wine, placed it on a hyssop, and put it to His mouth. **30**Then, when He had received[a] the sour wine, Jesus said, "Paid in full!!" And

[a] From the word 'received' it appears that He did swallow some. Since sour wine was not used at the Passover, this does not conflict with the Lord's statement in the upper room (Matthew 26:29) that He would not drink of "this product of the vine". All four Evangelists mention the sour wine. There was evidently a pot/vessel full of it (the

bowing His head He dismissed His spirit.[a]

Matthew, Mark and Luke all affirm that Jesus gave a great shout, but without giving the content. I take it that John supplies that information, although he does not mention that it was a shout. "Τετελεσται"—that was what they wrote on bills and promissory notes when they were paid off = 'paid in full'. When something is shouted the individual sounds can be distorted, but John was right there and could read His lips, if necessary. It was a shout of victory: "We did it!" "Finished!" "Paid in full!"[b]

However, after that shout, Jesus did one more thing, as recorded by Luke: "Then, after giving a loud shout, Jesus said, 'Father, it is into your hands that I will commit my spirit'. And having said this, He breathed out His spirit." Jesus had the authority to dismiss His spirit, but this statement indicates that He had reestablished contact with the Father; it also constitutes a declaration of His confidence in the Father, in spite of the terrible suffering He had just been through. Matthew, Mark and Luke record that at that point "the veil of the temple was ripped in two from top to bottom!" The Father Himself ripped the veil (or ordered it done); it was His

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soldiers were in for many hours of vigil and that was what they drank). The mocking offer mentioned in Luke 23:36 happened before the darkness; the other three accounts after. The offer recorded in Matthew 27:48 and Mark 15:36 was triggered by Jesus' cry, "My God, my God, …" The one in John 19:29-30 by His saying, "I'm thirsty". I venture to suggest that there was an interval between His despairing cry and His statement—after the cry He may have lapsed back into silence for a bit; He was trying to make contact with the Father. It may be that the sour wine sort of 'wet His whistle' so He could let out His shout of victory.

[a] That is right—the cross did not kill Jesus; He just told His spirit to leave. In John 10:17-18 he was very clear: no one could take His life from Him, but He could lay it down.

[b] Oh praise God!

declaration that the **Price** had indeed been paid! Access to God's presence is no longer limited to one man once a year. See Hebrews 10:19-22.

Only Matthew records that: "And the earth was shaken, and the rocks were split, and the graves were opened. (And many bodies, of the saints who had fallen asleep, were raised; and coming forth out of the graves after His resurrection, they entered the holy city and were made visible to many.[a])" The earthquake was added confirmation that something supernatural was happening; even the hardened centurion was convinced.

16) Mention is made of a variety of reactions: "And the whole crowd that had gathered for the spectacle, when they saw what actually happened, went away beating their breasts"—this was a cultural expression of sorrow and distress. A number of His followers were watching from a distance. But the centurion requires special attention. Matthew writes: "Now when the centurion and those with him guarding Jesus saw the earthquake and all that happened, they were scared stiff and said, 'This *Man* really was the Son of God!'" And Mark writes: "Well when the centurion, who was standing opposite Him, saw that He breathed out His spirit after giving such a loud shout,[b] he said, 'This man really was God's Son!'"

Any centurion would be a hardened soldier, who had seen no end of crucifixions. He knew that a cross killed by asphyxiation. Hanging from the hands pushes the diaphragm

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[a] Wow! How would you like a departed saint to knock at your door?! It would be tremendous confirmatory evidence for Christ's resurrection. The Text does not say what happened to these resurrected saints, but to be sent back into the ground would be a real drag. It is more likely that they went with the risen Christ to heaven.

[b] A mere handful (0.4%) of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, omit 'after giving a loud shout', to be followed by NASB and LB.

against the lungs so you can't breathe. Nailing the feet, with the knees bent, was a sadistic procedure to prolong the agony—even though painful, the victim would push up so he could get a breath, until finally too worn out to do so. Breaking the legs would put an end to that expedient, and the person died within a few minutes, asphyxiated. Someone who is dying asphyxiated does not shout. Since Jesus gave a loud shout, but then immediately died, the centurion knew beyond the shadow of a doubt that the cross had not killed Jesus (later, when Joseph asks for the body, Pilate is surprised that Jesus could already be dead). But who can just tell his spirit to leave? Putting two and two together, the centurion concluded that Jesus was a supernatural being. Just so!

17) Only John offers the following information:

> **31**Now then, because it was Preparation Day, so that the bodies should not remain on the cross on the Sabbath (for that Sabbath was a high day), the Jews requested Pilate that their legs might be broken and they be removed. **32**Then the soldiers came and broke the legs of the first man and of the other one who had been crucified with Him. **33**But upon coming to Jesus, they did not break His legs, since they saw that He had already died. **34**But one of the soldiers pierced His side with a spear, and immediately blood and water came out. **35**And the one who saw has testified, and his testimony is true (yes, he knows he is telling the truth), so that you may believe. **36**Because these things happened so that the Scripture should be fulfilled: "Not a bone of His will be broken."[a] **37**And again another Scripture says: "They will look on Him whom they pierced."[b]

[a] See Exodus 12:46, Numbers 9:12 and Psalm 34:20.

[b] See Zechariah 12:10.

John, the author of this Gospel, was right there, so he could see very clearly what came out of Jesus' side—that the blood had separated was a clear sign of physical death.[a]

35) Harmonizing the accounts of the post-resurrection appearances

I will attempt to discuss the appearances in chronological sequence, although the evidence available does not always permit a clear decision. The first five occurred on Resurrection Day.

1) The first appearance is related in Mark 16:9 and John 20:14-17. Mark simply records the fact, stating clearly that it was to Mary Magdalene. John gives further detail about the encounter.

2) The second appearance is recorded only by Matthew, 28:9-10. This appearance was to Mary the mother of James, Salome, Joanna and 'the others'; the Text does not specify that it was the second, but the only other possible candidate would be Peter (Luke 24:34), and there simply was not enough elapsed time to fit him in here. According to verse 7, the disciples were to go to Galilee to see Jesus, verse 10 giving the same instruction to His 'brothers'. In Matthew 26:32 Jesus Himself had said to them, "After I am raised, I will go before you into Galilee."

3) I arbitrarily give the third appearance to Peter, but it could have been to the Emmaus disciples—between them they are the third and fourth. The fact is mentioned in Luke 24:34 and 1 Corinthians 15:5; just the fact and no more.

4) The episode on the road to Emmaus is recorded in Mark 16:12, but related in Luke 24:13-32 (Luke's account is

[a] I guess we do not need to know, really, just how the separation came about, whether by purely natural processes or with supernatural intervention; in any case, John is emphatic about what he saw.

most interesting).

5) The fifth, and last, recorded appearance on Resurrection Day was to the Eleven (although only ten were present), as recorded in Mark 16:14-18, Luke 24:36-49 and John 20:19-23 (1 Corinthians 15:5). I assume that Mark's record refers to that first Sunday, although the 'later' that begins verse 14 could also apply to the second Sunday (the eleven at the table would presumably have to be one of the two Sundays). The content of Mark's record seems to me to fit better with the first Sunday. Luke makes clear (verse 33) that there were others besides the Eleven in that upper room. Verse 36 makes clear that this was the first Sunday. Strictly speaking, verses 44-49 could have been uttered at a later date, but if not, then verse 49 requires special handling. "You must stay in the city of Jerusalem until you are clothed with power from on High." Since Jesus had instructed them to meet Him in Galilee, and did in fact meet with them there, then this amounts to a directive to return to Jerusalem after the meeting(s) in Galilee. John's account clearly refers to the first Sunday, and provides new information, as is his custom (from him we learn that Thomas was absent). The reference to 'the Twelve' in 1 Corinthians 15:5, probably refers to the first Sunday, but could have been the second, or even in Galilee. (I take it that both 'the Twelve' and 'the Eleven' were used as technical terms referring to the apostolic 'college'.)

6) The next recorded meeting is found in John 20:26-29, taking place on the following Sunday, in the same upper room, to the complete 'Eleven'.

7) The breakfast on the beach (John 21:1-23) must be the seventh, because verse 14 states: "This was already a third time that Jesus appeared to His disciples after He was raised from among the dead." This would presumably be the first appearance in Galilee, following the two in the upper room.

8) 1 Corinthians 15:6 states that "He was seen by over five hundred brothers at once", and subsequently by James, and finally by all the apostles (verse 7). The 'finally by all the apostles' presumably refers to the Ascension. The 500 might have happened at Matthew 28:16-20, but the Text refers only to the Eleven, as well as stating that Jesus had indicated the place (and presumably also the time). The reference to doubters presumably means that there were others present, since the Eleven could scarcely still be in doubt. Jesus' half-brothers (verse 10) were probably there, as well as others (recall that Luke 24:33 mentions others besides the apostles). I will assume that the '500' happened later.

9) "Over five hundred brothers at once".

10) James.

11) The Ascension is recorded in Mark 16:9, Luke 24:50-51 and Acts 1:6-11. Mark merely states the fact. Luke gives bare detail, but he offers more information in Acts, which he also wrote.

12) Acts 1:3 has "appearing to them during forty days", and Acts 13:31 has "for many days He was seen", but no specifics are given. However, we may reasonably conclude that those forty days were not empty, there having been further appearances that were not recorded—that is to say, before the Ascension, since we do indeed have some after that event.

13) Stephen—Acts 7:55-56.

14) Saul of Tarsus—Acts 26:13-18, 1 Corinthians 15:8.

15) Ananias—Acts 9:10-15.

16) Paul, more than once—Acts 22:17-21, 23:11, etc.

17) John—Revelation 1:9-13, etc.

And Sovereign Jesus has continued appearing to people down through the ages to this very hour. As He said in Matthew 28:20, "Take note, I am with you every day, until the

end of the age". Since that 'end' is still down the road, His promise continues in effect.

36) Harmonizing the accounts of the Resurrection

A rough sequence within the parallel accounts

Matthew 27:62-28:1;
Mark 16:1-3 // Luke 24:1;
Matthew 28:2-4;
John 20:1-10;
Matthew 28:5-8 // Mark 16:4-8 // Luke 24:2-8;
Mark 16:9 // John 20:11-18;
Matthew 28:9-15;
Luke 24:13-35;
Luke 24:36-43 // John 20:19-31.

The presumed sequence of events

Opponents of a Bible with objective authority have long affirmed that there are insuperable discrepancies between /among the four Gospel accounts. My purpose here is to demonstrate that there are no discrepancies.

0) [Saturday—guards seal the stone and set up a watch (Matthew 27:62-66).] This gives a necessary piece of background.

1) Jesus rises from the dead. None of the Evangelists mentions the moment of the resurrection, probably because that information was never revealed. The fact is taken for granted (the "firstborn from the dead"—Col. 1:18, Rev. 1:5; the "firstfruits"—1 Cor. 15:20, 23).

2) Early Sunday morning the women set out for the tomb—Magdalene (John.20:1); Magdalene and Mary (Matthew 28:1); Magdalene, Mary and Salome (Mark 16:1-2); Magdalene, Mary, Joanna and others (Luke 23:55- 24:1, 10). The several accounts say it was very early, as the day began to dawn, while it was still dark, but by the time they got to

the tomb the sun had risen. There is no discrepancy: recall that the garden is on the west side of a mountain, so even after the sun had risen the tomb would be in shadow, besides the shade of the trees. It was still darkish when they started out, but away from the mountain it was already day by the time they arrived—the tomb area would still be gloomy.

3) On the way they worry about the stone, "Who will roll away the stone from the door of the tomb for us?", because it was very large (Mark 16:3).

4) Before they arrive an angel rolls back the stone, complete with earthquake, etc. (Matthew 28:2-4). The removal of the stone was not to let Jesus out; it was to let witnesses in! If we only had Matthew's record, we could assume that the women saw the shining angel outside the sepulcher, but a comparison of the other accounts leads to a different understanding. So how do we know those details? Matthew 28:11 says that "some" of the guard reported to the priests and accepted big money to spread a false report, but what happened to the other guards? I have no doubt that some of those guards were soundly converted and gave an eyewitness account to the Christian community.

5) They arrive and see that the stone has been rolled back, but the angel was no longer visible outside (Mark 16:4, Luke 24:2, John 20:1). If the angel had been visible, Magdalene would not have taken off, because she would not have thought that the body had been stolen. The hypothesis that she came once alone, before the others, is highly improbable (see the next point).

6) Magdalene takes off immediately to tell Peter—Peter and John run to the tomb to see (John 20:2-3). Her use of the plural "we", verse 2, indicates that she was not alone at the tomb.

7) Before Peter and John get there the other women enter the tomb, and see and hear the angels (Luke 24:3-8,

Mark 16:5-7, Matthew 28:5-7). I take Matthew and Mark to be parallel, describing the same event: the angel who rolled away the stone is now inside the sepulcher, sitting on the right side; he has turned off his neon and appears to be a young man clothed in white; each account furnishes a few distinct details in the angel's speech. I here offer a harmonization of the two (Matthew and Mark).

> Upon entering the tomb they saw a young man dressed in a white robe sitting on the right side, and they were alarmed. Then the angel spoke up and said to the women: "Do not be afraid! I know that you are looking for Jesus the Natsarene, who was crucified. [6]He is not here, because He is risen, just like He said! Come, see the place where they laid Him. Now go quickly and tell His disciples, also Peter: 'He is risen from the dead; and get this, He is going before you into Galilee; there you will see Him, as He said to you'. There, I have told you!" [It almost sounds like he was glad to get it off his chest. I wonder why.]

However, the women were not sure they were happy with the situation; they were having trouble assimilating the missing body (they were loaded with spices to put on that body—was their effort to be wasted?); they didn't know who that 'young man' was; everything was very strange [don't forget the 'dead' soldiers outside]. I take it that Luke records a second inning: so the angel calls in a colleague and they both turn on their neon—a little shock treatment; then they appeal to Jesus' own words, which the women remember, and with that they are convinced and go their way.

8) They leave the tomb in fear, saying nothing to the guards or anyone they chance to meet (Mark 16:8, Matthew 28:8a).

9) Probably right after the women leave, and before Peter and John arrive, the guards take off (Matthew 28:11-15).

10) Peter and John come and go [to their own homes] (John 20:4-10; cf. Luke 24:12 that is an historical aside). Verse 8 says that John (the author) "saw and believed". What did John 'see' that made him 'believe'? He saw the linen strips 'lying', that is, in the form of the body, only there was no body inside them! If someone had stolen the body, as Magdalene supposed, they would have taken the wrapped package (much easier to carry) and there would have been no linen strips. If someone had unwrapped the body, for whatever reason, there would have been a sizable mound of linen strips and spices piled up (how much cloth would it take to wrap up a hundred pounds of spices?). No, Jesus simply passed through the cloth, as He would later pass through the wall of the upper room, leaving the package like a mummy case or empty cocoon. When John saw that, he understood that the only possible explanation was resurrection.

11) Magdalene returns to the sepulcher but does not get there until everyone is gone (that is why she thought Jesus was the gardener); Jesus appears to her first (Mark 19:9, John 20:11-17). When the disciples took off running, of course Magdalene followed them back to the tomb. But she was winded, and could not keep up with them (actually, in that culture women probably seldom ran, so she would really be out of breath, but she was not about to be left out of the action, either). She may have arrived as they were leaving; if not, they would pass her on the road. In verse 12, John says that she saw two 'angels'. How did John know they were angels? He had just been there and knew there were no human beings around (the guards were presumably gone before the two got there). The angels were in white, but probably not shining, or Magdalene would have been shaken out of her despair. She was so locked in to her sorrow that not even seeing the wrappings collapsed without the body sank in.

12) Then Jesus appears to the other women and they go on their way to tell the disciples (Matthew 28:9-10, Luke 24:9-11). The question may reasonably be asked: How could Magdalene have time to go and come and Jesus appear to her first and still have time to appear to the women before they got to the disciples, the more so since Matthew 28:8 says the women "hurried and ran"? I offer the following considerations in relief of the perceived difficulty: 1) The Jerusalem of that day was small and distances were short ("nearby", John 19:42)—it was probably less than a mile, or even half a mile, between the tomb and Peter's house, as well as where the other disciples were staying; 2) the women were probably slow in entering the tomb—the guards making like dead men, dark, spooky (it's a cemetery), all very strange, Magdalene the impulsive one wasn't there; they would be leery—Magdalene may have been almost to Peter's house before they worked up the courage to enter the tomb; 3) Magdalene, Peter and John were excited and had extra adrenalin—it didn't take that long; 4) The women ran out of the tomb and the garden, but not necessarily all the way to the disciples—once they got away from the garden and on 'safe' ground they may well have slowed down, or even stopped, to get a grip on them-selves and discuss what had happened (Mary, the mother of James, was no longer young, and none of the women was used to running, not to mention the type of clothing they wore). Putting it all together, I see no reason to doubt that it all happened just like the Text says.

13) Magdalene goes and tells the disciples (Mark 16:10-11, John 20:18).

14) Later in the day Jesus appears to Peter (cf. Luke 24:34). I see no way of determining the correct sequence of items 14 and 15, it could have been the other way around. Also, during resurrection Sunday (we don't know just when) many resurrected saints "went into the holy city and

appeared to many" (Matthew 27:53), which would have been dramatic confirmatory evidence to those who were visited.

15) The Emmaus-road episode (Luke 24:13-35, Mark 16:12-13). Some have alleged a discrepancy between the two accounts—their mistake is to tie both accounts to the eleven, which was not the case. There were other people in the upper room, besides the eleven. The eleven (ten) were reclining at a table, the 'others' would be nearer the door. The two from Emmaus come bursting in, all excited and probably feeling just a little important; it is the 'others', probably to 'prick their balloon', who say, "Oh, we already know that; He has appeared to Simon." (Human nature hasn't changed, and they didn't have the Holy Spirit yet.) While the two from Emmaus are talking with the 'others', not the eleven, Jesus Himself appears and interacts with the eleven (and they think He's a ghost!). Mark, writing for a Roman audience, is emphasizing that the disciples were not gullible, did not 'believe' because they wanted to—in verse 11 they didn't believe Magdalene, in verse 13 nor the two, in verse 14 Jesus rebukes their unbelief. There is nothing here to impugn the genuineness of these verses—they were certainly written by Mark at the same time that he wrote the rest. According to Matthew 28:17 many days later some were still doubting. In any group of people there are always differing levels of belief and unbelief. People's heads work differently, and at different speeds.

16) Jesus appears to the eleven, Thomas being absent (Luke 24:36-48, Mark 16:14-18, John 20:19-23).

17) After Jesus leaves, Thomas comes in and they tell him (John 20:24-25).

Conclusion

Putting it all together, I see no reason to doubt that it all happened just like the Text says. There are no discrepancies, in spite of the variety of details furnished by various eye-

witnesses (including converted guards) and recorded by four different Evangelists. It is just what we should expect from an inspired Text—inspired and preserved, to this day.

37) Harmonizing the accounts of the 'temptation'

The 'temptation of Jesus' is mentioned by three of the Gospels. Mark is very brief (1:12-13); he has the Holy Spirit 'driving' Jesus into the wilderness, rather than the 'leading' of the other two; also, he is the only one who mentions the animals. Mathew and Luke give more detailed accounts, with some discrepancies, which give rise to this note.

Matthew has, "into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil." Luke has, "into the wilderness, being tempted for forty days by the devil." We have no record of what Satan did during the forty days. That which is recorded happened at the end. Both Matthew and Luke agree that Jesus ate nothing during the 40 days, that at the end He was hungry, and that at that point Satan presented himself. They both record the same three tests, but in a different order, and it is this difference that requires special comment. The descriptions of the tests are not identical, but can easily be harmonized. At the end, Matthew has, "then the devil left Him, and angels came and ministered to Him". (Mark also mentions the angels.) Luke has: "When the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from Him until an opportune time." The two statements complement each other.

I will now consider the three tests. Both begin with 'bread', but Matthew has "these stones", while Luke has 'this stone'. I assume that both are correct. Satan started with 'these stones' and then singled out one that looked just like a loaf and said 'this one'. Both have Jesus responding with Deuteronomy 8:3. (Unfortunately, in Luke 4:4, less than half a percent of the extant Greek manuscripts, of objectively

inferior quality, omit “but by every word of God”, to be followed by most modern versions.)

For the second test, Matthew has the temple, while Luke has the high mountain, the third test being the reverse. So who has the correct sequence? Luke introduces both his second and third tests with the conjunction ‘and’, as if they were like separate blocks in a row. Matthew introduces his second test with a temporal adverb of sequence, ‘then’; he introduces the third with another adverb, ‘again’, one of whose uses is sequence. Since Matthew overtly states the sequence, I conclude that his order is the correct one—Luke was not concerned to give the sequence; he handles the ‘temple’ almost like an afterthought (the introductory conjunction could be rendered ‘also’). Matthew’s order is also the logical sequence; there is a progression in the severity or importance of the tests.

The actual description of the temple test given by both is almost identical. Matthew says “holy city” while Luke says “Jerusalem”. Satan cites Psalm 91:11-12, and Jesus responds with Deuteronomy 6:16. As for the high mountain test, Luke has a fuller description than does Matthew, but they are in harmony. In Matthew 4:10 some 12% of the Greek manuscripts omit “behind me”, as in most versions; in Luke 4:8 the whole “Get behind me, Satan!” is omitted by perhaps 3.5% of the Greek manuscripts (of inferior quality), to be followed by most modern versions. (Strange to relate, in Luke 4:5 just three known Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality [against over 1,700, almost all of which are better than the three], omit “up on a high mountain the devil”, to be followed by most modern versions, except that some keep ‘the devil’.)

To conclude, each of the three accounts supplies some information not found in the others, but they harmonize, being complementary. The one apparent discrepancy, the order of tests two and three, has a reasonable solution.

38) Hebrews 2:13

In both Matthew 16:19 and 18:18 the Greek Text has a verb phrase that is a periphrastic future perfect, passive voice: "will have been bound/loosed". However, in both the AV and NKJV, at least, the phrase is rendered as if it were a simple future: "will be bound/loosed", with the result that people have thought that they could tell God what to do. Notice that the Text does not say if you 'try' to bind; it has to actually happen, for Heaven to be involved.

I recently saw an attempt to justify that simple future by an appeal to Hebrews 2:13, where all versions (including mine, until this fourth edition!) have "I will put my trust in Him". His argument was based on the circumstance that "I will put my trust" is a translation of a periphrastic future perfect verb phrase, not a simple future. When I asked myself why I had translated the phrase as a simple future, I concluded that I must have simply copied everyone else. I then asked myself how I could make sense out of 'I will have put my trust'. The answer lies in the circumstance that it is a quote from 2 Samuel 22:3, the beginning of a song that is repeated as Psalm 18.

David was thanking the LORD for having delivered him from all his enemies: "The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer; the God of my strength, in whom I will trust". Considering God's faithfulness in the past, David affirms that he will continue to trust Him. So far so good, but the author of Hebrews put those words in the mouth of the Christ [!], and he did not repeat the simple future. So why did he use the periphrastic future perfect? Verses 9 and 10 deal with the incarnation of the Son, which forms the basis for the three quotes from the OT in verses 12 and 13. For the Son to accept the incarnation required a supreme trust in the Father, since as a human baby He would be totally helpless and

dependent. For Jehovah the Son to use David's words as applying to His incarnation 1,000 years later, the periphrastic future perfect is precisely appropriate: "I will have put my trust in Him".

39) Herod and John

To begin, Matthew 14:1-2, Mark 6:14-16 and Luke 9:7-9 are really about Jesus, not John, so I will set them aside. That leaves Matthew 14:3-12 and Mark 6:17-29 for consideration. However, strictly speaking, Matthew 14:6-12 and Mark 6:21-29 are really about Herodias, how she got revenge, so I will start with the remaining verses, Matthew 14:3-5 and Mark 6:17-20.

> Matthew 14:—**3**For Herod had laid hold of John and bound him, and put him in prison because of Herodias, his brother Philip's wife. **4**For John would say to him, "It is not lawful for you to have her".[a] **5**And although he wanted to kill him, he feared the crowd, because they counted him as a prophet.
>
> Mark 6:—**17**You see, Herod himself had ordered John arrested, and bound him in prison, on account of Herodias, his brother Philip's wife; because he had married her—**18**John had kept saying to Herod, "It isn't lawful for you to have your brother's wife". **19**So Herodias nursed a grudge against him and wanted to kill him;[b] but she could not, **20**because Herod feared John and protected him, knowing him to be a just and holy man. And consulting

[a] The impression one gets is that John took Herod to task several times—a coward he was not.

[b] I suppose that Herodias was ambitious and figured that Herod offered more than did Philip, so it was probably she who took the initiative; but she had not counted on John being a persistent and vocal 'conscience'.

him he would do many things; indeed, he would hear him with pleasure.

At first glance there appears to be some discrepancy between the two accounts, but let us slow down and take a careful look.

1) The whole episode revolves around Herodias. Her marriage to Philip presumably had nothing to do with passionate love, as such marriages seldom had. With the passage of time (she had a teenage daughter) she decided that Herod had more to offer than did his brother, and managed to convince Herod to take her on.

2) Enter John the Baptizer: he evidently was on speaking terms with Herod, and had access to him to the extent that he was able to reprimand him repeatedly for what he had done. Now kings generally do not enjoy being reprimanded, and a queen such as Herodias even less. Herod was mad, and Herodias was furious.

3) The evident solution was to get rid of the irritant, so Herod had John arrested, with a view to executing him. But Herod was a puppet king, under the dominion of Rome, and some attention needed to be given to public opinion—it was public opinion that put off the execution: "he feared the crowd, because they counted him as a prophet."

4) Now Herod knew that John was "a just and holy man," and the two had been on talking terms. With the passing of time, Herod calmed down and cooled off. He decided that he did not want to kill John, but because of Herodias he could not release him, either (she kept on insisting that John should be killed). But if you must keep a prophet of God in your prison, you may as well make use of him.

5) Now consider the last half of Mark 6:20—"And consulting him he would do many things; indeed, he would hear him with pleasure." I here follow the best line of transmission, albeit representing only 20% of the Greek manuscripts, that

has ‘consulting’ in the present tense; the rest, followed by all versions, have the verb in the past. Thus the NKJV has: “when he heard him, he did many things”. However, and unfortunately, at this point most ‘modern’ versions garble the account.

The immediately following ‘he would do many things/he did many things’ is attested by over 99% of the Greek manuscripts—a mere handful (0.4%), of objectively inferior quality, have ‘he was greatly disturbed’ or ‘very perplexed’ (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.). But why then did Herod hear John with pleasure, and why was he ‘very sorry’ (verse 26)? Those modern versions do not make sense; and just why do they insist on garbling the account on such a totally inadequate basis?

But what sorts of things would Herod take to John for his opinion? I suggest that Herod used John as a sounding board for administrative problems, and since he often followed his advice, he had an unusually good administration, there for a while. That is why he was genuinely sorry to lose John.

6) Alas, Herodias knew how to nurse a grudge, and never gave up looking for a way to kill John. The opportune moment came on Herod’s birthday. Herod had doubtless already ‘celebrated’ more than was good for him before the banquet began, and was no longer thinking clearly. We know the rest of the story. One wonders why God would allow such a servant, as was John, to suffer such an ignominious death; but at least it was instantaneous—in terms of suffering, crucifixion or burning at the stake would have been worse. We have no right to understand everything, and therefore no obligation to explain everything. When you get to heaven you can ask God directly, if you still want to know.

40) How did Judas die?

Matthew 27:5-8 X Acts 1:18-19

In the NKJV, according to Matthew, he "went and hanged himself", while according to Acts, "falling headlong he burst open in the middle and all his entrails gushed out". From the context it is clear that this happened at the field that he purchased, posthumously. For a successful hanging, there must be enough altitude so that when the end of the rope is reached the victim is still in the air. But to fall headlong there has to be a cliff, and you would have to dive off. Putting the two accounts together we may understand that there must have been a tree near the edge of the cliff, with a branch reaching out beyond the edge; Judas tied a cord around that branch and his neck and jumped—either the cord or the branch broke, and the impact was sufficient to split him open. Matthew states that it was actually the chief priests who bought the field, using the money that Judas had thrown on the temple floor; so Judas made the purchase posthumously.

41) How long was Jesus' body in the tomb?

Many books and articles have been written about this question. The principal difficulty derives from Jesus' own use of several different expressions to describe that time. Referring to the time period between His death and resurrection He Himself said: "the third day", "after three days" and "three days and three nights". A careful look at all the relevant passages makes clear that the three phrases are not equal candidates. Consider:

There is only one instance of 'three days and three nights', to be found in Matthew 12:40. Jesus cites the experience of Jonah (Jonah 1:17) and says that He will have a similar experience. That we are in the presence of a Hebrew idiom will become apparent from what follows.

There are just two instances of ‘after three days’, to be found in Mark 8:31 and Matthew 27:63. In Mark Jesus is cited in an indirect quote, as Jesus tells the disciples what is going to happen to Him. In Matthew Jesus is quoted by the Jewish leaders as they ask Pilate to guard the tomb; but notice that in verse 64 they go on to say, “until the third day”, so the two phrases would appear to be synonymous.

As for ‘the third day’, there are eleven direct instances, plus three related ones. Proper hermeneutic procedure requires that we interpret the few in terms of the many, and not the reverse. In Matthew 16:21, 17:23, 20:19; Mark 9:31, 10:34;[a] Luke 9:22, 18:33, Jesus is telling the disciples what is going to happen to Him. In Luke 24:7 the angel quotes Jesus to the women at the empty tomb. In Luke 24:46 the resurrected Jesus is speaking with the disciples. In Acts 10:40 Peter is preaching to Cornelius. In 1 Corinthians 15:4 Paul makes a statement. Those are the eleven direct instances. In Luke 24:21 Cleopas says to Jesus, “today is the third day since these things happened”—the ‘these things’ refers to the crucifixion, and the ‘today’ includes the resurrection, since he cites the women. In John 2:19 Jesus says, “destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it”. In Luke 13:32 Jesus sends a message to Herod, “the third day I will be perfected”. Those are the three related instances, for a total of fourteen. Well, the last one is marginal, so make it thirteen.

I suppose that all human cultures have the tendency to think that their way of seeing things is right, and all others wrong. But what to do when conflicts arise? When attempting to understand a given event, it is the culture within which it happened that must be respected. Jews and Brazilians handle time differently than do ‘Westerners’ in general. Here

[a] In Mark 10:34 the eclectic text currently in vogue reads ‘after three days’, following a mere 0.7% of the extant Greek manuscripts, which manuscripts are of objectively inferior quality, demonstrably so.

in Brazil, after church, we often say, “I’ll see you in eight days”, which means the next Sunday. The day in which you are is included in the number. We have biblical basis; consider John 20:26. “Well, after eight days His disciples were inside again, and Thomas with them.” ‘Eight days’ from when? “Then at evening on that first day of the week, the doors being locked where the disciples were assembled, for fear of the Jews, Jesus came and stood in the middle” (John 20:19). The ‘first day of the week’ is Sunday; the use of “that” indicates that it was Resurrection Sunday.

With few exceptions, the Church Universal has always understood that Jesus arose on a Sunday, as the Text plainly indicates. In John 20:26 “after eight days” means the next Sunday. To the ‘western’ mind, the use of ‘after’ is misleading; ‘after eight days’ would place one in the ninth day. But we are in the presence of a Hebrew idiom, wherein ‘after eight days’ = ‘the eighth day’. This is plainly indicated in Matthew 27:63-64, where ‘after three days’ = ‘until the third day’. But as already noted, the beginning day is included in the number; so ‘after eight days’ = ‘the eighth day’ = seven consecutive solar days of elapsed time (although the first and last solar day may not be a full 24 hours).

Now consider Luke 23:53-24:1.

> “Then he took it down, wrapped it in linen, and placed it in a tomb cut out of rock, where no one had ever been laid. **54**It was a Preparation day; the Sabbath was drawing near. **55**The women who had come with Him from Galilee followed along, and they saw the tomb and how His body was placed there. **56**Then they returned and prepared spices and perfumes. But they rested on the Sabbath according to the commandment. **1**Then on the first day of the week, at early dawn, they went to the tomb carrying the spices that they had prepared, along with some others.”

After the women observed the burial, they rested for one day—Sabbath is singular. They took their spices to the tomb on Sunday. It follows that Jesus was buried on Friday. Jesus was in the tomb for part of Friday, all of Saturday, and part of Sunday—He rose 'the third day'.

Mark 14:1 may also be of interest. "It was two days before the Passover and the Unleavened Bread." According to a careful analysis of the sequence of events that made up the last week, at this point it was late Tuesday afternoon, probably after 6:00 p.m.—adding two days takes us to 6:00 p.m. on Thursday, but the proceedings in the upper room began after 6:00 p.m. on that Thursday, which to the Jews was already Friday. Therefore Jesus died on a Friday. We take it that "3 days and 3 nights" was an idiomatic expression that could refer to three solar days represented by some part of each, but in sequence—in this case: Friday, Saturday and Sunday.

42) How many animals?

Matthew 21:1-7 X Mark 11:1-10, Luke 19:29-36, John 12:12-15

Mark, Luke and John are agreed in mentioning a single animal, a donkey colt. It was loosed, brought to Jesus, garments placed upon it, and then Jesus rode on it. Matthew insists on telling us that there were really two animals, the colt and its mother. The AV (KJV) has a most unfortunate translation of both Matthew 21:5 and Zechariah 9:9 (that has been corrected in the NKJV, fortunately). In Zechariah the AV has, "riding upon an ass, and upon a colt the foal of an ass." In Matthew the AV has, "sitting upon an ass, and a colt the foal of an ass." The obvious difficulty is that the AV makes Jesus ride two animals, when in fact He only rode one. For the correct rendering of both Zechariah and Matthew, at this point, please see the NKJV. That said, however, the fact

remains that Matthew clearly has the disciples fetching two animals and placing garments on both.

Why do you suppose the Holy Spirit had Matthew supply the added information? I was not there, of course, but I offer my understanding of the event. Mark and Luke specify that no one had ever sat on the colt; they say that the colt was tied, but Matthew says it was really the mother that was tied. Evidently the colt was so young that it was still staying close to 'mother', so if she was tied, he was too, in effect (they were out in the street, and that may have been a new experience for the colt). Jesus was going to subject the colt to a strange and even frightening situation. From the peace and quiet of his little village, he would be surrounded by a shouting crowd. Strange things would be put on his back, and then someone who was probably bigger and heavier than he was would sit on him! I believe that Jesus had the mother brought along as moral support for her son. Clothes were put on her too (and of course she was surrounded by the shouting crowd as well), and seeing that she was calm would encourage the colt. Just by the way, Jesus probably had to lift His feet to keep them from dragging; it must have been a comical sight. It gives me a warm feeling to see that the Lord Jesus was concerned for the well-being of the colt.

43) How many people?

Acts 7:14 X Genesis 46:26 X Genesis 46:27

Again, we need only pay close attention to each context, and the precise wording of the text. The three verses give us three different numbers: 75, 66 and 70, respectively. I will begin with the smallest number, which is in Genesis 46:26: "All the persons who went with Jacob to Egypt, who came from his body, besides Jacob's sons' wives, were sixty-six persons in all." The crucial datum is 'from his body', so who were they? Reuben + four sons = 5, Simeon + six sons = 7, Levi

+ three sons = 4, Judah + five sons + 6, Issachar + four sons = 5, Zebulun + three sons = 4, that add up to 31, but we must include Dinah to get the total of 32 from Leah. Gad + seven sons = 8, Asher + six sons + 7, but we must add a daughter (mentioned in the record) to get the total of 16 from Zilpah. Joseph + two sons = 3, Benjamin + ten sons = 11, that add up to 14 from Rachel. Dan + one son = 2, Naphtali + four sons = 5, that add up to 7 from Bilhah. The grand total 'from his body' is 69. But of course Joseph and his two sons were already in Egypt, so that leaves 66 who 'went with Jacob to Egypt'. Genesis 46:27 says, "All the persons of the house of Jacob who went to Egypt were seventy." This includes Joseph and Jacob himself, so there is no discrepancy. But what about Acts 7:14? "Then Joseph sent and called his father Jacob and all his relatives to him, seventy-five people." The 75 presumably refers to 'all his relatives', which excludes Jacob and of course Joseph. I take it that nine wives came to Egypt (the wives are mentioned in Genesis 46:26), the other two having died before the migration. (If we include Jacob, there would be eight wives.)

44) How many Thousand?

1 Corinthians 10:8 X Numbers 25:9

"And let us not fornicate, just as some of them did—and in one day twenty-three thousand died!" Numbers 25:9 says, "And those who died of the plague were twenty-four thou-sand." So was it 23, or 24? As always, we must pay careful attention to the context. The key is in the phrase, "in one day". After the first day, another thousand died, making a total of 24,000 dead.

45) How Often Did Jesus Say Peter Would Deny Him?

The question can be understood in two different senses, and I wish to explore them both. How often was Peter to deny

the Lord, and how often did the Lord warn him? I will consider the second question first. Each Gospel records a warning—the relevant passages are Matthew 26:30-35, Mark 14:26-31, Luke 22:31-34, 39 and John 13:36-38, 18:1. For reasons that will presently become apparent I will start to discuss the passages in reverse order.

How Many Warnings?

First, John 13:36-38:

> **36**Simon Peter says to Him, "Lord, where are you going?" Jesus answered him, "Where I am going you cannot follow me now, but later you will follow me". **37**Peter says to Him: "Lord, why can't I follow you now? I will lay down my life for your sake!" **38**Jesus answered him: "You will lay down your life for my sake? Most assuredly I say to you, no rooster can crow until you have denied me three times!"[a]

Notice the distinctive context that leads into our Lord's warning. Notice also the emphatic nature of His declaration—by employing a double negative (in the Greek text) He leaves no question but that three denials will take place before the first rooster crows from that moment on. Notice finally where

[a] The emphasis here is on the obligatory absence of any cockcrow until Peter has denied [at least] three times. There is no definite article with 'rooster', so it is "a rooster"; the negative is double, therefore emphatic, "absolutely not". If you have lived where there were a number of roosters, you know that one or another can sound off at any time, and some one of them will crow almost on the hour throughout the night, while at dawn they put on a chorus. It was probably somewhere around 9 p.m. when Jesus issued this warning, and Peter's first denial probably happened at least five hours later. For not a single rooster to crow anywhere within earshot during that time required supernatural intervention—which is why I render "no rooster can crow" (if an angel can close lions' mouths [Dan. 6:22], closing roosters' beaks would be a cakewalk).

and when this exchange took place. They were in the upper room where they had gathered to observe the Passover. Evidently this conversation between the Lord and Peter came comparatively early in the proceedings, because it was followed by the contents of chapters 14, 15, 16 and 17 before they left the room and went to the garden on the Mount of Olives (18:1).

Second, Luke 22:31-34:

> **31**Then the Lord said, "Simon, Simon, indeed Satan has asked for you (pl) that he may sift you as wheat, **32**but I have prayed for you (sg) that your faith should not fail, and when you have returned to me strengthen your brothers." **33**But he said to Him, "Lord, I am ready to go with you both to prison and to death!" **34**So He said, "I tell you, Peter, no rooster can crow this day before you will deny three times that you know me!"

Notice again the distinctive context that leads into our Lord's warning. It is clearly different from that given in John 13. Notice also that there seems to be an increase in the intensity of their exchange. There is a note of reproach in Peter's speech, and the use of Peter's name gives a stern note to the Lord's response. The addition of "today" (compared to John 13) and the shifting of "thrice" to an emphatic position (in the Greek text—again as compared to John) contribute to the feeling of heightened intensity. Also, now Peter will deny that he even knows Him. Note finally where and when this exchange took place. They were still in the upper room, but this conversation evidently came near the end of the proceedings, because only the contents of verses 35-38 intervened before they left the room and went to the Mount of Olives (22:39). Of course, more may have actually happened than is recorded in 22:35-38, but it seems clear that the warning recorded in Luke is not the same as the one recorded in John, and that the one in John happened first.

I find a comparison of the two warnings in Greek to be impressive and convincing:

John 13:38: "*Την ψυχην σου ὑπερ εμου θησεις; Αμην, αμην λεγω σοι, ου μη αλεκτωρ φωνηση ἑως οὗ απαρνηση με τρις.*"

Luke 22:34: "*Λεγω σοι, Πετρε, ου μη φωνηση σημερον αλεκτωρ πριν ἢ τρις απαρνηση μη ειδεναι με.*"

Really, there is no comparison; they are obviously different (even taking into account that they probably spoke Hebrew, so we are looking at a translation). As in John, here again we have a plain affirmation that three denials [at least] will take place before the first rooster crows.

Third, Matthew 26:30-35:

30And after hymn-singing they went out to the Mount of Olives. **31**Then Jesus says to them, "All of you will be caused to stumble because of me this night, for it is written: 'I will strike the Shepherd and the sheep of the flock will be scattered'. **32**But after I am raised I will go before you to Galilee." **33**Peter answered and said to Him, "Even if everyone *else* is caused to stumble because of you, **I** will never be caused to stumble!" **34**Jesus said to him, "Assuredly I say to you that this night, before *any* rooster crows, you will deny me three times!" **35**Peter says to Him, "Even if I have to die with you, I will **not** deny you!" All the *other* disciples said the same.

Notice that this exchange took place after they had left the upper room and were on their way to the Garden of Gethsemane. Again, the context is distinct from that in Luke or John—here the Lord begins by warning all the disciples. Peter counters by contradicting Him. The Lord's reiterated specific warning to Peter contains no new elements except that now it is "this very night". Peter contradicts again, using a double negative for emphasis—he 'has his back up' and is

starting to get impertinent. It seems clear that Matthew records a third warning to Peter, subsequent to those in Luke and John.

Fourth, Mark 14:26-31:

> **26**And after hymn-singing they went out to the Mount of Olives. **27**And Jesus says to them, "All of you will be caused to stumble because of me this night, for it is written: 'I will strike the Shepherd and the sheep will be scattered'. **28**But after I am raised I will go before you to Galilee." **29**But Peter said to Him, "Even if all are caused to stumble, yet I will not be!" **30**And Jesus says to him, "Assuredly I say to you that you, today, even this night, before a rooster crows <u>twice</u>, you will deny me three times!" **31**But he spoke the more vehemently, "If I have to die with you, I will certainly not deny you!" And they all said the same.

The first four verses are virtually identical with the parallel passage in Matthew, so we evidently have the same time and place in both. But now we come to verse 30, the despair of those who defend scriptural inerrancy and the delight of their opponents. Our Lord's statement here differs in several ways from that in Matthew 26:34 but the main problem is the word "twice". What are we to say: Are Matthew 26:34 and Mark 14:30 contradictory accounts of the same warning?

Before settling for that explanation, the precise turn of phrase in Mark 14:30 invites our attention. I believe it will help to see a word for word rendering of what Jesus said. "Assuredly I say to you that <u>you</u>, today, this very night, before twice a rooster crows, thrice you will deny me." The Lord's declaration here seems quite sharp. There is extraordinary emphasis on the second "you". "Twice" is also heavily emphasized. How are we to account for such severity? Peter's effort in verse 29 scarcely seems to merit such a reaction—the reaction recorded in Matthew 26:34 seems much more

appropriate. And what shall we say to Mark 14:31? Peter's words here are virtually identical to those in Matthew 26:35 but they are introduced by "but he spoke the more vehemently." Why the vehement reiteration?

I suggest that the solution is to read the following sequence. Matthew 26:30-35[a] then Mark 14:30-31:

Jesus: "All of you will be caused to stumble because of me this night…"

Peter: "Though all are caused to stumble because of you, I will never be caused to stumble."

Jesus: "Assuredly I say to you that this night, before any rooster crows, you will deny me three times."

Peter: "Even if I have to die with you I will certainly not deny you!"

Jesus: "Assuredly I say to you that you, today, this very night, before a rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times."

Peter, more vehemently: "If I have to die with you, I will certainly not deny you!"

In other words, Mark omitted the exchange recorded in Matthew 26:34-35[a] while Matthew omitted the exchange recorded in Mark 14:30-31[a]. (The editorial comment "and they all said the same" comes at the end of the whole episode.)

On three separate occasions Jesus warned Peter that he would deny Him [at least] three times before a rooster crowed during that night. Peter's responses became increasingly belligerent until after the third warning he even contradicted the Lord with an emphatic double negative (Matthew 26:35). Finally, the Lord lost His patience, as it were, and said in effect, "Listen, not only will you deny me three times before a rooster crows once, you will deny me another three times before a rooster crows twice!" For answer Peter repeats his prior statement even more vehemently.

The reader will perceive that in answering the second question I have anticipated the answer to the first one. The Lord warned Peter four times, each Gospel recording a separate instance, and there would be [at least] six denials, three before the first crowing of a rooster (John, Luke, Matthew) and another three before the second (Mark). It remains to enquire whether the several accounts of Peter's denials will countenance this proposal. The relevant passages are Matthew 26:57-75, Mark 14:53-72, Luke 22:54-62 and John 18:15-27.

How Many Denials?

A cursory reading of these passages suggests that Peter's denials were provoked by eight different challenges—the maid at the outside entrance (John), a maid in the courtyard (Matthew, Mark, Luke), the same maid a second time (Mark), a different maid in the gateway (Matthew), two different men (Luke, John), and the bystanders on two occasions (John and Matthew, Mark). Although it may be possible to combine one pair or another, there is no reasonable way to get the number down to three. But what if there were at least six denials?

To really get the complete picture we need to plot the relevant information on a chart. We need to know who issued the challenge, where, when, just how was it done, what was Peter's reaction, and if a rooster crowed. Because of constraints of space and paper size, I will do a Gospel at a time, beginning with John.[a]

[a] A comparison of the contents of the four Gospels reveals that in the main John supplies information not recorded in the other three; he wrote last, with the purpose of supplementing their accounts. Here again, the three denials he describes are all new information, not to be found in the other three.

John 18:15-27:

	1st denial	2nd denial	3rd denial
Who?	the gatekeeper (f)	servants and operatives	a relative of Malchus
Where?	outside gate	by the fire	by the fire (?)
When?	at the beginning of the proceedings	a little while after the first one	a little while after the second one (?)
How was it done?	she asks: "You aren't one of this man's disciples too, are you?"	they ask: "You aren't one of his disciples too, are you?"	he asks: "Didn't I see you with him in the garden?"
What was the reaction?	he says: "I am not!"	he said: "I am not!"	(Peter denied again)
Rooster?	(no)	(no)	immediately a rooster crowed

Luke 22:54-62:

	1st denial	2nd denial	3rd denial
Who?	a servant girl	a man	another man
Where?	by the fire	by the fire (?)	by the fire (?)
When?	fairly early on (?)	a little later	about an hour later
How was it done?	she looked intently and said: "This man was also with him."	he said: "You also are of them."	he confidently affirmed: "Surely this fellow also was with him, for he is a Galilean."
What was the reaction?	he said: "Woman, I do not know him!"	he said: "Man, I am not!"	he said: "Man, I do not know what you are saying!"
Rooster?	(no)	(no)	immediately, while he was yet speaking, a rooster crowed.

Matthew 26:57-75:

	1st denial	2nd denial	3rd denial
Who?	a servant girl	another girl	bystanders
Where?	by the fire	in the gateway	by the fire (?)
When?	fairly early on (?)	a little later	a little later
How was it done?	approached him saying: "You too were with Jesus the Galilean."	says to the others: "This fellow also was with Jesus the Natsorean."	come up to Peter and say: "Really, you too are one of them, because your very accent gives you away!"
What was the reaction?	denied before them all: "I don't know what you are saying."	denied with an oath: "I do not know the man!"	began to curse and to swear: "I do not know the man!"
Rooster?	(no)	(no)	immediately a roster crowed

Mark 14:53-72:

	1st denial	2nd denial	3rd denial
Who?	a servant girl	the same girl	bystanders
Where?	by the fire	in the forecourt (?)	by the fire (?)
When?	fairly early on (?)	a little later	a little later

How was it done?	looked at him and said: "You also were with Jesus the Nazarene."	says to the bystanders: "This is one of them."	say to Peter again: "Surely you are one of them; for you are a Galilean and your speech shows it!"
What was the reaction?	denied, saying: "I neither know nor understand what you are saying!"	(he denied again)	he began to curse and to swear: "I do not know this man of who you speak!"
Rooster?	he went out to the fore-court and a rooster crowed	(no)	a rooster crowed a second time

If you compare all the parameters—who, where, when, how, what—there really is no way to come out with only three denials; even to come out with only six requires some gymnastics (something I attempted to do in an early draft). Let us try to arrange the events in chronological sequence and see what happens.

John 18:17 gives us what is clearly the first challenge—as the maid who kept the outside door let Peter in, at John's request, she asked, "You aren't one of this man's disciples too, are you?"[a] Even though John was evidently standing right there, Peter denied, "I am not". He then went in to stand near the fire in the courtyard. The other Gospels have Peter sitting, while John has him standing. Evidently there were quite a few people about—they could not all sit close to the fire. Presumably they would take turns standing near the fire to warm up and then move away a bit to sit down. Thus they, including Peter, would be alternately sitting and standing.

All four Gospels have Peter in the courtyard near the fire (Matthew 26:58 and 69, Mark 14:54 and 66, Luke 22:55, and

[a] Everyone there, including the girl, knows that John belongs to Jesus, so her question is perfectly natural, without malice—since John is vouching for Peter, she assumes that Peter must also belong to Jesus. John had heard all the warnings, so when Peter denied at the gate, in his presence, John doubtless kept a close eye on him the whole rest of the night. So we have an eyewitness account. Of course Peter himself would also be an eyewitness, but since he was undergoing satanic interference in his mind, his powers of recollection might be impaired.

John 18:18 and 25) and three of them (Matthew, Mark, John) give some account of the council's dealings with Jesus before going on with Peter's denials.[a] We know from Luke 22:61 that Jesus was at a window that looked out on the courtyard, only with His back to it. John is the only one who records that the high priest asked Jesus about His disciples (v. 19)—he is facing Jesus and therefore the open window, and would be speaking loudly enough for everyone in the room to hear clearly, so the people in the courtyard also heard everything he said—then in verse 25 we read, "Therefore they said to him, 'You aren't one of his disciples too, are you?'" I suggest that verse 25 gives us the second challenge and denial. The guards around the fire, presumably prompted by the high priest's questioning Jesus about His disciples, put their question to Peter. He answers them as he did the girl at the gate, "I am not". So far the challengers have only questioned, rather than affirm, but now the tempo quickens.

I take it that the first denials recorded in Matthew (26:69-70), Mark (14:66-68) and Luke (22:56-57) form a single episode. Collating them we may understand the following. A certain serving girl of the high priest came by and saw Peter sitting near the fire. She looked closely at him and said to the others, "This man also was with him" (Luke). She then addressed Peter directly, "You also were with Jesus the Nazarene, of Galilee" (Matthew, Mark). But he denied before them all, saying, "Girl, I don't know him; I neither know nor understand what you're talking about!" He then went out to the forecourt, and a rooster crowed (Mark 14:68). Thus, there were [at least] three denials before the first cockcrow.

I say 'at least' because the third denial in John probably belongs here as well. In 18:26 the verb "to say" is in the

[a] It is after midnight and chilly in the courtyard, hence the fire; but there must have been over fifty people in the room where the questioning was going on, and all windows would be open.

present tense, which seems to suggest a brief interval rather than nearly an hour (Luke 22:59); also the challenge is still framed as a question, "Didn't I see you with him in the garden?", rather than a direct accusation, which would fit better toward the beginning than at the end. I see no problem with suggesting that all three of the denials in John were part of the first set and thus he records the first rooster crow. In that event I would understand that there were actually four denials before the first crowing, the three in John plus the first one in the others. Because the rooster crowed "immediately" I imagine that the order would be as follows: the first two in John, in that order, then the first one in the others, and then, as Peter was moving toward the forecourt, the relative of Peter's victim comes alongside and puts his question, so that Peter is at the fore-court when the first rooster crows (Mark 14:68). Actually, I am inclined to suspect that indeed there were four denials before the first cockcrow, which is recorded by both Mark and John (recall that Jesus neither said nor implied that there would be 'only' three).[a]

Now for the next round. In Mark (14:69) the same girl sees Peter again and starts telling the bystanders, "This fellow is one of them". In Matthew (26:71) a different girl sees him and tells the bystanders, "This fellow was with Jesus the Natsorean". In Luke (22:58) a man saw him and said, "You also are one of them". In order to come out with only three denials in the second set, two of these would have to be combined, but as already stated, I am not aware of anything in the Text that rules out the possibility that there could be more than three. It seems to me that there is a progression in Peter's desperation which culminates in his cursing and swearing. On that basis I would consider the instances in Mark and Luke as forming a single episode (if I had to)—the

[a] The satanic interference in Peter's mind was so effective that not even the rooster's crowing woke him up.

girl speaks, Peter denies, a man backs the girl up and Peter answers, “Man, I am not!” Then the instance in Matthew would be the sixth denial—notice that now Peter adds an oath! Because of the oath I consider that this denial comes after the other two just mentioned; also, Peter has moved out to the gateway. Actually, I am inclined to suspect that there were also four denials before the second cockcrow, so I will start again on that basis.

The girl that provoked the third denial is not about to let Peter get away with that denial. Whether she followed him out to the forecourt, or he moved back toward the fire, I imagine that Mark 14:69 records the fifth denial. If so, Luke 22:58 records the sixth denial, perhaps near the fire. Peter is definitely uncomfortable; he is getting altogether too much unwelcome attention. He moves out to the gateway (perhaps thinking of abandoning the premises)[a] where he is challenged by a different girl (Matthew 26:71); Peter denies with an oath (number seven). Luke (22:59) puts ‘about an hour’ between denials six and eight, so perhaps Peter was left alone for a bit. However, the ‘trial’ is over but the bosses are waiting for dawn so they can take Jesus to Pilate. Since the bosses are not going home, the guards and employees cannot either—they are obliged to wait out in the cold, bored stiff—so Peter is now the only show in town.

For the eighth denial three Gospels offer a candidate (Mat. 26:73-74, Mark 14:70-72, Luke 22:59-60). The accounts in Matthew and Mark are very similar and evidently parallel. Since Matthew has the rooster crowing “immediately” and Mark “the second time” this has to be last denial—since by now Peter is cursing and swearing it is fitting that it should be. By that time most of the people on the premises would be

[a] So why didn’t Peter just bolt out the gate at that point? I would say that there was supernatural intervention—he simply was not allowed to leave.

aware of Peter and his denials. After listening for a while they closed in, citing his accent. The account in Luke has just one man speaking, but his words are in the same vein. This also has to be the last denial because we are told that the rooster crowed while Peter was still speaking. Evidently a number of people were speaking at once (but not in unison), or in rapid succession, and different writers preserve some of the variety of statement. It would appear that they were ganging up on Peter, because he is driven to curse and to swear. And so we have a second set of four denials, before the second cock-crow. Even then it took a direct look from the Lord (Luke 22:61) to break Satan's spell and bring Peter to a realization of what he had done.

But the question may well be asked, why did each Gospel writer report and speak of only three denials (albeit giving different selections) if there were really six or eight?[a] I

[a] Some 50% of the Greek manuscripts that contain the Gospels have colophons; these colophons state that Matthew was 'published' 8 years after Christ's ascension, Mark 10 years after, Luke 15 years after and John 32 years after Christ's ascension. (So the four Gospels are arranged in chronological order, not only in our Bibles but in the vast majority of the Greek manuscripts.) "To the Jew first, …"—since Matthew wrote for a Jewish audience, God's priorities dictated that Matthew's should be the first inspired account of our Savior's life on earth to circulate. Then Mark, with Matthew's Gospel open in front of him, and Peter at his elbow, wrote for the Roman mind (since Romans would care nothing for Hebrew Scriptures, Mark removed virtually all reference to fulfilled prophecy). Then Luke, with both Mark and Matthew to hand, wrote the third, for the Greek mind. Then John, with the first three open, wrote to fill in the gaps, preserving important information not provided by the others, for all minds. Now let's consider Peter's denials within that framework. Matthew wrote first, with one cockcrow. Mark says there were really two cockcrows and changes the second denial (1 and 3 are the same in Mark and Matthew). Luke speaks of just one cockcrow, changes the second denial yet again and provides added information (specific) about the third. So just with these three accounts we are up to five denials. John

suggest that we are looking at a prime example of the grace and sensitivity of God. It would be quite humiliating enough to have denied the Lord three/four times, but to go on to do so another three/four times, even after hearing a rooster crow, would be almost too much to bear. Rather than put the full extent of Peter's ignominy on display the Holy Spirit had each writer give only a partial account, enough for the purposes of the record but without flaying Peter unnecessarily. I find it interesting to note that it is Mark who furnishes the necessary clue that there was to be a second set of denials. The opinion is widely held that Peter influenced the composition of this Gospel—this is overtly stated in the introduction to the Gospel found in many manuscripts—and if so he may have insisted on including the hint as to the extent of his humiliation, whereas the others delicately avoided it.

The Text-critical Problem

Although there are around a hundred textual differences reflected in the printed editions of the Greek Text (in the passages considered), I will confine my remarks here to the set that is especially bothersome in terms of the subject matter of this paper.

There are four places in Mark's account that relate to the two cockcrows: "twice" in 14:30, "and a rooster crowed" in 14:68, "the second time" and "twice" in 14:72. Instances 1, 3 and 4 go together and appear to contradict the account in Matthew, Luke and John. Instance 2 is apparently even worse because according to Mark's account Peter had only denied once when the rooster 'jumped the gun' and crowed before he was supposed to (Jesus had said there would certainly be <u>three</u> denials, as recorded in the other three Gospels).

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speaks of just one cockcrow but records three new denials, not mentioned by the other three. If these are inspired accounts, then God did it on purpose, and it is up to us to try to figure out why (see my concluding paragraph).

Accordingly, ever since the second century there have been those who tried to 'help' Mark out of his difficulties, tampering with the text.

According to the present state of our knowledge, it appears that seven Greek MSS omit "twice" in 14:30 (but they do so in two different ways), nine MSS omit "and a rooster crowed" in 14:68 (but in two ways), five omit "the second time" in 14:72[a], and seven omit "twice" in 14:72[b] (two others omit the whole clause). The roster of MSS shifts in each case, as does the versional evidence that sides with the omissions. Only three witnesses are thoroughgoing and omit all four: Codex Aleph, cursive 579 and the Old Latin "c" (it[c]). This is a curious state of affairs. If the purpose of the omissions was to make Mark conform to the other Gospels, only Aleph, 579 and it[c] have succeeded. Of the seventeen MSS involved, twelve omit only one of the four; one MS omits two of them; and two MSS omit three (there is some doubt here). Unless someone is prepared to show why Aleph and 579 are to be preferred above every other MS (some 1700 for Mark), and it[c] above all the rest of the versional evidence, Latin and otherwise, there is really no reason to take the omissions seriously. However, the eclectic school does take them seriously, even without the requisite demonstration.

It appears that the 'harder reading' canon has come to the aid of the vast majority of the MSS, at least as far as the editors of the 'critical' or eclectic texts presently in vogue are concerned. Instances 1, 3, and 4 are retained in all Nestle and UBS editions (although UBS ascribes "a considerable degree of doubt" to 1 and 3, and "some degree of doubt" to 4—the change in grade here is strange). However, when it comes to instance 2 ("and a rooster crowed") we get some variety: Nestle editions 1 to 25 omit the words; Nestle[26] and all three UBS editions retain them, but in single brackets (the UBS editors ascribe "a very high degree of doubt" to these words,

along with the brackets which themselves signify “dubious textual validity”). Presumably the crucial datum here is that Codex B joins the evidence for omission with instance 2 (but not the others). From W-H through N^{25} that was enough to banish the words from the Text. One supposes that it was the “harder reading” canon that restored them to UBS and N^{26}, if only in brackets. It seems to me that this case affords a clear example of the superficiality that characterizes the work of the eclectic school—to challenge the authenticity of a reading supported by over 99% of the MSS is unreasonable at any time, but to do so in the face of a perfectly obvious motivation for the omission is irresponsible.

The English versions that I have consulted all retain instances 1, 3 and 4, but deal variously with instance 2. AV, LB, NKJV, Phillips and TEV all retain “and a rooster crowed”, but LB favors us with a footnote: “This statement is found in only some of the MSS.” What might the purpose of such a footnote be? From the use of the word “only” it would appear that the purpose is to raise a doubt in the reader’s mind about the reliability of the Text. Why would they want to do that? The use of the word “some” also invites comment: it is their way of referring to some 1700 MSS, against nine! Will the reader not be deceived?

Jerusalem, NASB, NEB, NIV and RSV all omit the clause, but only Jerusalem does so without comment. The footnote in NEB reads, “Some witnesses insert ‘and a cock crew’.” As in LB, by “some” they mean some 1700 MSS, not to mention massive versional support and almost unanimous lectionary support. Will the reader not be deceived? The footnote in RSV reads, “Other ancient authorities add ‘and the cock crowed’.” The footnote in NIV reads, “Some early MSS add ‘and the rooster crowd’.” The footnote in NASB reads, “Later mss. add: ‘and a cock crowed’.” In order to evaluate such footnotes, we would need to know the precise definitions for “ancient”,

"early" and "later". However, I submit that the uninitiated reader of such footnotes will certainly be misled as to the massive evidence against omission.

The case of the NIV invites special comment. It is the only version that offers a footnote at all four instances. At 14:30 we read, "Some early MSS omit 'twice'." At 14:68 we read, "Some early MSS add 'and the rooster crowed'." At 14:72[a] we read, "Some early MSS omit 'the second time'." At 14:72[b] we read, "Some early MSS omit 'twice'." (The meaning of "some" in the second instance is quite different from that in the other three.) What possible reason could the editors have had for including these footnotes? The immediate effect is to call in question the reliability of the Text at those points. Since the NIV editors held to a high view of Scripture, why would they want to do that? I suppose that it was precisely their concern for the inerrancy of the Text that was at work here. It appears that they did not see any other solution to the seeming discrepancy between Mark and the other Gospels than to imply that Aleph and Old Latin "c" might be right after all. Alas!

The NIV editors are barking up the wrong tree. The worst thing to be done here would be to follow Aleph in deleting all four instances. As already pointed out, the four Gospels record eight different challenges resulting in denials, but no two Gospels have the same selection. So to follow Aleph would force us to try to accommodate eight denials before the first rooster crow, which seems to me to be hopeless. The best thing to be done here is to follow the true Text, which God has graciously caused to be preserved, in this case, in over 99% of the evidence. Peter denied three/four times before the first rooster-crow and another set of three/four before the second. The Lord had warned him: "Simon, Simon, indeed Satan has asked for you, that he may sift you as wheat" (Luke 22:31). Peter should have paid attention.

Implications

One question that arises is this: What about the internal integrity of each account? For instance, in John's account, even if we were to claim that two of the denials occurred before the first rooster crow, while the third denial came after the first and before the second, would this claim do violence to the integrity of John's Gospel? Why would it? Let us review the record. In John 13:38 Jesus said to Peter, "Most assuredly I say to you, a rooster shall not crow till you have denied me three times!" The Lord did not say "only" three times—the emphasis is on the obligatory absence of any rooster crow until Peter has denied three times, at least three times (there is nothing in the Lord's turn of phrase to preclude the possibility that there could be more than three). In the Greek text there is no definite article with "rooster" and there is an emphatic double negative with the verb "to crow"—"a rooster shall not crow!" (These observations also apply in Luke 22:34; in fact, in all four Gospels, in both the predictions and the fulfilments, it is always "a" rooster.)

Turning to John's account of the denials themselves, the first one, at the outside door (18:17), poses no difficulty. The second denial (18:25) likewise poses no difficulty—these two occurred before any rooster crow. But what if the third denial (in John's account, 18:26-27) came after the first crowing?[a] I see no problem, in principle. The Lord made a statement of fact, correctly recorded by John—there had to be three denials before the first rooster crow. This was precisely fulfilled, the others supplying the third denial. Nothing in John's account precludes the possibility that there should be subsequent crowings. (Anyone who has lived near roosters knows that they start crowing off and on any time after

[a] As the reader knows, I believe the third denial in John comes before the first cockcrow, but I am covering this possibility for the sake of those who may prefer to have it in the second set.

midnight and at day-break put on a concert—it seems obvious to me that the first two crowings were overtly controlled by God so as to match Christ's predictions.) In 18:27, after the third denial recorded by John, we read, "and immediately a rooster crowed". John does not say that it was the first crowing. Someone without access to the other Gospels would naturally assume that John records the first rooster crow, and that the three denials he gives are the whole story—but nothing in John's statement demands that interpretation; it simply arises from incomplete information. The other three present several added denials that are clearly distinct. The several Evangelists provide distinct sets of details, much like the pieces of a puzzle, that must be fitted together to get the whole picture. The several accounts are complementary, not contradictory.

But how about the internal integrity of Mark's account? He is the only one who mentions the second rooster crow, as such, and in fact his account is tied to it. Jesus said, "before a rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times," and Mark records three denials before the second rooster crow. Again, Jesus did not say "only" three times, the emphasis is on "you" and "twice". The other Gospels are needed to get the full picture, but Mark's account is entirely self-consistent.

And how about Luke? In the warning the emphasis is on the obligatory absence of a rooster crow until Peter has denied three times—at least three times (Jesus did not say "only" three times). After describing three of the denials Luke writes, "and immediately, while he was still speaking, a rooster crowed". "A" rooster—he does not say it was the first. Then Luke has Peter remembering that Jesus said, "Before a rooster crows, you will deny me three times". Presumably Peter remembered every detail of all the warnings, but Luke (and each of the other Evangelists) gives only a partial description—in fact, Luke has him recalling the warning

recorded by Matthew, not the one he himself gave. A reader having only Luke's account may assume that he told the whole story, but it is an unwarranted assumption. Luke's account is internally consistent yet the precise turn of phrase is such that it does not preclude my proposal.

So what about Matthew? Virtually everything said about Luke above can be repeated here. He has Peter remembering the warning he himself recorded. Again it is "a" rooster. Matthew's account is internally consistent yet the turn of phrase will accommodate my proposal without being viola-ted. All of which brings us back to the question: Why does each Gospel speak of three denials, rather than six, eight or whatever? I don't know; we aren't told. My best guess is that God chose to draw a veil over the full extent of Peter's ignominy (and perhaps to test our disposition when faced with the unexplained). But it remains a plain fact that each Gospel offers a different assortment of challenges and denials, giving a total of at least eight denials.

Another question that I have heard concerns the validity of attempting an exercise such as this at all. I believe that God deliberately brings difficulties into our lives (Job in the ash heap, Abraham on Moriah, Moses herding sheep, Joseph in prison, Daniel with the lions, and on, and on), and puts puzzles in the world, to test our disposition and fiber, and to cause us to grow. "It is the glory of God to conceal a matter, but the glory of kings is to search out a matter" (Proverbs 25:2). [Even if you are not a king, you get the point.] The case of John the baptizer in prison comes closer to home. He is frustrated, maybe disillusioned; he did his job but his expectations are not being realized. So he sends two disciples to ask Jesus for an explanation. In effect Jesus answers, "Check the evidence; do your homework," and closes with, "And blessed is he who is not offended because of me" (Matthew 11:6). When faced with the difficult or unexplained we must be

careful not to rebel. It is much better to obey the command recorded in 1 Peter 3:15. "Sanctify the Lord God in your hearts, and always be ready to give a defense to everyone who asks you a reason for the hope that is in you…" Since opponents of a Text with objective authority have used the accounts of Peter's denials as an argument against any idea of inerrancy, I consider that a defense of that inerrancy is in order.

46) How to hear the Holy Spirit

Clearly, to begin, you must <u>have</u> the Holy Spirit, before you can hear Him. So how does one get the Holy Spirit?

Allow me to give my understanding of the sequence of events involved in receiving new life in Christ:

1) I believe into Jesus. The Text always has 'believe into' (εις) Jesus or His name, never 'believe in' (εν). A change of location is involved, from being outside of Christ to being in Him. That change involves commitment, and a change of worldview.

2) He baptizes me with Holy Spirit. Matthew 3:11, Mark 1:8 and Luke 3:16 all have the Baptizer saying that Jesus will baptize people with Holy Spirit. In John 1:33 God Himself says that. So when and how does Jesus do it? I take it that after Pentecost He does so from His position at the Father's right hand (1 Peter 3:21-22), and He does it as soon as a person believes into Him. Cornelius offers a concrete example.[a] (Please see my article, "Baptisms in the Bible",

[a] "To **Him** all the prophets bear witness that through His name everyone who believes into Him will receive forgiveness of sins." While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit fell on all who were hearing the message (Acts 10:43-44). This was the crucial bit of information they were waiting for, what they had to do to be

available from my site: www.prunch.org. It is also item 7 above.)

3) Holy Spirit regenerates me, giving me a new nature.

4) Probably at the same time, He baptizes me into Christ's body. 1 Corinthians 12:12-13 explains that it is the Holy Spirit who baptizes us into Christ: ". . . so also is Christ. For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body." The primary reference here is probably to the Church as being Christ's body.[a]

5) Then Holy Spirit takes up residence within me, and my body becomes His temple (1 Corinthians 6:19). It is the Holy Spirit within me who helps and enables me to appropriate the benefits that Christ's victory on the cross projects towards me.

Why would, or should, anyone want to 'hear' the Holy Spirit? Presumably to receive instruction and orientation, with a view to following or obeying it. In John 4:23-24 Sovereign Jesus said that the Father is looking for those who will worship Him in spirit and truth. To worship 'in truth' excludes mere curiosity. We must be committed to obey before we know what the order is. James 1:5-8 states plainly that God generally does not answer a double-minded person. We cannot play games with the Sovereign of the Universe!

How can we know when the Holy Spirit is dealing with us? It depends on intimacy and relationship. In John 15:14-15 (in the upper room) Jesus said: "You are my friends if you do

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saved. The minute Peter said, "believe into Jesus", they did! And the Holy Spirit came upon them!

[a] A secondary reference could be to Jesus' physical body. If we become part of Jesus' body, then whatever happened to that body happened to us. If that body died, we did. If it was buried, so were we. If it was raised from the dead, we will be too. Correction—we already have new life in Christ, and are to live on that basis.

whatever I command you. I no longer call you slaves, because a slave does not know what his owner is doing; rather I have called you friends, because I have made known to you everything that I heard from my Father." Amazing, the Sovereign offers us the privilege of being His friends, but first we must be His slaves, doing whatever He commands us. An owner will share his dream, his 'big idea' with a friend, but not necessarily with a slave. Now consider Psalm 32:8-9: "I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will guide you with my eye. Do not be like the horse or like the mule." Bits and whips cause physical pain, and altogether too often that is the way that God has to deal with us. To be guided by someone's eye requires intimacy, and to develop intimacy requires time. To develop intimacy with the Holy Spirit we must spend time reading His Word and asking Him to instruct us as we do so. To be guided by someone's eye, you must pay attention to that eye.

"Whatever I command you"—before God will give us individual commands, we must be living according to the standards that are laid down in the Scriptures. God's written Revelation is the starting point and is expressly called the Holy Spirit's 'sword' (Ephesians 6:17), and He uses it in a variety of ways (1 Timothy 3:16-17, Hebrews 4:12). James 1:22-25 compares the Word to a mirror, only this mirror tells us the truth about ourselves, and is therefore uncomfortable. Individual commands are reserved for slaves and friends. Since a slave exists to do what his owner commands, it is in the owner's own interest to be sure that the slave knows what he is supposed to do. A slave has to know what he is supposed to do, but he will not necessarily be told why the owner wants him to do it. To know what we are supposed to do, we must ask specifically to be guided.

In passing, let me say that I am not always full of the Spirit, but I am never without Him. This is important. If you ask Him

to warn you when you are in danger or about to do something you shouldn't, He usually will. I believe it was Oswald Chambers who wrote about the 'checks' of the Spirit; He 'checks' or warns you when you need it. One day a former colleague of mine was walking on a path in the Amazon jungle, when he felt the Spirit tell him to stop, so he did. He looked around and down and saw a very poisonous snake in the path ahead of him. If he had not stopped, he would have been bitten. Apart from the Holy Spirit`s `checks`, we all need discernment, and the Holy Spirit gives discernment. We need to develop the habit of always asking Him for discernment and guidance whenever we encounter a situation where we need it. Depending on our level of intimacy, we sometimes receive them without asking.

Also in passing, how does one avoid becoming an 'old wineskin'? Many 'churches' began with 'new wine', but did not continue to grow. They settled into a customary procedure and became 'old wineskins' in their turn. I would say that the only way to avoid it, whether as an individual or as a group, is to be constantly listening to the Holy Spirit as we read His Word. We must be open to change and in fact actually change, as He calls things to our attention. **However**, that will make us unpredictable.

Recall what Sovereign Jesus said to Nicodemus in John 3:8: "The wind blows where it wishes, and you (sg) hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who has been begotten by the Spirit." Notice that the Lord is saying here that it is **we** who are to be unpredictable, like the wind, or the Spirit ("comes" and "goes" are in the present tense). If you are really under the control of the Spirit you will do unexpected things, just like He does. And that will make you a *persona non grata*.

How so? Well, no religious denomination or school can tolerate someone who listens to and obeys the Holy Spirit. All

such institutions are committed to a particular doctrinal 'package',[a] and the Holy Spirit does not like packages; He cannot be put in a box. No such school can tolerate a student, or a faculty member, who listens to and obeys the Holy Spirit. One of the conditions for being on the faculty is that you must respect your colleagues: respect for colleagues trumps respect for the Holy Spirit. The point I am making is that listening to the Holy Spirit carries a price. Do not expect human approval. John 12:43 refers to some people who "loved the praise of men more than the praise of God", and he was not being complementary.

Furthermore, there is the matter of dying to self. In 1 Corinthians 15:31 Paul wrote, "I die every day". Paul could not have been referring to actual physical death, obviously, since Hebrews 9:27 affirms that it is appointed to men to die only once (no re-incarnation). He may well have faced possible death often enough, but I suppose he is referring to dying to himself, to his own ambitions, ideas and wishes, so as to embrace God's will. Remember what the Lord Jesus Himself said in Luke 9:23. "If anyone desires to come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross, and follow me." Some 13% of the Greek manuscripts add 'daily', as in most versions, but if you take it up, you have it. It sounds like being without a cross is not an option for those who follow Jesus. In those days a cross represented death; as with Paul, Jesus was not talking about physical death.

Then there is Romans 12:1-2.

> Now then, brothers, I exhort you, in view of God's compassions, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy, satisfying to God—your intelligent duty. Yes, stop conforming to the pattern of this world; rather, be transformed

[a] The institutions financial survival may depend on 'toeing the line'.

by the renewing of your mind so as to be able to experience the good and satisfying and perfect will of God.[a]

Any animal in the Old Testament had to die in order to become a sacrifice, so what does Paul mean by a 'living' one? You live 'dying'. To present the body is presumably a metonym for presenting one's whole self.

Now consider Romans 8:14, "as many as are led by God's Spirit, these are God's sons". Hey, wait a minute; this is not what I was taught in Seminary! The Text says that in order to be God's son you must be led by God's Spirit! Verse 12 is addressed to 'brothers', and verse 13 says that to live according to the flesh results in death. But someone living according to the flesh is obviously not being led by the Spirit. You cannot die unless you are alive; notice also the "if indeed" in verse 17. In order to be led by the Holy Spirit, you have to listen to Him!

Consider also Galatians 5:16-18.

> I say then: walk in the Spirit, and you will not fulfill any lust of the flesh. Because the flesh desires what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh; they oppose each other; it follows that you may not do the things that you wish. However, if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under law.

What the flesh wants is bad for you; what the Spirit wants is good for you. To be led by the Spirit is not to be under a set of rules; it is a relationship.

To walk is to take a sequence of individual steps. In physical walking we do not think about the individual steps, they are 'automatic', unless unusual circumstances oblige us to do so. I would say that walking in the Spirit is similar. We all

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[a] 'The pattern of this world' belongs to Satan, so it must be rejected in order to do God's will.

have responsibilities and commitments that take up most of our time, but a commitment to Christ and His Kingdom should be our controlling factor. Each morning I commit myself and my day's activities to the Holy Spirit and ask for His protection and direction. I then do the logical and reasonable thing to do within my context, except that I expressly ask the Holy Spirit to 'check' me when necessary.

Consider also 1 Thessalonians 5:19, "Do not quench the Spirit!" When you quench a lighted candle, you put out its light. To quench the Spirit is presumably to 'put out' or refuse His light, to suppress or ignore His voice when He speaks to us—this would include any rejection of the revealed will of God.

To recapitulate:

1) We must **have** the Holy Spirit, before we can listen to Him.
2) We must be willing and ready to obey.
3) We must maintain an active relationship with Him.
4) We must be open to change and in fact actually change, as He calls things to our attention.
5) We must die to self.

47) How to save your life

When someone asks me how I view my relationship with Jesus Christ, and if there is time to explain, I say that I am His slave. I am in good company since Paul (Romans 1:1), James (James 1:1), Peter (2 Peter 1:1) and Jude (Jude 1) said the same thing. It is a slavery that you choose because of love (see Exodus 21:1-6), love of Jesus, as a free and spontaneous act of the will. Presumably some will not like the idea of being a slave, but do not forget one little detail: everyone is a slave! It is an inherent aspect of the human condition. We are born as slaves, we live as slaves, we die as slaves. In John 8:34 the

Lord Jesus declared: “Most assuredly I say to you, whoever commits sin is a slave of sin.” Apart from God the human being has no option; he is born a sinner and remains a slave of sin until he dies. “Slave of sin” is another way of saying ‘slave of self’—this is what destroys us; we are self-centered (it leads us to rebel against God)—and to be a slave of ‘self’ is to be a slave of Satan, because the unaided, self-centered person cannot withstand him. But Jesus offers a choice. Hallelujah! The choice is not to stop being a slave, oh no! The choice is to change masters.

I became a slave of Christ on the 13th of April, 1956, when I was almost twenty-two years old. I have been a ‘believer’ virtually from birth—I cannot remember a time when I did not believe in the Lord Jesus. I was a believer, but I was not a disciple; I had not yet surrendered my will. Before 4/13/56 I was still ruled by my own ideas and ambitions, my own wishes and desires. I was still trying to choose my own way, to guide my own steps. I had a bad time of it! It seemed like I was always ‘falling on my face’. Of course. Wherever would a twenty-year-old gain the wisdom, the knowledge, the capacity to run his own life? When and from whom could he have learned it? (Or a forty-year-old, or a sixty-year-old—do you suppose the situation improves sufficiently?) The Bible states plainly that the human being is not competent to direct his own steps (here please read Jeremiah 10:23, Proverbs 28:26, Jeremiah 17:9 and Proverbs 20:24). Before I became a slave of Jesus, I was under the control of a master that lacked understanding, lacked power and lacked competence—I was really in a bad way. Now I have a Master who has all knowledge, has all power, and loves me so much He died for me. What could be better than that?

Let us see how it works. Consider the situation of a slave in Jesus’ time. Did he have any rights? No. Why did a slave exist? To serve, his owner. A slave owned nothing, not even

himself. It follows that the owner must meet the slave's physical needs—the slave has nothing. For over sixty years I have lived on the basis of Luke 12:22-34. For over sixty years I did not know from month to month just how much God would give me; rarely was it the same two months in a row. Yet neither I nor my wife and children ever went hungry. I have seen a time when there were at least four knots in my shoelaces (before I married), but I have never been without shoes. In short, we have never lacked.

If the owner gives an order that involves expense (e.g. to build a house), then he must furnish the materials, etc. In other words, what the owner orders he himself has to pay for. When Jesus orders something He pays for it. In my case He ordered two master's degrees and a doctorate. They cost plenty—Jesus paid everything; I have nothing. The distance I have traveled by air would girdle the globe more than once—Jesus paid it all; I have nothing. **What Jesus orders He pays for**.

In fact, I have just one major concern in life: to understand just what my Owner wants me to do. Once I am sure, I move forward, without looking back. It is a sure thing. Can I imagine that my Master will go back on His word? Can I doubt His ability or willingness to supply my needs (Psalm 24:1)? Are there any other relevant doubts? I must confess that I find it hard to understand why so many believers refuse to be slaves (or true disciples) of Jesus, why they won't turn their lives over to Him. Can it be that they are asking the wrong question? I suppose many ask themselves, "What is it going to cost me to be a slave/disciple of Christ?" That is not the right question.

The correct question to ask is, "What will it cost me if I am **not** His slave/disciple?" Instead of thinking about what Jesus may demand, about giving up our ambitions and desires, about maybe being sent to the jungle to work with

'Indians', we should really think about the consequences of refusing to surrender our lives to Jesus. The price you pay for not living for Christ's kingdom is to lose your life. That's all it costs, just your life! Consider the words of the Lord Jesus recorded in Luke 9:24-25. Let us begin with verse 23. "If anyone desires to come after me let him deny himself, take up his cross each day and follow me. For whoever wants to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake, he will save it. For what will it profit a man to gain the whole world but waste or forfeit himself?" What does the Lord mean when He speaks of losing one's "life"? One does not lose one's soul for love of Christ. Nor is the reference to being killed. Rather, Jesus has in mind the life we live, the accumulated results of our living. All that I have done up to this moment plus all that I will yet do until overtaken by death or the rapture of the Church, whichever happens first—that is the "life" that is at risk (in my own case).

Let us look at our Lord's words a little more closely. There seems to be a contradiction here—if you lose, you save; if you want to save, you lose. How can it work? The following context helps us out. In verse 26 Jesus explains verses 24-25 in terms of His second coming. The parallel passage, Matthew 16:27, is clearer. "For the Son of Man is going to come in the glory of his Father, with his angels, and then he will repay each according to his deeds." Christ was thinking of the day of reckoning. In other words, "we will all stand before the judgment seat of Christ" (Romans 14:10) and "each of us will give account of himself to God" (Romans 14:12). "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive his due according to what he has done while in the body, whether good or bad" (2 Corinthians 5:10). I understand that 1 Corinthians 3:11-15 is referring to the same occasion, the day of reckoning. After declaring that Jesus Christ is the only foundation, Paul speaks of different

materials that one might use in building on it: “gold, silver, precious stones” or “wood, hay, straw”. (Although the primary interpretation of this passage presumably has to do with the performance of teachers and leaders in the church, I believe it clearly applies to the daily life of each believer as well.) The point is, our deeds will be tested by fire. If fire has any effect upon gold or silver it is only to purify them, but its effect on hay and straw is devastating! Okay, so what?

Let us go back to the beginning. God created the human being for His glory; to reflect it and contribute to it. I suppose we may understand Psalm 19:1 and Isaiah 43:7 in this way, at least by extension. But Adam lost this capacity when he rebelled against God. For this reason, the sentence that weighs against our race is that we “fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23). But the Son came into the world to restore our lost potential. Ephesians 1:12 and 14 tell us that the object of the plan of salvation is “the praise of His glory” (see also 2 Corinthians 1:20). And 1 Corinthians 10:31 puts it into a **command**: “Whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God.” Now then, the point of all this is not to ‘ruin’ our lives, to take all the ‘fun’ out of them (as many seem to think). God is not being arrogant, unreasonable, too demanding. Quite the contrary—He is just trying to save us from throwing away our lives. Surely, because the glory of God is eternal (Psalm 104:31), and when I do something for His glory that something is transformed and acquires eternal value—it becomes “gold, silver, precious stones”. Works done for the glory of God will go through the fire without harm. On the other hand, what is done with a view to our own ambitions and ideas is “straw”. We all know what fire does to straw!

So there it is. To be a slave of Christ means to live with reference to the Kingdom; it means to do everything for the glory of God. In this way the slave “saves” his life because he

will be building it with “gold and silver”, which will pass through the fire at the judgment seat of Christ without loss. In contrast, the believer who refuses to be a slave of Jesus builds his life with “hay and straw”, which will be consumed by the fire—and so he “loses”’ his life; he lived in vain; the potential that his life represented was wasted, thrown away. What a tragedy!

(I suppose there might be someone who will say: “Okay, okay! I get the point. I’m throwing away my life. So what? What business is it of yours? If I want to lose my life that's my problem!” Well, sure, that is right, it is your problem. But I wish you would consider one detail: the problem is not exclusively yours; it is not just **yours**! It also concerns the individuals who should have been reached through your life but were not. And it concerns Christ Himself who was cheated out of His right in your life.)

48) How to use God’s power to take, and maintain, the initiative in the war against evil

Isaiah 47:10: “You have trusted in your wickedness; you have said, ‘No one sees me.’” This is a word addressed to Babylon, that in the context constantly used witchcraft. The translation of the Jewish Publication Society has, ‘you have been secure’. I think that in our country and world today many servants of Satan, because they have never seen a Christian who knew how to use God’s power (see Ephesians 3:20 below), have come to the conclusion that Satan's power is greater than the power of God, at least for practical purposes in this world. They feel safe and secure.

Ephesians 3:20-21: “Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to

the power that is working in us,[a] 21 to Him be the glory in the Church in Christ Jesus, to all generations, forever and ever. Amen."[b] Ephesians 1:19 speaks of "the exceeding greatness of His power **into** us who are believing"—note that the verb is in the present tense; having believed yesterday won't hack it, we must believe today. This tremendous power that God pours into us, as we believe, exceeds our powers of imagination. Well now, my personal horizon is limited and defined by my ability to imagine. Anything that I can't imagine lies outside my horizon, and so obviously I won't ask for it. I sadly confess that I have not yet arrived at a spiritual level where I can unleash this power—I have yet to make the truth in this verse work for me. Worse, much worse, during the 90 years of my life, I have never seen anyone who wielded this power.[c] No wonder Satan's servants feel secure—that is a calamity the size of the world, worse than a pandemic!![d]

Ephesians 1:19-20: "and what the exceeding greatness of His power into us who are believing, according to the

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[a] The whole point of the exercise (verse 21) is for God to get glory [not for me to have a good time, although if I ever get there I will certainly have a great good time!], and to the extent that we do not put His power in us to work we are depriving Him of glory that He could and should have.

[b] The glory that God gets from the Church will go on forever.

[c] But I understand that the truth affirmed here is literal, and I only hope that others will get there before I do (so I can learn from them), if I keep on delaying.

[d] And there is more: I don't know anyone in Brazil, where I live, who has the gift of discerning spirits (or at least who makes use of the gift). Since there are humanoids (offspring of demon with woman) and 'robots' (a person who voluntarily surrenders himself to the total control of a demon), operating everywhere, we desperately need this gift! Is the Holy Spirit not giving it to anyone? Or could it be that no church is giving space for the exercise of this gift? (In this case, the person with the gift remains silent, inert.) And why denounce an evil spirit if no one in the church knows what to do about it?

demonstration of the extent of His might which He exercised in the Christ when He raised Him from among the dead and seated Him at His right, in the heavenly realms, far above every ruler and authority and power and dominion—even every name that can be named, not only in this age but also in the next." It is generally understood that the reference is to the angelic hierarchy. The two thirds that remained faithful to God were never a problem, so presumably the special point is that Christ defeated Satan, with his one third (Revelation 12:3-4), and is now (as the God/man, the second Adam) seated 'far above' that enemy. Now consider Ephesians 2:5-6.

Ephesians 2:5-6: "even when we were dead in our transgressions—made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved) and raised us up together and seated us together in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus." This is tremendous! Here we have our authority. Christ is now seated at the Father's right, "far above" (1:21) the enemy and his hosts. This verse affirms that we are there too! So in Christ we also are far above the enemy and his hosts. We should be consciously operating on that basis, but since few churches teach this, most Christians live in spiritual defeat. Since they don't know anything else, they think that is the normal Christian life. How sad!

But there is a 'condition'! Now consider John 5:19-20: "Then Jesus answered and said to them: 'Most assuredly I say to you, the Son is not able to do anything from Himself, except something He sees the Father doing; because whatever things He does, precisely these the Son also does.[a] For the Father

[a] For a long time, I only looked at the 'saw', not the 'could', which is still true. Jesus only did what He saw the Father doing; so how about us? I would say that my main 'ministry' problem is that I often don't know what the Father is doing, and so I waste a lot of time and effort.

loves[a] the Son and shows Him everything that He Himself is doing.'"

The Son "could not" do what the Father was not doing. Well now, if Jesus couldn't, how much less can we! What this saying by the Sovereign teaches me is that handling God's power in an aggressive way, as offense, must be in accord with the Father's will, something that He 'is doing'. It follows that before I act, I need to spend time in the Father's presence to hear from Him what He is doing. Jesus was always in contact with the Father, but I am not, at least not in the same sense.

I think it is worth noting that God is prepared to use just one person who is available to Him. God used Moses, Joshua, Elijah, Elisha and Paul: Acts 13:9 says that Paul was "filled with Holy Spirit", so blinding Elymas was something God wanted to do. Ezekiel 22:30 says that God looked for just one man to stand in the gap, but there wasn't one. Malachi 1:10 says that God looked for 'even one'. I would like to be such a person.

I understand that there is a fundamental difference between defense and offense. Consider Luke 10:19: "Take note, I am giving[b] you the authority to trample on snakes and scorpions,[c]

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[a] To my surprise the verb here is φιλεω, not αγαπαω—the Father is emotionally attached to the Son. Well, since we have emotions God must have had them first. God affirms that He has soul (Isaiah 42:1, Matthew 12:18, Hebrews 10:38).

[b] Instead of 'am giving', perhaps 2.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have 'have given' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.)—a serious error. Jesus said this perhaps five months before His death and resurrection, addressing the seventy (not just the twelve). The Lord is talking about the future, not the past; a future that includes us!

[c] The Lord gives us the authority to "trample snakes and scorpions". Well now, to smash the literal insect, a scorpion, you don't need power from on High, just a slipper (if you're fast you can do it bare-

and over all the power of the enemy,[a] and nothing at all may harm you." In Matthew 28:18 Sovereign Jesus affirms that He holds "all authority in heaven and on earth", so He is clearly competent to delegate some of that authority to us. "Nothing at all may harm you" clearly refers to self-defense. So, I understand that we already have God's authorization to use His power in self-defense. However, exactly how does "authority over all the power of the enemy" work in practice? We should use our authority to forbid the use of Satan's power, with reference to specific situations—in my experience, we must be specific.

Returning to offensive procedures, I confess that in my exposition of texts such as Psalm 149:5-9, 2 Corinthians 10:3-6 and 1 John 3:8, at least until now, I have left aside the need

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foot). To trample a snake I prefer a boot, but we can kill literal snakes without supernatural help. It becomes obvious that Jesus was referring to something other than reptiles and insects. I understand Mark 16:18 to be referring to the same reality. For a more detailed discussion, please see my article, "Are we to handle snakes?"

[a] In the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. The Text tells us that this sword is "the ρημα of God"—ρημα, not λογος. It is God's Word spoken, or applied. Really, what good is a sword left in its sheath? However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.

In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1, 18:36, 2 Kings 1:10). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:19). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak! But we need to consult the Father first.

to consult the Father first, to know what He is doing. An omission that I intend to correct from now on.

P.S.: what I am proposing is a 'heavy-weight fight'; there will certainly be counter-attacks. So, whoever is going to participate needs to protect himself beforehand: protect himself, his family and his interests. A woman should only participate under the spiritual protection of her husband (1 Corinthians 11:10), and an unmarried daughter under that of her father (Numbers 30:3-8).

49) Hunger and thirst for righteousness

Matthew 5:6

The semantic area of the word 'righteousness' occurs hundreds of times in the Bible, in both Testaments. To begin with, we must distinguish 'righteousness' from 'holiness'. Holiness has to do with the absence of sin, and only the Triune God is perfectly holy in His essence. Righteousness (or 'wholeness of character') has to do with appropriate behavior within a certain standard of conduct. Now then, since a standard of conduct devised by men is often different from the standard of conduct promulgated by the Sovereign Creator, I have used 'moral rectitude'. Certainly Jesus was thinking of God's standard; He was referring to acting with moral rightness before God.

But why did Jesus cite both hunger and thirst? Whoever is hungry will look for some-thing to eat; those who are thirsty will look for something to drink. And what happens if someone is both hungry and thirsty? It seems to me that the person's situation becomes urgent; he will search with determination until he finds something. What is at stake is the relationship between the person and God. And since the Father seeks those who worship Him in spirit and in truth (John 4:23), He will go to meet such people.

Consider 2 Chronicles 16:9—"The eyes of Jehovah run to and fro throughout the whole earth to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him." God is looking for whom He can bless. Consider also Jeremiah 29:13—"You will seek me and find me when you search for me with all your heart." It is a promise; but it depends on us. It is the consequence of the 'great' commandment: "You must love Jehovah your God with your whole heart, and with your whole soul, and with your whole mind" (Matthew 22:37, Deuteronomy 6:5). Then, with all certainty, God will satisfy the person who dedicates himself to moral righteousness with determination.

50) Jeremiah?

Matthew 27:9-10

In the NKJV, Matthew 27:9-10 reads like this: "Then was fulfilled what was spoken by Jeremiah the prophet, saying, *And they took the thirty pieces of silver, the value of Him who was priced*, whom they of the children of Israel priced, *and gave them for the potter's field, as the LORD directed me*." The difficulty comes when we try to find this material in our canonical Jeremiah. Cross-references send us to Jeremiah 32:6-9, or 18:1-4, or 19:1-3, but upon inspection they just do not match. In Zechariah 11:12-13 we find a general approximation, but it is not precise—and of course Zechariah is not Jeremiah. Evidently there are Hebrew manuscripts that begin the scroll containing the prophets (major and minor) with Jeremiah, and it has been argued that Matthew used 'Jeremiah' to refer to the contents of the entire scroll.

I suppose that could be a possibility, but I prefer to appeal to Daniel 9:2. "In the first year of his reign [Darius] I, Daniel, understood by the books the number of the years *specified* by the word of the LORD through Jeremiah the prophet…" Note that 'books' is plural. Why should any of us assume that men like Jeremiah, or Isaiah, wrote only what is in our canon?

(I myself have written a great deal that has never been published.) Daniel clearly wrote 'books', presumably referring to Jeremiah. I conclude that such extra-canonical books were still known in Matthew's day, and that he refers to one of them. I am aware that the distinction cannot be insisted upon, but Matthew did use 'spoken' rather than 'written'.

51) Jesus in the OT

Since the name 'Jesus' does not occur in the OT, the question must be elucidated using references in the NT. I will base my discussion on eight references. What is the importance of this study? As you may be aware, the so-called Jehovah's Witnesses and the Mormons, among others, deny that Jesus is the Jehovah of the OT. They do this because they also deny the Trinity, and for them Jesus is not eternal God.

1) John 12:41—"Isaiah said these things when[a] he saw His glory and spoke concerning Him." Wait just a minute! Whom did Isaiah see? From verses 36 and 37 it is clear that John was speaking of Jesus; so when did Isaiah see Jesus? In verse 40 John quotes Isaiah 6:10. The quoted words were spoken by Jehovah, verse 8, the One who sat on the throne, verse 1. In verse 5 Isaiah says of Him, "My eyes have seen the King, the LORD of hosts." So then, John declares that the One seated on the throne was Jehovah the Son,[b] Jesus!

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[a] Less than 2% of the Greek manuscripts, of inferior quality, have 'because' instead of 'when' (as in most modern versions). The difference in meaning is significant.

[b] If the phrase 'Jehovah the Son' is new to any reader/hearer, I explain it as follows: God is one Essence subsisting in three Persons. If the Name, Jehovah, represents the aggregate, the Trinity, then there are Jehovah the Father, Jehovah the Son, and Jehovah the Holy Spirit. I think that the academic world generally rejects 'Jehovah' as a representation of the Name. However, a writer in Egypt in the first century A.D. (I forget the name) said that the Name was pronounced with four vowels, but he didn't say what they were. However, when

Here is Isaiah 6:1-3, 5, 8-10 (NKJV): “In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lifted up, and the train of His *robe* filled the temple. Above it stood seraphim; each one had six wings: with two he covered his face, with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. And one cried to another and said: ‘Holy, holy, holy is the LORD [Jehovah] of hosts; the whole earth is full of His glory!’ . . . . So I said: ‘Woe is me, for I am undone! Because I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, the LORD of hosts.’ . . . . And I heard the voice of the Lord, saying: ‘Whom shall I send, and who will go for Us?’ Then I said, ‘Here am I! Send me.’ And He said, ‘Go, and tell this people: “Keep on hearing, but do not understand; keep on seeing, but do not perceive.” Make the heart of this people dull, and their ears heavy, and shut their eyes; lest they see with their eyes, and hear with their ears, and understand with their heart, and return and be healed.’”

2) John 8:56—“Your father Abraham was overjoyed to see my day; yes, he saw it and rejoiced.” Jesus was conversing with the Pharisees. What ‘day’ was that? I suppose He was referring to the time when He, Jehovah the Son, paid a visit to Abraham, accompanied by two angels (Genesis 18:1-33).[a]

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the first half of the Name is used as a prefix in a proper name, like Jehoshaphat, the first two vowels are always 'e' and 'o'. When the second half of the Name is used as a suffix in a proper name, such as Netanyahu, the last two vowels are always 'a' and 'u'. So, written out in full, the Name would be Yehovahu. By suppressing the last vowel, and 'Anglicizing' the rest, we have 'Jehovah'. Should anyone ask why the Name, Jehovah, does not appear in the NT, it is because from the first verses of the four Gospels the Son was already in the body of Jesus. Now His name is 'the Lord Jesus Christ’.

[a] If Melchizedek was indeed a theophany, being Jehovah the Son, he could be a candidate, but I don't see how to know for sure whether or not he was a theophany. Even so, I think the visit to Abraham wins.

From the Record it is clear that Abraham knew very well that he was talking to Jehovah, and in verse 25 he calls Him "the Judge of all the earth". That brings us to John 5:22, where Jesus declared—“In fact the Father does not judge anyone but has committed all judging to the Son.”[a] So then, at that time Jesus was exercising His office as judge, decreeing judgment against Sodom. Don’t you know that was the high point in Abraham's life! Note that Jesus Himself declares that He was with Abraham.

3) Hebrews 4:8—"Because if Jesus had given them rest, He would not have spoken afterward of another day." Beginning in chapter three, the author has been commenting on Psalm 95:6-11. Without any doubt, the Greek Text reads 'Jesus', but most versions put 'Joshua'. I suppose the translators judged 'Jesus' to be an anachronism, preferring 'Joshua'. In fact, the Septuagint as we know it (based on inferior Alexandrian manuscripts from centuries after Christ) always writes 'Joshua' as Ιησους (Jesus). (As a linguist, PhD, I cannot understand how translators could transliterate '*Yehoshua*', Joshua’s name in Hebrew, as '*Iesus*'—something strange happened.) Perhaps as a consequence, in Acts 7:45 Luke refers to Joshua as '*Iesus*'. It was not his purpose to correct the LXX at that time, for Stephen was speaking Hebrew. Normally, going from one language to another, proper names are transliterated, and once a certain transliteration reaches the status of a 'norm', there would usually be no reason to change it, since the meaning does not change.

However, looking at the context in Psalm 95:6-11, Joshua does not fit. Here it is (NKJV): “Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD our Maker. For He is our God, and we are the people of His pasture, and the sheep

[a] I take this to mean that the Son will be seated on the 'great white throne' (Revelation 20:11).

of His hand. Today, if you will hear His voice: 'Do not harden your hearts, as in the rebellion, as in the day of trial in the wilderness, when your fathers tested Me; they tried me, though they saw My work. For forty years I was grieved with that generation, and said, "It is a people who go astray in their hearts and they do not know My ways." So I swore in My wrath, "They shall not enter My rest".'"

It is presumably Jehovah the Son who was speaking ("Jehovah our Maker", verse 6; "I swore in My wrath", verse 11), and since the reference is to those who fell in the wilderness during the forty years, Joshua is out of the question. Furthermore, I invite attention to Joshua 21:43-45 and 23:1, where the Text states that Joshua did indeed give them rest. Putting 'Joshua' in Hebrews has the effect of making Hebrews contradict Joshua (the books), a procedure to which the Holy Spirit will not take kindly. It was precisely Jesus, Jehovah the Son, who did not allow that generation to enter into 'rest'.

4) 1 Corinthians 10:1-4—"Now I do not want you to be ignorant, brothers, that our fathers were all under the cloud and all passed through the sea 2—all were baptized into Moses by the cloud and by the sea—3 and all ate the same spiritual food 4 and drank the same spiritual drink; because they kept drinking from a spiritual rock that accompanied them, and that Rock was the Christ." Christ was with Israel in the desert.

I would say that each time Jehovah appeared in the OT it was Jehovah the Son, who became the Christ at His incarnation. He was sometimes called 'the Angel of Jehovah'; in several contexts the 'Angel' is stated to be Jehovah Himself. But in what sense were they "drinking from a spiritual Rock that accompanied them"? The physical rock (which Moses struck) did not move, presumably, but the "spiritual rock" did. Actually, what kept moving was the pillar of cloud and fire,

which represented the presence of Jehovah the Son with them.

5) Hebrews 11:24-26—"By faith Moses, when he had grown up, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter,[a] 25 choosing rather to be maltreated along with God's people than to have the temporary pleasure of sin, 26 considering the reproach for the Christ to be greater riches than the treasures of Egypt; because he was looking ahead to the reward."

This statement intrigues me. What did Moses know about the Christ (when he left Egypt), and from whom did he learn it? And how did he know about the reward? Well, I think it quite possible that he made a point of finding out who his parents were, and talked at length with them about their history. In any case, this text also places Christ in the OT.

6) Philippians 2:8-11—"And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself, becoming obedient to the point of death[b]—even death on a cross! 9 Indeed, that is why God highly exalted Him and gave Him the name that is above every name, 10 so that at the name of **Jesus** every knee will bow—of those in heaven,[c] those on earth[d] and those under the

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[a] This may explain Exodus 2:15. If Moses had rejected a proposal from Pharaoh, based on his adoption, then Pharaoh would be angry and would gladly be given a pretext to kill Moses.

[b] Hebrews 5:8 says that Jehovah the Son "learned obedience by the things he suffered." He had never been through anything like this before. So what will happen to us if we have the same way of thinking?

[c] This presumably includes the angels, whether or not they have literal 'knees'.

[d] It will be those who are actually alive on the earth at the time the decree is imposed; I suppose it will be during the millennial Messianic Kingdom.

earth[a]—11 and every tongue will acknowledge[b] that Jesus Christ is Sovereign, to the glory of God the Father."

This brings us back to Isaiah 45:23, where Jehovah the Son was speaking—"I have sworn by Myself; the word has gone out of My mouth in righteousness, and shall not return, that to Me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall take an oath." Paul, inspired by the Holy Spirit, applied the text directly to Jesus.

Please note that it is at the name of Jesus, not Christ or even Jehovah, that every knee will bow. 'Jesus' is his name as a human being—recall that in Revelation (5:6, 12; 7:14; 12:11) the slain Lamb receives glory and praise along with the Father. It is not possible to kill God, so the Lamb is Jesus. Although at the moment I see no way to 'close the question' (as we say here in Brazil), I verily suspect that the correct transliteration of 'Jesus' into Hebrew will turn out to be יֵסוּס (Yesus) and not יֵשׁוּעַ (Yeshua). [I wonder who invented the idea that 'Yeshua' could be Jesus' name in Hebrew.]

7) Colossians 1:16—"Because by Him all things were created—those in the heavens and those on the earth, things visible and things invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities[c]—all things have been created through

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[a] Since Hades is inside the earth (Matthew 12:40, Ephesians 4:9, 1 Samuel 28:13), this will presumably include the wicked dead, as well as the demons in the Abyss (at least). Just suppose that God decided to confine evil to this planet; the logical place for a 'prison' would be beneath its crust.

[b] The verbs 'bow' and 'acknowledge' are in the subjunctive mood in the Text, so many versions render 'should bow' rather than 'will bow'. However, the mood of the verbs is governed by the conjunction *hina*, that normally takes the subjunctive; but in the context the author evidently does not intend to leave any doubt about the extent of the recognition – it will be every knee and every tongue.

[c] "Those in the heavens" would include angelic beings, including high-ranking ones—all owe their existence to the Son.

Him and for Him".[a] Although the entire Trinity participated in the creation, this verse clearly says that the Son was the primary agent (see also Hebrews 1:10 and John 1:10). This brings us back to Isaiah 45:12, where Jehovah the Son was speaking—"I have made the earth, and created man on it. I—My hands—stretched out the heavens." So then, not only was Jesus in the OT, He created the world in which the OT took place.

8) 1 Peter 1:17-20 – "Also, since you invoke as Father[b] the One who without partiality judges according to each one's work, conduct yourselves during the time of your sojourn here **in fear**,[c] 18 knowing that it was not with perishable things (silver or gold) that you were redeemed from the futile way of life handed down by your forefathers,[d] 19 but with the precious blood of Christ, as of a faultless and pure lamb; 20 who was foreknown indeed before the foundation of the world, but was revealed in these last times for your sake."

Revelation 13:8 goes in the same direction. The Text states that the Lamb, with blood already shed, was so known before the creation of our race and planet. Now then, you cannot have blood without a body, and the body was the body of Jesus. So, Jesus was there even before the OT!

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[a] Most of the inhabitants of planet Earth do not understand that God created them for Himself, so they live out their existence here without knowing why they are here. That is why Sovereign Jesus commanded that the Gospel should be proclaimed to everyone.

[b] To "invoke as Father" is to place yourself under His authority and protection; but also of His evaluation!

[c] "In fear" is emphasized in the Text. We tend to forget just who and what God is, and so we get complacent, which is <u>not</u> a good idea, according to Peter.

[d] All ways of life that are not biblical are futile. We should not be apologetic about challenging people's belief systems or presuppositions, provided we are in a position to present the biblical worldview.

Now let us stop and think for a moment: the Text makes it clear that the Creator knew, before creating, what was going to happen and the terrible price of redemption that He Himself would have to pay, yet He went ahead anyway! If I am not mistaken, the very creation of our race was due to the Son's desire for a Bride. That He agreed to pay the terrible price allows us to glimpse the importance He places on her.

Conclusion: To an eternal Being time is irrelevant (time and space may be limited to our solar system) so God knew the history of our world before it happened. Hebrews 13:8: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever." God's character does not change; the God of the OT is the same as the God of the NT. The way He administers the human race may change, from time to time, but His nature, His moral character does not change.

52) 'Jesus', or 'Joshua'?

Hebrews 4:8

Beyond question, the Greek Text has 'Jesus', as in the AV, but most modern versions put 'Joshua'. I suppose that 'Jesus' was judged to be an anachronism, and so 'Joshua' was elected to relieve the situation. To be sure, the Septuagint we know uniformly spells 'Joshua' as *Ιησους* (Jesus) [as a linguist I wonder why the translators transliterated '*Iehoshua*' as '*Iesus*'], and probably in consequence, in Acts 7:45 Luke refers to Joshua as '*Iesus*'. It was not his purpose to correct the LXX, and Stephen was speaking Hebrew. Normally, going from one language to another, proper names are transliterated, and once a certain transliteration reaches the status of a 'norm', there would usually be no reason to change it, since the meaning does not change.

However, looking carefully at the context in Psalm 95:7-11, Joshua just does not fit. Consider: it is presumably Jehovah the Son who is speaking ("Jehovah our Maker", verse

6), and since the reference is to those who fell in the wilderness during the forty years, Joshua cannot be in view. Not only that, I invite attention to Joshua 21:43-45 and 23:1, where the Text says that Joshua did in fact give them rest. So whom are you going to believe? Of course the Text is referring to physical rest, not spiritual, since neither Joshua nor anyone else could be responsible for a people's spiritual rest. Ezekiel chapter 18 is very clear to the effect that each individual is responsible for his own eternal destiny. God has no grandchildren, only sons and daughters. In Mathew 23:8-10 Sovereign Jesus forbids any attempt to dominate someone else's faith or conscience. This is consistent with His statement in John 4:23-24. The worship that the Father wants cannot be forced, imposed, controlled or faked.

In relief of the notion of 'anachronism' I offer the following: 1) in John 12:41 John affirms that Isaiah saw Jesus (it was Jehovah the Son on the throne); 2) in 1 Corinthians 10:4 Paul affirms that the Rock that provided water was Christ; 3) in Hebrews 11:26 the same author [as I believe] has Moses choosing "the reproach of Christ"; 4) in 1 Peter 1:19-20 Peter affirms that the shed blood of God's Lamb, Jesus, was foreknown before Creation—but blood requires a body, and the Lamb's body was that of Jesus; so Jesus, as Jesus, was known before Creation. Returning to Hebrews 4:8, it was precisely Jesus, Jehovah the Son, who did not allow that generation to enter the 'rest'.

53) John is not Elijah

'Substitutionism' predominates in Christian churches around the world, the idea that the Church has completely replaced Israel in all of God's future plans. It is theological anti-Semitism. But to maintain that idea, its advocates are obliged to disregard Romans chapters 9, 10, and 11, several

other NT texts, and much of the OT prophecies. Disregarding such a large portion of the Sacred Text can have somewhat unpleasant consequences, since the Author of the Text will not take kindly to such an attitude. Further, it should come as no surprise to anyone to find that those who approach the Text with this preconceived idea tend to do nasty things to any passage that is inconvenient for them—for example, Matthew 17:10-13.

> So His disciples questioned Him saying, "Why then do the scribes say that Elijah must come first?" **11**In answer Jesus said to them: "Elijah is indeed coming first, and he will restore all things. **12**But I say to you that 'Elijah' has come already, and they did not recognize him, but did to him whatever they wished. Thus also the Son of the Man is about to suffer at their hands." **13**Then the disciples understood that He spoke to them of John the Baptizer.[a]

It is common to hear such people discourse on verses 12 and 13, severely disregarding verse 11. But since any doctrine should take into account all relevant texts, we can start with the source of the discussion, Malachi 4:5-6.

> Behold, I will send you the prophet Elijah, before the coming of the great and dreadful day of Jehovah. And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers; lest I come and strike the earth with total destruction.[b]

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[a] At this point John is already dead, but in verse 11 the Lord declares that Elijah is still going to come—John performed the function for Christ's first advent that Elijah (literally) will perform for the second advent.

[b] The Hebrew word here means 'total destruction', not 'curse', as in many versions. And when will there be total destruction of the planet? It will be at the end of the Millennial Messianic Kingdom. On the other hand, destruction during the 'great tribulation' will come close; it will be terribly terrible!

In Matthew 16:28 Jesus spoke of seeing “the Son of the Man coming in His kingdom,” and in the understanding of the three disciples, the Kingdom of the Messiah was linked to ‘the day of Jehovah’. They understood that they had just seen a microcosm of the Kingdom, and they had seen Elijah, but they were descending the mountain back into a reality that hardly resembled the Kingdom. Hence the question, I suppose. But let us get back to the relevant texts.

The second is found in Luke 1:17–the angel Gabriel is announcing to Zechariah truths about the son he is going to have, John the Baptizer. This son would go before the Lord his God “in the spirit and power of Elijah”; and refers to Malachi 4:5-6. Faced with the old man's doubt, Gabriel declares that he was sent by God to deliver the message. Now then, would anyone have the courage to say that both the angel and God himself had the intention of deceiving the old man? If John would be Elijah himself, how could the angel say that John would act in Elijah's spirit and power, instead of being Elijah?

Now let us go to John 1:21—when priests and Levites from Jerusalem asked John if he was Elijah, he replied, “I am not.” Come now, would anyone have the courage to say that John lied? If he did not lie, then he was not Elijah. Could John be mistaken about his own person and his own office? Hardly: his father had been very clear, and after a long time in the wilderness with God, he began his public ministry. Luke 3:2 clarifies that “the word of God came upon John the son of Zechariah in the wilderness” (the Text says “upon John”, not ‘to John’; he was compelled by the Word). In John 1:23 the Baptizer quotes Isaiah 40:3 as referring to himself. John neither lied nor made a mistake–he was not Elijah.

But what about Matthew 11:14—“if you are willing to receive it, he is Elijah who is to come”? Jesus was praising John the Baptizer with some sayings rather difficult to understand; for example in verse 11: “among those born of

women there has not arisen a greater than John the Baptizer; but he who is least in the kingdom of the heavens is greater than he".[a] Verse 12 has also given commentators trouble. In verse 14, when Jesus says, "if you are willing to receive it", it is because the matter is not transparent. Although John was still alive, he was in prison, from whence he would only emerge dead. How then could Jesus say that Elijah still had to come, if it was in fact Elijah who was in prison and would only come out dead? Now we go to Matthew 17:10-13 and Mark 9:11-13, which are parallel; only now John was in fact dead.

In verse 11 (Matthew 17) Jesus declares, "Elijah is indeed coming first, and he will restore all things." Since John was already dead, and Jesus puts the coming of Elijah in the future, then John was not Elijah. Further, John did not "restore all things"; in fact, he restored relatively little. In short: John filled the office, herald, for the first advent of Christ that Elijah himself (literally) will fill for the second advent. They are different people, with different moments.

54) John's Gospel: Jewish time or Roman time?

Recently a friend and correspondent wrote me that 90% of commentaries and 95% of Bible versions affirm that John's Gospel uses Jewish time, not Roman. Well now, as far back as I can remember, I have always supposed that John used Roman time. Although in spiritual matters the majority is generally wrong, 9 to 1 borders on the lopsided, so I decided

[a] Evidently, as forerunner of the Kingdom John was not part of it—the Kingdom was rejected at that time; both forerunner and King were killed—those who participate in the actual future Kingdom will be more privileged. "Born of women" excludes Adam. Men like Noah, Abraham, Moses, Daniel would be of equal standing, just not "greater". But those who live during the Messianic Kingdom (Millennium) will be more privileged than all except Adam, because the earth will return to conditions similar to Eden.

to go back and look again. As best I can tell, there are four places where John mentions a specific hour: 1:39, 4:6, 4:52 and 19:14. I will consider them in that order.

> John 1:—**35**Again the next day John was standing with two of his disciples. **36**And seeing Jesus walking by, he says, "Look, the Lamb of God!" **37**The two disciples heard him speak, and they followed Jesus. **38**So turning and observing them following[a] Jesus says to them, "What do you want?" So they said to Him, "Rabbi" (which translated means 'Teacher'), "where are You staying?" **39**He says to them, "Come and see". So they went and saw where He was staying, and stayed with Him that day—**it was about the tenth hour**.

Note the "and stayed with Him that day". If John were using Jewish time, this would be 4:00 p.m. But in Jewish time there would only be two more hours in the day, since the new day would begin at 6:00 p.m. It would border on the dishonest for John to use "and stayed with Him that day" with reference to only two hours. John uses Roman time, so this is 10 a.m., which means that Jesus spent most of the day with just those two men. You had better believe they were talking the whole time. Jesus knew they would be two of His disciples and was already investing in them—to such good effect that the next day they brought in two more.

> John 4:—**1**Now when Jesus[b] knew that the Pharisees had heard, "Jesus is making and baptizing more disciples than John" **2**(although Jesus Himself was not baptizing, but His

[a] Presumably Jesus waited for them to catch up, so He was observing them during that time. His purpose in passing by there was precisely to attract those two men (so I imagine), and He was doubtless aware when they started out after Him.

[b] I follow the best line of transmission in reading "Jesus", rather than 'the Lord', albeit with only 21.7% of the Greek manuscripts.

disciples), **3**He left Judea and went away into Galilee.[a] **4**Now He needed to go through Samaria;[b] **5**so He comes to a city of Samaria called Sychar, near the plot of land that Jacob gave to his son Joseph.[c] **6**Now Jacob's well was there; so Jesus, being worn out from the journey, sat as He was by the well. **It was about 6 p.m.**

The Text has "the sixth hour". Many versions put "noon", which reflects Jewish time. But the Text says Jesus was worn out, which agrees better with a full day's walk than with a half day's walk (remember that they did all their travelling on foot, and so were used to it). The distance between Salem and Sychar was probably about 35 miles, as the crow flies, but since the whole distance was over accidented terrain, the walking distance would be a good deal more. They had walked some 50 miles in twelve hours. Like the Text says, He was tired! And He was hot and thirsty. John emphasizes that as a human being He felt the full effects of the day. But where did I get Salem?

John 3:—**22**After these things Jesus, with His disciples, went into the Judean countryside, and there He spent time with them and baptized. **23**Now John also was baptizing in Aenon, near Salem, because there was plenty of water there. And *people* were coming and being baptized; **24**for John had not yet been thrown into prison.

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[a] This was a tactical withdrawal. I take it that Matthew 4:12 refers to the same withdrawal. Between John 3:36 and 4:1 the Baptizer was imprisoned. If the Pharisees knew something it would not be long before Herod knew it. It was not part of the Plan for Jesus to have to deal with Herod at this juncture.

[b] He could have gone up the coast and avoided most of the mountains, but He "needed" to go through Samaria. Probably because the Father told Him to—it was harvest-time in Sychar.

[c] See Joshua 24:32.

To this day there is “plenty of water” in the Aijalon valley, some 15-20 miles WNW of Jerusalem (Salem is an ancient name for Jerusalem; see Genesis 14:18 and Hebrews 7:1)—perhaps that is where it was. I take it that Jesus and John were in the same area, at this point (“John also was baptizing in Aenon”). Even from the nearest point in Judea to Sychar, it is unlikely that they could have walked the distance in six hours.

> John 4:—**46**So Jesus went again to Cana of Galilee,[a] where He made the water wine. Now there was a certain royal official whose son was sick in Capernaum. **47**When this man heard that Jesus had come out of Judea into Galilee, he went to Him and implored Him to come down and heal his son,[b] for he was about to die. **48**So Jesus said to him, “Unless you people see signs and wonders you will not believe!” **49**The official says to Him, “Sir, come down before my child dies!” **50**Jesus says to him, “Go; your son lives”. Well the man believed the word that Jesus spoke to him and off he went. **51**Now while he was still going down his slaves met him and reported saying, “Your son lives!” **52**So he inquired of them the hour in which he got better. And they said to him, “Yesterday **at the seventh hour** the fever left him”. **53**So the father knew that it was at the exact hour in which Jesus told him, “Your son lives”. Both he himself and his whole household believed.

It is virtually certain that the official and his slaves used Roman time, in which case the cure took place at 7 p.m. It could not be 7 a.m. because the man would have met his slaves before noon and they would have said ‘today’, not ‘yesterday’ (verse 52). It could not be Jewish time for a similar

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[a] I suspect that He had a brother-in-law living there.

[b] The man was asking Jesus to make an emergency hike of some 25 miles (unless he was mounted and had brought an extra horse for Jesus; but He probably was not used to riding). Evidently he figured that the healer had to be physically present.

reason—if Jesus healed at 1 p.m., the man would have met his slaves before sundown and they would have said 'today' (an official may well have been mounted, and it would not take him long—he was in a hurry). The man probably walked (unless he was mounted, but at night the horse would be held to a walk) during at least part of the night; the slaves would have started out at dawn; they probably met at a point much closer to Capernaum than to Cana.

> John 19:—**12**From that moment Pilate really tried to release Him; but the Jews kept shouting, saying: "If you release this fellow, you are no friend of Caesar's! Whoever makes himself a king is opposing Caesar!"[a] **13**Well, upon hearing this statement Pilate led Jesus outside and sat down on the judgment seat, in a place called 'Stone Pavement', while in Hebrew '*Gabatha*'[b] **14**(now it was the day of preparation for the Passover;[c] **the hour was about six a.m.**), and he says to the Jews, "Look at your king!"

The Text says "the sixth hour", which in Roman time is six a.m. If it were Jewish time, it would be noon, which won't work here. Actually it says 'around' or 'about' six—I assume that it was a little after the hour. But why do I say that 'noon' won't work? Any honest interpreter of Scripture has the obligation to consider all relevant passages, which in this case include Matthew 27:45, Mark 15:25 and 33, and Luke 23:44. Mark specifies that Jesus was crucified at the 3rd hour and all

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[a] Oops! Pilate owed his position to Caesar's good graces, and simply could not afford to do something that could be construed (even with a little twisting) as treason. He is beaten and knows it.

[b] This action signaled that he had reached a decision and was about to give the verdict.

[c] If the Jews were still preparing for the Passover, then Jesus and His disciples observed it a day early—which must have seemed strange to the disciples. But as the ultimate Passover Lamb, it would be appropriate for Jesus to die on that preparation day.

three mention the supernatural darkness from the 6th to the 9th. It is clear that all three use Jewish time: the darkness could not have been from 6:00 to 9:00 a.m., nor from 6:00 to 9:00 p.m. (using Roman time). Therefore the supernatural darkness occurred between 12:00 noon and 3:00 p.m. Since Mark uses Jewish time, his 3rd hour has to be 9:00 a.m. (it obviously could not be 9:00 p.m.). To argue that John used Jewish time here makes him out to be ridiculous; how could Pilate pass sentence three hours after the crucifixion?! Please remember that John was physically present, an eyewitness of the proceedings, which cannot be said of any of the commentators or translators (or of any of the non-biblical sources that they may cite).

To conclude, the evidence is surely adequate: John used Roman time.[a] To ascribe errors of fact and stupidities to the Apostle John, by alleging that he used Jewish time, is to be perverse.

55) Judgment begins at the house of God

Let me begin by explaining why I am writing such an article as this. I am looking for a way (if it is still possible) to stop, and even turn back, the satanic steamroller that is destroying the culture and taking over all aspects of life in the country where I live, Brazil. (Of course, the same is true of other countries as well.) The only possible 'medicine' is the love of the truth (2 Thessalonians 2:10, see below), so the bottom line is this: what can we do to promote the love of the truth? Lamentably, the vast majority of the churches are part of the problem, rather than being part of the solution. I venture to say that less than 1% of the churches want a Bible

[a] I fail to see any reasonable basis for an honest student of Scripture to arrive at the conclusion that John used Jewish time. So where did the 90% of commentaries and 95% of Bible versions get that idea? In spiritual matters there is no neutrality (Matthew 12:30, Luke 11:23).

with objective authority.[a] The culture outside the church is totally dominated by relativistic humanism, and most church members have been heavily influenced by that worldview. On the way to promoting the love of the truth, we must defend the objective authority of the biblical Text,[b] and the place to begin is with the churches.[c] **To promote truth necessarily involves exposing lies**.

Any surgeon knows that for certain pathological conditions the only alternative to a premature physical death is radical surgery. The patient will not like the news, but if the surgery is successful, he will end up thanking the surgeon. Similarly, a brother probably will not appreciate being told that he has embraced a lie, but if he will stop and think, and change, he will end up thanking us. In desperate times 'business as usual' is not enough; it is necessary to take risks.[d]

Now consider 1 Peter 4:17—"Because the time has come for judgment to begin at God's house; now if it starts with us, what will be the end of those who keep disobeying the Gospel of God?" Although the 'publishing' of this letter is often stated to have been around 60 AD, or even later, I suspect it may have been at least ten years earlier. In any case, although the nation of Israel will yet return to center stage, beginning with the day of Pentecost Sovereign Jesus has been interacting

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[a] In consequence, they are lacking in spiritual power and spiritual discernment.

[b] It is the biblical Text that defines and teaches the Truth, and in order to arrive at the Truth we must understand that the Text has objective authority. Relativistic humanism is inimical to objective authority, and any attempt to relativize the authority of Scripture only serves the enemy.

[c] Our only hope of correcting the national culture depends upon first correcting the churches.

[d] In order to try to save the 'patient', I must take the risk of being rejected and hated. On the other hand, Ezekiel 3:20-21 explains an even more serious risk.

with the world using mainly His body, the Church. Since Peter is writing to Christians, he is referring to them as "God's house". It is possible to translate the verse above as 'from God's house', that house being the point of departure. It seems clear that God's judgment does not stop with us; it goes on to the world.

God has always judged His people

Once the blood of God's Lamb had been shed, thus paying for the sin of the world, the judgment against those "who keep disobeying the Gospel of God" became more direct. But since judgment starts with God's house, the demands upon those claiming to belong to Christ also became more direct. The fate of Ananias and Sapphira is an emphatic case in point.[a] What I wish to emphasize is that God's judging His house began at the beginning, it began on the day of Pentecost, with reference to the Church. When we cry out to God to judge the world, the judging of God's house as a prior condition is not a factor[b]—God has been judging His house right along.[c] However, I would say that judging is one thing, but correcting is another. The correcting of the culture begins with, and depends on, the correcting of the churches.

Consider what happened to the apostle Paul. The Holy Spirit had told him repeatedly **NOT** to go to Jerusalem, but he went anyway. When he got there, he kowtowed to big boss James, who was well on his way back into Judaism. Do you remember his pitch to Paul? "You see, brother, how many tens of thousands are the Jews who have believed, and they

[a] They were not given any warning, nor any chance to repent or explain.

[b] For many years I had the idea that it was a prior condition that had not yet been fulfilled—don't ask me where I got it!

[c] Of course this has always been true. The OT is full of God's judgment upon His people, Israel. Adam was judged; Moses was judged. God has always required an accounting based on the benefits and blessings one receives.

are all zealous for the law; but they have been informed about you that you teach all the Jews who are among the Gentiles to forsake Moses, telling them not to circumcise their children nor to walk according to our customs" (Acts 21:20-21).[a] If his "many tens of thousands" was not a blatant exaggeration, as I suspect, then the whole church in that area was in a bad way (which it probably was anyway). Was Paul judged? He spent the next five years, at least, in chains.[b]

Was James judged? He was killed, not long after. Was the church in Jerusalem judged? The city was destroyed in 70 AD, and the Jerusalem church ceased to exist. The city was little more than a ruin for centuries.[c] And now consider 1 Corinthians 11:29-30: "He who eats and drinks unworthily eats and drinks judgment to himself, not distinguishing the Lord's body. Because of this many among you are weak and sick, and a good many have died." Paul declares that God had already visited sickness on many, and death on even more. God was judging His people. A variety of further texts could be mentioned, but Hebrews will do. Please read 2:1-3, 3:12 - 4:13, 6:3-8, 10:26-31, and 12:28-29. "It is a dreadful thing to fall into the hands of the Living God", "because our God is indeed a consuming fire!"

And then there are the seven letters that the glorified Jesus sent to the seven churches. Each letter ends with a promise to "the one who overcomes"; so what happens to you if you don't? Although He had some good things to say about the church in Ephesus, He said He would remove their 'lamp-stand' if they did not return to their first love. Indeed, in due time all seven of those churches lost their lampstand.

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[a] "The law", "Moses", "our customs" = Judaism.

[b] Try living in chains for just twenty-four hours, and see how you like it!

[c] References during the early centuries to especially good NT manuscripts in Jerusalem are probably just pious hogwash. The center of gravity of the Church had moved north.

Two of the letters refer to the doctrine and works of the Nicolaitans, that Sovereign Jesus says He hates. The etymology of the term suggests the beginning of the distinction between clergy and laity. It may have begun with James in Jerusalem.[a] Before the end of the first century, a certain Clement was the bishop of Rome. The term 'bishop' came to be used of a presbyter who had authority over the other presbyters in his area, the boss presbyter.[b]

Attempting to control someone else's spiritual life is forbidden

But the concept of special spiritual authority being vested in a 'bishop' soon ran afoul of Sovereign Jesus' words in Matthew 23:8-12 and John 4:23-24. First Matthew:

> "But you (pl.), do not be called 'Rabbi'; because your Teacher is one, the Christ,[c] and you are all brothers. **9**And do not call anyone on earth your 'father'; because your Father is one, He who is in the heavens. **10**Neither be called leaders /guides; because your Leader is one, the Christ. **11**On the contrary, the greatest among you must be your servant. **12**And whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted."

In verse 9, since the second person here is plural, the Lord is evidently referring to calling someone your spiritual father;

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[a] The Jews were accustomed to a high priest, a single individual at the top of the religious pyramid. Evidently that attitude invaded the churches.

[b] In the writings of the 'church fathers' that have come down to us, there appears to be no mention of 'apostles' after the first century. This means that there was no 'apostolic succession'; the more so since apostles are designated by God, not ordained by men. Since the second century there has only been 'discipolic' succession. Any claims in our day based on apostolic succession are spurious (as were any such claims after the first century).

[c] Perhaps 4% of the Greek manuscripts omit "the Christ" (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.).

He is not saying not to acknowledge your physical father. "Your (pl.) Father is one"—obviously they did not all have the same physical father. Verse 10 may be why we have no record in Scripture of a Christian calling someone his disciple; even in 1 Corinthians 3:4 Paul evidently avoids using the term. **I take it that our Lord is forbidding any effort by one Christian to control the spiritual life of another**. We may point the way, we may encourage, we may discipline when occasion warrants, but the rest is up to the Holy Spirit.[a] The Lord had already told the Samaritan woman that the Father must be worshipped "in spirit and truth" (John 4:23-24).

> "The time is coming, in fact now is, when the genuine worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth. Really, because the Father is looking for **such** people to worship Him. **24**God is Spirit,[b] and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truth."

The Father "is looking" for those who will worship Him in spirit and truth.[c] It may be that we have here a window on the reason why God created a race such as ours—persons in His image with the capacity to **choose**. God "is looking" for something, which means He does not have it, at least not automatically, nor in sufficient quantity. I take it that He wants to be appreciated for who He is, but to have meaning such appreciation cannot come from robots—it has to be voluntary. So He created a type of being with that capacity, but He had to take the risk that such a being would choose not to

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[a] It is normal, indeed inescapable, that a new Christian will receive his first ideas about spiritual things from the older Christians around him. But as he grows and matures, he should learn to depend directly upon Scripture and the Holy Spirit.

[b] Again the lack of the definite article presents us with an ambiguity; the rendering 'a spirit' is possible. But as I indicate by the underlining, I understand that the quality inherent in the noun is being emphasized, which is another use of an absent article (in Greek).

[c] See also 2 Chronicles 16:9, that tells you how to have God's help.

appreciate Him. Unfortunately, most human beings make the negative choice, and with that negative choice come all sorts of negative consequences. Ever since Adam human beings are born with an inclination toward sin,[a] so for someone to choose to appreciate God is definitely not automatic, nor even easy. No one can reasonably accuse God of having 'stacked the deck' in His own favor, of 'buying votes'—He seems to have done just the opposite. If a human being, against his natural inclination, chooses to appreciate God, then God receives what He is looking for.

"In spirit and truth" presumably means that it cannot be faked, cannot be forced or imposed, cannot be merely physical, cannot be merely emotional (though both body and emotions can, and often will, be utilized). The concept of 'bishop' (and in our day even of lowly pastors) as someone having the authority to control the spiritual life of others is an open rebellion against Sovereign Jesus, who forbids any such attitude or proceeding.[b] But rebellion against God is Satan's 'thing', and will certainly call down God's judgment (see the discussion of 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12 below).

Someone who wishes to control the spiritual life of others must develop a doctrinal 'package'; he must define what they may and may not believe, and/or do. But of course that gave rise to competing 'packages', and competition between 'bishops', to the point that they were mutually excommunicating each other, and so on. That gave rise to different 'churches', and in our day to different

[a] Babies have to be self-centered in order to survive, but self-centeredness is the essence of sin, which, however, is not charged to the account until the person can understand what he is doing. At that point, the person needs to receive adequate instruction, to escape from that self-centeredness (Proverbs 22:6).

[b] A typical proceeding is to dictate who may, or may not, participate in the 'Lord's Supper', as though the 'table' belongs to the leaders of the congregation, rather than to the Lord—after all, it is the 'Lord's Table'.

'denominations'. This mentality guarantees the perpetuation of the falsehoods that have been incorporated into the denominational 'packages'. In some cases, they reached the point of declaring that only those who were within their ranks could be saved. Anyone who embraces a 'package' elevates that package above God's inspired Word, and that is idolatry. Such idolatry offends the Holy Spirit, who has a special interest in that Word; such idolaters no longer listen to the Holy Spirit (if they ever did). Such idolaters condemn their 'package' to become an 'old wineskin', devoid of spiritual power.

I would say that the only way to avoid becoming an 'old wineskin' is to be constantly listening to the Holy Spirit and obeying what He says. Unfortunately, few Christians are in the habit of consulting the Holy Spirit, and those who do are marked for persecution. No Establishment can tolerate anyone who listens to the Holy Spirit. Surely, or have you forgotten John 3:8? "The wind blows where it wishes, and you (sg) hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who has been begotten by the Spirit." Notice that the Lord is saying here that it is **we** who are to be unpredictable, like the wind, or the Spirit ("comes" and "goes" are in the present tense). If you are really under the control of the Spirit you will do unexpected things, just like He does, and that definitely will not please the 'bosses'.[a] (Since Satan is forever muddying the water with

[a] But what about Hebrews 13:17? "Obey your leaders and submit, for they keep watch over your souls, as those who must give account." In the first place, I would say that the reference is to administrative matters, so that things be done 'decently and in order'. But the minute a leader attempts to impose a falsehood, he should not be obeyed; he is no longer listening to the Holy Spirit. As Peter said to the council, "We must obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29). I treat 1 Peter 5:5 similarly. Some 4% of the Greek manuscripts, of inferior

excesses and abuses, spiritual discernment is needed, but lamentably such discernment appears to be a rare commodity in the churches.) An Establishment is defined by its 'straight-jacket' (or 'package'), and the Holy Spirit does not like straight-jackets, and vice versa.

The love of the Truth

During the middle-ages the Church all but died out, at least in the West. And why did the Church almost die out? It was because the Church became part of the problem, rather than being part of the solution. And how did it become part of the problem? It became part of the problem by rejecting the love of the truth (see the discussion of 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12 below). When the Church becomes part of the problem, the surrounding culture is condemned. Did you get that? **When the Church becomes part of the problem, the surrounding culture is condemned.** Surely, because salvation begins at the house of God.

Consider 1 Timothy 3:15—"so that you may know how it is necessary to conduct oneself in God's household, which is the Church of the living God, pillar and foundation of the truth." My first impression would be that the truth should be sustaining the Church, not vice versa. But it is the Church that has the responsibility to promote and defend the truth in the society at large—in education, health, commerce, government, everywhere. Salvation can come to an individual just by reading God's Word, all by himself, but to transform a whole culture requires the Church. Remember also what Jesus said to the Samaritan woman in John 4:22, "salvation is from the Jews". Quite so. The Lamb of God is a Jew, and the OT canon came through the Jewish people (for that matter, most of the NT was written by Jews as well). As Paul says in Romans 3:2,

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quality, omit "submitting to one another" (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.).

"they were entrusted with the oracles of God". The Oracles of God are His written revelation to the human race.

Then came the Protestant Reformation, but because of its emphasis on reason it was born deformed. It was not long before 'packages' developed within the Reformation, and in the nineteenth century it was besieged by three satanic sophistries (2 Corinthians 10:5): 1) Darwin's theory of evolution, 2) the so-called 'higher criticism' of the Bible, and then 3) the text-critical theory of Westcott and Hort.[a] These were followed by materialism, humanism, relativism, etc. A biblical Text with objective authority barely limped into the twentieth century, but then came the onslaught of liberal theology.[b]

To understand the full impact of the onslaught of liberal theology, one must take account of the milieu. Reason has always been important to the historic or traditional Protestant denominations. In consequence, academic respectability has always been important to their graduate schools of theology. The difficulty resides in the following circumstance: for at least two centuries academia has been dominated by Satan, and so the terms of 'respectability' are dictated by him. Those terms include 'publish or perish', but of course he controls the technical journals. Since he is the father of lies (John 8:44), anyone who wished to tell the whole truth has always had a

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[a] The W-H theory did away with any notion of a NT text with objective authority. My demonstration that that theory is a tissue of falsehoods was first published in 1977 (the book having gone through at least seven revisions since), and so far as I know, it has never been refuted. *The Identity of the New Testament Text* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson Inc., Publishers, 1977); *The Identity of the New Testament Text V* (self-published with Amazon.com, 2023).

[b] One response to liberal theology was the so-called Neo-orthodoxy; it holds that the Bible is made up of divine parts and human parts, so that the whole cannot be said to **be** God's Word. Since that view offers no way to know which parts are and which are not, it also does away with any notion of a NT text with objective authority.

hard time getting an article published, no matter how good it was. To get an article published one had to toe the party line. 'Taking account of the existing literature' obliges one to waste a great deal of time reading the nonsense produced by Satan's servants, all of which was designed to keep the reader away from the **truth**—the 'reader' in this case being the students who in their turn would become pastors and church leaders, seminary professors, etc.[a]

The TRUTH—aye, there's the rub. Consider 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12:

> That one's coming is according to the working of Satan with all power[b] and signs and lying wonders, 10 and with all wicked deception among those who are wasting themselves,[c] because they did not receive the love of the truth so that they might be saved. 11 Yes, because of this God will send them an active delusion so that they will believe the lie 12 and so that all may be condemned who have not believed the truth but have taken pleasure in wickedness.[d]

Although verse ten is in the context of the activity of the Antichrist, who will find an easy target in 'those who are

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[a] The systematic contamination of successive generations of future pastors inevitably resulted in the contamination of the congregations as well.

[b] When Satan fell he did not lose his power.

[c] The verb here, απωλλυμι, often rendered 'to perish' (John 3:16 in KJV), is used in a variety of contexts, but I take the core meaning to be 'waste'. The participial form here is ambiguous as to voice, either middle or passive, but the basic form of the verb is middle. Ephesians 1:5-14 makes clear that a basic objective of our redemption is that we be "to the praise of His glory", which was part of the original Plan (Isaiah 43:7). Only as we live for the glory of God can we realize or fulfill our potential, our reason for being. If you live for any other reason, you are wasting yourself.

[d] 'Taking pleasure in wickedness' involves rejecting the Truth of a moral Creator who will demand an accounting, or even overt rebellion against that Creator (like Lucifer/Satan).

wasting themselves' (my translation), it does not follow that no one will be wasting himself before that activity. Obviously, people have been wasting themselves all down through history, and the underlying cause for that 'wasting' has never changed—"they did not receive the love of the truth". (It began in the Garden.)

Consider Romans 1:18: "Now the wrath of God is revealed from Heaven upon all ungodliness and unrighteousness of the people who suppress the truth by unrighteousness." To 'suppress the truth' is a deliberate act, an evil choice that invites God's wrath. (Romans 1:24-25 and 2:8 give more detail.) To hear a sermon about 'the love of God' is easy enough, but how many have you heard (or preached) about 'the wrath of God'? 'God hates sin but loves the sinner' is standard fare, but consider Psalm 5:4-6.

> "For You are not a God who takes pleasure in wickedness, nor shall evil dwell with You. The boastful shall not stand in your sight; You **hate** all workers of iniquity. You shall destroy those who speak falsehood; the LORD abhors the blood-thirsty and deceitful man."

This is not an isolated text; there are a fair number of others in the same vein. Someone who deliberately chooses to be evil and to promote evil, having rejected the truth, thereby makes God his enemy, makes himself an object of His wrath.[a] God has been judging sin for six thousand years.

Consider also Luke 16:31 "He said to him, 'If they do not listen to Moses and the prophets, they will not be persuaded even if someone should rise from the dead'." Abraham states a disquieting reality: people who reject God's written revelation are self-condemned. As Jesus said in John 8:31-32, "If you abide in my word, you really are my disciples; and you will

[a] A person who sells himself to evil will spend eternity in the Lake of Fire and Brimstone, but usually gets a taste of God's wrath in this life as well.

know the Truth, and the Truth will make you free." So what happens if you do not abide?

Consider further 2 Timothy 4:4, "They will turn their ears away from the Truth and be turned aside to fables." Notice the progression: first they choose to turn away from the Truth, but after that someone else takes over and leads them into ever greater stupidities—that someone else is Satan, using his servants.

But to return to Thessalonians, please notice carefully what is said there: it is God Himself who sends the "active delusion"![a] And upon whom does He send it? Upon those who do not receive the love of the truth—it is a direct judgment upon their rejection of the truth.[b] And what is the purpose of the strong delusion?—the condemnation of those who do not believe the truth. Dear me, this is heavy. Notice that the truth is **central** to anyone's salvation. This raises the necessary question: just what is meant by 'the truth'?

In John 14:6 Sovereign Jesus declared Himself to be 'the truth'. Praying to the Father in John 17:17 He said, "Thy Word is truth". Once each in John chapters 14, 15 and 16 He referred to the third person of the Trinity as "the Spirit of the Truth". Since the Son is back in Heaven at the Father's right hand, and the Spirit is not very perceptible to most of us, most of the time, and since the Word is the Spirit's sword (Ephesians 6:17), our main access to 'the Truth' is through God's Word, the Bible. The Bible offers propositional truth, but we need

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[a] I understand 'active' in the sense of 'aggressive'; it is not a passive delusion that lies quietly in your brain, allowing you to go your merry way. It is aggressive, it tries to control how you think, and therefore what you do and who you are.

[b] Please note that it is not enough to merely 'accept' the truth; it is required that we love the truth. Satan tantalizes us with fame and fortune (on his terms, of course), so to love the truth requires determination; since the love in question is αγαπη, it involves an act of the will.

the Holy Spirit to illumine that truth, and to have the Holy Spirit we must be adequately related to Sovereign Jesus—it is Jesus who baptizes with the Holy Spirit (John 1:33). If that is 'the Truth', then what is 'the lie'? I suggest that 'the lie' is short for Satan's kingdom and all it represents. In that event, we could also say that 'the Truth' is short for Christ's Kingdom and all it represents.

Now then, for something to be received, it must be offered; one cannot believe in something he has never heard about (Romans 10:14). A baby born to Satanist parents and dedicated to him may well grow to adulthood without ever having been exposed to 'the truth'. The same holds for cultures that have no knowledge at all of Christianity. In such circumstances a person can be serving 'the lie' because that is all he knows. He has not rejected 'the truth', because he has no knowledge of it. For such a person there is hope; if some day 'the truth' is presented to him, he has the option of embracing it, as has happened many times.

The use of the verb 'receive' clearly implies an act of volition on the part of those not receiving the truth; that love was offered or made available to them but they did not want it; they wanted to be able to lie and to entertain lies told by others. But the consequences of such a choice are terrible; they turned their back on salvation. Notice in verse 11 that God sends the active delusion so that they will believe the lie; God pushes them toward the lie! In John 8:44 Sovereign Jesus stated that Satan is the father of lying, there being no truth in him. So if God Himself sends delusion, He is turning the victims over to Satan. So if God turns you over to Satan, what are your chances?

Notice the sequence: first they reject the love of the truth; it is as a consequence of that choice that God sends the

delusion. The implication is that there is a **point of no return**;[a] God sends the delusion so that they may be condemned. The only intelligent choice is to embrace the truth! If God offers you the truth and you reject it, your choice turns Him into your enemy—not a good idea!

A correct solution depends upon a correct diagnosis

Why did I write this article? I am looking for a way (if it is still possible) to stop, and even turn back, the satanic steam-roller that is destroying the culture and taking over all aspects of life in the country where I live, Brazil. (Of course, the same is true of other countries as well.) The only possible 'medicine' is the love of the truth, so the bottom line is this: what can we do to promote the love of the truth? Lamentably, the vast majority of the churches are part of the problem, rather than being part of the solution. I venture to say that less than 1% of the churches want a Bible with objective authority.[b] The culture outside the church is totally dominated by relativistic humanism, and most church members have been heavily influenced by that worldview. On the way to promoting the love of the truth, we must defend the objective authority of the biblical Text,[c] and the place to begin is with the churches.[d]

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[a] However, since God is gracious and longsuffering, He may grant a number of opportunities to repent before a person reaches that point. In my own experience, I threw off a variety of falsehoods that I was taught, one at a time over a period of years. That said, I should not assume that I am now totally free from false ideas; I need to keep listening to the Holy Spirit as I study the Scriptures.

[b] In consequence, they are lacking in spiritual power and spiritual discernment.

[c] It is the biblical Text that defines and teaches the Truth, and in order to arrive at the Truth we must understand that the Text has objective authority. Relativistic humanism is inimical to objective authority, and any attempt to relativize the authority of Scripture only serves the enemy.

[d] Our only hope of correcting the national culture depends upon first correcting the churches.

To promote truth necessarily involves exposing lies.

The world hates the Truth

Satan never quits with his attacks against the objective authority of God's Word; it began back in the Garden: "Yea, hath God said?" Satan hates the Truth, because as Sovereign Jesus said in John 8:44, “there is no truth in him”. Satan is the father of lying (same verse), so whenever we tell a lie we are doing Satan’s thing. And whenever we embrace a lie (like evolutionism, Marxism, Freudianism, Hortianism, humanism, relativism, etc.) we give Satan a foothold in our minds, which he usually turns into a stronghold. When Satan gets someone to sell himself to evil, having rejected the truth, that someone becomes what Jesus called a ‘dog’ in Matthew 7:6.[a] A ‘dog’ reacts in an aggressive and violent manner against any presentation of the Truth.

The media and academia are filled with such dogs; they are sworn enemies of the Truth. Why did the Sovereign say **not** to offer anything ‘holy’ to such people? The implication is that it would be a waste of time; they are beyond recovery—their ongoing opposition will also get in the way. However, in order to save the people that they are damaging, it will be necessary to challenge and refute what they represent—before attempting to do this, you had better know how to wield God’s power (Ephesians 3:20). To confront a ‘dog’ is not the same as offering him something ‘holy’.

Consider our Lord’s words recorded in Luke 17:2—“It would be better for him if a millstone were hung around his neck and he were thrown into the sea, than that he should cause one of these little ones to fall.” What is worse than a horrible, premature physical death? Spiritual death. Whoever destroys the faith of a ‘little one’ is self-condemned. What about all the professors and pastors who make it their

[a] 1 Timothy 6:5 and 2 timothy 3:8 may refer to such ‘dogs’ as well.

business to destroy the faith of their students and hearers?

Consider also 2 Peter 3:5—**"**This because they deliberately ignore that heavens and land (out of water and through water) had been existing from of old by the word of God." It appears to me that the term "deliberately" has a direct bearing on the intended meaning of the Greek term usually rendered as 'forget'. How can one 'forget' deliberately? To 'ignore' is deliberate; to 'pretend' is deliberate. When a professor, a scholar, or a scientist ignores the scientific evidence for a worldwide flood, he is deliberately deceiving his students or readers. To do so is to be perverse, to do so is to serve Satan.

Comparing Romans 1:18: the wrath of God is upon those who suppress the truth, with Psalm 5:5: God hates all workers of iniquity, and with what Jesus said in John 6:44: "No one is able to come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him", we may reasonably conclude that the Father will not draw someone whom He hates. So anyone who has become a 'dog' is condemned. Just by the way, have you not noticed that those who were brought up in a Christian environment but then turned their back on Jesus are often more virulent in their opposition to God's truth than those who were brought up as pagans? There is no way to save a 'dog', but we should work to save their students and readers—how can we do this apart from demonstrating that what the 'dog' teaches is wrong? To confront a 'dog' is not the same as offering him something 'holy'; we are not trying to save him, we are refuting him for the sake of his students and readers.

False doctrines in the churches

I suspect that not many Christians in the so-called 'first world' really believe what Sovereign Jesus said in Matthew 7:14: those who find the way of Life are **few**![a] We need to

[a] Consider also Romans 9:27, "the remnant will be saved". The context is about Israel, but the statement is descriptive of all human history.

consider carefully Revelation 22:15; "whoever loves and practices a lie" is excluded from the heavenly City.[a] The Text has 'a' lie, not 'the' lie. The verb here is φιλεω, that refers to emotional love; someone who sells himself to a lie usually becomes emotionally attached to it, and they react aggressively (often irrationally) if you challenge their lie. In contrast, in 2 Thessalonians 2:10 the love of the truth is αγαπη love, that refers to an act of the will whereby you align yourself with the truth.

Consider 1 Timothy 4:1-2—"Now the Spirit says explicitly that in later times some will fall away from the faith, paying attention to deceiving spirits and to things taught by demons—through hypocritical liars whose own consciences have been cauterized." Notice that one cannot "fall away from the faith" unless he was first with the faith. Be not deceived, the churches (with exceptions, of course) are filled with a variety of 'doctrines' of demonic origin. The enemy uses a certain type of person to 'sell' them. Whatever its origin, any false doctrine gives the enemy an entrance into the life of the church, and then into the persons who attend there.

But let us return to Revelation 22:15. The verb 'practice' indicates a value that orients your conduct. If you are

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At any moment during the last 6,000 years, only a very small percentage of the total population was seriously committed to God. The same is true of the Christian population during the last 2,000 years. What percentage of a wheat plant is edible grain (Luke 3:17)? And then there is Matthew 24:37—after 1,650 years of human procreation, how many people would there have been on the earth? Probably well over a million. And how many were saved? Sovereign Jesus said that at His coming it will be like it was in the days of Noah.

[a] Help! "A lie" is rather general, open-ended. What happens if I accepted a lie without realizing that it was one? But the text does not say 'accepts'; it says 'loves' and 'practices'. The implication is that the contrary evidence, to the lie, is available, but has been rejected, or deliberately ignored—the person sold himself to the lie.

practicing a lie, that lie has become part of what you are, part of your private 'package'. Depending on the nature of the lie, its contaminating influence could end up touching all areas of your life. A lie like 'God does not exist' touches everything. Obviously, the more lies that someone practices, the worse off that he will be. Notice, however, that the verbs "loves" and "practices" are in the present tense, which means that while there is life there is hope; it is still possible to repent and change and escape condemnation. Anyone who is overtaken by death while practicing a lie will be excluded from the City.[a]

Now notice what it says in Ezekiel 18; I encourage you to read the whole chapter with care. Each person is responsible for his own destiny, and it is possible to change destinies. Verses 21-22 teach that someone who starts out wrong can change to right, and live. Verse 23: "Do I have any pleasure at all that the wicked should die?" says the Lord GOD, "and not that he should turn from his ways and live?" But verse 24 teaches that the reverse is true; someone who starts out right can change to wrong, and die. While there is life there is hope, except for certain irreversible conditions.[b]

If you consult the Holy Spirit on a given matter, He will not permit you to believe a lie. "He will guide you into all truth" (John 16:13). He is the Spirit of the Truth (John 15:26) and He cannot lie (Titus 1:2). It follows that He hates lies. "These six things the LORD hates, yes, seven are an abomination to Him: a proud look, **a lying tongue**, . . ." (Proverbs 6:16-17). "Lying lips are an abomination to the LORD" (Proverbs 12:22). And remember that liars cannot enter the New Jerusalem

[a] All of us have received false information that we assumed to be true, and in some cases may even have acted upon it, but if it did not become part of our ongoing practice, then it will not necessarily result in keeping us out of the City.

[b] These will be discussed below in the section, "Sins that lead to death".

(Revelation 21:27, 22:15). The case of Joshua and the Gibeonites provides a negative example. The Text says explicitly that they did not seek the Lord's guidance (Joshua 9:14), and the negative consequences lasted for centuries.

I will now discuss some of the lies that Satan has succeeded in 'selling' to many Christians, precisely because they did not consult the Holy Spirit before embracing them. It may be that most people simply accept what they are taught because they trust the teacher, as well as not feeling competent to attempt an independent judgement—and many of them may stop short of 'loving' and 'practicing'. It is also lamentably true that very few churches teach how to consult the Holy Spirit, but none of this changes the consequences of a lie. Such lies often become strongholds of Satan in their minds, that they then defend emotionally. Have you never noticed that when you challenge certain doctrines the people simply explode? They are incapable of discussing the question rationally; they do not know all that the Bible says on the subject. <u>For all that, to promote the truth we must expose lies</u>. If the promoting of the love of the Truth is our top priority, then we must accept the consequences of exposing and denouncing lies. If all Christians were to throw off all of the eight cherished falsehoods discussed below, the world would see an outpouring of God's power unprecedented in human history.

Sovereign grace: The doctrine of 'sovereign grace' is obviously false. God is indeed sovereign, but no single one of His attributes can be, by simple logic, since it is constrained by all the others. God is certainly grace, but He is also love (which necessarily includes the hate of evil, because of the consequences to loved ones), truth, wisdom, power, justice, wrath, eternity, and doubtless others that our finite minds cannot comprehend. Nowhere does the Bible teach that grace is sovereign; the doctrine is an invention. Those who use the

idea of sovereign grace to protect sin and comfort the sinner[a] are in for a terrible surprise. Anyone who has embraced the notion of 'sovereign grace' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

Unconditional love: The doctrine that God's love is 'unconditional' is also false. Since we have no way of deserving His love beforehand, presumably God offers His love without prior condition—it is unconditional only in that sense. But the minute someone receives God's love, then His expectations come into play. From John 4:23-24 it is clear that the Father is looking for a response to His love; He wants to be reciprocated. This is also clear from John 14:21 and 23. If God's love is unconditional, why then does He chasten us? "As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten" (Revelation 3:19). "Whom the LORD loves He chastens, and scourges every son whom He receives" (Hebrews 12:6). And why does He demand an accounting? "We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive the things done in the body, according to what he has done, whether good or bad" (2 Corinthians 5:10; see also 1 Corinthians 3:11-15). Those who use the idea of unconditional love to protect sin and comfort the sinner are in for a terrible surprise. Anyone who has embraced the notion of 'unconditional love' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

Eternal security: The doctrine of 'eternal security', as usually understood, is also false, and even more dangerous to the souls of men than the two discussed above. A crass statement of the 'doctrine' would go something like this: Once saved, always saved, no matter what you do afterwards. When one mentions passages like Ephesians 5:5-6 and 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, that list practices that exclude from the Kingdom, the

[a] By 'comfort the sinner' I mean to tell a sinner not to worry about his sin, rather than confronting it.

standard defense is to say that such people never were saved. But do they not beg the question? Both the passages above were written to believers, not unbelievers. Why would the Holy Spirit write such things to believers if it were simply impossible for them to fall into such practices? And why did the glorified Jesus say, "I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life" (Revelation 3:5)? Please note that it is impossible to blot out a name that is not there! To try to argue that the glorified Jesus was using an impossible 'bogey-man' to scare them would make Him out to be a liar, which He cannot be (Titus 1:2). And then there are all the passages that speak of enduring to the end, so as to be saved. But the definitive text on the subject is Hebrews 6:3-6. The descriptions given in verses 4 and 5 can only refer to someone who has been regenerated, as verse 6 makes clear. The only way to "crucify again" is if you have already done so, at least once. To say that the Holy Spirit is using an impossible 'bogey-man' to scare them would make Him out to be a liar, as well, also impossible.[a] Those who use the idea of eternal security to protect sin and comfort the sinner are in for a terrible surprise. Anyone who has embraced the notion of 'eternal security' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

Salvation without works: The Protestant Reformation correctly rejected the Roman doctrine of salvation by works, but

[a] An appeal to John 10:28-29 reflects a basic misunderstanding of the Text; the crucial point is the semantic area of the verb "snatch". Being snatched is one thing; jumping out is another. You cannot 'snatch' yourself, it must be done by an outside force, and no such force is greater than God. But, if you don't want to go to Heaven, you won't; God will certainly not take you there against your will. Sovereign Jesus puts it very plainly in John 15:6, "If anyone does not abide in me, he is cast out as a branch . . ." 'Abiding' is up to us; we are not forced to do it. If we choose not to, we are out. Note that you cannot be "cast out" unless you are first in.

to replace it with 'faith alone' is open to serious misunderstanding. Ephesians 2:8-10 gives us the truth on this subject in a nutshell:

> "For by grace you have been saved, through the Faith[a]—and this not of yourselves, it is the gift of God—9 not by works, so that no one may boast. 10 You see, we are His 'poem',[b] created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared in advance in order that we should walk in them."[c]

We are not saved <u>by</u> good works, but we are indeed saved <u>for</u> good works; we do not do good works in order to be saved, but we must do good works because we are saved. James is very clear on this point; a faith that does not produce <u>cannot</u> save (James 2:14). Faith without works is dead (James 2:17, 20, 26). If you are alive, you do things. The plan of redemption is not just about getting us to Heaven, it is about our contributing to Christ's Kingdom down here. To tell someone that all he has to do is 'believe in Jesus'[d] and 'bang', he goes to

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[a] The Text has 'the' faith; the reference is to a specific Faith, presumably the body of truth that revolves around the person of Jesus.

[b] The English word 'poem' comes from the Greek word here, *poiema*, and is one of its meanings. Just as each poem is an individual creation of the poet, so we are individual creations, not produced by a production line in a factory.

[c] "Prepared in advance"—I imagine that this refers to God's moral code, the rules of conduct that everyone should follow (if everyone did, we would not need jails, rescue missions, etc.).

[d] Unfortunately, most versions do not translate the Greek text adequately with this clause; the Text never has 'believe <u>in</u> Jesus', it always has 'believe <u>into</u> Jesus', the point being that one must change location from being outside to being inside. To believe into Jesus involves commitment. It is also wrong to use 'accept Jesus' rather than the biblical 'receive Jesus'—one 'accepts' from someone who is inferior in rank, from someone superior in rank one 'receives'. A 'Jesus' that you merely accept cannot save you, since he would be smaller than you are.

heaven, is a cruel falsehood. Anyone who has embraced the notion that he can be saved without working did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

Substitutionism: The doctrine of 'substitution' holds that the Church totally replaces Israel as God's people and that never again will Israel receive any special attention from God. Adherents of substitution are obliged to ignore or mistreat the considerable percentage of the total biblical text that is prophecy relating to the end times. They must also reject plain biblical statements to the contrary, the equivalent of making the Holy Spirit out to be a liar (don't forget that to blaspheme the Holy Spirit is unforgivable). 1 Corinthians 10:32—"Give no offense, either to the Jews or to the Greeks or to the church of God." This text makes clear that during the Church Age there are three categories of people: Jews, non-Jews and the Church (made up of both Jews and non-Jews who are in Christ).

Before Pentecost there were two categories: Jews and non-Jews. Substitutionists hold that after Pentecost there were still just two: Church and non-Church, wherein the Church replaced Israel. But it is not so; Israel still exists as a separate entity in God's plan. Chapters nine, ten and eleven of Romans go into some detail on this point. Romans 11:1-2—"I say then, has God cast away His people? Certainly not! . . . God has not cast away His people whom He foreknew."[a] Substitutionism contradicts this plain statement. At the end of Galatians 6:16 we find "the Israel of God". It is very common to hear this phrase used as a synonym for the Church, but it is not. According to Greek grammar, the repetition of the preposition 'upon' in two phrases joined by 'and' makes clear that the objects of the prepositions refer to

[a] Recall that this was written decades after Pentecost and the beginning of the Church.

distinct entities. Hence, "the Israel of God" cannot be a reference to the Church, assuming that "those who conform to this rule" refers to those who are "in Christ Jesus". I take "the Israel of God" to refer to sincere, devout Israelites. Anyone who has embraced the notion of 'substitution' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

Idolatry: Idolatry is certainly sin, but in what sense is it a lie? Well, does it not replace something true with something false? 2 Timothy 3:16 says that Scripture is like God's breath. Psalm 138:2 says: "You have magnified your word above all your name", and a name represents the person. And John 17:17 says: "Your word is truth". To place church tradition above God's Word is a form of idolatry. To place a denomination's doctrinal 'package' above God's Word is a form of idolatry. To place a church leader's word above God's Word is a form of idolatry. Any of the above hinder spiritual growth, and may lead to ultimate loss, because they all contain falsehood. Anyone who has adopted any of those practices did not consult the Holy Spirit before so doing.

Cessationism: The doctrine of 'cessationism' is also false. Cessationism claims that the 'sign gifts' ceased when the NT Canon was completed, or when the last shovelful of dirt landed on the apostle John's grave.[a] The alleged scriptural basis for this is found in 1 Corinthians 13:8[b]-10. These verses

[a] To affirm that the miraculous gifts ceased when the last shovelful of dirt fell on the apostle John's grave is an historical falsehood. Christians who lived during the second, third and fourth centuries, whose writings have come down to us, affirm that the gifts were still in use in their day. No 20th or 21st century Christian, who was not there, is competent to contradict them. Any 'cessationist' will have a stronghold of Satan in his mind on that subject, because he has embraced a lie. Any doctrine that derives from reaction against excesses and abuses gives victory to Satan. Any argument designed to justify lack of spiritual power cannot be right.

have received more than their fair share of mistreatment, partly because commentators have not linked verse 12 to them (seeing verse 11 as parenthetical). Consider verse 10: "But whenever the complete should come, then the 'in part' will be done away with." If we can pinpoint the 'then', we will have also pinpointed the 'when';[a] and verse 12 pinpoints the 'then'. When will we see 'face to face', when will we know as we are known? 1 John 3:2 has the answer: "Beloved, now we are children of God; and it has not yet been revealed what we shall be, but we know that when He is revealed, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is." It is at the return of Christ that we will see 'face to face', so "whenever the complete should come" refers to Christ at His second coming.

The problem with 'prophecy', 'tongues' and our present 'knowledge' is that they are 'in part', but after the return of Christ we will have no further need for them. Since Christ has not returned yet, these 'in part' things are certainly still with us. The claim that 'the complete' refers to the completed New Testament canon does violence to the Text. If it had really been the Holy Spirit's purpose to tell us that the *charismata* would disappear in a few decades, He presumably could have done a much better job of it. Cessationists also generally choose to ignore all that the Bible says about warfare with Satan and his angels, and in consequence they spend their lives in spiritual defeat, producing much less for the Kingdom than they could and should. They do not even do the same things that Jesus did, much less the greater things (John 14:12). Those who use the idea of cessationism in an attempt to explain and justify their lack of spiritual power are being foolish, if not worse. Anyone who has embraced the notion of 'cessationism' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

[a] These two temporal adverbs work together.

Prosperity gospel: While there may be variations on the theme, the basic 'pitch' is to the hearer's selfish interests, while any serious commitment to Christ and His Kingdom is severely ignored. The emphasis is upon blessings, not the Blesser, but the blessings are not free; to get them one must contribute heavily to the purveyors thereof. But Sovereign Jesus gave the definitive answer to this stupidity (or should it be 'perversity') in Matthew 6:24—"No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will be loyal to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mamon." 'Mamon' is sometimes translated as 'money', but it probably includes more than that, although money is central to it—a materialistic worldview. As Jesus said, someone serving mamon cannot be serving God at the same time. Anyone who wants to go to heaven must reject mammon. Anyone who has embraced any form of the prosperity 'gospel' did not consult the Holy Spirit before doing so.

The reader may well have tired of the refrain, "did not consult the Holy Spirit", but of course there is more to the story than that. Recall what Sovereign Jesus said to the Sadducees, "You are deceived, not knowing the Scripture nor the power of God" (Matthew 22:29). To be ignorant of both the Scripture and the power of God is to be spiritually bankrupt. Anyone who has embraced any of the falsehoods discussed above did not study the Scriptures sufficiently before doing so.

There are many, many more false things being taught in our churches,[a] but I consider that the short list discussed above is sufficient for my present purpose. **If all Christians were to throw off all of the eight cherished falsehoods**

[a] All false teaching has a certain destiny; as Sovereign Jesus said in Matthew 15:13, "Every plant that my heavenly Father did not plant will be uprooted."

discussed above, the world would see an outpouring of God's power unprecedented in human history.[a] I am well aware that one painful consequence of taking Revelation 22:15 seriously is to consider the fate of people we loved and respected who passed on while embracing one or more of the falsehoods discussed above. That is a question that is in God's capable hands. For ourselves, 2 Corinthians 10:12 comes to mind: "But they, measuring themselves by themselves, and comparing themselves among themselves, are not wise." We had best base what we are and do on God's Text.

I now move on to a topic that has received very little attention, so far as I know. It underscores the importance of promoting the love of the Truth.

Sins that lead to death

Consider 1 John 5:16-17—"If anyone should see his brother sinning a sin not leading to death, let him ask, and He will give him life, for those who do not sin unto death. There is sin leading to death; I am not saying that he should make request about that.[b] 17 All unrighteousness is sin, and there is sin not leading to death." It should be obvious that John is not contradicting Romans 6:23—"The wages of sin is death, but the gracious gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord." Obvious, because the shed blood of God's Lamb delivers the true believer from that death (the spiritual part). Anyone who dies outside of Christ is condemned by his sin.

But notice that John is talking about Christians; "If anyone should see his **brother** . . ." John is saying that for <u>believers</u>

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[a] The outpouring in Moses' time was limited to a small area, as was the outpouring in Jesus' time. Today there are Christians all around the world.

[b] I suppose that a request about a sin leading to death simply will not be granted. In that case it does no harm to take a chance, in the hope that you can still make a difference. We ignore this area of truth to our peril.

there are sins that lead to death and others that do not. A necessary question presents itself; is he talking about a premature physical death (everyone dies sooner or later), or is it spiritual death? John clearly says that a sin leading to death is irreversible, there is no point in praying about it, God will not grant life. A premature physical death is not all that serious if the person still goes to heaven. I think of two possible candidates:

1) God sometimes kills those who participate in the 'Lord's Table' in an unworthy manner (1 Corinthians 11:29-30). The use of the verb 'sleep' indicates that they do not lose their salvation; I believe it is reserved for the death of believers.
2) Acting in an irresponsible manner (presumptuously) with the intent of obliging God to work a miracle to save you. Satan tried to get Jesus to do this, but did not succeed (Matthew 4:5-7). People who attempt this generally die prematurely.

That said, however, I rather doubt that John was writing about physical death. Consider what is said in Hebrews 10:26-31.

> "Because, if we deliberately keep on sinning after having received the real knowledge of the Truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins, 27 just a certain fearful anticipation of judgment and fierce fire that is ready to consume the hostiles. 28 Anyone who rejected Moses' law died without mercy on the testimony of two or three witnesses. 29 Of how much worse punishment, do you suppose, will he be deemed worthy who has trampled the Son of God under foot, who has regarded as unholy the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified, and who has insulted the Spirit of grace? 30 For we know Him who said, '"Vengeance is up to me", says the Lord, "I will repay".' And again, 'The LORD will judge His people.' 31 It

is a dreadful thing to fall into the hands of the Living God!"

Notice that verse 28 refers to a premature physical death, so the "how much worse punishment" in the next verse must refer to spiritual death. Notice further that from verses 19-25 (same chapter) it is clear that the author is addressing believers. This is confirmed by verse 26: "there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins" can only apply to someone who has already taken advantage of Christ's sacrifice. Notice also the 'after having received the real knowledge of the Truth' and 'by which he was sanctified' (verses 26 and 29).

I will now discuss some possible candidates for sin that condemn a Christian to spiritual death, that cause irreversible spiritual ruin.

1) Matthew 10:33 falls within the instructions that Jesus gave to the twelve apostles before He sent them out two by two: "Whoever denies me before men, him I will also deny before my Father who is in heaven". One possible reference is to a Christian who caves under persecution. Revelation 21:8 consigns 'the cowardly' to the Lake. A Christian who becomes a Mason (Freemason) is clearly condemned. During the initiation ritual the candidate is asked, "Where are you coming from?" and he must answer, "I am coming from darkness". Then he is asked, "What are you coming for?" and he must answer, "I am coming for light". At that moment the candidate has formally denied Jesus before men. Surely, because in John 8:12 Jesus affirmed: "I am the light of the world. He who follows me shall not walk in darkness, but have the light of life." Further, such people generally do so for material gain, thereby switching from Jesus to mamon (Mathew 6:24).

2) Hebrews 10:29 refers to someone "who has trampled the Son of God under foot", evidently referring to a virulent rejection by someone who was once a Christian (sanctified). I can

think of several modern-day examples. Some years ago there was a very successful Canadian evangelist named Charles Templeton. His evangelistic campaigns filled football stadiums; many thousands of people responded to his invitations; at least one hundred Canadian foreign missionaries received their call under his ministry. But then someone convinced him that he needed more 'culture', more 'sophistication', and he went to a liberal theological seminary in the USA to get it. When he returned, he was blaspheming God and cursing Jesus Christ; as a television host his favorite sport was to ridicule the Christian faith. Years later he told someone that he "missed Jesus", which indicates that he knew that he could not return (Hebrews 6:6).

3) And how about blasphemy against the Holy Spirit? Mark 3:30 defines it as ascribing to Satan something done by the Holy Spirit. Is it impossible for a Christian to do this? Have you never heard someone roundly condemn all things charismatic as being from Satan? I would suggest that to be careless on this point is not to be recommended—better safe than sorry.

Sins for which we may pray

Now then, having said all of that, what might be some sins about which we may, and should, pray? Well, how about the embracing of any one of the lies that I discussed above? If we can get a brother to abandon such a lie, we will be doing him a tremendous favor. I may not enjoy hearing a doctor tell me I have a life-threatening condition, but if I allow him to save me from a premature death, I will end up thanking him. Similarly, a brother probably will not appreciate being told that he has embraced a lie, but if he will stop and think, and change, he will end up thanking us. If we wish to save a brother from Revelation 22:15, it is a risk that we must take.

And then there is Hebrews 3:12-13. "Take care, brothers, that there not be a malignant heart of unbelief in any of you,

so as to go away from[a] the living God; 13 rather, exhort yourselves every day, while it is called 'today', so that none of you be hardened through sin's deceitfulness." I rendered "exhort yourselves" because the pronoun here is reflexive, not reciprocal, but being plural it probably includes both ideas—each one should exhort himself, but we should also exhort each other. If we are attentive and vigilant, there will be no end of things to pray about, things where we can still make a difference.

All of this relates to the purpose of this article in the following way. To promote truth it is necessary to expose and combat falsehood. The obvious place to start with our promoting is with individual believers, and the more so if they are leaders and teachers within their communities. Although they may reject us and our 'impertinence', Ezekiel 3:20-21 bears directly on this question.

> "Again, when a righteous man turns from his righteousness and commits iniquity, and I lay a stumbling block before him, he shall die; because you did not give him warning, he shall die in his sin, and his righteousness which he has done shall not be remembered; but his blood I will require at your hand. 21 Nevertheless if you warn the righteous man that the righteous should not sin, and he does not sin, he shall surely live because he took warning; also, you will have delivered your soul."

When we see a brother going in the wrong direction, it is incumbent upon us to warn him, even if he rejects us. Notice again, "his righteousness which he has done shall not be remembered"—how terrible! Allow me to insist that the question before us is not merely theoretical or 'pedantic'; it is terribly practical, it is of the essence. In the words of Deuteronomy 32:47, "It is not a vain thing for you, because it

[a] Notice the direction. The term 'malignant' implies satanic influence.

is your life." It is certainly life for each one of us individually, but it is also life for the churches, and then it will be life for the world.

Conclusion

In conclusion, I will review the 'building blocks' that make up the article.

1) Why did I use 1 Peter 4:17? There was a time when I thought that I could not ask God to judge the world because He had not yet judged the Church. But I was mistaken. God has always judged both His 'house' and the world. More to the point, the world is in the mess that it is because of failure in the Church. Further, judging is one thing, but correcting is another, and the correcting of the culture begins with, and depends on, the correcting of the churches. To correct a group of people begins with getting them to see where they are wrong, which involves denouncing error and showing a way out.

2) Why did I use Matthew 23:8-12 and John 4:23-24? I tried to trace a basic cause of failure in the Church—a correct solution depends upon a correct diagnosis. The Church became part of the problem, rather than being part of the solution, and it became part of the problem by rejecting the love of the Truth. The concept of 'bishop' (and in our day even of lowly pastors) as someone having the authority to control the spiritual life of others is an open rebellion against Sovereign Jesus, who forbids any such attitude or proceeding. But rebellion against God is Satan's 'thing', and will certainly call down God's judgment.

3) Why did I use 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12? This text gives the essence of the problem and the essence of the solution. The consequences of rejecting the love of the Truth are devastating, both to the Church and to the world. It is God Himself

who sends the "active delusion"![a] And upon whom does He send it? Upon those who do not receive the love of the truth—it is a direct judgment upon their rejection of the truth.[b] And what is the purpose of the strong delusion?—the condemnation of those who do not believe the truth. The only solution that I can see is to promote the love of the Truth, which necessarily involves denouncing error.

4) Why did I use Revelation 22:15? This text states plainly the terrible consequence of embracing a lie. To promote love of the Truth it is necessary to expose lies, and this is a necessary part of correcting the churches so they can be salt and light in the surrounding culture. A correct solution depends upon a correct diagnosis. Although they may reject us and our 'impertinence', Ezekiel 3:20-21 bears directly on this question. When we see a brother going in the wrong direction, it is incumbent upon us to warn him, even if he rejects us. Notice again, "his righteousness which he has done shall not be remembered"—how terrible!

5) Why did I use 1 John 5:16-17? This text emphasizes the possible terrible end result of being flippant about sin and the Truth. Anyone who is flippant about sin does not have the mind of Christ. We ignore to our peril the instruction given in Hebrews 3:12-13. And then there is 1 Corinthians 9:27—the Greek term *adokimos* is stronger than some commentaries would have you believe.

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[a] I understand 'active' in the sense of 'aggressive'; it is not a passive delusion that lies quietly in your brain, allowing you to go your merry way. It is aggressive; it tries to control how you think, and therefore what you do and who you are.

[b] Please note that it is not enough to merely 'accept' the truth; it is required that we love the truth. Satan tantalizes us with fame and fortune (on his terms, of course), so to love the truth requires determination; since the love in question is αγαπη, it involves an act of the will.

The future of the Church and of the world depends on the love of the Truth.

56) 'Lament', not 'weep'

Matthew 5:4

The question before us is to understand what Jesus meant. We must interpret it from Jesus' point of view, not ours, or anyone else's. The 'lament' here is not crying because you are hurting; nor is it crying in mourning because you lost a loved one. It is lamentation for evil and sin, and the consequences of both. The 'Bible' that Jesus had was the Old Testament, and that is where we must look for the definition of the word.

We can start with Ezra. In 9:1-4 Ezra learns of the sin of the people.[a] In 9:5-15 we have a prayer with identification. Ezra prays, confessing the sin of the people, and as the leader he includes his person in the confession, even though he did not participate in the sin he was confessing. In 10:1 we have Ezra praying, making confession and weeping, prostrate before the house of God. Now note especially 10.6–Ezra isolates himself, does not eat bread or drink water, "for he mourned because of the guilt (infidelity) of those from the captivity." Here we have a concrete case of lamentation for sin and its consequences.

Now consider Daniel. In 9:3 he addressed the Lord God with prayer and supplications, with fasting, sackcloth and ashes. In 9:4-19 we have another prayer with identification. Daniel prays, confessing the sin of his people, including himself in the confession, even though the sin was not his personally. In 9:20-27 Daniel receives a visit and a communication from the angel Gabriel. Perhaps three years later, at

[a] Both 9:4 and 10:3 mention the portion of the people who trembled at the words of the God of Israel—it is the 'humble spirit'.

10.2, Daniel affirms that he himself spent three weeks mourning, fasting all the time. Certainly he was not bemoaning any of his own problems; it was because of evil and its consequences.

Now Jeremiah 7:28-29—"This is a nation that does not obey the voice of Jehovah their God nor receive correction. Truth has perished and has been cut off from their mouth. Cut off your hair and cast it away, and take up a lamentation on the desolate heights; for Jehovah has rejected and forsaken the generation of His wrath." The sin of the people went so far as to provoke the wrath of God, so much so that He turned his back on that generation. Here we have another case of lamentation for sin and its consequences.

Now consider two texts that link comfort to lamentation. Isaiah 57:18 says, "I will restore comforts to him and to his mourners." In Luke 4:18-19 Jesus applied the prophecy in Isaiah 61:1-2 to Himself, but He did not quote the entire prophecy. I here use 61.2-3; the Messiah was anointed: "to comfort all who mourn, to console those who mourn in Zion, to give them beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning, the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness."

But exactly how does comfort and solace work? Before paying attention to comfort in this life, let us consider the coming one. When someone laments evil and sin, it is evident that he is on God's side, seeing how He sees. For such people, ultimate and total comfort will come in Heaven. In Revelation 21:4 the great voice from Heaven declares: "God will wipe away every tear from their eyes; there will be no more death nor sorrow nor weeping nor pain–they will exist no more, because the first things have passed away."

We may start with Luke 16:25—"But Abraham said: 'Child, remember that in your lifetime you received your good things, while Lazarus had bad things; but now it is he who is being comforted, and you tormented." The account of the

rich man and the beggar Lazarus begins in verse 19 and ends in verse 31. In verse 25 both had already died and were in Hades, the 'waiting room' where the spirits of the departed await the final judgment. But since one's final destination is determined by what was done in life, the lost are already separated from the saved. A presumed criminal suffers in prison, even before the case is judged. On the other hand, the saints already receive benefits in advance–which is why Lazarus was already receiving comfort.

Now we go to 2 Thessalonians 1:4-8:

> "We ourselves boast about you among God's congregations, referring to your steadfastness and faith in the midst of all your persecutions, and the tribulations that you are enduring—**5**the above is evidence that God's judgment is right, to the end that you be considered worthy of the Kingdom of God, on behalf of which you are actually suffering; **6**since to God it is right to pay back affliction to those who are afflicting you **7**and rest (along with us) to you who are being afflicted, at the revelation of the Lord Jesus from heaven with His powerful angels in blazing fire, **8**inflicting vengeance on those who do not know God and on those who do not obey the Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ."

It is at the time of the second coming of the Lord Jesus that those who have suffered for the sake of the Gospel will enter into their rest. Then they will have permanent comfort, but they will also have the 'comfort' of seeing their persecutors punished. In fact, the certainty that evil will be punished helps us to withstand mistreatment while still alive. Asaph's Psalm 73 clearly addresses this.

In the first verse, Asaph gives the final conclusion so that the reader will not be shaken by what follows. In verses 2-14 he recounts the struggle he had, seeing the prosperity of the wicked while he, seeking to be righteous, suffered. In verses

15-16 he thinks of the negative effect on others if he speaks his mind. Now verse 17: “Until I entered the sanctuary of God; then I understood their end (the fate of the wicked)”. Verses 18-20 deal with the destruction of the wicked. In verses 21-22 Asaph confesses his sin, and verses 23-26 speak of his spiritual restoration. Verses 27-28 conclude the Psalm with appropriate conclusions. We can take comfort in the certainty that evil will be punished, but far more important is the spiritual comfort we receive when we walk with God. 2 Chronicles 7:14 and 2 Corinthians 1:3-5 also speak of the comfort we receive in this life, when we lament evil.

Jonah 3:7-9 provides us with a very interesting practical example. Remembering the context: God tells Jonah to go to Nineveh and preach against it. Jonah goes, but very grudgingly. He delivers the message brutally. Then a miracle happened: the Ninevites repented, starting with the king. Just look at Jonah 3:7-9:

> “By the decree of the king and his nobles: Let neither man nor beast, herd nor flock, taste anything; do not let them eat, or drink water. But let man and beast be covered with sackcloth, and cry mightily to God; yes, let everyone turn from his evil way and from the violence that is in his hands. Who can tell if God will turn and relent, and turn away from His fierce anger, so that we may not perish?”

Verse 10 says that in fact God relented from destroying them at that time. There was lamentation over sin, and there was comfort. They trembled at the Word of God!

To conclude, consider what the Lord Jesus said in Matthew 11:29—“Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, because I am meek and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.” That rest works throughout this lifetime, as well as for eternity. Oh praise God!

57) Light for the Blind?

Acts 26:18

Paul was defending himself before King Agrippa. In verses 12–18 he described his encounter with the glorified Jesus.

> **12**It was on one of those journeys, as I was going to Damascus with authority and a commission from the chief priests, **13**at midday, O king, as I was on the road, I saw a light from heaven brighter than the sun, blazing around me and those traveling with me. **14**Well we all fell to the ground and I heard a voice speaking to me and saying in the Hebrew language:[a] "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me? It is hard for you to kick against the goads." **15**So I said, "Who are you, Lord?" And He said: "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting. **16**Now get up and stand on your feet; because I have appeared to you for this purpose, to appoint you as a servant and a witness both of the things you have seen and of the things I will reveal to you, **17**delivering you from 'the people' and the ethnic nations, to which I am sending you: **18**to open their eyes, so as to bring them back from darkness into light and from the authority of Satan to God, so that they may receive forgiveness of sins and an inheritance among those who are sanctified, by the faith into me."

I wish to focus attention on the missionary commission that Paul (he was still Saul) received. Matthew 28:19, Mark 16:15, John 20:21 and Acts 1:8 took place between the resurrection and the ascension, but to commission Paul Jesus returned from Heaven! One other detail deserves special notice—the responsibility that Paul received was primarily concerned with the ethnic nations ("Gentiles" is a translation of the same word that in Matthew 28:19 is rendered "nations"). For these reasons it seems to me that this

[a] A conversation between two Jews would naturally be in Hebrew.

missionary commission takes on a special importance for us, and the more so for whoever is going to do pioneer trans-cultural work. So let us consider this commission in more detail.

Paul is sent to the nations (defined ethnically), "to open their eyes, so as to bring them back from darkness into light and from the authority of Satan to God, so that they may receive forgiveness of sins and an inheritance among those who are sanctified, by the faith into Me."

I rendered the second verb as ‘bring back’ rather than ‘turn’ or ‘convert’ because I take that to be the correct nuance of the Text. It gives the impression that someone is in the wrong place or situation and needs to be brought to the correct one. And now for the main point: the purpose clause introduced by the conjunction ‘so that’ is subordinated to the verbal phrase dominated by the verb "bring back". In other words, before someone can receive forgiveness of sins, even, he must be freed from the power of Satan! Before a person can be saved someone must do something about Satan's influence upon him.

But I am getting ahead of myself; we need to start at the beginning, “to open their eyes”. If their eyes are shut, they are blind. What good is light to a blind person? It should be obvious that the glorified Jesus was not saying that all Gentiles were physically blind; He was referring to spiritual blindness. In Matthew 15:14 He referred to blind guides leading blind people, and He was not speaking of physical blindness, except as an illustration of the spiritual. In Romans 2:19 Paul refers to the spiritually blind. In 2 Corinthians 3:14 he refers to that blindness as a ‘veil’. In 2 Corinthians 4:4 Paul spells it out.

In verse 3 he refers to the Gospel being hidden from those who are perishing, or wasting themselves, and then proceeds: "among whom the god of this age has blinded the minds of the unbelieving, so that the light of the Gospel of the glory of

Christ, who is the image of God, should not dawn on them." The Text clearly states that Satan, 'the god of this world', is in the business of blinding the minds of unbelievers when they hear the Gospel, so they will not understand, so they will not be convicted, so they will not repent and convert. This is a terrible truth. The enemy has access to our minds, access in the sense that he has the power or ability to invade them, whether by introducing thoughts or by jamming our reasoning. The Lord Jesus had already declared this truth previously, when He explained the parable of the sower. "These are the ones by the wayside where the word is sown; but, as soon as they hear it Satan comes and takes away the word that was planted in their hearts" (Mark 4:15). In the parallel passage in Luke 8:12 Jesus adds the following words: "lest they believe and be saved". Note that the Word is already in the mind or heart of the person, but then Satan comes, invades the mind and 'takes away' that word. I am not sure just how this intrusion by the enemy works, perhaps he causes a mental block of some sort, but the practical effect is that the Word becomes ineffective, as if the person had not even heard it.

It seems obvious to me that whoever does not take this truth into account will be condemning himself to produce little effect in the spiritual realm, to work hard and achieve little. So how can we open people's eyes? We must deal with the cause of the blindness, we must free them from the power of Satan, we must do something about Satan's influence upon them.

The Lord Jesus had already said the same thing in different words during His earthly ministry. We find it in Mark 3:27. "No one can plunder the strong man's goods, invading his house, unless he first bind the strong man; then he may plunder his house." I have used the definite article with the first occurrence of 'strong man' because the Greek text has it, the point being that this particular strong man has already

been introduced in the immediate context. ‘The strong man’ here is Satan. (The Jewish leaders tried to explain Jesus' authority over the demons by saying that He expelled them by the power of Beelzebul, prince of the demons. In His retort Jesus does not waste time with that name but uses the enemy's proper name, Satan.)

So then, the Lord Jesus declares that it is impossible to steal Satan's goods unless we bind him first. (From His use of ‘no one’ it seems clear that the Lord is enunciating a general principle or truth.) And what might the nature of those ‘goods’ be? In the context (see Matthew 12:22-24) Jesus had delivered someone from a demon that caused blindness and dumbness, and in their comments the scribes and Pharisees include other instances where Jesus had expelled demons—it seems clear that the ‘goods’ are people who are subject to Satan's power, in one way or another. Thus we have the same essential truth as that declared in Acts 26:18—we have to do something about Satan's power over a person so that he or she can be saved! So just what can or should we do? Since the point of handcuffs (‘bind’) is to keep someone from acting, I believe that in so many words, aloud or in thought, we must forbid Satan (who will usually be using demons) from interfering in the minds of our hearers, before we witness, preach or teach. Consider what Sovereign Jesus said in Luke 10:19.

“Take note, I am giving[a] you the authority to trample on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing at all may harm you.” In Matthew 28:18 Sovereign Jesus affirms that He holds "all authority in heaven

[a] Instead of ‘am giving’, perhaps 2.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have ‘have given’ (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.)—a serious error. Jesus said this perhaps five months before His death and resurrection, addressing the seventy (not just the twelve). The Lord is talking about the future, not the past; a future that includes us!

and on earth", so He is clearly competent to delegate some of that authority to us. Now then, just how does "authority over all the power of the enemy" work, in practice? Authority controls power, but since we have access to God's limitless power (Ephesians 3:20), we should not give Satan the satisfaction of our using his (and he could easily deceive us into doing things we shouldn't). We should use our authority to forbid the use of Satan's power, with reference to specific situations—in my experience, we must be specific. (I have tried binding Satan once for all until the end of the world, but it does not work; presumably because God's plan calls for the enemy's continued activity in this world. We can limit what the enemy does, but not put him completely out of business, or so I deem.) But just how should we go about it?

In the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. The Text tells us that this sword is "the ρημα of God"—ρημα, not λογος. It is God's Word spoken, or applied. Really, what good is a sword left in its sheath? However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.

In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1, 18:36, 2 Kings 1:10). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:19). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak![a]

[a] For more on this subject the reader may consult my site: www.prunch.org, under the heading, "Biblical Spiritual Warfare".

I have been asked why Paul himself is not recorded to have forbidden Satan's activity; and if this is so important, why were not the other Apostles told as well. I would say that the other Apostles were indeed told, and three of the Gospels mention it (Matthew 12:29, Mark 3:27, Luke 11:21-2). As for Paul, he did not merely preach and teach, he gave visible demonstrations of God's power (1 Thessalonians 1:5). The first recorded example of his procedure is in Acts 13:6-12. Elymas was presumably demonized, but in any case was being used by Satan to keep Sergius Paulus from the truth. Paul discerned what was involved and took appropriate action, with the result that the proconsul believed, "when he **saw** what had been done". That this was not an isolated case may be seen from Acts 14:3, 16:18, 19:11-20, 2 Corinthians 12:12 and especially Romans 15:18-19. Paul declares that he made the Gentiles obedient "by word and **deed**", "by mighty signs and wonders, by the power of the Spirit of God", and on that basis he claimed to have "fully preached the Gospel of Christ". Which leads to the question of how the other Apostles understood their commission.

Paul did not share with the Twelve the advantage of observing the three years of Jesus' ministry at close range. Christ's preaching was inextricably mixed with His healing the sick and expelling demons. He knew exactly what was involved (cf. Luke 13:16). When He sent them out two by two His orders were explicit: "As you go, preach, . . . heal the sick, cleanse lepers, expel demons" (Matthew 10:7-8; cf. Mark 6:7-13 and Luke 9:1-6). In Mark 16:15-18 healing and expelling are expressly included in the Great Commission (I am prepared to demonstrate that verses 9-20 are of necessity the original ending of Mark, and therefore Scripture), and verse 20 affirms that the Lord confirmed their preaching "through the accompanying signs". Hebrews 2:4 repeats that their ministry was characterized by "signs, wonders and various

miracles". The Apostles demonstrated the truth of John 14:12, where Jesus affirmed: "he who believes into me, the works that I do he will do also". The Gospel as preached by Jesus and His Apostles was with word and **deed**, miraculous deed, supernatural deed. How about the Gospel we preach?[a]

I now return to an analysis of Paul's commission. When attempting to evangelize one or more pagans (non-Christians), there was a sequence of things to be done:

1) Since light is of no use to a blind person, the necessary starting point is to deal with their spiritual blindness, by cancelling the satanic strongholds and blind-spots in their minds (1 John 3:8).

2) "So as to bring them back from darkness into light and from the authority of Satan to God"—the prepositional phrases are

[a] I wonder sometimes if we evangelicals do not regard the Apostles, especially Paul, as virtually divine. Scripture makes clear that the OT writers did not understand the full implications of what they wrote. They were kept from error while writing, but not when interpreting to themselves what they had written. I see no reason for supposing that the NT writers were treated differently. The Sacred Text itself records some of their failures. Why should we assume that Paul and the others had a full grasp of the complete range of options for spiritual warfare? Certainly no detailed procedure or technique is spelled out in the Bible. Why not? I suggest the following. This area of truth is so powerful that if an infallible procedure had been spelled out in an unmistakable way, Satan and his angels would have been wiped out long since. But that would have frustrated the purpose of God in allowing them to continue in operation even though defeated and with their final destination defined. Also, it seems to be God's purpose that our walk with Him not be easy or automatic—He is a rewarder of those who "**diligently** seek" Him (Hebrews 11:6). Further, to wield the power of God is a demanding privilege; it requires clean hands and a pure heart (James 4:8), it demands humility (James 4:6). God does not give up His secrets to the lazy and uncommitted (Proverbs 25:2).

parallel and basically synonymous. Having been delivered from the blindness, the person is now ready for light, the light of God's Good News. Once we have repelled the enemy's interference, I believe it is possible to introduce a positive influence, based on Matthew 18:18. I understand the 'binding' to include the repelling of the enemy's interference, and in that event the 'loosing' presumably includes the introduction of a positive influence. I invoke the Spirit of the Truth (John 15:26) and of conviction (John 16:8) to guide and encourage the person to believe into Jesus.

3) "So that they may receive forgiveness of sins and an inheritance among those who are sanctified"—this is the desired result. Strictly speaking, the Text has 'those who have been sanctified', referring to the final result. However, it is well to remember that sanctification is also a process.

4) To receive that desired result, the person must believe into Jesus, 'into', not 'in'—the Text always has 'believe **into** Jesus', the point being that there is a change of position, from being outside to being inside, and commitment is involved.

58) Luke 24:46-47

A friend recently phoned me to ask if I had a solution for what appeared to be a problem in Luke 24:46-47. In the NKJV it reads like this: Then He said to them, "Thus it is written, and thus it was necessary for the Christ to suffer and to rise from the dead the third day, and that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in His name to all nations, beginning at Jerusalem." I believe that most versions (including my own[a]) have essentially the same thing. The 'problem' is that such a translation places the content of what Jesus said in the OT, where it is not to be found. Jesus is made to affirm a

[a] So it was in the first two editions; now corrected.

falsehood, definitely out of character, to say the least! On the spur of the moment, I had no answer for my friend, but I promised to look into it. Here is the result.

I believe it is generally agreed that a series of nouns linked by 'and', each having the definite article, refers to distinct entities. The baptismal formula in Matthew 28:19 gives a nice example: "of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit".[a] The normal meaning of the compound phrase is that the three entities are distinct; each one is distinct from the other two.[b]

I submit for due consideration that the same holds true for a series of nouns, or phrases, linked by 'and', when the same preposition is repeated for each one. I suggest that Galatians 6:16 offers a fair example: "peace and mercy be upon them, and upon the Israel of God". "Them" and "the Israel of God" refer to distinct groups of people.[c]

I submit for further consideration that the same adverb, overtly repeated, and linked by 'and', will function in a similar way; which brings me back to our 'problem'. The Text has: *ουτως γεγραπται και ουτως εδει παθειν τον Χριστον*.

Lamentably, the eclectic text currently in vogue omits *και ουτως εδει*, following 0.5% of the extant Greek manuscripts, all of which are of objectively inferior quality.[d] The 99.5% are certainly correct. In verse 44 Jesus tells the Eleven that the OT

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[a] Because Greek grammar has case, the preposition here is part of the definite article, in the Greek Text.

[b] In passing, please note that the compound phrase is subordinate to "the name of", 'the name' being singular. So here we have a presentation of the Trinity: three persons representing one 'name' or essence. We have it on the word of the resurrected Christ!

[c] In the Greek Text, the preposition 'upon' is overtly repeated.

[d] What objective basis did the editors have for following 7 manuscripts (of objectively inferior quality) against 1,600 better ones? None. How could they perpetrate such an atrocity? The answer may be found in Ephesians 2:2.

had to be fulfilled. Verse 45 has: "Then He opened their understanding so as to comprehend the Scriptures," and verse 46 continues, "and He said to them: 'Thus it was written. And so it was necessary for the Christ to suffer …'" The 'thus it was written' refers back to the content of verses 44-45 and closes the topic. The second 'thus' opens a new topic, so the material that follows is not attributed to the OT. The 'problem' that our incorrect translations create is spurious.

That said, however, the eclectic text maintains and imposes the problem. Versions that follow that text will have something like this: And He said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and rise again from the dead the third day." Beyond question, any such rendering makes Jesus affirm a falsehood. Is that not perverse?

59) Mark 16:9-20 and the doctrine of Inspiration

For well over a hundred years it has been a commonplace of New Testament textual criticism to argue that Mark 16:9-20 was not and could not have been written by Mark (or whoever wrote the rest of the book), that it was a subsequent accretion. However, among those who wish to believe or claim that Mark's Gospel was inspired by the Holy Spirit, that it is God's Word, I am not aware of any who are prepared to believe that it could really have been God's intention to terminate the book with *εφοβουντο γαρ* (verse 8). The most popular hypothesis seems to be that the Autograph was produced as a codex (not a scroll) and that the sheet (or sheets) containing the original ending was torn off and lost before any copies were made.[a] I wish to examine the implications of the claim that verses 9-20 did not form part of

1 See, for example, B.M. Metzger, *A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament* (New York: United Bible Societies, 1971), p. 126, fn. 7.

the Autograph and that the original ending has vanished (whatever the explanation offered for such a circumstance).

I am writing from the position of one who believes in the verbal, plenary inspiration of Scripture and am addressing those who believe (or would like to believe) that the Bible is God's Word written—"*all Scripture is God-breathed"* (2 Timothy 3:16).

So, we claim that the Holy Spirit inspired Mark's Gospel. And why would He do something like that? Evidently God wanted subsequent generations to have an official biography of Jesus Christ, a description of His life, death and resurrection whose accuracy was guaranteed and whose content was sufficient for His purpose. (That there are several official biographies written from different perspectives does not obviate the integrity of each one individually.)[a] I find it inconceivable that an official biography, commissioned by God and written subject to His quality control, should omit proofs of the resurrection, should exclude all post-resurrection appearances, should end with the clause *"because they were afraid*"!

But most modern critics assure us that such is the case, that the genuine text ends at verse 8. So where was God all this time? If the critics' assessment is correct, we seem to be between a rock and a hard place. Mark's Gospel as it stands is mutilated (if it ends at verse 8), the original ending having disappeared without a trace. But in that event what about God's purpose in commissioning this biography? Are we to say that God was unable to protect the text of Mark or that He just could not be bothered? Either option would be fatal to the claim that Mark's Gospel is *"God-breathed".*

If God tried but was powerless to prevent the mutilation of Mark in this way, how can we be sure that the book has not been mutilated in other ways and places, or even

[a] I would say that Matthew wrote for a Jewish audience, Mark for a Roman audience, Luke for a Greek audience, and John for everyone.

systematically? For that matter, how can we be sure that other New Testament books have not been mutilated too, or maybe even all of them? Anyway, the degree of mutilation would no longer be an issue, because if God was powerless to protect His Word, then He would not really be God and it would not make all that much difference what He says. The Bible would lose its authority and consequently its importance.

What about the other option—that God could have protected Mark but chose not to? Of what value would quality control be if it extended only to the writing? If God permitted the original ending of Mark to be lost before any copies were made then the biography was 'published' in a seriously incomplete form, and it becomes decidedly awkward to speak of its 'verbal, plenary' inspiration. If God would permit a mutilation of such magnitude, then what assurance do we have that He would not permit any number of further mutilations? Again, the problem extends to the other New Testament books. Quality control would be gone out the window and we would be left 'whistling in the dark'. If God is not going to protect His text will not the purpose of inspiration be frustrated? 1 Chronicles 16:15 speaks of "the Word which He commanded, for a thousand generations"—there have been fewer than 300 since Adam.

But, What About All the Variants?

It is a plain fact that the extant manuscripts contain a great many copying mistakes and even deliberate alterations. Since we cannot deny that God permitted this to happen, it remains to ask why and with what implications. First, the why.

Why would God permit mistakes and alterations in the copying process? I have no direct revelation to offer on the subject but I suppose the answer begins with God's purpose in creating the human race. It appears that He desired a type of being that could respond to Him in worship and love, a

being that could choose (John 4:23-24). In Hebrews 11:6 we are taught that God demands faith and rewards those who **diligently** seek Him. It would seem that His purpose in creating man entails an element of test. The evidence may not be overwhelming, crushing, inescapable or there would be no adequate 'test'. Thus, God permitted textual variants to test our faith and determination, to test our attitude, to test our willingness to humbly and patiently look for answers (Proverbs 25:2 and Revelation 5:10).

Another aspect of the creation of beings with volition is that both God and man must live with the consequences of the exercise of that volition. If He exerts complete control, we become robots and the whole point of the experiment is lost. Alas, most of man's volition is expressed in rebellion against our Creator. A fair share of that rebellion has been directed against His Word—usually by rejecting it, but sometimes by trying to alter it.

Besides all that, our abilities and capacity to understand are limited. As it says in 2 Corinthians 4:7, we are mere *"earthen vessels",* clay pots. Even if the Autographs had been engraved on gold tablets and miraculously preserved intact to this hour, who among us could offer a 'perfect' interpretation of that Text? (Anyone working from a translation is dealing with some imperfection before he even starts, because no translation can be perfect—the nature of language does not permit it.) Since our understanding is condemned to be imperfect in any case, is it really necessary to have a perfect Text? If not, is there some point at which the amount of imperfection ceases to be 'tolerable'? Which brings us to the implications. I will begin with some analogies.

Our everyday lives furnish several analogies which illumine this question. All our lives we use measuring devices—rulers, yardsticks, tapes—that vary slightly from each other. We buy many things according to measure without

questioning the accuracy of the instrument, even though a precise comparison would reveal discrepancies between instruments. Why? Because the discrepancies are not big enough to concern us and because we know there is an absolute standard to refer to should the need arise. At the Bureau of Standards in Washington, D.C., in a hermetically sealed case, is the absolute, unvarying standard yardstick. How many Americans have ever seen that standard? Very few, comparatively. Yet we are born, live and die without seeing the standard and without feeling any inconvenience. We assume that our rulers are close enough for ordinary practical purposes, as indeed they are, and live happily with them. We know that we can go to Washington if a question arises that warrants the expense.

If someone asks a group of people for the time of day he may well get up to ten different answers, scattered along a ten-minute continuum. We daily live with one or two-minute discrepancies among the several time pieces we may consult and think nothing of it. Two different radio stations in a city often differ from each other by a minute or two, and so on. The system works well enough because there is a recognized standard in Greenwich, England. I have never been there and I suppose few Americans have, but we get along handily just the same. But if there were no standard we would soon be in trouble.

When a legislature draws up a law great care is taken with the precise wording, because once it is published it is law—it becomes a standard, binding upon the people under its jurisdiction. Great care is taken with the standard, but law enforcement officers are not expected to memorize it. All they need is a reasonably accurate understanding of the intent and pro-visions of the law. When an officer arrests an offender and cites the law he will probably only give the gist of it. No court will countenance a plea by the defendant that the

arresting officer did not cite the law verbatim. (Similarly, I doubt that God will countenance an unbeliever's plea that he did not have access to the Law verbatim—it is enough to have the gist.) However, during a trial emphasis is often given to the precise 'letter' of the law and the whole disposition of the case may depend on the interpretation given to that 'letter'.

Alcohol (ethanol) may be found on the shelf at any drug-store, but seldom exceeding 92%; perhaps the pharmacist has a private supply of 96% for special purposes. For ordinary household use 92% is more than adequate—in a pinch, a stout 60% rum will burn and may be used to disinfect. It may be that certain scientific experiments require 100% alcohol but it will be hard to come by and quite expensive. As with all manufactured goods, the higher the degree of precision or 'perfection' the more difficult and costly it is to attain. Different purposes require different degrees of precision (in any area), but for most people and most purposes most of the time the degree of precision does not have to be very high. In fact, in the majority of cases a superlative degree of precision would be wasted—the context simply does not allow for its full utilization or appreciation.

So, why has God allowed errors to get into the Text, or why does He permit faulty interpretation? In the first place the whole point of having a human race apparently involves giving us the ability and freedom to sin and take the consequences (both individually and corporately—the larger the group is that participates in a sin, the more serious and far-reaching are the consequences). But in the second place normal and daily use does not require a superlative degree of precision—in any event we have more of God's Truth than we can possibly appropriate. However, it is the availability of a recognized standard that enables us to tolerate minor imperfections, in a given area. We have the treasure in *"earthen vessels",* but the *"treasure"* must exist!

But, Are Not the Autographs Lost?

The question of a lost standard remains. Returning to the analogy of measuring devices, what would happen if someone stole the 'inerrant' yardstick from the Bureau of Standards? Well, there would be no inconvenience so long as we did not know about it—we would continue happily as we always have. But if the loss became known then confidence in the individual instruments would be undermined and our business dealings would become complicated by arguments about the standard of measurement (as I have observed in certain places). I believe we have seen this syndrome with reference to the Bible. Until the 19th century there was no question (to speak of) about the standard, and the Bible was accepted as authoritative even though in fact the text they were using was not identical to the Original. But during the past 200 years critics have convinced the majority (in Europe and North America) that the standard is gone, with the resulting spiritual and moral confusion we see on every side.

The problem is largely one of perception. Generations have lived and died happily using their imperfect rulers and yardsticks without suffering any damage or inconvenience—the discrepancies were not big enough to matter. (If someone had convinced them that they had an insuperable problem, however, they would have been damaged—gratuitously.) Similarly, our manuscripts and versions contain discrepancies, most of which are not serious enough to matter for ordinary purposes. However, if someone makes a 'court case' out of some issue then the existence and identity of the relevant standard become crucial.

I submit that the central 'issue' has to do with the authority of Scripture. When the Protestant Reformation appealed to the Scriptures (in the original languages) as the supreme authority, the Roman Catholic Church countered by pointing to the textual variation in the manuscripts and challenging the

Reformation leaders to produce the standard.[a] In the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries destructive critics went beyond the variants to challenge the date, authorship and composition of the individual books of the Bible. I consider that these challenges have been adequately handled by others and return to the problem of textual variation.

How does textual variation affect the authority of Scripture? It depends. Is that authority to be seen as absolute or relative? If we are prepared to settle for a relative authority, the 'Neo-orthodox' position, we can assimilate an admixture of error in the Text. But if we wish to claim absolute authority the standard must be perfect. Scripture derives its authority from divine inspiration, but if any part of the text is not inspired that part lacks authority. Specifically, the errors and alterations introduced by fallible men down through the centuries of copying lack authority. For this reason, those who claim that the Bible is inerrant usually limit the claim to the Autographs. But since the Autographs are gone (they were probably worn out from use within the first one hundred years) what good does that do us? It depends.

The analogies already given show that we can coexist with minor discrepancies quite handily without feeling that we have been cheated or deceived. In fact, in most contexts to insist on absolute perfection would be deemed unreasonable, if not intolerable. We accept small discrepancies, but not **big** ones! If we feel that someone is trying to take advantage of us our reaction is prompt. Similarly, we must distinguish between honest copying errors, due to inattention, and deliberate alterations. Further, many alterations appear to be relatively 'harmless', while others are overtly damaging.

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[a] See Theodore P. Letis, "John Owens Versus Brian Walton", *The Majority Text: Essays and Reviews in the Continuing Debate* (Fort Wayne: The Institute for Reformation Biblical Studies, 1987), pp. 145-190. For more on this subject please see Appendix I.

In Matthew 13:25 and 39 the Lord Jesus explains that Satan sows tares among wheat—this is true of the Church and it is true of the Biblical text; although the analogy is not perfect, in the latter case the "tares" may be likened to poison mixed with the Bread of Life. To give a few quick examples: the variants in Matthew 1:7 and 10 that introduce Asaph and Amos into Jesus' genealogy are poison; the variant in Matthew 1:18 that ascribes to Christ a "beginning" is poison; the variant in Mark 6:22 that turns Herodias into Herod's daughter is poison; the variant in Luke 3:33 that inserts the fictitious Admin and Arni into Jesus' genealogy is poison (these were probably the result of scribal carelessness, or ignorance, but for modern editors to intrude them into the printed text is irresponsible); the variant in Luke 23:45 that has the sun being eclipsed is poison; the variant in John 1:18 that reads "an only begotten god" is poison; the variant in 1 Corinthians 5:1 that denies the existence of incest among the Gentiles is poison; the omission of Mark 16:9-20 is poison; the use of brackets in printed Scripture (in whatever language) to insinuate to the user that the enclosed material is spurious is poison. By 'poison' I mean violence done to the Biblical text that undermines its credibility.

So where does that leave us? It leaves us with thousands of manuscript copies (of the NT writings) from which we may recover the precise wording of the Autographs, provided we evaluate the evidence on the basis of what the Bible says about itself, about God and His purposes, about man, and about Satan and his ways. To these must be added the declarations of the early Church Fathers and the facts of history that have come down to us. By careful attention to all relevant considerations, we can weed out the errors and alterations and affirm with reasonable certainty what must have been the wording of the Autographs.

Since God the Son on earth emphatically declared, *"till heaven and earth pass away not one jot or one tittle will by any means pass from the Law till all is fulfilled"* (Matthew 5:18), I conclude that He would never permit a true reading to disappear from the manuscript tradition. I am well aware that Jesus was presumably referring specifically to the Pentateuch. How then can I apply His statement to the NT? First, jots and tittles refer to **letters**, not concepts or ideas; in fact, they are the smallest of letters. Our Lord's words constitute a rather radical declaration about the preservation through time of the precise form of the Sacred Text. The third chapter of 2 Corinthians makes clear that the *"new covenant"* (verse 6) is *"more glorious"* (verse 8) than the old, including the very Decalogue itself ("e*ngraved on stones,"* verse 7). Chapters 7 through 9 of Hebrews demonstrate the general superiority of the new covenant over the old and Jesus Himself both guarantees (7:22) and mediates (8:6) this "better" covenant. I conclude that God's protective interest in the New Testament must be at least as great as His protective interest in the Old. 1 Chronicles 16:15 declares that interest to extend to a thousand generations; in other words, to the end of the world (there have yet to be 300, since Adam).

To be faced with the task of recognizing the genuine reading among two or more variants is one thing; to affirm that something so crucial as the ending of a Gospel has disappeared without a trace is altogether different. If Mark 16:9-20 is not genuine then it would seem that Christ's statement in Matthew 5:18 is in error.

The Matter of Canonicity

There is a further question—why do we claim that Mark is "Gospel" in the first place? Where did it get its canonicity? Or to put it another way, if God is going to inspire a text for the use of subsequent generations, He has to make sure that people recognize it for what it is. If the nature of such a text is

not perceived and it is relegated to oblivion, or treated with no more respect than any other bit of literature, then God's purpose is frustrated. So why do we say that Mark's Gospel is "Bible"? Because the Church, in her corporate capacity, has so declared, and she has done so down through the centuries, beginning in the second (at least). (We do not have hard evidence from the first century, but we do from the second and all subsequent centuries.) Of necessity God worked through the Church to achieve both canonicity (the public recognition of its quality) and preservation. (I would say that the superior quality of the inspired writings is intrinsic and can be perceived by a spiritual person in any age, but if the early Church had not recognized them, they would not have been copied through the centuries and thus would not have come down to us.)

What has the Church, down through the centuries, said about Mark 16:9-20? With united voice she has declared its canonicity. If she was deceived on this point, how do we know she was not deceived about the rest of the book? However, satanic activity on the fringes produced variant readings that in some cases were quite damaging. The primary evidence is furnished by the continuous text Greek manuscripts.

The External Evidence

The passage in question is contained in every extant Greek manuscript (about 1,700) except three: codices B (Vaticanus) and ℵ (Sinaiticus) and the twelfth century minuscule 304. It is also contained in all extant lectionaries (compendia of the established Scripture lessons linked to the ecclesiastical calendar). The importance of this lectionary evidence has been explained by J.W. Burgon: "That lessons from the New Testament were publicly read in the assemblies of the faithful according to a definite scheme, and on an established system,

at least as early as the fourth century,—has been shown to be a plain historical fact."[a] And again:

> It is found that, from the very first, S. Mark xvi. 9-20 has been everywhere, and by all branches of the Church Catholic, claimed for **two** of the Church's greatest Festivals, —Easter and Ascension. A more weighty or a more significant circumstance can scarcely be imagined. To suppose that a portion of Scripture singled out for such extraordinary honour by the Church universal is a spurious addition to the Gospel, is purely irrational.[b]

Although after a time there came to be prescribed Scripture passages for every day of the year, the practice evidently began with the weekends, and most especially the most important ones. According to Baumstark's Law the lections associated with the great festivals seem to have been the earliest to have been adopted.[c] Since the idea was borrowed from the Jewish synagogue the practice may well have been generalized during the second century, if not the first.

Before the Church started producing lectionaries as such (as well as after), regular manuscripts were adapted by putting symbols in the margins (or in the text) to indicate the beginning and ending of lections. These included the word τελος "end", either in full or abbreviated. Statements of evidence for omitting verses 9-20 usually mention a number of MSS that have such symbols at the end of verse 8 (and thus at the beginning of verse 9), claiming that they were put there

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[a] *The Last Twelve Verses according to S. Mark,* 1871, p. 207. Reprinted in 1959 by the Sovereign Grace Book Club, but the pagination given refers to the 1871 edition (to find the corresponding place in the 1959 edition add 78 to the page number).

[b] *Ibid.*, p. 210.

[c] W.R. Farmer, *The Last Twelve Verses of Mark* (Cambridge University Press, 1974), p. 35. On pp. 34 and 35 he gives a good summary of the lectionary evidence.

to indicate doubt about the genuineness of the following verses. It happens that not only is Mark 16:9-20 itself one of the most prominent of all lections in the liturgical calendar, but a separate lection ends precisely with verse 8.

Consider what Bruce Metzger wrote concerning MS 2386:

> The latter, however, is only an apparent witness for the omission, for although the last page of Mark closes with *εφοβουντο γαρ*, the next leaf of the manuscript is missing, and following 16:8 is the sign indicating the close of an ecclesiastical lection . . ., a clear implication that the manuscript originally continued with additional material from Mark.[a]

Notice his "clear implication". Is it not obvious? One cannot read beyond the end of a book so there is no point in putting a lection sign there. Which makes one wonder about the intentions of the editors of UBS[3]. In their apparatus, as evidence for the omission of verses 9-20, they include *"(Lect? Lection ends with verse 8)"*—this presumably refers to lection signs in the margins since it cannot mean that the lectionaries do not have verses 9-20. But lection signs in the margin are evidence for, not against! Notice that in discussing the evidence for variant sets within verses 9-20 UBS[3] invariably cites *Byz Lect,* which means that they recognize that the lectionaries contain the passage. In fact, from the circumstance that they also list 'l185m' it appears that lectionary 185 is the only one that does not have the verses in the Synaxarion (just in the Menologion).

The Syriac, Latin, Coptic and Gothic versions all massively support the passage. Only the Armenian and Georgian versions (both fifth century) omit it. To be more precise, every Syriac MS (about 1,000?) except one (the Sinaitic, usually

[a] Metzger, p. 122, fn. 1.

dated around 400) contains the passage. Although the Sinaitic is the oldest extant Syriac MS, apparently, it is not representative of the Syriac tradition. B.F. Westcott himself, writing in 1864, assigned the Peshitta to the early second century, in accord with the general opinion of the Scholarly world of the time.[a] The demands of the W-H theory subsequently led them to assign the Peshitta to the fifth century, but Vööbus demonstrates that the Peshitta goes back to at least the mid-fourth century and that it was not the result of an authoritative revision.[b] The Sinaitic is a palimpsest; it was scraped off to make way for some devotional material, which is an eloquent commentary upon the contemporary evaluation of its quality!

Every Latin MS (8,000?) except one (Bobiensis, usually dated about 400) contains the passage. But Bobiensis (k) also seems to be the only witness of any kind to offer us the so-called 'shorter ending' by itself—every other witness that contains the 'shorter ending' also contains the 'longer ending', thereby displaying a conflation (an incredibly stupid one!). Now then, so far as I know everyone recognizes the 'shorter ending' to be an aberration, which means that Bobiensis is aberrant at this point and does not represent the Latin tradition. If the Latin tradition dates to the second century here we have second century support for the 'longer ending'. It appears that the only Coptic witness that omits the passage is one Sahidic MS, although there are a few that exhibit the conflation already mentioned (they are thereby convicted as being aberrant).

The Diatessaron (according to the Arabic, Italian and Old Dutch traditions) and Irenaeus clearly attest the last twelve

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[a] *The Bible in the Church* (London: MacMillan) p. 132 (reprintings in the 1890s still contain the statement).

[b] *Early Versions of the New Testament* (Stockholm: Estonian Theological Society in Exile, 1954), pp. 100-102.

verses in the second century! As does Hippolytus a few years later. Then come Vincentius, the Gospel of Nicodemus and the Apostolic Constitutions in the third century; Eusebius, Aphraates, Ambrose and Chrysostom in the fourth; followed by Jerome, Augustine, Cyril of Alexandria, Victor of Antioch, etc.

Clement of Alexandria and Origen are usually cited as being against these verses, but it is an argument from silence. Clement's surviving works seem not to refer to the last chapter of Mark, but neither do they refer to the last chapter of Matthew. So?

The main patristic source used to argue against Mark 16:9-20 is Eusebius. It appears that he wrote a defense against four alleged discrepancies between resurrection accounts of the Gospels put forward by a certain "Marinus" (our knowledge is based on a tenth century abridgement of what he presumably wrote, an abridgement that lacks internal consistency). The first alleged discrepancy is between Matthew 28:1 and Mark 16:9. On the face of it, "Marinus" is assuming that verse 9 is genuine "Gospel" or there would be no problem, so we may conclude that he understood that to be the position of the Church. That Eusebius takes the time to answer as he does points in the same direction. Further, in answering the second alleged discrepancy Eusebius simply assumes the genuineness of the Marcan account and argues that Matthew's turn of phrase has been misunderstood. However, in answering the first allegation (according to the abridgement) he offers two options: "One might say that the passage is not contained in all the copies of Mark's Gospel . . .; another says that both accounts (Matthew and Mark) are genuine and must be properly understood." With the first option he employs the optative mood, appropriate to the genre of hypothetical rhetoric (which means that nothing said by the hypothetical speaker is being vouched for by Eusebius),

while with the second he switches to the indicative mood, presumably an indication of what he himself considered to be the correct position—so much so that when he moves on to the second "discrepancy" he does not offer the option of rejecting the passage.

However, the "canons" or "sections" of Eusebius (but not the so-called "sections of Ammonius") may not have included verses 9-20. In some Greek MSS the sectional number "233" is placed in the margin beside verse 8 and is the last such number (in Mark)—which means that section 233 started at verse 8, but since many "sections" contained more than one verse we do not know the extent of this one. But there is more to the story. Burgon checked out 151 Greek MSS that have "Eusebian sections" marked in the margin and offers the following tabulation of results:

in 3 MSS the last section number is 232, set against v. 6,
in 34 MSS the last section number is 233, set against v. 8,
in 41 MSS the last section number is 234, set against v. 9 (?),
in 4 MSS the last section number is 235, set against v. 10 (?),
in 7 MSS the last section number is 236, set against v. 12 (?),
in 12 MSS the last section number is 237, set against v. 14 (?),
in 3 MSS the last section number is 238, set against v. 15,
in 1 MS the last section number is 239, set against v. 17,
in 10 MSS the last section number is 240, set against v. 19,
in 36 MSS the last section number is 241, set against v. 20.

Added to this, the following information may be of interest:

the oldest MS that stops with 232 is A of the 5th century,
the oldest MS that stops with 233 is L of the 8th century,
the oldest MS that stops with 234 is □ of the 9th century,
the oldest MS that stops with 237 is □ of the 9th century,
the oldest MS that stops with 239 is G of the 9th century,

the oldest MS that stops with 240 is H of the 9th century,
the oldest MS that stops with 241 is C of the 5th century.[a]

For sections 235, 236 and 238, the earliest MS is 10th century or later. So, in three-fourths of these MSS the section numbers overtly go beyond verse 8, and the two oldest ones (A and C) do not aid the case for omission.

Jerome is cited as being against the passage because he put Marinus' questions in a certain "Hebidia's" mouth and used an abridgement of Eusebius' answers in reply. However, Jerome's own evaluation is clear from the fact that he included Mark 16:9-20 in his Latin Vulgate; he also quotes verses 9 and 14 in his writings. Hesychius of Jerusalem (not Severus of Antioch, nor Gregory of Nyssa) reproduces Eusebius in his own words in a treatise about the familiar "problems". However, since he quotes Mark 16:19 and expressly states that St. Mark wrote the words, his own position is clear. Victor of Antioch repeats Eusebius yet again, and acknowledges that "very many" copies of Mark lack verses 9-20 (it is not clear whether he had verified this to be true or was just quoting Eusebius). Then he affirms that he himself has verified that "very many" contain them, and appeals to "accurate copies" and most especially to "the Palestinian exemplar of Mark which exhibits the Gospel verity" in support of his own contention that the passage is genuine. He even blames the omission on individuals who thought the verses to be spurious.[b]

Parenthesis—down with forgery!

((Every now and again I am handed a question that starts out by irritating me, but after I calm down, I perceive that God is nudging me to clarify a point that needs it. This happened

[a] Burgon, p. 313; for the general discussion see pp. 127-134 and 297-314.

[b] For detailed documentation and an exhaustive discussion, see Burgon, pp. 19-31, 38-69, 265-90.

recently with the 'jewel' attributed to Jerome that in his day 'most' or 'almost all' of the Greek manuscripts did not have the last twelve verses of Mark. Since of the 1700 or so Greek MSS known to us that contain the last chapter of Mark only three do not have them (one of them being a falsification at this point), how could a vast majority in the 5th century be reduced to a small fraction of one percent later on? In terms of the science of statistical probability, such an inversion is simply impossible. Only a world-wide campaign that was virtually 100% successful could bring about such a switch, and there is not a shred of evidence for such a campaign.

Recall that Diocletian's campaign to destroy NT MSS (applied unevenly in different areas) was past history by a century (not to mention Constantine's 'conversion' and the consequences thereof). Kenneth Scott Latourette (*A History of Christianity* [New York: Harper,1953], p. 231) describes Eusebius Hieronimus Sophronius (alias Jerome) as "a gifted and diligent scholar, enormously erudite, a master of languages, a lover of books, wielding a facile, vigorous, and often vitriolic pen" who "was an eloquent advocate of the monastic life". He doubtless had his defects [don't we all], but he was not ridiculously stupid, as he would have had to be to make the statement attributed to him. Our knowledge of the 'jewel' comes from the tenth century [the interval of five centuries does not inspire confidence]; it is almost certainly a forgery (someone 'borrowing' a famous name to give credence to some statement). Since 'sacred cows' don't like to die, a review of some relevant history is in order.

K. Aland on Egypt

Even that great champion of an Egyptian text, Kurt Aland, recognized that during the early centuries, including the 4th, Asia Minor (especially the Aegean area) was "the heartland of the Church". (It also became the heartland of the Byzantine Empire and the Orthodox Churches.) The demand for copies

of the NT would have a direct bearing on the supply, and on the areas where copies would be concentrated. But on the subject of Egypt, Aland had this to say:

> Our knowledge of the church in Egypt begins at the close of the 2nd century with bishop Demetrius who reorganized the dominantly Gnostic Egyptian church by founding new communities, consecrating bishops, and above all by establishing relationships with the other provinces of the church fellowship. Every church needed manuscripts of the New Testament—how was Demetrius to provide them? Even if there were a scriptorium in his own see, he would have to procure "orthodox" exemplars for the scribes. The copies existing in the Gnostic communities could not be used, because they were under suspicion of being corrupt. There is no way of knowing where the bishop turned for scribal exemplars, or for the large number of papyrus manuscripts he could give directly to his communities.[a]

But just a minute, please. In the year of our Lord 200, who in Egypt was still speaking Greek? (For that matter, who among the ordinary people had ever spoken Greek there?) What Greek speaking communities could the worthy Demetrius have been serving? Would the scholars linked to the library in Alexandria be likely to bow to Demetrius? So far as we know, no apostle ever ministered in Egypt, and no Autograph of a New Testament book was held there. The Gnostic dominance probably should not surprise us. But the situation in Alexandria is relevant to the question in hand because of Clement, and especially Origen, who was mentor to Pamphilus, who was mentor to Eusebius of Caesarea.

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[a] "The Text of the Church?" Kurt Aland, *Trinity Journal*, Vol. 8, Nº 2, Fall, 1987, p. 138 [actually sent out in the Spring, 1989].

Eusebius (Caesarea)

One suspects that the forger who 'borrowed' Jerome actually started out by 'borrowing' Eusebius (Caesarea). He has Eusebius answering a certain 'Marinus' with, "One might say that the passage is not contained in all the copies of Mark's Gospel . . ." The 'not all' became 'some' or even 'many', here and there. If Eusebius actually wrote such a thing, of which we aren't sure [the interval of six centuries does not inspire confidence here either], how was he qualified to do so? After the Roman destruction in 70 AD, Palestine became a back-water in the flow of the Christian river. The transmission of the true NT Text owes nothing to Caesarea. By the 4th century there would have been thousands, literally, of NT MSS in use around the world, of which Eusebius (d. 339, b. about 265) probably would not have seen more than a dozen (most from Alexandria, not Asia Minor). If Codex B was produced in Alexandria in time for Eusebius to see it, it would indeed permit him to say 'not all' copies; but why would he do so? And why should we pay any attention to him if he did? Here again, who in Palestine was still speaking Greek in the 4th century? What use would Eusebius have for Greek manuscripts? One other point: had Eusebius written such a thing, it would have been after Diocletian's campaign, presumably, but it would still be fresh in his memory and he should have mentioned it. Emboldened by success, as I suppose, the forger decided to 'up the ante' attributing the same exchange to Jerome, answering a certain 'Hebidia', except that now it is 'most' or 'almost all'.

Jerome (Bethlehem)

Jerome was born around 342 and died in 420 (or so). During 382-384 he was secretary to Pope Damasus, in Rome, and began work on the Latin Vulgate. Not long after the death of Damasus (384) he moved to Bethlehem, followed a few months later by the wealthy Paula, who helped him build a

monastery, and so on. Jerome spent the last 30+ years of his life in Bethlehem, even more of a 'backwater' than Caesarea, and a century after Eusebius. All the negative observations made about Caesarea apply here with added force. Further, who in the Pope's entourage in Rome was speaking Greek in 380 AD? From Rome Jerome moved to Bethlehem. How many actual Greek MSS of the NT would Jerome have seen? Certainly fewer than 1% of the total in use (at that time there would be few Greek MSS in Italy and Palestine—who would use them?). In lists of early Church 'fathers' Jerome is usually listed with those who wrote in Latin, not Greek. The statement attributed to him is patently false, scientifically impossible; and he would have been ridiculously unqualified to make it. Not being stupid or dishonest, he didn't!

Addendum

After I circulated the above, my Canadian friend, Charles Holm, called my attention to historical research done by Timothy David Barnes that is relevant to the credibility of Jerome (*Tertullian: A Historical and Literary Study*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971). In an appendix dealing specifically with Jerome, there is a section called "Jerome and Eusebius" wherein Barnes offers the following observations (pages 236-238).

> First, Jerome never questions the reliability of Eusebius. Thus he accepts Eusebius' interpretation of what a writer says without asking whether it is correct.
>
> . . . . . .
>
> Secondly, Jerome far surpasses Eusebius in credulity. What was in Eusebius presented as surmise or mere rumour is for Jerome established and indubitable fact.
>
> . . . . . .
>
> Thirdly, Jerome mistranslates and misunderstands.
>
> . . . . . .
>
> Fourthly, Jerome dishonestly conceals both his ignorance and his debt to Eusebius.

Well, well, well, it appears that one should read Jerome with a full salt shaker to hand. Perhaps my closing sentence above should have been: Not being stupid, he didn't! However, I continue to insist that Jerome could not have been so grossly stupid and/or dishonest as to make the ridiculous statement attributed to him. Down with **forgery**!**))**

Unfortunately, commentaries can still be found that reproduce certain misstatements of yesteryear about "scholia" and "catenae". The "catenae" may not be adduced for the omission, as demonstrated by Burgon (pp. 135-157). As for the "scholia" (critical notes), the situation seems to be something like this: at least 22 MSS simply repeat Victor of Antioch's statement, which includes the affirmation that he himself had verified that "very many" copies, including "accurate" ones and most especially the "true Palestinian exemplar", contained verses 9-20; several have footnotes defending the verses on the basis of "ancient copies at Jerusalem" (attention is directed to the footnote by a "+" or "*" in the text which is repeated before the footnote—much as we do today); two MSS say the passage is missing in "some" copies but present in "many"; four MSS say it is missing in "some" copies while present in "others"; three say it is missing in "many" and present in "many".[a] Now the earliest of these MSS is from the 10th century (most are later), so the copyists were repeating the "scholia" blindly, with no way of knowing if they were true or not. The fact remains that of the extant MSS only three lack the passage.

Codices L, Ψ, 099, 0112 and 579 are sometimes claimed as being against the genuineness of verses 9-20 because they also contain the so-called 'shorter ending'. Metzger's comment (p. 126) is misleading—these five MSS did not "replace" one ending with another, they conflated both. A conflation

[a] Burgon, pp. 116-125, 290-292.

condemns the MSS that contain it, at that point, but says nothing about the relative merits of the component parts.

We must return to codices B and ℵ, both of the 4th century and both from Egypt (presumably, see Farmer, p. 37), being generally regarded as the two most important MSS of the New Testament (frequently referred to as the "oldest and best"). Their agreement in omitting verses 9-20 has been an important factor in the thinking of those who reject the passage (since they generally regard the "Alexandrian text-type" as superior to all others). However, the evidence is not quite straightforward. Codex B is written in three columns and upon completing a book it normally begins the next book at the top of the next column. But between Mark and Luke there is a completely vacant column, the only such column in the NT. Considering that parchment was expensive (and B is on very fine vellum), the "wasting" of such a space would be quite unusual. Why did the copyist do it?

As for Codex ℵ, the folded sheet containing the end of Mark and beginning of Luke is, quite frankly, a forgery. Tischendorf, who discovered the codex, warned that those four pages appeared to be written by a different hand and with different ink than the rest of the manuscript. However that may be, a careful scrutiny reveals the following: the end of Mark and beginning of Luke occur on page 3 (of the four); pages 1 and 4 contain an average of 17 lines of printed Greek text per column (there are four columns per page), just like the rest of the codex; page 2 contains an average of 15.5 lines of printed text per column (four columns); the first column of page 3 contains only **twelve** lines of printed text and in this way verse 8 occupies the top of the second column, the rest of which is blank (except for some designs); Luke begins at the top of column 3, which contains 16 lines of printed text while column 4 is back up to 17 lines. On page 2 the forger began to spread the letters, displacing six lines of printed text; in the

first column of page 3 he got desperate and displaced **five** lines of printed text, just in one column! In this way he managed to get two lines of verse 8 over onto the second column, avoiding the telltale vacant column (as in B). That second column would accommodate 15 more lines of printed text, which with the other 11 make 26. Verses 9-20 occupy 23.5 such lines, so there is plenty of room for them. It really does seem that there has been foul play, and there would have been no need for it unless the first hand did in fact display the disputed verses. In any event, ℵ as it stands is a forgery and therefore may not legitimately be alleged as evidence against them.

To sum up: every extant Greek MS (about 1,700) except two (B and 304—ℵ is not 'extant' because it is a forgery at this point) contains verses 9-20. Every extant Greek lectionary (about 2,000?) contains them (one of them, 185, doing so only in the Menologion). Every extant Syriac MS (about 1,000?) except one (Sinaitic) contains them. Every extant Latin MS (8,000?) except one (k) contains them. Every extant Coptic MS except one contains them. We have hard evidence for the 'inclusion' from the 2nd century (Irenaeus, Diatessaron?). We have no such hard evidence for the 'exclusion'.

It would appear that sometime during the 3rd century MSS lacking the passage began to be produced in Egypt, probably in Alexandria, of which two (or one) from the fourth century have survived to our day. Although the idea gained some currency in Egypt, it did not take over even there since most Alexandrian witnesses, including the Coptic version, contain the verses. The translators of the Armenian version had studied in Alexandria, and the Georgian version was based on the Armenian, which explains how the idea escaped from Egypt. The rest of the Christian world seems not to have picked up this aberration. As stated at the outset, with united voice, down through the centuries, in all parts of the world

(including Egypt), the Church universal has affirmed and insisted that Mark's Gospel goes from 1:1 to 16:20. Since that is so, how can someone who denies the authenticity of Mark 16:9-20 still affirm the Divine Inspiration of Mark 1:1-16:8? Is he not being inconsistent?

The Internal 'Evidence'?

It should not be necessary to prolong this exercise, but something probably ought to be said about the "internal evidence" that some critics evidently feel to be fatal to the passage. We are told that Mark "never" uses certain words or phrases, which nonetheless occur there; that others which he "always" uses are missing; that the style is "foreign" to Mark; that there are insuperable problems with the discourse structure and the very content; in short, that it is "impossible" that the same person could have penned 1:1-16:8 and 16:9-20. Alas, what to do?

Most of the 'arguments' of this sort that have been advanced reveal a disappointing degree of superficiality in research and ignorance of language. Such supposed arguments were thoroughly refuted over 100 years ago by J.A. Broadus (*The Baptist Quarterly*, July, 1869, pp. 355-62) and Burgon (pp. 136-90). A more recent (1975) treatment is offered by Farmer (pp. 79-103). I will take up one argument that might seem impressive to the uninitiated reader.

It has been alleged as a sinister circumstance that Jesus is not mentioned by name in verse 9 (or in the following verses).[a] The rules of discourse structure have been violated, so they say. Really? Let's consider Mark's practice elsewhere. Be-tween Mark 9:27 and 39 Jesus is not mentioned by name, although there are two paragraph breaks and one section break in between, plus two changes in location. Jesus is next named in 10:5, five verses after a section break and another

[a] The true Text has "Jesus" at the beginning of verse 9, as well as at the end of verse 1.

change of location. Between Mark 3:7 and 5:6 (75 verses) Jesus is not named even though there are numerous participants and several radical changes in location, scene and content. In each case it is only when another man is introduced in the narrative, creating a potential for ambiguity, that Jesus is again named since a mere pronoun would be ambiguous in reference.

In Mark 16 there is only one dead person in focus, precisely the participant who has dominated the whole book, so verse 9 could only refer to Him—there is no ambiguity so a proper name is not necessary. Throughout verses 9-20 no other singular masculine participant is introduced so there is no need to identify Jesus by name. By way of contrast, Mary Magdalene had to be fully identified, because not only is there more than one woman in the account, there is more than one Mary! (The background information, "out of whom He had cast seven demons", is entirely appropriate here, and only here, because this is the first time she is brought into focus—in the prior references she was just part of the group.)

There is one aspect of this situation which has not received sufficient attention that I am aware of. The more strident and caustic a critic becomes in proclaiming the "impossibility" of accepting Mark 16:9-20 as genuine (because of style, vocabulary and discourse features), the more he insults the ancients and undercuts his own position. After all, Irenaeus was a native speaker of Koine Greek (presumably)—why didn't he notice the "impossibility"? How come the native speakers of Koine Greek who lived in Greece and Asia Minor and copied Mark down through the years didn't recognize the "obvious stupidity", the "odious fabrication"? How come? How is it that modern critics who deal with Koine Greek as a dead language, and at a distance of 1800 years, are more competent to judge something like this than the native speakers who were on the scene? Irenaeus knew Polycarp

personally, who knew the Apostle John personally, who knew Mark personally. Irenaeus declares that Mark wrote 16:19. Who among us is qualified to say that he was deceived?

It would seem to be obvious that the more preposterous the pericope is affirmed to be, the more difficult it becomes to explain how it imposed itself on the Church universal, beginning in the second century (at least). In fact, if the passage contains difficulties this would easily account for its omission in certain quarters. The perceived difficulties would be a more than sufficient stimulus to activate editors and copyists trained in the Alexandrian school of textual criticism. Indeed, in our own day there are not a few who find the content of Mark 16:9-20 to be unpalatable and greet the claim that the passage is spurious with relief.

Hopefully all concerned will agree that the identity of the text of Scripture is to be established on the basis of the evidence, not personal prejudice. I submit that the evidence in this case is perfectly clear and that the overwhelming testimony of the Church down through the centuries should be loyally accepted.

I see a corollary here: not only is Mark 16:9-20 vindicated, but codices B and ℵ stand convicted of containing 'poison'. They also contain the poison (mentioned above) in Matthew 1:7, 1:10 and 1:18, Mark 6:22, Luke 3:33 and 23:45, John 1:18 and 1 Corinthians 5:1. Does this not diminish their credibility as witnesses?

I confess that I am puzzled at the dedication and industry of the opponents of these verses. Why do they go to such lengths and expend so much energy to discredit them? Another curious feature of their work is the frequent misrepresentation of the evidence. For instance, in his advice to translators about how to proceed at the end of verse 8, A. Pope suggests putting the following:

"[Some manuscripts end at this point]

[In some manuscripts the following words are found]
SHORTER ENDING
[In some manuscripts the following words are found after verse 8]
LONGER ENDING"[a]

What interests me here is the lack of semantic precision in the use of the word "some". The first time it means "three". The second time it means "six". The third time it means "about 1,700"! Will the unsuspecting reader of Pope's article not be misled? And if anyone follows Pope's advice will not his readers also be misled?

I wonder sometimes if people really believe what the glorified Jesus said in Revelation 22:19.

60) Mark 16 revisited

Recently an article written by Peter M. Head, "A Case against the Longer Ending of Mark", came to my attention. He trots out a fairly complete list of the arguments that are usually levelled against Mark 16:9-20, but then offers one that I do not remember seeing before.

- **The lack of any meeting in Galilee predicted in Mark 14:28 and 16:7.** This is a major problem with the Longer Ending of Mark—it doesn't deliver what both Jesus and the angel promised would take place!

Well dear me, how does that follow? On what basis does Head claim that Mark had to 'deliver' anything? Does Mark say that the 'meeting' did not take place? Luke also does not mention any Galilee meeting; so does Head question the legitimacy of

[a] *Selected Technical Articles Related to Translation*, Oct., 1984, p. 22. Pope should also have mentioned that in the six MSS that have the 'shorter ending' the 'longer ending' is also found (so they are convicted of having an obvious conflation, and therefore of being corrupt).

Luke as well? But there is a more serious problem with his thesis. If it is intolerable that the last twelve verses of Mark do not mention a Galilee meeting, then it is equally intolerable that the Gospel should end at verse eight! 2 + 2 = 4. To say that the original ending disappeared without leaving a trace is to deny the divine inspiration of Mark's Gospel. There is no point in God inspiring if He is not going to preserve. Even enemy of the NT Ernest Cadman Colwell recognized this. He wrote that if God had inspired the NT, He would have preserved it; He did not preserve it, therefore He did not inspire it ("Biblical Criticism: Lower and Higher", *Journal of Biblical Literature*, LXVII (1948), 10-11). I believe that I have demonstrated that God did indeed preserve it, and therefore He must have inspired it.

With reference to Codex Sinaiticus, discussing the falsified folded sheet that presently contains the ending of Mark and beginning of Luke, Head wrote: "the so-called longer ending of Mark could never have fit on this sheet". I personally examined a facsimile of the Codex at the Newberry Library in Chicago, and I guarantee the following.

The end of Mark and beginning of Luke occur on page 3 (of the four); pages 1 and 4 contain an average of 17 lines of printed Greek text[a] per column (there are four columns per page), just like the rest of the codex. Page 2 contains an average of 15.5 lines of printed text per column (four columns);[b] the first column of page 3 contains only **twelve** lines of printed text and in this way part of verse 8 occupies the top of the second column, the rest of which is blank (except for some designs). Luke begins at the top of column 3, which

[a] Different published Greek texts may give slightly different numbers, but the conclusion will be the same.

[b] Just by the way, Aleph is the only known Greek MS of the NT with four columns, which indicates that it was not prepared for ordinary use. It is a museum piece.

contains 16 lines of printed text while column 4 is back up to 17 lines. On page 2 the forger began to spread the letters, displacing six lines of printed text; in the first column of page 3 he got desperate and displaced **five** lines of printed text, just in one column! In this way he managed to get two lines of verse 8 over onto the second column, thereby avoiding the telltale vacant column (as in B). That second column would accommodate 15 more lines of printed text, which with the other 11 make 26. Verses 9-20 occupy 23.5 such lines, so there is plenty of room for them (there would even have been a little space at the end of the second column, like in B`s second column). It really does seem that there has been foul play, and there would have been no need for it, unless the first hand did in fact display the disputed verses. In any event, ℵ as it stands is a forgery, and therefore may not legitimately be alleged as evidence against them.

Head demonstrates the predilection for the earliest witnesses that is typical of practitioners of eclecticism. I would say that they ignore a plain physical fact: books that are used wear out. Is it not obvious that a book that survived for 1,500 years or more was not used? At that time copies of the NT were hard to come by, and any decent copy would have been used. I would say that the earliest extant copies were so bad that people simply refused to use them. The oldest Syriac MS is so bad that it was scraped off to make room for something else (a palimpsest); the same holds for GA 04. GA 01 (*Sinaiticus*) and 03 (*Vaticanus*) are among the worst copies that we have. Just in the four Gospels they disagree between themselves over 3,000 times (apart from the times that they are both wrong), which number does <u>not</u> include itacisms and alternate spellings of the same word. In fact, they are not true copies at all; they are fabricated copies (and therefore

dishonest copies).[a] They are not part of any demonstrable line of transmission.

Whenever you read an article that questions the integrity of the Biblical Text, you need to think about the author's presuppositions. More often than not, he does not believe in the divine inspiration of that Text, and he certainly does not believe in its divine preservation. It follows that his working model does not allow for the supernatural. That is a problem, because both God and Satan exist, and both were involved in the transmission of the Text. It is also certain that he did not consult the Holy Spirit as he worked, and he thereby condemned himself to never arrive at a correct understanding of what actually happened. A mind that is not under the protection of the Holy Spirit will certainly suffer satanic interference (Ephesians 2:2), and most especially when it is dealing with the Biblical Text (2 Corinthians 4:4).

61) Mary's genealogy

Luke 3:23

Και αυτος ἦν ὁ Ιησους, ὡσει ετων τριακοντα αρχομενος, ων ὡς ενομιζετο υἱος Ιωσηφ, του Ηλει, του Ματθαν, του Λευι, του Μελχι,…

There are four words here that invite special attention: *και, αυτος, ἦν* and *ὡς*. Since verse 22 ends with a statement from the Father at Jesus' baptism, it is clear that verse 23 begins another section. But the conjunction that signals the transition is *και* and not *δε*, as one would expect—this means that 'Jesus' continues as the topic. But in that event, how does one explain the personal pronoun *αυτος*, the more so in such an emphatic position? If the author's purpose was simp-

[a] Recall that apart from GA 03, with its vacant column, and the falsified GA 01, GA 304 is the only other extant continuous text MS that omits the verses; this against some 1,700 extant continuous text Greek MSS that contain them.

ly to register Jesus as a son of Joseph, as many suppose, why didn't he just write *και ὁ Ιησους, ἦν υἱος Ιωσηφ*, etc.?

But then, why write *ὡς ενομιζετο*? It seems to me that the normal meaning of "as was supposed" is to affirm that Jesus was in fact Joseph's son; but that is precisely what Jesus **was <u>not</u>**. Luke has already made clear that Jesus' real Father was the Holy Spirit—1:34-35, 43, 45; 2:49. So what Luke is really saying is that although the people supposed Jesus to be Joseph's son, He actually had a different lineage—we should translate "so it was supposed". (Recall that a faithful and loyal translation seeks to transmit correctly the meaning intended by the <u>author</u>.)

The verb *ἦν* is the only independent one in the whole paragraph, verses 23-38. Is it working with the participle *αρχομενος* in a periphrastic construction? That appears to be the tendency of the eclectic text that places the participle right after Jesus (following less than 2% of the Greek MSS), which makes Jesus out to be in fact Joseph's son. It seems to me to be far more natural to take the participial clauses as being circumstantial: "beginning at about thirty years of age" and "being (so it was supposed) a son of Joseph." Setting those two clauses aside, the independent clause that remains is *ἦν ὁ Ιησους του Ηλει*, "Jesus was of Eli".

The participle 'beginning' requires an object, that the Text leaves implicit; from the context it seems clear that we may supply 'His ministry', or some such thing, which is why most versions do so. I suggest the following rendering: "Beginning *His ministry* at about thirty years of age, being (so it was sup-posed) a son of Joseph, Jesus was actually of Eli, of Mathan, of Levi…" I take it that the emphatic pronoun *αυτος,* heightens the contrast between what the people imagined and the reality. Jesus was a grandson of Eli, Mary's father—Luke gives the genealogy of Jesus through His mother, while Matthew gives it through His adoptive father. Jesus received

some of David's genes through Mary and Nathan; the glorified body now at the Father's right hand, and that will one day occupy David's throne, has some of his genes.

The eclectic text gives our verse a different wording: *και αυτος ἦν Ιησους αρχομενος ὡσει ετων τριακοντα, ων υίος, ὡς ενομιζετο, Ιωσηφ του Ηλι του Μαθθατ του Λευι του Μελχι, …* The RSV translates it like this: "Jesus, when he began his ministry, was about thirty years of age, being the son (as was supposed) of Joseph, the son of Heli, the son of Matthat …" Is not the normal meaning of this rendering that Jesus was in fact the son of Joseph? However, every version that I recall seeing has "Joseph, the son of Heli", which directly contradicts Matthew, "Jacob begot Joseph". The word 'son' (without the article) occurs only with Joseph, although most versions supply it on down the genealogy. But Luke is precisely correct in not using it, because it would not hold for the first and last names in the list—Eli did not beget Jesus (nor Joseph) and God did not beget Adam.

So then, properly understood Luke does not contradict Matthew (with reference to Joseph's father), nor does he affirm an error of fact (with reference to Jesus' father).

62) 'Meek' is not 'weak'

Matthew 5:5

What we need to understand is what Jesus intended to say. We need to interpret from His point of view, not ours, or anyone else's. First: 'meek' is not 'weak', it is power under control. A little kitten is merely weak; a lion can act in a meek way, with its claws withdrawn (with animals we use 'tame'). Further, to be meek is not to remain passive in the presence of evil, nor is it to remain inert when God is working on you. It could be the lack of personal ambition, but that does not jive with the second half of the verse. Second: "inherit the earth" is not a synonym for 'go to heaven' (nor for receiving

spiritual blessings); the earth is one thing and Heaven is another (and spiritual life yet another). Also, 'the' earth (the Text has the definite article) must refer to this present earth, not to a new or different one. Surely, because there is only this earth in the context, and the Apocalypse would not be written for another 60 years.

We may begin with Moses. Numbers 12:3 says: "Now the man Moses was very meek, above all the men that were upon the face of the earth".[a] Hey, wait a minute! How could he be the meekest man on the planet? He could, precisely because he was also the most powerful man on the planet, in his day. Moses was not weak, he was meek. Further, he did not remain passive in the presence of evil, nor did he remain inert while God was working on him.

Then there is Sovereign Jesus, while He walked this earth. Matthew 11:29 says: "Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, because I am meek and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls". Jesus declared Himself to be 'meek'. Can anyone imagine that Jesus was weak? I think not! Much like Moses, Jesus was meek precisely because He was the most powerful, in His day. It is more than clear that He did not remain passive in the presence of evil, nor did He remain inert about the suffering determined by the Father.

Very well, meek is power under control, but just how can the meek 'inherit the earth'? To begin, they will need power, lots of power. Then, they will need to know how to make use of that power. Surely, because in order to inherit the earth they will have to take it out of Satan's hand. Has anyone forgotten Luke 4:6? While Satan was testing Jesus, he offered Him the world, saying, "because it was handed over to me, and I give it to whomever I want to!" Recall that Jesus did not deny Satan's right to do so. It is true that Jesus won the victory

[a] Taken from the translation of the Jewish Publication Society.

over Satan by the cross and the resurrection, but for His own reasons God permits Satan to continue operating in this world as if he were still the owner. It is up to us to oblige the enemy to acknowledge his defeat. It is up to us to "undo the works of the devil" (1 John 3:8); yes, because Jesus said, "Just as the Father sent me, I also send you" (John 20:21). Well then, where is the necessary power for doing it?

We may begin with Ephesians 3:20—"Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to the power that is working in us, to Him be the glory in the Church in Christ Jesus, …" The range of my imagination represents my personal limit; obviously I will not ask for something that I cannot even imagine. But the power that is working in me (us) "is able to do immeasurably more". In other words, on God's side the power is unlimited. It is on our side that the business fails. We do not know how to ask, or what to ask for, and even less how to use such power. But that the power is available to us, yes it is.

Consider Ephesians 1:19-21. Paul is praying for the Ephesians, and he asks that they may be able to know three things, including:

> What the exceeding greatness of His power into us who are believing, according to the demonstration of the extent of His might which He exercised in the Christ when He raised Him[S] from among the dead and seated Him at His[F] right, in the heavenly realms, far above every ruler and authority and power and dominion[a]—even every name that can be named, not only in this age but also in the next.

[a] It is generally understood that the reference is to the angelic hierarchy. The two thirds that remained faithful to God were never a problem, so presumably the special point is that Christ defeated Satan, with his one third, and is now (as the God/man, the second Adam) seated 'far above' that enemy.

The Text does actually say "power into us who are believing"—please note that the power is to be within us, but the verb 'believe' is in the present tense; that you believed yester-day is not enough, you must be believing today. Note also Christ's present position: at the Father's right, far above any and all ranks and names, which includes the angelic beings and Satan himself. Now consider Ephesians 2:5-6—"But God, **…** made us alive together with Christ**…** and raised us up together and seated us together in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus". This is tremendous! Here we have our position and authority. If we are in Christ we are at the Father's right, and therefore we too are above the enemy and all his host.

Now consider Luke 10:19—"Take note, I am giving[a] you the authority to trample on snakes and scorpions,[b] and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing at all may harm you."

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[a] Instead of 'am giving', perhaps 2.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have 'have given' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.)—a serious error. Jesus said this perhaps five months before His death and resurrection, addressing the seventy (not just the twelve). The Lord was talking about the future, not the past; a future that includes us!

[b] The Lord gives us the authority to "trample snakes and scorpions". Well now, to smash the literal insect, a scorpion, you do not need power from on High, just a slipper (if you are fast you can do it barefoot). To trample a snake I prefer a boot, but we can kill literal snakes without supernatural help. It becomes obvious that Jesus was referring to something other than reptiles and insects. I understand Mark 16:18 to be referring to the same reality—Jesus declares that certain signs will accompany the believers (the turn of phrase virtually has the effect of commands): they will expel demons, they will speak strange languages, they will remove 'snakes', they will place hands on the sick. ("If they drink**…**" is not a command; it refers to an eventuality.) But what did the Lord Jesus mean by 'snakes'?

In a list of distinct activities Jesus had already referred to demons, so the 'snakes' must be something else. In Matthew 12:34 Jesus called the Pharisees a 'brood of vipers', and in 23:33, 'snakes, brood of

Since Jesus has been given "all authority in heaven and on earth" (Matthew 28:18), He is certainly competent to delegate some of that authority to us. Now then, authority gives orders to power. Since Satan's power is a malignant power, we should not think of using it to do good; to do good we have the power of Christ, that is far greater. I believe that we should use our delegated authority to prohibit the use of Satan's power, against us and in other circumstances—based on my own experience, I would say that it is necessary to be specific. When Jesus said "and nothing at all may harm you," I take it that He was presupposing that we would be using our delegated authority to forbid any initiative against us. I do this every day. However, the protection is not absolute; every now and again my Owner allows the enemy to get to me. And why would God do that? I understand that it is to keep me humble and dependent.

But just how do we manage to 'inherit the earth'? How much space can a solitary person occupy? For example, in order to transform a neighborhood, I suppose it will require a collective effort from the 'meek' who live there. By definition, the 'meek' are people who know how to use God's power and are disposed to do so. They should also know how to be

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vipers'. In John 8:44, after they claimed God as their father, Jesus said, "You are of your father the devil". And 1 John 3:10 makes clear that Satan has many other 'sons'. In Revelation 20:2 we read: "He seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is a slanderer, even Satan, who deceives the whole inhabited earth, and bound him for a thousand years." If Satan is a snake, then his children are also snakes. So then, I take it that our 'snakes' are human beings who chose to serve Satan, who sold themselves to evil. I conclude that the 'snakes' in Luke 10:19 are the same as those in Mark 16:18, but what of the 'scorpions'? Since they also are of the enemy, they may be demons, in which case the term may well include their offspring, the humanoids [see "As were the Days of Noah", item 6) above]. I am still working on the question of just how the removal is done.

guided by the Holy Spirit. And it will be even better if at least one of them is maintaining an intimate relationship with God to the point that he can know what the Father is doing (John 5:19).[a] Still, in general terms, since "the Son of God was manifested for this purpose: to undo the devil's works" (1 John 3:8), I believe that we may and should take action against anything that is of the enemy. Since God Himself hates "all workers of iniquity" (Psalm 5:5), I take it that we also can and should do so.[b] And in Psalm 97:10 we have a command to hate evil. So how may we remain passive in the presence of evil if we are commanded to hate it? And then there is the very nature of *agape* love: it necessarily includes the hating of evil, because of the consequences of evil against the loved ones.

Let us give a little more thought to the idea of remaining passive in the presence of evil. In Ephesians 6:10-11 we are commanded to "be strong in the Lord and in His mighty power" and to "put on the full armor of God". What for? Consider 2 Corinthians 10:3-5.

> Well, we do walk about in flesh, but we do not wage war that way,[c] **4**because the weapons of our warfare are not physical, but are powerful in God for demolishing strongholds:[d]

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[a] Psalm 32:8-9 also deals with intimacy: "I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will guide you with my eye. Do not be like the horse… whose mouth must be held in with bit and bridle." To guide with the eye requires intimacy, and to develop intimacy requires time.

[b] In John 6:44 Sovereign Jesus declared: "No one is able to come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him". (With objects the verb 'draw' means 'drag'.) So, would the Father 'draw' someone that He hates?

[c] Well, at least we shouldn't!

[d] The subject of biblical spiritual warfare is generally not well understood in Christian circles. Much of what has been written

[5]demolishing sophistries[a] and every arrogance that sets itself up against the knowledge of God; taking captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ."[b]

If we have weapons for waging war, it is because we are supposed to be doing it! Psalm 78:9-10 is to the point: "The children of Ephraim, being armed and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle. They did not keep the covenant of God; they refused to walk in His law." God considered those men to be traitors; by refusing to fight, albeit well-armed, they broke the covenant. So there it is: if we have weapons for waging war, it is because we are supposed to be doing it! Of course, because the enemy of our souls never stops attacking us; never.

But just how does one go about forbidding and undoing the enemy's works? As part of the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. Now the Text declares that this sword is "the *ρημα* of God"—*ρημα*, not *λογος*. It is God's Word spoken, or applied in a specific way. Really, what good is a sword left in its sheath?

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concerns defensive procedures, but this text speaks of demolishing strongholds (presumably the enemy's, since no one will want to destroy his own), that has to do with taking the offensive. For more on this subject the reader may consult my site: www.prunch.org.

[a] A sophistry is a false argument that is presented in such a way as to appear correct, and impressive, especially if not properly analyzed. Satan has purveyed a number of sophistries designed to keep people from the knowledge of God, such as humanism, relativism, materialism, Freudianism, and so on.

[b] I suppose that the two gerunds—'demolishing sophistries' and 'taking captive every thought'—are some of our weapons, being grammatically subordinated to 'demolishing strongholds'. In the context, the thoughts we take captive are not our own (though that also is a good thing to do), but those of the enemy's servants. I do this in so many words, aloud or in thought, and thereby avoid unnecessary complications.

However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.

In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1, 18:36, 2 Kings 1:10). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:19). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak!

Here in Brazil, there are said to be many millions of 'believers' (up to 35), but they evidently are making very little difference in the national life. Satan controls all the governments—federal, state, county. Satan controls the education, the instruction, at all levels (beginning with the nurseries). Satan controls the health services, the commerce, the media, the culture, the entertainment, and a fair share of the churches—any church with a pastor who is a Freemason is in Satan's hand (in Brazil many hundreds of pastors are Freemasons). Well dear me, how may it be possible to 'inherit the earth' in a country like Brazil? What can we do in concrete terms so as to change that reality?

I would like to offer a proposal, as follows. Consider the public schools in a given town, both grade and high. It has been a while since they were taken over by demons, drugs, sex, crime violence—the teachers have a hard time to even maintain a semblance of order; to teach something constructive has become almost impossible. The time has come for a collective effort by the 'meek' who live in that town. With the authority and the power available to them, they can clean up their schools: they should send the demons to the Abyss, forbidding any others to take their place; they should declare

the premises to be off limits to any drug, illicit sex, indecent conduct, crime, violence, and whatever else the local situation dictates; thereupon the teachers can get back to teaching, in an ambient of peace and respect. Now then, in neighboring towns there will be no lack of distressed parents, seeing their children being damaged at school. When they hear of the transformation going on in the schools of the neigh-boring town, what will they do? They will run over to find out how it was achieved; and in that way the transformation will spread. What was done in the schools can be done in other areas as well; health, commerce, government, and so on, until the whole country is changed, thereby inheriting the land where they live.[a]

"The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are bold as a lion" (Proverbs 28:1). Really now, how many believers do you know who conduct themselves like lions? A lion can act in a tame way, but can also be a fearsome beast. The prophet Elijah was a lion type, and the third captain fell on his knees before him (2 Kings 1:13). A lion type believer knows that he can be bold because "the eyes of Jehovah run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him" (2 Chronicles 16:9). "Since God is for us, who is against us?" (Romans 8:31). So take courage! Have at it!

63) Merciful receives mercy

Matthew 5:7

It seems clear that the purpose of this 'beatitude' is to encourage mercy. We need to understand the difference between grace and mercy. To receive grace is to be awarded

[a] I happen to believe that we will participate in the administration of the Messianic Kingdom, as well as of the new earth, but that is a different topic.

an undeserved benefit (deserved benefit is salary). On the other hand, to be contemplated with mercy is to not receive a deserved punishment, a negative consequence of what was done. Part of the importance of this 'beatitude' derives from the fact that the opposite is also true: whoever is not merciful will also not receive mercy. Consider.

In Psalm 18:25, which is a copy of 2 Samuel 22:26, the correct translation would be this: "With the merciful you will show yourself merciful." In Hosea 6:6, which is quoted by Jesus in Matthew 9:13 and 12:7, we read: "I desire mercy and not sacrifice; and the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings". Consider also Micah 6:8: "He has shown you, O man, what is good; and what does Jehovah require of you but to do justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?" But in Luke 6:36 the Lord Jesus sets the standard at the highest possible level: "So be compassionate, even as your Father is compassionate!" Attention, thinking that a goal or standard is beyond our reach does not invalidate that standard—any standard set by God is independent of human capability.

In James 2:12-13 we read: "Speak and act as being those who are about to be judged by a law of liberty 13 (the judgment will be without mercy to the one not showing mercy).[a] *That law* exalts mercy[b] over judgment." This agrees with the description of Himself that Jehovah gave Moses on that rarest of occasions: "Jehovah, God, merciful and gracious, longsuffering, and abounding in goodness and truth,

[a] Even though inserted as an aside, this is a very serious bit of information!

[b] Perhaps 20% of the Greek manuscripts have 'mercy' in the nominative case, making it the subject of the verb (as in most versions), but some 80%, including the best line of transmission, have 'mercy' in the accusative case, making it the direct object (which to me makes much better sense).

keeping mercy unto the thousandth generation, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, by no means clearing the guilty, visiting the iniquity of the parents upon the children and the children's children to the third and the fourth generation" (Exodus 34:6-7). He keeps mercy to the 1000th generation, He punishes to the 4th; the proportion is 250:1. Hence the importance of mercy in our behavior.

The statement made in James 2:13 is terrible: "judgment will be without mercy to the one not showing mercy." I believe this applies mainly to those who have received mercy. The parable inserted in Matthew 18:21-35 is relevant. The king forgave a terribly large sum to the first slave, who in turn did not want to forgive a paltry sum to a fellow slave. In verse 33 the king addresses the first one like this: "Were you not obligated to have mercy on your fellow servant, just as I had mercy on you?" The fact that God has forgiven me obliges me to forgive others.[a]

64) Museum pieces

Persecuted people have neither the leisure nor the means to work on museum pieces. During the first three centuries the true Christians were an unpopular minority, both with the Roman Empire and the Jewish Establishment. Often the persecution was overt. Once Christianity became a state religion, rulers would have the means to cover the cost.

Consider the 'purple MSS', of which there are four of any size: GA 022, 023, 042 and 043. The parchment (leather) was stained purple and the text was written with silver ink. Now then, such documents were not prepared for ordinary use, because ordinary use would wear them out. For ordinary use

[a] In Luke 9:52-56 we find a negative example. The "sons of thunder", James and John, wanted to destroy the village, but Jesus immediately rebuked them.

you use ordinary materials. So why would someone contract the production of a 'purple MS'? Might a ruler think that thereby he could curry favor with God? Or might it be a symbol of the state religion? And who would be called upon to do the work? It would certainly be an artisan, not a textual scholar. An artisan would know nothing about textual quality; he would simply use whatever exemplar was handy, or was handed to him. If he made mistakes, no one would ever notice them. I consider the purple MSS to be museum pieces. They were not part of the normal transmission.

Now consider the MSS with fancy and expensive artwork. Again, such documents were not being prepared for ordinary use. In 2014 I spent nine days on the Mt. Athos peninsula, with its twenty independent monasteries. I visited five of them. I talked with the librarian of three of them. I was taken to the treasury of two of them. The only MSS that are in the treasuries are those with fancy and expensive artwork; the quality of text is simply not a factor. When talking with the librarians I raised the matter of lines of textual transmission in the MSS and was met with a blank look; they had no idea what I was talking about (their life is governed by tradition). But why was that artwork created? Why were elaborate cathedrals constructed? I suppose it was their way of honoring God. Monks in monasteries all have a work assignment: some work in the kitchen, some work in the garden, some copy manuscripts and some do artwork; it is their religious duty. The artist doing the artwork would know nothing about the quality of the text that his work was decorating. Some of the ink colors may have been almost as precious as gold or silver, not easy to come by. Decorated MSS were not for ordinary use and thus had a chance to survive. They were museum pieces.

Now consider the number of columns of text per page. About 10% of the papyri have two columns, the rest have one

column. As for the uncials: one has four columns, GA 01 (Aleph); three have three columns, GA 03 (B), 048 and 053; around 55% have two columns, and the rest have one. As for the minuscules: GA 460 has three columns; less than 15% have two columns, and the rest have one. For ease of reading, one column is best and two is alright; three and four are inferior. Codex Aleph (Sinaiticus) is a curiosity: its text is clearly fabricated, not belonging to any known line of transmission. With four columns it evidently was not intended for public reading or ordinary use. Codex B (Vaticanus) is also a curiosity: its text is also clearly fabricated, not belonging to any known line of transmission. Besides having three columns, it is written on very fine vellum, and therefore was not intended for public reading or ordinary use. I would say that those two MSS, along with A, D, W and others, survived because they were not used, and they were not used because the quality of their text was too poor to be used. They are museum pieces.

I believe that from the very beginning the Christians used books, not scrolls, to make copies of the NT writings. A book is more efficient and practical. With a book you can easily find the place you are looking for; with a scroll it is far more difficult. A book is written on both sides of the sheet, while a scroll is written on only one side, so a scroll wastes half of the available space. With the need to proliferate copies, the Christians could not afford to waste that space. And what material could they use? Before the invention of paper, there was just papyrus and parchment. Papyrus would be far more plentiful and less expensive than parchment (leather). Further, papyrus is simply not an adequate material for making scrolls; it is more suited for making books.

However, there is definitely a down-side to using papyrus. It is fragile. It is made with strips of pith from the stem of the papyrus plant. If it gets wet, it falls apart. Although it is

vegetable, it is impervious; ink does not sink in, but dries as a crust on the surface. If you flex the sheet, the ink may fly off, leaving no trace on the papyrus. A book on papyrus sent from congregation to congregation would probably be falling apart before it got to the twentieth one. To survive for seventeen or eighteen centuries a manuscript on papyrus would have to be buried in desert sand without having been used. Our oldest papyrus manuscript of any size, P^{66}, has an average of two mistakes per verse, stupid mistakes, nonsensical mistakes. It would be psychologically impossible to use it for devotional reading or study, so it was buried in desert sand. $P^{45,46,47,75}$ are all bad, and they survived because they were buried in desert sand, without having been used. (Personally, the only value that I ascribe to those early papyri is that they prove that any reading that they contain is early—veritable museum pieces.)

So, what is my point; why did I write this article? My point is that 'museum pieces' were not prepared in order to preserve a pure text; they were prepared for other reasons. It follows that we should not expect to find a good text in museum pieces, and therefore they should not be depended upon as we work to identify the original wording of the Text. Any and all MSS need to be placed in a line of transmission; a copy that is not part of a line of transmission is a fabricated copy, not an honest one.

From the very beginning, the vast majority of copies of the NT writings were made by honest people, people sincerely trying to make faithful copies. Those copies were made to be used, and therefore were worn out and could not survive, the more so if made on papyrus. That is why there are no 'Byzantine' MSS from the earliest centuries. The earliest MSS that are even partially Byzantine are usually dated to the fifth century. **However**, before 1881, the academic world, including Westcott himself (!), held that the Syriac Peshitta was produced in the second century, and its text is heavily

'Byzantine'. The Latin tradition is more Byzantine than anything else. Even the Coptic tradition is half Byzantine. Whoever produced P^{66} had a second century Byzantine exemplar, because he alternated freely between 'Byzantine' and 'Alexandrian' readings. It follows that the Byzantine text certainly existed in the second century. I hold that Family 35 was the core of the Byzantine tradition.

65) Peter's mother-in-law

Matthew 8:14-15 X Mark 1:29-31, Luke 4:38-39

For most of my adult life, I assumed that Jesus healed Peter's mother-in-law only once, until one day it occurred to me that some of the details do not match. Consider: although the details of the actual healing are slightly different in the three accounts, they could be harmonized to come out with a single episode; it is the context that differs. Mark and Luke have the same context; the healing they record took place not long after the ministry in Samaria (John chapter four), but certainly before the 'Sermon on the Mount' recorded by Matthew. The context for the healing in Matthew is quite different, and happened after that 'Sermon'. As recorded by Matthew, Mark and Luke, I would say that the events occurring between the two healings occupy the following stretches of Text: Matthew 4:23-8:13, Mark 1:32-45 and Luke 4:40-5:15. I see a practical application to this: just because God heals you one time does not mean that you will never get sick again (even with the same problem).

66) Poor in spirit

Matthew 5:3

The question before us is to understand what Jesus meant. We must interpret it from Jesus' point of view, not ours, or anyone else's. To be 'poor in spirit' means to have a

humble spirit. It is not about money; it is about attitude. The Bible that Jesus had was the Old Testament, and that is where we should look for the definition of the phrase.

> Isaiah 66:1-2—Thus says Jehovah: "Heaven is my throne, and earth is my footstool. Where is the house that you will build for me? And where is the place of my rest? For all these things my hand has made, and all those things exist," says Jehovah. "But on this one will I look: on him who is poor and of a contrite spirit, and who trembles at my word."

Jehovah identifies himself as the Creator of everything, and then says what kind of person He wants. The word 'poor' is allied to 'contrite', but the fundamental requirement is to tremble at the Word of God. A person who 'trembles' like this is acknowledging that this Word exercises objective authority over him.

Psalm 34:18 goes in the same direction: "Jehovah is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves such as have a contrite spirit." Psalm 51:17 also: "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit, a broken and contrite heart—these, O God, you will not despise." And Isaiah 57:15 also: "Thus says the High and Lofty One, who inhabits eternity, whose name is Holy: I dwell in the high and holy place, with him who has a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble, and to revive the heart of the contrite ones." And this matches 2 Chronicles 16:9: "The eyes of Jehovah run to and fro throughout the whole earth to show himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him." God is looking for whom He can bless. This is what is also found in James 4:6, 1 Peter 5:5 and Proverbs 3:34: "God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble."

Now then, Jesus said the Kingdom of God belongs to such people. If the Kingdom is theirs, they are part of that kingdom. No one enters the Kingdom without having a humble

spirit, but not everyone who has a humble spirit enters the Kingdom, not necessarily. We must remember that no benefit from the shed blood of the Lamb of God is automatic–everything is potential. God's promises need to be appropriated, but on the way the preconditions have to be met. God's part is guaranteed, but not ours; there are levels of appropriation. Remember the parable of the sower, or of the soils; the seeds that fell into the good soil produced at different levels—100%, 60%, 30%.

Consider Matthew 18:3—"Assuredly I say to you, unless you change and become like little children, you will not enter the Kingdom of the heavens." But why would Jesus have used a little child as a model? Well, they are literalists, they truly believe, they are dependent and teachable—we also have to understand that we are dependent on God, being open to His teachings; we must genuinely believe in His Word, taking that word literally (respecting the norms of language), knowing that this word is to be obeyed. And as we do so we will find that we are being blessed.

But how would all this work for an 'Indian' lost in the jungle, who has never heard of Jesus, a God who loves us, but who sets standards of conduct—never, nothing. Consider Acts 10:34-35; this is the case of the centurion Cornelius. After hearing his explanation, Peter declared: "Really, I comprehend that God is not One to show partiality, but in every ethnic nation whoever fears Him and works righteousness is acceptable to Him." Cornelius lived up to the light that he had, and God performed a miracle to give him more light. The same thing happened to the Ethiopian treasurer (Acts 8:26-39)—he lived up to the light that he had, and God performed a miracle to give him more light.

It is true that both Cornelius and the Ethiopian had some access to the Bible, which the 'Indian' would not have. But everyone is born with a conscience, and everyone has the

light of creation, Romans 1:20. There are cases in the annals of modern missions where God worked a miracle to bring more light to someone who was living up to the little light that he had. Our God is just. Jehovah's eyes roam the entire earth, seeing each ethnic group and the people who make it up, and He reaches out to anyone who is deserving it.

67) Poor Pilate—wrong place, wrong time

According to John 18:12, there was a *chiliarch* among those who went to the Garden of Gethsemane to arrest Jesus. Well now, a *chiliarch* commanded a thousand men (or perhaps a cohort, about 600). There would scarcely be more than one of them stationed in Jerusalem, so he was presumably the top commanding military officer in town. So what was the top military commander doing in Gethsemane at 2:00 a.m.? If he was there, it was because the governor, Pilate, had sent him. And why would Pilate do something like that? He had his reasons.

As governor, Pilate represented the Roman Empire. He was responsible for keeping the peace, according to Caesar's interests. In those days the city of Jerusalem was not very big, and keeping well informed would not have been difficult. Pilate was doubtless well aware of Jesus, and would have followed His career with attention. Someone with a large public following could be a threat. Moreover, since it was the chief priests' man who led the expedition, and they kept the prisoner, it is clear that they had gone to Pilate and convinced him that Jesus represented enough of a threat that something needed to be done about it. (Jesus had used violence in cleansing the temple, as well as totally disregarding their authority. Why would He not do the same against Rome?) Even so, just why Pilate decided to send his *chiliarch* is hard to say; perhaps to be sure that things were done

professionally, as well as to form a professional opinion as to the nature of the threat. Certain it is that Pilate and the chief priests had agreed on a plan of action, as John makes clear, a plan that included death by crucifixion.

Both Mark 15:1 and John 18:28 inform us that it was early morning when Jesus was taken to Pilate, but John 19:14 states that it was around 6:00 a.m. when Pilate pronounced sentence. Even allowing that 'around' 6:00 was perhaps five or ten minutes after the hour, it could not have been later than 5:30 when the chief priests pounded on Pilate's door. Now then, we all know that one just does not go pounding on a governor's door at such an hour, especially a conquered people. Not only that, Pilate was dressed and waiting. Actually, he had doubtless been up, waiting for the *chiliarch*'s report. But at that point he changed the game-plan. He went out and asked, "What accusation do you bring against this man?" (John 18:29). Their reply was petulant, "If he were not an evildoer, we would not have handed him over to you." They thought that they had an agreement, but something had made Pilate change his mind.

To understand what happened, we need to go back to Gethsemane, and the *chiliarch*. The traitor had told them that there would be eleven men besides Jesus, and that they had two swords (Luke 22:38). But they were country bumpkins with no fighting ability. Even so, the *chiliarch* probably had over twice as many men, and all were armed—he doubtless expected some attempt at resistance. When they arrived and stated their business, Jesus calmly identified Himself, but at His word they all fell to the ground (John 18:6). Later, after the traitor's kiss, Peter managed to slice off an ear, but not only did Jesus tell him to quit it, He healed the ear (Luke 22:51)! Then the disciples abandoned Jesus, and He allowed Himself to be bound, without resistance. So what sort of report would the *chiliarch* give to Pilate? It was more than

obvious that Jesus was no wild-eyed insurrectionist. He had supernatural power, and yet submitted peacefully. And Jesus was impressive! Pilate had to conclude that the picture that the chief priests had painted was wrong, and so the agreement could not stand.

Now a *chiliarch* was a hardened and seasoned warrior, not easily impressed. He probably told Pilate that if it were up to him, he would leave Jesus alone! But Pilate had to deal with the chief priests, and he knew it would not be easy. In Acts 3:13 Peter affirms that Pilate was determined to let Jesus go, but the chief priests got what they wanted in the end. Close attention to the Record makes clear that Peter's affirmation is correct. Pilate wanted no part of killing Jesus! He made repeated attempts to 'get off the hook'. Consider:

1) Pilate answered their petulant response with, "<u>You</u> take him and judge him according to your law." To this they responded, "We are not permitted to execute anyone." This exchange indicates that execution had been in the agreement, but Pilate also rubbed salt in their wound, making them recognize that they were a subjugated people. Even so, he told them to do the judging, which would make them responsible.
2) Luke 23:2 probably gives the first concrete accusation: "We found this fellow perverting the nation and forbidding to pay taxes to Caesar, declaring himself to be Christ, a king." The part about taxes was a plain lie, but the part about the Christ was true. In any case, Pilate could not safely ignore such accusations, so he interrogated Jesus.
3) Matthew 27:11, Mark 15:2, Luke 23:3 and John 18:33-38 all refer to this first interrogation. It revolved around the king-ship of Jesus, which could be a crime against Caesar. Jesus affirms that He is a king, but His kingdom "is not of this world" (John 18:36). A kingdom that was not of this world would not represent a threat to Rome. So Pilate

went out and said to the crowd, “I find no crime in him at all.” If there was no crime, there should be no punishment.

4) This led to a barrage of further accusations, to which Jesus did not answer, which surprised Pilate (Matthew 27:12-14, Mark 15:3-5 and Luke 23:5). But among the accusations they mentioned Galilee, which allowed Pilate to learn that Jesus was a Galilean, thereby belonging to Herod’s jurisdiction. As ‘luck’ would have it, Herod was in town and nearby. (He had doubtless been informed about what was afoot, since he also was up and dressed at that early hour.)
5) So Pilate sent Jesus to Herod, probably hoping that Herod would take responsibility. Luke is the only one who records this side-trip (23:7-12). But Jesus refused to speak; and what can you do with someone who won’t talk? From the Lord’s point of view, Herod was irrelevant; it was Pilate who had the authority to crucify. So, frustrated, Herod sent Him back, only now arrayed in a gorgeous robe. The whole side-trip probably took no more than fifteen minutes.
6) Poor Pilate, what was he to do? Next he tried the ‘releasing a prisoner at Passover’ gambit, hoping to release Jesus, but the crowd demanded Barabbas. (Both Matthew and Mark record that Pilate knew that the chief priests had acted out of envy.) In the middle of this proceeding, Pilate received a message from his wife, about her dream (Matthew 27:19) [she had probably been told why he didn’t go to bed that night]. When Pilate asked what he should do with Jesus, they demanded that he be crucified. When Pilate asked what evil Jesus had done, they just yelled all the louder. Luke gives us a little further information. Pilate affirmed that neither he nor Herod had found guilt in Jesus, but because of their fury he offered to flog Jesus, hoping that would appease them.
7) Matthew, Mark and John give some account of the treatment Jesus received from the soldiers. They made a crown

of thorns, probably poisonous, and then drove the thorns into His scalp by beating on the crown with a rod. The poison would cause the scalp to swell, and blood would ooze from the wounds. They covered His face with spittle. Although none of the Evangelists mentions it, Isaiah 50:6 was presumably fulfilled as well—a soldier grabbing a fist-ful of beard and giving a violent yank would tear away the skin holding the hair, which would leave a painful and ugly wound. The total effect must have been horrible, leaving Jesus unrecognizable—Isaiah 52:14 was literally fulfilled. Then Pilate had Him brought out and said, "Look at the man!" (He had repeated that he found no crime in Him.) Pilate was hoping that when the crowd saw how much Jesus had already suffered, they would be satisfied, but it only made them worse!

8) To their "Crucify! Crucify him!" Pilate answered, "<u>You</u> take and crucify him, because I find no crime in him." The Jews answered him, "We have a law, and according to our law he ought to die, because he made himself 'Son of God'!" That statement made Pilate more afraid than ever (John 19:6-8). So he took Jesus inside for a second interview. Although Pilate represented the greatest temporal power at that time, Jesus calmly affirmed that there was a higher power, and that He, Jesus, represented that higher power. It appears to me that Pilate at least half believed Him, because John 19:12 says, "From that moment Pilate really tried to release Him." But the Jews did an 'end run'.
9) They kept shouting: "If you release this fellow, you are no friend of Caesar's! Whoever makes himself a king is oppos-ing Caesar!" Oops! Pilate owed his position to Caesar's good graces, and simply could not afford to do something that could be construed (even with a little twisting) as treason. He was beaten and knew it. But he still managed to get them to declare that their only king was Caesar.

10) Sitting on the judgment seat, Pilate called for water, washed his hands in front of the crowd, and said: "I am innocent of the blood of this righteous man. It's your problem!" So in answer all the people said, "His blood be upon us and upon our children!" (Matthew 27:24-25). Terrible, terrible, terrible! This may well be the worst curse that any parents ever placed upon their descendants. Since Pilate declared Jesus to be righteous, and since the Jews took full responsibility, I suspect that God will not hold Pilate responsible. After all, he was fulfilling the Plan: Jesus had to die by crucifixion.

Before bringing this article to a close, I would like to call attention to several further items that bear on Pilate's attitude.

1) Pilate had Jesus' 'crime' posted in *three* languages; he evidently wanted as wide an audience as possible. All four Gospels mention this, and from them we may understand that the full Accusation was: This is Jesus the Natsorean, the King of the Jews. That Pilate put "**the** Natsorean" (<u>not</u> Natsarene [Nazarene]) indicates that he had researched Jesus. The reference is to Isaiah 11:1; Jesus was David's Branch, the Messiah. Pilate was making a statement. When the chief priests complained, he answered, "What I have written, I have written!" (John 19:21-22).
2) All four Gospels mention the burial, but only Mark registers that when Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate for permission to remove Jesus' body, Pilate was surprised that Jesus was already dead. So he summoned the centurion to confirm the fact (15:44-45). As soon as Jesus died, the centurion most probably had left the scene, going back to headquarters, leaving the four soldiers to guard the two malefactors. Of course, Pilate had experienced the three hours of darkness, and had felt the earthquake, but he was not on the scene. He knew that a person on a cross dies from

asphyxiation. The weight of the body pushes the diaphragm against the lungs and he can't breathe. Nailing the feet was a sadistic procedure that prolonged the agony—rather than die they would push against the nail to get a breath. Finally, when too weak to do that, they would die for lack of air. (That is why they broke the legs of the two thieves; they then died within a few minutes.) Jesus had been on the cross for six hours, but victims could last several times that long. Whether just then or later, Pilate doubtless got a full report from the centurion. Jesus had given a great shout and then died. Obviously, if you are dying without air, you can't shout! The centurion knew that the cross had not killed Jesus. But what mere human can just tell his spirit to leave? 2 + 2 = 4. Jesus had to be the Son of God.

3) Only Matthew mentions the sealing and guarding of the tomb (27:62-66). The chief priests went to Pilate requesting that the tomb be made secure until the third day. To this Pilate replied, "You have a guard; go make it as secure as you can!" His turn of phrase is interesting, "make it as secure as you can". In other words, he was hinting that it would not make any difference. I rather suspect that Pilate believed that Jesus would do what He said.

We learn from Tertullian that Pilate wrote a letter to the emperor suggesting that Jesus be added to the roster of Roman deities. Now to make a suggestion like that involved an element of risk. But evidently Pilate was sufficiently convinced that he took the risk. If I someday meet Pilate in Heaven, I will not be surprised. If his experience with Jesus resulted in his salvation, Pilate would likely suggest a different title for this study: Blessed Pilate—right place, right time!

68) “Projection”

Romans 6:5

I invite attention to Romans 6:5, that I would now translate like this: “Now since we have become united with Him through the projection of His death, we will certainly be so through that of His resurrection as well.” Instead of “through the projection”, most versions have ‘in the likeness’. Although the word ‘likeness’ is certainly in the Greek Text, I regret to have to say that my translation (on the market since 2013) omitted the word altogether, reading simply ‘in His death’. I do not remember why I did that; perhaps it was because I could not make sense of ‘likeness’. Just what might ‘the likeness of His death’ mean, and how does that ‘unite’ me with Him?

While translating Romans into Portuguese I bumped my nose on this verse again. In order to translate something, you need to decide what it means. ‘Likeness’ doesn’t make any better sense in Portuguese than it does in English. What to do? I decided to analyze the semantic area covered by the term—the semantic area of a word is determined by the sum of the contexts in which it may appropriately be used. When I am working with the Text, I always ask the Holy Spirit to illumine me as to the intended meaning. In this case, I believe He gave me the word ‘projection’—it remains for others to evaluate whether I was illumined, or not.

Let us analyze the term. The sun projects heat and light, this projecting being a result of something that happens within the sun, its internal combustion. When we are impacted by that heat and light, we share in the result of what happened within the sun. A firearm projects a bullet, so much so that it may be called a projectile. The projection of the bullet is the result of something that happens within the firearm—if you are hit by the bullet, you share in the result. Images that

are projected are caused by something that happens within the projector; and so on.

It is only when someone is appropriately impacted by the projection of the results of Christ's victory on the cross that he becomes united with Him. Now then, being impacted by a projection is one thing; taking advantage of the results that are projected is something else. Although all who live on this planet are impacted by the heat and light that the sun projects, obviously not all make equal use of that heat and light. It is equally obvious that Christians take advantage of the results of Christ's victory at very different levels.

Consider 2 Peter 1:2-4.

> "May grace and peace be multiplied to you through a real knowledge of God and of our Lord Jesus, **3**in that His divine power has granted to us all things *pertaining* to life and godliness, through the real knowledge of the One[a] who called us by glory and excellence, **4**through which[b] He has granted to us such precious and extraordinary promises, so that through these[c] you may become partakers of a divine nature,[d] having escaped the depravity that is in the world because of lust."

Please note verse 3: "His divine power has granted to us all things *pertaining* to life and godliness". These are things that Christ's victory projects toward us; it is up to us to take

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[a] Again, we only appropriate the complete provision for "life and godliness" to the degree that we grow in our genuine knowledge of God. As Creator He made everything upon which life depends, including life itself, but our understanding of and appreciation for His provision is measured by our relationship with Him.

[b] "Which" is plural and presumably refers back to "glory and excellence".

[c] The promises—but of course we have to appropriate them.

[d] There is no definite article with "divine nature"; "become" indicates a process—the more like Christ we become, the more divine will our nature be.

advantage of that bounty. I suppose that few of us would deny that we need help in that direction. That is where the Holy Spirit comes in.

Allow me to give my understanding of the sequence of events involved in receiving new life in Christ:

1) I believe into Jesus. The Text always has 'believe into' (*εις*) Jesus or His name, never 'believe in' (*εν*). A change of location is involved, from being outside of Christ to being in Him. That change involves commitment and a change of worldview.

2) He baptizes me with Holy Spirit. Matthew 3:11, Mark 1:8 and Luke 3:16 all have the Baptizer saying that Jesus will baptize people with Holy Spirit. In John 1:33 God Himself says it. So when and how does Jesus do it? I take it that after Pentecost He does so from His position at the Father's right hand (1 Peter 3:21-22), and He does it as soon as a person believes into Him. Cornelius offers a concrete example.[a] (Please see "Baptisms in the Bible", item #7 above.)

3) Holy Spirit regenerates me, giving me a new nature.

4) Probably at the same time, He baptizes me into Christ's body. 1 Corinthians 12:12-13 explains that it is the Holy Spirit who baptizes us into Christ: "…so also is Christ. For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body." The primary reference here is probably to the Church as being Christ's body.[b]

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[a] "To **Him** all the prophets bear witness that through His name everyone who believes into Him will receive forgiveness of sins." While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit fell on all who were hearing the message (Acts 10:43-44). This was the crucial bit of information they were waiting for, what they had to do to be saved. The minute Peter said, "believe into Jesus", they did! And the Holy Spirit came upon them!

[b] A secondary reference could be to Jesus' physical body. If we become part of Jesus' body, then whatever happened to that body happened to us. If that body died, we did. If it was buried, so were we. If it was

5) Then Holy Spirit takes up residence within me, and my body becomes His temple (1 Corinthians 6:19). It is the Holy Spirit within me who helps and enables me to appropriate the benefits that Christ's victory on the cross projects towards me.

"Now since we have become united with Him through the projection of His death, we will certainly be so through that of His resurrection as well." I suspect that "united with Him" is supposed to mean more than people tend to think. Just for starters, consider John 14:12: "Most assuredly I say to you, the one believing into me, he too will do the works that I do;[a] in fact he will do greater works than these,[b] because I am

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raised from the dead, we will be too. Correction—we already have new life in Christ, and are to live on that basis.

[a] This is a tremendous statement, and not a little disconcerting. Notice that the Lord said, "will do"; not 'maybe', 'perhaps', 'if you feel like it'; and certainly not 'if the doctrine of your church permits it'! If you believe you **will do!** The verb 'believe' is in the present tense, 2nd person singular; if you (sg) are believing you will do; it follows that if you are not doing it is because you are not believing. 2 + 2 = 4. Doing what? "The works that I do." Well, Jesus preached the Gospel, He taught, He cast out demons, He healed all sorts and sizes of sickness and disease, He raised an occasional dead person, and He performed a variety of miracles (water to wine, walk on water, stop a storm instantaneously, transport a boat several miles instantaneously, multiply food, shrivel a tree—and He implied that the disciples should have stopped the storm and multiplied the food, and He stated that they could shrivel a tree [Peter actually took a few steps on water]). So how about us? The preaching and teaching we can handle, but what about the rest? I once heard the president of a certain Christian college affirm that this verse obviously could not mean what it says because it isn't happening! Well, in his own experience and in that of his associates (cessationists all) I guess it isn't. But many people today cast out demons and heal. Miracles are also happening. So how about me? And you?

[b] Well now, if we cast out demons, heal and perform miracles, isn't that enough? Jesus wants more, He wants "greater things" than those just

going to my Father." And then there is Luke 10:19, Ephesians 1:19, Ephesians 3:20, and on, and on.

69) 'Prophets'

Matthew 2:23

> "And upon arriving he settled in a town called Natsareth [Branch-town], so that what was spoken through the prophets should be fulfilled, that He would be called a Natsorean [Branch-man]."

We know from Luke that Natsareth was Joseph's home—his house and business were waiting for him (although he had been gone for quite a while). The name of the town in Hebrew is based on the consonants **נצר** (*resh, tsadde, nun*), but since Hebrew is read from right to left, for us the order is reversed = n, ts, r. This word root means 'branch'. Greek has the equivalent for 'ps' and 'ks', but not for 'ts', so the transliteration used a 'dz' (*zeta*), which is the voiced counterpart of 'ts'. But when the Greek was transliterated into English it came out as 'z'! But Hebrew has a 'z', **ז** (*zayin*), so in transliterating back into Hebrew people assumed the consonants **נזר**, replacing the correct *tsadde* with *zayin*. This technical information is necessary as background for what follows.

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mentioned. Notice again that He said "will do", not maybe, perhaps, or if your church permits. But what could be 'greater' than miracles? This cannot refer to modern technology because in that event such 'greater things' would not have been available to the believers during the first 1900 years. Note that the key is in the Lord's final statement (in verse 12), "because I am going to my Father". Only if He won could He return to the Father, so He is here declaring His victory before the fact. It is on the basis of that victory that the 'greater things' can be performed. Just what are those 'greater' things? For my answer, see my outline, "Biblical Spiritual Warfare", available from my site: www.prunch.org.

Neither ‘Nazareth’ nor ‘Nazarene’, spelled with a *zayin*, is to be found in the Old Testament, but there is a prophetic reference to Messiah as the Branch, *netser*—Isaiah 11:1—and several to the related word, *tsemach*—Isaiah 4:2, Jeremiah 23:5, 33:15; Zechariah 3:8, 6:12. So Matthew is quite right—the prophets (plural, being at least three) referred to Christ as the Branch. Since Jesus was a man, He would be the ‘Branch-man’, from ‘Branch-town’. Which brings us to the word ‘natsorean’. The familiar ‘Nazarene’ (*Ναζαρηνος*) [Natsarene] occurs in Mark 1:24, 14:67, 16:6 and Luke 4:34, but here in Matthew 2:23 and in fourteen other places, including Acts 22:8 where the glorified Jesus calls Himself that, the word is ‘Natsorean’ (*Ναζωραιος*), which is quite different. (Actually, in Acts 22:8 Jesus introduced Himself to Saul as ‘the Natsorean’, which strict Pharisee Saul would understand as a reference to the Messiah.) I have been given to understand that the Natsareth of Jesus’ day had been founded some 100 years before by a Branch family who called it Branch town; they were very much aware of the prophecies about the Branch and fully expected the Messiah to be born from among them—they called themselves Branch-people (Natsoreans). Of course everyone else thought it was a big joke and tended to look down on them. “Can anything good …?”

The difficulty in this case is caused by differing phonologies; the sounds of Hebrew do not match those of Greek, or of English. Since proper names are often just transliterated, as in this case, and a translator will normally follow the phonology of the target language, what happened here was straightforward, without malice. We would have felt no inconvenience had Matthew not appealed to “the prophets”. It is the false transliteration going back to Hebrew, from either Greek or English, that creates the seeming difficulty.

70) Pure in Heart

Matthew 5:8

A pure substance, like honey, is unmixed, it is 100% honey. A pure person is without contamination. A pure heart unites both of these qualities. In 2 Chronicles 16:9 Jehovah looks for people "whose heart is loyal to Him"; it is the pure heart, uncontaminated with other gods.

Consider Psalm 24:3-4—"Who may ascend into the hill of Jehovah, or who may stand in His holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart." The cleanliness of hands spoken of here does not refer to physical dirt, but to moral dirt. Whoever has clean hands is not practicing sin. "Stand in His holy place" refers to being in the presence of God. Hebrews 12:14 declares that without holiness "no one shall see the Lord". James 4:8 states the matter as an order: "Sinners, cleanse your hands! Double-minded, purify your hearts!" These are the prerequisites for God to draw near to us.

Now then, to actually see God is a devastating experience, but it leads to a higher spiritual level. Consider the case of Job: "I have heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you. Therefore I abhor myself, and repent in dust and ashes" (Job 42:5-6). Hearing about it is one thing, seeing it is another! And also that of Isaiah: "Woe is me, for I am undone! Because I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, Jehovah of Hosts!" (Isaiah 6:5). Both men, Job and Isaiah, improved spiritually as a result.

Now consider the exhortation in 1 John 3:2-3—"We know that when He is revealed we will be like Him, because we will see Him just as He is–everyone who has this hope upon him purifies himself, even as He is pure." I take it that 'purifying oneself' means being careful about one's own holiness, to lessen the shock when we meet the Owner face to face.

Is the zeal for purity something we should develop on our own? 2 Timothy 2:22 implies that it is not: "pursue righteousness, faith, love, peace, along with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart." We should look for others who have the same spiritual purpose, to give and receive help and encouragement. Hebrews 3:13 is to the point—"Exhort yourselves every day, while it is called 'today', so that none of you be hardened through sin's deceitfulness."

71) Quirinius—Luke 2:2

It has been alleged that Luke's reference to Quirinius in Luke 2:2 is an error. If that were the case, it would be the only error in the dozens of historical references that Luke made. It is clear that Luke interviewed Mary, Jesus' mother, because several times he wrote that she treasured things in her heart. Such an interview would have been an obvious thing for him to do. Mary had been personally inconvenienced, and to a considerable extent, by Caesar's decree, and she would have had a vivid memory of all relevant factors at that time. If she told Luke that Quirinius was officiating, that was the fact, and of course Luke had access to other witnesses and the whole episode was recent history in his day.

Joseph undertook a very inconvenient and expensive journey from Natsareth to Bethlehem. He would only have done so if he considered that he had no viable alternative. It follows that Caesar's decree was a fact, and in force at that time. How could Luke possibly have been mistaken on the subject of Quirinius?

Quirinius, 51 BC – 21 AD, was an able Roman military commander. During his life he was a senator, a consul, a duumvir and a legate. He is famous for his campaign against the Homonadensians, a nomadic people in Cilicia. Cilicia bordered Syria on the north. The campaign occupied roughly 12-2 BC, and Quirinius would have used Syria as his base of

operations. He had the confidence of the emperor and may very well have been given a variety of jobs during that decade. In Luke 2:2 Luke did not use the noun 'governor'; he used the verb 'to govern /administer/officiate'. In those days a census took a lot of time, and could be a fussy undertaking. Whom should the emperor choose to run the show in Syria? Of the people available, who was better qualified than Quirinius?

Conclusion: Luke informs us that Quirinius was administering the census in Syria at the time of Jesus' birth. I see no reason to doubt his statement. I see no reason whatsoever for alleging that Luke wrote an historical error.

72) Relative (in part) X absolute

It has always been standard procedure for Satan and his servants to attack strong arguments in favor of the truth as if they were weak and wrong. In today's world, take a hard look at any 'principle' or 'law' that Satan is using, such as 'everything is relative' or 'hate speech'. It is the opposite that will be true. The purpose of this article is to take up the claim that 'everything is relative'. The statement itself, 'everything is relative', rejects the existence of the Sovereign Creator, because He cannot be 'relative', obviously. He is absolute. Anyone who rejects the Creator belongs to Satan's kingdom, and that is very serious.

To begin, the truth is not relative; neither is it democratic, it is not determined by human vote or opinion. The truth **is**. The truth, or actual fact, about anything is not relative, it is absolute. It is our perception, or opinion or interpretation that is 'relative'. That is because no one on earth has complete knowledge about anything; our 'knowledge' is condemned to be partial, incomplete. That is because we are finite, small, with limited mental capacity. We are surrounded by limitation: our bodies confine us to one place at a time, as well as

limit us in a variety of ways; our language limits how we think, as does our culture; our ignorance of the supernatural condemns us to be wrong about all sorts of things. As the Creator's Manual affirms, "we know in part" (1 Corinthians 13:9).

However, knowing in part does not mean that we do not know at all. It also does not mean that the `in part` is not real truth. If you cut off a piece from a beef steak, that piece does not stop being real meat—it is 'in part', but it is still real. Even though our knowledge is not complete, it can be adequate for practical purposes within a given context. Perhaps the most serious consequence of the doctrine that everything is relative has been the `conclusion` that man does not, and cannot, know anything for sure, that true knowledge does not exist. Facts are facts, and they exist. The sun exists, water exists, trees exist; fire is hot, ice is cold; 2 + 2 = 4. It was true knowledge that permitted a man to walk on the moon. To know for sure that fire is hot, just stick your hand in a fire.

I lived and worked with an indigenous people in the Amazon jungle for a number of years. They did not believe in germs and bacteria, because they couldn't see them. That did not prevent them from getting sick and dying. What they believed did not change the facts.

The C.S. Lewis Institute recently posted an article by Christopher L. Reese, "Isn't Morality Relative?"[a] It says some of what I want to say so well that I will repeat some of it.

> It is widely accepted in the Western world today that morality is relative. People who say this usually mean

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that morality is a matter of personal or cultural sentiment that has no objective basis in reality. Many modern people tend to think of the physical world as consisting of matters of fact (it's not relative whether water is H2O) but of morality as being a matter of subjective opinion.

If we accept the modern, secular story of the world, this is a natural belief. If there is no higher authority on moral issues than individual or group opinion, then moral judgments are indeed subjective. Further, if the naturalistic story is true, and all that exists are matter and energy governed by natural laws, then good and evil are illusory concepts with no basis in reality. After all, no material thing has the property of being good or evil; there are no good or evil atoms or molecules, thus, neither good nor evil exists. Yes, one could have ideas about good and evil on this view, but they wouldn't be any different from ideas about unicorns or leprechauns—none of these, in reality, would exist.

Well, up to a point. As I have already said, I lived and worked with an indigenous people in the Amazon jungle for a number of years. Although they had never been exposed to the Bible, they had a morality, they believed that some things are good and others are bad. If I am not mistaken, all cultures in the world have a morality of some sort. Without cultural norms, people cannot coexist peacefully. The Sovereign Creator, while walking this earth in the body of Jesus, gave the clue: "Beware of false prophets who come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves. You will know them by their fruits. Do people gather grapes from thorn bushes, or figs from thistles? Just so, every good tree produces good fruits, but the rotten tree produces evil

fruits"[a] (Matthew 7:15-17). Check the results of what people do; if the results are bad, then that activity is not good.

> Naturalism undermines any basis for objective moral values and duties. The key word here is objective, meaning something that exists or is true regardless of what any person or group of people believe about it. Even if every person in an ancient culture believed that human sacrifice was a good and necessary practice, they would still be objectively wrong—that is, if an objective standard of morality exists. And the only plausible candidate for such an objective standard is God, whose very nature determines what is good.
>
> Many who hold to a naturalistic worldview have never thought through its logical implications, especially in relation to morality. A number of leading naturalistic thinkers, though, have recognized and acknowledged that morality and naturalism are incompatible. It is difficult for most secular moderns to come to grips with this idea. One can hardly blame them, because the implications of naturalism are truly horrifying. It represents the complete dissolution of all objective meaning, value, purpose, and morality. [[**Is that not truly horrifying?**]] [In today's world, are not many people lost in a moral quagmire?]

All genuine science is based on the principle of cause and effect—we observe an effect and try to isolate the cause; and it is logically impossible for a cause to produce an effect larger or more complex than itself. Any human being who is both honest and intelligent, when confronted with the observable universe with its incredible organization and complexity, is obliged to conclude that there must be a

[a] The Lord uses 'rotten' and 'evil' (or 'malignant') because He is really talking about people, not trees.

CAUSE, a Cause with intelligence and power beyond our understanding—to refuse to do so is to be perverse.

The evolutionary hypothesis of origins is scientifically impossible; stupidly, ridiculously impossible. A number of decades ago the scholar Sir Frederick Hoyle was contracted to evaluate the scientific probability that life could have appeared on the planet by chance (he had unlimited funding and free access to libraries). He arrived at the following conclusion: it would be easier for a whirlwind to pass through a junk yard and a perfect Boeing 747 come flying out of the other side than for life to have appeared on our planet by chance. Well, well, well, that life could have originated by an evolutionary process is absolutely impossible: obviously, stupidly, ridiculously impossible. [By the way, any questions about the morality of the Creator have nothing to do with science.]

Since a Sovereign Creator exists, He holds absolute authority over what He has created. But in what ways can authority be exercised? It can be exercised by fiat, by sovereign intervention, but doing that to beings created in God's own image would turn them into robots, which would be contradictory to the purpose in creating such beings. As the Sovereign said to the Samaritan woman, while He walked this earth: "the true worshippers will worship the Father in spirit and truth; for the Father is seeking such to worship Him. God is Spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truth" (John 4:23-24). If the Father is seeking spontaneous, or at least voluntary, worship, then it cannot be coerced, or forced. But how can man know what the Sovereign Creator wants? There must be communication. But what form could such communication take? To communicate concepts, He would have to use human language. Since human language is governed by rules—phonological, grammatical, semantic—the Creator would have to limit Himself

to the repertoire of possibilities offered by the language of choice.

If the Creator was only concerned to transmit information to a given individual, or group, at a given point in time, for a specific purpose, it could be done orally, either speaking directly, or through a representative. But if the Creator's purpose was to furnish orientation that would be valid for subsequent generations as well, then the appropriate form would be in writing. Consider 1 Chronicles 16:15, "the word which He commanded for a thousand generations". Well now, there have scarcely been 300 generations since Adam, so the Creator's written revelation will be in effect until the end of the world. However, to be in effect until the end, it must be kept available until the end. For more about that, see my book, *God Has Preserved His Text* (sixth edition).

If the Sovereign Creator exists, and if He has addressed a written Revelation to our race, then nothing is more important for us than to know what He said (with a view to obeying it, if we are smart). This because such a revelation will have objective authority over us (although the Creator gives us the option of rejecting that authority [but due regard should be given to the consequences]). Objective authority depends on verifiable meaning; if a reader/hearer can give any meaning he chooses to a message, any authority it ends up having for him will be relative and subjective (the 'neo-orthodox' approach).

As a linguist (PhD) I affirm that the fundamental principle of communication is this: both the speaker/writer and the hearer/reader must respect the norms of language, in particular those of the specific code being used. If the encoder violates the rules, he will be deceiving the decoder (deliberately, if he knows what he is doing). If the decoder violates the rules, he will misrepresent the encoder (deliberately, if he knows what he is doing). In either event, communication is

damaged; the extent of the damage will depend on the circumstances.

Not only does the idea that 'everything is relative' reject the existence of the Sovereign Creator, it does away with the objective authority of the biblical Text. Of course, since a non-existent Creator can't do anything, much less produce a revelation with objective authority. But that idea does not alter the fact, and there will certainly be an Accounting.

Having said all of the above, however, I recognize that to affirm the divine inspiration of the Bible is a declaration of faith—an intelligent faith that is based on evidences, but still faith, since the evidences are not absolute;[a] and they are not absolute for a very good reason. The Sovereign Creator deliberately does not allow the evidences to be absolute, because then there would be no true test. The Creator requires that men choose between good and evil, and the choice may not be coerced.

Another very serious derivative of the doctrine that there is no true knowledge is the idea of 'your truth', that each person creates his own 'truth'. In itself, the very act of determining that you can define your own truth amounts to a rejection of God's Truth. It demonstrates an attitude of rebellion against the Sovereign Creator, and rebellion against the Creator is Satan's 'thing'. Someone who defines his own truth will almost certainly deny that he is a sinner, and therefore will deny that he needs salvation. The obvious difficulty with that is that denying that he is a sinner and needs salvation does not change the fact. That 'someone' is condemning himself to spend eternity in the Lake. To deny the existence of the Lake does not change the fact.

Well, maybe not. If there really is no Heaven or Hell, my believing that they exist does not create them. It is equally

[a] So we are not dealing with science, in an objective sense.

true that if there really is both Heaven and Hell, someone's not believing that they exist does not destroy them. And there is a further detail that should be considered. If my belief is wrong, I have lost nothing (except my expectation), but if that someone's belief is wrong, he has lost everything, and forever. I like my chances better than that someone's. (I once saw a nasty little exchange between two college students: "What is the difference between true love and herpes?" "Herpes is forever." Right. Hell is forever.)

There are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world. While the Sovereign Creator was walking this earth in the body of Jesus He declared: "He who is not with me is against me, and he who does not gather with me, scatters" (Luke 11:23, Matthew 12:30). Note that the Sovereign does not permit neutrality; either you are with Him or you are against Him (agnosticism is a passive rejection). Even what we do is not neutral; if we are not gathering with Him, we are scattering. There is no third option. Whoever is not with Jesus is with Satan, automatically. This applies to everything in this life.

Why do people reject the evidence, or at least ignore it? Because Satan blinds their minds, as is plainly stated in 2 Corinthians 4:3-4. "So where our Gospel has actually been concealed, it has been hidden from those who are being wasted, among whom the god of this age has blinded the minds of the unbelieving, so that the light of the Gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God, should not dawn on them." See also Mark 4:15 and Luke 8:12.

In John 8:44 the Sovereign declared that Satan is "the father of lying", and that "there is no truth in him". According to Hebrew idiomatic usage, the 'son' of something is characterized by that something. It follows that to be the 'father' of something is to be the owner of that something. Several times Jesus called the Holy Spirit "the Spirit of the Truth" (John 14:17, 15:26, 16:13). So, all truth belongs to the Holy

Spirit, and all falsehood belongs to Satan. It follows that whenever someone lies, he will be serving Satan. And whenever someone embraces a lie (such as evolutionism, Marxism, humanism, relativism, etc.), he will be giving Satan a bridgehead in his mind, which Satan will try to develop into a stronghold. A stronghold of Satan on a given subject does not allow one to think freely about that subject. The person is forced to stay with the lie. (The only way out is for someone with the power of God to come and nullify the stronghold.)

Ephesians 2:2 states that Satan is "the spirit who is now at work in the sons of the disobedience". This spirit is presently at work (present tense) in 'the sons of the disobedience'. 'Sons' of something are characterized by that something, and the something in this case is 'the' disobedience (the Text has the definite article)—a continuation of the original rebellion against the Sovereign of the universe. Anyone in rebellion against the Creator is under satanic influence, direct or indirect (in most cases a demon acts as Satan's agent, since he is not omnipresent, when something more than the influence of the surrounding culture is required; that includes the academic culture). Anyone in rebellion against the Creator will also have strongholds of Satan in his mind. Of a certainty.

Further on the subject that our knowledge is 'in part', not relative, I offer the following: Most computers are binary; that is, they are programed to make a sequence of binary choices—plus or minus, yes or no. Over the years the speed with which those choices are made has kept increasing. If I am not mistaken, modern computers can process millions of such choices per second (which I find difficult to comprehend). I suggest for the consideration of the reader that our opinion on any subject is also binary; that is, an opinion is made up of a number of components that are either true or false. The higher the proportion of true components to false ones, the

more nearly valid will the opinion be, the closer its approximation to the fact. Because opinions are many and varied, they are commonly said to be 'relative'. But the truth is not relative. The open-ended number of components that make up our opinions are either true or false.

I will close with Isaiah 29:11-12. "The whole vision has become to you like the words of a book that is sealed, which men deliver to one who is literate, saying, 'Read this, please.' And he says, 'I cannot, for it is sealed.' Then the book is delivered to one who is illiterate, saying, 'Read this, please.' And he says, 'I am not literate.'" (NKJV) The result is that the people remain in ignorance about the contents of the book, **and are condemned to suffer the consequences of that ignorance**. How many schools, or churches, or organizations of any kind teach that the Bible has objective authority? How many teach the Bible at all? The consequences are not pretty.

73) 'Rights' X options

"The weapons of our warfare are not physical, but are powerful in God for demolishing strongholds:[a] demolishing sophistries and every arrogance that sets itself up against the knowledge of God" (2 Corinthians 10:4-5). A sophistry is a false argument that is presented in such a way as to appear correct, and impressive, especially if not properly analyzed. Satan is in the business of purveying a number of sophistries

[a] The subject of biblical spiritual warfare is generally not well understood in Christian circles. Much of what has been written concerns defensive procedures, but this text speaks of demolishing strongholds (presumably the enemy's, since no one will want to destroy his own), that has to do with taking the offensive. For more on this subject the reader may consult my site: www.prunch.org.

designed to keep people from the knowledge of God, such as humanism, relativism, materialism, Freudianism, and so on.

Perhaps the most effective sophistry in recent times has been the theory of evolution, since it denies the very existence of God. If there is no God, there will be no Accounting, so you can do what you want! That theory has been stridently presented as science, even though it is scientifically impossible: absolutely, stupidly, ridiculously impossible! Chance working blindly with nothing could never produce anything; not in five billion, or trillion, or quadrillion years; not in an eternity of eternities. One of the spinoffs of that theory is the doctrine that people have all sorts of fictitious 'rights'.

My concern here is with the word 'right' when used as a noun. When used as an adjective its meaning is different: a right answer is a correct answer, as opposed to a wrong answer. As a noun, a 'right' refers to something to which one is legally entitled; to be legally entitled means it came from a competent authority. It is also used of something to which one is morally entitled, but who is competent to define morality? The Sovereign Creator is the only One who is competent to define morality, and He has done so in His written Revelation. In today's world most people reject that authority. Of course, a nonexistent Creator cannot do anything, but even those who acknowledge His existence generally reject any idea of objective authority. They have been taught to doubt the reliability of that written Revelation.

With reference to the New Testament, the dominant paradigm teaches that the original wording was lost at its beginning, there being no objective way of knowing what it may have been. I am prepared to demonstrate empirically that it was not lost, that the original wording has always

existed in the knowledge of the Church, that we have it today and can know what it is.

The Sovereign Creator created the human being with soul, with a will, with the ability to choose. The corollary to that is that both God and man must deal with the consequences of the choices made. We are not robots. We are certainly influenced by the circumstances that surround us, but we are not controlled by them; we have genuine choice. Because we have genuine choice, we are responsible for the consequences of the choices that we make.

Satan's sophistries are generally designed to convince people that there is no real responsibility, that there will be no final Accounting. If you have the 'right' to do something, then that something cannot be a crime or a sin. If you have the 'right' to do whatever you want to, then nothing that you do is wrong. **However**, the Sovereign Creator does not give anyone the right to do what He says is wrong. Not even Satan has that right. God gives us the **option** of doing evil, but we must take the consequences. We can know that something is evil by its bad consequences.

Nowadays, people are told that the poor have the 'right' to steal, that the oppressed have the 'right' to use violence; and there are places where crime is no longer punished. Since the vast majority of crimes are perpetrated by repeat offenders, the result is the destruction of civilization. Of course, there are ideologies that deliberately create and promote chaos as a prelude to taking over and imposing an absolute dictatorship. Then the bosses can live like nabobs, until the money runs out. There appears to be no limit to human perversity; the more so if aided and abetted by evil spirits.

So what can we do about it? We must denounce Satan's lies and promote God's Truth, in the public square.[a]

74) Saturday X Sunday

Where does the idea of a seven-day week come from? It comes from the Sovereign Creator: "On the seventh day God ended His work that He had done, and He rested on the seventh day from all His work that He had done. Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because in it He rested from all His work that God created and made" (Genesis 2:2-3). Some 4000 years later, the Sovereign Creator, walking this earth in the body of Jesus, said, "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27). The Creator himself explained that He established a week of seven days, with one day of rest, with a view to the well-being of man.

However, there is no mention in the Bible of anyone keeping the Sabbath before the Law of Moses. In the only canonical book written before Moses, Job, it does not appear. Job was so righteous that God cast him in Satan's face; it appears from there that keeping the Sabbath was not part of God's righteousness at that time. The march from Elim to Sin (about 35 km, in the desert) took place on a Sabbath (Exodus 16:1-22). The following Sabbath was the first one to be observed (Exodus 16:23-30). See also Nehemiah 9:13-14.

The Sabbath was a sign between God and Israel, and the observance of it was binding on them; it was never imposed on the Gentiles (but of course any individual among them could observe it). The matter is detailed in Exodus 31:12-17,

[a] For a discussion of our resources, please see the last four paragraphs of my article, 'God hates', item 28) above.

but here is verse 17: “It is a sign between me and the children of Israel forever; for in six days the LORD made the heavens and earth, and on the seventh day He rested and was refreshed.” See also Ezekiel 20:10-12. God linked the Sabbath with the Creation week; it is a remembrance and acknowledgment of the creation of this world, and is to be perpetual.

The Law itself, including the tablets, was a covenant between God and Israel. “Now therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, then you will be a special treasure to me above all people, for all the earth is mine” (Exodus 19:5). “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery” (Exodus 20:2). This verse is part of the decalogue, the tablets, and the commandments themselves are in the second person singular, “Thou shalt not have, thou shalt not do, etc.”. And the Law was accepted by the people (Exodus 24.3). It follows that the Law had nothing to do with the Gentiles, at least directly and at first (but naturally any individual among them could observe it).

So much for the old one, but Jeremiah 31:31-33 speaks of a <u>new</u> covenant, written on hearts, not on tablets of stone. “Behold, the days are coming, says the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah. Not according to the covenant that I made with their fathers in the day that I took them by the hand to lead them out of the land of Egypt; my covenant which they broke, though I was a husband to them, says the LORD. But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the LORD: I will put my law in their minds, and write it on their hearts; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people.” Here this new covenant is stated to be for the nation

of Israel, but nothing is said about the foundation for this covenant.

I understand that the Sovereign Jesus declared that foundation in Matthew 26:28 (also Mark 14:24 and Luke 22:20). There in the upper room, that last night, Jesus took the cup and said, “This is my blood, that of the new covenant, that which is being shed on behalf of many for forgiveness of sins”. The Text has the definite article with 'new covenant' = **the** new covenant, which must be a reference to Jeremiah 31. But the saving value of the shed blood of the Lamb of God is not limited to Israel; “Behold the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world” (John 1:29).

Hebrews chapters 7 to 10 deal with the difference between the two covenants, the old and the new. The new revolves around the person and work of the Lord Jesus, and it is on these that the Church is founded. He is the Mediator of the new (8:6). The old was annulled, as being weak and useless (7:18). The new came after the Law (7:28), which means that the old was left behind. The change was necessary (7:12). The son “removes the first in order to establish the second” (10:9). Hebrews 8:8-12 repeats Jeremiah 31:31-34, and verse 13 explains: “By saying ‘new’ He has made the first one ‘old’; and what is obsolete and aging is near the end”.

In Mark 2.27-28 Jesus, Lord/Owner of the Sabbath, said: “The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath”. As Owner, Jesus could change the rules in this regard, or even annul them. In Romans 6:14 Paul states that we are not under law but under grace. Actually, there are several texts that lead to the understanding that the Owner of the Sabbath did actually abolish it, at least with regard to the Church—Acts 15:24-29; Galatians 2:11-19; 3:10-13 and 24-25; 4:24-5:1;

5:18; Ephesians 2:15; Colossians 2:14 and the texts already quoted in Hebrews.

Jesus did not mention the Sabbath in the Upper Room, nor in the appearances after His resurrection. Indeed, **it does not appear in any command given by Jesus to His disciples**. In John 15:10 He said, "If you keep my commandments, you will abide in my love". It follows that we can remain in the love of Christ without keeping the Sabbath, for it is not among those commandments.

An appeal to Hebrews 13:8: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and forever", or James 1:17: "the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning", does not work, because such texts have to do with His character, not with the way of administering the world. Obvious. The situation after the fall of man was very different from what it was before; after the flood than before; after the Law of Moses than before; after Christ's victory than before. Nobody in the OT was saved by trusting in the shed blood of the Lord Jesus Christ: if God has already changed the specific requirements for a person to be saved, then why can't He change a lesser detail like the day of rest?

God's moral character does not change. In 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, Ephesians 5:5 and Revelation 21:8 we find lists of the types of people who will not enter the Kingdom of God. There are sins related to each of the ten commandments, except for the fourth, keeping the Sabbath. It follows that keeping the Sabbath is no longer a condition for entering the Kingdom, precisely because it is not a moral issue (at least so it seems to me).

Nothing that has already been said alters the fact that the Sovereign Creator established a week of seven days, with one day of rest, and He did this with a view to the welfare of man.

Even though keeping the Sabbath is no longer mandatory, we can still use that day for our rest, as well as some other day of the week. It is well known that Christian churches usually use Sunday. Why do they do this? In Revelation 1:10 John refers to Sunday as 'the Lord's day'. That is because Jesus arose on a Sunday. In Exodus 31:12-17 God linked the Sabbath with the Creation week; it was a remembrance and acknowledgment of the creation of this world. But Jesus Christ's victory on the cross and with His resurrection represents a new creation, or at least the redemption of the first. It was natural and appropriate for Christians to choose Sunday as their day of rest.

In addition to the risen Lord Jesus appearing to the assembled Apostles on Sunday at least twice (John 20:19 and 26), Acts 20:7 and 1 Corinthians 16:2 point to a routine use of Sunday by Christians. In fact, after Christ's resurrection there is no mention in the NT of any believer observing the Sabbath as such (Paul went to the synagogues to evangelize).

The Council that took place in Jerusalem, related in Acts 15, dealt precisely with the question of the extent to which Gentile Christians should obey the law of Moses, and the Sabbath was left out; it is not in the list of the four things that were imposed. “It seemed good to the Holy Spirit” (verse 28) states that the decision was of divine inspiration, and therefore of divine authority. If the Holy Spirit no longer enforces the Sabbath, who among us has the authority to enforce it?

But the force of the Jewish customs was such that even James, who in Acts 15 correctly heard the Holy Spirit, later succumbed and pressured Paul to do what he should not have done (Acts 21:18-26). From then on it seems that the leadership in Jerusalem lost its importance, and with the destruction of the city it disappeared from sight. Hence, the practices of

any Jewish church at the time should not be considered as norms for the Church. Church norms must be drawn from the New Testament.

The Jews observe the Sabbath, and there must be other such observers who also are not trusting in the shed blood of the Lamb of God for the salvation of the soul, and therefore will not go to Heaven. It follows that being a Sabbatarian does not necessarily earn God's good pleasure. Further, when someone develops spiritual pride for being a Sabbatarian, it is because Sabbatarianism has become a stronghold of Satan in his life.[a]

In Colossians 2:16 it is forbidden to judge others on account of the Sabbath; therefore Saturday cannot be the norm. So much so that in Romans 14:5-6 it is said that the choice of the day is at the discretion of each individual: “One man esteems one day above another; another esteems every day alike. Let each one be fully convinced in his own mind. He who observes the day, observes it to the Lord; and he who does not observe the day, to the Lord he does not observe it.” Therefore, the day of the week we choose to observe must not be made into doctrine. Christians generally observe Sunday, Jews Saturday, Muslims Friday, but if someone prefers Tuesday, he should be allowed that freedom. But on the other hand, if you want to hold on to a job, you will need to respect local culture; in an Islamic country you may have to observe Friday.

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[a] When someone is more interested in defending a point of view than in listening to the Word of God, it is quite possible that that point of view is a stronghold of Satan. A person who, in his eagerness to defend a thesis, makes use of stupid arguments, but who thinks he is being very logical, is almost always suffering from spiritual blindness.

Conclusion: if someone wants to observe the Sabbath, he can; if someone wants to observe Sunday, he can; if someone wants to observe Wednesday, he can; etc. However, according to Hebrews 10:25 we are supposed to meet regularly, and for that purpose there obviously has to be consensus. Since the resurrection of Christ, the general consensus of so-called Christian churches has been to meet on Sundays. It is the Lord's day, which commemorates the new creation, the new covenant (just as the Sabbath commemorated the old creation and covenant).

75) Saved in childbearing

1 Timothy 2:15

In the NKJV, 1 Timothy 2:14-15 reads like this: "And Adam was not deceived, but the woman being deceived, fell into transgression. Nevertheless she will be saved in childbearing if they continue in faith, love, and holiness, with self-control." We begin with "she will be saved"; 'she' is a pronoun, that stands for a noun, and in the context the reference is clearly to Eve. So how is Eve to be saved? (To render 'preserved' is basically meaningless.) Neither Eve nor any other woman is saved by bearing a child.

In the Greek Text we find 'childbirth', a noun, not a verb. Further, there is a definite article with the noun, so it is 'the childbirth'. There is only one childbirth that could result in salvation for Eve, and the rest of us, the birth of the Messiah. Of course, Eve bore Seth, thus beginning the line that culminated in the Messiah (Genesis 3:15). In the middle of verse 15, and of the sentence, Paul breaks the rules of grammar and switches from 'she' to 'they'—what is true of Eve is applied to all women. Well, strictly speaking, since 'they' has no antecedent, I suppose it could include men as well, everybody (unless someone wants to argue that women are saved on a

different basis than men [which I think would run afoul of other passages]). Still, the paragraph is about women. Any sisters in Christ who have been troubled by this verse, thinking that they must bear a child, may relax on that score.

76) 'Size' of faith?

Luke 17:6, Matthew 17:20

In the NKJV, Luke 17:6 reads like this: "If you have faith as a mustard seed, you can say to this mulberry tree, 'Be pulled up by the roots and be planted in the sea,' and it would obey you." Perhaps because of the parables just discussed, I don't remember ever hearing any other interpretation for this than the size of the faith. (The same holds for Matthew 17:20.) But that usually left me disgruntled: surely my faith was bigger than a seed, but I was never able to make a tree or hill obey me! But looking at the Text again, might the intended meaning of 'as a mustard seed' be different? Is not the phrase ambiguous? Could the verb 'has' be implied? Well then, what kind of 'faith' might a mustard seed have? Albeit so small, it reacts without question to the climactic circumstances, and grows to remarkable proportions. If we reacted similarly, without question, to the Holy Spirit's promptings, our spiritual 'climactic circumstances', we should indeed move mountains, literally. Or to put it another way, a seed has the faith to die, like the Lord Jesus said in John 12:24: "unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it remains alone." In 1 Corinthians 15:31 Paul said that he died daily. How so? Obviously he did not die physically; he died to himself, his own ideas and ambitions, so as to embrace God's will. Dying to self is a prerequisite for moving mountains, because then we will only attempt to do what we see the Father doing (John 5:19).

77) Some related anomalies in Matthew's genealogy of the Christ

Matthew's purpose is to demonstrate that Jesus, the Messiah, has a legal right to sit on David's throne (perhaps answering the Lord's own question in Matthew 22:42). Although there are many kings in the genealogy, David is the only one who is described as 'the king', twice. Since David's throne has to do with the covenant people, and that covenant began with Abraham, the genealogy does as well. It ends with Joseph, Jesus' 'father' by adoption, since Jesus had none of Joseph's genes.[a] It was sufficient to Matthew's purpose to show that Joseph was a linear, and legal, descendant of David, the number of intervening generations was beside the point. Matthew's Gospel was directed primarily to a Jewish audience, to whom legal rights were important.

Matthew divides his genealogy of the Christ into three groups of fourteen 'generations'. A comparison of his genealogy with the OT record indicates that it is not a 'normal', straightforward genealogy—there are some anomalies.[b] In an effort to understand the purpose behind the anomalies, I will begin with the second group, which may be said to be made up of sovereign kings of Judah. Going back to the OT we discover that there were seventeen such kings, not fourteen. But, Matthew says 'generations', not reigns, and since Ahaziah reigned only one year, Amon only two, and Abijah only

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[a] Indeed He could not, because of the prophesies in Jeremiah 22:30 and 36:30, wherein Jeconiah and Jehoiakim are cursed. However, Jesus received some of David's genes through Mary (please see the note that accompanies Luke 3:23 in my translation).

[b] I believe that Matthew composed his Gospel under divine guidance, which leads me to the conclusion that the anomalies were deliberate, on God's part. Therefore, my attempt to unravel the anomalies tries to understand the Holy Spirit's purpose in introducing them into the record.

three, they can be assimilated into the fourteen generations. That said, however, we next observe that Abijah and Amon are duly included in the list, while Ahaziah is not, followed by Joash and Amaziah. The three excluded names form a group between Jehoram and Uzziah.

Verse eight says that "Joram begot Uzziah," the verb 'begot' being the same one used throughout, but in fact Uzziah was Joram's (Jehoram's) great-great-grandson. So we see that 'begot' refers to a linear descendant, not necessarily a son. We also see that the number 'fourteen' is not being used in a strictly literal sense (whatever the author's purpose may have been). It also appears that 'generation' is not being used in a strictly literal sense. It follows that we are looking at an edited genealogy, edited in accord with the author's purpose.

In an effort to understand why the group of three was excluded, I ask: What might they have in common? They had in common genes from Ahab and Jezebel, as also a direct spiritual and moral influence from them. Ahaziah's mother was Athaliah, daughter of Ahab and Jezebel, so 50% of his genes were from Ahab. 2 Kings 8:27 says that Ahaziah was a son-in-law of the house of Ahab, referring to the mother of Joash, so 75% of his genes were from Ahab. Since Joash married Jehoaddan of Jerusalem, the contamination in Amaziah was down to 37%, and then in Uzziah it was below 20%.[a] This is my best guess as to why that group was excluded; a rebuke after the fact. (Matthew is giving an edited genealogy of the Christ, and Ahab's genes were definitely undesirable.)

We come now to another anomaly: 14 x 3 = 42, but only 41 names are given; what to do? We begin by noticing that both David and Jeconiah are mentioned on both sides of a

[a] It was Dr. Floyd N. Jones who started me thinking along this line (*Chronology of the Old Testament: A Return to the Basics*, King's Word Press, 1999, pp. 38-42).

'boundary'. I will consider the second boundary first. Verse eleven says that "Josiah begot Jeconiah and his brothers," passing over Jehoiakim, Jeconiah's father. But according to the Record, it was Jehoiakim who had "brothers", not Jeconiah. Since we need the real Jeconiah in the third group to make fourteen names, I place Jeconiah in the third group —counting both Jeconiah and Christ we get fourteen names.[a] But why was Jehoiakim omitted? So far as I know, he was the only king who had the perversity to actually cut up a scroll with God's Word and then throw it in the fire, Jeremiah 36:23, and the curse that follows in verse 30 is stated to be a consequence of that act. If we count David in the second group, Jehoiakim would make fifteen. But without Jehoiakim we need David in the second group to make fourteen. But that raises another difficulty: we also need David in the first group, to make fourteen. Because of the "brothers", I consider that the 'Jeconiah' before the captivity actually stands for Jehoiakim, whose name is omitted because of his heinous crime in destroying the scroll. In that event, we have fourteen without David, so he can be assigned to the first group.

If the second group is made up of kings, the first group is made up of patriarchs. Acts 2:29 calls David a 'patriarch', so we may not disqualify him on that basis, but of course he is better known as a king—indeed he is expressly called that in the genealogy (the only one who is). Although David may be both patriarch and king, he may not be two people, nor two generations. In consequence, I am decidedly uncomfortable with the proposal that David must be placed in both groups —we should neither split him in two, not double him. To my

[a] Of course, if four people were omitted from the second group, some may also have been omitted from the third, but we have no way of knowing, and it would make no difference to the purpose of this genealogy.

mind, he fits better in the second group, but that would leave only thirteen for the first one. Enter Rahab and Ruth (and if four people were omitted from the second group, why could not some also be omitted from the first?). However, I tentatively assign David to the first group, making fourteen. Since David is used as the first boundary, and the purpose of the genealogy is to establish Jesus' right to David's throne, his name is repeated, but I do not count him in the second group.

There were 340 years between the death of Joshua and the birth of David, and Salmon married Rahab while Joshua was still alive, presumably. That sort of obliges Boaz, Obed and Jesse to do their begetting at age 100, or thereabouts (perhaps not impossible, but certainly improbable). But what if 'begot' is being used for a grandson, as we have already seen? (Josiah begot Jeconiah, with no mention of Jehoiakim.) If Athaliah's genes were enough to disqualify Ahaziah, what about Rahab's genes? She was not even an Israelite, and worse, she was a prostitute. Now the Law says some rather severe things about prostitutes.[a] "You shall not bring the wages of a harlot or the price of a dog [catamite] to the house of the LORD your God… for both of these are an abomination to the LORD your God" (Deuteronomy 23:18). For a priest to marry a harlot would profane his posterity (Leviticus 21:13-15), so how about an ancestor of the Messiah? Of course it is possible for a prostitute to be saved, but why was she even mentioned? And why were Tamar, Ruth, and Uriah's wife mentioned? Women were not normally included in genealogies.[b]

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[a] However, "the law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17). This being an edited genealogy of the Messiah, perhaps Rahab, and the other women, were included to emphasize the grace of the Messiah.

[b] None of the decent, honest, honorable, responsible mothers are mentioned, only 'exceptions'!

Now consider Ruth. She was a Moabitess, and according to Deuteronomy 23:3 a Moabite could not enter the assembly of the LORD to the tenth generation. [To me it is an astonishing example of the grace of God that she was included in the Messiah's line.] She embraced Naomi's God, but what about her genes? 'Ten generations' has to do with genes, not spiritual conversion. Moab was a son of Lot, and the first 'Moabite' would be his son, probably a contemporary of Jacob. From Jacob to Salmon we have seven generations, certainly fewer than ten, so Ruth could not enter. Could it be possible that Rahab and Ruth each represent a missing generation? Could that be why they are mentioned?[a] If we divide 300 years by five, then the average begetting age would be 60, certainly within the bounds of reason (and if more than two genera-tions were skipped, the number would be further reduced). I repeat that this is not a 'normal' genealogy. Why did Matthew want three 'equal' groups, and why did he choose 'fourteen'? Perhaps for stylistic (symmetry, balance) and mnemonic reasons. However, my concern has been to address any perceived errors of fact, which an inspired Text should not have.

To conclude: Matthew gives us an edited genealogy of the Messiah. If on the one hand it emphasizes the Messiah's grace, on the other it reflects the Messiah's holiness—He cannot overlook sin and its consequences (the four excluded names in the second group are due to that holiness). If the four women were included as a reflection of the Messiah's grace, it is also true that the consequences of sin are not hidden—the fourth is called simply 'Uriah's wife' (not 'widow', even though Solomon was conceived after the

[a] Tamar had suffered a severe injustice, and David's sin with Bathsheba was unusually perverse (cowardly murder), but Rahab was probably a victim of circumstances, and Ruth was certainly not to blame for having been born a Moabitess.

murder of Uriah—David did not marry a widow, he stole someone else's wife).

78) 'Staff', or 'bed'?

Hebrews 11:21 X Genesis 47:31

In the NKJV, Hebrews 11:21 reads like this: "By faith Jacob, when he was dying, blessed each of the sons of Joseph, and worshipped, *leaning* on the top of his staff." It has been alleged that this statement disagrees with Genesis 47:31, that has Jacob leaning on the head of the bed (following the Massoretic Text), rather than the top of his staff. However, close attention to the contexts indicates that Hebrews 11:21 and Genesis 47:31 refer to different occasions, so there is no need to imagine a discrepancy. That said, it may be of interest to note the following. The Hebrew words for 'bed' and 'staff' are spelled with the same three consonants, the difference being in the vowels, that were not written. Thus the Original Hebrew Text was ambiguous here. When the Massoretes added vowel pointing to the Hebrew Text, many centuries after Christ, they chose 'bed'. Long before, the Septuagint had chosen 'staff'.

79) The cursed fig tree

Matthew 21.18-20, Mark 11.12-14, 20-21

First, I will transcribe the texts:

Matthew 21:—**18**Now in the early morning, as He returned to the city, He was hungry. **19**And seeing a lone fig tree by the road, He went up to it and found nothing on it, just leaves. And He says to it, "May you never again produce fruit!" And forthwith the fig tree started to wither. **20**And seeing it the disciples marveled saying, "How quickly the fig tree became withered!"

Mark 11:—[12]Now the next day, as they were leaving Bethany, He was hungry. [13]And seeing from a distance a fig tree having leaves, He went to see if perhaps He would find something on it. When He came to it He found nothing but leaves, because it was not fig season. [14]So Jesus reacted by saying to it, "Let no one ever eat fruit from you again!" And His disciples were listening … [20]Now in the morning, as they passed by, they saw the fig tree dried up from the roots. [21]And Peter, remembering, said to Him: "Rabbi, look! The fig tree that you cursed has dried up!"

As Mark points out (Mark 11:13), it was not fig season, but a tree with leaves might have some dried figs. Since dried figs are very good eating, any visible figs would have been eaten long since (the tree was near the road). In fact, Jesus was certainly not the first person to come up with this idea, so there was little chance of Him finding any figs. Before commenting on Jesus' reaction, let us clarify what happened to the fig tree.

If we only had Matthew's account, we could understand that everything happened immediately, right there. That is, that the tree dried up immediately before their eyes, causing the disciples to react. But Mark 11:20 makes it clear that the disciples' reaction did not take place until the next morning, 24 hours later. Matthew 21:19 says that after Jesus spoke the fig tree began to wither. Strictly speaking, the Text says that the sap was cut off; the result would not be visible right away. But as the sap comes from the roots, the tree dried up from the roots, just as Mark 11.20 says! If Peter was the first to speak, the others certainly did too.

Matthew and Mark record what Jesus said differently, but I understand that Jesus actually said both things, one after the other. But how may we understand Jesus' attitude? It was out of season—it was not the tree's fault that it had no figs! Was Jesus unfair for cursing it? Well, to begin, being the

Creator, Jesus had the right to do as He pleased with His creation. But it seems to me more likely that it was a prophetic act, the fig tree representing Israel—indeed, the parable of the fig tree in Luke 13:6-9 seems to me to tend in that direction; the owner looked for fruit for three years, without finding any, and since the tree continued without bearing, it was cut down. Third, Jesus took the opportunity to give the disciples a lesson in faith.

80) The date of Job

Genesis 25:8 says that Abraham "died in a good old age, an old man and full of years", and he was 175 years old. Job 42:17 says that Job "died, old and full of days". Job 42:16 says that after his Test, "Job lived one hundred and forty years". The Text does not say how old Job was at the time of his Test, but with ten children, at least some of which were presumably adults, he must have been at least sixty. His life span of at least 200 years would have made him a contemporary of Terah, or even Nahor, Abraham's grandfather. Job 1:1 says that Job lived in the "land of Uz". This Uz was presumably a son of Aram, a son of Shem (Genesis 10:23). It could not have been the distant descendant of Esau (Genesis 36:28), since by that time no one was living anywhere near 200 years.

Job knew Jehovah by name (Job 1:21), and he knew about animal sacrifice (verse 5). Being a descendant of Shem, as was Abraham, he had evidently received instruction about how to please God; and he did so to such good effect that God Himself called Job the best servant He had down here (verse 8).

Elihu is said to be a Buzite (Job 32:2). The second son of Nahor, Abraham's brother was called Buz (Genesis 22:21). But Elihu was also "of the family of Ram". This 'Ram' could not have been the great, great, grandson of Jacob (1 Chronicles 2:9), because that would make Elihu be born later than Ram

and he would not have been alive in Job's time. Elihu was the son of Barachel, who was the Buzite, who was of Ram's family. If the Buz here was Nahor's son, why was not Nahor, or perhaps Terah, mentioned, instead of Ram? I conclude that we do not know the identity of the Buz and the Ram mentioned in Job 32:2. If the Buz here were actually Nahor's son, Elihu would not have been born in time to participate in the debate with Job. Job 42:16 also says that Job saw four generations of descendants. If a generation at that time was an average of thirty years, Job could easily have seen the fourth generation, but perhaps not the fifth. On the basis of a generation of thirty years, even if Elihu was a great grandson of Nahor, he would not have been born in time.

But how is it that we have a precise transcription of the discourses in Job? And who recorded all the events in Abraham's life, etc.? Genesis 14:14 records that Abraham led 318 trained men, born in his household, to rescue Lot; that means that with women and children and older men his household probably numbered over 1,000 people. That number would certainly have included a scribe or two, who had the responsibility of making a record of all that happened. If Job was greater than Abraham (Job 1:3), then his household would have been at least as large, including some scribes. There were certainly hundreds of people observing everything that happened to Job, at first hand, and the scribes would be busy recording the discourses. Eliphas himself may have been a scribe. If God inspired the book of Job, He knew beforehand that He was going to do so, and He would make sure that the discourses were correctly transcribed.

The final composition of the book of Job, as we have it, had to wait for Job's death. Job may have died before Abraham did, or about the same time. The book of Job may have been 'published' some 300 years before Moses wrote the Pentateuch, and would therefore be the oldest book in the

OT. Eliphas may well have outlived Job, and he would be a good candidate to have done the final composition. The account of the conversations in Heaven had to be given by revelation to the editor. God's conversation with Job was audible and could have been recorded by a scribe.

To conclude, I would say that the book of Job was probably 'published' around 1,800 B.C.

81) The death penalty

Exposition of the Biblical Text

At the very beginning of human history, "the LORD God commanded the man, saying, 'You shall not eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die'" (Genesis 2:16-17). Said and done, Adam ate and immediately lost his communion with God—spiritual death had begun. Physical death too. Soon, there was the first murder (Genesis 4.8). Things got so bad that less than 2,000 years later the Sovereign Creator found it necessary to completely destroy the earth. The earth after the Flood was totally different, with a very different topography and climate. And there were only eight human beings to start all over again. It was to those eight that the Creator decreed a basic norm, a norm that continues to this day.

> 5 For your lifeblood I will surely demand an accounting. I will demand an accounting from every animal, and also from every man. Yes, at the hand of every man's brother will I require the life of man. 6 Whoever sheds man's blood, by man his blood shall be shed; because God made the man in His own image (Genesis 9:5-6).

Verse 6 contains a decree, a decree that was never revoked. Note that what is at stake is **the image of God**. Murdering the image of God is such a great crime that the Sovereign Creator allows only one way to atone: the murderer must be executed. Anyone who deprives another person of life without

adequate justification (i.e., established by the Creator: execute a murderer, kill a thief at night [Exodus 22:1-4—there was no prison; crimes were resolved on the basis of restitution or indemnity], etc.) must pay with their own, since there is no way to indemnify. That is for the physical life. But if the murdered person died in disbelief, he lost eternal life as well. To deprive someone of the possibility of attaining eternal life (by killing in advance) is a crime without size—it is too big to measure. There is simply no way to expiate or indemnify. Leaving the murderer unpunished is to say that the murdered person was worthless—the image of God was worthless, the physical life was worthless, the eternal life was worthless. This is intolerable! I suppose that is why the Creator demands the maximum penalty in case of murder.

Now I want to follow the chronological sequence (more or less) of the divine revelation on the subject. I begin with Genesis 38:8-10. The Sacred Text declares that God killed Onan. Why? It was not because he didn't want to give a descendent to his brother—under the greater rigor of the Law of Moses the penalty was ‘merely’ public humiliation, not death (Deuteronomy 25:5-10). In the time of Onan the Mosaic Law did not yet exist. Until then, only one crime called for execution, precisely murder. Since life is in the seed, when Onan spilled the seed on the ground, he purposely killed the human life in the seed—he murdered. And God punished! We may add here Exodus 21:22-23. A fetus is also a person, and whoever caused the death of a fetus received the maximum penalty.

In Genesis 42:22, Reuben, who for years had been imagining that Joseph had been killed, understands that God is now avenging Joseph's blood. In Exodus 20:13 the sixth commandment is, "Thou shalt not murder". The Hebrew word here explicitly means 'to murder'; the translation 'thou shalt not kill' misleads the reader. In Exodus 21:12 God repeats the

decree of the maximum penalty—"he shall surely be executed"! In the next verse God exempts unintentional death, even taking the responsibility—"God permitted". But in verse 14 God returns to the case of a murderer; for such there is no exemption; he has to die! "You shall even take him from my altar, that he may die!" Just think about that! At that time the altar represented precisely the way to expiate sins. Running to the altar was the way to claim God's mercy and protection, but for a murderer the Sovereign Creator denies that expedient—a murderer must be executed. No matter how much someone does not like it, the Creator is immoveable—whoever purposely kills the image of God (without just cause) will have to be killed in turn; there is no compensation.

Now let us consider Numbers 35:15-34, one of the most relevant passages precisely because it deals with the cities of refuge. The Creator makes a basic distinction between those who kill unintentionally and those who kill on purpose. He designated six cities to receive and protect the unintentional manslayer, precisely to prevent the death of an 'innocent' manslayer (he killed unintentionally) (Deuteronomy 19:5-6). But attention to a detail that greatly emphasizes the value that the Creator places on 'blood'. 'Blood' is of such high value that if the innocent manslayer left the city of refuge (for whatever reason, and before the death of the high priest) and was found and executed by the 'avenger of blood', that avenger "will not be guilty" (Numbers 35.27, 32). Even though unintentionally, the killer had shed blood, and the consequences were serious. However, for the murderer there was no mercy—"the murderer must be executed" (verse 16); "the murderer must be executed" (verse 17); "the murderer must be executed" (verse 18); "the avenger . . . will kill him" (verse 19); "the avenger will kill him" (verse 21); "shall be executed" (verse 30). In short, "You shall not accept a ransom for the life

of a murderer, who deserves to die. He must surely be put to death!" (verse 31).

Why is God so severe? The explanation is given in verse 33 (see also Deuteronomy 19:13, which speaks of 'innocent blood'): "You shall not pollute the land in which you are. Blood pollutes the land, and no atonement can be made for the land for the blood that is shed in it, except by the blood of the one who shed it." Blood pollutes the land. *Blood pollutes the land*. **Blood pollutes the land**. BLOOD POLLUTES THE LAND. **BLOOD POLLUTES THE LAND**!!! And no atonement can be made for the land . . . except by the murderer's blood. Please take note: in the midst of all the sacrifices and burnt offerings reported in the Old Testament, there is not even one for a murderer—not even one. Don't you think we should take the Sacred Text seriously? If the Sovereign Creator Himself **forbids** accepting a ransom for a murderer's life, how would He offer such a ransom? Please note: the words of Sovereign Jesus in Matthew 12:31 and Mark 3:28 concern the future life, not the consequences in this life.

Attention please: the blood of Christ and the grace of God do not necessarily free us from the consequences of our sins in this life. Whoever commits adultery carries consequences until death. Whoever cuts off his foot lives without that foot until he dies. Etc. And it does not even have to be a sin: if I accidentally kill my son, I will be without that son until death. We also bear the consequences of the sins of others. The blood of Christ and the grace of God do not (necessarily or automatically) deliver us from the consequences, for this life, of our own (or others') wrongdoings. The Creator demands a murderer's death. That is, his physical death. A murderer can embrace the Gospel of Christ and save his soul, like the evildoer on the cross—that evildoer trusted the Lord Jesus and went to Heaven, but he did not escape physical death at that time. He paid for his crime.

Deuteronomy 21:1-9 shows once again the importance that the Creator attaches to the problem. If a corpse was found, and there was no way to identify the murderer, a detailed procedure was required for the people to get rid of the **bloodguilt**. That procedure was quite demanding, thereby rein-forcing the gravity of that guilt. (In verse 4 the correct verb is 'to break' the neck.)

2 Kings 24:3-4 makes clear that the fall of the kingdom of Judah was due to the iniquities of Manasseh, and mainly because of the innocent blood shed. "For he had filled Jerusalem with innocent blood, which the LORD would not pardon." Did you get that? The Lord did not want to forgive!

Psalm 106:38, 40 repeats that innocent blood stains the earth and kindles the wrath of God. Proverbs 6:16-17 declares that "the Lord hates . . . hands that shed innocent blood". Jeremiah 22:3, 17-19 shows that the judgment against Jehoiakim rested, in part, on innocent blood. Ezekiel 22:3-16 is stronger: "Woe to the city that sheds blood" (verse 3); " you have become guilty by the blood which you have shed " (verse 4); verses 6, 9 and 12 return to the subject, and verses 13 to 16 declare the punishment.

Isaiah has a lot to say on the subject. In 1:15 God declares that He no longer hears their prayers because "your hands are full of blood". 1.21 adds that the city is full of murderers (obviously they were not being executed). 4:4 speaks of cleansing Jerusalem of the **bloodguilt** from its midst. Isaiah 59:1-15 is almost violent. In the first place it is because "your hands are contaminated with blood" that God no longer listens to them. "They make haste to shed innocent blood" (verse 7). Now notice verses 9-15, which portray the consequences: "justice is far from us", "there is only darkness", "salvation is far off". Verses 13 and 14 speak of "transgressing and lying against the LORD, . . . justice is turned back, and righteousness stands afar off; for truth is fallen in the street,

and equity cannot enter." It seems to be a portrait of many countries that were once 'Christian'. The 'evangelical' people of the country are characterized by "transgressing and lying against the Lord", since they reject the death penalty that the Sovereign Creator decrees. That must be why God does not hear our prayers for the nation. That must be why our country is increasingly plunging into corruption, economic chaos, moral rottenness, mindless violence—without any solution or salvation appearing. Our land is polluted by innocent blood spilled without punishment, and the Sovereign Creator does not forgive!

It will not work to argue that God's grace nullifies His moral law. Pay attention to Romans 1:18-32, where it is clear that the application is current. So much so that in verse 32 God's sentence is that those who do the things mentioned (including "murder") "**are** worthy of death". "Are", not 'were' —the verb is in the present tense, also in the Original Text. In other words, Paul asserts that the sentence has not changed; even in the age of the Church, of grace, certain people are still liable to death—by divine sentence. 1 Corinthians 10:6-12 declares that Israel's experiences in the wilderness "happened to them as examples" and "were written for our admonition" (verse 11), and concludes: "Therefore let him who thinks he stands take heed lest he fall." All the cases cited resulted in physical death, and if they were recorded "for our admonition" it is because we may face something similar. You can't be too careful! 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, Revelation 21:8 and 22:14-15 were also written after the day of Pentecost.

(Do we really have an adequate view of God's love? "Whom the LORD loves He chastens, yes scourges every son whom He receives" (Hebrews 12:6); see also Revelation 3:19. [I myself have been scourged, literally, and I can assure the reader that it is not pleasant.] In Deuteronomy 33:2-3 the "fire of the law" is an expression of God's love. Precisely

because He is concerned for our true wellbeing, the Creator imposes the earthly consequences of our sins. God's love **necessarily** includes hatred of evil, because of the consequences of evil that befall the objects of His love.)

And as for the Law of Moses, the decree in Genesis 9:6 is independent of it, as well as of the covenant with Abraham, for it precedes it by many centuries. If I am not mistaken, the decision taken by the Council of Jerusalem and recorded in Acts 15:29 reaffirms Genesis 9. The four things prohibited (and the prohibition is "necessary", verse 28) are expressed in the Original Text by one word each, a rather cryptic statement, therefore. So cryptic, in fact, that it can give rise to discussion when we want to define the exact intended meaning. However, the third item, "strangled", seems to pertain to the prohibition first promulgated in Genesis 9:4—to consume blood is forbid-den (see also Leviticus 17:10-11). That being the case, the second item, "blood", must have another reference. The most likely candidate would be shed blood, precisely the decree in Genesis 9:5-6. We must avoid ‘bloodguilt’; remember that this guilt is acquired in two ways: to murder, and to fail to execute a murderer.

That the New Testament makes no change in the Creator's stance on bloodguilt is clearly seen in 1 Corinthians 11:27-30. According to verse 27, whoever drinks the cup unworthily will be "guilty of the blood" of the Lord. And what is the consequence of that? Verse 30 gives the answer: "because of this . . . many sleep". "Sleep" means they are dead; in other words, God killed them. The Apostle Paul, inspired by the Holy Spirit, declares that as far as the "many" were concerned, the Creator had literally punished ‘bloodguilt’—the culprit died. I confess that the severity of God in this case surprises me, but there it is. Let no one be deceived; the Creator is still punishing the ‘bloodguilt’!

Leviticus 18:6-30 prohibits certain practices because they contaminate the land, and it can get to the point where the land "vomits" the people. But what a striking picture: the soil itself loathes the residents! And what are those practices? All kinds of incest (verses 6-17), intercourse with a menstruating woman (verse 19), adultery (verse 20), human sacrifice (verse 21), anal sex (verse 22) and sex with an animal (verse 23). Verse 29 decrees the death penalty for all those practices; Leviticus 20:1-22 decrees death for the same sins one by one, ending with the possibility of the land spewing them out (verse 22). We already know that shed blood (without punishment) pollutes the land, and that God demands the death penalty for murder. But why is the Creator's reaction to the aforementioned practices the same? I suppose it is because of this: sex with an animal, anal sex and sex with a menstruating woman destroy the seed of the man, and it is that seed that transmits "the image of God", life. Therefore they are types of homicide—remember the case of Onan. Human sacrifice is obvious murder. Incest and adultery degrade the seed. In short, the Creator takes His ‘image’ seriously!

In summary, here in Brazil we are living in a land contaminated by ‘bloodguilt’. Every day, at least a hundred people are killed violently (across the country, on average) and the government never avenges that blood (in isolated cases, some individual does, only then the 'law' goes after the avenger much harder than it did after the assassin). In present-day Brazil, the law protects the criminal more than the victims. If someone murders your child, the only option you have is to mourn your child, for there will be no punishment for the criminal. Brazilian society declares that your child's life has no value, because anyone can take it without reparation. You may even acquiesce, but the Creator

does not acquiesce, He does not forgive. Innocent blood spilled, no! The 'image' despised, no! The land polluted, no!

Possible Objections

1. "In the few countries that still retain the death penalty, there are no clear indications that the death penalty serves to discourage murder." This question is beside the point. This is not why the Sovereign Creator has decreed the penalty. We must demand the maximum penalty because the Creator decrees it, simply that. [It should be noted, in passing, that the 'death penalty' in the United States is a hoax, and should not enter as an argument in this question, but as a hoax.] Now then, since someone raises the question, the manner in which the media approach the subject is generally somewhat biased. If I am not mistaken, the police forces around the world agree that at least 80% of the crimes committed are committed by those who have already committed them—they are repeat offenders. More than half of the murders are done by repeat offenders. Now then, it is obvious that if every murderer were killed the first time, we would reduce the murder rate by more than half—beyond question. The executed assassin will not kill anyone else, not he. We would be saving the lives of all the other people he would kill later.

2. "According to 2 Chronicles 33:12-13, Manasseh came to the point of repenting and humbling himself, and he obtained the mercy of God." It is true that God did not kill him for all his terrible sins, including a lot of murder—it was the people who 'paid the price', and especially a subsequent generation. It may cause us some surprise, but the sins of the authorities tend to fall much more on the people than on them themselves. Since the avenging of blood was handed over to organized society (Genesis 9:6), when the head of the government murders, there is no longer anyone to avenge—as long as he remains in power, he goes unpunished (with the maximum penalty). But the land is contaminated, and the people pay. It

follows that great care should be exercised in choosing our rulers. It seems to me that as evangelical people we have been very negligent in this area, and we are getting the consequences. We must look for true disciples of Jesus Christ, capable people with integrity who cannot be ‘bought’, and compete with them for positions at all levels of government. And we must obey 1 Timothy 2:1-4.

3. "Many former murderers are now converted and are serving the Lord, some even prominently. Should they be executed?" They still live due to the law and culture of the country that do not respect the Creator's norms. In fact, in most cases, they would not even have become murderers, if the surrounding culture and laws were embracing biblical values. Presumably they are not in violation of the current law, and therefore there is no social context in which to execute them. The biggest problem is to correct the law, because the Creator Himself has established that we should obey the constituted authorities.

I understand that anyone who genuinely converts will seek to make restitution for the wrong he has already done. A thief seeks to make right what he stole. A liar seeks to undo the consequences of his lies. But a murderer cannot repay or indemnify—there is no way. The crime of murder is irreversible (unless God restores a life). God's grace can reach him, but the ‘bloodguilt’ has to be exacted—society and the land itself pay. The larger question would be this: is it fair to punish society and the land just to benefit an individual? God always seeks to make evil revert to good in some way, to recover some good even within a damaged social framework, but it is nothing more than a palliative—the proper solution is for society to embrace the Creator's norms. And that is what God's people should be working toward. (The case of Saul of Tarsus does not fit here because he was 'executing', obeying a higher order of the Sanhedrin.)

4. "If the maximum penalty were reinstated in Brazil, it would be applied unfairly—the poor would be executed, but the rich would always find ways to escape." It seems clear that in the current social and political context this would indeed happen; the law would be applied unevenly. And so? Is that a sufficient argument for continuing with the disastrous situation as it is? It seems obvious to me that we will have to fight on several fronts at the same time. Among them we have to work towards an incorruptible judiciary. However, any decrease in the 'blood-guilt' that plagues us would be an advantage.

5. "If there is a death penalty, there is a risk of executing innocent people." Of course, there will always be risk in this life. I believe, however, that the Creator Himself will agree that it is better to err attempting to do what is right than to err by omission or even rebellion. In other words, we will reduce the 'bloodguilt' that hangs over us, because any mistakes will represent a small percentage of the total number of executions. And I wonder to what extent God will punish a sincere mistake; that is to say, when society, wanting to obey the Creator, executes a supposed murderer unjustly.

6. "The death penalty does not resolve the causes of murder, such as social injustice, etc." Perhaps this is the argument most read and heard on our subject. It reflects humanist /relativist /materialist, rather than biblical, presuppositions. It is preached that the individual is fatally a product of his context, and therefore has no personal responsibility—it is society's fault. But the Creator strongly disagrees with this view. The human being is created with conscience, with will, with choice; he is not an animal, he is not a robot—he can overcome his context. Each individual is personally responsible for his actions, which is why there will be an Accounting. We should certainly strive to correct social injustices, but none of that takes care of 'bloodguilt'.

Conclusion

'Life penalty' — this is what we are experiencing in Brazil today, since we are part of a society that is under the wrath of the Creator. And we evangelicals are to blame for that. We have not been 'salt' or 'light'; we agree with the humanist values of society, instead of denouncing them. Let us work to undo the damage. Better late than never! Let us publicly promote biblical values, consciously and coherently. Let us raise the prophetic voice of those who are fully committed to Jesus Christ, His Word and His Kingdom, whatever the cost. Who knows, maybe God will grant us to transform the society so He can heal our land (2 Chronicles 7:14). But if even God's people do not want to "turn from their wicked ways", then there is no hope. Our land is doomed!

82) The four rivers

(10 And a river went out of Eden to water the garden; and from there it was divided into four head-waters. **11** The name of the first [river] was Pishon; it wound through all the land of Havilah, where there was gold. **12** And the gold of this land was good; there was bdellium, and the onyx stone. **13** And the name of the second river was Gihon; it wound through all the land of Cush. **14** And the name of the third river was Hiddekel; it flowed along the east side of Asshur. And the fourth river was Euphrates.**)**

This paragraph about the rivers (Gen. 2:10-14) interrupts the flow of the narrative. It could not have been part of what Jehovah shared with Adam as they walked and talked in the Garden. During the 1,400+ years between Creation and the Flood, people were reproducing much faster than they were dying. By the time of the Flood, there must have been many hundreds of thousands, if not millions, of inhabitants on this planet. Once the fallen pair was expelled from the Garden, their descendants would have spread out in all directions.

They built towns and gave names to their towns, as well as their areas. I take it that this paragraph about the rivers was included to give some idea of the extent of the human population (before the Flood), including its geographical distribution.

But why are gold, bdellium and onyx mentioned? Well, evidently gold came to be viewed as having special value early on, functioning as a sort of money. Bdellium is a plant with aromatic gum, perhaps a type of cosmetic, indicating that people were already paying attention to that sort of thing. Onyx is a pretty semi-precious stone that would have ornamental value (not useful for building). So this paragraph also mentions the development of cultural values.

Whoever wrote this paragraph would have done so a long time after the Fall. (It would have been part of a document that was preserved in Noah's Ark, along with other pre-flood literature, which was delivered to Moses in due time.) But why was it inserted precisely here, along with the creation of the Garden? Well, where else would it fit? After the fallen pair was expelled, there is only one further mention of the Garden, in Genesis, giving the location of Cain's descendants. In any case, it is where it is, presumably because the Holy Spirit told Moses to put it there.

Noah's Flood totally destroyed the surface of the earth at that time. After the Flood the surface was totally different. That is why it is impossible to know the location of Eden. It would be natural for Noah and his sons to reuse names they had known before; in this case the Tigris (Hiddekel) and Euphrates rivers (whose headwaters are not far from Ararat).

83) The 'Legion' and the pigs; where was it?

We need to start with the evidence supplied by the Greek manuscripts. We encounter the episode in three of the Gospels.

Matthew 8:28: *γεργεσηνων* 98% (Gergesenes) AV,NKJV
γαδαρηνων 2% (Gadarenes) NIV,NASB, LB,TEV, etc.

NIV footnote: "Some manuscripts *Gergesenes*; others *Gerasenes*."

Mark 5:1: *γαδαρηνων* 95.5% (Gadarenes) AV,NKJV
γεργεσηνων 4.1% (Gergesenes)
γερασηνων 0.3% (Gerasenes) NIV,NASB,LB, TEV, etc.

NIV footnote: "Some manuscripts *Gadarenes*; other manuscripts *Gergesenes*."

Luke 8:26: *γαδαρηνων* 97% (Gadarenes) AV,NKJV
γεργεσηνων 2% (Gergesenes) TEV
γερασηνων 0.3% (Gerasenes) NIV,NASB,LB, etc.

NIV footnote: "Some manuscripts *Gadarenes;* other manuscripts *Gergesenes;* also in verse 37."

Luke 8:37: *γαδαρηνων* 96% (Gadarenes) AV,NKJV
γεργεσηνων 3.5% (Gergesenes) TEV
γερασηνων 0.3% (Gerasenes) NIV,NASB, LB, etc.

I will begin with Mark. Jesus arrived at "the region [not 'province'] of the Gadarenes." Gadara was the capital city of the Roman province of Perara, located some six miles from the Sea of Galilee. Since Mark was writing for a Roman

audience,[a] "the region of the Gadarenes" was a perfectly reasonable description of the site. Lamentably, the eclectic Greek text currently in vogue follows about five Greek manuscripts of objectively inferior quality (against at least 1,700 better ones) in reading 'Gerasenes' (to be followed by NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.). The NIV footnote is dishonest: to use 'some' to describe some 1,700 manuscripts against five is a dishonest use of the King's English (to use 'others' to refer to some 60 is acceptable).

Luke also has Jesus arriving at "the region of the Gadarenes." Since he was writing for a Greek audience, he follows Mark's example. Again, NIV has a dishonest footnote. It is most likely that 'Gerasa' is a fiction, a 'place' that never existed. On the other hand, 'Gergesa' certainly did exist, although we no longer know the exact location. As I will explain while discussing Matthew, below, I have no doubt that it was a village near the spot where Jesus landed.

Matthew clearly wrote 'Gergesenes' rather than 'Gadarenes'. Since he was writing for a Jewish audience, and many Galileans would be quite familiar with the Sea of Galilee, he provided a more localized description. Further, try to picture the events in your mind. Do you suppose that the swineherds ran six miles to Gadara? The populace would certainly not run the six miles back. All of that would have taken entirely too long. To me it is obvious that there was a village close by, probably within half a mile, called 'Gergesa'. It was to that village that the swineherds ran, told their story, and brought the residents back. Galileans familiar with the Sea of Galilee would certainly recognize 'Gergesa'.

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[a] Although, as explained elsewhere, I understand that Matthew was published first, and Mark probably had a copy open before him as he wrote, yet he deliberately changed Matthew's 'Gergesenes' to 'Gadarenes'—to his intended Roman audience 'Gergesa' would be unknown, while some would indeed know about 'Gadara'.

Not only does Matthew name a different place, he affirms that there were really two demonized men, whereas Mark and Luke mention only one. As a former tax collector, numerical precision was important to Matthew. Neither Mark nor Luke uses the number 'one'; they merely commented on the more prominent of the two, the one who wanted to go with Jesus. I understand that indeed there were two of them.

84) The Mercy Seat

The Ark of the Testimony was a box made of acacia wood, overlaid with pure gold, in and out. It was about 45 inches long, 27 inches wide and 27 inches high. That box had a lid, of the same length and width, made of pure gold. That lid is generally called the mercy seat;[a] at each end there was a cherub looking in, also of pure gold, of one piece with the lid.[b] That lid was the place where propitiation was effected, the place where God's holiness, justice, love and mercy met together to deal with man's sin. But at first God said to Moses, "there I will meet with you, and I will speak with you from above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubim which are on the ark of the testimony" (Exodus 25:22). Apparently this was a privilege that only Moses had, because after that only the high priest could go into the Most Holy Place, and even so, only once a year. The entire chapter 16 of Leviticus spells out the required procedure, whose purpose was to make atonement for all the sins of the people. The detailed procedure emphasized the difficulty surrounding a propitiating of God's outraged character, outraged by man's sin. Access to the mercy seat was protected by several barriers, the final one being the heavy curtain that separated the Holy Place from

[a] The KJV called the lid the 'mercy seat', and that designation continues in general use. The term 'propitiatory', used as a noun, would perhaps be more precise.

[b] See Exodus 25:10-21.

the Most Holy Place. Anyone who attempted to enter in an unauthorized manner died on the spot.

Those rules were not changed until the Lamb of God achieved the ultimate propitiation—it took an infinite Being to pay an infinite price. God Himself tore that curtain in two, top to bottom, symbolizing in a dramatic way that access to God was now potentially available to all. But there is more to the story than that, as Hebrews makes clear. "Without shedding of blood there is no remission" (Hebrews 9:22). This statement points back to Leviticus 17:11, "For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it to you upon the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement for the soul". Note that for blood to be on the altar it has to be shed—someone, or something, has to die. Recall that "the wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23). In the beginning, the blood of animals was used, but that was only a temporary, stopgap, measure, "because it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (Hebrews 10:4). So where does that leave us?

For an Eternal Being, time is irrelevant, because He knows the end from the beginning.[a] For God Himself to set up and decree a stopgap procedure, He must have had a permanent solution waiting for the appointed time. Indeed, this is expressly stated in 1 Peter 1:18-21: "you were redeemed … with the precious blood of Christ, as of a faultless and pure lamb; who was foreknown indeed before the foundation of the world,[b] but was revealed in these last times for your

[a] As the glorified Jesus said in Revelation 22:13, "I am the Alpha and the Omega, beginning and end, the First and the Last." How could He know that He was the 'end' and the 'last', if He had not been there? I suspect that time and space may be limited to our solar system, being especially relevant to our planet, as the home of the human race. Without time and space, it is impossible to measure the universe.

[b] This sort of 'blows my mind'—the Text is saying that the Lamb, with blood shed, was so known before the creation of our race and planet;

sake." The Lamb of God was the permanent solution. But that permanent solution was not tied to the Ark of the Testimony, with its mercy seat, that was prepared by Moses.[a] God told Moses repeatedly to be sure to make everything "according to the pattern" that he had received on the mountain (Exodus 25:40).

And why was God so insistent? Because that tabernacle with its furnishings was a "copy and shadow of the heavenly things" (Hebrews 8:5).[b] This would appear to mean that there is a 'mercy seat' in Heaven! Is this not clearly implied by Hebrews 9:11-12? "Christ entered once for all into the real Holy Places, having obtained eternal redemption—He had come as High Priest of the good things that are about to be, with the greater and more perfect tabernacle not made with hands, that is to say, not of this creation, 12 and with His own blood, not that of goats and calves." 'Holy Places' being plural, the phrase must include the Most Holy Place, which contains but one piece of furniture, whose principal component is the mercy seat. Christ entered the heavenly Most Holy Place, as eternal high priest, carrying His own blood. And what did He do with that blood? He applied it to

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which means that the Creator knew, before creating, what would happen and the terrible redemption price He Himself would have to pay, yet He went ahead anyway. Wow!

[a] In passing, remember that the 'box' contained three items: 1) the stone tablets, 2) the gold pot full of manna and 3) Aaron's rod that budded—all were covered by the 'lid', the mercy seat. Have you ever considered the significance of those three items? Allow me to suggest the following possibility: 1) the stone tablets represent God's written Revelation to mankind, and its purpose is to orient our conduct; 2) the manna represents God's provision for our physical needs; 3) Aaron's rod represents God's authentication of His plan of salvation, or redemption—His provision for our spiritual need. All three ultimately depend upon the definitive propitiation provided by God's Lamb.

[b] Revelation 15:5 refers to "the sanctuary of the Tabernacle of the testimony in the heaven".

the heavenly mercy seat, “having obtained eternal redemption,” “so that those who have been called may receive the promised eternal inheritance” (Hebrews 9:15).

But even that is not the whole story. The shed blood of God’s Lamb also served for something else; it served to purify the heavenly things (Hebrews 9:23)! But how could anything in Heaven need purifying? Well, is Satan not a contamination, everywhere he goes? Job 1:6 and 2:1 state plainly that Satan presented himself before the LORD in Heaven, along with other high-ranking angels. If I understand Revelation 12:7-12 correctly, Satan still has access to God’s throne:

> War was declared in heaven; Michael and his angels were to wage war with the dragon; so the dragon and his angels made war,[a] **8**but he was not strong enough; neither was there any place found for him in heaven any more. **9**So the great dragon was expelled, that ancient serpent, who is called Slanderer and Satan, who deceives the whole inhabited world; he was thrown into the earth,[b] and his angels were expelled with him. **10**And I heard a loud voice in the heaven saying: “Now the salvation and the power have come,[c] even the Kingdom of our God and the authority of His Christ, because the

[a] The dragon knew that Michael had received the order, so he decided to get in the first blow.

[b] “Into the earth”, including its atmosphere. The idea seems to be that at this point Satan is confined to this planet. From the content of the following verses, I take it that Satan’s expulsion occurs in the middle of the seven-year period. So he is still in heaven accusing us (accusing us of what? There would be no point in bringing false accusations, so we must be providing Satan with ‘ammunition’—not a nice thought!).

[c] Wait a minute! If it is only “Now”, where have the Kingdom and Authority been in the meantime? As long as a government is being challenged, its rule is not complete or tranquil. I find it instructive that Satan still has sufficient power to wage war, in Heaven!

accuser of our brothers[a] has been thrown down, who accused them before our God day and night. **11**And they conquered[b] him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, and they did not cherish their lives, *even* up to death. **12**Therefore rejoice, O heavens, yes, you who are dwelling in them![c] Woe to the earth and the sea! Because the devil has come down to you, having great wrath, knowing that he has little time."

Once Satan is expelled from Heaven, the final cleansing will take place. According to our timeframe, the Lamb's propitiation has already occurred, while the expelling of Satan is still in the future. But to an Eternal Being our timeframe is irrelevant. The heavenly things have been cleansed.

The eternal mercy seat, with the infinite propitiation, resides in the heavenly Tabernacle. It is there that God's holiness, justice, love and mercy met together[d] and formulated the definitive solution to man's sin, and all other consequences of Lucifer's rebellion. It is that mercy seat that guarantees the Plan of Redemption, with all its ramifications. Oh praise our God! Surely a doxology is in order.

Praise God from whom all blessings flow,
Praise Him all creatures here below,
Praise Him above ye heavenly host,
Praise Father, Son and Holy Ghost!

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[a] "Our brothers"—I wonder who is speaking, since the 'brothers' are saved by the blood of the lamb.

[b] That is what the Text says. Comparing 6:11 and 7:13 (Revelation), perhaps it is necessary for a certain number of God's servants to be willing to die for the Cause to bring about the accuser's expulsion.

[c] It is the inhabitants that do the rejoicing, not the place.

[d] God's holiness alone could not resolve the problem, nor His justice alone, nor His love alone, nor His mercy alone—it took all four, working together.

How many sermons have you heard, or preached, on the subject of the heavenly mercy seat, or even the earthly one? I would suggest for your consideration that this has been a serious omission. The mercy seat should be at the center of any and every exposition of God's Plan of Redemption. Perhaps then people would not be so careless about their relationship with the Sovereign Creator!

85) The Natsorean

Every version that I remember seeing misleads the reader by obliterating one of the Lord's titles, a title that the glorified Jesus Himself used when dealing with Saul of Tarsus on the Damascus-road. When Saul asked, "Who are you, Lord?", He answered, "I am Jesus the Natsorean, whom you are persecuting" (Acts 22:8). Most versions at this place render 'Jesus of Nazareth', while some have 'Jesus the Nazarene'. For an explanation of why I use 'ts' instead of 'z', please see my article, "'Prophets' in Matthew 3:23", item 69) above.

The familiar 'Nazarene' [*Ναζαρηνος*] occurs four times: Mark 1:24, 14:67, 16:6 and Luke 4:34. 'Jesus the Nazarene' would appear to be another way of saying 'Jesus of/from Nazareth', and some versions so translate the phrase. Unfortunately, the versions do the same with 'Natsorean' [*Ναζωραιος*], which I consider to be a serious error. Just looking at the two Greek words, they are obviously different. The Hebrew root is *netser*, 'branch', a reference to Isaiah 11.1 ('Nazareth' is a transliteration of the Hebrew name). Going back to Acts 22:8, why would Jesus waste time with the name of a town? He was dealing with a highly instructed Pharisee; He introduced Himself as David's Branch, the Messiah—a reference that Saul would immediately understand.

'Natsorean' occurs fifteen times: Matthew 2:23, 26:71; Mark 10:47; Luke 18:37, 24:19; John 18:5,7, 19:19; Acts 2:22,

3:6, 4:10, 6:14, 22:8, 24:5 and 26:9. All have the definite article, except the first one—the Natsorean; except that in Acts 24:5 Felix speaks of 'the sect of the Natsoreans'. Speaking of Felix, his use of the term 'sect' is instructive. Aside from Acts 22:8, that I have already discussed, I consider that John 19:19 deserves special comment. The title above the cross read: This is Jesus the Natsorean, the King of the Jews. Pilate had evidently researched Jesus quite well (anyone with a large following is a potential problem); I believe that he knew precisely what he was doing when he used 'Natsorean', just as he knew precisely what he was doing when he put 'the King of the Jews'. For more on the subject of Pilate, please see my article: "Poor Pilate—wrong place, wrong time", item 67) above.

Whatever version of the Bible you are using, I would urge you to correct it at the references mentioned above, so you know when a title is being used. 'The Natsorean' needs to be added to any list of the Lord's titles.

86) The problem of Dinah's age

Genesis 33:4, "Then Esau ran to meet him and embraced him, falling on his neck and kissing him; and they wept."

Jacob and Esau certainly said much more than is recorded in the Text. Jacob certainly asked for news of his parents, and it is more than likely that Rebekah was already dead. Sarah died at the age of 127, and Rebekah was at least 120 when Jacob fled, and he had been gone twenty years. This explains why Jacob was in no hurry to see his father. It is also possible that Jacob was bitter toward his father: if Isaac had recognized what God had told Rebekah, and the fact that Esau had sold the birthright, and had not tried to bless Esau anyway, Jacob would not have gone through the distress and humiliation that he did. In fact, it seems that Isaac was in his last ten years when Jacob finally showed up (**35:27-29**). The fact that Jacob

was in no hurry to see his father explains what happened at Succoth.

Genesis 33:16, "So Esau returned that day to Seir by the same route. **17** And Jacob went to Succoth, and built himself a house, and made shelters for his cattle; therefore he called the name of that place Succoth."

The name means: shelters. We do not know how long Jacob stayed in Succoth, but if he built a house for himself and made shelters for his livestock, he certainly stayed there for some time; probably a few years. They were accustomed to tents; it is very strange that he would have built a house. In **31:3** Jehovah said to Jacob, "Return to the land of your fathers, and to your family"; but since Succoth was on the east side of the Jordan, Jacob stopped before entering that land. Jacob's attitude is indeed strange.

On second thought, Jacob must have stayed there for quite a number of years, because of the problem of Dinah's age. When they arrived in Succoth, Reuben, the firstborn, could have been no more than thirteen years old. **30:21** says that Dinah was born "after" Zebulun, Leah's sixth son, so Dinah may not have been even five years old. To attract Shechem's attention, she would have had to be a well-developed teenager, probably at least fifteen years old. Also, Simeon and Levi would have been no more than twelve and eleven when they arrived in Succoth, but to do what they did (**34:25**), they would have had to be men at full strength. They stayed in Succoth for at least ten years, but I would guess that it was between thirteen and fifteen. The time they spent near Shechem before plundering the city was probably not very long.

87) The ‘smallest’ seed?

Mark 4:31-32, Matthew 13:32

In the NKJV, Mark 4:31-32 reads like this: “It is like a mustard seed which, when it is sown on the ground, is smaller than all the seeds on earth; but when it is sown, it grows up and becomes greater than all herbs, and shoots out large branches, so that the birds of the air may nest under its shade.”

The rendering ‘the smallest seed in the world/earth’ is unfortunate and misleading. The Text has ‘of those on the ground’, repeating the phrase above it, only eliding the verb. The Lord was not making a global botanical statement, as the next verse makes clear—He was referring to vegetables planted in a garden in His day and in that area, and of such herbs mustard had the smallest seed. To object that tobacco and orchid seeds are smaller is beside the point. My translation reads like this: “It is like a mustard seed, that when it is sown on the ground is the smallest of all such seeds, yet when it is sown, it grows up and becomes larger than all the garden herbs and produces big branches, so that the birds of the air are able to rest in its shade.” The verb I have rendered ‘to rest’ is a compound form. The noun root refers to a temporary shelter, like a tent or a hut. The verbal form means to make use of such a shelter. Here the preposition *kata* is prefixed to the verb, emphasizing, as I suppose, the temporariness. The Text says that the birds can use the shade, not the branches. But shade moves with the sun, and with the wind—how can you build a nest in something that keeps moving around (the Text actually says ‘under its shade’)? My comments also serve for Matthew 13:32, except that there the birds are resting in the ‘branches’, rather than the shade. The verb is the same, and I handle it the same way, ‘rest’ rather than ‘nest’, although ‘nest’ is possible.

88) The theory of evolution

All genuine science is based on the principle of cause and effect—we observe an effect and try to isolate the cause; and it is logically impossible for a cause to produce an effect larger or more complex than itself. Any human being who is both honest and intelligent, when confronted with the observable universe with its incredible organization and complexity, is obliged to conclude that there must be a CAUSE, a Cause with intelligence and power beyond our understanding—to refuse to do so is to be perverse. Since we have personality, He must also.

The only alternative to a Cause would be chance working with nothing. But it is stupidly, ridiculously impossible that chance, working blindly with nothing, could produce anything. 10 x 0 = 0, 1,000 x 0 = 0, 1,000,000 x 0 = 0, and so on; no matter how many times you multiply zero, the result is always zero. If you multiply zero by something every day during five billion (or trillion) years, the result will always be zero. That chance working blindly with nothing produced the universe is scientifically impossible: absolutely, stupidly, ridiculously impossible. Even if one starts with the superstition of a 'big bang' of inorganic (without life) material, where did life come from. [I bypass the question of where all that inorganic material came from.]

The science of physics tells us that the inorganic [no life] known universe can be described with up to 350 information 'bits'; but it takes 1,500 information 'bits' to describe the smallest protein—it is so small that it cannot live by itself, but it is part of a living system. So how could evolution produce life? Where could chance find 1,150 'bits' of new information, if in the whole universe there were only 350? Not only that, the 'e-coli' bacteria takes about seven million 'bits', and one human cell takes around twenty billion 'bits'! The theory of

evolution, to explain the origin of life, is stupidly, ridiculously impossible!!

The science of genetics, with its genome projects, has discovered that a random change of only three nucleotides is fatal to the organism. Consider the chimpanzee, presumably man's 'nearest relative': the genetic difference is said to be about 1.6%. That may not sound like much, but it is around 48 million nucleotide differences, and a random change of only three nucleotides is fatal to the animal—it follows that it is simply impossible for a chimp to evolve until it becomes a man (some 15 million chimps would perish in the attempt, never getting beyond the first three nucleotides!). Each different type of animal had to be created separately, just as Genesis affirms. Any evolutionary hypothesis, to explain the different types of animals (not to mention birds, insects, fish, plants, etc.) is scientifically impossible: absolutely, stupidly, ridiculously impossible.

The so-called 'geologic column' is a fiction. In Australia there are fossilized tree trunks, upright, passing through various layers of sedimentary rock, that according to the 'geologic column' represent many millions of years—stupidly, ridiculously impossible! In the U.S. there is a high plateau (mesa) with a layer of older rock on top of a layer of newer rock (according to the 'column'), but the area involved is so extensive that no known force would be able to overcome the friction caused by an attempt to have one layer slide over the other layer (the argument that is used)—this also is impossible for the 'geologic column'.

Some 60 miles southwest of Dallas, Texas, there is a town called Glen Rose, that is close to the Paluxy River. The Dinosaur Valley State Park is located there, because the river bed has tracks of two types of dinosaur: three-toed and four-toed. Upriver from the park a paleontologist named Dr. Carl Baugh bought a significant amount of land on both sides of the river,

so he could do his own excavations. On his property he has a museum that I myself have visited. In the **same layer** of sedimentary rock he encountered the following: two trilobite fossils, that evolutionists say existed 550 million years ago; a fossilized moss called 'lapidodendron', that evolutionists say existed 250 million years ago; a complete fossil of a dinosaur called 'acrocanthasaurus' (40 feet long), that evolutionists say existed 100 million years ago; seven tracks of a huge 'cat', that evolutionists say existed 6 million years ago; 57 human footprints (some being inside a dinosaur track); the fourth finger of a woman's left hand, fossilized; and even a pre-diluvian iron hammer (its iron does not rust, being 96.6% iron and 2.7% chlorine)—**all of that in the very same layer of sedimentary rock**!

It follows that a geologic column does not exist; it is a perverse invention perpetrated by dishonest and perverse persons. All those fossils were produced by Noah's Flood, about 4,365 years ago; otherwise, how can you explain that all those things are in the very same layer of rock? (We may note in passing that it is common for defenders of the 'geologic column' to argue in a circle: the age of a rock layer is determined by the fossils it contains, while the age of a fossil is determined by the rock layer where it is found!)

Furthermore, the earth is young. In the royal observatory in England they have been measuring the force of the magnetic field that surrounds the earth each year since 1839. They have found that the magnetic force is diminishing at a constant rate, or geometric progression: plotting the yearly values on a graph, they form a cline. This means that it is possible to project the line in both directions. If we project the line to a point 10,000 years ago, the magnetic force would be so strong that it would crush all life on the planet. It follows that any theory that requires millions, or billions of years is stupidly, ridiculously impossible.

The Mississippi river dumps 80,000 tons of sediment into the gulf of Mexico [now America] every hour! All you have to do is measure the delta to see that the earth is young. The diameter of the sun is diminishing at the rate of about 40 inches every hour. Projecting backwards for 100,000 years the sun would be twice its present size—it would fry everything on the earth's surface; there would be no life. Evolutionists say that granite took 300 million years to crystalize, but within granite there are polonium 'haloes' with half-lives of minutes, or even seconds. Granite had to be created instantaneously. Symbiotic plants and insects had to be created at the same time, and require 24-hour days. And so on.

In short, the evolutionary hypothesis of origins is scientifically impossible: absolutely, stupidly, ridiculously impossible. A number of decades ago the scholar Sir Frederick Hoyle was contracted to evaluate the scientific probability that life could have appeared on the planet by chance (he had unlimited funding and free access to libraries). He arrived at the following conclusion: it would be easier for a whirlwind to pass through a junk yard and a perfect Boeing 747 come flying out of the other side than for life to have appeared on our planet by chance. Well, well, well, that life could have originated by an evolutionary process is obviously, stupidly, ridiculously impossible! [By the way, any questions about the morality of the Creator have nothing to do with science.]

89) The tithe

The word 'tithe' means the tenth part, 10% (Leviticus 27:32). Tithing was codified by the Law of Moses, but the idea existed before that. Abraham tithed Melchizedek: "Abram gave him a tithe of all" (Genesis 14:18-20; Hebrews 7:2). Job gave a lot (Job 29:11-17). I would say that tithing is like the

rent we pay the Creator for the use of the earth's natural resources – water, air, soil, wood, etc. But those who are aware of the multiple benefits we receive from the Creator tend to give more, like Job.

The tithe belongs to the LORD [not the church]: "All the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land, or of the fruit of the tree, is the LORD's. It is holy to the LORD. And concerning the tithe of the herd or the flock, of whatever passes under the rod, the tenth one shall be holy to the LORD" (Leviticus 27:30, 32). At that time, the entire economy was based on agriculture and animal husbandry; nowadays the economy is much more diversified, but the principle does not change. 10% remains 10%, whether it is still mandatory or not.

Now look at Numbers 18:26: "Speak to the Levites and say to them: 'When you receive from the Israelites the tithe I give you as an inheritance, you must present a tenth of that tithe as the LORD's offering". Those who receive tithes—whether Levites, pastors, or missionaries—must also tithe. A personal observation: Even though I am a slave of Jesus, as I am, and living my life to serve the Kingdom, as I do, I understand that there is a principle here that should not be disregarded, because I have seen the negative consequences of such disregard; I, in our day, and therefore I myself do not disregard it.

Now then, since putting money directly into God's hand is not possible, nor does He need it, the idea is to redistribute it to those in need. Deuteronomy 26:12-13: "When you have finished setting aside a tenth of all your produce in the third year, the year of the tithe, you shall give it to the Levite, the alien, the fatherless and the widow, so that they may eat in your towns and be satisfied. Then say to the LORD your God:

‘I have removed from my house the sacred portion and have given it to the Levite, the alien, the fatherless and the widow, according to all you commanded. I have not turned aside from your commands, nor have I forgotten any of them’.” In the context, Moses was giving instructions for just after the occupation of the land, hence 'the third year'; after that it would have to be every year, of course— otherwise the produce would spoil and the needy would starve.

The main text used to 'impose' tithing on believers today is Malachi 3:8-10: "Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed me! But you say, ‘In what way have we robbed you?’ In tithes and offerings. You are cursed with a curse, for you have robbed me, even this whole nation. Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house, and try me now in this, says the LORD of hosts, if I will not open for you the windows of heaven, and pour out for you such blessing that there will not be room enough to receive it.” Although this text was addressed to the people of Israel, I believe it continues to be true that God really does bless the tither, to this day (see Proverbs 3:9-10 as well).

But to return to Malachi, the crucial point is in verse 10: “Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house . . . says Jehovah of hosts.” Was Jehovah’s ‘house’ the temple? In Malachi's time Ezra's temple was more or less new, and far less pretentious than Solomon's. The warehouse would not be the temple itself, since stored food could spoil (giving off a bad smell, attracting rats, etc.). Beyond question the food was distributed to the needy, otherwise the warehouse would turn into a dump.

The difficulty today is that every pastor wants 'the house of the Lord' to be his church—but does that follow? The NT speaks of the Church as the 'house of God', but it is the global

Church, not a local congregation. Hebrews 10:21: "Having a Great Priest over the house of God". It is the global church. 1 Timothy 3:15: "so that you may know how it is necessary to conduct yourself in God's household, which is the Church of the living God, pillar and foundation of the truth."[a] It is the global church. 1 Peter 4:17: "Because the time has come for judgment to begin at God's house; now if it starts with us, what will be the end of those who keep disobeying the Gospel of God?" It is the global church. And don't forget Galatians 6:10: "So then, as we have opportunity, let us do what is good toward every-one, but especially toward those who are of the household of the faith." Each of us must listen to the Holy Spirit, so that we may know what we should do, case by case.

In passing, we may agree on the following. Naturally, if you participate in a community that has expenses – water, electricity, taxes, wages [pastor (1 Timothy 5:17), janitor], etc.—you should help with those expenses; of course, and that may take a portion of your tithe, but you should listen to the Owner—simply giving the tithe to the church, without caring what they do with it, may seem comfortable, but I doubt that it will work before the judgment seat of Christ; the one who has to answer for the blessings you have received is you!

In the New Testament there is no mention of tithing after the day of Pentecost, apart from mentioning some historical event in the Old Testament. In the Gospels the Lord Jesus criticized some misuse of tithe by Pharisees. The point is that

[a] My first impression would be that the truth should be sustaining the Church, not the other way around. But it is the Church that has the responsibility to promote and defend the truth in global society – in education, in health, in commerce, in government, everywhere.

now we are to serve God because we want to, not because we have to. As Jesus told the Samaritan woman, the Father wants to worship in spirit and in truth (John 4:23-24). And God still wants us to help those in need.

In Luke 14:26-33 the Lord Jesus defines discipleship; first, verses 26-27: “If anyone comes to me and does not hate his father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters, yes, and even his own life, he cannot be my disciple. And whoever does not carry his cross, and come after me, cannot be my disciple.” Then He gave two practical examples and concluded with verse 33: “So likewise, any of you who does not renounce all his own possessions cannot be my disciple”. Note that three times Sovereign Jesus said, “cannot be my disciple”, and the ‘cannot’ is a strong negative. Jesus demands first place in our lives and in our hearts—above family, material things, our very being. In verse 26 the verb 'to hate' is not an active hatred, it goes in the direction of disregard. In line 33 'all' is 100%; the tithe is gone; now Jesus demands everything. I know, you didn't like it. How is that possible? If I give it all away, how can I survive, etc. The solution is to be a slave of Jesus. Exactly how this works is explained in another video in this series, 'How to save your life'. Further, I invite attention to Luke 12:22-34, where Jesus portrays what I call the Kingdom mentality; those verses contain no fewer than ten commands. It is worth reading them carefully.

In the NT we have several texts, already in the time of the Church, which say that we should help the needy. I will cite here only Paul's example in Acts 20:34-35: “You yourselves know that these hands have supplied my own needs, and of those who were with me. In every way I showed you that working hard like this it is necessary to help the weak, and to remember the word of the Lord Jesus, that He Himself said,

‘It is more blessed to give than to receive’.” Although this saying of the Lord Jesus is not found in the four Gospels, He must have said many things that were not recorded, and Paul was informed of this saying by someone who heard it. Note, 'It is necessary to help the weak’.

I ask special attention to 'It is more blessed to give than to receive': we should not deprive anyone of the blessing of giving. When I was about 20, I turned down a small offering from someone I thought needed it more than I did. But that night the Holy Spirit made me understand that He was not pleased. I had deprived that person of the blessing of giving. I learned, and I never again turned down an offering, from whoever it was. (However, it is necessary to be awake to neutralize anything cursed that is offered to us.)

Conclusion: tithing is no longer mandatory, because God wants voluntary service. Having said that, God continues to bless the tither, but we must remember that the tithe belongs to the LORD, not to the church. Yes, because we are to be disciples of JESUS, not of the church, nor of any denomination. And Jesus demands total commitment, but at the same time He guarantees to supply the basic needs of those who live to serve the Kingdom (Matthew 6:33).

90) The Trinity

Matthew 28:19

It is the Great Commission, the Lord Jesus giving a solemn declaration: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. As you go, make disciples all ethnic nations: baptizing them into the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit; . . . "

Our Lord defines the Trinity here. According to Greek gram-mar the use of ‘and’ plus the definite article with items

in a series makes clear that the items are distinct entities. So "the Father" is different from "the Son" is different from "the Holy Spirit". So we have three persons. But He also said, "into the name", singular, not 'names'. So we have only one name. God is one 'name' or essence subsisting in three persons.

This baptism is to be administered **into the name of the Trinity, which represents a new revelation about the nature of God.** It also represents a new 'religion', being different from what was known up to that time. In the OT there are veiled references, and looking back we can associate them with the Trinity, but here we have the first clear statement of it.

It is a mystery, but if we are to take the whole Bible seriously, we are obliged to believe in the Trinity, the Triune God. That is why since the 3rd century the Trinity has been the orthodox doctrine of the Christian Church.

The Sabellian or Modalist (who believes that the Father and the Son are identical – the idea of 'oneness') must maintain that Jesus made a mistake when he gave the Great Commission, or that Matthew recorded it wrongly. If Jesus made a mistake, he is not God; if Matthew made a mistake, he was not inspired. If someone denies the divinity of Jesus, or the inspiration of Matthew, he cannot be a true Christian – he is a heretic.

See also John 8:17-18 – the Lord Jesus, after observing that the Law requires two witnesses, declares that He Himself is one and the Father is another. Now, if the Father and the Son were identical (as the Sabellians claim) then Christ would be deliberately deceiving His listeners. However, in verse 19 He states that to know Him is to know the Father. Again, only the doctrine of the Trinity can do justice to all the texts.

The doctrine of the Trinity is one of the cardinal or fundamental doctrines of the Christian Faith; it is one of the doctrines that defines that Faith. For example, the Orthodox Jew

is a monotheist, he believes in the God of the Old Testament, but he is definitely not a Christian. Anyone who does not believe in the Trinity should not present himself as a Christian. It is a question of consistency.

But what does it mean to be baptized into the name of the Trinity? A person's name represents that person. To do something 'in the name of the king' means that the king gave the order; whoever said it represents the king (or claims that he does). So what does it mean to be baptized into the Trinity? Well, if you are within the Trinity, you are protected by them, since to reach you an attack must pass through them. That is tremendous! So then, the true meaning of this baptism should be this: it is a public declaration, taking a formal stand, whereby the candidate is formally renouncing Satan, and the world he controls, and is placing himself under the protection of the Triune God. It is to change sides, to change kingdoms. (Kind reader, do you know of any local church, anywhere, that teaches this meaning for this baptism? Alas!) For a fuller discussion, please see "Baptisms in the Bible", item 7) above.

91) The wedding in Cana

John:1-11

In John 1:43 Jesus decided to leave for Galilee, since He was in Judea, on the east side of the Jordan River, more or less opposite Jericho, probably. In 2:13 Jesus returned to Judea, but to Jerusalem, because of the Passover. The interval would have been two or three weeks. Well, each 'leg' of the trip must have been at least 130 km, on foot, which allows us to deduce that the reason for the trip was of some importance.

"On the third day a wedding took place in Cana of Galilee" (2:1). The third day counting from when? 1:19-28 happened on one day; 1:29-34 happened the next day (2nd); 1:35-42

happened the following day (3rd); 1:43-51 happened the day after that (4th). So the third day here should be counted from the last day mentioned (1:43-51), although it may be included (which is likely, in Jewish thought). The wedding feast began that day, but such feasts often lasted for several days. Jesus and His disciples (four?) had a walk of about 130 km (probably): 90 up the Jordan Valley (relatively flat and straight) and 40 through more rugged terrain. Since everyone made their journeys on foot, and therefore were used to it, they could easily complete the journey in two days. Therefore, they would have arrived there by the end of the first day of the party (if not earlier).

Jesus' family lived in Natsareth, which was perhaps 30 km from Cana, in a straight line, but the terrain was rugged. The entire family was at the wedding (2:12), but the lack of any mention of Joseph permits us to understand that he was already dead. Therefore, as the eldest son, Jesus was the head of the family. Mary was in a position to give orders to the employees (2:5). Adding it all up, I come to the conclusion that the bride was one of Jesus' half-sisters,[a] which would give the mother, Mary, the authority to give instructions; it would also explain her concern about the lack of wine. It would also explain what prompted Jesus to undertake such a journey, only to return with little delay.

A wedding feast would usually last several days. The supply of food and drink would not run out until near the end, in the event. If Mary was the bride's mother, we can understand her concern about the lack of wine, since it would be a

[a] In Matthew 13:54-56 the inhabitants of Natsareth name Mary as the mother of Jesus; James, Joseph, Simon and Judas as His brothers (half-brothers); and they spoke of "all their sisters" (half-sisters). The use of 'all' suggests more than two, and the married woman in Cana would no longer be there. After Jesus was born, Joseph and Mary had a normal family.

disgrace to the family. But why appeal to Jesus, even though He was the head of the family? What could He do? It seems to me that she was asking for a miracle, at least judging by the order she gave to the employees; in fact, it would be the only possible solution. Jesus' answer, that it was not yet time, goes in the same direction. But why, then, did He choose to act anyway? I do not know, the Text does not say; but I offer the following suggestion: Jesus well knew that the function of being His mother brought humiliation to Mary, because the gossips would not forgive the fact that she had married already pregnant (and even though Joseph had assumed him as a son, the physical aspect of Jesus didn't match)[a]—Jesus understood that he owed her a special consideration. Besides, Jesus owed the family a great deal, and it would be up to Him to avoid embarrassing her, if possible.

The fact is that Jesus acted and produced around 600 liters of wine–600 liters of wine! Well, if there were 100 people at the feast, that would make six liters per person! Who would drink six liters (near the end of the feast)? And the wine was of outstanding quality. My conclusion is that Jesus gave the new couple a nice gift—most of the wine would be left over, and could be sold later. Because it was very good, the wine would bring a good price. I find it curious that the first miraculous sign was not a healing one, but a domestic one. He 'saved the feast', saving the family from a disgrace, and He made a significant contribution to the new couple's happiness–to them, at least, Jesus would always be remembered as a benefactor.

[a] John 8:41 is inserted in the midst of a heated argument between Jesus and the Pharisees. They had researched everything about Jesus thoroughly. They knew that Jesus was born six months after Joseph and Mary's marriage, and was born normal size. Two plus two equals four.

92) The will of God

THE SOVREIGNTY OF GOD COVERS EVERYTHING

(Ephesians 1:11, Isaiah 46:9^{b}-10)

THE WILL OF GOD WITH REFERENCE TO THE EARTH

I. Imposed, inevitable: At times God intervenes in situations, obliging or forbidding certain things.

II. Permitting human volition and choice.

A. Conscience: All are born with it.

B. Passive, permissive: The sinful choices of men and angels; we have to live with the consequences.

C. Active, declared:

1. Conjoined: When we collaborate with the Holy Spirit, bringing divine action to bear on circumstances—John 5:19, 14:12.
2. Moral: The ten commandments and other declarations of the will of God that are generic—everyone should obey them. If everyone did, we would live in peace, justice and abundance.
3. Individual: Psalms 37:23—"steps"; Proverbs 3:5-6—"your (sg)"; Psalms 37:5—"your (sg) way": Psalms 32:8—"you (sg) should". "Horse" (Psalms 32:9) X "slave" (John 13:13,16) X "friend" (John 15:15,20).
   a. Analogy of a slave (or employee)—you have to know the specific will of the owner.
   b. Analogy of a body with members (1 Cor. 12:12-18) and the gifts of the Spirit (1 Cor. 12:7-11, 27-28)—the functions are specific and different.
   c. Be guided by the Spirit (Rom. 8:14; Gal. 5:16,18,25; Eph. 5:18).

HOW TO DISCERN THE INDIVIDUAL WILL?

? (Circumstances, counsel, Bible, common sense, what you want?) **?** See Ps. 37:4 → Isa. 58:13-14; Jer. 17:5,9; Ps. 106:15.

1. The witness of the Holy Spirit in our spirit (Col. 3:15; Filip. 4:6-7; Isa. 26:3).
2. This is only for disciples/slaves—you cannot play games with God (James 1:2-8).
3. Oswald Chambers—"the checks of the Spirit".
4. Wait for God [when He puts you in the dark], do not devise your own 'light' (Isaiah 50:10-11).
5. Intimacy → sensitivity (Psalm 32:8).

93) 'This is', or 'you are'?

Matthew 3:17 X Mark 1:11, Luke 3:22

In the NKJV, Matthew 3:17 reads like this: "And suddenly a voice came from heaven, saying, 'This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased'." And Mark 1:11 reads like this: "Then a voice came from heaven, 'You are My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased'." Luke also has "You are". So what did the Voice actually say? In a manner similar to what happened on the Day of Pentecost, I conclude that each hearer received his own interpretation, or message. Matthew records the event from John's perspective: he heard, "This is …" Mark and Luke record the event from Jesus' perspective: He heard, "You are …" At Pentecost, with over a dozen languages being spoken at once, even if one of them was yours, it would require a personal miracle in your ear to enable you to extract your message from the welter of sound.

94) 'Valley', or ravine'?

Luke 3:5

In the NKJV, Luke 3:4-5 reads like this: "The voice of one crying in the wilderness: 'Prepare the way of the Lord; make His paths straight. Every valley shall be filled and every mountain and hill brought low; the crooked places shall be made straight and the rough ways smooth…'" Does this mean

that the surface of the earth will be flattened out? My translation reads like this: “A voice calling out: ‘Prepare the way of the Lord in the wilderness, make His paths straight. [5]Every ravine will be filled up, and every mountain and hill will be leveled; the crooked parts of the roads will be straightened out, and the rough parts will be smoothed out; …” The reference is to Isaiah 40:3. Hebrew poetry, and prose, makes heavy use of parallel or synonymous statements. From the context in Isaiah, it seems clear that “in the wilderness” goes with the verb “make straight”, not “call out”. But why a straight road in the wilderness? Any road facilitates the movement of people and goods, but a straight road through accidented terrain is a major asset, and Jerusalem is surrounded by accidented terrain. I render ‘ravine’ according to the normal meaning of the Greek word here; ‘ravine’ is also one of the normal meanings of the corresponding Hebrew word in Isaiah. Actually, Isaiah 40:3-4 describes the construction of a modern super highway. Verse 5 describes what happens where the highway passes, not all over the place.

95) When did Jesus leave Annas?

John 18:24

After Jesus was taken prisoner in the Garden, only John mentions that He was taken first to Annas; all the others only mention His being taken to Caiaphas, where the recorded proceedings took place, although of the three only Matthew actually names him (Matthew 26:57, Mark 14:53, Luke 22:54).

So far, so good, but the difficulty begins with John 18:15, that takes up Peter’s denials without further ado; but Peter’s denials took place at Caiaphas’ house, not Annas’. Then verses 19-23 have the high priest questioning Jesus, still at Caiaphas’. Then comes verse 24: NKJV reads, “Then Annas sent Him bound to Caiaphas the high priest”; NIV reads,

"Then Annas sent him, still bound, to Caiaphas the high priest" (but a footnote offers, "Now Annas had sent him"); TEV reads, "So Annas sent him, still bound, to Caiaphas the High Priest"; while NASB reads, "Annas therefore sent Him bound to Caiaphas the high priest". All four of these versions have John 18:15-23 occurring in Annas' house, rather than that of Caiaphas—the NIV footnote points to the correct rendering.

It would appear that all four of the versions follow the so-called 'critical' (read 'eclectic') text, that follows some 9% of the Greek manuscripts in adding a conjunction, 'then' or 'therefore' (*ouv*), after the initial verb, thereby creating the 'problem'. Following the 90%, including the best line of transmission, I render, "(Annas had sent Him bound to Caiaphas the high priest.)". The use of parenthetical comments, or historical /cultural asides, is standard procedure for John; for a partial list see: 1:44, 2:6, 4:2,9,44, 6:4,64, 7:50, 9:14, 11:2, 18-19,30-31, 12:1,6,16, 13:2,11,28-29 (there are at least a dozen more). I take it that verse 24 here is just one more instance; it is as if at this point John realizes that the reader could think that the proceedings were still going on at Annas' house. 8:25 resumes with Peter's denials. Following the correct Text, and the correct understanding thereof, John's record is not at variance with that of the other three Gospels.

96) When is an apostle?

The beginning

The basic meaning of the term is 'sent one'; in John 13:16 it is used in that way. But within the incipient Christian Church it came to have a specialized meaning: an office or function characterized by special spiritual authority. It began with the twelve disciples who were personally chosen by Jesus; after His resurrection they received the designation, 'apostles' (but the Iscariot had lost his place, leaving eleven). With the

exception of four verses (Luke 11:49, John 13:16, Acts 14:4 and 14) I would say that all the occurrences of the term in the four Gospels and Acts, about thirty-five, refer to that group, as do Galatians 1:17, 19; 2 Peter 3:2; Jude 17 and Revelation 21:14. The purpose of this note is to enquire whether the NT signals any further uses of the term.

Acts 1:13-26 records Peter's initiative to replace the Iscariot. The Text does not say that it was God's idea; and when they asked God to choose between the two candidates, they did not give Him the option of saying "neither". The Text affirms that Matthias was numbered with the Eleven apostles, but he receives no further mention.

Paul (erstwhile Saul of Tarsus) repeatedly refers to himself as an apostle: Romans 1:1, 11:13, 1 Corinthians 1:1, 9:1, 2, 15:9, 2 Corinthians 1:1, Galatians 1:1, Ephesians 1:1, Colossians 1:1, 1 Thessalonians 2:6, 1 Timothy 1:1, 2:7, 2 Timothy 1:1, 11 and Titus 1:1. Luke refers to Paul as an apostle in Acts 14:4 and 14. Jesus personally chose Paul, returning from Heaven to do so. Aside from the Eleven, Paul was the only one personally designated by Jesus.

Jesus Himself is called "the Apostle" of our confession in Hebrews 3:1. Peter calls himself an apostle in 1 Peter 1:1 and 2 Peter 1:1, but of course he is one of the Twelve. James, the half-brother of Jesus, became the 'big boss' in Jerusalem, and evidently was regarded as an apostle—1 Corinthians 15:7 and Galatians 1:19. Luke refers to Barnabas as an apostle: Acts 14:4 and 14. Paul seems to refer to Silvanus and Timothy as apostles: 1 Thessalonians 2:6. It is possible to interpret Romans 16:7 in the same way with reference to Andronicus and Junias. I believe those are the only ones who are actually named.

The discussion up to this point was necessary to provide the background for the questions that are the occasion for this study: did 'apostle' become an established office or

function for the ongoing life of the Church, until the return of Christ, and if so, how is an apostle to be designated or recognized? It is my intention to analyze every verse where the term is used, and I will begin with those that may be purely historical, going on from those already dealt with.

In 2 Corinthians 11:5 and 12:11 Paul compares himself to 'the most eminent apostles', which must be limited to his contemporaries. 1 Corinthians 9:5 also must be limited to his contemporaries. 1 Corinthians 15:5 and 7 refer to physical appearances of the resurrected Jesus before His ascension (of necessity historical). 1 Corinthians 4:9 is a little different: "I think that God has displayed us, the apostles, last, as men condemned to death; for we have been made a spectacle to the world, both to angels and to men" (read also verses 10-13). In the context, Paul is complaining about the way he has been treated by some in Corinth, but in this verse he seems actually to be blaming God for the way he has been treated! I suppose that the use of the word 'last' would be a comparison with God's servants in prior ages. Paul is not talking about the future of the Church in this passage, and if we only had this text on the subject, we would have to conclude that to be an apostle was not a good thing.

And now we come to Luke 11:49-51, a most interesting text. "Therefore the wisdom of God also said, 'I will send them prophets and apostles, and some of them they will kill and persecute,' that the blood of all the prophets which was shed from the foundation of the world may be required of this generation, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah who perished between the altar and the temple. Yes, I say to you, it shall be required of this generation." Jesus is speaking, deriding the lawyers. His citation of "the wisdom of God" appears to have no match in the OT, so what was His meaning? In 1 Corinthians 1:24 Paul refers to Christ as 'the wisdom of God'. In Matthew 23:34 Jesus said, "I send you

prophets", so here Jesus may be referring to Himself as 'the wisdom of God'. However that may be, if the "required of this generation" was fulfilled in 70 AD, as I suppose, then the 'apostles' here are also historical.

I will now consider the other places where the phrase 'prophets and apostles' occurs, albeit with the terms in reverse order: Ephesians 2:20 and 3:5, and Revelation 18:20.

Ephesians 2:19-22—"So then, you are no longer strangers and aliens, but fellow citizens with the saints and members of God's household, **20**built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ Himself being the chief corner-stone; **21**in whom the whole building, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord; **22**in whom you also are being built together to become a habitation of God in spirit." The truth that Paul is expounding is that in Christ Gentiles join Jews as "fellow citizens" and "members of God's household", part of "the whole building". In what sense can that "building" be built upon "the foundation of the apostles and prophets"? Presumably "prophets" is short for the writings that make up the Old Testament Scriptures, or Canon. **The Faith is based on revealed Truth, not individual people**. Analogously, presumably "apostles" is short for the writings that make up the New Testament Scriptures, or Canon. Again, the Faith is based on revealed Truth, not individual people. Our "growing into a holy temple" (verse 21) depends upon the Holy Spirit and His Sword (not individuals whom God used). Note that Paul mentions the 'apostles' first. In any case, the 'apostles' here are historical.

Ephesians 3:1-7—"For this reason I, Paul, the prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you Gentiles—**2**surely you have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me for you, **3**how that by revelation He made known to me the

'secret'[a] (as I have written briefly already, **4**with reference to which, when you read, you can understand my insight into Christ's secret), **5**which in different generations was not made known to the sons of men, as it has now been revealed by Spirit[b] to His holy apostles and prophets: **6**that the Gentiles are joint-heirs, of the same body, and fellow partakers of His promise in the Christ through the Gospel, **7**of which I became a servant according to the gift of God's grace, the gift given to me according to the outworking of His power." The use of "now" in verse 5 indicates that Paul is referring to the NT Canon. An apostle, upon receiving a revelation, would also function as a prophet, but people like Mark and Luke were prophets without being apostles. I take the 'apostles' here to be historical.

Revelation 18:20—"Rejoice over her, O heaven, yes you saints and apostles and prophets, because God has pronounced your judgment against her!"[c] Perhaps this verse should be connected to 18:6-7, and in that event the judgment was pronounced in faith. But just who are these apostles? I take it that "saints and apostles and prophets" is in apposition to "heaven", and in that event, whoever they are, they are already in heaven. It follows that this text is irrelevant to the occasion for this study.

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[a] I consider that 'secret' is a better rendering than 'mystery'. The truth about the Church is not all that mysterious; it just had not been explained before.

[b] There being no article with 'spirit', it could be either 'by Spirit' (used as a proper name) or 'in spirit' (referring to the manner). Both are true and legitimate, but I have chosen the first option in the translation.

[c] Instead of "saints and apostles", a small minority of the Greek manuscripts has 'holy apostles', as in AV and NKJV.

The hinge

As a hinge to link the past to the present, I will now consider the two texts that refer to 'false apostles'; they are 2 Corinthians 11:13 and Revelation 2:2.

2 Corinthians 11:12-15—"Further, I will keep on doing what I do in order to cut off the opportunity from those who desire an opportunity to be considered equal with us in the things of which they boast. **13**Such men are really false apostles, deceitful workers, trans-forming themselves into 'apostles' of Christ.[a] **14**And no wonder, because Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light. **15**So it is no great thing if his servants also masquerade as ministers of righteousness, whose end will be according to their works." It is well to remember that neither Satan nor his servants are in the habit of appearing with horns and tails. Just because someone 'looks good' does not mean that he is. We need spiritual discernment at all times. Note that Paul affirms that such people are Satan's servants, and they evidently declared themselves to be 'apostles'. In our day we have a veritable plague of self-proclaimed 'apostles' (that I call 'apustles'); now whom do you suppose they are serving?

Going back to the title of this study, when is an apostle? In Galatians 1:1 Paul affirms that his apostleship was "not from men nor through a man", but through both the Father and the Son. Paul's apostleship did not depend upon human ordination or recognition. So what about apostleship today? In Romans 1:1 Paul says he is a "called apostle". I take the point to be that true apostles are not ordained by man; they are designated by God, who has a specific reason for doing

[a] There have always been those who want to 'get on the band-wagon', to get a free ride; who traffic in spiritual things for personal, temporal advantage. Since such people only do damage, Paul's desire to expose them stems from his concern for the Corinthians' welfare.

so.[a] In the case of Paul, it was "to promote obedience of faith among all ethnic nations" (verse 5). Any genuine apostle will have a specific task to fulfil. Although God does not take back His gifts (Romans 11:29), a gift may be ignored (because the church's doctrine does not allow it), or neglected (1 Timothy 4:14), and hence aborted. Far worse, even an apostle that Jesus chose personally can be 'rejected' (1 Corinthians 9:27). If Paul recognized the possibility for himself, how about all the 'apostles' in our day?

In Revelation 2:2 the glorified Christ is writing to the church in Ephesus: "I know your works, yes the labor, and your endurance, and that you cannot stand those who are evil. And you have tested those who claim to be apostles and are not, and found them *to be* liars." The glorified Christ Himself declares that there are false apostles (and this at the close of the first century), and that the church in Ephesus knew how to test them.[b] Unfortunately, at least from my point of view, we are not told how they did it, the criteria that they used. There is one text that speaks of the 'signs of an apostle', 2 Corinthians 12:12. "Truly the apostolic signs were produced among you with all perseverance, by signs and wonders and miracles."

Both Stephen and Philip, 'mere' deacons, performed miracles, but evidently that did not transform them into apostles. And then there are the words of Sovereign Jesus Himself in John 14:12. "Most assuredly I say to you,[c] the one

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[a] It follows that there is no 'apostolic succession', since an apostle is not 'ordained' by men. There is only 'discipolic' succession.

[b] Is there not an implication here that there were also genuine apostles? If there were no such thing as an apostle, there could be no candidates, and hence no need for criteria. When John wrote this, he was the last survivor of the Twelve (also Paul), and he himself would soon die.

[c] "Most assuredly" is actually "amen, amen"—rendered "verily, verily" in the AV. Only John registers the word as repeated, in the other

believing into me, he too will do the works that I do; in fact he will do greater works than these,[a] because I am going to my Father."

This is a tremendous statement, and not a little disconcerting. Notice that the Lord said, "will do"; not 'maybe', 'perhaps', 'if you feel like it'; and certainly not 'if the doctrine of your church permits it'! If you believe you **will do!** The verb 'believe' is in the present tense, 2nd person singular; if you (sg) are believing you will do; it follows that if you are not doing, it is because you are not believing. 2 + 2 = 4. Doing what? "The works that I do." Well, Jesus preached the Gospel, He taught, He cast out demons, He healed all sorts and sizes of sickness and disease, He raised an occasional dead person, and He performed a variety of miracles (water to wine, walk on water, stop a storm instantaneously, transport a boat several miles instantaneously, multiply food, shrivel a tree—and He implied that the disciples should have stopped the storm and multi-plied the food, and He stated that they could shrivel a

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Gospels it is just "amen". In the contemporary literature we have no example of anyone else using the word in this way. It seems that Jesus coined His own use, and the point seems to be to call attention to an important pronouncement: "Stop and listen!" Often it precedes a formal statement of doctrine or policy, as here.

[a] Well now, if we cast out demons, heal and perform miracles, isn't that enough? Jesus wants more, He wants "greater things" than those just mentioned. Notice again that He said "will do", not maybe, perhaps, or if your church permits. But what could be 'greater' than miracles? This can't refer to modern technology because in that event such 'greater things' would not have been available to the believers during the first 1900 years. Note that the key is in the Lord's final statement (in verse 12), "because I am going to my Father." Only if He won could He return to the Father, so He is here declaring His victory before the fact. It is on the basis of that victory that the 'greater things' can be performed. Just what are those 'greater' things? For my answer, see my outline, "Biblical Spiritual Warfare", available from www.prunch.org.

tree [Peter actually took a few steps on water]). So how about us? The preaching and teaching we can handle, but what about the rest?

I once heard the president of a certain Christian college affirm that this verse obviously could not mean what it says because it isn't happening! Well, in his own experience, and in that of his associates (cessationists all), I guess it isn't. But many people today cast out demons and heal. Miracles are also happening. So how about me? And you? But to get back to the 'signs of an apostle', if all of us are supposed to be producing miracles, that does not make us all apostles, so there must be further criteria. (Please notice the 'further', I am not denying the 'signs'.)

I suggest that we must consider the matter of spiritual authority, and I begin with 2 Corinthians 10:8 and 13:10. 10:8 reads like this: "Now even if I boast a little to excess about our authority (which the Lord gave us for building up, not to tear you down), …" 13:10 reads like this: "This is why I write these things while absent, so that when present I may not have to deal harshly, according to the authority that the Lord gave me, for building up and not tearing down." In both verses Paul states that the authority is for building up, not tearing down, although his mention of harsh dealing indicates that such may be included in the process, as circumstance may require. (In fact, on at least two occasions, Paul actually turned someone over to Satan!—1 Corinthians 5:5 and 1 Timothy 1:20.)

Is this not what we are to understand from 1 Timothy 1:3? "You recall that I urged you to remain in Ephesus, when I went into Macedonia, in order that you should command certain persons to stop teaching a different doctrine . . ." Now the church was well established in Ephesus, yet Timothy had authority to command; I suppose that Paul designated him as his deputy. And what about 1 Timothy 5:19-20? "Do not entertain an accusation against an elder except on the basis

of two or three witnesses. [20]Those who are sinning rebuke publicly, so that the rest also may be in fear." Evidently Timothy had authority over the elders, being competent to rebuke them publicly.

Now consider Jeremiah 1:10—"See, I have this day set you over the nations and over the kingdoms, to root out and to pull down, to destroy and to throw down, to build and to plant." Of course this was before the Church, but there is a principle here that remains valid. If you plan to build on a site that is covered with ruins and rubble, where must you start? You must remove the wreckage. If God sent you to the church in Laodicea (Revelation 3:14-19), to try to straighten it out, where would you have to start? You might have to depose the leaders, as well as denounce the error. Presumably, also, you would have to be able to establish your authority over them. In Timothy's case, Paul presumably took care of that.

Something similar happened with Titus; consider: "I left you in Crete for this reason, that you should set in order the things that were lacking and appoint elders in every town, as I directed you" (1:5). "Because there really are lots of rebels, loud-mouths and deceivers, especially those of the circumcision group, who must be silenced" (1:10-11). "Speak these things, whether you exhort or reprove, with all authority" (2:15). If Titus was to appoint elders, he evidently had authority over them. And to silence 'rebels' evidently requires authority. Now then, does anyone imagine that such situations, requiring apostolic authority, ceased to exist in 100 AD? History records no lack of such situations, and far worse, down through the centuries and millennia. In our day the degree of perversity in the churches is such that I don't know how God can stand the stench! We desperately need people with apostolic authority who are prepared to function.

But to get back to the Text, consider Ephesians 4:11-13—"Yes, He Himself gave some to be apostles, some to be

prophets, some to be evangelists, and some to be pastors and teachers,[a] **12**for the equipping of the saints into the work of

[a] One might imagine that this list follows the chronological sequence of the several ministries. An apostle introduces the Gospel into an area or context; a prophet gets the people's attention and an evangelist urges them to believe; but once people are regenerated then pastors and teachers come to the fore—they are the ones who equip the saints. However, in practice, especially in a pioneer missionary situation, there are seldom that many people around. The missionary preaches the Gospel and it is up to him to teach the first converts; he is alone. A pioneer missionary, the first one to introduce the Gospel to an ethnic group or area, has an apostolic function (whether or not he himself is an apostle). But he must also function as an evangelist and as a teacher (whether or not he has those gifts).

However, most of us live and work where there are established, functioning congregations. So what would be the function of an apostle within an established, functioning congregation? If he lives and worships in that community, probably none at all, in that specific capacity—he might function as a teacher or a prophet. In a country, or area, where there is no more pioneer missionary work to be done, the exercise of the apostolic function would be itinerant, acting as God's special emissary, an official intervener, for disciplinary and correctional purposes.

I will take up evangelist next; what would his function be within an established congregation? Well, can you evangelize someone who is already regenerated? Evidently the function of an evangelist is directed to unbelievers, who should not be members of the congregation (although some often are). Of course an evangelist might also function as a pastor or teacher. A truly gifted evangelist will function beyond the limits of a local congregation.

As for the prophetic function, I will address the question of supernatural revelation of information not available through existing channels. (1 Corinthians 14:3 speaks of 'edification', 'exhortation' and 'comfort' as coming from a prophet, but I will not take up such activity here.) We understand that the Canon of Scripture is closed; God is no longer giving written revelation that is of general or universal application. But that does not mean that God no longer speaks into specific situations. Divine guidance is a type of prophecy; He is giving information not otherwise available. I myself have been

the ministry, so as to build up the body of Christ, [13]until we all attain into the unity of the faith and of the real knowledge of the Son of God, into a complete man, into the resulting full stature of Christ." If verses 12 and 13 are still being worked on, then the apostles, etc. are still necessary. Verse 13 emphasizes the truth in verse 12—every believer is supposed to grow into full stature. Just because we do not reach a goal does not invalidate that goal. I would say that one of the principal causes for the lamentable spiritual condition of most churches is the total lack of the apostolic function among us—itinerant, acting as God's special emissary, an official intervener, for disciplinary and correctional purposes. The idea of Christian or ministerial 'ethics', where one must not criticize a neighbor, is clearly designed to silence any prophetic or apostolic voice. It is designed to protect error.

Now consider 1 Corinthians 12:27-31—"Now you are the body of Christ, and members individually. [28]And those whom God has appointed in the Church are: first apostles, second prophets, third teachers; after that miracles, then presents of healings, helps, administrations, kinds of languages. [29]All are not apostles, are they? All are not prophets, are they? All are not teachers, are they? All are not miracle workers, are they?

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contemplated with a prophecy delivered by someone who had no idea who I was, and not in the context of a local congregation. The function of a true prophet cannot be limited to one congregation. Indeed, God may use a prophet at city, state or country level. Our world desperately needs prophetic voices.

A teacher will normally reside in a specific community, but his ministry may range beyond it. A pastor's function is local, just as he is chosen and ordained locally. It is simply a fact of life that someone with a shepherd's heart is not necessarily a good teacher, and an honest to goodness teacher often lacks a shepherd's heart. The functions are supposed to be complementary, and the object is to get all true believers involved in the work of the ministry. Life in Christ is not a spectator sport!

30All do not have presents of healings, do they? All do not speak languages, do they? All do not interpret, do they?[a] **31**But earnestly desire the best gifts."

It should be observed that the terminology here is clearly hierarchical: '1st, 2nd, 3rd, then, then, …' (similar lists in other places lack this terminology) [the Kingdom of God is not a democracy]. Next, if God has appointed these functions, there must be a good reason for them, and to deliberately exclude any of them is to go against God. Here in Brazil, with a few exceptions, the churches have no place for a true teacher; they simply are not allowed. The consequences are not pretty.

Presumably even the most ardent 'cessationist' will grant that "teachers", "helps" and "administrations" are still around. But this letter was written around 55 AD, well into the Church Age, therefore. Why would God "appoint in the

[a] The Greek grammar of verses 29 and 30 is plain: no gift is given to everybody—not everyone is an apostle and not everyone speaks languages. Those churches that teach that speaking in tongues is the necessary sign of being 'baptized in the Spirit' (and until you are 'baptized' you are a 2nd class citizen, if a citizen at all), have done untold damage to their people. Since the Holy Spirit simply does not give 'tongues' to everybody, those who do not get it are out in the cold. But the social pressure is intolerable, so many end up faking it. Since many of the leaders are also faking it, the social problem is solved; the person is 'in'. But since Satan is the source of all lies, someone who fakes it is living a lie and invites Satan into his life. I have been in many Pentecostal, neo-Pentecostal, charismatic, whatever churches and have heard thousands of people 'speaking in tongues'—a large majority were faking it, while a few were speaking a real language, but under demonic control. (I am a linguist, PhD, and can tell when I am listening to a real language, even though I don't understand it, because real language has structure. To know whether or not a language is demonic requires spiritual discernment.) A church that teaches a lie invites Satan into the church, and he does not hesitate. Of course some had the genuine gift.

Church" things that would be extinguished in a few decades. If miracles come "after" teachers, how can miracles be gone if teachers are still here? We have the command to "earnestly desire the best gifts", so which ones are the best? Presumably those at the top of the hierarchical list. Why would God command us to earnestly desire a gift like apostleship, if He was going to extinguish it before the end of the first century? In such an event the command would be meaningless for the last 1900 years!

The present

Somewhere along the line, I heard this: 'the status quo' is Latin for 'the mess we're in'. Whether Latin or English, I imagine that most of us would agree that the world is in a bad way, and that is at least partly because the Church is in a bad way. By and large, 'Christians' have ceased to be salt and light in the surrounding culture (Matthew 5:13-16); they are part of the problem, rather than part of the solution. As I have already opined, the lamentable spiritual condition of most churches is a direct result of the total lack of the apostolic function among us. It would appear that that 'lack' began early on.

In the writings of the 'church fathers' that have come down to us, there appears to be no mention of 'apostles' after the first century. Already in the second century, the concept of a 'bishop' came into being, an elder having authority over other elders in a given area—so a 'bishop' could exercise the apostolic function within his area (but all too often the bishop became part of the problem, since bishops were not chosen by God). It did not take long before the 'bishop of Rome' started to claim authority over other 'bishops', and then there were archbishops, and so on. If I am correct in defining the apostolic function as someone 'acting as God's special emissary, an official intervener, for disciplinary and correctional purposes', and if there has been a general lack of this

function for 1900 years, then we should not be surprised at the 'status quo'.

In our day we have denominations, defined by different doctrinal and procedural 'packages', and there is no end of splitting within such denominations. Here in Brazil we have at least five 'Baptist' denominations, four 'Presbyterian' ones, and no end of 'Assemblies of God', plus any number of 'independent' ones. We have literally thousands of self-proclaimed 'apustles'; everywhere you turn there is an 'apostolic ministry'. It is a generalized ego trip; no one wants to be left behind, or to appear inferior to his neighbor. They are building private empires, and fleecing the sheep in the process. I am not aware of any theological seminary in this country that teaches the students how to study the Bible, and much less how to expound it; expository preaching is almost nonexistent. In consequence, the variety of abject stupidities promulgated from the pulpits appears to be without end, doing ever increasing damage to the hearers. I am not aware of any denomination here where the biblical Text has objective authority.

But it gets worse. We actually have self-proclaimed 'apostles' who pontificate like this: "I am an apostle on a level with Peter or Paul, so I can disagree with them; I can change what the Bible says." And they do; they reject plain biblical teaching and impose their own ideas on their flocks. It should be evident to any true subject of Sovereign Jesus that all such 'apustles' are in the service of Satan. We have already noted Ephesians 2:20, God's household is "built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ Himself being the chief cornerstone." 1 Corinthians 3:11 says that "no one can lay any foundation other than what is laid, which is Jesus Christ." And Revelation 21:14 informs us that the foundations of the New Jerusalem are "the twelve apostles of the Lamb". No pipsqueak 'apustle' of our day is competent to alter the

Sacred Text—they obviously do not believe what the glorified Christ said in Revelation 22:18-19.

To someone who intends to be totally committed to Christ and His Kingdom, the following question is obvious and necessary: What can be done to remedy, to correct the calamitous reality I have described? We must cry out to God to raise up true apostles; but this raises another question: How is an apostle to be recognized, and how can he establish his authority so as to be able to bring about necessary changes in actual situations? I see only one way, the use of supernatural power; and that power must be used to clear out wreckage before it can be used to build. I see a difference between a prophet and an apostle in this connection: a prophet warns; an apostle inflicts. In Acts 5 Peter simply executed Ananias and Sapphira, without warning and without chance for repentance. In Acts 13 Paul inflicted blindness on the sorcerer Elymas, again without ado.

It should be obvious that anyone who starts functioning in this way will promptly be declared to be 'public enemy number one'. Any and all leaders who are serving Satan will do all in their power to eliminate a true apostle, because of the threat to them personally and to the perverse structures they have created and maintained. It will be all out war. I am reminded of 1 Corinthians 4:11-13—"To this very hour we go hungry and thirsty; we are poorly dressed, brutally treated, and wander homeless; **12**yes, we labor, working with our own hands. Upon being reviled, we bless; upon being persecuted, we endure it; **13**upon being slandered, we exhort. We have been made as the refuse of the world, the off-scouring of whatever, to this moment." Well now, how many of the plague of self-styled 'apostles' in our day would maintain their pretentions if they had to experience the conditions described above? They would run and hide.

We need to understand what Paul is saying here. To be looked down on and criticized by believers among whom one has labored is one thing. Local people with personal ambition know how to do that. For God to make us "as the refuse of the world" is something very different. How should we understand this? If we insist on proclaiming a 'gospel' that the world considers to be stupid, abject foolishness, we will certainly be ridiculed. But if we insist on biblical values that the world has declared to be 'hate crimes', we will certainly be hated and persecuted, treated as refuse. The choice of Hebrews 13:13 is upon us: "So then, let us go out to Him, outside the camp, bearing His disgrace." The above applies to any true subject of Sovereign Jesus, but any true apostle will be the target of the total fury of the religious leaders as well. In short, to be an apostle is not for the fainthearted.

And now please consider 2 Thessalonians 2:8-12, noting especially verses 10 and 11. "And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord will consume with the breath of His mouth and abolish by the splendor of His coming; **9**that one's coming is according to the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders, **10**and with all wicked deception among those who are wasting themselves, because they did not receive the love of the truth[a] so that they might be saved.[b] **11**Yes, because of this God will send them an active

[a] The use of the verb 'receive' clearly implies an act of volition on their part; that love was offered or made available to them but they did not want it; they wanted to be able to lie and to entertain lies told by others. But the consequences of such a choice are terrible; they turned their back on salvation.

[b] Since there are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world, that of Sovereign Jesus and that of Satan, "those who are wasting themselves", in this text, are still in Satan's kingdom and therefore wide open to his "wicked deception". The Text states plainly that they are wasting themselves "because they did not receive the love of the truth so that they might be saved". They are not saved.

delusion so that they will believe the lie[a] **12**and so that all may be con-demned who have not believed the truth but have taken pleasure in wickedness."[b] Notice the sequence: first they reject the love of the truth; it is as a consequence of that choice that God sends the delusion. The implication is that there is a point of no return; God sends the delusion so that they may be condemned. The only intelligent choice is to embrace the truth!

Consider with me the consequences of the facts enunciated in verses 10-12 for a whole nation, like Brazil, where I now live. We have many thousands of local churches that call themselves Christian. But I know of almost none that could be characterized as 'loving the truth'. No one wants a Bible with objective authority. Humanistic, relativistic, materialistic values have taken over the churches. Biblical values are no longer acceptable. In consequence, Satan has control of the government, of education, of health services, of commerce, of the entertainment industry, in short, of the whole culture. The churches that have rejected biblical values are part of the problem—since they have rejected "the love of the truth", they have been taken over by "active delusion".

Note that God Himself sends that delusion with the declared objective of condemning all those who believed the lie. If God Himself visits "active delusion" upon a whole country, what possible escape is there? The only possible 'medicine' is "the love of the truth". Those of us who consider ourselves to be true subjects of Sovereign Jesus need to appeal to Him to show us how to promote the love of the

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[a] Perhaps "the lie" is best illustrated in our day by the theory of evolution: 'There is no Creator'—so there will not be any accounting; so you can do what you feel like. How terrible will be the awakening!

[b] "Taking pleasure in wickedness" involves rejecting the Truth of a moral Creator who will demand an accounting, or even overt rebellion against that Creator (like Lucifer/Satan).

truth to the churches and to the society at large. Here in Brazil it may be too late, but if God's grace still offers us a window of opportunity, we must devote ourselves to promoting the love of the truth by all possible means. I imagine that the most effective means would be the exercise of the apostolic function, and that at more than one level. I am thinking of the following: local congregations, whole denominations, and the various levels of civil government. **Dear God, please send us apostles**!

97) When was Jesus born?

Tertullian wrote that Pilate sent a letter to the emperor, Tiberius, recommending that Jesus be added to the Roman roster of deities.[a] Now to make a suggestion like that involved an element of risk.[b] But evidently Pilate was sufficiently convinced that he took the risk. So what convinced him? Presumably it was Jesus' resurrection, as evidenced by the miracles that the Apostles did in His name. But the Apostles did not start proclaiming the Resurrection and doing miracles until after Pentecost. I conclude that the month of June would be the earliest that Pilate could write such a letter, but it was probably a month or two later.

Presumably the letter was sent by boat, which would take a while to get to Rome. But Tiberius was no longer in Rome, he was on the island Capri, so the letter had to go to Capri. Tiberius finally submitted the question to the Senate, but how long did it take for him to come to that decision? How much importance would he assign to a letter from Judea, and how long did the people in Rome delay before sending it on to Capri? And how much importance would the leaders of the Senate assign to such a suggestion? How long did they mull

[a] *Apology*, 5 and 21.

[b] Especially if he was indebted to Sejanus, as many have argued.

over the suggestion before submitting it to the full Senate for debate?

Enter Sergius Sejanus: he was the commander of the Praetorian Guard and the *de facto* ruler of Rome at the time. When the suggestion about Jesus came up for debate by the Senate, Sejanus "inflexibly" opposed the suggestion, and it was not approved.[a] Historians generally give a different reason for that decision, but my point is that Sejanus was there, whatever the reason for the decision. Now then, Sejanus was executed for treason on October 18, 31 AD. (The people of the city 'loved' him so much that they dragged and kicked his corpse around the streets of Rome!) So what is my point? Just this: there simply was not enough time between April and October of that year for all of that to happen; and we do not know the interval between the debate and the execution. Conclusion: Jesus could not have died in 31 AD; He died on April 5 and arose on April 7, 30.[b]

Luke 3:1-2 states that John began his ministry in the fifteenth year of Tiberius Caesar, which was 26 AD. He would have begun when he turned 30, as did Jesus, Luke 3:23. I take it that John began in the Spring and Jesus in the Fall of that year. Since Jesus' public ministry lasted about 3.5 years, He died at Passover, 30 AD.

If we know the date of His death, we can calculate the date of His birth. Calculating time across the BC/AD divide is tricky, because there is no year 'zero'. Jesus lived 29.25 years after the divide. From the Gospel accounts we know that

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[a] Paulus Orosius, *Seven books of history against the pagans*, pp. 325-26 (book 7,4). Histories of the life of Sejanus are in general agreement that he hated the Jews, and Jesus was a Jew.

[b] Floyd N. Jones also concludes that Jesus died in April, 30 AD, using a different line of reasoning. *Chronology of the Old Testament: A Return to the Basics* (The Wood-lands, Texas: KingsWord Press, 14th edition, 1999), pp. 230-33.

Jesus lived about 33.5 years. 33.5 – 29.25 = 4.25. Jesus lived 4.25 years before the divide, which takes us to around October 1, 5 BC. (A calculation based on John the Baptizer also places the birth at the September/October divide.) Since the Herod who ordered the massacre died in 4 BC, the claim that Jesus was born in 4 BC is difficult to defend. If the star that the magi saw appeared when Jesus was conceived, early January, 5, then the 'two years' is easier to explain (a suspicious type like Herod would give himself a good margin).

So when was Jesus born? Around October 1, 5 BC. I am well aware that people have entrenched opinions on this subject. My thesis hinges on two questions: 1) Did Tiberius submit Jesus to the Senate? yes, or no. 2) Did Sejanus participate in the debate? yes, or no. If the answer to both questions is 'yes', then Jesus died in 30 AD; all other considerations would become 'beside the point'.[a]

I am also aware that many people have never heard the name, Sejanus. There is a great deal of information about him on the internet. To anyone who decides to investigate him, I suggest that the following questions should be asked: 1) Was he not the *de facto* ruler of Rome at the time? 2) Would he not keep an eye on the Senate? 3) Did he not hate Jews? 4) Would he do nothing when he learned of the recommendation?

98) Where is Mt. Sinai?

I invite attention to Galatians 4:25, that declares that Mt. Sinai is in Arabia: I don't know Paul's definition of 'Arabia', but what the maps call 'Mt. Sinai' probably is not the real one;[b]

[a] Any shift in the equivalence between the Years of Rome and our present calendar would affect all dates equally and make no difference as to the elapsed time between events.

[b] The difficulty here is not in the Text itself, but in the circumstance that almost all modern maps, whether in Bibles or elsewhere, place Mt.

consider: When Moses fled from Pharaoh he stopped in Midian (Exodus 2:15). Midian lies on the east side of the eastern 'rabbit-ear' of the Red Sea (the Gulf of Aqaba), in present day Saudi Arabia. It has never been part of the so-called 'Sinai Peninsula'. It was at "Horeb, the mountain of God" that Moses saw the 'burning bush' (Exodus 3:1), and in verse 12 God tells Moses: "when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you shall serve God on this mountain". Mt. Horeb has always been in Midian. (Present day Saudi Arabia calls it 'el Lowz', and has it fenced off.) As God continues with Moses' commission, He specifies "three days' journey into the wilderness" (verse 18). According to Exodus 4:27 Aaron met Moses at "the mountain of God" (Horeb, in Midian), and they went together to Egypt.

When the people left Egypt, God led them on a forced march; notice the "so as to go by day and night" (Exodus 13:21). Three days of forced march (Exodus 3:18) would have gotten them close to Ezion Geber (present day Elath), and just another two days would have put them well into Midian. But then God told them to "turn back" and "encamp by the sea, directly opposite Baal Zephon" (Exodus 14:2). To do this they had to leave the established route from Egypt to Arabia, and head south into the wilderness, and this led Pharaoh to conclude that they had lost their way (obviously he would have spies following them, mounted on good horses, to keep him informed). It would have been simply impossible for them to lose their way between Goshen and the western arm of the Red Sea (the Gulf of Suez), but that is what those who place Mt. Sinai in today's 'Sinai Peninsula' are obliged to say—

Sinai in the peninsula between the two gulfs, Suez and Aqaba; so much so that the peninsula itself is even so named. But such a location for the mount makes the Biblical account out to be ridiculous, as I explain below, and an inspired Text should not be ridiculous.

an evident stupidity. The Israelites would have hunted and explored all over that area, down through the years. (And why the chariots? Pharaoh could have surrounded them with foot soldiers.)

God led them down a ravine called 'Wadi Watir' which comes out on a surprisingly large beach called 'Nuweiba' (it is the only beach on that gulf large enough to accommodate that crowd of people and animals). Most of the Gulf of Aqaba is many hundreds of feet deep, with sheer sides, but precisely at Nuweiba there is a land bridge not far below the surface that goes from shore to shore, the width of the gulf at that point being close to 10 miles—the width of the land bridge is several hundred yards, so there was an ample 'causeway' for the crossing. The ravine that opens out on Nuweiba is narrow, with steep sides, so when God moved the pillar of cloud to the mouth of the ravine, Pharaoh and his chariots were blocked. They could not pass the pillar, they could not climb the sides of the ravine with chariots, and with over six hundred chariots in a narrow ravine they would have a proper 'gridlock' (lots of unhappy horses!). I suppose that God removed the pillar of cloud while part of the crowd was still on the land bridge, which encouraged Pharaoh to chase after them; and we know the rest of the story. If God let them get out to the middle, they would be five miles from either shore, too far for most people to swim.[a] I take it that God's purpose was to destroy the Egyptian army so it could not be a threat to Israel in the early years.

99) Where to place a 'comma'

Acts 12:25

Since Acts was written at least two years after Paul arrived in Rome in chains, it would not have been 'published'

[a] In our day chariot pieces have been discovered along that land bridge.

until into the 60s. When Jerusalem was destroyed in 70, it disappeared from the Christian map for centuries—the center of gravity of the Church was now Asia Minor. Although Luke himself was no doubt very fluent in Greek, for most Christians in Asia Minor it would be a second language. If this was also true of most people who made copies of NT books (especially in the early decades), and since those books were written without punctuation (or even spaces between words), it was predictable that now and again someone would put a 'comma' in the wrong spot. I imagine that it would have been just such an event that gave rise to the peculiar set of variants that we encounter in Acts 12:25.

Throughout the NT there are numerous places where there is a more or less serious split within Family 35, with two competing readings (usually involving just one letter). But this is the **only** place (yes, only) in the whole NT where the family splinters—there are no fewer than seven variants, five of them being of some consequence.

Instead of "Barnabas and Saul returned to Antioch, having fulfilled their mission," someone (or several 'some-ones') put the comma after 'returned', resulting in "Barnabas and Saul returned, having fulfilled their mission to Antioch"—but with that punctuation 'Antioch' must be changed to 'Jerusalem'. (Having done that, we have two ways of saying essentially the same thing—if you get the 'comma' right!) Following that hypothesis, that change must have occurred rather early on, and in circumstances that resulted in that change dominating the transmission of Acts down through the years. To see what I mean we need to have the evidence before us:

1) *υπεστρεψαν εις αντιοχειαν* (**f**^{35}=27.8%) (5.1%)
2) *υπεστρεψαν απο ιερουσαλημ* (**f**^{35}=8.9%) D (10.9%)
3) *υπεστρεψαν απο ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν* (**f**^{35}=12.7%) (7.3%)
4) *υπεστρεψαν εξ ιερουσαλημ* (**f**^{35}=1.3%) ℵA (3.6%) OC,TR

5) *υπεστρεψαν εξ ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν* (**f**^{35}=11.4%) (12.2%) CP
6) *υπεστρεψαν εις ιερουσαλημ* (**f**^{35}=36.7%) B (60%) RP,HF,NU
7) *υπεστρεψαν εις ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν* (**f**^{35}=1.3%) (0.6%) [not a conflation, being nonsense; the copyist was aware of both, and didn't know how to choose]

It is evident that variants 2) - 5) were created deliberately; the copyists were reacting to the meaning of the whole phrase within the context (in this situation it will not do to consider the name of each city in isolation; the accompanying preposition must also be taken into account). But they were reacting to variant 6), not variant 1). However, once they were created, and as they became exemplars, those who made copies would see no problem and simply reproduce what was in front of them [so we may not add the percentages for 2) - 6) and say that Jerusalem has over 90% of the vote]. Having myself collated at least one book in 130 MSS (and over thirty entire MSS), I have observed repeatedly that the copyist faithfully reproduced a nonsensical reading—either they weren't paying attention, or their respect for the Text was such that they did not venture to change it (or in later years the monks may have been instructed to not make changes, precisely to preserve the variety of readings that had come down to them [their superiors may not have felt that they had the competence to choose one form to the exclusion of others])—so the 60% does not mean that all those copyists agreed with what they copied, or even that they understood it.

I will now list the evidence for all the Family 35 MSS that are presently available. The MSS within { } were spot-checked, all the rest were fully collated for the book of Acts.

εις αντιοχειαν 141,204,328,394,801,928,986,1140,1247,1249,1482, 1723,1725,1732,1749,1761,1855,1856,1876,1897, 2080,2255,2261,2378,2431,2441

απο ιερουσαλημ 18,386,1100,2554 {634,1101,1733,2303}

απο ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν 444,1058,1548,2587 {664,1400, 1752,1763,2221,2704}

εξ ιερουσαλημ 1865

εξ ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν 604,1865[c] {432,1767,1768}

εις ιερουσαλημ 35[c],149,201,757,824,1040,1072,1075,1248,1503, 1508,1617,1619,1628,1636,1637,1656,1723[c],1740, 1746,1864,1892,2352,2431[c],2466,2723 {1618,1737, 1748,2653,2691}

εις ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν 35 (not a conflation, because it is nonsense; the copyist knew both readings and recorded them both)

Lacking: 1652,2218 {206[s,fr],1745[fr],1754[s,fr],1766[fr],1858[fr],2175[fr],2289[fr], 2626[fr],2777[fr],2778[fr],2926[s,fr]} [fr = fragment]

Totals: εις αντιοχειαν = 26
απο ιερουσαλημ = 8
απο ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν = 10
εξ ιερουσαλημ = 1
εξ ιερουσαλημ εις αντιοχειαν = 4
εις ιερουσαλημ = 28
Lacking = 13

Comment: The first five readings are votes against the sixth, so the vote is 49:28. However, 15 of the 28 are from the M. Lavras monastery (Mt. Athos), which probably indicates a common influence. The vote for the sixth reading should probably be reduced, making the advantage of the first reading all the stronger (if the 15 represent 5 exemplars, the vote would be 49:18). The reading of the Family 35 archetype is the first, εις αντιοχειαν. Within the context, 'to Jerusalem' is nonsense.

I now return to the statement of the total evidence. Since the normal meaning of the syntax here is the first one (they returned to Antioch), and since both the Holy Spirit and Luke knew how to write good Greek (Koine), my presuppositions lead me to choose it. But it is not only my presuppositions; consider:

a) Acts 11:30, *ο και εποιησαν αποστειλαντες*, "which they also did, having sent… by B. & S." An aorist participle is prior in time to its main verb, in this case also aorist—their purpose is stated to have been realized. The author clearly implies that the offering did arrive, or had arrived, in Judea/Jerusalem. [In Acts the author seems almost to use "Jerusalem" and "Judea" interchangeably, perhaps to avoid repetition. E.g.: 11:1 Judea, 11:2 Jerusalem (were the apostles not in Jerusalem, or immediate environs?); 11:27 Jerusalem, 11:29 Judea, 11:30 the elders (would not the ruling elders be in Jerusalem?); 12:1-19 took place in Jerusalem, but v. 19 says Herod went down from Judea to Caesarea; 15:1 Judea, 15:2 Jerusalem; 28:21 letters from "Judea" probably means Jerusalem.] Note that the next verse (12:1) places us in Jerusalem.
b) Acts 12:25 (12:1-24 is unrelated, except that verses 1-19 take place in Jerusalem), *βαρναβας και σαυλος*—the action includes **both**.
c) Acts 12:25, *υπεστρεψαν… πληρωσαντες την διακονιαν*, "they returned… having fulfilled the mission." Again, both the participle and the main verb are aorist, and both plural. "Having fulfilled the mission" defines the main verb. Since the mission was to Judea, which of necessity includes Jerusalem as its capital city, the 'returning' must be to the place where the mission originated.
d) Acts 12:25, "also taking with them John, the one called Mark"—we have no record that John Mark had ever been in Antioch before this, so how could he return to Jerusalem if he was already there? Acts 13:13 raises the same question.

Barnabas could be viewed as returning to Jerusalem, having completed his mission to Antioch, but this could not be said of Saul. I conclude that 'to Jerusalem' cannot be correct here even though attested by 60% of the MSS. We

observe that the other 40% of the MSS, plus the three ancient versions, are agreed that the motion was away from Jerusalem, not toward it. It seems to me that there is only one way to 'save' the majority variant here: place a comma between *υπεστρεψαν* and *εις*, thereby making 'to Jerusalem' modify 'the ministry'. (This was my opening hypothesis.) But such a construction is unnatural to the point of being unacceptable —had that been the author's purpose we should expect *την εις ιερουσαλημ διακονιαν* or *την διακονιαν εις ιερουσαλημ* (assuming that both the Holy Spirit and Luke were good at Greek). The other sixteen times that Luke uses *υποστρεφω εις* we find the normal, expected meaning, 'return to'. As a linguist (PhD) I would say that the norms of language require us to use the same meaning in Acts 12:25. Which to my mind leaves *εις αντιοχειαν* as the only viable candidate for the Original reading in this place. (Which, however, would not prevent copyists who were not native speakers of Greek from putting the 'comma' in the wrong spot.)

The whole contour of the evidence is troubling, strange, and as I have already observed, it is absolutely the only place in the whole NT where Family 35 splinters. Variants 1) through 5) are all votes against 6), but we must choose one of them to stand against 6)—the clear choice is 1). "To Jerusalem" has 'Number', 'Antiquity' and 'Continuity'. "To Antioch" has 'Antiquity', 'Variety', 'Continuity' and 'Reasonableness'. As Burgon would say, this is one of those places where 'Reasonableness' just cannot be ignored. I believe he would agree that his 'notes of truth' give the nod to Antioch.

100) Who bought what from whom, and where?

Stephen X Genesis

Acts 7:15-16—"So Jacob went down to Egypt; and he died, he and our fathers; and they were transferred to

Shechem and placed in the tomb that Abraham bought for a sum of money from the sons of Hamor of Shechem."

When we compare this text with the relevant passages in Genesis, we appear to be confronted with some discrepancies. Who bought what from whom, and where? Genesis 33:19 informs us that Jacob bought a plot from Hamor, in Shechem. On the other hand, Genesis 23:16-20 explains that Abraham bought an area that included the cave of Machpelah from Ephron, in Hebron. That cave became the sepulcher of Abraham and Sarah, of Isaac and Rebecca, and of Jacob and Lea, because Jacob insisted upon being buried there, as indeed he was (Genesis 49:29-30, 50:13). Looking again at Acts 7, it was 'our fathers' that were buried in Shechem, not Jacob. Indeed, Joshua 24:32 states explicitly that Joseph's bones were buried in Shechem.

Yes but, whenever did Abraham buy anything in Shechem? I believe Genesis 12:6-7 gives us the clue. Abraham stopped in Shechem and built an altar. Now then, to build on someone else's property, with that someone looking on, probably won't work very well. I believe we may reasonably deduce that Abraham bought a plot "from the sons of Hamor of Shechem." The 'Hamor' of Jacob's day would be a descendant of the 'Hamor' in Abraham's (sons were often named after their fathers). In Genesis 14:14 we read that Abraham "armed his three hundred and eighteen trained servants who were born in his own house." If we add women and children, the total number of people under Abraham's command was probably over a thousand. Well now, with such a crowd it is not at all unlikely that someone died while they were stopped at Shechem. (People older than Abraham would not have been 'born in his own house', but there were doubtless older persons in that crowd.) In that event Abraham would need space for a cemetery, if the plot he had already bought for the altar wasn't big enough, or appropriate. That sort of

information may have been available to Stephen from an extra-biblical document, or he may have figured it out as I have done (in his case guided by the Holy Spirit—Acts 7:55).

Going back to Genesis 33:19, it is possible that Jacob increased the area that Abraham had bought, by purchase. But why were all of Jacob's sons buried in Shechem? I believe the answer lies in Genesis 34:27-29. We read that Jacob's sons killed all the men of Shechem, looted everything, but kept the women and children. And what do you suppose they did with the women? So where did you think they found wives for so many men? They got them from Shechem. Since Shechem was the source of their wives and material possessions, it would be a natural place for them to be buried.

To conclude: there is no discrepancy. Both Abraham and Jacob bought land in Shechem. It was Jacob's sons who were buried there, not Jacob himself.

101) Who said what?

Matthew 27:48-49 X Mark 15:36 X John 19:29-30 (Luke 23:36)

I take it that the action in John 19:29, as well as Luke 23:36, was carried out by soldiers, and should not be confused with that recorded in Matthew and Mark, although all four refer to offering Jesus sour wine to drink (since Jesus was on the cross for some six hours, there was time for several drinks). The seeming discrepancy I wish to address is in Matthew and Mark. In the NKJV, Matthew 27:48-49 reads like this: "Immediately one of them ran and took a sponge, filled it with sour wine and put it on a reed, and offered it to Him to drink. The rest said, 'Let Him alone; let us see if Elijah will come to save Him'." A single man offers the drink, but the rest say, "Let Him alone, …" And Mark 15:36 reads like this: "Then someone ran and filled a sponge full of sour wine, put it on a reed, and offered it to Him to drink, saying, 'Let Him alone;

…'" A single man offers the drink, and **he** says, "Let Him alone, …" I would not be surprised if the man involved here was John Mark himself. But whoever he was, if he knew Hebrew he knew perfectly well that Jesus was not calling Elijah, so he sarcastically repeats their statement, in disgust. I deny any discrepancy.

102) Why would God kill Moses?

In Exodus 4:24-26 we have a drastically abbreviated account of an episode that occurred when Moses started back to Egypt to rescue the Israelites. It is so abbreviated that readers down through the centuries have been puzzled by it. It is necessary to analyze the larger context, all relevant considerations.

We must go back to Genesis 17:9-14, where God imposed circumcision as the 'sign of the covenant' between Himself and Abraham, and his descendants. Especially to the point is verse 14; the uncircumcised male "shall be cut off from his people; he has broken My covenant." In ordinary English, he was to be executed; the penalty was death.

Moses had certainly been circumcised by his parents on the eighth day, but at three months he was adopted by Pharaoh's daughter and was brought up as an Egyptian. Well, not quite; the baby was returned to his mother to be nursed, and we are not told his exact age when he was taken back to Pharaoh's daughter. So we do not know how much his parents may have taught him. In any case, all his schooling was Egyptian. However, he obviously knew where he came from and had made it his business to learn about the Israelites. "When he was forty years old, it came into his heart to visit his brothers, the sons of Israel" (Acts 7:23).

Moses was forty years old when he fled to Midian and married one of Jethro's[a] daughters, Zipporah, and had two sons by her. After another forty years (Moses is now eighty), God appears to him at the burning bush and commissions him to return to Egypt and deliver the Israelites. So Moses sets out, taking 'his wife and his sons' (Exodus 4:20). **However**, Moses' sons had not been circumcised!

Well now, Moses certainly knew about circumcision, and may even have tried to circumcise his sons, but Zipporah, not an Israelite, evidently stamped her foot and said "No way!" From her reaction (Exodus 4:25), it seems clear that at least part of the fault was hers, and she knew it. And Moses did not insist. But now Moses has been commissioned to lead the people of the covenant, but he himself had not kept the covenant! According to Genesis 17:14, it was the sons who should have been killed, but Moses, the father, was the one at fault for not having circumcised them when they were eight days old. By now they were doubtless grown men (when the procedure is far more painful).

God evidently determined that the situation had to be corrected, and the means He chose was dramatic! The Text does not tell us what form God used to make His presence known, or just what He did to Moses, but the man evidently was immobilized, because the woman had to perform the operation. Obviously there was a conversation, which is why Zipporah knew what she had to do. She was not happy, but she obeyed. The grown sons had to cooperate as well. Verse 25 has 'son' (singular), but presumably both had to be circumcised. Verse 26 begins by saying that then God let Moses go, which He presumably would not have done until the condition was met. Note that she used a stone (flint), and

[a] He is also called Reuel.

Joshua 5:2 speaks of 'flint knives'. Iron rusts and can carry tetanus, so a stone knife was definitely safer.

As a side benefit of this episode, Moses evidently sent his wife and sons back to Jethro. Then he met Aaron at Mt. Horeb and the two went on to Egypt. I say 'benefit' because the following days and weeks would be very intense, and Moses was free from domestic concerns. Exodus 18:2 states plainly that Moses had sent his wife back, and verse 5 says that Jethro took Zipporah and the two sons to Moses at Horeb. So at that point the family was finally together again. (This is the last mention of the sons, except in Chronicles—their main claim to fame was a negative one.)

103) "You feed them!"

Mark 6:37

"You feed them!" Really now, did you ever really stop to think about that? Just tell me please, what with? How could the disciples obey that command?

Let us pause and recall the scene. The Sacred Text affirms that there were about five thousand men, without counting the women and children. Now then, whenever you see a crowd of people, what is there usually the most of—is it not women and children? In other words, I suppose that crowd was made up of at least 15,000 people. Okay, now try to imagine that you are one of those twelve disciples and you have just heard the Master say: "**You** feed them!" Now what? Did the disciples have anything? As a matter of fact, no. They had neither money (which would not have helped much since they were a long way from town) nor food. Even the five loaves and two fish belonged to somebody else.

Can it be that Jesus was playing a joke on them, or was He serious? I do not know, but I prefer to think that He would not make a joke out of such a situation. But if He was serious, how could the disciples obey? Only with a miracle. In fact,

they could not see a solution and gave the problem back to Jesus to solve; which He did. But did Jesus Himself hand the bread and fish to the crowd? No. Let us think about that scene a little more and we will see that the disciples still had to exercise faith.

The Record affirms that they all ate until they were "full" or "satisfied". It was not just a little something to tide them over. Have you ever considered how much bread and fish it would take to "fill" 15,000 people (who had gone without lunch)? It seems to me certain that when Jesus blessed and broke those loaves and fish there was not an instant multiplication, such that there was enough for everybody; the tremendous pile would have buried Jesus, the disciples and the closest of the people! Really. Just stop and think about it. It must not have been instantaneous. When Jesus placed some bread and fish in the hands of each disciple that was all there was, up to that moment.

Now then, try to imagine that you are one of those disciples with a handful of bread and fish, and you have to feed at least a thousand people (12 disciples and 15,000 people). Can you picture it? Wouldn't you feel just a little ridiculous taking that first step toward the crowd? Somehow the disciples find the courage and approach the people. The first one helps himself and, wonder of wonders, the supply is undiminished! The second one helps himself and the supply is unchanged. It was never used up—as they went around distributing, the food kept multiplying (to have twelve bushels of leftovers, the people were also involved in passing it on). If they had tired and stopped in the middle, half the people would have stayed hungry. If the disciples had decided to eat first, I rather imagine that the miracle would have been frustrated and the crowd would have gone hungry. The disciples ate last, but they ate very well, thank you very much! (Have you ever tried eating a bushel of bread?)

I tend to smile, thinking about that picture, until I remember that the Lord Jesus is still telling us: "You give them something to eat"—only this time it is no less than 2,000 ethnic groups and 2.5 billion people perishing from an absolute lack of the Bread of Life. And we, like the disciples, say, "With what, Lord?" As long as we are looking at our empty hands, we will not find the courage to face the challenge of the lost world. It does not depend on our empty hands; it depends on Jesus' full hands! It does not depend on our weakness and smallness, it depends on **Jesus**, on what He has and can do. We have to learn how to collaborate with God, and actually do it. In short, we need to understand how God's economy works.

104) **"Surely I am coming quickly"**

"Amen. Even so come, Sovereign Jesus!" (Rev. 22:20). "With the Lord a thousand years is as one day" (2 Peter 3:8), so from His point of view, it has only been two days. Recently a grandson wrote to me that he had decided to delve into eschatology and asked if he could send me questions. The resulting dialog served as the basis for this study.

Most church members probably do not concern themselves with the subject; they are 'pan'—it will all pan out in the end. And of course it all will, just as God has declared. Those who have concerned themselves with the subject have usually picked a 'package', one of the several lines of interpretation that exist among Christians. Arguments based on packages tend to generate more heat than light. As the old saying went, 'a man convinced against his will is of the same opinion still'. As a sometime theologian, ThM, I speak from personal observation.

But I am also a linguist, PhD, and I insist that the norms of language must be respected. Further, with reference to an inspired Text, that text must be interpreted on its own terms

(not those of a 'package'). Attention please. Interpreting the Sacred Text is not a game of tiddlywinks, it is a matter of life or death, eternal life or death. The truth is not democratic, is not determined by opinion or vote; the truth **IS**, and it has an Owner (John 14:17, 15:26, 16:13, 17:17). The truth on any subject is absolute, but our understanding is faulty; because we are small, limited, ignorant—we simply do not have all the facts (but God does, so when He speaks, smart people listen).

Now consider Mark 8:38—"Yes, whoever is ashamed of me **and my words** in this adulterous and sinful generation, the Son of the Man will also be ashamed of him whenever He comes in the glory of His Father with the holy Angels." We are not allowed to be ashamed of the words that Jesus spoke; it is mandatory to agree with what He taught. Surely, because we will be judged by those words. "The one who rejects me and does not receive my sayings has that which judges him—the word that I have spoken, that is what will judge him on the last day; because I have not spoken on my own, but the Father who sent me, He gave me a command, what I should say and what I should speak" (John 12:48-49). (To reject His sayings is to reject Him; and how can you "have the mind of Christ", 1 Cor. 2:16, if you don't think like He does?) So how can those words judge you? They will judge you based on what you did with them, as defined by the normal rules of language (since God's words are true and faithful). But how can they judge you? They can judge you because they are living (Hebrews 4:12, 1 Peter 1:23, Acts 7:38). Any word delivered by the Sovereign Creator will be authoritative, and He does not deliver words without purpose. To discern the purpose, it is often necessary to ask the Holy Spirit for illumination.

The crucial question at issue is the interpretation of Revelation, although other texts also come into play. For one line of interpretation, the date that Revelation was 'published' is

crucial, since for them it had to be before 70 AD. However, the date that the book of Revelation was published is beside the point, as I will now explain, based on the necessity of interpreting the Text on its own terms. In Revelation 21:5, the One sitting on the throne, the glorified Christ, said: "Write, for these words are true and faithful". Now then, a true word cannot be false, obviously. And a faithful word cannot be duplicitous, deceiving, designed to fake us out. A faithful word must be taken at face value, within the norms of the language involved. A faithful word exists to give us honest information.

Revelation 1:1 states that the whole book of Revelation was given by the glorified Jesus Christ to John, that the whole book is “the testimony of Jesus Christ” (v. 2). It is the same glorified Jesus who is sitting on the throne in 21:9 and declared: “these words are true and faithful”—He guarantees the veracity and faithfulness of everything in the book of Revelation. It follows that to interpret those words in any way that is not “true and faithful” is to call the glorified Jesus a liar, to which He will not take kindly, since in John 14:6 He Himself said: “I am the Truth”.

Figures of speech are a normal part of any language, but they are governed by rules. In contrast to them, grammatical categories cannot be ‘spiritualized’ or given figurative meanings. Their function is literal. A Subject is a Subject, a Verb is a Verb, a Preposition is a Preposition, an Article is an Article. And a definite article defines; that is its function. To illustrate, consider Revelation 20:7; "when the thousand years are finished" is defined by the definite article "the"; according to the rules of grammar it has to be a literal thousand years. Anyone who denies that there will be a literal thousand-year Messianic Kingdom is interpreting the Greek language dishonestly. It follows that Revelation 20:7 does away with amillennialism, postmillennialism and preterism; surely, because at no time during the past 6,000 years has Satan been bound,

and certainly not for a thousand years, as the glorified Christ declared he must be. The Sovereign declared that there will be a literal thousand-year Messianic Reign, if the words in Rev. 20:2-7 are “true and faithful”, which declaration owes nothing to so-called ‘dispensational theology’.

In Matthew 24:21-22 Sovereign Jesus declared that there will be an unprecedented world-wide tribulation “never been . . . and never again”, immediately followed by His return to earth (vv. 29-30). So there will certainly be a ‘Great Tribulation’, and Sovereign Jesus will certainly return to earth. Neither of those events has happened so far.

In 1 Thessalonians 4:15-17 Paul describes the Rapture of the Church, “by a word of the Lord”. So there will certainly be that Rapture, that has not happened so far. There is a legitimate question about the moment that the Rapture will occur, since there are several texts that permit different interpretations (except that it must occur before the Millenium).

'Apocalyptic literature', with the meaning given to it by Satan's instruments, does not exist. Our word 'apocalypse' is a transliteration of the Greek word that means 'revelation' or 'disclosure'. The corresponding verb means to reveal or disclose. When a lawyer reads a will, it is an apocalypse; he is making information public that had not been available. There is nothing mysterious or symbolic about it. That phrase is just a gambit by Satan's instruments to undermine the authority of Scripture. To use such a gambit to avoid the plain meaning of the Text is dishonest. (Forget not Rev. 21:8.)

Now about the claim that Revelation is figurative language. In Rev. 12:3 the huge red dragon is plainly stated to be a sign, a metaphor, but there is no question as to what it represents. Rev. 20:2 says: "the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is a slanderer, even Satan". The dragon is Satan. In Rev. 7:8, "the tribe of Zebulon" can only have the literal, biblical

meaning; and numbers like 'twelve thousand' do not have a symbolic meaning, they are literal (although large numbers can be 'rounded'). Everything that John wrote, he **saw**. And he saw it because the Sovereign showed it to him. And since everything that the Sovereign showed him is true and faithful, it must be handled as honest information.

Could it be that most people are just 'parrots', repeating what they were taught? How many seminary professors and pastors have gone to the Sacred Text for themselves, allowing it to say what it says, treating it as being "true and faithful"? To be sincerely wrong does not deliver you from the consequences of being wrong. When I lived in the Amazon jungle with a tribal people, they sincerely did not believe in the existence of germs and bacteria, because they couldn't see them; but they got sick and died anyway. Their sincere belief did not deliver them from the consequences of being wrong. Of course, the seriousness of the consequences depends on the nature and importance of the mistake.

'Ignorance of the law is no excuse.' If you break the law ignorantly, you have still broken the law and will have to pay. In John 8:44 Sovereign Jesus declared that Satan is "the father of lying". In Hebrew idiom the 'son' of something is characterized by that something. The 'father' of something owns that something, because he produced it. So Satan owns all falsehood, and the Holy Spirit owns all truth. It follows that to repeat a falsehood serves Satan, even if the person thinks that it is true. Fact is fact; how you feel about it does not make it a non-fact!

A 'parrot', ignorantly repeating what it was taught, is one thing, but Revelation 21:27 and 22:15 refer to something else. 22:15 refers to "everyone who loves and practices a lie": this is not a 'parrot', it is someone who has embraced the lie and made it a part of his philosophy of life. In John 16:13 Sovereign Jesus said that the Holy Spirit "will guide you into

all the truth"; it follows that someone who embraces a lie does not have the Holy Spirit, or at least is not listening to Him. Such a person condemns himself, but 21:27 refers to something worse. To condemn yourself is your choice, but to condemn other people is malignant.

Revelation 21:27 refers to "provoking a lie"; such a person is promoting the lie, is 'selling' it as truth. Actually the Greek verb has a wide area of meaning, the basic ones being 'to do, make or cause', and all three apply here. To 'do' a lie is to tell or live it. To 'make' a lie is to create it. To 'cause' a lie is to put it in other people's heads so that they repeat it as truth. All three are excluded from the City. I rendered 'cause' as 'provoke', to promote a lie and 'sell' it as truth. People who do that are damaging their students and hearers—the extent of the damage depends on the nature of the falsehood. It should be obvious that such people did not consult the Holy Spirit before teaching what they teach. If they are not knowingly serving Satan, they almost certainly have one or more strongholds of Satan in their minds; a stronghold of Satan on a given subject locks you into the falsehood on that subject. Again, some falsehoods are more serious than others. The Righteous Judge knows all the relevant factors about each of us and will judge us fairly, albeit He abominates falsehood.

And that brings us to 2 Thess. 2:9-12, that describes an even more serious reality.

> 9 that one's coming is according to the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders, 10 and with all wicked deception among those who are wasting themselves, because they did not receive the love of the

truth[a] so that they might be saved.[b] 11 Yes, because of this God will send them an active delusion so that they will believe the lie 12 and so that all may be condemned who have not believed the truth but have taken pleasure in wickedness.

God Himself sends “an active delusion” upon those who do not “receive the love of the truth”, so that they “may be condemned”. Notice the sequence: first they reject the love of the truth; it is as a consequence of that choice that God sends the delusion. The implication is that there is a point of no return; God sends the delusion so that they may be condemned. The only intelligent choice is to embrace the truth, as defined by the Sacred Text, interpreted on its own terms.

[a] The use of the verb ‘receive’ clearly implies an act of volition on their part; that love was offered or made available to them but they did not want it; they wanted to be able to lie and to entertain lies told by others. But the consequences of such a choice are terrible; they turned their back on salvation.

[b] Since there are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world, that of Sovereign Jesus and that of Satan, “those who are wasting themselves”, in this text, are still in Satan’s kingdom and therefore wide open to his “wicked deception”. The Text states plainly that they are wasting themselves “because they did not receive the love of the truth so that they might be saved”. They are not saved.

APPENDIX

Chronology of the Life of CHRIST

Based on every verse of the four Gospels.

A. Preamble.

1. Anticipated summary—**Jn. 1:1-14.**
2. His human genealogy.
   a. Through His adopted father, Joseph—**Mt. 1:1-17**.
   b. Through His mother, Mary—**Lk. 3:23-38**.

B. Introduction.

3. John's birth—[**Lk. 1:1-4**]. **5 BC**
   a. Predicted by the angel Gabriel—**Lk. 1:5-25.**
   b. Accomplished—**Lk. 1:57-66.**
   c. Zacharias' prophecy—**Lk. 1:67-79.**
   d. The child grows—**Lk. 1:80.**
4. The birth of Jesus. **5 BC**
   a. Announced to the virgin Mary—**Lk. 1:26-38.**
   b. Mary visits Elizabeth—**Lk. 1:39-45,56.**
   c. Mary's "Magnificat"—**Lk. 1:46-55.**
   d. An angel instructs Joseph—**Mt. 1:18-25.**
   e. The birth—**Lk. 2:1-7.**
   f. Pastors and angels—**Lk. 2:8-20.**
   g. Circumcision and presentation—**Lk. 2:21-24.**
   h. Simeon—**Lk. 2:25-35.**
   i. Ana—**Lk. 2:36-38.**
   j. The magi—**Mt. 2:1-12.**
   k. The flight to Egypt—**Mt. 2:13-15.**
   l. The massacre—**Mt. 2:16-18.**
5. The return to Natsareth—**Mt. 2:19-23; Lk. 2:39.**
6. The child grows—**Lk. 2:40-52.**
7. The ministry of John—**Mt. 3:1-12; Mk. 1:1-8; Lk. 3:1-18; Jn. 1:6-8.**
8. The baptism of Jesus—**Mt. 3:13-17; Mk. 1:9-11; Lk. 3:21-22. 26 AD**
9. Jesus tested by Satan—**Mt. 4:1-11;Mk. 1:12-13;Lk. 4:1-13.**

C. Jesus begins His ministry, concentrating on Judea.

1. Jesus returns to John.
   a. The witness of John—**Jn. 1:15-34.**
      1) John answers the Pharisees—**Jn. 1:19-28.**
      2) John identifies the Messiah—**Jn. 1:29-34.**
   b. Jesus calls Andrew, Peter, Philip and Nathaniel—**Jn. 1:35-51.**
2. A wedding in Cana; the first "sign"—**Jn. 2:1-11 (12).**
3. The first Passover and purification of temple—**Jn. 2:13-25.**
   27 AD
4. A conversation with Nicodemus—**Jn. 3:1-21.**
5. John testifies again—**Jn. 3:22-36.**
6. John is imprisoned—**(Mt. 14:3-5); (Mk. 6:17-20); Lk. 3:19-20; (Jn. 3:24).**
7. Jesus leaves Judea for Galilee—**Mt. 4:12; Jn. 4:1-4.**
8. Jesus and the Samaritans—**Jn. 4:5-6.**
   a. The woman—**Jn. 4:7-29.**
      1) "Give Me a drink"—**Jn. 4:7-15.**
      2) "Go, call your husband"—**Jn. 4:16-26.**
      3) "Could this be the Christ?"—**Jn. 4:28-29.**
   b. The disciples—**Jn. 4:27, 31-38.**
   c. The Samaritans—**Jn. 4:30, 39-42.**

D. Jesus concentrates His ministry in Galilee.

1. He arrives in Galilee—**Mk. 1:14-15; Lk. 4:14-15; Jn. 4:43.**
2. He is rejected in Nazareth—**Lk. 4:16-30; (Jn. 4:44).**[a]
3. The nobleman's son (2nd sign in Galilee)—**Jn. 4:45-54.**
4. The ministry in the Capernaum area.
   a. Jesus settles there—**Mt. 4:13-17.**
   b. Peter, Andrew, James & John—**Mt. 4:18-22; Mk. 1:16-20.**
   c. He expels demons in Capernaum—**Mk. 1:21-28; Lk. 4:31-37.**

[a] I believe that the episode recorded in Luke 4:16-30 took place between verses 43 and 45 here (John 4), and verse 44 is an echo of Luke 4:24. From Sychar Jesus went directly to Natsareth, was rejected there, and proceeded to Cana (I suspect that He had a brother-in-law living there). Verse 45 is a summary statement, after the fact. [Of course He was born in Bethlehem, Judea, but I doubt that He is referring to it as 'his own country'.]

d. He cures Peter's mother-in-law—**Mk. 1:29-31; Lk. 4:38-39.**
e. He heals many others—**Mk. 1:32-34; Lk. 4:40-41.**
f. He retires to pray—**Mk. 1:35-38; Lk. 4:42-43.**

5. A tour of Galilee—**Mt. 4:23-25; Mk. 1:39; Lk. 4:44.**
6. A miraculous catch—**Lk. 5:1-11.**
7. The sermon on the mount—**Mt. 5:1-2.**
   a. The beatitudes—M**t. 5:3-10.**
   b. "Blessed are you (pl.)"—**Mt. 5:11-12.**
   c. "Salt and light"—**Mt. 5:13-16.**
   d. Christ and the Law—**Mt. 5:17-20.**
   e. Reconciliation—**Mt. 5:21-26.**
   f. Adultery and divorce—**Mt. 5:27-32.**
   g. Do not swear—**Mt. 5:33-37.**
   h. Do not retaliate—**Mt. 5:38-42.**
   i. Love your enemies—**Mt. 5:43-48.**
   j. Religious ostentation—**Mt. 6:1-8.**
   k. A model prayer, and fasting—**Mt. 6:9-18.**
   l. Treasure, eye and owner—**Mt. 6:19-24.**
   m. Do not be anxious—**Mt. 6:25-34.**
   n. Do not judge unjustly—**Mt. 7:1-5.**
   o. Pearls aren't for pigs—**Mt. 7:6**
   p. Ask and do—**Mt. 7:7-12.**
   q. The two ways—**Mt. 7:13-14.**
   r. Good and bad trees—**Mt. 7:15-23.**
   s. The two foundations—**Mt. 7:24-27.**
8. The people's reaction—**Mt. 7:28-29.**

E. The hinge: proof, evaluation, rejection, blasphemy, denunciation.

1. The leper, "as a <u>proof</u>"—**Mt. 8:1-4; Mk. 1:40-45; Lk. 5:12-15(16).**
2. A centurion's servant—**Mt. 8:5-13.**
3. Peter's mother-in-law, again—**Mt. 8:14-15.**
4. Many others healed—**Mt. 8:16-17.**
5. The paralytic (the <u>evaluation</u>)—**Mt. 9:2-8; Mk. 2:1-12; <u>Lk</u>. <u>5:17-26</u>.**

6. Matthew called, makes banquet—**Mt. 9:9-13; Mk. 2:13-17; Lk. 5:27-32.**
7. Fasting, "cloth, wineskins"—**Lk. 5:33-39.**
8. Jesus returns to Jerusalem—(the 2nd Passover) **Jn. 5:1**. **28 AD**
9. A paralytic of Bethesda—**Jn. 5:2-15.**
10. Jesus and the Jews—**Jn. 5:16-47.**
11. Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath—**Mt. 12:1-8; Mk. 2:23-28; Lk. 6:1-5.**
12. Jesus heals on the Sabbath—**Mt. 12:9-13; Mk. 3:1-5; Lk. 6:6-10.**
13. P and H plot to kill (the rejection)—**Mt. 12:14; Mk. 3:6; Lk. 6:11.**
14. Jesus heals by the sea—**Mt. 12:15-21; Mk. 3:7-12.**
15. He chooses the twelve—M**k. 3:13-19; Lk. 6:12-16.**
16. The sermon on the plain (not the mount)—**Lk. 6:17-49.**
    a. Preamble—**Lk. 6:17-19.**
    b. Blessing and woe—**Lk. 6:20-26.**
    c. Love your enemy—**Lk. 6:27-36.**
    d. Don't judge unjustly—**Lk. 6:37-45.**
    e. The two foundations—**Lk. 6:46-49.**
17. A centurion's slave—**Lk. 7:1-10.**
18. The son of a widow—**Lk. 7:11-17.**
19. Jesus eulogizes John Baptist—**Mt. 11:2-19; Lk. 7:18-35.**
20. He denounces three cities—**Mt. 11:20-24.**
21. Personal discipleship—**Mt. 11:25-30.**
22. Simon, the Pharisee—**Lk. 7:36-50.**
23. In a house (perhaps His own)—**Mk. 3:20-21.**
24. A demoniac cured, Pharisees blaspheme—**Mt. 12:22-32; Mk. 3:22-30.**
25. Jesus denounces the Pharisees—**Mt. 12:33-42.**
26. "Seven others worse"—**Mt. 12:43-45.**

F. Jesus takes the offensive.

1. New relationships—**Mt. 12:46-50; Mk. 3:31-35; Lk. 8:19-21.**
2. The parables—**Mt. 13:1-2; Mk. 4:1-2,33-34; Lk. 8:4.**
    a. The sower—**Mt. 13:3-9; Mk. 4:3-9; Lk. 8:5-8.**

b. Why parables?—**Mt. 13:10-7,34-5; Mk. 4:10-12; Lk. 8:9-10.**
c. "The sower" explained—**Mt. 13:18-23; Mk. 4:13-20; Lk. 8:11-15.**
d. Wheat and tares—**Mt. 13:24-30,36-43.**
e. The lampstand—**Mk. 4;21-25; Lk. 8:16-18.**
f. Growth and harvest—**Mk. 4:26-29.**
g. A grain of mustard seed—**Mt. 13:31-32; Mk. 4:30-32.**
h. Leaven—**Mt. 13:33.**
i. Further parables—**Mt. 13:44-52.**

3. The scribe—**Mt. 8:18-22.**
4. The tempest—**Mt. 8:23-27; Mk. 4:35-41; Lk. 8:22-25.**
5. The "legion"— **Mt. 8:28-9:1; Mk. 5:1-21; Lk. 8:26-40.**
6. Fasting, "cloth, wineskins"—**Mt. 9:14-17; Mk. 2:18-22.**
7. A hemorrhage and a dead girl—**Mt. 9:18-26; Mk. 5:22-43; Lk. 8:41-56.**
8. Two blind men—**Mt. 9:27-31.**
9. A demoniac healed—**Mt. 9:32-34.**
10. A visit to Natsareth—**Mt. 13:53-58; Mk. 6:1-6[a].**
11. A tour of Galilee—**Mt. 9:35-38; Mk. 6:6[b]; Lk. 8:1-3(?).**
12. The Twelve sent out—**Mt. 10:1-5[a];Mk. 6:7,12-13;Lk. 9:1-2,6.**
    a. Commissioned—**Mt. 10:5[b]-15; Mk. 6:8-11; Lk. 9:3-5.**
    b. Prophetic orientation—**Mt. 10:16-42.**
13. The tour continues—**Mt. 11:1.**
14. Herod and John's death—**Mt. 14:1-12; Mk. 6:14-29; Lk. 9:7-9.**
15. The Twelve return—**Mk. 6:30-31; Lk. 9:10.**
16. Bread for 5.000 men—**Mt. 14:13-21; Mk. 6:32-44; Lk. 9:11-17; Jn. 6:1-14.**
17. Jesus retires to pray—**Mt. 14:22-23;Mk. 6:45-47;Jn. 6:15.**
18. Jesus walks on water—**Mt. 14:24-33; Mk. 6:47-52; Jn. 6:16-21.**
19. In Genesaret—**Mt. 14:34-36; Mk. 6:53-56.**
20. Discourse in Capernaum (see verse 59)—**Jn. 6:22-71.**
    a. The people look for Jesus—**Jn. 6:22-25.**
    b. The Bread of Life—**Jn. 6:26-35.**
    c. The will of the Father—**Jn. 6:36-51.**

d. Eat flesh, drink blood—**Jn. 6:52-59.**

e. "You have the words of eternal life"—**Jn. 6:60-71.**

21. (A secret trip to Jerusalem; the third Passover)—(Deut. 16:16); **(Jn. 6:4, 7:1). 29 AD**
22. He answers the scribes and Pharisees—**Mt. 15:1-9; Mk. 7:1-13.**
23. That which contaminates—**Mt. 15:10-20; Mk. 7:14-23.**
24. A Canaanite woman—**Mt. 15:21-28; Mk. 7:24-30.**
25. In Decapolis—**Mt. 15:29-31; Mk. 7:31-37.**
26. Bread for 4,000 men—**Mt. 15:32-39; Mk. 8:1-10.**
27. The "sign of Jonah"—**Mt. 16:1-4; Mk. 8:11-13.**
28. Pharisee 'leaven'—**Mt. 16:5-12; Mk. 8:14-21.**
29. In Bethsaida—**Mk. 8:22-26.**

G. Jesus ministers on the basis of His impending death (now openly declared).

1. Peter's confession—**Mt. 16:13-23;Mk. 8:27-33;Lk. 9:18-22.**
2. The price of discipleship—**Mt. 16:24-27; Mk. 8:34-38; Lk. 9:23-26.**
3. The transfiguration—**Mt. 16:28-17:13; Mk. 9:1-13; Lk. 9:27-36.**
4. A demonized boy—**Mt. 17:14-21; Mk. 9:14-29; Lk. 9:37-43.**
5. Jesus predicts His death, again—**Mt. 17:22-23; Mk. 9:30-32; Lk. 9:43^{b}-45.**
6. Money from a fish—**Mt. 17:24-27.**
7. Faith and humility—**Mt. 18:1-5; Mk. 9:33-37; Lk. 9:46-48.**
8. If not against us, on our side—**Mk. 9:38-41; Lk. 9:49-50.**
9. Offenses bring woe—**Mt. 18:6-9; Mk. 9:42-50.**
10. More about offenses—**Mt. 18:10-20.**
11. Forgive seventy times seven—**Mt. 18:21-35.**
12. His brothers don't believe—**Jn. 7:2-9.**
13. Jesus leaves Galilee—**Mt. 19:1; Mk. 10:1; Jn. 7:10.**
14. He is rejected in Samaria—**Lk. 9:51-56.**
15. What it takes to be a "disciple"—**Lk. 9:57-62.**
16. The feast of Tabernacles—**Jn. 7:11-43. 29 AD**

a. Jesus teaches in the temple—**Jn. 7:14-36.**

1) Moses against the Jews—**Jn. 7:19-24.**

2) Public opinion is divided—**Jn. 7:25-36.**

b. The last day of the feast—**Jn. 7:37-43.**

17. An attempted arrest—**Jn. 7:44-53.**
18. A dirty plot—**Jn. 8:1-11.**
19. "The Light of the world"—**Jn. 8:12-59.**
    a. "You will die in your sins"—**Jn. 8:21-29.**
    b. "The Truth will set you free"—**Jn. 8:30-38.**
    c. "You are of your father, the devil"—J**n. 8:39-51.**
    d. "Before Abraham existed, I AM"—**Jn. 8:52-59.**
20. Blind from birth—**Jn. 9:1-41.**
    a. "Who sinned?"—**Jn. 9:2-5.**
    b. The blind man is cured—**Jn. 9:6-12.**
    c. The Pharisees research—**Jn. 9:13-17.**
    d. Evasive parents—**Jn. 9:18-23.**
    e. Ex-blind man instructs Pharisees—**Jn. 9:24-34.**
    f. Jesus affirms His divinity—**Jn. 9:35-41.**
21. "The good shepherd"—**Jn. 10:1-21.**
22. The seventy sent out—**Lk. 10:1-16.**
23. The seventy return—**Lk. 10:17-24.**
24. The good Samaritan—**Lk. 10:25-37.**
25. Martha and Mary—**Lk. 10:38-42.**
26. A model prayer—**Lk. 11:1-4.**
27. The persistent friend—**Lk. 11:5-13.**
28. A demoniac cured, Pharisees <u>blaspheme</u>—**Lk. 11:14-23.**
29. "Seven others worse"—**Lk. 11:24-28.**
30. Jesus <u>denounces</u> the Pharisees—**Lk. 11:29-36.**
31. In a Pharisee's house—**Lk. 11:37-54.**
32. Leaven of the Pharisees—**Lk. 12:1-3.**
33. Don't fear people—**Lk. 12:4-12.**
34. Warning against materialism—**Lk. 12:13-21.**
35. The Kingdom mentality—**Lk. 12:22-34.**
36. The accounting—**Lk. 12:35-48.**
37. Christ divides—**Lk. 12:49-59.**
38. The fig tree—**Lk. 13:1-9.**
39. A "daughter of Abraham"—**Lk. 13:10-17.**
40. Parables of the Kingdom—**Lk. 13:18-21.**
41. "The narrow gate"—**Lk. 13:22-30.**

42. Herod is a "fox"—**Lk. 13:31-33.**
43. The feast of dedication (Monday, Dec. 17, 29)—**Jn. 10:22-23.**
    a. "If you are the Christ, tell us plainly"—**Jn. 10:24-30.**
    b. "We stone you for blasphemy"—**Jn. 10:31-39.**
44. Jesus laments over Jerusalem—**Lk. 13:34-35.**
45. In a Pharisee's house.—**Lk. 14:1-24.**
    a. A man is cured—**Lk. 14:1-6.**
    b. "Whoever exalts himself will be humbled"—**Lk. 14:7-11.**
    c. "The great supper"—**Lk. 14:12 -24.**

H. Jesus ministers (mainly) in Perea.

1. Jesus retires to Perea—**(Mt. 19:1); (Mk. 10:1); Jn. 10:40-42.**
2. Jesus defines "disciple"—**Lk. 14:25-35.**
3. Response to criticism from Pharisees—**Lk. 15:1-2.**
    a. "The lost sheep"—**Lk. 15:3-7.**
    b. "The lost coin"—**Lk. 15:8-10.**
    c. "The lost son"—**Lk. 15:11-32.**
4. "The stupid steward"—**Lk. 16:1-13.**
5. Greedy Pharisees—**Lk. 16:14-17.**
6. Jesus on divorce—**Mt. 19:2-12; Mk. 10:2-12; Lk. 16:18.**
7. A rich man and Lazarus (another)—**Lk. 16:19-31.**
8. Offense and pardon—**Lk. 17:1-4.**
9. "Increase our faith"—**Lk. 17:5-6.**
10. "We are unprofitable servants"—**Lk. 17:7-10.**
11. Ten lepers healed—**Lk. 17:11-19.**
12. The Day of the Son of man—**Lk. 17:20-37.**
13. "The persistent widow"—**Lk. 18:1-8.**
14. A Pharisee and a publican—**Lk. 18:9-14.**
15. He blesses children—**Mt. 19:13-15; Mk. 10:13-16; Lk. 18:15-17.**
16. Lazarus (of Bethany) dies—**Jn. 11:1-16.**
17. A rich young ruler—**Mt. 19:16-26; Mk. 10:17-27; Lk.18:18-27.**
18. Apostolic reward—**Mt. 19:27-30; Mk. 10:28-31; Lk. 18:28-30.**
19. Parable of the laborers—**Mt. 20:1-16.**

20. Jesus predicts His death (3rd)—**Mt. 20:17-19; Mk. 10:32-34; Lk. 18:31-34.**
21. James' and John's request— **Mt. 20:20-28; Mk. 10:35-45.**
22. Bartimaeus—**Mt. 20:29-34; Mk. 10:46-52; Lk. 18:35-43.**
23. Zacchaeus—**Lk. 19:1-10.**
24. Parable of the despised king—**Lk. 19:11-27.**
25. Lazarus is resurrected—**Jn. 11:17-46.**
26. The reaction—**Jn. 11:47-53.**
27. Jesus retires to Ephraim—**Jn. 11:54.**
28. The last Passover is near—**Jn. 11:55-57.** **30 AD**

I. The last week.

1. Mary anoints His feet—**Jn. 12:1-11.**
2. The 'triumphal' entry—**Mt. 21:1-11, Mk. 11:1-11, Lk. 19:28-40, Jn. 12:12-19.**
3. He curses the fig tree—**Mt. 21:18-19, Mk. 11:12-14.**
4. Jesus laments Jerusalem (2nd)—**Lk. 19:41-44.**
5. He purifies the temple (2nd)—**Mt. 21:12-17, Mk. 11:15-19, Lk. 19:45-46.**
6. Certain Greeks seek Jesus—**Jn. 12:20-26.**
7. "Father, glorify Your name"—**Jn. 12:27-36.**
8. His daily routine—**Lk. 19:47-48 (21:37-38).**
9. Send a mount into the sea—**Mt. 21:20-22, Mk. 11:20-26.**
10. "The baptism of John"—**Mt. 21:23-27, Mk. 11:27-33, Lk. 20:1-8.**
11. Two sons—**Mt. 21:28-32.**
12. Perverse vinedressers—**Mt. 21:33-46, Mk. 12:1-12, Lk. 20:9-19.**
13. Correct wedding attire—**Mt. 22:1-14.**
14. Tribute to Caesar?—**Mt. 22:15-22, Mk. 12:13-17, Lk. 20:20-26.**
15. The Sadducees' question—**Mt. 22:23-33, Mk. 12:18-27, Lk. 20:27-40.**
16. The greatest commandment—**Mt. 22:34-40, Mk. 12:28-34.**
17. David calls Messiah "Lord"—**Mt. 22:41-46, Mk. 12:35-37, Lk. 20:41-44.**
18. "Beware of the scribes"—**Mk. 12:38-40, Lk. 20:45-47.**

19. The widow's mites—**Mk. 12:41-44, Lk. 21:1-4.**
20. "Woes" for Pharisees—**Mt. 23:1-36.**
21. He laments Jerusalem (3rd)—**Mt. 23:37-39.**
22. The temple will be destroyed—**Mt. 24:1-2, Mk. 13:1-2, Lk. 21:5-6.**
23. The Olivet discourse—"the end time".
    a. Preamble—**Mt. 24:3-14, Mk. 13:3-13, Lk. 21:7-19.**
    b. Destruction of Jerusalem—**Lk. 21:20-24.**
    c. Abomination of desolation—**Mt. 24:15-20, Mk. 13:14-18.**
    d. The Great Tribulation—**Mt. 24:21-28, Mk. 13:19-23, Lk. 21:25-26.**
    e. Christ's return to earth—**Mt. 24:29-31, Mk. 13:24-27, Lk. 21:27-28.**
    f. "The fig tree"—**Mt. 24:32-35, Mk. 13:28-31, Lk. 21:29-33.**
    g. Watch!—**Mt. 24:36-44, Mk. 13:32-37, Lk. 21:34-36.**
    h. The accounting—**Mt. 24:45-51.**
    i. "The ten virgins"—**Mt. 25:1-13.**
    j. "The talents"—**Mt. 25:14-30.**
    k. Sheep and goats—**Mt. 25:31-46.**
24. "After two days is the Passover"—**Mt. 26:1-2.**
25. The Sanhedrin conspires—**Mt. 26:3-5, Mk. 14:1-2, Lk. 22:1-2.**
26. Someone anoints His head—**Mt. 26:6-13, Mk. 14:3-9.**
27. Judas is contracted— **Mt. 26:14-16, Mk. 14:10-11, Lk. 22:3-6 (Jn. 13:2).**
28. The disbelief of the Jews—**Jn. 12:37-43.**
29. The last word—**Jn. 12:44-50.**

J. The last night.

1. Upper room prepared—**Mt. 26:17-19, Mk. 14:12-16, Lk. 22:7-13.**
2. In the upper room—**(Jn. 13:1).**
    a. They arrive—**Mt. 26:20, Mk. 14:17, Lk. 22:14.**
    b. "I have desired to eat this Passover"—**Lk. 22:15-18.**
    c. Traitor identified (1st time)—**Mt. 26:21-25, Mk. 14:18-21, Lk. 22:21-23.**

d. Who is the greatest?—**Lk. 22:24-30.**
e. Foot washing—**Jn. 13:2-20.**
f. Traitor identified (2nd time)—**Jn. 13:21-30.**
g. The new commandment—**Jn. 13:31-35.**
h. Jesus warns Peter (1st time)—**Jn. 13:36-38.**
i. The Lord's Supper—**Mt. 26:26-29, Mk. 14:22-25, Lk. 22:19-20**, (1 Cor. 11:23-26).
j. The Father's house—**Jn. 14:1-4.**
k. Thomas' question: "How can we know the way?"—**Jn. 14:5-7.**
l. Philip's request: "Lord, show us the Father"—**Jn. 14:8-14.**
m. The Spirit of the Truth—**Jn. 14:15-21.**
n. Thaddeus' question—**Jn. 14:22-26.**
o. "My peace I give you"—**Jn. 14:27-31.**
p. The true vine—**Jn. 15:1-8.**
q. Friends, not slaves—**Jn. 15:9-17.**
r. "The world hates you"— **Jn. 15:18-16:4.**
s. Jesus warns Peter (2nd time)—**Lk.22:31-34.**
t. Buy a sword—**Lk. 22:35-38.**
u. The work of the Spirit—**Jn. 16:5-15.**
v. "A little . . . a little"—**Jn. 16:16-22.**
w. Ask the Father—**Jn. 16:23-28.**
x. Be of good cheer!—**Jn. 16:29-33.**
y. Jesus prays—**Jn. 17:1-26.**
1) For Himself—**Jn. 17:1-5.**
2) For His disciples—**Jn. 17:6-19.**
3) For all believers—**Jn. 17:20-26.**

3. They go to the garden—**Mt. 26:30, Mk. 14:26, Lk. 22:39, Jn. 18:1.**
4. Jesus warns Peter (3rd time)—**Mt. 26:31-35.**
5. Jesus warns Peter (4th time)—**Mk. 14:27-31.**
6. The agony in Gethsemane.
a. Takes Peter, James, John—**Mt. 26:36-38, Mk. 14:32-34.**
b. The first prayer—**Mt. 26:39-41, Mk. 14:35-38, Lk. 22:40-46.**
c. The second prayer—**Mt. 26:42-43, Mk. 14:39-40.**

d. The third prayer—**Mt. 26:44-46, Mk. 14:41-42.**

7. The betrayal.
   a. The kiss—**Mt. 26:47-50, Mk. 14:43-45, Lk. 22:47-48, Jn. 18:2-3.**
   b. On their backs—**Jn. 18:4-9.**
   c. Peter's sword—**Mt. 26:51-54, Mk. 14:47, Lk. 22:49-51, Jn. 18:10-11.**
   d. The arrest—**Mt. 26:55-56, Mk.14:46,48-50, Lk. 22:52-53, Jn. 18:12.**
8. A naked youth—**Mk. 14:51-52.**
9. Jesus taken to Annas—**Jn. 18:13-14.**
10. Then taken to Caiaphas—**Mt. 26:57, Mk. 14:53, Lk. 22:54, (Jn. 18:24).**
11. Peter denies (1st--doorkeeper)—**Jn. 18:15-17.**
12. Peter with the servants—**Mt. 26:58, Mk. 14:54, Lk. 22:55, Jn. 18:18.**
13. Caiaphas interrogates Jesus—**Jn. 18:19-23.**
14. Peter denies (2nd--guards)—**Jn. 18:25.**
15. False witnesses—**Mt. 26:59-62, Mk. 14:55-60.**
16. The High priest cheats—**Mt. 26:63-68, Mk. 14:61-65.**
17. Peter denies (3rd--a maid)—**Mt. 26:69-70, Mk. 14:66-68[b], Lk. 22:56-57.**
18. Peter denies (4th--relative)—**Jn. 18:26-27.**
19. Rooster crows first time—**Mk. 14:68[c], Jn. 18:27.**
20. Peter denies (5th--same maid)—**Mk. 14:69-70.**
21. Peter denies (6th--a man)—L**k. 22:58.**
22. Peter denies (7th--another maid)—**Mt. 26:71-72.**
23. Peter denies (8th--general)—**Mt. 26:73-74, Mk. 14:70-71, Lk. 22:59-60.**
24. Rooster crows 2nd time—**Mt. 26:74, Mk. 14:71, Lk. 22:60.**
25. Jesus stares at Peter—**Lk. 22:61.**
26. Peter weeps—**Mt. 26:75, Mk. 14:72, Lk. 22:62.**
27. Guards abuse Jesus—**Lk. 22:63-65.**

K. Crucifixion day. (Friday, Apr. 05, 30)

1. Sanhedrin tries Jesus—**Mt. 27:1, Mk. 15:1, Lk. 22:66-71.**
2. Jesus is taken to Pilate—**Mt. 27:2, Mk. 15:1, Lk. 23:1, Jn. 18:28.**

3. The 1st accusation—**Lk. 23:2, Jn. 18:29-32.**
4. Pilate and Jesus (1st time)—**Mt. 27:11, Mk. 15:2, Lk. 23:3, Jn. 18:33-38.**
5. The 2nd accusation—**Mt. 27:12-14, Mk. 15:3-5, Lk. 23:4-6.**
6. Jesus is taken to Herod—**Lk. 23:7-12.**
7. Barabbas or Christ—**Mt. 27:15-21, Mk. 15:6-11, Lk. 23:13-25, Jn. 18:39-40.**
8. Pilate's wife—**Mt. 27:19.**
9. "Crucify Him!"—**Mt. 27:22-23, Mk. 15:12-15.**
10. Soldiers mock Jesus—**Mt. 27:27-30, Mk. 15:16-19, Jn. 19:1-3, (Is. 50:6).**
11. "Behold the man!"—**Jn. 19:4-7.**
12. Pilate and Jesus (2nd time)—**Jn. 19:8-11.**
13. "You are not Caesar's friend"—**Jn. 19:12-15.**
14. Pilate washes his hands—**Mt. 27:24-26.**
15. The crucifixion of Jesus—**Mt. 27:31, Mk. 15:20, Jn. 19:16.**
    a. Simon the Cyrenian—**Mt. 27:32, Mk. 15:21, Lk. 23:26.**
    b. "Daughters of Jerusalem"—**Lk. 23:27-31.**
    c. Golgotha; Jesus crucified—**Mt. 27:33-36, Mk. 15:22-25, Lk. 23:33, Jn. 19:17-18.**
    d. The Accusation—**Mt. 27:37, Mk. 15:26, Lk. 23:38, Jn. 19:19-22.**
    e. Two malefactors—**Mt. 27:38,Mk. 15:27-28,(Lk. 23:32).**
    f. "Father, forgive"—**Lk. 23:34[a].**
    g. Soldiers divide clothes—**Mt. 27:35, Mk. 15:24, Lk. 23:34b, Jn. 19:23-24.**
    h. Spectators blaspheme—**Mt. 27:39-44, Mk. 15:29-32, Lk. 23:35-37.**
    i. "Behold your mother"—**Jn. 19:25-27.**
    j. Penitent malefactor—**Lk. 23:39-43.**
    k. Dark from 12:00 to 3:00—**Mt. 27:45, Mk. 15:33, Lk. 23:44.**
    l. "My God, My God!"—**Mt. 27:46-49, Mk. 15:34-36.**
    m. "I thirst"—**Jn. 19:28-29.**
    n. Jesus dismisses His spirit—**Mt. 27:50, Mk. 15:37, Lk. 23:46, Jn. 19:30.**

o. The veil of the temple is ripped—**Mt. 27:51, Mk. 15:38, Lk. 23:45.**
p. Saints resurrect— **Mt. 27:52-53.**
q. Centurion testifies—**Mt. 27:54, Mk. 15:39, Lk. 23:47.**
r. The crowd laments—**Lk. 23:48.**
s. Women from Galilee—**Mt. 27:55-56, Mk. 15:40-41, Lk. 23:49.**
t. "Not a bone broken"—**Jn. 19:31-37.**

16. Jesus is buried—**Mt. 27:57-61, Mk. 15:42-47, Lk. 23:50-56, Jn. 19:38-42.**
17. The tomb is sealed—**Mt. 27:62-66.**
18. The traitor's remorse—**Mt. 27:3-10**, (Acts 1:18-19).
19. Women buy spices—**Mk. 16:1, (Lk. 23:56).**

L. Resurrection Day. (Sunday, Apr. 07, 30)

1. (Jesus rises from the dead!!—the firstfruits.)
2. Women go to the tomb—**Mt. 28:1, Mk. 16:2-3, Lk. 24:1, Jn. 20:1.**
3. An angel removes the stone—**Mt. 28:2-4.**
4. Women arrive at the spot—**Mk. 16:4, Lk. 24:2, Jn. 20:1.**
5. Magdalene runs to Peter—**Jn. 20:2.**
6. Women enter the tomb—**Mt. 28:5-7, Mk. 16:5-7, Lk. 24:3-8.**
7. Women take off running—**Mt. 28:8, Mk. 16:8.**
8. Guards take off—**Mt. 28:11-15.**
9. Peter and John come, see and go—**(Lk. 24:12), Jn. 20:3-10.**
10. Then Magdalene arrives—**Jn. 20:11-13.**
11. Jesus appears to Magdalene (1st)—**Mk. 16:9, Jn. 20:14-17.**
12. Jesus appears to the women (2nd)—**Mt. 28:9-10.**
13. Women inform the eleven—**Lk. 24:9-11.**
14. Magdalene informs the eleven—**Mk. 16:10-11, Jn. 20:18.**
15. Saints appear in Jerusalem—**Mt. 27:53.**
16. Jesus appears to Peter (3rd or 4th)—**(Lk. 24:34) (1 Cor. 15:5).**
17. On the road to Emmaus (3rd or 4th)—**Mk. 16:12, Lk. 24:13-32.**
18. The two return to Jerusalem—**Mk. 16:13, Lk. 24:33-35.**

19. Jesus appears to the eleven (5th)—**Mk. 16:14-18, Lk. 24:36-49, Jn. 20:19-23.**
20. Thomas arrives later—**Jn. 20:24-25.**

M. Epilogue.

1. Eight days later (Thomas present)—**Jn. 20:26-29.**
2. On a mount, in Galilee—**Mt. 28:16-20.**
3. By the sea of Galilee—**Jn. 21:1-23.**
4. Jesus appears to over 500—(1 Cor. 15:6).
5. Jesus appears to James—(1 Cor. 15:7).
6. The ascension, from Mount Olivet—**Mk. 16:19, Lk. 24:50-51**, Acts 1:4-11.
7. Jesus sends the Holy Spirit—**(Jn. 16:7)** Acts 2:1-4.
8. The Lord works with the disciples—**Mk. 16:20.**
9. Jesus appears to Stephen—Acts 7:55-56.
10. Jesus comes back to earth to deal with Paul—(Acts 26:13-18, 1 Cor. 15:8).
11. Jesus appears to Ananias—Acts 9:10-11.
12. Appears to Paul several times—Acts 22:17-21, 23:11.
13. Appears to John on Patmos—Rev. 1:9-13, etc.
14. (Acts 1:3, 10:41 and 13:31 suggest other appearances.)

A new translation of GENESIS

The Beginning

1.1 In the beginning[a] God created the heavens and the earth.[b] **2** And the earth was without form and void,[c] and there was darkness upon the face of the deep; and the Spirit of God hovered over the face of the waters.[d] **3** And God said, "Let there be light", and there was light.[e] **4** And God saw the light, that it was good; and God made a separation between the light and the darkness. **5** And

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[a] The beginning of this world's history. This first verse functions as a title, and contradicts the theory of evolution as an explanation of origins.

[b] The only one who could pass this information on to Adam was the Creator Himself; the Author is identifying Himself. Adam certainly developed a written form for the language God gave him, and he would have made a written record of everything the Creator told him about the beginning of this planet. If Enoch wrote (Jude 14), it was because Adam wrote first, and all those writings were in Noah's Ark, to be delivered to Moses in due time.

[c] Revelation 21:1 states that this world as we know it is "the first earth", which disproves the 'gap theory'. However, this phrase, “without form and void”, is one of the arguments used in defense of that theory. Aside from the pressure exerted by the theory of evolution (which is scientifically impossible), it was the discovery of fossils of creatures that no longer exist on earth that motivated that theory: how could we account for those fossils (not recognizing that it was Noah’s flood that created them)? It is possible to translate the verb ‘create’ (in v. 1) as ‘recreate’, and so it was argued that a former earth had been destroyed, and then God created a new one. Use was also made of Ezekiel 28:13, “You were in Eden, the garden of God”. Although verse 12 addresses the king of Tyre, the following description is not of a man, “you were the anointed cherub who covers” (v. 14). They argued that the first world was Lucifer’s ‘garden’, but when he rebelled, God destroyed it, resulting in the “without form and void”. Since all fossils are in sedimentary rocks, that were a result of Noah’s flood, there is no need for a ‘gap’.

[d] “Face of the deep”, “face of the waters”, and verse 10 says that the dry ground “appeared”. And that was after half of the water had been placed above the dome. When something ‘appears’ it is usually small, compared to the surrounding situation. Apparently, the surface of the globe was mostly water, at the beginning.

[e] How could there have been light before the creation of the sun? “God is light”, 1 John 1:5, and He resides “in unapproachable light”, 1 Timothy 6:16. It was just a matter of using a little of His light.

God called the light, Day, and called the darkness, Night. And there was dusk and dawn, day one.[a]

6 And God said, "Let there be a dome in the midst of the waters, and let it separate the waters from the waters". **7** And God made the dome and made a separation between the waters that were under the dome and the waters that were above the dome; and it was so.[b] **8** And God called the dome, Heaven. And there was dusk and dawn, day two.[c]

9 And God said, "Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together in one place, and let the dry ground appear"; and it was so. **10** And God called the dry ground, Earth, and called the gathering of the waters, Seas; and God saw that it was good. **11** And God said, "Let the earth bring forth vegetation: herb that yields seed, and fruit-tree that bears fruit after its kind, whose seed is in it, upon the earth"; and it was so.[d] **12** And the land brought forth vegetation: herb yielding seed after its kind, and tree bearing fruit, whose seed is in it, after its kind; and God saw that it was good. **13** And there was dusk and dawn, day three.

14 And God said, "Let there be lights in the dome of heaven, to separate the day from the night; and let them be for signs, and for seasons, and for days and years. **15** And let them be lights in the dome of heaven, to give light to the earth"; and it was so.

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[a] On the fourth day God created the sun "to rule the day", but the day already existed; that is why the Text says "day one". If there was light and darkness, then the earth was already rotating on its axis, and there was a centralized source of light.

[b] The dome was solid and translucent [perhaps frozen hydrogen]. It had to be solid to withstand the weight of the water; and it had to be translucent to let the sunlight through. Half of the water now on earth was above the dome, and served to filter the harmful rays that come from the sun: ultraviolet and infrared. That is why men and animals lived longer, and reached greater size, before the Flood, when the dome was destroyed.

[c] The dome defined the nature of this world from the beginning until the Flood. Perhaps that is why a whole day is dedicated to it, although creating the dome, and moving half of the water above it, was a major undertaking.

[d] 'Seed' and 'fruit' are emphasized, perhaps because they represent food, but presumably every type of vegetation was created that day. Before the Flood, all birds, animals and people were herbivorous, so it was necessary to create the vegetation first, so they would have something to eat.

16 And God made the two great lights: the greater light to rule the day, and the lesser light to rule the night; as well as the stars. **17** And God put them in the dome of heaven to give light to the earth,[a] **18** and to rule the day and the night, and to separate the light from the dark-ness; and God saw that it was good. **19** And there was dusk and dawn, day four.

20 And God said, "Let the waters swarm with swarms of living creatures; and let birds fly above the earth, under the dome of heaven".[b] **21** And God created the great sea creatures,[c] and every living creature that moved, with which the waters swarmed, after its kind, and every winged bird, according to its kind;[d] and God saw that it was good. **22** And God blessed them, saying, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the waters in the seas; and let the birds multiply on the earth". **23** And there was dusk and dawn, day five.

24 And God said,[e] "Let the earth bring forth the living creature according to its kind: cattle, and creeping things, and animals of the earth, according to their kinds"; and it was so. **25** And God made the animals of the earth after their kind, and the cattle after their

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[a] Since the dome was translucent, men looking up would not even know of its existence, seeing the sun, moon and stars normally. To them the luminaries would simply be in the heaven.

[b] The Text does not say how far above the surface of the earth the dome was, but it was evidently farther up than any bird can fly.

[c] Evidently there was a variety of such creatures, but we are not given any details.

[d] I wonder why the fish and birds were created before the animals, but the Text does not say.

[e] Hebrews 11:3 says: “By faith we understand that the ages were created by a word from God, so that the things that are seen were made out of things invisible”. Just so: in this account of the Creation “God said” occurs six times in creative acts (it occurs twice more giving orders to created things, and once God talking to Himself). Why the emphasis on the spoken word? God could have done it all just with His thought. Consider: “Death and life are in the power of the tongue” (Proverbs 18:21); “By your words you will be justified, and by your words you will be condemned” (Matthew 12:37, Sovereign Jesus speaking). There are many texts that indicate the importance of language, spoken and written, and the need to make responsible use thereof. And there are numerous passages that record how a human being brought about a manifestation of God’s power by speaking. God gave us the example when He created our world and our race.

kind, and everything that creeps upon the ground after its kind; and God saw that it was good. **26** And God said, "Let Us[a] make man in our image, after our likeness; and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the birds of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth,[b] and over everything that creeps upon the

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[a] The verb is plural, which agrees with the doctrine of the Trinity. Looking back, we can see some veiled references in the OT, the clearest perhaps being Isaiah 48:16, which mentions all three persons. The doctrine was defined by the glorified Christ in Matthew 28:19: "As you go, make disciples of all ethnic nations: baptizing them into the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit." Our Lord defined the Trinity here. According to Greek grammar, the use of 'and' plus the definite article with a series of items makes it clear that the items are distinct entities. So then, "the Father" is different from "the Son" who is different from "the Holy Spirit". So we have three persons. But Jesus also said, "**the** name", singular, not 'names'. Therefore, we have only one name. God is one 'name', or essence, subsisting in three persons. This baptism is to be administered into the name of the Trinity, which represents a new revelation concerning the nature of God. It also represents a new 'religion', very different from those that were known until then. In the Old Testament we have veiled references, which looking back we can associate with the Trinity, but here we have the first clear statement about it. (To read more about this baptism, please see my article, 'Baptisms in the Bible', available on my website: www.prunch.org, but also article 7 above.)

[b] God turned the administration of this world over to the human race, which means that we are responsible for what happens down here, or would be, except for the Fall. Calamitously, when Adam followed Satan's word, he turned that administration over to Satan. When testing Jesus, Satan showed Him the kingdoms of the world and said: "To you I will give all this authority, and their glory, because it has been handed over to me, and I give it to whomever I want to" (Luke 4:6). And Jesus did not contradict him. However, as a result of Christ's victory with the cross and the resurrection, Satan was demoted. But for His sovereign purposes, God still allows Satan and his demons to function in this world, and it is up to us to stop them: something we can do only by using Christ's power. Further, it appears that the choices that people make do make a difference in what the enemy can do. In a country where the people serve Satan, a boss demon is in control and the demons can act freely. In a country where the people serve God, a boss angel is in control, and the demonic activity is limited.

ground". **27** And God created man in His own image, in the image of God He created him.[a]

Male and female He created them.[b] **28** And God blessed them, and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth, and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the birds of the air, and over everything that creeps upon the ground." **29** And God said, "Listen, I have given you every seed-bearing plant that is on the face of the whole earth, and every tree on which there is seed-bearing fruit: it shall be to you for food. **30** And every green herb shall be for food for every animal of the earth, and for every bird of the air, and for everything that creeps upon the ground, in which there is the breath of life"; and it was so.[c]—**31** And God saw all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was dusk and dawn, day six.

2:1 Thus the heaven and the earth were finished, and all their 'army.'[d] **2** And on the seventh day God had finished His work which He had made and rested on the seventh day from all his work which He had made. **3** And God blessed the seventh day, and sanctified it, because on it He rested from all His work, which God in creating had made.[e]

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[a] In 1 Corinthians 11:7 Paul quotes this text with precision. He uses the Greek word meaning 'male', unambiguously. That verse states further that the male is the ‘glory’ of God, while the woman is the ‘glory’ of man.

[b] The woman was not created on the sixth day, but some time later. Since verses 28 to 30 were addressed to the couple, they must have been spoken after the creation of the woman. The animals and the male were created on the sixth day.

[c] Before the Flood, all animals were herbivorous, and so were humans. It was after the Flood that God authorized the eating of flesh, but not of blood, Genesis 9:3-4.

[d] The Hebrew text literally has 'army', which presumably refers to all the created things mentioned.

[e] The first chapter and these first three verses of the second tell us the sequence of the creation. Starting with verse 4 here, we have vignettes or isolated topics out of sequence. The phrase, "His work which He had made", is repeated three times, emphasizing that it was God himself who did it, and did it directly, in six solar days. Hebrews 1:10, John 1:3,10 and Colossians 1:16 state expressly that of the members of the Trinity, Jehovah the son was the primary agent in the creation of this world. In passing, the Jewish practice of

The Beginning re-stated, using the Creator's personal name

2.4 These are the 'generations'[a] of the heavens and the earth when they were created, in the day[b] that God JEHOVAH[c] made the earth and the heavens.[d]

5 No plant of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprouted; for God JEHOVAH had not caused it to rain upon the earth, and there was no man to till the ground. **6** (But a mist went up from the earth and watered the whole surface of the

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starting their day at 6:00 p.m. is probably based on the creation account in the first chapter.

[a] The Hebrew text literally has 'generations,' which seems to include both the origin and the later history.

[b] Here 'day' has the meaning of a time period, not of a solar day.

[c] Just like 'Coach Joe', or 'Captain Jim', 'God' works as a title and 'JEHOVAH' as a proper name. This verse introduces and identifies the Creator with His proper name. Before the Masoretes added the vowel pointing, centuries into the Christian era, the Hebrew Text was consonantal, written only with consonants. It turns out that the Masoretes left the Name, YHVH, without this pointing, because in their time the Jews no longer pronounced the Name. When the first half of the Name is used as a prefix to a proper name, such as the king of Judah, Jehoshaphat, the first two vowels are always 'e' and 'o'. When the second half is used as a suffix, such as Israel's prime minister, Netanyahu, the last two vowels are always 'a' and 'u'. From this, I deduce that the full Name was YEHOVAHU. By suppressing the last vowel and anglicizing, we are left with JEHOVAH.

In the century before last, the 'higher criticism' of the Bible denied its divine inspiration, even denying the stated authorship of the books. As for the early chapters of Genesis, they claimed that they were a mosaic composed of pieces written by several people. In doing so, they demonstrated ignorance as to the way in which Hebrew discourse works, as well as the way in which language itself functions. The human sound apparatus can only produce one sound at a time. As a result, our communication is necessarily linear. It is impossible to say everything at the same time. It is perfectly normal that the account of creation was given from different perspectives.

[d] With the exception of the first verse (1:1), this is the first time that 'heavens' appears, plural. Being plural, it refers to more than the sky defined by the dome. The celestial luminaries were above the dome, in the second heaven.

ground.)[a]

7 God JEHOVAH formed man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.[b] **8** And God JEHOVAH planted a garden in Eden, on the east side;[c] and he put there the man whom he had formed. **9** And God JEHOVAH caused every tree to grow out of the ground, which is pleasant to the sight and good for food; also the tree of life in the midst of the garden, and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.

(10 And a river went out of Eden to water the garden; and from there it was divided into four headwaters. **11** The name of the first [river] was Pishon; it wound through all the land of Havilah, where there was gold. **12** And the gold of this land was good; there was bdellium, and the onyx stone. **13** And the name of the second river was Gihon; it wound through all the land of Cush. **14** And the name of the third river was Hiddekel; it flowed along the east side of Asshur. And the fourth river was Euphrates.**)**[d]

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[a] I understand that verse 6 is an explanatory aside from Moses, who wrote after the Flood. Before the Flood there was no rain, and Moses explains how the plants were watered.

[b] Although birds, fish and insects have life, they do not have soul. We have soul as well as life, but they are intimately related. When a person dies, life and soul leave together.

[c] The Text does not give us the point of reference. But since the surface of the entire earth, including Eden, was destroyed by the Flood, this 'point' would no longer make sense to us. That said, I do not under-stand the purpose of this information.

[d] The rivers in the world today, after the Flood, are caused by rain, or melting snow. But before the Flood there was no rain; so how could there be a river? As part of the Flood, “the fountains of the great deep were broken up” (7:11), which must refer to reservoirs of water under the earth’s crust. But “broken up” suggests that the water was under pressure, which could result in springs, or even geysers, as happens in our day. Evidently God opened a spring of considerable size to produce the river in Eden. Before the Flood, there may have been an occasional small stream, here and there around the world, but there were no large rivers such as we have today.

This paragraph about the rivers interrupts the flow of the narrative. It could not have been part of what Jehovah shared with Adam as they walked and talked in the Garden. During the 1,650+ years between Creation and the Flood, people were reproducing much faster than they were dying. By the

15 And God JEHOVAH took the man and put him in the garden of Eden, to cultivate it and to keep it. **16** And God JEHOVAH commanded the man, saying: "Of every tree of the garden you may eat freely; **17** but of the tree of the know-ledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you will surely die."[a]

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time of the Flood, there must have been many hundreds of thousands, if not millions, of inhabitants on this planet. Once the fallen pair was expelled from the Garden, their descendants would have spread out in all directions. They built towns and gave names to their towns and their areas. I take it that this paragraph about the rivers was included to give some idea of the extent of the human population (before the Flood), including its geographical distribution.

But why are gold, bdellium and onyx mentioned? Well, evidently gold came to be viewed as having special value early on, functioning as a sort of money. Bdellium is a plant with aromatic gum, perhaps a type of cosmetic, indicating that people were already paying attention to that sort of thing. Onyx is a pretty semi-precious stone that would have ornamental value (not useful for building). So this paragraph also mentions the development of cultural values.

Whoever wrote this paragraph would have done so hundreds of years after the Fall. (It would have been part of a document that was preserved in Noah's Ark, along with other pre-flood literature, which was delivered to Moses in due time.) But why was it inserted precisely here, along with the creation of the Garden? Well, where else would it fit? After the fallen pair was expelled, there is only one further mention of the Garden, in Genesis, giving the location of Cain's descendants. In any case, it is where it is, presumably because the Holy Spirit told Moses to put it there.

Noah's Flood totally destroyed the surface of the earth at that time. After the Flood the surface was totally different. That is why it is impossible to know the location of Eden. It would be natural for Noah and his sons to reuse names they had known before; in this case the Tigris (Hiddekel) and Euphrates rivers (whose headwaters are not far from Ararat).

[a] But why did God place this tree in the Garden, not to mention the Tree of Life? There had to be a test; John 4:23-4. The Father is "looking for" people who will worship Him in spirit and truth. Perhaps we have a window here into why God created a race like ours–people in His image with the ability to **choose**. God is "seeking" something, which means that He does not have it, at least not automatically, or in sufficient quantity. I understand that He wants to be appreciated for who He is, He wants to be reciprocated, but to have meaning, such appreciation cannot come from robots–it has to be voluntary. So He created a kind of being with that ability, but with that He

18 And God JEHOVAH said: "It is not good for the man to be alone; I will make him a helper[a] that will correspond to him". **19** And when God JEHOVAH had formed out of the ground all the animals of the field, and all the birds of the air, He brought them to the man, to see what he would call them; and whatever name the man gave to every living creature, that would be its name. **20** And Adam[b] gave names to all the cattle, and to the fowls of the air, and to every animal of the field; but there was not found for Adam a helper that would correspond to him. **21** Then God JEHOVAH caused a deep sleep to fall upon Adam, and he fell asleep; and He took one of his ribs and closed up the place with flesh. **22** And God JEHOVAH transformed the rib which He took from Adam into a woman and brought her to Adam. **23** Then Adam said, "Now this is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh;[c] she will be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man".[d] **24** Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother, and shall be joined to his wife, and they shall become one flesh.[e] **25** And they were both naked, the man and his wife; and they were not ashamed.

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had to run the risk that such beings would choose <u>not</u> to appreciate Him! Unfortunately, most human beings make the negative choice, and that negative choice carries with it all sorts of negative consequences. From Adam to now, human beings are born with an inclination to sin, so that choosing to appreciate God is not automatic, not in the slightest, nor is it easy. Hence, no one can accuse God of 'buying votes' – He seems to have done just the opposite. If a human being, against his natural inclination, chooses to appreciate God, then He receives what He is seeking. "In spirit and in truth" must mean that it cannot be faked or coerced. Please see Matthew 23:9-10 and 13.

[a] The Hebrew word here means simply someone who helps; of course there are various ways of helping.

[b] The same Hebrew word means both ‘man’ and ‘Adam’, and the choice can be arbitrary. Up to this point I have translated 'the man', although many versions have begun with 'Adam' much earlier. God created Adam as an adult, and evidently put a language in his mind, for otherwise he would not have been able to name the animals.

[c] That was literally the truth; flesh and bone represent the physical body.

[d] The Hebrew word here means a human male and is different from the generic word ‘man’; it is also different from just ‘male’, which can also apply to animals. The feminine equivalent means a human female.

[e] This expression is not poetic language; it is a chemical reality.

The Fall

3.1 Now the serpent[a] was more cunning than every animal of the field that God JEHOVAH had made. And it said to the woman, "Did God really say, 'You shall not eat from a certain tree of the garden'?" **2** And the woman said to the serpent, "We may eat of the fruit of the trees of the garden; **3** but of the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden, God said, 'You shall not eat of it, nor touch it,[b] or you will die'". **4** Then the serpent said to the woman, "It is not certain that you will die![c] **5** It is because God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like gods,[d] knowing good and evil." **6** Then the woman, seeing that the tree was good to eat, and pleasant to the eyes, and

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[a] The serpent was not yet a snake, crawling on the ground (see verse 14 below). We have no way of knowing what the serpent looked like, but apparently it did not startle the woman, including its ability to speak. Might some animals have been able to speak before the Fall? In the beginning, when the Creator handed over the administration of this planet to Adam, everything was 'good'. But then came the Fall, and the administrator himself was no longer good. How could a fallen administrator govern a perfect creation? Since the creation existed to provide context for man, the Creator lowered the creation to the same level, based on the 'hope' of a future restoration for both man and nature (see Romans 8:19-22). We understand that Satan used the serpent. In Revelation 20:2 "the ancient serpent" is one of Satan's descriptions, and it is presumably a reference to Genesis 3:1.

[b] The woman was not present when God gave this prohibition to Adam, but obviously he transmitted the prohibition to her. Presumably he conveyed the prohibition correctly, since he had not yet fallen, and in that case the woman made an undue addition. Why would she do that?

[c] Satan lied, according to his nature, John 8:44. For human beings, not animals, the essence of death is separation, not annihilation. At physical death the body is separated from the spirit-soul, and at the resurrection they will be reunited: in the case of the saved, the body will be glorified; in the case of the lost, the Bible says nothing about the nature of the body. In spiritual death the spirit is separated from God, the "Father of spirits", Hebrews 12:9 (cf. Numbers 16:22). In order for this separation not to be eternal, it is necessary to believe into Sovereign Jesus.

[d] The Hebrew word translated 'God' is *Elohim*, which is plural. Depend-ing on the context, it can mean 'gods', 'angels' and even 'men'. I chose 'gods', but it can be 'God', as in most versions.

a tree desirable to give wisdom;[a] she took of its fruit and ate, and gave it to her husband as well, and he ate with her.[b] **7** Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they perceived that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together,[c] and made coverings for themselves.[d]

8 And they heard the voice of God JEHOVAH walking in the garden in the cool of the day; and Adam and his wife hid themselves from the presence of God JEHOVAH among the trees of the garden. **9** And God JEHOVAH called to Adam, and said to him, "Where are you?"[e] **10** And he said, "I heard your voice in the garden, and I was afraid, because I am naked, and I hid myself".

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[a] Satan attacked the woman through her soul. If I am not mistaken, in a woman the soul is stronger than the spirit, while in a man the spirit is stronger than the soul. The most important thing about a woman is not her body, it is her soul.

[b] Here we have a drastically reduced account; certainly much more happened than we have here. 1 Timothy 2:14 states that Adam was not deceived, but the woman was; but in that case Adam ate on purpose, and it was he who plunged the world into ruin, Romans 5:12. Woman was created to help man, not to order him around, but by eating the forbidden fruit she made a command-decision, usurp-ing the man's function. She presented him with a *fait accompli*, putting the man in the worst 'snooker' of all time. What to do? Let her die alone? But in that case, since God had said that it was not good for man to be alone, he would lose a second rib. Then Satan would deceive the second woman, and then he would lose a third rib, and one day he would be left without a chest! Further, God certainly did a good job when he created Eve, she would 'stop any traffic', and Adam did not want to be without her. What happened, happened, and we are left with the consequences.

[c] Why fig-leaves? Were there not bigger, better leaves available? And how did they do the sewing? We are not told.

[d] Before they did not feel shame (2:25), but now they did. The fact that they were naked did not change; what changed was the way they interpreted things. They lost their innocence, and that calamity persists to this day. There was no other human being to see them, but there was God Himself (verses 9-10).

[e] It appears that God was in the habit of walking with Adam in the garden, and naturally they would not walk in silence. It must have been on those walks that God told Adam all about creation (which Adam subsequently wrote down). In order to walk with Adam, God had to materialize, which means that the initiative was with Him. He enjoyed that fellowship.

11 And God said, "Who told you that you were naked?![a] Have you eaten of the tree of which I commanded you not to eat?" **12** Then Adam said, "The woman whom you gave to be with me, she gave me from the tree, and I ate".[b] **13** And God JEHOVAH said to the woman, "Why have you done this?" And the woman said, "The serpent deceived me, and I ate".

14 Then God JEHOVAH said to the serpent, "Because you have done this, cursed will you be more than all cattle, and more than all the animals of the field: you shall move upon your belly, and you shall eat dust all the days of your life.[c] **15** And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, namely, between thy seed and her seed;[d] he will bruise thy head, and you will bruise his heel."[e] **16** To

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[a] He had always been naked, but now it made a difference.

[b] Alas! The effort to avoid assuming one's own responsibility, one's own guilt, had begun, a perversity that lasts to this day. People will blame the circumstances, other people, whatever, rather than admit that they are responsible for their wrongdoing.

[c] This word was addressed to the animal that Satan used, which turned into a snake. Since there are many types of snakes, the animal here became one of the types. Since that animal had unusual intelligence, it must have collaborated with Satan willingly, which is why it was punished.

[d] The Hebrew Text simply has 'seed' both times, but the 'he' that follows is masculine singular. Here we have a prophecy concerning the Messiah. But how are we to understand the enmity between the serpent and the woman? Since God said "thee", the reference is to Satan. Satan did not like Eve, and after the Fall she would not have liked Satan either, but that enmity would end with her death. I understand that the reference to 'seed' is explanatory, and so I translated, "namely"; the enmity is between the 'seeds'. A snake can have offspring, and we generally do not like snakes, but the 'enmity' referred to is probably different. The Sovereign Creator, while walking on this earth in the body of Jesus, stated that angelic beings in Heaven do not procreate (Matthew 22:30, Mark 12:25, Luke 20:36) [the matter of humanoids will be dealt with in chapter six]. So then, what ‘seed’ could Satan have? In John 8:44 Jesus said that the Phari-sees were children of the devil, and 1 John 3:8-10 makes it clear that Satan has many other 'sons'. Explaining the parable of the tares, Jesus said: "the tares are the sons of the malignant one", who is "the devil", Matthew 13:38-39. There is certainly enmity between Satan's servants and God's servants, and nowadays this enmity is becoming more and more obvious.

[e] Hebrews 2:14 states that Jehovah the Son became incarnate on this earth to "abolish" the devil, and he succeeded! See John 12:31 and 16:11, Ephesians

the woman He said, "I will greatly multiply your suffering in your pregnancy; with pain you will give birth to children; and your desire will be for your husband,[a] and he will rule over you."[b] **17** And to Adam He said, "Because you have listened to the voice of your wife,[c] and have eaten of the tree from which I commanded you, saying, 'You shall not eat of it': the ground will be cursed because of you;[d] with toil you shall eat of it all the days of your life. **18** Thorns and thistles shall it bring forth to you, and you shall eat the herb of the field. **19** In the sweat of your face you shall eat your bread, until you return to the ground, for you were taken from it; since you are dust, to dust you shall return."[e]

20 And Adam called his wife's name Eve, for she became the mother of all who live.[f] **21** And God JEHOVAH made tunics of skin for Adam and his wife and clothed them.[g]

22 Then God JEHOVAH said, "Alas, the man has become like one of us, knowing good and evil; so then, lest he put forth his hand, and take also of the Tree of Life, and eat, and live forever"[h]— **23** God JEHOVAH sent him out of the garden of Eden, to till the ground from which he had been taken. **24** So He drove out the man, and He placed cherubim on the east side of the garden of Eden, and a flaming sword that moved in all directions, to guard

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1:20-21, Colossians 2:15, 1 Peter 3:22, and 1 John 4:4. That Jesus went through suffering, because of Satan, is also a fact.

[a] I am not a woman, but I have heard a woman say that it is true.

[b] Feminism rejects this directive. See 1 Corinthians 11:3, Ephesians 5:22-23, Titus 2:5 and 1 Peter 3:1.

[c] Obviously she said something when she offered the fruit to Adam. Perhaps she begged him not to let her die alone. There would have been no need to say anything, if Adam had been with her when she ate.

[d] Paul refers to this in Romans 8:19-22. Nature, poor thing, also suffered for man's sin.

[e] This saying refers to the physical body only; it does not include the soul-spirit.

[f] The Hebrew Text says 'living', meaning human beings. The Hebrew word, '*eve*', has to do with life.

[g] It follows that God is against nudism. Apparently He killed animals, so that He could clothe the couple, setting an example to be followed.

[h] Physical death had begun; and so had spiritual death. For some reason, they had not yet touched that tree.

the way to the Tree of Life.[a]

The first murder

4.1 And Adam knew[b] Eve his wife, and she conceived and bore Cain. And she said: "I have obtained a man from JEHOVAH." **2** And she gave birth again to his brother Abel. Abel became a shepherd, and Cain became a tiller of the ground. **3** And after a time it came to pass that Cain brought an offering to JEHOVAH of the fruit of the ground. **4** And Abel also brought of the firstborn of his flock as well as of their fat; and JEHOVAH accepted Abel and his offering. **5** But he did not accept Cain and his offering.[c] And Cain was furious,[d] and his countenance fell. **6** And JEHOVAH said to Cain: "Why did you become angry? And why has your countenance fallen? **7** If you do well, is it not certain that you will be accepted?[e] But if you do not do well, sin is crouched at the door; its desire is against you,[f] but you should master it."

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[a] But why did God place the Tree of Life in the garden? What purpose would it serve? God knew beforehand that man would fall. Perhaps it was to serve as a reason to expel the fallen couple from the garden. Life in the garden was too easy, and they lost that easy life. After the Fall, the tree of the knowledge of good and evil no longer had a function, but the Tree of Life did. Did this Tree represent Christ? Eating of Him would not be possible until 4,000 years later (John 6:53-58). The Flood destroyed the Garden, if it still existed, but was it there intact during the 1,650 years until the Flood? The Bible does not say. If so, protecting the Tree would have been increasingly difficult.

[b] In the Bible, the verb 'to know' is used to refer to sexual intercourse. The Text explicitly says that it was Adam who begot Cain, which disproves other theories.

[c] Although the Text says nothing about it, God must have given instruction as to the necessity of sacrifice. If Abel brought fat, it was because he killed the animal. Hebrews 11:4 affirms that Abel acted by faith. We are not told just how God did the accepting and rejecting.

[d] Why did he become so furious, to the point of murdering Abel? A great deal more must have happened than is recorded.

[e] In order for God to express Himself in this way, He must have given instruction beforehand.

[f] Sin is presented as having life and will. The fallen nature within us is Satan's natural ally. If we should "master" it, it should be possible to do so. However, due to the pressure exerted by Satan and his culture, for someone without the Holy Spirit it may not be possible.

8 Now Cain would talk with his brother Abel.[a] And it came to pass, while they were in the field, that Cain rose up against his brother Abel and killed him. **9** And JEHOVAH said to Cain: "Where is Abel your brother?" And he said, "I don't know;[b] am I my brother's keeper?" **10** And He said, "What have you done? The voice of your brother's blood cries out to me from the ground. **11** Now therefore you are cursed as to the ground, which has opened its mouth to receive your brother's blood from your hand. **12** When you till the ground, it will no longer give you its strength.[c] You will be a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth." **13** Then Cain said to JEHOVAH: "My punishment is greater than I can bear.[d] **14** Behold, you have driven me from the face of the earth this day, and I will be hid from your face; and I will be a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth: and it will happen that whoever finds me will kill me."[e] **15** But JEHOVAH said to him, "Therefore, whoever kills Cain will suffer vengeance seven-fold". And JEHOVAH put a mark on Cain, so that anyone who found him would not kill him.[f] **16** And Cain went out from the presence of JEHOVAH,[g] and dwelt in the land of Nod, on the east side of Eden.

17 And Cain knew his wife,[h] and she conceived and bore Enoch.

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[a] Cain pretended that everything was fine, so that his brother would not suspect anything.

[b] Cain lied, and lying belongs to Satan. 1 John 3:12 states that Satan got Cain.

[c] Cain was a tiller of the ground, verse 2, but he lost his job. He was condemned to be a vagabond.

[d] No regret, no remorse. Cain was 100% selfish, thinking only of himself.

[e] Wait a minute! Who was there on the earth at that time who could kill Cain? His brothers, who would not forgive the murder of their brother. (When Abel did not return, they would have gone looking for him and discovered his remains.) 5:4 says that Adam “begot sons and daughters”, and Cain and Abel were presumably grown men at the time of the murder. Adam and Eve were certainly producing children during that time, and Cain must have taken at least one grown sister with him when he left.

[f] We have no way of knowing what that signal would have been. But why did God protect Cain to such an extent? He deserved to die. We are not told why. But Cain had been deceived by Satan (1 John 3:12), just as his mother had been, and God made allowances.

[g] He went out, never to return.

[h] 5:4 says that Adam "begot sons and daughters". Obviously Cain and Seth married sisters. At the beginning there were still no inbred deficiencies; the blood was pure.

And Cain built a city and called the name of the city by the name of his son, Enoch. **18** And to Enoch was born Irad, and Irad begot Mehujael, and Mehujael begot Methushael, and Methushael begot Lamech. **19** And Lamech took to him-self two wives: the name of one was Adah, and the name of the other was Zillah. **20** And Adah bore Jabal; he was the father of those who dwell in tents and have cattle.[a] **21** And his brother's name was Jubal; he was the father of all those who play the harp and the flute. **22** And as for Zillah, she bore Tubal-Cain, a forger of all kinds of tools of brass and iron;[b] and the sister of Tubal-Cain was Naamah.[c] **23** And Lamech said to his wives, "Adah and Zillah, hear my voice; you wives of Lamech, listen to my words; for I have killed a man for wounding me, and a young man for injuring me. **24** If Cain will be avenged seven times, Lamech will be seventy-seven."[d]

25 And Adam knew his wife again; and she bore a son, and called his name Seth: "For God has granted me another seed in place of Abel; for Cain killed him." **26** And to Seth also a son was born, and he called his name Enos. It was then that they began to

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[a] Since all of Cain's descendants were destroyed by the Flood, why did God have this genealogy recorded? Well, since Cain was the first man begotten on earth, he would deserve some attention. On the other hand, it serves to show that despite Cain's crime, and his punishment, his descendants had a 'normal' life. But why single out the sons of Lamech? During the more than 500 years before Jabal, certainly others used tents, and in the very beginning Abel was already a shepherd. And there were certainly musical instruments before Jubal. I do not understand the use of the word 'father' in this context.

[b] Noah certainly had iron instruments to help in the construction of the Ark, but men had learned to make iron much earlier.

[c] Why mention the sister? She must have stood out in some way.

[d] If it were possible, Lamech was even more selfish than Cain! The way in which Lamech expressed himself leads us to understand that Cain was still alive, which would be natural if he lived as long as his brother, Seth. In the genealogy of Seth there were ten men, including Seth and Shem, until the Flood. In Cain's genealogy we have seven names, including Cain and Jabal. Since this one does not have years, we do not know if it is complete until the Flood. However, it would make little sense to say that Jabal was the 'father' of something if there were no generations after him. Of course, after the Flood there were no more descendants of Cain.

call on the name of JEHOVAH.[a]

Seth's genealogy

5.1 This is the book of the generations of Adam. On the day that God created the man, He made him in the likeness of God. **2** He created them male and female and blessed them, and called their name, Man, on the day that they were created. **3** And Adam lived a hundred and thirty years, and begot a son in his own likeness, after his image,[b] and called his name Seth. **4** And the days of Adam, after he begot Seth, were eight hundred years;[c] and he begot sons and daughters. **5** And all the days that Adam lived were nine hundred and thirty years, and he died.[d]

6 And Seth lived a hundred and five years, and begot Enosh. **7** And after he begot Enosh, Seth lived eight hundred and seven years; and he begot sons and daughters. **8** And all the days of Seth were nine hundred and twelve years, and he died.

9 And Enosh lived ninety years, and begot Cainan. **10** And after he begot Cainan, Enosh lived eight hundred and fifteen years; and he begot sons and daughters. **11** And all the days of Enos were nine hundred and five years, and he died.

12 And Cainan lived seventy years, and begot Mahalaleel. **13** And after he begot Mahalaleel, Cainan lived eight hundred and forty years; and he begot sons and daughters. **14** And all the days of Cainan were nine hundred and ten years, and he died.

15 And Mahalaleel lived sixty-five years, and begot Jared. **16** And after he begot Jared, Mahalaleel lived eight hundred and thirty years; and he begot sons and daughters. **17** And all the days

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[a] Throughout the time of the Old Testament the Name was pronounced. Even Cyrus, king of Persia, pronounced it (Ezra 1:2). Why is it that no one invoked it before? To 'invoke' would be to ask for God's protection or help, thus acknowledging one's own dependence on Him.

[b] A man begets, a woman bears. It is the man who transmits life. Seth was born after Cain murdered Abel (4:25), and they were grown men when that happened, so there was quite an interval between the births of Abel and Seth. Some daughters were certainly born in that interim.

[c] Notice that Adam's age is calculated based on Seth, not the older brothers. Presumably Abel had no son.

[d] Since Adam was created as an adult, with the ability to procreate, that might be worth another seventy years, giving a total of a thousand.

of Mahalaleel were eight hundred and ninety-five years, and he died.

18 And Jared lived a hundred and sixty-two years, and begot Enoch. **19** And after he begot Enoch, Jared lived eight hundred years; and he begot sons and daughters. **20** And all the days of Jared were nine hundred and sixty-two years, and he died.

21 And Enoch lived sixty-five years, and begot Methuselah. **22** And after he begot Methuselah, Enoch walked with God three hundred years, and begot sons and daughters. **23** And all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years. **24** And Enoch walked with God; then he was no more, because God took him.[a]

25 And Methuselah lived a hundred and eighty-seven years, and begot Lamech. **26** And after he begot Lamech, Methuselah lived seven hundred and eighty-two years; and he begot sons and daughters. **27** And all the days of Methu-selah were nine hundred and sixty-nine years, and he died.[b]

28 And Lamech lived a hundred and eighty-two years, and begot a son. **29** And he called his name Noah, saying, "This one will comfort us about our work and the toil of our hands,[c] because of the ground that JEHOVAH has cursed." **30** And after he begot Noah, Lamech lived five hundred and ninety-five years; and he begot sons and daughters. **31** And all the days of Lamech were seven hundred and seventy and seven years, and he died.

32 And Noah was five hundred years old; and Noah begot Shem,[d] Ham, and Japheth.

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[a] Hebrews 9:27 states that we are destined to die once, followed by the judgment. That is, to die physically. So then, Enoch 'is owing' this death, as is Elijah. Could they be the two witnesses (Revelation 11:3)?

[b] Methuselah died in the same year that the Flood came. His son, Lamech, died five years before the Flood.

[c] Since the Flood destroyed all the antediluvian "works", it appears that Lamech was not a prophet.

[d] According to 11:10, Shem was 98 years old when the Flood came; Noah was 502 when he begot him. Was Japheth two years older than Shem? The Text does not say that he begot sons and daughters, like it does for the others. If he did, they died in the flood. But it is strange that he did not beget until he was 500. If he did have other children, it would have been hard on him and his wife to have lost them all in the flood.

The Flood

6:1 Now it came to pass, when men began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born to them, **2** that the sons of God[a] saw that the daughters of men were beautiful, and they took to themselves wives of all whom they chose. **3** Then JEHOVAH said: "My Spirit will not contend with man forever, because of his sinning;[b] he is flesh.[c] His days will be a hundred and twenty years."[d]

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[a] The phrase, "the sons of God", translates the Hebrew phrase, *bene-haelohim*, which in the other places where it occurs – Job 1:6, 2:1, and 38:7 – clearly refers to angelic beings, and apparently high-ranking ones. The inspired commentary in the New Testament, Jude 6-7 and 2 Peter 2:4-7, makes it clear that they were indeed angelic beings, in this case ones who had rebelled against God. Jude makes it clear that the phrase in Genesis 6:2 is no exception. "And the angels who did not keep their proper domain but deserted their own dwelling [apparently they could not return] He has kept bound in everlasting chains under darkness for the judgment of the great day. So also Sodom and Gomorrah and the surrounding towns—who gave themselves up to fornication and went after a different kind of flesh [Greek ετερος], in a manner similar to those angels—stand as an example, undergoing a punishment of eternal fire" (Jude 6-7) [the eternal Lake contains fire and brimstone].

The author, inspired by God, affirms that the people of Sodom did what certain angelic beings did; they wanted sex with a different kind of flesh. Remember that the men of Sodom, old and young, from every neighborhood, wanted to rape the angels who were with Lot (Genesis 19:4-5). Whatever kind of flesh an angel has (when he materializes), it is not human flesh; it is precisely "a different kind of flesh" [Greek ετερος]. The parallel text in 2 Peter 2:4-6 links the crime of those angels to the Flood. (In Matthew 22:30 [Mark 12:25, Luke 20:35-36] the Lord did not say that angels are sexless. Evidently baby angels are not born [whether good or bad], but if angels are of only one gender, they cannot reproduce. In the Bible, whenever an angel materializes, he does so in the form of a man, not a woman.) 1 Corinthians 11:10 is serious.

[b] This saying of the Creator has received a variety of interpretations. I always ask for the enlightenment of the Holy Spirit when translating. I put what I understood.

[c] The Creator recognizes the limitations imposed by fallen flesh.

[d] After the Flood, the age of men gradually decreased, but Moses still lived 120 years, about 500 years later. However, I understand that the intended meaning here is different: God was predicting the Flood, which would destroy everyone except the eight, 120 years from then.

4 In those days there were *Nephilim* on the earth, and also afterward,[a] when the sons of God went in to the daughters of men, and they bore them sons; these were the mighty men of old, men of renown. **5** And JEHOVAH saw that the wickedness of man had multiplied upon the earth, and that every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually.[b] **6** Then JEHOVAH lamented that He had made man on the earth, and it grieved Him in His

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[a] "And also afterward" refers to what happened after the Flood. Obviously, after the Flood there was no longer a 'daughter of Cain', so those three words close the issue against the thesis of the 'sons of Shem'. From Deuteronomy 2:10-12 and 20-21 we can understand that already in the time of Abraham, and even before, other mixed races had emerged, with impressive size. Deuteronomy 3:11 expressly says that Og, king of Bashan, was the last of his race, the *Rephaim*, who were similar to the *Anakim*; and it also says that his bed was about 4.5 meters long, which allows us to imagine that Og himself was about 4 meters tall. Thirty-eight years earlier the spies, wanting to defame the land, spoke of a number of giants, sons of Anak, who are specifically called *Nephilim* (Numbers 13:33). Four hundred years later, David still had to face Goliath, and others of his race**,** the *Raphaim* (1 Chronicles 20:4-8), except that his height was only three meters, not four (1 Samuel 17:4).

The severity used by God in the case of Sodom and Gomorrah indicates that the level of wickedness there was unusual. Although the text does not directly speak of giants in Sodom, we can deduce that there were, because Deuteronomy 2:10-12 says that Moab, who occupied what was left of the area controlled by Sodom and Gomorrah (which was not under the Dead Sea), took the area from the *Emim* (who were the same size as the *Anakim*)– it appears that there were several mixed races of that type.

[b] This description indicates that something strange had happened. An ordinary human being is certainly capable of doing bad things and perpetrating perverse deeds, but not 100% of the time, unless they are fully surrendered to Satan. But the hybrid offspring, on the other hand, would be totally bad. Just think about it for a moment. According to Jude 18-19, "in the last time" men will be "soulish" [characterized by soul] (Greek ψυχικοι), "not having a spirit". This is what the Text says. Your Bible probably says "not having the Spirit", but in the Text there is no definite article. Further, the description of such people that occupies Jude 8-16 is beyond scathing – it is a totally wicked race; it reminds us of Genesis 6:5 and 2 Timothy 3:1-5. The question is exactly this: would a demon's offspring have a spirit? We know from the Sacred Text that the human spirit is transmitted by the male sperm, so that 'hybrid' race

heart. **7** And JEHOVAH said: "I will blot out the man whom I have created from the face of the earth: both man and animal, and creeping thing and even birds of the air; because I lament having made them".

8 But Noah found favor in Jehovah's eyes.[a] **9** These are the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous and upright man among his contemporaries. Noah walked with God. **10** And Noah begot three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth. **11** Now the earth was corrupt before God; and the earth was filled with violence. **12** And God looked at the earth, and indeed, it was corrupt; for all the people had corrupted their way upon the earth.

13 Then God said to Noah, "The end of every living being has come before me, because the earth is full of violence through them; yes indeed, I will destroy them with the earth. **14** Make for yourself an ark of gopher wood;[b] you shall make compartments in

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had lost the human spirit, and presumably the 'image of God' as well. Consider the following:

In all genealogies it is always the man who begets; a woman bears. It seems to me that Hebrews 7:9-10 closes the issue. "—in a word, even Levi, who receives tithes, paid the tithe through Abraham, because he was still in the reproductive system of his forefather when Melchizedek met him". When Abraham paid the tithe to Melchizedek, not even Isaac had been begotten, much less Jacob and Levi. However, the inspired author states that the person of Levi was in Abraham's reproductive system. So it is the seed of man that transmits life, the human spirit, and the image of the Creator. That is why Romans 5:12-21 teaches that Adam's sin passed on to all his descendants, and death as well. When Eve sinned, she alone sinned; when Adam sinned, we all did.

[a] Dear me; have you ever thought about the results of that ‘favor’? Noah had to spend his entire time, during perhaps a hundred years, building an ark to protect his family from something that did not exist! Before the Flood, during 1,600 years, it had never rained; without rain there could be no flood. He was the laughingstock of the surrounding community for all those years. And after the Flood his life was certainly dreary, compared to what he had known before. Would you like to receive a ‘favor’ like that? However, Noah lived for 350 years after the Flood, and things certainly got a lot better before he died.

[b] 'Gopher' is a transliteration of the Hebrew word, and we are not sure about its meaning. However, a piece of a square beam, about five thousand years old (carbon 14), found near Ararat, is of a type of oak.

the ark,[a] and cover it inside and outside with pitch. **15** And this is how you must make it: the length of the ark three hundred cubits, and its width fifty cubits, and its height thirty cubits.[b] **16** You must make a window in the ark a cubit high, covered on the top;[c] and you must set the door of the ark in its side; you must make it with stories, lower, second, and third. **17** I myself really am bringing a flood of waters upon the earth, to destroy all flesh in which there is the breath of life under heaven. Everything on the earth will perish.[d]

18 But with you I will establish my covenant;[e] and you will enter into the ark, you and your sons, your wife, and your sons' wives with you. **19** And of all that lives, of all flesh, two of each kind, you will take into the ark, to preserve them alive with you: they shall be male and female. **20** Of the birds after their kind, of the animals

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[a] There had to be rooms, or pens so that each type of animal could have its own 'space'. This would keep them from roaming around and causing fights; it would also keep them from going after the food. But that meant that the people had to take food and water to the animals, which would give them something to do with all their time.

[b] The dimensions of the ark could be used for a modern ship. However, as the purpose of the ark was only to float, not to navigate, the structure may have been a rectangle, with a flat bottom, which would have given the maximum space for those dimensions (and would be easier to build). Incidentally, the NT refers to Noah's ark, as well as the ark of the covenant, with the Greek word κιβωτος = box, chest (Matthew 24:38; Hebrews 9:4). [The Hebrew word translated 'ark' also means a box or chest.] Both can be square, but they are more commonly rectangular. In fact, we know that the ark of the covenant was indeed a rectangular box. Since the width was much greater than the height, the ark was very stable.

[c] Naturally the ark needed a roof, probably of wood covered with pitch. The 'window' separated the roof from the walls, and ran around the circumference of the entire ark. Since there were no ordinary windows in the 'walls', the larger window was needed to provide air and light inside the ark.

[d] Obviously, Jehovah was not talking about a local flood. He spoke of the destruction of the surface of the whole earth. The destruction did not include the fish, since they were at home in the water. It was not necessary to have them in the Ark.

[e] Why did God not just destroy everything and start all over again? Why did He need a 'covenant' with Noah? I suppose that the answer harks back to 3:15; the Redeemer had to be a descendant of Adam and Eve. Noah and Shem carried Adam's genes beyond the Flood.

after their kind, and of everything that creeps on the ground according to its kind: two of each will come to you,[a] to keep them alive. **21** And you, take for yourself of all food that is eaten, and store it up for yourself, that it may be for food, for you and for them."[b] **22** Then Noah did according to all that God commanded him; so he did.

7.1 Then JEHOVAH said to Noah: "Come into[c] the ark, you and all your household, because I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation. **2** Of every clean animal you shall take with you seven pairs, male and female; but of animals that are not clean one pair, male and female; **3** also of the birds of the air seven pairs, male and female, to preserve the seed alive on the face of all the earth. **4** For after seven more days[d] I will cause it to rain on the earth forty days and forty nights, and I will blot out every living thing which I have made from off the face of the earth." **5** And Noah did according to all that JEHOVAH had commanded him.

6 Noah was six hundred years old when the flood of waters came upon the earth. **7** And Noah went into the ark, and with him his sons, his wife, and his sons' wives, because of the waters of the flood. **8** And male and female of the clean animals, and of the unclean animals, and of the birds, and of those that creep on the ground, went into the ark with Noah, **9** two by two, as God had commanded Noah.

10 And it came to pass that after the seven days the waters of

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[a] God brought all the animals to be saved to the ark. It would have been impossible for Noah to go after so many.

[b] Remember that they were all herbivores. God must have given Noah a hint as to how much he should store. Only God knew that they would stay a year in the ark. He probably also brought seeds of the fruits, vegetables, and grains that they liked best, so that they could plant them when they left the ark. The animals would be as if in hibernation, eating relatively little, and producing little manure. As for the larger animals, God may have brought juveniles.

[c] The Hebrew word here can mean, 'go in', 'come in' or even 'take in'. For God to say, "Come in", means that He is there inside and you will be with Him in that place. There are times when God takes us into difficult situations, but He is there with us.

[d] God gave Noah advance warning. To take in and settle all those animals would take a little time, as also to get and store all the food.

the flood came upon the earth. **11** In the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month,[a] on that same day all the fountains of the great deep[b] were broken up, and the windows of the heaven were opened.[c] **12** And there was rain on the earth forty days and forty nights. **13** That same day Noah, and Shem, Ham, and Japheth, the sons of Noah, went into the ark, and Noah's wife, and the three wives of his sons with them: **14** they, and every animal after its kind, and all cattle after their kind, and every creature that creeps upon the ground after its kind, and every bird according to its kind, birds of every kind of wing.[d] **15** Yes, they went into the ark with Noah two by two, of all flesh in which was the breath of life. **16** Male and female of all flesh went in, as God had commanded him; and JEHOVAH shut him in.[e]

17 The flood lasted forty days upon the earth, and the waters increased and lifted up the ark, and it was lifted up above the earth. **18** The waters prevailed, and increased exceedingly upon the earth; and the ark floated upon the waters. **19** And the waters prevailed exceedingly upon the earth; and all the high hills that were under the whole heaven were covered.[f] **20** The waters

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[a] Why did God make a point of recording the exact day on which the Flood began? Maybe He considers chronology to be important. But it also reinforces the historicity of the account. Only an eyewitness could know that information.

[b] This deep is not the "bottomless pit" of Revelation 9:1-2. It refers to water reservoirs within the earth. If they were ‘broken up’, they were under pressure.

[c] Why 'windows', plural? Obviously, God did not undo the dome all at once, or all the water would have fallen in a short time, not during 40 days. He undid the dome little by little, here and there, creating 'windows' through which the water fell. But due to the altitude the water was probably frozen, but God did what was necessary for it to fall. At the end of the 40 days the whole dome had been undone and all the water above it had fallen.

[d] That is what the Text says: "every kind of wing". Certainly there are different types of wings, but why did God make a point of mentioning them?

[e] God closed the door (there was only one). With that, no one else could enter, and those who were inside could not leave.

[f] Again, the language here refers to a global, not local, flood. Modern technology estimates that if all the water in the world’s oceans and seas

prevailed fifteen cubits upwards, and the hills were covered. **21** And all flesh that moved upon the earth perished: the birds, the cattle, the wild animals, every creature that creeps upon the ground, and all mankind. **22** Everything that had the breath of the spirit of life[a] in its nostrils, everything that was on the dry land, died. **23** Every living thing that was on the face of the earth was destroyed: both man and animal, creeper and bird of the air; they

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were added together, it would be enough to cover the entire planet with a depth of 3.7 km of water, if the entire surface were solid like a marble. In fact, the presence of a lot of water has always been a characteristic of this earth, since creation. Genesis 1:2 speaks of the “face of the deep” and the “face of the waters”. In 1:6-7 God placed a dome (solid and translucent) in the sky and placed half of this water above it. Even so, the half that remained below was so much that God made the dry ground “appear” (1:9), still leaving “seas” (1:10). Verse 11 here in chapter 6 says that “all the fountains of the great deep were broken up”, referring to reservoirs of water beneath the earth’s crust. And with the destruction of the dome, the water up there returned to the surface. In short, there was a LOT of water! But since there were seas before the flood, although we have no way of knowing how much water they contained, I think it is reasonable to imagine that the water above the surface was at least two km deep.

I believe that before the Flood, the high mountain ranges that we have in the world today did not exist. Since the water covered the highest peaks, they could scarcely be more than 3 km high. When God separated the continents by fissure in the time of Peleg, He must have created the current mountain ranges. In order to make dry land appear again, God dug the basins of the oceans. There are trenches deeper than the height of our highest peak, Mount Everest. He used the material that He dug up to form the continents and the mountains. The Pacific Ocean is said to have an average depth of around 4 km, and it occupies around half of the surface of the globe!

[a] "The spirit of life", that is what the Text says. Life is mysterious, much like an electric current. We cannot see it, but we can feel it and see the effects it produces. Let us think of a body, whether human or of an animal, that is dying. One moment it is alive, the next moment it is dead. The body is the same, but something is gone. It was the spirit of life. Germs have life, plants have life, insects have life, fish have life, birds have life, animals have life, we have life; but it seems that they are different types of life. But how so? The bodies are different, with different abilities, but would not the spirit of life be the same? The Text includes all kinds of beings with nostrils. In passing, it seems to me that only human beings and mammals have a soul, and only human beings have a spirit (of the types mentioned).

were blotted out from the earth;[a] and only Noah remained, and those who were with him in the ark. **24** And the waters prevailed upon the earth a hundred and fifty days.

8.1 Then God remembered Noah, and every living thing, and all the cattle that were with him in the ark; and God caused a wind to pass over the earth, and the waters subsided.[b] **2** The fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven had been stopped also, and the rain of heaven had been restrained. **3** And the waters were continually flowing from off the earth; and at the end of a hundred and fifty days the waters had diminished. **4** And in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, the ark alighted on the mountains of Ararat.[c] **5** And the waters continued to recede until the tenth month;[d] in the tenth month, on the first *day* of the month, the tops of the mountains appeared.[e]

6 And it came to pass that at the end of forty days Noah opened the window[f] of the ark which he had made. **7** And he sent out a

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[a] It is repeated no less than four times that all life on earth was wiped out. Why so much emphasis on that fact? God knew that later men would deny the existence of the Flood, inventing various theories. Whoever rejects any clear statement of the Sacred Text will have to answer for it. See 2 Peter 3:3-7.

[b] Certainly there were monster tsunamis that triturated the surface of the earth. That triturated material was turned into sediment, which was deposited. The Grand Canyon in the United States reveals more than two thousand vertical meters of distinct layers of sedimentary rock. There are layers of sedimentary rock all around the world. It is the sedimentary rock that contains all the fossils, so the fossils were produced by Noah's Flood.

[c] Currently the Ararat range has peaks over four thousand meters high (and the Ark is there). Moses wrote this book many centuries after the Flood, as well as after the separation of the continents in the time of Peleg. When the Ark landed, it would hardly have been much more than two km above sea level. God raised the mountain ranges later.

[d] The waters needed to have somewhere to go. I suppose that God was excavating the basins of the oceans to receive the waters.

[e] While Noah certainly made a written record of all that happened, which writings came into Moses' hands, the account here contains information that only God could have known. This information Moses received by inspiration, unless God had given it to Noah first.

[f] How did that happen? I imagine that the quarters for the family would be on the top story, and probably at one end. Noah may have covered the window

raven, which went to and fro[a] until the waters were dried up from the earth. **8** He also sent out a dove, to see if the waters had receded from the face of the ground. **9** But the dove found no rest for the sole of its foot and returned unto him into the ark; for the waters were upon the face of all the earth. And he stretched out his hand and took it and brought it to himself into the ark. **10** And he waited yet another seven days and sent the dove out of the ark again. **11** And the dove returned to him in the evening, and indeed, a freshly plucked olive leaf was in its beak. Thus Noah knew that the waters had receded from the earth. **12** Then he waited another seven days and sent the dove out, but it did not return to him anymore.

13 And it came to pass in the year six hundred and one, in the first month, on the first day of the month, that the waters were dried up from off the earth. Then Noah removed the covering[b] of the ark and looked, and indeed the face of the ground was dry. **14** And in the second month, on the twenty-seventh day of the month,[c] the land was dry. **15** Then God spoke to Noah[d], saying, **16** "Go out of the ark, you, and your wife, and your sons, and your sons' wives with you. **17** Bring out with you every living creature that is with you, of all flesh: of birds, of cattle and of every creature that creeps upon the ground; and let them abound on the earth, and be fruitful, and multiply upon the earth." **18** Then Noah went out, and with him his sons, and his wife, and his sons' wives. **19** Every animal, every creeping thing, and every bird, everything that moves on the earth, according to their families, went out of the ark.[e]

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around their quarters to keep water from splashing in. He would have a ladder, if it was necessary.

[a] It may have even rested on top of the ark, but it never returned to Noah.

[b] Presumably his covering of the window around his quarters; it could not have been the roof.

[c] That would be May 27th.

[d] Since it was God who closed the door, it must have been He who opened the door, allowing them to leave.

[e] By then there would be enough vegetation for all of them to eat. Presumably God made sure that there would be plenty in the vicinity of the ark. If there was an olive sapling, there probably were saplings of other fruit trees as well.

20 Then Noah built an altar to JEHOVAH, and took of every clean animal and of every clean bird, and offered burnt offerings on the altar.[a] **21** And JEHOVAH smelled the soothing aroma, and JEHOVAH said in his heart:[b] "I will never again curse the ground for man's sake, because the imagination of man's heart is evil from his youth; and I will never again destroy every living thing, as I have done.[c] **22** As long as the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, and day and night shall not cease."[d]

If there was still food in the ark that the people could eat, they had access to it.

[a] Surely God had given instruction regarding the necessity of animal sacrifice – that is why seven pairs of the clean animals were taken into the ark.

[b] Obviously God gave this information to Noah, or to somebody.

[c] That is to say, in a similar fashion. After the Millenium, the planet with its atmosphere will be completely destroyed (2 Peter 3:7, Revelation 21:1).

[d] Before the Flood the world was like a tremendous greenhouse. The water-covered dome distributed the heat more or less evenly over the entire globe; so there was no winter and summer. The world revolved around its axis, producing the days, but it did not oscillate; it began to oscillate after, or during, the Flood, producing the seasons. There is a considerable reserve of petroleum in the Arctic, and petroleum is a fossil fuel; it was made of vegetation, a lot of vegetation, vegetation that no longer exists in the Arctic, and not even nearby. In Siberia there is a deposit of fossilized tree trunks, trees that no longer exist in the region, nor nearby. Also in Siberia, frozen mastodons have been found, standing up (the dogs were able to eat the meat), with plants in their mouths that are now to be found only a thousand kilometers to the south. How was it possible to freeze a mastodon standing up, eating, without it having time to swallow? I wasn't there, but I deduce the following. At some point during the 40 days, God turned the globe, that is, the equator, to the north the 23º to the Tropic of Cancer, placing the sun above the Tropic of Capricorn, giving the Antarctic its summer and the Arctic its winter. Depending on the speed with which this was done, it would have generated gigantic tsunamis. (There is a place in the Arctic that has already registered minus 70 degrees Celsius. At minus 50 degrees centigrade, spit turns to ice before reaching the ground.) Then, after placing the sun above Capricorn, God undid the dome above the mastodons and a mass of intense cold descended and froze the animals – if you breathe at minus 50 in a normal way, it freezes the lungs. The water, falling in the form of snow or hail, would bury them without delay.

But how could there be petroleum under the Arctic and frozen mastodons on the surface not very far away? I suppose that God sovereignly did things differently at different places on the globe. Why are there coal

A new world, with new rules

9:1 Then God blessed Noah and his sons, and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth. **2** And the fear of you, and the dread of you, shall come upon every animal of the earth, and upon every bird of the air. Everything that moves on the earth, and all the fish of the sea, is given into your hands. **3** Everything that moves and lives shall be for your food; I have given you all things, even as the green herb.[a] 4 But you shall not eat flesh with its life, *that is,* with its blood.[b] **5** I will surely require the blood of your lives; from the hand of every animal, I will require it, as well as from the hand of man. From the hand of every man's brother, I will require the life of man. **6** Whoever sheds man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed; for God made the man in His image.[c] **7** As for you, be fruitful and multiply; populate the earth abundantly, and multiply in it."

8 Then God spoke to Noah and his sons with him, saying: **9** "Take heed, I, myself, am establishing my covenant with you, and with your descendants after you, **10** and with every living creature that is with you: of birds and of cattle and of every animal of the earth with you: all that came out of the ark, every animal on earth.[d]

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deposits in some places, and oil deposits in others? Why is there a Grand Canyon (and a similar one in Mexico) only in Arizona, with its over two vertical km of layers of sedimentary rock, but nowhere else in the world—there are vertical layers of sedimentary rock all over the world, but nowhere near that deep. Just what God did with the mountains is a mystery. And He put distinct species of animals and fowl in different places, also plants. Since none of that could have happened by chance, there must be a sovereign CAUSE. 2 Peter 3:3-7.

[a] Before the Flood they could only eat vegetables, but now God adds meat.

[b] Really, it is the circulation of the blood that makes it possible for the body to live and function. Note that God prohibited the ingestion of blood, and that prohibition has never been lifted. Any animal or bird slaughtered for food should be bled.

[c] God here established the maximum penalty for murder, and that penalty has never been revoked. In the Law of Moses there was no mercy for the murderer (Numbers 35:32). The reason given is that the man is the bearer of the image of God.

[d] The animals and birds can certainly see the rainbow, but presumably do not know what it represents.

11 Yes, I establish my covenant with you: All flesh will never again be destroyed by the waters of the flood; there will be no more flood to destroy the earth." **12** And God said, "This is the sign of the covenant that I am making between me and you, and every living creature that is with you, for everlasting generations.[a] **13** I have set my rainbow in the clouds,[b] and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth. **14** And it shall come to pass, when I bring clouds upon the earth, and the rainbow shall appear in the clouds, **15** then I will remember my covenant between me and you, and every living creature of all flesh; and the waters shall never again become a flood, to destroy all flesh.[c] **16** The rainbow will be in the clouds, and I will see it, to remind me[d] of the everlasting covenant between God and every living creature of all flesh that is on the earth." **17** And God said to Noah, "This [the rainbow] is the sign of the covenant that I have established between me and all the flesh that is on the earth."

18 The sons of Noah who came out of the ark were Shem, Ham, and Japheth; and Ham is the father of Canaan. **19** These three were the sons of Noah; and the whole earth was populated from them.[e] **20** And Noah began to be a farmer, and planted a vineyard. **21** And he drank of the wine and got drunk;[f]

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[a] In other words, until the end of this world.

[b] Since there was no rain before the Flood, there were no rainbows either. The rainbow was a new thing. In recent times Satan's servants have usurped the rainbow, making it represent something else.

[c] Next time it will be by fire.

[d] In order to communicate with us, God must use our language and explain things in a way that we can understand. In order to explain something to a child, you must lower the explanation down to the child's level. However, I find it curious that God said it would remind Him! For us, a rainbow is beautiful, and is a promise, although local floods can still do a lot of damage.

[e] This means that Noah did not beget any more sons after the Flood. He may have had daughters, but the refrain, "and he begot sons and daughters" that occurs from Adam through Lamech, Noah's father, is not repeated for Noah (but it is resumed for Shem through Nahor).

[f] Noah is to be pitied. His world was destroyed, and compared to the old, the new world he saw was dull. There was no one to talk to except his family; there was nothing to do except plant, eat, drink, and sleep. Compared to the old life, the new one was dreary. No wonder he got drunk; it would have

and he became uncovered[a] in his tent. **22** And Ham, the father of Canaan, saw[b] his father's nakedness, and told both his brothers outside. **23** Then Shem and Japheth took a garment and put it on both of their shoulders, and went backwards and covered their father's nakedness; their faces were turned away and they did not notice their father's nakedness. **24** And Noah awoke from his wine and knew what his youngest son had done to him. **25** And he said, "Cursed be Canaan;[c] he shall be a slave of slaves[d] to his brothers". **26** And he said: "Blessed be JEHOVAH, the God of Shem;[e] and let Canaan be his slave. **27** May God enlarge Japheth, and he shall dwell in the tents of Shem; and let Canaan be his slave." **28** And after the flood Noah lived three hundred and fifty years. **29** And all the days of Noah were nine hundred and fifty years, and he died.

10:1 These are the generations of Noah's sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth; sons were born to them after the flood. **2** The sons of Japheth: Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech and Tyras. **3** And the sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz, Riphath and Togarmah. **4** And the sons of Javan: Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim and Dodanim. **5** From these came the coastland ethnic groups who were separated in

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been a way to forget reality for a few hours. God chose Noah to 'save' the Plan of salvation, which Satan had almost aborted with the *Nephilim*.

[a] He was naked.

[b] 'To see the nakedness' is a euphemism used in the OT for sexual intercourse; Ham raped his father. That is why Noah reacted so violently. Merely looking would not have deserved such a curse. Someone who is dead drunk will not notice someone looking through the doorway, but he will feel a physical invasion—he may have opened his eyes to see who it was, so he knew.

[c] Wait a minute, it was Ham who sinned, not Canaan. God had already blessed Ham (9:1), and Noah had no authority to annul that blessing. In the Decalogue God Himself visits the sin of the fathers on the children up to the third or fourth generation (Exodus 20:5).

[d] Being a slave of slaves would be as low as one can get.

[e] Hebrews 7:7 says, "Now without dispute the lesser is blessed by the greater". So Noah was not blessing Jehovah. I understand that Shem was blessed because Jehovah was his God, and Noah was 'blessing' that fact. That Jehovah is stated to be Shem's God indicates that His Plan would be executed through Shem and his descendants. That Japheth was to dwell in Shem's tent indicates that Shem was the more prominent.

their lands, each according to his language,[a] according to his families within his ethnic group. **6** The sons of Ham: Cush, Mizraim, Put and Canaan. **7** And the sons of Cush: Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Raamah and Sabteca. And the sons of Raamah: Sheba and Dedan. **8** And Cush begot Nimrod also; he began to be mighty in the earth.

9 He was a mighty hunter before JEHOVAH;[b] hence the saying: 'Like Nimrod, the mighty hunter before JEHOVAH'. **10** And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, Accad, and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.[c] **11** Out of that land Asshur went out, and built Nineveh, Rehoboth-ir, Calah **12** and Resen, between Nineveh and Calah (this was the principal city). **13** And Mitzraim fathered the Ludites, the Anamites, the Lehabites, the Naphtuhites, **14** the Pathrusites, the Casluhites[d] (from whom came the Philistines) and the Caphtorites. **15** And Canaan begot Sidon his firstborn, and Heth; **16** and the Jebusite, the Amorite, the Girgashite, **17** the Hivite, the Arkite, the Sinite, **18** the Arvadite, the Zemarite, and the Hamathite (later the families of the Canaanites were undone).[e] **19** And the border of the Canaanites was from Sidon, going toward Gerar, unto Gaza; going toward Sodom and Gomorrah, Adma and Zeboiim, unto Lasha. **20** Those were the sons of Ham according to their families, according to their languages, in their lands, within their ethnic groups.

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[a] All of them were alive when God multiplied the languages in Peleg's time, which caused the scattering of the families.

[b] I confess that I do not understand this statement. The man could really have been a great hunter, but why "before Jehovah"? Well, in Matthew 10:29 Sovereign Jesus said that not even a sparrow can fall without the Father. So then, what Nimrod was doing was not without the Father either.

[c] Nimrod was a grandson of Ham and may have been born around 50 years after the Flood. Being a dominant sort of person, some of his brothers may have gone with him to Shinar. I imagine that the multiplication of the languages happened between 150 and 200 years after the Flood (11:1-9).

[d] All of those names could be translated as proper names, but they all have the suffix meaning 'plural', and they have the definite article, which the proper names do not have.

[e] The semantic area of the verb here covers several senses, but I understand that the central sense has to do with destruction. I translated it as a prophecy of the Israelites' conquest of the land of Canaan with Joshua.

21 Now to Shem, the older brother of Japheth,[a] to him was born the father[b] of all the sons of Eber.[c] **22** The sons of Shem: Elam, Asshur, Arphaxad, Lud and Aram. **23** And the sons of Aram: Uz,[d] Hul, Gether and Mash. **24** And Arphaxad begot Shelah; and Shelah begot Eber. **25** And to Eber were born two sons: the name of the one was Peleg, because in his days the land was divided,[e] and his brother's name was Joktan. **26** And Joktan begot Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Jerah, **27** Hadoram, Uzal, Diklah, **28** Obal, Abimael, Sheba, **29** Ophir, Havilah and Jobab; all these were the sons of Joktan. **30** And his dwelling was from Mesha, going toward Sephar, the mountain of the east. **31** Those were the sons of Shem according to their families, according to their languages, in their lands, within their ethnic groups.[f] **32** Those were the families of the sons of Noah according to their generations, within their ethnic groups; and from these the ethnic nations of the earth were divided after the Flood.[g]

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[a] The grammar of the Hebrew text here is ambiguous as to which of the brothers was the older; it could even be understood as saying that Eber had a brother named Japheth, which is unlikely. I understand from the larger context that Shem was the oldest (and the translation of the Jewish Publication Society has Shem as the oldest). In any case, Shem was the more prominent of the two.

[b] That "father" was Arphaxad.

[c] I understand that verse 21 serves as an introduction to Shem's genealogy. Shem's genealogy was more important than the others, because the Savior came through Shem. But why was Eber so emphasized? Perhaps because the word 'Hebrew' is based on it, which became the patronymic for the Israelites.

[d] It is possible that Job was a descendant of Uz, Job 1:1.

[e] That is, by fissure, creating the continents. Perhaps it was a little after the multiplication of languages. When God changed the languages, He must have changed the cultures as well, and perhaps He created the different races (different colors) as well. Presumably, the separation of the continents happened after the main migrations, and with that each continent would have its own ethnic groups.

[f] Each of the three genealogies refers to their families, languages, lands and ethnic groups. The division of the earth by languages and continents (next chapter) happened in the middle of the genealogies, but this record was written centuries later.

[g] The Text emphasizes that they alone survived the Flood.

The earth is divided, by languages and continents

11:1 Now the whole earth had one language[a] and the same objectives. **2** And it came to pass, as they traveled from the east, that they found a plain in the land of Shinar;[b] and they dwelt there. **3** And each one said to his neighbor, "Come on, let us make bricks, and burn them thoroughly". They had brick for stone, and pitch for mortar. **4** And they said, "Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower, whose top is like the heavens,[c] and let us make ourselves a name, that we may not be scattered over the face of the whole earth". **5** Then JEHOVAH came down to see the city and the tower that Adam's sons[d] were building. **6** And JEHOVAH said: "Indeed, the people are one and they all have one language, and this is what

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[a] "The whole earth had one language"; that language was presumably a type of Hebrew. Jude 14 says, "Now even Enoch, the seventh from Adam, prophesied about these men". Since I believe that Jude was inspired by the Holy Spirit in writing his letter, then I understand that Enoch, the seventh from Adam, actually did write a prophecy and copies still existed in Jude's day. Note that this affirms the historicity /accuracy of the Genesis genealogy. If Enoch wrote, Adam also wrote, and their writings (and any other pre-flood literature) were preserved in Noah's Ark, becoming available for use by Moses and others later on. If the language spoken before the Flood was a type of Hebrew, as I assume, then Jude could easily read it. (No copies of this prophecy in Hebrew are known today, although Jews are reported to have used one as late as the 13th century A.D.) Job, the first canonical book, is in Hebrew, and that Hebrew has been said to be a bit 'older' than that used by Moses 300 years later. The point is: God certainly knew from the very beginning that in due time He would use Moses to write the Pentateuch, in Hebrew. When He multiplied the languages, it is not said that He abandoned the first one. There would be no reason to do so. The logical thing would be to maintain the original language, in which both Adam's and Noah's written accounts were preserved, within the family line that He would later choose and use (thereby avoiding the need to translate).

[b] This brings us back to 10:10; it was Nimrod's people who ended up in Shinar.

[c] With brick and pitch you cannot make a skyscraper; they may have made a drawing on the top of the tower, perhaps representing the zodiac.

[d] That is what the Text says. The Hebrew Text has the definite article with 'man', so I take it that 'the man' refers to Adam.

they are beginning with! Now, there will be no restriction on everything they intend to do.[a] **7** Come, let us go down and confound[b] their language there, that they may not understand each other's speech." **8** So JEHOVAH scattered them from there over the face of all the earth; and they stopped building the city. **9** Therefore its name was called Babel, because there JEHOVAH confused the language of all the earth,[c] and JEHOVAH scattered them from there over the face of all the earth.[d]

10 These are the generations of Shem: Shem was one hundred years old, and begot Arphaxad two years after the flood. **11** And after he begot Arphaxad, Shem lived five hundred years; and begot sons and daughters. **12** And Arphaxad lived thirty-five years, and begot Salah. **13** And after he begot Salah, Arphaxad lived four hundred and three years; and begot sons and daughters.[e] **14** And Salah lived thirty years, and begot Eber. **15** And after he begot Eber, Salah lived four hundred and three years; and begot sons and daughters. **16** And Eber lived thirty-four years, and begot Peleg.[f]

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[a] It is possible that Satan revealed to Nimrod the principles of the workings of the earth. Technological advances could have started already there. Do not the Egyptian pyramids reveal an advanced technology? And they are not alone.

[b] Again, the verbs are in the plural, which harmonizes with the Trinity.

[c] I am a linguist, PhD, and I can say that it is simply impossible that the 7,000 languages spoken today on earth could have evolved from a single mother tongue, absolutely impossible. I do not remember how many linguistic trunks there are in the world, but if there are 100, then God created 100 mother tongues. What God did affected all the inhabitants of the world at that time, not just the inhabitants of Shinar. Families with the same language would have migrated together, forming ethnic groups.

[d] Twice it says, “over the face of all the earth”. ‘All the earth’ does not mean, locally; when God separated the continents, there were people on all of them.

[e] The lack of the dome, which filtered the harmful rays from the sun, was already being felt. Arphaxad lived only half of what people lived before the Flood. Shem had the advantage of having started his life earlier, but he lived much less than his father.

[f] Peleg was born 101 years after the flood and lived for 239 years; so he died 340 years after the Flood. 10:25 indicates that the continents were created during his lifetime. I imagine that the division happened between 250 and

17 And after he begot Peleg, Eber lived four hundred and thirty years; and he begot sons and daughters. **18** And Peleg lived thirty years, and begot Reu. **19** And after he begot Reu, Peleg lived two hundred and nine years; and begot sons and daughters.[a] **20** And Reu lived thirty-two years, and begot Serug. **21** And after he begot Serug, Reu lived two hundred and seven years; and begot sons and daughters. **22** And Serug lived thirty years, and begot Nahor. **23** And after he begot Nahor, Serug lived two hundred years; and begot sons and daughters. **24** And Nahor lived twenty-nine years, and begot Terah. **25** And after he begot Terah, Nahor lived a hundred and nineteen years;[b] and begot sons and daughters. **26** And Terah lived seventy years, and begot Abram, Nahor, and Haran.[c]

27 These are the generations of Terah: Terah begot Abram, Nahor, and Haran; and Haran begot Lot. **28** And Haran died in the presence of his father Terah, in the land of his birth, in Ur of the Chaldees. **29** And Abram and Nahor took wives for themselves: the name of Abram's wife was Sarai, and the name of Nahor's wife was Milcah, the daughter of Haran,[d] the father of Milcah, and the father of Iscah. **30** And Sarai was barren; she had no child. **31** And Terah took Abram his son, and Lot the son of Haran, his son's son, and Sarai his daughter-in-law, his son Abram's wife, and went out with them from Ur of the Chaldees to go into the land of Canaan;[e] and they came to Haran, and dwelt there. **32** And the days of Terah

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300 years after the Flood, which would give ample time for the migrations after the multiplication of the languages.

[a] With Peleg the average life span was halved again; from then on it gradually decreased. The lack of the dome explains the first division, after the flood, but this division must have been by a sovereign act of God.

[b] Nahor died early.

[c] Abram was the youngest of the three, but was more important for the subsequent history.

[d] Milcah was Lot's sister.

[e] The plan was to go to Canaan, the destination that God had for Abram, but they stopped halfway. That must have been why Terah did not take Nahor, only Abram. We do not have a record of the circumstances of Haran's death, but Terah may have been happy for an excuse to leave Ur. From 24:10 we learn that Nahor followed later.

were two hundred and five years; and Terah died in Haran.

God focuses on Abraham

12:1 Now JEHOVAH had said to Abram: "Get out of your country, from your relatives, and from your father's house,[a] to the land that I will show you. **2** And I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you, and make your name great; and you shall be a blessing. **3** And I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse him who curses you;[b] and all the families of the earth shall be blessed through you."[c]

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[a] Abram's obedience was incomplete. He did leave the land, but he took his father (who cost him fifteen years in Haran) and his nephew Lot (who would be a lot of trouble). God sovereignly chose Abram to begin the family and the nation through whom the Messiah, the Savior of the world, would come. But in order for Abram to start a new relationship with Jehovah, He had to get him away from Nahor and Ur. Nahor, Abram's older brother, was presumably sixty years older than Abram, and would become the head of the family when their father died. In 31:30 Laban refers to his "gods", the family idols, which he had inherited from Bethuel, his father, who had inherited them from Nahor. In order to start something new, God had to get Abram out of Ur.

1 Corinthians 10:11 says, "Now all these things happened to them as examples and were written for our admonition, upon whom the ends of the ages have come." The following chapters are full of experiences, many of which are negative. I understand that the main lesson God wants to give us with this, is that everything we do has consequences, sometimes in the long run. It is not recorded that Abram consulted God before taking Hagar, and the consequences are with us to this day. It is also true that the experiences illustrate the scope of the Fall, as well as the scope of God's grace and mercy.

[b] Notice that the blessing is plural, while the cursing is singular. "Those who bless" is generic, offering a general principle. "Him who curses" is specific; God will personally curse that person!! It is clear in the context that the "you" includes his descendants; that is made explicit in 22:18. To curse Israel is probably not a good idea!

[c] All these promises would be fulfilled in the long run. Abram was 60 years old when he left Ur, but Isaac would not be born until 40 years later, when Abram was 100 years old (God having changed his name to Abraham a year earlier). This first communication that Jehovah gave to Abram was simple, more comprehensive, including the blessing of all the families of the earth. In 22:18 Jehovah makes clear that the blessing will come through his descendants. Indeed, as Paul wrote in Romans 3:2, "the oracles of God were entrusted" to the Jews. The book of Job was written before there was a Jew,

4 So Abram departed, as JEHOVAH had spoken to him,[a] and Lot went with him.[b] And Abram was seventy-five years old when he departed from Haran. **5** And Abram took Sarai his wife and Lot his brother's son, and all the goods that they had accumulated, and the people whom they had acquired in Haran;[c] and they went out to go into the land of Canaan. And they came to the land of Canaan. **6** And Abram passed through the land to the place of Shechem, as far as the oak of Moreh;[d] and at that time the Canaanites were in that land. **7** Then JEHOVAH appeared to Abram,[e] and said, "I will give this land to your descendants". And there he built an altar to JEHOVAH, who had appeared to him.[f] **8** And he moved from there to a mountain east of Bethel, and pitched his tent with Bethel on the west, and Ai on the east; there he built an altar to JEHOVAH and called on the name of JEHOVAH.[g] **9** Then Abram journeyed, going toward the south.

10 And there was a famine in that land, and because the famine was severe, Abram went down to Egypt to sojourn there.

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properly speaking, but all the rest of the Old Testament, and it is to it that Paul refers, was written by Jews. By the way, all of the books of the New Testament were also written by Jews (with the exception of the two books by Luke). "The Oracles of God" are the written Revelation given by God to the human race. Even more important, the Messiah, the Savior of the world, was a descendant of Abraham. There is no greater blessing than Salvation.

[a] Fifteen years earlier!

[b] Abram should not have taken Lot with him. Aside from the trouble Lot caused, if he had stayed in Haran, or even in Ur, he would not have produced the Moabites and Ammonites, who were always a negative presence in the land.

[c] As we will see later, that was probably around 1,000 people!

[d] I find that to be curious; that tree must have been impressive.

[e] Jehovah had already spoken to Abram (12:1), but here, once he was finally, after fifteen years, in the promised land, Jehovah appeared to him. God materialized in some way that Abram could see him; this enabled Abram to recognize Him on future occasions.

[f] If he built an altar, we may reasonably deduce that he bought a plot “from the sons of Hamor of Shechem” (Acts 7:16). For a fuller discussion, please see my article, ‘Who bought what from whom, and where?’ above.

[g] Because the name represents the person, Abram placed himself under Jehovah's authority and protection. And in Egypt Jehovah did indeed protect him.

11 And it came to pass, when he was about to enter Egypt, that he said to Sarai his wife: "Indeed I know that you are a woman beautiful to look at. **12** And it will happen, when the Egyptians see you, that they will say, 'This is his wife', and they will kill me, but keep you alive. **13** Please say that you are my sister,[a] that it may go well with me for your sake, and my soul may live because of you." **14** And it came to pass, when Abram came into Egypt, that the Egyptians saw the woman, that she was very beautiful. **15** And Pharaoh's princes saw her and praised her to Pharaoh. And the woman was taken into Pharaoh's house. **16** And he treated Abram well for her sake; and he gained sheep, oxen, male donkeys, male and female slaves, female donkeys and camels. **17** But JEHOVAH plagued Pharaoh and his house with great plagues because of Sarai, Abram's wife.[b] **18** Then Pharaoh called Abram and said, "What is this that you have done to me? Why didn't you tell me that she was your wife? **19** Why did you say, 'She is my sister'? That is why I took her to be my wife. Now therefore, here is your wife, take her and go!" **20** And Pharaoh gave orders to his men concerning him, and they sent him away, with his wife and all that he had.[c]

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[a] In fact, she was his half-sister, daughter of the same father, but another mother (Genesis 20:12), but the intention was to deceive the Egyptians. If on the one hand it was cowardice on Abram's part, on the other hand, for at least twenty years, Sarai had not become pregnant, she was barren, which was a shame for her, and a disappointment for him—the fact that she was beautiful did not give her children. Notice that Abram was assuming that she would in fact be taken! So why did he go to Egypt, expecting to lose his wife? If it was because of the famine, he would soon be sent right back; and since Abram survived, he would have survived if he hadn't gone to Egypt.

[b] We do not know what the plagues were, nor how God made Pharaoh know what the problem was. Also, it all happened within a short time, before Pharaoh slept with Sarai.

[c] Dear me, what a sad story! Was Abram a "blessing" in Egypt? Poor Pharaoh was not to blame, he was deceived. Abram got an earful, but he also became rich. But if Pharaoh was not to blame, why did God punish him so severely? I understand that God was protecting Sarai; He did not allow her to be defiled, nor to stay in Egypt, because the Messiah would come through her, and she had not yet given birth to Isaac, whose father had to be Abram. Usually God

13:1 Then Abram went up from Egypt to the Negev, he and his wife, and all that he had, and Lot with him. **2** And Abram was very rich in cattle, silver, and gold. **3** And he made his way from the Negev to Bethel, to the place where his tent had been at the beginning, between Bethel and Ai; **4** to the place of the altar which he had made there before; and Abram called upon the name of JEHOVAH there.

5 Now Lot, who was going with Abram, also had flocks, cattle, and tents.[a] **6** And the land was not able to support them, that they might dwell together; for their goods were so great that they could not dwell together. **7** And there was strife between the herdsmen of Abram's cattle and the herdsmen of Lot's cattle; and at that time the Canaanites and the Perizzites dwelt in that land.[b] **8** Then Abram said to Lot: "Please let there be no contention between me and you, and between my herdsmen and your herdsmen, for we are brothers. **9** Is not the whole land before you? Well then, separate from me; if you go to the left, I will go to the right; or if you go to the right, I will go to the left."[c] **10** And Lot lifted up his eyes and saw all the plain of the Jordan, that it was all well- watered (before JEHOVAH destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah), even as the garden of JEHOVAH,[d] as the land of Egypt, going toward Zoar.[e] **11** Then Lot chose for himself all the plain of the Jordan, and Lot journeyed east, and they separated from each other. **12** Abram dwelt in the

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lets us act freely, taking the consequences, but when it is necessary to protect the Plan, He intervenes sovereignly.

[a] He had inherited all that from his father before he left Ur, except that it all had doubtless increased during the fifteen years in Haran. The “tents” presumably refers to people.

[b] In other words, the land was not empty, and there would be competition for its use.

[c] Abram offering the choice to Lot was noble and generous, and since Lot was selfish and self-centered, he accepted. And he chose exactly what seemed to be the most privileged area of the region.

[d] The expression is probably poetic, evoking a very pleasant place. The garden of Eden no longer existed, and no one living at that time would know what it was like.

[e] Zoar was not far from Sodom, unless this was a second one some-where in Egypt. The reference to Egypt probably referred to Goshen, which was well-watered.

land of Canaan, and Lot dwelt in the cities of the plain, and moved his tent as far as Sodom.[a] **13** Now the men of Sodom were wicked, and sinners against JEHOVAH—exceedingly.[b]

14 After Lot parted from him,[c] JEHOVAH said to Abram: "Now lift up your eyes and look from the place where you are—to the north, to the south, to the east and to the west. **15** For all the land which you see I will give to you, and to your descendants, forever.[d] **16** And I will make your descendants as the dust of the earth; so that if a man could number the dust of the earth, your descendants also could be numbered. **17** Arise, walk through the land, in its length and in its breadth; for to you I will give it."[e] **18** Then Abram moved his tent, and went and dwelt by the oaks of Mamre,[f] which are in Hebron; and he built an altar there to JEHOVAH.[g]

Abram delivers Lot

14:1 And it came to pass in the days of Amraphel king of Shinar, Arioch king of Ellasar, Chedorlaomer king of Elam, and Tidal king of Goyim, **2** that they made war with Bera king of Sodom, with Birsha king of Gomorrah, with Shinab king of Admah, with Shemeber king of Zeboim, and with the king of Bela (that is, Zoar). **3** All these gathered together in the valley of Siddim (that is, the Salt Sea).[h]

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[a] Did Lot know nothing of the nature of Sodom? It seems that Sodom was the most important city, politically.

[b] Why does the Text say that they were “sinners against JEHOVAH” and “exceedingly”? Of course, all sin is against Jehovah, but they were especially bad. Their appetite for anal sex did not stop at angelic beings, and there were probably *Nephilim* among them.

[c] Finally, Abram was entirely freed from his kindred, which was part of the first command that God gave him, and God renewed the promise in much more detail.

[d] "Forever"—it seems that in God's mind the land of Canaan belongs to Israel, always, even when not occupied or controlled by it.

[e] We have no record that Abram obeyed this command to go through the land.

[f] Why are the oak trees emphasized? Well, they did all their cooking with wood, and oak wood is good firewood.

[g] This was the third altar that Abram built to Jehovah. He was leaving his 'mark' on the land.

[h] The 'Salt Sea', or Dead Sea, was the result of the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah, and did not yet exist at that time; but Moses, writing centuries later, gives this clarification.

4 For they had served Chedorlaomer twelve years, but in the thirteenth year they rebelled.

5 In the fourteenth year Chedorlaomer and the kings who were with him came, and struck the *Rephaim* in Ashteroth-karnaim, the *Zuzim* in Ham, the *Emim* in Shaveh-kiriathaim[a] **6** and the Horites in their mountain of Seir, as far as El-paran, which is by the wilderness. **7** Then they returned and came to En-mishpat (which is Kadesh), and struck all the country of the Amalekites, and also the Amorites who dwelt in Hazazon-tamar.[b] **8** Then the king of Sodom, the king of Gomorrah, the king of Admah, the king of Zeboim, and the king of Bela (that is, Zoar) went out, and they set the battle in array against them in the valley of Siddim, **9** against Chedorlaomer king of Elam, Tidal king of Goyim, Amraphel king of Shinar, and Arioch king of Ellasar: four kings against five. **10** Now the valley of Siddim was full of asphalt pits; and the kings of Sodom and Gomorrah fled; some fell there, and the rest fled to a mountain. **11** And they took all the goods of Sodom and Gomorrah, and all their food, and departed. **12** They also took Lot the son of Abram's brother, who dwelt in Sodom, and his goods, and departed.

13 But one who had escaped came and told Abram the Hebrew,[c] who dwelt by the oaks of Mamre the Amorite, Eshcol's brother, and Aner's brother; they were Abram's allies. **14** And when Abram heard that his brother[d] was taken captive, he led out his three hundred and eighteen trained men, born in his house,[e]

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[a] Those three races were hybrid races, like the *Nephilim*.

[b] Why did the Holy Spirit lead Moses to record the names of peoples and places in such detail and precision? What sense would it make, or difference would it make centuries later? Because God's written Revelation has always been a historical and true record, not a 'religious book'.

[c] This is the first occurrence of the word 'Hebrew', which became the patronymic of Abraham and his descendants.

[d] The term is used *lato sensu*, Lot being his nephew, but it is likely that they felt like brothers, being of the same age, more or less, and having been raised together.

[e] This is impressive. If they were "born in his house", they were not mercenaries. With women and children, and old men, the community that Abram led probably numbered over a thousand people. That was a lot of

and went in pursuit as far as Dan.[a] **15** Then he divided his servants and attacked them by night, and smote them, and pursued them as far as Hobah, which is on the left side of Damascus.[b] **16** And he brought back all the goods, and also brought his brother Lot, with his goods, as well as the women and the people.[c]

17 And when Abram had returned, after striking Chedor-laomer and the kings who were with him, the king of Sodom went out to meet him,[d] at the valley of Shaveh, which is the king's valley. **18** And Melchizedek king of Salem brought bread and wine;[e] and he was priest of the Most-High God. **19** And he blessed him, and said: "Blessed be Abram by the Most-High God, Owner of heaven and earth. **20** And blessed be the Most-High God, who has delivered your enemies into your hand." And *Abram* gave him a tenth of everything.[f] **21** Then the king of Sodom said to Abram, "Give me the people, and take the goods for yourself". **22** But Abram said to the king of Sodom, "I have lifted up my hand to

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people! On the other hand, with so many men capable of war, taking action against him would be risky.

[a] Abram did not stay at home; he commanded the operation.

[b] Since they were heading north, the left would be the west side.

[c] Now it is obvious that God helped Abram, because the four kings would have many more men than Abram. Hebron was only about forty km from Salem (Jerusalem). Did Abram know nothing of Melchizedek, king of Salem and priest of the Most-High God? I imagine that Abram had asked God's blessing through Melchizedek, which is why he tithed. It is also obvious that Abram's interest was to rescue Lot, not the others. And God helped Abram, even though He knew what would happen to Lot later. Perhaps God was giving Lot one last chance to correct his life; he should have left Sodom.

[d] The king of Sodom had not been taken prisoner.

[e] What was Melchizedek doing so far from Jerusalem? How did he know when and where Abram was coming? I do not doubt that there was supernatural involvement.

[f] Hebrews 7:1-7 gives us an inspired commentary on this meeting between Melchizedek and Abram. The figure of Melchizedek is a bit of a mystery. Since he is "priest of the Most-High", how is it that such an office has never been spoken of before? And how is it that Abram submitted to him without objection? And where did the idea of 'tithing' come from? If Melchizedek was a manifestation of Jehovah, who had appeared to Abram before, then Abram's attitude was natural. Hebrews 7:7 – "Now without dispute, the lesser is blessed by the greater". Melchizedek was greater than Abram.

JEHOVAH, the Most-High God, Owner of heaven and earth,[a] **23** that I will not take from a thread to a sandal-strap, or anything that is yours; lest you should say, 'I have made Abram rich'[b]–**24** nothing for me; only what the young men have eaten, and the portion of the men that went with me, Aner, Eshcol, and Mamre;[c] let them take their portion."

God and Abram

15.1 After these things the word of JEHOVAH came to Abram in a vision, saying, "Do not be afraid, Abram, I am your shield; your reward will be exceedingly great."[d] **2** Then Abram said, "Lord JEHOVAH, what will you give me, since I am still childless, and the heir of my house is Eliezer of Damascus?" **3** Then Abram said, "Really, You have given me no descendant; indeed, one born in my house will be my heir!" **4** Then the word of JEHOVAH came to him, saying, "This one will not be your heir; but he who will come out of your own body, he shall be your heir". **5** Then He took him outside,[e] and said, "Look now toward the heavens and count the stars,[f] if you are able to count them". And He said to him, "So shall your descendants be". **6** And he believed in JEHOVAH, and He reckoned it to him for righteousness.[g]

7 Then He said to him, "I am JEHOVAH, who brought you out of Ur of the Chaldeans, to give you this land to inherit it". **8** And he

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[a] Abram repeats the titles of God given by Melchizedek, but adds His name, Jehovah; but he had raised his hand before leaving. He had certainly asked for God's help.

[b] Abram was already very rich, and he did not need the spoil. Further, anything from Sodom would be contaminated by the utterly wicked life of the inhabitants and would do no good.

[c] We are not told how many fighting men they had, but they would be added to Abram's 318.

[d] Would such a reward be in Heaven? Here on earth Abraham was already very rich, and he appeals to the fact that he has no son.

[e] To take him out, God had to be there. In the first verse God used a vision, but from verse four on, He was present.

[f] To see the stars, it had to be at night.

[g] Well, that took some believing! God kept telling him that his descendants would be uncountable, but he had no son.

said, "My Lord JEHOVAH, how shall I know that I shall inherit it?"[a] **9** And He said unto him, "Bring me a three-year-old heifer, a three-year-old female goat, a three-year-old ram, a turtledove and a young pigeon". **10** So he brought all these to Him and cut them in two, and he placed each half opposite the other;[b] but he did not divide the birds. **11** And the birds of prey came down on the carcasses, and Abram drove them away.[c]

12 And it happened, when the sun was going down, that a deep sleep fell upon Abram; and behold, a terrible and dense darkness fell upon him.[d] **13** Then He said to Abram: "Know certainly that your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs—and will be enslaved and mistreated—for four hundred years.[e] **14** But I also will judge the nation whom they will serve;[f] and afterward they will come out with great wealth.[g] **15** And you shall go to your

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[a] Verse 6 says he believed, but here he asks for confirmation. The cruel truth was that he was still childless. In verses 13 to 16 God gives a more detailed answer. Abraham questioned God, and He answered, but the experience was not pleasant.

[b] Separating the front half from the back half would be easier than splitting the carcass from end to end. Presumably God had told him to kill the animals in that way. They were not burned, so it was not a normal offering.

[c] This all happened during the day, presumably the immediately following one.

[d] The prophecy he was about to receive was also dark, but evidently that was an unusual darkness; a very unpleasant one.

[e] This verse should be understood as a chiasmus, a common structure in the Bible:

A. your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs
B. and will be enslaved
B. and mistreated
A. for four hundred years.

A careful comparison of the relevant passages shows that the 400 years include from Isaac's weaning to the exodus (1891 to 1491 B.C.). Since Jacob moved to Egypt in 1706, Abraham's descendants were foreigners in Canaan for 185 years, and then were foreigners in Egypt (where they were enslaved) for 215 years. The exodus occurred 144 years after Joseph's death, so the period of slave labor must have been somewhat less, perhaps around 100 years. (I owe the analysis given above to Dr. Floyd N. Jones.)

[f] Indeed, God punished Egypt with some severity.

[g] Exodus 12:35-36 records that they plundered the Egyptians, taking away a lot of wealth.

fathers in peace; you shall be buried in a good old age.[a] **16** And in the fourth generation they shall return here;[b] for the measure of the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet full."[c] **17** And it came to pass, when the sun had set and it was dark, that behold, a smoking portable stove and a torch of fire that passed between those halves![d] **18** That same day JEHOVAH made a covenant with Abram, saying: "I have given this land to your descendants, from the river

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[a] In fact, he died peacefully at the age of 175, Genesis 25:7-8.

[b] Verse 15 recounts Abraham's death; So the "fourth generation" of verse 16 must be reckoned after that death. Jacob was born well before his grandfather's death, and therefore the calculation must begin with a son of his. I understand that the four generations were: Levi (lived 137 years), Kohath (lived 133 years), Amram (lived 137 years) and Moses (lived 120 years) (Exodus 6:16-20). Only these first three are given a record of the years they lived (in Exodus 6), which was certainly on purpose.

[c] Alas, this statement leaves me melancholy. Is there a 'measure of wickedness' for every evildoer? Do countries have this measure? A congress that has already filled barrels with corruption–is there no point in praying against it? Notice that God Himself declared that the measure was not full, meaning that He knew the point at which it would be, and He would not shorten the interval. It is Sovereignty in action. The Amorites were descendants of Canaan, whom Noah had cursed. Perhaps the curse resulted in a certain measure of iniquity. Exodus 20:5 says that God Himself "visits the iniquity of the fathers upon the children to the third and fourth generation". Does God determine a 'measure' for the iniquity? I confess that I would like to understand this subject better, but to this day I have not found a better explanation.

[d] We are not told what the purpose of the stove and torch may have been. For that matter, we are not told the purpose of the whole procedure. However, I asked the Holy Spirit to illumine me about the episode, and this is what came to me. The animals represent projects that we undertake on behalf of Christ's Kingdom (like sacrifices). The heifer stands for big ones, the goat and ram for middle-sized ones, and the birds for small ones. Any three-year-old animal is mature, full-grown, so the projects are in effect. The buzzards represent Satan's servants, who work to contaminate and diminish what we have achieved, and like Abraham, we have to keep alert to try to stop them. Then there are times when God puts us in the dark, without explanation, which is very unpleasant! Isaiah 50:10-11 refers to this. The stove will burn some of the contamination, and the torch will expose the extent of the damage: they are things that God does. That is what came to me. It serves as an application, if no more.

of Egypt[a] to the great river, the River Euphrates;[b] **19** including the Kenite, the Kenizzite, the Kadmonite, **20** the Hittite, the Perizzite, the *Rephaim*, **21** the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Girgashite, and the Jebusite."[c]

Hagar

16:1 Now Sarai, Abram's wife, had borne him no children, and she had an Egyptian slave girl, whose name was Hagar.[d] **2** And Sarai said to Abram, "Indeed, JEHOVAH has kept me from bearing;[e] please go in to my slave girl, maybe I can build a family through her." And Abram listened to Sarai. **3** So Sarai, Abram's wife, took her slave girl Hagar, the Egyptian, and gave her to her husband Abram to be his wife; Abram had been living in the land of Canaan for ten years.[f] **4** And he went in to Hagar, and she conceived; and when she saw

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[a] This river was not the Nile, but a stream south of Gaza.

[b] As far as we know, the people of Israel never occupied this entire area; not to the Euphrates. Is it a reference to the Millennial Messianic Kingdom? Until then God had promised Canaan, but now He increases the size.

[c] That was ten ethnic groups, one of which was hybrid. It was the land that those groups occupied that God gave.

[d] 12:16 says that Pharaoh gave Abram female slaves, and Hagar was probably one of them. If Abram had not gone to Egypt, they would not have had Hagar to deal with.

[e] It had been 25 years since they left Ur, and we do not know how many years they had been married when they left. What is certain is that Sarai had lost any hope of having a child. She introduced Jehovah into the question, saying that He was responsible for her not having a child. In that case, was she going against God's will by offering Hagar?

[f] Abram was already 85 years old. Romans 4:19 states that Abraham "did not consider his own body, already dead (being about a hundred years old)." Paul declares that Abraham had become impotent before he fathered Isaac. This means that he had gone into decline much earlier, and no one would know that better than Sarai. Perhaps that is the explanation for why she offered Hagar–she knew of the Pro-mise and that Abram needed a descendant. Until that moment, God had not revealed that the mother would be Sarah herself, only that Abram would have a son. It was when he was 99 years old that God changed his name to Abraham, and Sarai's name to Sarah. And it was only then that God revealed that it would be Sarah who would give birth to the son of the Promise. (In passing, God revived Abraham to such good effect that he later fathered six sons with Keturah!)

that she had conceived, her mistress became despised in her eyes.[a] **5** Then Sarai said to Abram: "My grievance be upon you! I gave my slave girl into your arms; and when she saw that she had conceived, I became despised in her eyes; may JEHOVAH judge between you and me!"[b] **6** So Abram said to Sarai, "Indeed, your slave girl is in your hand; do to her what is good in your eyes". Then Sarai dealt harshly with her, and she fled from her face.

7 And the Angel of JEHOVAH[c] found her by a spring of water in the wilderness, by the spring on the way to Shur. **8** And He said, "Hagar, slave-girl of Sarai, where have you come from, and where are you going?" And she said, "I am running away from the face of my mistress Sarai".[d] **9** Then the Angel of JEHOVAH said to her, "Return to your mistress, and submit yourself under her hand".[e] **10** The Angel of JEHOVAH continued, "I will multiply your descendants exceedingly, so that they will not be numbered for multitude." **11** And the Angel of JEHOVAH said to her: "Indeed, you are with child, and you will give birth to a son, and you shall call his name Ishmael;[f] because JEHOVAH has considered your affliction.[g] **12** And he shall be a wild-donkey of a man: his hand shall be against everyone, and the hand of everyone against him; and he shall dwell in the presence of all his brothers."[h] **13** And she called the name of JEHOVAH, who spoke to her, 'You are the God who sees'; for she said,

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[a] But that was perfectly predictable.

[b] How so? It was she who asked Abram to take the slave girl. It seems that she was blaming Abram for having accepted the proposal. On the other hand, we are not told that Abram sought to know God's will for the case. If he had, surely God would have said not to do it, thus avoiding the negative consequences, that last until our days.

[c] This is the first mention of the Angel of Jehovah, who was Jehovah Himself.

[d] She didn't say where she was going, probably because she didn't know. It is not said that she was afraid or uncomfortable; she answered normally.

[e] Why did God send her back? Well, she was carrying Abram's son. Notice that God reminded her that she was a slave.

[f] The name means: God hears.

[g] What affliction? Well, it wasn't her fault that she was a slave, nor that she had been given to Abram. She had been given to him precisely to bear children.

[h] Why does it say "all" the brothers; Isaac was only one. Abraham had six sons by Keturah (Genesis 25:1-2).

"Have I also looked upon Him who sees me?"[a] **14** That is why the well was called *Beer-lahai-roi*;[b] indeed, it is between Kadesh and Bered. **15** And Hagar bore Abram a son; and Abram named his son, whom Hagar bore, Ishmael.[c] **16** And Abram was eighty-six years old when Hagar bore him Ishmael.

Circumcision becomes the sign of the Covenant

17:1 When Abram was ninety-nine years old, JEHOVAH appeared to Abram and said to him: "I am Almighty God;[d] walk in my presence and be blameless. **2** And I will make my covenant between me and you, and will multiply you exceedingly."[e] **3** Then Abram fell on his face, and God spoke with him, saying: **4** "As for me, indeed, my covenant is with you, and you will be a father of many nations; **5** And your name shall no longer be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham[f]; for I have made you the father of many nations.[g] **6** And I will make you exceedingly fruitful, and I will make nations of you, and kings shall come out from you. **7** And I will establish my covenant between me and you, and your descendants after you throughout their generations, by an everlasting covenant, to be God to you, and to your descendants after you. **8** And I will give to you, and to your descendants after you, the land of your sojournings, all the land of Canaan for an everlasting possession;[h] and I will be their God."[i]

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[a] The Text does not say that the Angel appeared to her, but the way in which she expressed herself gives the idea that she saw something.

[b] The name means: the well of him who lives and sees me.

[c] God Himself had given that name to Hagar, and she must have told Abram.

[d] The name in Hebrew is *El Shaddai*.

[e] But why did God each time emphasize the numerous offspring? Well, at that time, what was the reason for living? Was it just existing, living well? The main objective was to leave descendants.

[f] The name means: father of a multitude.

[g] God used the past tense because He had already determined what He said.

[h] In 15:18 God promised the area up to the Euphrates River, but here He returns to the land of Canaan. "Everlasting" presumably means until the end of this world.

[i] The reason for the covenant was to be their God. But since every covenant has two sides, to effectively receive God's blessing depends on our behavior. And it is possible to change gods, as some have done.

9 Then God said to Abraham:[a] "As for you, you must keep my covenant, you and your descendants after you throughout their generations. **10** This is my covenant which you must keep, between me and you[b] and your descendants after you: Every male among you shall be circumcised.[c] **11** You [pl] shall be circumcised in the flesh of your foreskin, which shall be a sign of the covenant between me and you. **12** The eight-day-old son among you shall be circumcised,[d] every male in your generations, whether he is born in your house or bought for money from any foreigner, who is not your descendant. **13** He who is born in your house and he who is bought with your money must be circumcised; my covenant shall be in your flesh for an everlasting covenant. **14** And an uncircumcised male, whose flesh of the foreskin is not circumcised, his soul shall be cut off from his people;[e] he has broken my covenant."

15 God also said to Abraham: "As for Sarai your wife, you shall not call her name Sarai, but Sarah will be her name.[f] **16** For I will bless her and also give you a son by her; indeed, I have blessed her, and she shall become nations; kings of peoples shall be from her." **17** Then Abraham fell on his face and laughed, and said in his heart:

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[a] From here the new name is used: Abraham.

[b] This pronoun is plural rather than singular. It would include Ishmael and the other males who were part of Abraham's household at that time, of which there were hundreds.

[c] Circumcision was the symbol of the covenant, which was perpetual. God said, "You must keep," so that the obligation of Abraham's descendants to circumcise their sons will never end. This is what verse 13 says: "My covenant in your flesh is an everlasting covenant." That means that God's commitment to those descendants also will never end. Now then, does that also apply to non-Jews who are circumcised? Even in our day?

[d] "Eight days" – two different blood-clotting agents, vitamin K and prothrombin, reach their highest level in the blood (110% of normal) on a person's eighth day, so that is the best day of a lifetime for minor surgery. 4,000 years ago, who but the Creator knew this when He determined the procedure for Abraham? It was not a sadistic procedure, as if God liked to see a baby suffer. It was a matter of hygiene and health; a woman with a circumcised husband does not get cervical cancer.

[e] This expression seems to indicate the death penalty.

[f] The name means: princess.

"Will a son be born to a hundred-year-old man?[a] And will Sarah give birth at the age of ninety?" **18** And Abraham said to God, "Oh that Ishmael might live before you!"[b] **19** And God said: "Sarah your wife will surely bear you a son, and you shall call his name Isaac;[c] I will establish my covenant with him and with his descendants after him, for an everlasting covenant. **20** And as for Ishmael, I have heard you; indeed, I have blessed him, and will make him fruitful, and will multiply him exceedingly; he shall beget twelve chiefs, and I will make him a great nation. **21** But it is with Isaac that I will establish my covenant, whom Sarah will bear to you at this time, next year." **22** When God had finished talking with Abraham, He ascended.

23 Then Abraham took his son Ishmael, all who were born in his house and all who were bought with his money, every male among the people of Abraham's house; and he circumcised the flesh of their foreskin that very day, just as God had said to him. **24** Abraham was ninety-nine years old when the flesh of his foreskin was circumcised. **25** And Ishmael his son was thirteen years old when the flesh of his foreskin was circumcised. **26** Abraham and Ishmael his son were circumcised on the same day. **27** And all the males of his household, those born in the house and those bought with money from a foreigner, were circumcised with him.[d]

Abraham saves Lot's life

18:1 Then JEHOVAH appeared to him by the oaks of Mamre, while he was sitting at the tent door in the heat of the day. **2** And he lifted his eyes and looked, and behold, three men standing near him. And when he saw them, he ran from the tent door to meet them, and

[a] At that time, men were still procreating at well over 100 years old, but Abraham had already lost this ability (Romans 4:19).

[b] Abraham had affection for Ishmael, and in effect was asking that he be the son of the Promise.

[c] The name means: he laughs.

[d] This time Abraham obeyed completely. The men would be unable to fight for three or four days, but God doubtless protected them.

bowed down to the ground. **3** And he said: "My Lord,[a] if I have now found favor in your sight, I beg you not to pass on from your [sg] servant. **4** Please, let a little water be brought, and wash your [pl] feet, and rest under the tree. **5** And I will bring you a morsel of bread to refresh your heart; that is why you have come to your servant; then you may pass on." And they said, "Do so, as you have said". **6** So Abraham ran into the tent to Sarah, and said, "Hurry, knead three measures of fine flour, and make cakes!" **7** Then Abraham ran to the herd, took a tender and good calf, and gave it to a young man, who hastened to prepare it. **8** And he took curds and milk, and the veal which he had prepared, and set it before them; and he stood by them under the tree; and they ate.[b]

9 And they said to him, "Where is Sarah your wife?" And he said, "There in the tent." **10** And He said,[c] "I will certainly return to you according to the time of life;[d] and indeed, Sarah your wife shall bear a son". (And Sarah was listening at the door of the tent behind him.[e]) **11** Now Abraham and Sarah were old and well advanced in age; the custom of women had ceased for Sarah.[f] **12** And Sarah laughed within herself, saying, "Being old, shall I have pleasure, my lord being old also?" **13** And JEHOVAH said to Abraham: "Why did Sarah laugh, saying, 'Indeed, will I really bear, I who am old?' **14** Is anything too hard for JEHOVAH? At the appointed time[g] I will return to you,[h] according to the time of life, and Sarah shall have a son."

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[a] Since Jehovah had already appeared to him, Abraham recognized Him and addressed Him.

[b] They were Jehovah the Son and two angels, materialized. They ate without needing food. Why? I suppose it went along with pretending to be men.

[c] In verse 9 the verb is plural, but here it changes to singular. It is Jehovah who speaks (verse 13).

[d] The phrase "the time of life" presumably refers to the nine months of gestation, although we do not know if it took longer at that time, since people also lived longer.

[e] Of course she would! She wanted to know what was going on, and Jehovah spoke loudly enough so that she could hear—He knew that she was listening.

[f] Her menopause was already history.

[g] "Appointed" by whom? By God.

[h] Why did God have to ‘return’? Perhaps He was affirming His involvement in the pregnancy, from beginning to end.

15 And Sarah denied it, saying, "I did not laugh", be-cause she was afraid; and He said, "No, you really did laugh!"[a]

16 Then the men got up to leave and started out toward Sodom; and Abraham went with them to guide them.[b] **17** And JEHOVAH said: "Shall I conceal from Abraham what I am doing, **18** since Abraham will certainly become a great and mighty nation, and all the nations of the earth will be blessed through him? **19** For I have known him,[c] in order that he may command his sons and his household after him, to keep the way of JEHOVAH, to practice righteousness and justice; that JEHOVAH may bring upon Abraham what he has spoken about him."[d] **20** Then JEHOVAH said: "Because the outcry against Sodom and Gomorrah is great, and because their sin is very grievous,[e] **21** I will go down now[f] and see if indeed they have done according to the outcry that has come to me; and if not, I will know it."[g]

22 Then the men departed from there and went toward Sodom; but Abraham still stood before JEHOVAH. **23** Then Abraham spoke up and said: "Would you actually destroy the righteous with the wicked? **24** If perchance there be fifty righteous within the city,

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[a] I find this to be curious; what did it matter to Jehovah that Sarah laughed? It did give Him the occasion for making an important statement: “Is anything too hard for Jehovah?”

[b] This was presumably just a pretext for going along, since they certainly did not need help to find the way. Abraham knew that something serious was going to happen. When Jehovah shows up, it is serious!!

[c] To know in the sense of recognizing, or choosing.

[d] This is interesting. Jehovah spoke out loud for Abraham to hear. And why would he do that? Presumably to get Abraham to make the intercession that he did. God could have remained silent, and Abra-ham would not have known anything. God knew He was going to save Lot. As for the content of verse 19, each individual must "keep the way of Jehovah" in order to receive the declared blessings.

[e] Chapter 19 clarifies that this sin was anal sex–the men even wanted to rape the angels!

[f] When the Text says that God 'descends', it is because He will act sovereignly. Abraham understood that judgment had already been determined, and he wanted to save Lot.

[g] But He already knew the answer. The way He expressed Himself was part of the reason why He promoted this encounter with Abraham.

would you destroy it even so, and not spare the place for the sake of the fifty righteous who are within it? **25** Far be it from you that you should do such a thing, to kill the righteous with the wicked; so that the righteous should be like the wicked; far be it from you! Shall not the Judge of all the earth do what is right?"[a] **26** Then JEHOVAH said, "If I find fifty righteous people within the city[b] of Sodom, I will spare the whole place for their sake". **27** Then Abraham answered and said: "Indeed now, I, dust and ashes, have presumed to speak to the Lord. **28** If five righteous are lacking from the fifty, would you destroy the whole city for lack of five?" And He said, "If I find forty-five there, I will not destroy". **29** And he spoke to Him yet again, and said, "And if forty be found there?" And He said, "I will not do it for the sake of forty". **30** And he said, "Please, my Lord, do not be angry because I speak, 'If thirty be found there?'" And He said, "I will not do it if I find thirty there". **31** And he said, " Indeed now, I have presumed to speak to the Lord, 'If twenty be found there?'" And He said, "I will not destroy for the sake of the twenty". **32** Then he said, "Please, my Lord, do not be angry because I speak just once more, 'If ten be found there?'"[c] And He said, "I will not destroy for the sake of the ten". **33** And when JEHOVAH had finished speaking with Abraham, He departed; and Abraham returned to his place.

19:1 Now the two angels came to Sodom in the evening, and Lot was sitting at the gate of Sodom.[d] When Lot saw them, he rose

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[a] "The Judge of all the earth" could only be Jehovah Himself. Abraham knew who He was. In John 5:22 sovereign Jesus declared that the Father had committed all judging to the Son, so this was Jehovah the Son. Who did Abraham think that he was, wanting to teach God about justice!? Since that was exactly what God had foreseen, it worked out.

[b] It had to be within the city.

[c] Why did Abraham insist until he reached ten? 19:14 mentions "his sons-in-law", plural, who would be at least two, making eight in the family. But if there were three, it would make ten in the family. It appears that Abraham did not believe that Lot had made a difference for good in Sodom. In fact, in addition to not winning anyone, Lot lost his own family.

[d] This means that he had already achieved some importance in the city. The fact that Abraham rescued the people for Lot's sake certainly contributed – see verse 9 below.

up to meet them, and bowed his face to the earth.[a] **2** And he said, "Indeed, my lords, please come into your servant's house, and spend the night, and wash your feet; then you may rise early and go on your way." And they said, "No, we will spend the night in the square". **3** But he insisted with them strongly;[b] so they went with him and entered his house. And he made them a meal, baking unleavened bread, and they ate.[c]

4 But before they lay down, the men of the city surrounded the house, the men of Sodom, both young and old, all the people of all the neighborhoods.[d] **5** And they called to Lot, and said to him: "Where are the men who came to you tonight? Bring them out to us, that we may know them sexually."[e] **6** Then Lot went out to them and shut the door behind him.[f] **7** And he said: "My brothers, please do not act so wickedly! **8** Come now, I have two daughters who have not known a man;[g] please let me bring them out to you, and do with them as you will; only do nothing to these men, since that is why they have come under the protection of my roof."[h] **9** But they said, "Stand back!" and went on: "This fellow came in to sojourn, and wants to judge everything. Now we will do worse to

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[a] It seems that Lot realized, somehow, that they were not ordinary people. Perhaps, through his association with Abram, he had some knowledge of the supernatural.

[b] Lot knew that it would not work at all for them to stay in the square.

[c] Again, being materialized angels, they did not need to eat. But if they were presenting themselves as men, it would be part of the 'play'. But why was the bread ‘unleavened’? Leavening takes time, which Lot did not have.

[d] But how did the whole city find out in time to participate? Was it by demonic action?

[e] Jude 7 states that those men "went after a different kind of flesh". Be that as it may, the 'flesh' that an angel has when it materializes, is not human flesh. The men of Sodom also knew that the angels were not ordinary people, and they wanted to rape them.

[f] By shutting the door, he was at their mercy.

[g] They were virgins.

[h] Why did Lot offer up his daughters; was it because he knew that the two men were angels? But apparently he did not think that they could protect themselves. At that time hospitality was taken very seriously, and Lot would do his best to protect his guests. Even so, to offer his own daughters was an abomination. The cruel fact was that Lot was in a ‘dead end street’.

you than to them." And they attacked the man, Lot, and started to break down the door. **10** But the men reached out their hands and pulled Lot into the house with them and shut the door.[a] **11** And they struck the men at the door of the house with blindness,[b] both small and great, so that they wearied themselves to find the door.[c]

12 Then the men said to Lot: "Whom else do you have here? Take them out of this place: son-in-law, your sons, your daughters, and all whom you have[d] in this city. **13** For we are about to destroy this place, because the outcry against them has become very great before JEHOVAH,[e] and JEHOVAH has sent us to destroy it." **14** So Lot went out and spoke to his sons-in-law, who were married to his daughters, and said, "Get up, get out of this place, for JEHOVAH is about to destroy the city!" But to his sons-in-law he seemed to be joking.[f]

15 When the day dawned, the angels urged Lot, saying, "Get up, take your wife and your two daughters who are here,[g] lest you be destroyed in the punishment of the city". **16** But he lingered, so the men took hold of his hand, his wife's hand, and the hands of his two daughters, JEHOVAH having mercy on him; and they brought him out and put him outside the city.[h] **17** And it came to pass, when

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[a] They used supernatural power to do that.

[b] Here it became clear that the two were supernatural. Obviously the men outside didn't expect that.

[c] Wow, even though they were blind, they did not give up! They were certainly demonized. However, the angels were probably also involved, or the men could have found the door by feel. In any case, the angels would not let them break down the door.

[d] The angels declare that God will take into consideration any people Lot had 'won' in the city, even though they knew that he had no one.

[e] Who was doing the 'crying', who was denouncing the iniquity? Daniel 4:17 speaks of "watchers", presumably a certain kind of angel; perhaps they were the ones.

[f] The husbands' attitude condemned Lot's married daughters, but they probably agreed with their husbands.

[g] "Take" meaning to take them out of the city. "Your two daughters who are here" indicates that there were others who were not there.

[h] The angels took them out by force, because they were under obligation to spare them (see verse 22). Each angel took two people.

they had brought them out, that he said:[a] "Escape for your life! Do not look behind you nor stop anywhere in the plain; escape to the mountain, lest you be destroyed." **18** And Lot said to them: "Oh no, Lord! **19** Indeed now, your servant has found grace in your sight, and you have magnified your mercy which you have shown to me by saving my life; but I am not able to escape to the mountain, lest the calamity overtake me and I die.[b] **20** Look, that city is near to flee to, and it is small; please let me escape there, (is it not small?), that my soul may live." **21** And he said to him: "See, I have accepted you in this matter also, so as not to destroy the city of which you have spoken. **22** Hurry, escape there! For I cannot do anything until you have arrived there."[c] (So the name of the city was called Zoar.)[d]

23 The sun had risen upon the earth when Lot entered Zoar. **24** Then JEHOVAH Himself[e] rained brimstone and fire on Sodom and Gomorrah from the heavens. **25** And He destroyed those cities, all the plain, all the inhabitants of the cities, and the produce of the soil. **26** But *Lot's* wife, who was behind him, looked back, and became a pillar of salt.[f] **27** And Abraham got up early in the morning and went to the place where he had stood before JEHOVAH. **28** And he looked toward Sodom and Gomorrah, and toward all the land of the plain; and he saw, yes indeed, the smoke of the land

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[a] One of the two was the boss, and he spoke. It is to him that Lot addresses himself in verses 18 to 20.

[b] Probably Lot was not in a physical condition to run very far, and he doubted that he would have the strength to reach the mountain. He was afraid of dying.

[c] Obviously the angel had been ordered to spare Lot, at any cost.

[d] The name means: small. It is also true that Lot saved that village, otherwise it would have been destroyed as well.

[e] Why does the Text emphasize that it was Jehovah Himself? The situation there must have been REALLY bad! Indeed, the destruction was complete; in fact, Jude 7 says that God used “eternal fire”! Well, God used “brimstone and fire” (Genesis 19:24), and the eternal Lake contains “fire and brimstone” (Revelation 20:10).

[f] Certainly she was not in physical condition to run, and she was not enjoying having to leave the city. She could have been some distance behind Lot when she looked back. The destruction certainly made quite a bit of noise that she heard. Looking back had been forbidden. In Luke 17:32, Sovereign Jesus affirmed the historicity of the pillar of salt.

that went up like the smoke of a furnace.[a] **29** When God destroyed the cities of the plain, God remembered Abraham and sent Lot out of the midst of destruction,[b] when he destroyed the cities in which Lot had dwelt.[c]

30 Lot went up out of Zoar, and dwelt in the mountain, and his two daughters with him, because he was afraid to dwell in Zoar;[d] and he and his two daughters dwelt in a cave.[e] **31** Then the first-born said to the younger, "Our father is old, and there is no man in the land to come in to us, according to the custom of all the earth. **32** Come, let us make our father drink wine, and let us lie with him, that we may keep alive our father's progeny."[f] **33** So they made their father drink wine that night; and the firstborn went in and lay with her father, and he did not know when she lay down, nor when

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[a] Would he have known that Lot was delivered? Perhaps he was shaken, thinking that Lot was destroyed too. Jehovah had said that He would spare the city for ten, and since He did not spare it, there were not the ten.

[b] Here we have a clear statement that God saved Lot because of Abra-ham, despite the negative consequences that followed. Indeed, it would have been better for Lot to die in Sodom. I see a lesson for us here. Sometimes we pray 'for' someone based on our emotions, without thinking about God's will. And sometimes God answers those prayers, but the consequences are negative; it gets worse for the person for whom we prayed. We should always seek to know what the Father is doing (John 5:19). Further, when God chooses us, He does not turn us into robots, He respects our choices, but we and others must live with the consequences.

[c] The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah created the Dead Sea, totally altering the Jordan River valley. In order for all of this to enter the Historical Record, God saw fit to include Lot's story in this Record.

[d] Why was he afraid? Well, the pillar of salt would be very visible, as well as the ruins of Sodom, and Lot lost everything; He only had the clothes that he wore. Without being able to pay, there was no way to stay in the city. And the angel's command was to flee to the mountain. Even so, how did he survive? We are not told.

[e] Why did Lot not return to Abraham, who would surely care for him? Perhaps he was ashamed, and it would be too humiliating to return as a beggar. It is also possible that he became deeply depressed. His world had been totally destroyed; he lost everything, including his wife.

[f] The main function of women was to produce children, and there was no man for them. And Lot was already without a wife, and he had no way of having descendants. That is to say, male descendants, because he already had daughters.

she got up.[a] **34** And it came to pass the next day that the firstborn said to the younger, "Now then, I lay with my father last night; let us make him drink wine tonight also, and you go in and lie with him, that we may keep alive our father's progeny." **35** Then they made their father drink wine that night also; and the younger arose and lay with him; and he did not know when she lay down, nor when she got up. **36** Thus both of Lot's daughters were with child by their father. **37** The firstborn bore a son and called his name Moab; he is the father of the Moabites to this day. **38** And the younger also gave birth to a son and called his name Ben-Ammi; he is the father of the Ammonites to this day.[b]

Poor Abimelech!

20:1 And Abraham moved from there to the land of the south, and dwelt between Kadesh and Shur;[c] and he stopped in Gerar. **2** And Abraham said of Sarah his wife, "She is my sister". And Abimelech king of Gerar sent and took Sarah.[d] **3** But God came to Abimelech in a dream by night, and said to him: "Listen! You are about to die

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[a] That could not have been the normal procedure. One wonders if there was demonic participation.

[b] Lot should have died in Sodom.

[c] Abraham was probably sad and shaken by the destruction of Sodom and Lot as well, as far as he knew. It was natural for him to want to change the landscape.

[d] Our tendency is to say, "Not again!" But let's go slowly. First, Abra-ham was an ordinary human being, with the weaknesses we all have, not a superman (and he didn't have the Holy Spirit, like we do). Second, I would say that he was demonized. How so? Satan has always been committed to overthrowing the plan of salvation. He brought about the Flood with the hybrid race of the *Nephilim*. Since the spirit and life are transmitted by the male sperm, if Satan had succeeded in contaminating everyone, there would have been no 'seed of the woman' (3:15). The moment God chose Abram and the land of Canaan, Satan had a new target. From Deuteronomy 2:10-12 and 20-21 we can understand that already in the time of Abraham, and even before, other mixed races had emerged, with impressive size.

The severity used by God in the case of Sodom and Gomorrah indicates that the level of wickedness there was unusual. Although the text does not directly speak of giants in Sodom, we can deduce that there were, because Deuteronomy 2:10-12 says that Moab, who occupied what was left of the area controlled by Sodom and Gomorrah (which was not under the Dead

because of the woman you have taken, because she has a husband." **4** But Abimelech had not come near her, and he said: "Lord, will you actually kill a righteous nation? **5** Didn't he himself say to me, 'She is my sister'? And she, even she herself said, 'He is my brother'.[a] In the integrity of my heart and innocence of my hands I have done this."[b] **6** And God said to him in a dream: "Yes, I know that you did this in the integrity of your heart; so I myself kept you from sinning against me; that is why I did not allow you to touch her. **7** Now therefore, restore the man's wife; for he is a prophet,[c] and he will pray for you and you shall live. But if you do

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Sea), took the area from the *Emim* (who were the same size as the *Anakim*) – it appears that there were several mixed races of that type.

Sara was 90 years old; why did Abimelech become interested in such an old woman? I deduce from the Text that Sarah was already pregnant with Isaac, and Abraham absolutely should not have done what he did. Like in Egypt, he was expecting his wife to be taken; so why did he go there? The situation was so serious that God intervened energetically and without delay. Demons are cowards and like to attack the weak; and Abraham was emotionally shaken by Lot's death (as he had imagined). Do not forget that Satan had a special interest in preventing the birth of Isaac. But that is not all; when God decides to use a person in a special way, that person will be watched and attacked by Satan, without doubt, to this day! (Since he is not omnipresent, he presumably assigns a demon to watch the person.)

[a] By saying that, Sarah knew that she would be taken. So why did she do it?

[b] It seems that at that time it was normal for a king to take a woman just because he wanted to; it was part of the culture. That was why the king thought he was innocent.

[c] Romans 11:29–"God's gracious gifts and calling are irrevocable." That is, God does not revoke them; what we do with them is another story. Abraham's being a prophet was determined by God and did not depend on his behavior. I see an important principle here: there is a sense in which the office is more important than the person who has that office; that is, God respects the office in spite of the person. Abraham had behaved badly, but being a prophet, God would listen to his prayer. Aaron had serious problems, but he was the High-priest. Kings had authority, in spite of their personal lives. Peter had his problems, but Jesus gave him the keys. A judge has authority, in spite of who he is. And so on. The principle holds for the choice of Israel, as a people or nation. God chose to deliver His Oracles to the human race through them, and the Messiah, the Savior of the world, came through them. And there is the throne of David, that the Messiah has yet to sit upon, but He will.

not restore her, know that you and all your people will surely die."[a]

8 So Abimelech got up early in the morning, called all his servants, and spoke all these words in their hearing; and the men were very afraid. **9** Then Abimelech called Abraham and said to him, "What have you done to us? In what way have I offended you, that you should bring such a sin upon me and my kingdom? You have done things to me that ought not to be done."[b] **10** And Abimelech said further to Abraham, "What did you have in view to do such a thing?" **11** And Abraham said, "Because I thought, 'Surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me for my wife's sake'. **12** Yet she really is my sister, my father's daughter, but not my mother's daughter; and she became my wife. **13** And when God made me a wanderer from my father's house, I said to her, 'This is the kindness that you will do me in every place wherever we come; say of me, "He is my brother".'"

14 Then Abimelech took sheep and oxen, male and female slaves, and gave them to Abraham, and restored Sarah his wife to him. **15** And Abimelech said, "Indeed, my land is before you; live where it pleases you". **16** And to Sarah he said: "Indeed, I have given your brother a thousand *pieces* of silver. This is to make up for the offense against you in the sight of all those who are with you, and that all may consider you to be vindicated." **17** And Abraham prayed to God,[c] and God healed Abimelech, his wife, and his female servants, so that they had children. **18** For JEHOVAH had closed up every womb of the house of Abimelech because of Sarah, the wife of Abraham.

The birth of Isaac

21:1 And JEHOVAH visited Sarah, as he had said;[d] yes, JEHOVAH did for Sarah as he had promised. **2** And Sarah conceived, and bore

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[a] The threat could not have been more serious, total destruction. God was really bent on saving Sarah and Isaac.

[b] Absolutely; the man's complaint was more than justified.

[c] God had said that Abraham would pray for them, and he must have told Abraham what to pray for. In such a short time there would be no way to know about the closed wombs, by normal means.

[d] As is typical with Hebrew discourse structure, the topic changes without maintaining chronological sequence. Wanting to keep the sequence, the

Abraham a son in his old age, at the appointed time, which God had spoken to him. **3** And Abraham called the name of his son who was born to him, whom Sarah had borne to him, Isaac.[a] **4** And Abraham circumcised his son Isaac when he was eight days old, as God had commanded him. **5** Abra-ham was a hundred years old when Isaac his son was born to him. **6** And Sarah said, "God has made laughter for me; everyone who hears it will laugh with me". **7** And she added: "Who would have told Abraham that Sarah would nurse children? for I have borne him a son in his old age."[b]

8 And the child grew and was weaned; and Abraham made a great feast on the day that Isaac was weaned. **9** And Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian, whom she had borne to Abraham, mocking. **10** So she said to Abraham, "Send away this bondwoman and her son; for the son of this bondwoman shall not be heir with my son, with Isaac". **11** And the matter was very distressing to Abraham because of his son.[c] **12** But God said to Abraham: "Do not be distressed because of the boy, and your bondwoman. Whatever Sarah has said to you, listen to her voice, for in Isaac your seed shall be called. **13** Yet I will also make a nation of the bond-woman's son, because he is your descendant." **14** So Abraham got up early in the morning, took bread and a skin of water, and putting them on Hagar's shoulder he gave her the boy, and sent her away.[d] So she departed and wandered in the wilderness of Beersheba.

15 The water in the skin was finished, and she put the boy under one of the bushes. **16** Then she went and sat down about a bow shot away from him; for she said, "Let me not see the death of the boy". And sitting down she raised her voice and wept

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translation would be: And JEHOVAH had visited Sarah, as He had said; yes, JEHOVAH had done for Sarah as He had promised.

[a] God Himself had given that name in 17:19.

[b] Only God could have known that, and He did!

[c] All said and done, Ishmael was his son, and Abraham had affection for him (remember 17:18).

[d] That was tough! Poor Hagar was not to blame; she was merely a piece on the chessboard. She wandered around because she didn't know where to go. But God kept an eye on her.

sobbing.[a] **17** And God heard the voice of the boy,[b] and the Angel of God called to Hagar from the heavens, and said to her: “What is it, Hagar? Do not be afraid, for God has heard the voice of the boy where he is. **18** Get up, lift the boy up and take him by the hand; for I will make him a great nation." **19** And God opened her eyes, and she saw a well of water; and she went and filled the skin with water, and gave the boy a drink. **20** And God was with the boy;[c] and he grew up and dwelt in the wilderness, and became an archer.[d] **21** He dwelt in the wilderness of Paran; and his mother took him a wife from the land of Egypt.[e]

22 And it came to pass at that time that Abimelech, with Phichol the commander of his army, spoke to Abraham, saying: "God is with you in all that you do. **23** Now therefore, swear to me here by God that you will not deal falsely with me, nor with my son, nor with my grandson. According to the kindness with which I have treated you, you will treat me and the land wherein you have sojourned." **24** And Abraham said, "I will swear". **25** Then Abraham complained to Abimelech about a well of water, which Abimelech's servants had taken by force. **26** Then Abimelech said, "I do not know who has done this thing; and you also did not tell me, nor did I hear it until today". **27** Then Abraham took sheep and oxen and gave them to Abimelech; and they both made a covenant. **28** Then Abraham set seven ewe-lambs of the flock by themselves. **29** And Abimelech said to Abraham, "What do these seven ewe-lambs mean, which you have set by themselves?" **30** And he said, "You will receive these seven ewe-lambs from my hand, that they may be my witness that I have dug this well". **31** That is why the place was called Beersheba,[f] because they both swore there. **32** So

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[a] Poor thing! She had plenty of reason.

[b] We do not know what the boy said. But certainly the fact that he was rejected by his own father left a negative mark on his soul (remember the prophecy in 16:12). He was already a teenager.

[c] God took care of the boy, and of the mother too (He created the well of water), but that did not eliminate the suffering.

[d] He lived by hunting, a very different life from the one he had at his father's house.

[e] She was Egyptian and had relatives there.

[f] The name means: well of the oath.

they made a covenant in Beersheba. Then Abimelech got up, and Phichol the commander of his army, and they returned to the land of the Philistines. **33** And Abraham planted a tamarisk tree in Beersheba, and there he called on the name of JEHOVAH, the Everlasting God.[a] **34** And Abraham lived in the land of the Philistines many days.

Moriah!

22:1 And it came to pass after these things, that God tested Abraham, and said to him, "Abraham!" And he said, "Here I am". **2** Then He said: "Take now your son, your only son whom you love, Isaac, and go to the land of Moriah; and offer him there as a burnt offering[b] on one of the mountains, which I will indicate to you." **3** Then Abraham got up early in the morning, and saddled his donkey,[c] and took with him two of his young men, and Isaac his son; and he split wood for the burnt offering.[d] He got up and went to the place that God had told him. **4** On the third day Abraham lifted up his eyes and saw the place afar off. **5** And Abraham said to his young men, "Stay here with the donkey; I and the youth will go over there, where we will worship, and we will return to you."[e]

6 Then Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering, and laid

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[a] In Hebrew it is: *El Olam*.

[b] I think we can agree that the test was very hard, not to say cruel, but Abraham obeyed without delay, even though God bluntly stated that he was to kill his son. 2 Chronicles 3:1 records that Solomon built the temple on Mount Moriah. Golgotha is nearby.

[c] Presumably the donkey was used to carry the firewood, water, and food, not for Abraham to ride. They would be away from home for at least five days.

[d] Abraham did not know Moriah, and he did not know what kind of wood he would have there. Also, the firewood had to be dry, not green. The safe thing to do was to take adequate firewood.

[e] Notice the plural, "we will return". How could Isaac come back dead and burned? Hebrews 11:17-19 offers an inspired commentary on this test. "By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac; yes, he who had received the promises was about to sacrifice his only-begotten, of whom it had been said, 'Through Isaac will your seed be reckoned', calculating that God was indeed able to raise him from the dead; from where in fact he did received him, figuratively speaking." In fact, they returned together.

it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire,[a] and the knife in his hand, and they both went together. **7** Then Isaac spoke to Abraham his father, and said, "My father!" And he said, "Here I am, my son." Then he said, "We have the fire and the wood; but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" **8** And Abraham said, "God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering, my son."[b] And both went on together. **9** Then they came to the place of which God had told him. And Abraham built an altar there and placed the wood in order; and he bound Isaac his son[c] and laid him on the altar, upon the wood. **10** Then Abraham stretched out his hand and took the knife to kill his son.[d] **11** But the Angel of JEHOVAH called to him from the heavens, and said, "Abraham, Abraham!" So he said, "Here I am." **12** Then He said, "Do not lay your hand on the youth, nor do anything to him; for now I know that you are a God-fearer, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from me."[e]

13 Then Abraham lifted up his eyes and looked; and there, behind him, was a ram, caught by its horns in a thicket. So Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering, instead of his son. **14** And Abraham called the name of that place, JEHOVAH Jireh;[f] as it is said to this day: 'In the mount of JEHOVAH[g] it will be provided'. **15** Then the Angel of JEHOVAH called to Abraham a second time from the heavens, **16** and said: "By myself I have sworn, says JEHOVAH, 'Because you have done this thing, and have not withheld your son, your only son: **17** I will certainly bless you

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[a] Abraham must have taken a brazier with live coals when he left. They spent the night twice on the way and would want fire. And they renewed the embers.

[b] The answer was indirect. If Abraham really expected that God would provide the lamb, God waited until the last moment.

[c] Isaac was a young man strong enough to carry the wood. He could have defended himself by forbidding his father to tie him up, but he meekly submitted. Perhaps there was sovereign action of God in the case.

[d] Isaac would not be burned alive. In fact, none of the animal sacrifices were burned alive; they were killed first.

[e] Presumably God knew beforehand, but Abraham had to prove it. See James 2:21-24.

[f] The name means, Jehovah will provide.

[g] 'In the mount of JEHOVAH': that was a special mount. If Jehovah is present in His mount, there will be no lack of provision.

and multiply your offspring like the stars of the heavens, and like the sand on the seashore; and your descendants will possess the gate of their enemies. **18** Through your descendant all the ethnic nations of the earth shall be blessed; because you have obeyed my voice."[a] **19** Then Abraham returned to his young men, and they rose up and went together to Beersheba; and Abraham lived at Beersheba.

20 And it came to pass after these things that Abraham was told, saying, "Indeed, Milcah also has borne sons to your brother Nahor: **21 "**Uz his firstborn, Buz his brother, Kemuel the father of Aram, **22** Chesed, Hazo, Pildash, Jidlaph, and Bethuel." **23** And Bethuel begot Rebekah. Milcah bore those eight to Nahor, Abraham's brother. **24** And his concubine, whose name was Reumah, she also bore Tebah, Gaham, Tahash, and Maacah.[b]

Sarah's death and burial

23:1 Sarah lived one hundred and twenty-seven years; those were the years of Sarah's life.[c] **2** Sarah died in Kiriatharba (which is Hebron) in the land of Canaan; and Abraham went to mourn for Sarah, and to weep for her.[d] **3** Then Abraham stood up from beside his dead, and spoke to the sons of Heth, saying, **4** "I am a stranger and a sojourner among you; give me the possession[e] of a burying-place with you, that I may bury my dead out of sight". **5** And the sons of Heth answered Abraham, saying to him: **6** "Hear us, my

[a] But God had already promised all this, without preconditions. I wonder why God kept repeating the Promise.

[b] Nahor had twelve sons, quite apart from daughters. Evidently it was standard procedure to have more than one wife.

[c] If Sarah died at the age of 127, Abraham was 137 and Isaac was 37.

[d] If he came from Beersheba, he had a journey of about 60 km, in a straight line; they were living in separate places. Sarah certainly only learned the purpose of the trip to Moriah after the fact, when she asked her son for a report. Considering the whole idea to be abhor-rent, she may have rebelled against Jehovah and Abraham, and eventually moved to Hebron, a familiar place. Naturally, she was accompanied by enough servants and cattle to protect and maintain her. Surely Abraham was told that she was dying.

[e] He was asking to buy it.

lord;[a] you are a prince of God[b] among us. Bury your dead in the best of our burying-places. None of us will withhold from you his burying-place, so that you may bury your dead." **7** Then Abraham stood up and bowed down to the people of the land, to the sons of Heth. **8** And he spoke with them, saying: "If it is your wish that I bury my dead out of my sight, hear me and intercede for me with Ephron the son of Zohar, **9** that he may give to me the cave of Machpelah, which he has, which is at the end of his field. Let him give it to me at the full price as a possession of a burying-place among you."

10 Now Ephron was sitting in the midst of the sons of Heth. And Ephron the Hittite answered Abraham in the hearing of the sons of Heth, of all who entered the gate of his city, saying: **11** "No, my lord, hear me: I give you the field and the cave that is in it; I give it to you in the presence of the sons of my people; bury your dead." **12** Then Abraham bowed down before the people of the land; **13** and he spoke to Ephron in the hearing of the people of the land, saying, "If only you would hear me; I will give the price of the field; take it from me, that I may bury my dead there". **14** And Ephron answered Abraham, saying to him: **15** "My lord, hear me: the land is worth four hundred shekels of silver. What is that between me and you? So bury your dead."[c] **16** And Abraham listened to Ephron; and Abraham weighed out to Ephron the silver which he had named in the hearing of the sons of Heth, four hundred shekels of silver, standard among the merchants.

17 So the field of Ephron which was in Machpelah, oppo-site Mamre, the field and the cave that was in it, and all the trees that

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[a] One of the chiefs spoke for everyone.

[b] This is what the Text says. It could be 'of the gods' or seen as hyper-bole, but they well knew that Abraham was a servant of Jehovah, who blessed him exceedingly. There was an altar to Jehovah there.

[c] That whole conversation was certainly the way in which such a subject was conducted at the time. Abraham knew he would have to pay, and Ephron probably charged plenty, but Abraham could afford it, and that cave served the family for generations.

were in the field,[a] that were within all the surrounding borders, **18** were confirmed to Abraham as a possession before the sons of Heth, before all who entered the gate of his city. **19** And after this, Abraham buried Sarah his wife in the cave of the field of Mach-pelah, opposite Mamre, which is Hebron, in the land of Canaan. **20** So the field and the cave that is in it were deeded to Abraham by the sons of Heth for possession of a burying-place.

A bride for Isaac

24:1 Now Abraham was old, well advanced in age,[b] and JEHOVAH had blessed Abraham in all things. **2** And Abraham said to his slave, the oldest of his household, who ruled over all that he had: "Please put your hand under my thigh, **3** and I will make you swear by JEHOVAH, the God of heaven and the God of the earth, that you will not take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, among whom I dwell. **4** But you shall go to my country and to my kindred, to take a wife for my son Isaac." **5** And the slave said to him, "Perhaps the woman will not be willing to follow me into this land; must I take your son back to the land from which you came?" **6** And Abraham said to him: "You be careful that you do not take my son back there! **7** JEHOVAH, the God of heaven, who took me from my father's house and from my native land, who spoke to me and swore to me, saying, 'I will give this land to your descendants', He will send His angel before you, and you shall take a wife for my son from there. **8** If the woman does not want to follow you, then you will be free from this my oath; only do not take my son back there." **9** Then the slave put his hand under the thigh of Abraham his master, and swore to him concerning this matter.[c]

10 Then the slave took ten of his master's camels and set out, taking with him all manner of his master's good things.[d] He rose up

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[a] Why were the trees mentioned? I suppose they would hide the entrance to the cave, at least from a distance. There had to be a hill, for there to be a cave, and any travel would go around the hill.

[b] He was now 140.

[c] In that culture and at that time, this procedure must have been customary for solemn oaths.

[d] He wasn't going to get there empty-handed!

and left for Mesopotamia, to the city of Nahor.[a] **11** And he made the camels kneel outside the city, by a well of water, in the evening, the time when the women went out to draw water. **12** And he said: "O JEHOVAH, the God of my master Abraham! Please give me success today and show kindness to my master Abraham. **13** Finally, I am standing by the well of water, and the daughters of the men of the city are coming out to draw water. **14** Now let it be that the young woman to whom I say, 'Please lower your pitcher that I may drink', and she says, 'Drink, and I will also water your camels', let it be she whom you have appointed for your servant Isaac. And by this I will know that you have shown kindness to my master."[b]

15 And it happened, before he had finished speaking, that really, Rebekah, who was born to Bethuel the son of Milcah, the wife of Nahor, Abraham's brother, came out with her pitcher on her shoulder. **16** Now the young woman was very good looking, a virgin, whom no man had known; and she went down to the well, filled her pitcher and came back up. **17** Then the slave ran to meet her, and said, "Please let me drink a little water from your pitcher". **18** And she said, "Drink, my lord"; and she hurried and lowered her pitcher upon her hand and gave him a drink. **19** And when she had finished giving him a drink, she said, "I will also draw water for your camels, until they have finished drinking". **20** And she hurried and emptied her pitcher into the trough, ran again to the well to draw water, and drew for all his camels.[c] **21** And the man watched her in silence, to know whether JEHOVAH had prospered his journey or not.

22 So when the camels had finished drinking, the man took a nose-ring of gold, weighing half a shekel, and two gold bracelets for her wrists, weighing ten *shekels*. **23** And he said: "Whose daughter are you? Tell me, please, is there room in your father's house for us to lodge?" **24** And she said to him, "I am the daughter

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[a] Nahor had moved from Ur to the area of Haran; the town was called Paddan-Aram. “Mesopotamia” referred to the area between the two rivers: Tigris and Euphrates.

[b] The servant gave God plenty of detail!

[c] The girl was not afraid of work, and was helpful (perhaps God had helped too); for ten thirsty camels, that was a lot of water!

of Bethuel, the son of Milcah, whom she bore to Nahor".[a] **25** She also said to him, "We have plenty of straw and fodder, and room to lodge". **26** Then the man bowed down and worshipped JEHOVAH. **27** And he said, "Blessed be JEHOVAH, the God of my master Abraham, who has not forsaken His goodness and His truth toward my master; as for me, JEHOVAH has led me on the way to the house of my master's relatives." **28** So the young woman ran and told these things to her mother's household.

29 Now Rebekah had a brother, whose name was Laban; and Laban ran out to the man at the well. **30** When he saw the nose-ring, and the bracelets on his sister's wrists, and when he heard the words of his sister Rebekah, saying, "Thus the man spoke to me", then he went to the man, who was standing by the camels at the well.[b] **31** And he said: "Come in, blessed of JEHOVAH;[c] why are you standing outside? For I have prepared the house, and the place for the camels." **32** Then the man went into the house. And he [Laban] unloaded the camels, and gave straw and fodder to the camels, and water to wash his feet, and the feet of the men with him.[d]

33 Then food was placed before him to eat, but he said, "I will not eat until I have spoken my message". And *Laban* said, "Well speak!" **34** So he said: "I am Abraham's slave. **35** JEHOVAH has blessed my master very much, and he has become great. Yes, He has given him flocks and herds, silver and gold, male and female slaves, and camels and donkeys. **36** And Sarah my master's wife bore a son to my master when she was old; to whom he has given all that he has. **37** And my master made me swear, saying: 'You shall not take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, in

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[a] Bethuel was the eighth son of Nahor by Milcah. Nahor was sixty years older than Abram, and Abram was a hundred years old when Isaac was born. Even though Bethuel was the eighth son, he could easily have been sixty years older than Isaac, or even more. Isaac was forty at the time, which would give Bethuel a hundred years. Perhaps that was why Laban conducted the business, rather than his father.

[b] Well, well, Laban had his problems, but he wasn't stupid. Someone who paid for a small service with gold and who had ten camels – Laban wasted no time!

[c] Note that Laban used God's personal name.

[d] Carrying so much wealth, he certainly had armed guards, maybe five or six.

whose land I dwell. **38** Rather, you shall go to my father's house, and to my family, and take a wife for my son.' **39** Then I said to my master, 'Perhaps the woman will not follow me'. **40** And he said to me: 'JEHOVAH, before whom I walk,[a] will send His angel with you, and prosper your way. And you shall take a wife for my son from my family, from my father's house. **41** When you have come to my family, then you will be released from my oath; if they do not give one to you, you will be released from my oath.'

42 "Now today I came to the well, and said: 'O JEHOVAH, the God of my master Abraham! Please prosper my way in which I go. **43** As you see, I am standing by the well of water; let it be therefore that the young woman who comes out to draw water, to whom I say, "Please let me drink a little water from your pitcher"**, 44** and she says to me, "Drink, and I will also draw for your camels"; let her be the woman whom JEHOVAH has appointed for my master's son.' **45** Before I had finished speaking in my heart, yes indeed, Rebekah came out with her pitcher on her shoulder, went down to the well, and drew. Then I said to her, 'Please give me a drink'. **46** And she hurried, lowered her pitcher from her shoulder, and said, 'Drink, and I will also water your camels'; so I drank, and she also watered the camels. **47** Then I asked her, and said, 'Whose daughter are you?' And she said, 'Bethuel's, a son of Nahor, whom Milcah bore to him'. So I put the ring on her nose, and the bracelets on her wrists. **48** And I bowed down and worshipped JEHOVAH, and blessed JEHOVAH, the God of my master Abraham, who had led me in the way of truth to take the daughter of my master's brother for his son. **49** So now, if you will deal kindly and faithfully with my master, tell me; and if not, tell me, that I may turn to the right or to the left."

50 Then Laban and Bethuel answered and said: "The thing has come from JEHOVAH;[b]

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[a] What does "before whom I walk" mean? God is watching everything that we do, whether we keep that in mind, or not. But here Abraham affirms that Jehovah has a special interest in the case.

[b] Why did God record this repetitive repetition, which might seem unnecessary to us? It seems to me that it was to emphasize Jehovah's direct participation from the beginning to the end of the story, which, by the way, convinced

we cannot speak to you bad or good.[a] **51** Here is Rebekah before you; take her and go, and let her become the wife of your master's son, as JEHOVAH has spoken." **52** When Abraham's slave heard their words, he bowed down to the earth before JEHOVAH. **53** And the slave brought out vessels of silver, and vessels of gold, and garments, and gave them to Rebekah; and he gave precious things to her brother and to her mother.[b] **54** Then they ate and drank,[c] he and the men who were with him, and spent the night. When they got up in the morning, he said, "Send me away to my master". **55** But her brother and her mother said, "Let the young woman stay with us at least ten days, then she may go". **56** But he said to them, "Do not detain me, since JEHOVAH has prospered my way; send me away, that I may go to my master".[d] **57** So they said, "We will call the young woman and ask her personally". **58** Then they called Rebekah and said to her, "Will you go with this man?" And she said, "I will go!"[e]

59 Then they sent away Rebekah their sister and her nurse, and Abraham's slave and his men. **60** And they blessed Rebekah and said to her, "Our sister, may you become the mother of thousands of ten-thousands, and may your descendants possess the gate of those who hate them!" **61** Then Rebekah and her maidservants[f] got up, mounted the camels, and followed the man. So the slave took Rebekah and departed. **62** Now Isaac had come

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Bethuel and Laban. They recognized Jehovah's hand and submitted without protest.

[a] This seems to be an expression meaning that they really did not have a choice, or voice, in the matter. Jehovah had spoken, and that was that.

[b] All of that certainly helped the environment!

[c] That whole conversation didn't take that long; so they did not really suffer because of the delay.

[d] For him it would be ten days lost. He wanted to give the woman to Isaac as soon as possible.

[e] Well, for the first time in her life Rebecca had gold. At that time, marriage was based on financial condition and social position, and not on emotion or passion (although love could come). If she was still single, it was because she had no attractive option near bye. So she gladly said, "I will go!"

[f] "Maidservants" is plural, so that in addition to the nurse there was at least one more. The number would be limited by the number of camels available.

from *Beer-lahai-roi*,[a] for he dwelt in the land of the south.[b] **63** And Isaac went out into the field to meditate in the evening; and he lifted up his eyes and looked, and the camels were coming! **64** Rebekah also had looked up and seen Isaac, and she dismounted from the camel. **65** For she had said to the slave, "Who is that man who is walking in the field to meet us?" And the slave said, "He is my master". Then she took her veil and covered herself **66** And the slave told Isaac all the things that he had done. **67** Then Isaac brought her into the tent of his mother Sarah; and he took Rebekah and she became his wife, and he loved her. Thus Isaac was comforted for his mother.[c]

The death of Abraham

25:1 Now Abraham had taken another wife, and her name was Keturah.[d] **2** And she bore him Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, Midian, Ishbak and Shuah. **3** And Jokshan begot Sheba and Dedan; and the sons of Dedan were Asshurim, Letushim and Leummim. **4** And the sons of Midian were Ephah, Epher, Hanoch, Abidah, and Eldaah. All these were sons of Keturah. **5** And Abraham gave all that he had to Isaac; **6** But to the sons of Abraham's concubines that he had, Abraham gave gifts; and while he was still alive he sent them away from his son Isaac and sent them eastward to an eastern land.[e]

7 These are the days of the years of Abraham's life which he lived, one hundred and seventy-five years. **8** And Abraham expired and died in a good old age, aged and full of years, and he was

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[a] The name means: the well of him who lives and sees me.

[b] He would have come to Beersheba, where his father was living, for verse 67 mentions "the tent of his mother Sarah". Although Sarah had died in Hebron, she would have had a tent in Beersheba. But this was several years after her death; why was her tent still available?

[c] Since his mother had died three years earlier, he must have really missed her.

[d] 1 Chronicles 1:32 says that Keturah was Abraham's concubine, and verse 6 here mentions "concubines", plural. Hagar was a concubine, no doubt. If Sarah rebelled against Abraham and Jehovah because of Moriah, Abraham may have begun with Keturah before Sarah's death. What is certain is that Sarah was not with Abraham when she died.

[e] They may have gone together, as a family. Since they had certainly been circumcised, and were Abraham’s descendants, I wonder what became of them. The Midianites are mentioned.

gathered to his people. **9** And his sons Isaac and Ishmael buried him in the cave of Machpelah, in the field of Ephron the son of Zohar the Hittite, opposite Mamre, **10** the field which Abraham had bought from the sons of Heth. That is where Abraham was buried, and Sarah his wife. **11** And it came to pass, after Abraham's death, that God blessed Isaac his son; and Isaac dwelt by the well *Beer-lahai-roi*.

12 Now these are the generations of Ishmael, Abraham's son, whom Hagar the Egyptian, Sarah's maidservant, bore to Abraham. **13** These are the names of the sons of Ishmael, name by name, according to their generations: the firstborn of Ishmael was Nebaioth; then Kedar, Adbeel, Mibsam, **14** Mishma, Dumah, Massa, **15** Hadad, Tema, Jetur, Naphish, and Kedemah. **16** These were the sons of Ishmael, and these were their names in their settlements and in their camps; twelve chiefs according to their clans. **17** These were the years of Ishmael's life, one hundred and thirty-seven years;[a] and he expired and died and was gathered to his people. **18** (They dwelt from Havilah as far as Shur, which is opposite Egypt, as one goes toward Asshur; he had settled over against all his brothers.[b])

19 Now these are the generations of Isaac, Abraham's son: Abraham begot Isaac. **20** And Isaac was forty years old when he took Rebekah the daughter of Bethuel, an Aramean of Paddan-Aram, the sister of Laban the Aramean, to be his wife. **21** And Isaac pleaded with JEHOVAH on behalf of his wife, because she was barren;[c] and JEHOVAH was entreated by him, and Rebekah his wife conceived. **22** And the babies struggled together inside her. So she said, "I wonder what is happening to me". And she went to ask JEHOVAH.[d] **23** And JEHOVAH said to her: "There are two nations in your womb, yes, two peoples will be separated from your body; one

[a] Since Isaac died at the age of 180, he lived 43 years longer than did Ishmael.

[b] These would have to be Keturah's sons, and this is the last mention they receive, except for the Midianites (and the Medanites, in the Hebrew Text).

[c] Since Isaac was sixty years old when the twins were born, Rebekah had been married for nineteen years when she conceived. It was natural for Isaac to plead with Jehovah, for without a son the promises could not be fulfilled.

[d] She did the right thing, inquiring of Jehovah, and He answered!

people will be stronger than the other people; and the older will serve the younger."[a]

24 And when her days were fulfilled to give birth, indeed, she had twins in her womb. **25** And the first came out red, his whole body like a hairy garment; so they called his name Esau.[b] **26** And afterward his brother came out, with his hand grasping Esau's heel; so his name was called Jacob.[c] Isaac was sixty years old[d] when she bore them. **27** And the boys grew up, and Esau became an expert hunter, a man of the field; but Jacob was a quiet man, dwelling in tents.

28 Isaac loved Esau because he liked game, but Rebekah loved Jacob. **29** Now Jacob had prepared a stew; and Esau came in from the field, and he was faint from hunger. **30** And Esau said to Jacob, "Quick, let me eat of that red stuff, the red stuff over there, because I'm famished!" That is why his name was called Edom.[e] **31** Then Jacob said, "Sell me your birthright today". **32** And Esau said, "Hey, I am dying; so what *good will* the birthright do me?" **33** And Jacob said, "Swear to me today". So he swore to him, and sold his birthright to Jacob. **34** And Jacob gave Esau bread and the stew of lentils; and he ate and drank, and got up and left. Thus Esau despised the birthright.

God blesses Isaac

26:1 And there was a famine in the land, besides the first famine, which was in the days of Abraham; and Isaac went to Abimelech king of the Philistines, to Gerar. **2** And JEHOVAH appeared to him, and said: "Do not go down to Egypt; live in the land that I indicate to you. **3** Stay in this land, and I will be with you and bless you; for I will give all these lands to you and your descendants, and will establish the oath which I swore to Abraham your father. **4** And I will multiply your descendants like the stars of heaven, and will give all these lands to your descendants; and through your descendant

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[a] She certainly told Isaac this, so that he knew that Jehovah had chosen the younger.

[b] The name means: hairy.

[c] The name means: place-taker.

[d] Since he died at 180, he lived for 120 more years.

[e] The name means: red.

all the nations of the earth shall bless themselves;[a] **5** For Abra-ham obeyed my voice, and kept my charge, my precepts, my statutes, and my laws."[b] **6** So Isaac dwelt in Gerar.

7 And the men of the place asked about his wife, and he said, "She is my sister";[c] for he was afraid to say, "She is my wife", 'lest the men of the place kill me for Rebekah'; because she was good looking. **8** Now it came to pass, when he had been there a long time, that Abimelech king of the Philistines looked through a window, and saw Isaac caressing Rebekah his wife![d] **9** Then Abimelech called Isaac, and said, "Indeed, she is your wife; so how could you say, 'She is my sister'?" And Isaac said to him, "Because I said, 'Lest I die because of her'." **10** And Abimelech said: "What is this that you have done to us? One of the people could easily have lain with your wife,[e] and you would have brought guilt upon us." **11** And Abimelech charged all the people, saying, "Whoever touches this man or his wife will surely be put to death!"

12 Then Isaac sowed in that land, and reaped that same year a hundredfold, because JEHOVAH was blessing him. **13** And the man became great, and grew rich, until he became very rich; **14** for he

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[a] If I am not mistaken, the verb here is in the reflexive voice, which is why I translated it that way. When someone surrenders to Sovereign Jesus, he receives God's protection and blessing. So, we could say that this person, by making this decision, is blessing himself. The same thing happens when a nation decides to obey God's laws.

[b] We have no record of all these things; God must have given him instructions that are not in the Text. In fact, during the hundred years that Abraham dwelt in the land of Canaan, certainly much more happened than is reported in the Text.

[c] Not again! In Abraham's case, it was a half-truth, but here it was simply a lie. Like Abraham, Isaac was offering his wife to them to save his own skin!

[d] This case is curious. For the king to see what he saw, he had to be on a second or third floor. That the king's palace had more than one floor would not be surprising, but how could Isaac's tent be so close to the palace? How was there even room for that, and how was it allowed?

[e] "One of the people" – if it was the same Abimelech who suffered with Abraham, he had already been 'scalded' and would not repeat it; but even if it was a son, he was already grown when the affair with Abra-ham happened, and he would not have forgotten. So he himself would not touch Rebekah, but that would not necessarily hold for all his men.

had possessions of flocks, and possessions of herds, and many slaves; so that the Philistines envied him. **15** And all the wells which his father's slaves had dug in the days of his father Abraham, the Philistines stopped up and filled with earth.[a] **16** Then Abimelech said to Isaac, "Depart from us; for you are more powerful than we are."[b]

17 So Isaac departed from there, encamped in the valley of Gerar, and dwelt there. **18** And Isaac dug again the wells of water which they had dug in the days of Abraham his father, and which the Philistines had filled up after the death of Abraham; and he called them by the names which his father had called them. **19** Isaac's slaves also dug in an arroyo and found there a well of living water. **20** But the shepherds of Gerar contended with Isaac's shepherds, saying, "The water is ours!" So he called the name of the well Esek,[c] because they contended with him.[d] **21** Then they dug another well, and they quarreled over it also; so he called its name Sitnah.[e] **22** And he moved from there and dug another well, and they did not quarrel over it; so he called its name Rehoboth,[f] and said, "For now JEHOVAH has made room for us, and we shall be fruitful in the land."

23 Then he went up from there to Beersheba.[g] **24** And JEHOVAH appeared to him that very night, and said: "I am the God of your father Abraham; do not be afraid, for I am with you; and I will bless you and multiply your descendants, because of Abraham my servant." **25** Then he built an altar there, and called on the name of JEHOVAH, and pitched his tent there; and Isaac's slaves dug a well there.

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[a] Water was difficult to find, and therefore precious. To stop up a well would be nonsense. The Philistines must have been really mad, or maybe demonized.

[b] Indeed, Isaac's presence was already problematic.

[c] The name means: contention.

[d] At least they didn't stop it up! But it appears that the people of the valley were not enjoying Isaac's presence either.

[e] The name means: opposition.

[f] The name means: space.

[g] Isaac knew this place very well; it was there that his father lived, and it was there that he received Rebekah.

26 Then Abimelech came to him from Gerar, with Ahuzzath his aide, and Phichol the commander of his army. **27** And Isaac said to them, "Why have you come to me, since you hate me and sent me away from you?" **28** And they said: "We have clearly seen that JEHOVAH is with you. So we said: 'Let there now be an oath between us, between us and you; and let us make a covenant with you: **29** that you will do us no harm, since we have not touched you, and since we have only done you good, and let you go in peace'—you being the blessed one of JEHOVAH."[a] **30** Then he made a feast for them, and they ate and drank. **31** And they got up early in the morning and swore an oath with one another; then Isaac sent them away, and they departed from him in peace. **32** And it came to pass that same day, that Isaac's slaves came and told him about the well which they had dug, and said to him, "We have found water". **33** And he called its name Shibah; so the name of the city is Beersheba, to this day.[b]

34 Now when Esau was forty years old, he took as wives Judith the daughter of Beeri the Hittite, and Basemath the daughter of Elon the Hittite. **35** And they were a grief of spirit to Isaac and Rebekah.

Jacob is blessed

27:1 Now it came to pass, when Isaac was old, and his eyes became so dim that he could not see, that he called Esau his older son and said to him, "My son". And he said to him, "Here I am".
2 And he said: "The fact is, I am old; I do not know the day of my

[a] Notice that they called God by his proper name, Jehovah. "You are the blessed one of JEHOVAH"–they understood that Jehovah was responsible for Isaac's extraordinary prosperity. But the fact that they went to Beersheba to ask for an alliance showed a concern of some size; they didn't want to fight with that God! Perhaps it would be better to say that they were acknowledging and even worshipping Jehovah. It is reminiscent of Romans 2:14-15.

[b] Now Abraham had already dug a well there and named it Beersheba. But Abraham had died, and Isaac was absent for a time. The inhabitants of the place would have taken the well, a logical thing, and Isaac was forced to dig another one, giving it the same name that his father had given.

death.[a] **3** Now therefore, please take your weapons, your quiver, and your bow, and go out to the field, and hunt game for me. **4** And make me tasty food, such as I love,[b] and bring it to me that I may eat; that my soul may bless you before I die."[c]

5 Now Rebekah heard what Isaac said to his son Esau. And Esau went to the field to hunt game and to bring it. **6** Then Rebekah spoke to Jacob her son, saying: "Indeed, I heard your father speaking to your brother Esau saying, **7** 'Bring me game, and make me tasty food, that I may eat, and bless you before JEHOVAH before I die.'[d] **8** Now therefore, my son, hear my voice in what I command you: **9** Go now to the flock, and bring me from there two good kids of the goats, and I will make tasty food for your father, such as he loves. **10** And you shall take it to your father, that he may eat it, and that he may bless you before his death." **11** Then Jacob said to Rebekah his mother: "You know that Esau my brother is a hairy man, and I am a smooth man. **12** Perhaps my father will feel me, and I will seem to be a deceiver to him; and I will bring a curse upon me, and not a blessing." **13** And his mother said to him, "Your curse be upon me, my son; only listen to my voice and go, get them for me". **14** And he went and got them, and brought them to his mother; and his mother made tasty food, such as his father loved. **15** Then Rebekah took the best clothes of her older son Esau, that were with her in the house, and put them on Jacob her younger son. **16** And she put the skins of the kids of the goats on his hands, and on the smooth of his neck. **17** And she gave the tasty food and the bread which she had prepared into the hand of her son Jacob.

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[a] He was 137 years old and died at 180. But being completely blind, life was no longer 'fun'.

[b] Being blind, the pleasure he still had was eating.

[c] That was serious. Isaac well knew that Jehovah had said that the elder would serve the younger, and he must have heard of the episode when Esau sold the birthright to Jacob. Therefore, the decision to give Esau the greatest blessing was a rebellion against Jehovah, a fact that he came to recognize (verse 33).

[d] Rebekah understood what Isaac was about to do, and she knew that it represented rebellion against Jehovah's stated will. Whether or not we agree with what she did, the fact is that God used her to thwart Isaac's plan.

18 So he went to his father, and said, "My father!" And he said, "Here I am; who are you, my son?" **19** And Jacob said to his father, "I am Esau your firstborn; I have done as you said to me; please get up, sit and eat of my game, that your soul may bless me." **20** But Isaac said to his son, "How is it that you found it so quickly, my son?"[a] And he said, "Because JEHOVAH your God brought it to me".[b] **21** And Isaac said to Jacob, "Come near now, that I may feel you, my son; whether you are really my son Esau or not". **22** So Jacob went near to Isaac his father, and he felt him and said, "The voice is the voice of Jacob, but the hands are the hands of Esau".[c] **23** And he did not recognize him, because his hands were hairy like the hands of Esau his brother; so he blessed him. **24** And he said, "Are you really my son Esau?" And he said, "I am". **25** Then he said, "Bring it to me and I will eat of my son's game, that my soul may bless you". So he took it to him, and he ate; he also brought him wine, and he drank. **26** Then his father Isaac said to him, "Now come and kiss me, my son".[d] **27** And he came and kissed him; and he smelled the smell of his clothes, blessed him and said: "Indeed, the smell of my son is like the smell of a field which JEHOVAH has blessed. **28** So then, may God give you of the dew of the heavens, and of the fatness of the earth, and plenty of grain and wine. **29** Let nations serve you, and peoples bow down to you. Be a ruler to your brothers, and may your mother's sons bow down to you. Cursed be those who curse you, and blessed be those who bless you."

30 And it came to pass, as soon as Isaac had finished blessing Jacob, and Jacob had scarcely left the presence of Isaac his father, that Esau his brother came in from his hunting. **31** And he also made tasty food, and brought it to his father; and said to his father, "Let my father get up and eat of his son's game, that your soul may

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[a] Isaac was suspicious; the difficulty was the voice. Even if Jacob tried to copy Esau's way of speaking, he could hardly copy it perfectly, precisely because of the quality of the voice.

[b] That was a lie, pure and simple! It took a deal of 'daring' to introduce Jehovah into the plot.

[c] It was the voice, but how could Jacob's hands be hairy?

[d] Isaac was reluctant, he was still suspicious.

bless me". **32** And his father Isaac said to him, "Who are you?" And he said, "I am your son, your firstborn, Esau". **33** Then Isaac trembled violently,[a] and said: "Who then was the one who hunted game and brought it to me? And I ate from all before you came, and blessed him; and indeed he shall be blessed!"[b]

34 When Esau heard his father's words, he cried out with a great and very bitter cry, and said to his father, "Bless me, me also, my father!" **35** But he said, "Your brother came with deceit and took your blessing". **36** Then he said: "That is why his name is called Jacob, for he has supplanted me these two times. He took my birthright, and now he has taken my blessing!"[c] And he said, "Have you not reserved a blessing for me?" **37** Then Isaac answered and said to Esau: "Indeed, I have made him your ruler, and all his brothers I have given to him as servants; I have sustained him with grain and wine. What then can I do for you, my son?" **38** And Esau said to his father: "Do you have only one blessing, my father? Bless me, me also, my father!" And Esau lifted up his voice, and wept. **39** Then Isaac his father answered and said to him: "Yes, your dwelling will have the fatness of the earth, and the dew from the heavens above. **40** And you shall live by your sword, and serve your brother; but when you become free, you will shake off his yoke from your neck."

41 So Esau hated Jacob because of the blessing with which his father had blessed him; and Esau said in his heart, 'The days of

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[a] The Hebrew expression here is very strong; Isaac was terrified, realizing that he was in rebellion against Jehovah.

[b] Isaac recognized that, even though he was deceived, he did the right thing: he blessed Jacob; and he declared that it would remain so. Hebrews 12:16-17 affirms this: "Let no one be a fornicator or worldly like Esau, who in exchange for one meal gave up his birthright. Because you do indeed know that afterward, when he wanted to inherit the blessing, he was rejected; he found no place for a change of mind, though he sought it diligently with tears." Neither Isaac nor God changed his mind; Jacob was in and Esau was out.

[c] Esau was the kind of person who never takes responsibility for what he does; he always blames others, or the circumstances. Jacob did not 'take' the birthright, Esau sold it, knowing what he was doing. Since he had sold the birthright, he was no longer entitled to the blessing.

mourning for my father are at hand; then I will kill my brother Jacob'. **42** And the words of Esau her older son were told to Rebekah,[a] so she sent and called her younger son Jacob, and said to him: "Look, your brother Esau is comforting himself concerning you, intending to kill you. **43** Now therefore, my son, listen to my voice in your own interest: arise and flee to Laban my brother, to Haran.[b] **44** And stay with him a few days, until the fury of your brother turns away;[c] **45** until your brother's anger turns away from you, and he forgets what you have done to him. Then I will send to bring you back from there.[d] Why should I be bereaved of you both on the same day?" **46** And Rebekah said to Isaac, "I am weary of my life because of the daughters of Heth; if Jacob takes a wife of the daughters of Heth, such as the daughters of the land, what *good will* life be to me?"

Jacob Goes to Paddan-Aram

28.1 Then Isaac called Jacob and blessed him, and charged him, saying: "You must not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan. **2** Arise, go to Paddan-Aram, to the house of Bethuel your mother's father, and take a wife for yourself from there, from the daughters of Laban your mother's brother.[e] **3** May God Almighty bless you and make you fruitful and multiply you, so that you may become a community of peoples. **4** And may He give you the blessing of

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[a] Surely Esau had spoken of his purpose openly, somewhere (perhaps to his women), which made it possible for it to get to Rebekah.

[b] 28:2 says that Laban lived in Paddan-Aram; Haran was the name of the area.

[c] Rebekah was afraid that Esau would not wait; taken by fury, he could act at any moment.

[d] But she never saw Jacob again. That is a deduction, based on her statement that she would send for him. If she ever did send for him, he would not have been able to return during the first fourteen years because he was paying for his wives. Curiously, her death is not recorded. What is recorded is the death of her nurse (Genesis 35:8). It is also recorded that she was buried in Machpelah (Genesis 49:31). Esau must not have liked his mother very much, and Isaac, being blind, could do nothing.

[e] Evidently, they were not yet aware of the dangers of inbreeding, and it was a tradition within the family. This may be why Sarai and Rebekah were barren, as was Rachel. With Jacob things began to change, since two of his four wives were from outside the family. As for Jacob's sons, none of them married within the family.

Abraham, to you and your descendants with you, that you may possess the land of your sojournings, which God gave to Abraham."[a] **5** So Isaac sent Jacob away, and he went to Paddan-Aram, to Laban son of Bethuel the Aramean, the brother of Rebekah, the mother of Jacob and Esau.[b]

6 (Now Esau saw that Isaac had blessed Jacob and sent him away to Paddan-Aram to take a wife for himself from there, and that as he blessed him he gave him a charge, saying, "You must not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan"; **7** and that Jacob had obeyed his father and his mother and gone to Paddan-Aram. **8** Esau also saw that the daughters of Canaan were not acceptable to Isaac his father, **9** so Esau went to Ishmael and took Mahalath the daughter of Ishmael, Abraham's son, the sister of Nebaioth,[c] to be his wife, besides the wives he had.)

10 So Jacob left Beersheba and went toward Haran.[d] **11** And he came to a certain place, and there he spent the night, because the sun had set. And he took one of the stones of that place and put it at his head and lay down in that place. **12** And he dreamed, and behold, a ladder set up on the earth, and its top reached to heaven; and indeed, the angels of God were ascending and descending on it.[e] **13** And behold, Jehovah stood above it and said, "I am Jehovah, the God of Abraham your father and the God of

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[a] Isaac passed Abraham's blessing on to Jacob. He understood that God had used Rebekah's 'trick' to circumvent his own rebellion.

[b] Esau married when he was forty (26:34), and Isaac was a hundred. Now Isaac was 137, and so the twins were 77, and Esau probably had grown children. Therefore he would have had his own little com-pound, some distance from Isaac's. Jacob probably left while it was dark, and it was some time before Esau learned what had happened.

[c] Mahalath was the sister of Nebaioth. 25:13 says that Nebaioth was the firstborn of Ishmael.

[d] It appears that Paddan-Aram was located in the area dominated by the city of Haran, where Terah died. Nahor must have moved there from Ur. In 24:10 Abraham's servant went to Mesopotamia, the area where Haran was located. (Mesopotamia means 'between rivers', the area between the Tigris and the Euphrates.)

[e] The text states that they were angels. It was certainly the first time, but not the last, that Jacob saw an angel (Mahanaim).

Isaac;[a] I will give the land on which you lie to you and your descendants. **14** And your descendants will be as the dust of the earth; and you will spread out to the west, to the east, to the north and to the south; and in you and in your descendant[b] all the families of the earth will be blessed. **15** And behold, I am with you, and will keep you wherever you go, and I will bring you back to this land; for I will not leave you until I have done what I have spoken to you." **16** Then Jacob awoke from his sleep and said, "Surely Jehovah is in this place, and I did not know it". **17** And he was afraid[c] and said, "How fearsome is this place! This is none other than the house of God; and this is the gate of heaven."[d]

18 Then Jacob rose early in the morning, took the stone that he had placed at his head and set it up as a pillar, and poured oil on top of it.[e] **19** And he called the name of that place Bethel,[f] although the name of that city at first was Luz. **20** Then Jacob made a vow, saying, "If God will be with me, and keep me in this way that I am going, and give me bread to eat and clothes to wear,[g] **21** so that I return to my father's house in peace, then Jehovah will be my God.[h] **22** And this stone that I have set up as a pillar will become

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[a] Jehovah introduced himself and identified himself. But why did God appear to Jacob at this moment? Jacob was fleeing, carrying only what he had on his back. At the age of 77, it was the most depressing moment of his life. It was a strategic moment for God. The promise was detailed, and it was one-sided.

[b] The Hebrew text has 'seed' both here and at the beginning of the verse, and the word can be understood as singular or plural. It is through the Savior that all the families of the earth are blessed.

[c] When God appears, it usually causes fear. But it is also true that Jacob had not been relating to Him, which we can understand from verse 21.

[d] There was even a ladder to climb up! But of course it wasn't physical. It was a Sovereign event that was not repeated.

[e] He was travelling 'light', but he had some 'oil', presumably vegetable. Why would he be carrying oil?

[f] Bethel means 'the house of God'. From Beersheba to Bethel was about 100 km, in a straight line. Jacob walked a long way that day. He was running away; it was still dark when he left, and he walked as fast as he could all day, stopping when there was no more light for walking.

[g] Wow, he only asked for food and clothes, the basics to survive. Did he not even have money to buy food?

[h] He repeated some of what Jehovah had said. Jehovah introduced Himself as the God of Abraham and Isaac, and here Jacob wants to be added to that list.

God's house;[a] and of all that You give me I will surely give a tenth to You."[b]

Jacob arrives and marries

29.1 Then Jacob continued his journey and came to the land of the people of the east. **2** And he looked, and there was a well in the field, and furthermore, three flocks of sheep were lying by it!—for they watered the flocks from that well; and there was a large stone on the well's mouth. **3** (For all the flocks would be gathered there; and they would roll the stone away from the well's mouth, water the sheep, and then put the stone back in its place on the well's mouth.) **4** And Jacob said to them, "My brethren, where are you from?" And they said, "We are from Haran". **5** And he said to them, "Do you know Laban the son of Nahor?" And they said, "We know him". **6** And he said to them, "Is he well?" And they said, "He is well. And look, his daughter Rachel is coming with the sheep." **7** Then he said, "Look, the sun is still high; it is not the time to gather the cattle; water the sheep, and go and feed them." **8** But they said, "We cannot, until all the flocks are gathered and they roll the stone away from the well's mouth; then we water the sheep."[c]

9 While he was still talking with them, Rachel came with her father's sheep, for she was a shepherdess. **10** It happened, when Jacob saw Rachel, the daughter of Laban his mother's brother, and the sheep of Laban his mother's brother, that Jacob went and rolled the stone from the well's mouth and watered the sheep of Laban his mother's brother.[d] **11** Then Jacob kissed Rachel and lifted up his voice and wept.[e] **12** And Jacob told Rachel that he was her

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[a] How so, 'house of God'? Can a stone be a house of God? Or did he want it to be a place where he could always meet with God?

[b] Dear me, Jacob thought that he could negotiate with God! Since he knew Abraham personally, he must have learned the idea of tithing from him, when he met Melchizedek. But, how could he give that tithe to God? In fact, that tithe is never mentioned again. Up to the last clause, Jacob addressed God indirectly, but then switched to direct address.

[c] This is curious; in verse 10 Jacob removes the stone alone. It seems that this was an arbitrary rule among them.

[d] The Hebrew text repeats the phrase.

[e] He wept in shame and bitterness. Abraham's servant had come with ten camels, gold and silver; Jacob came with nothing. He had come looking for a

father's brother, the son of Rebecca. So she ran and told her father.[a]

13 So when Laban heard the news about Jacob his sister's son, he ran to meet him, embraced him and kissed him, and brought him into his house. And he told Laban all these things.[b] **14** Then Laban said to him, "Surely you are my bone and my flesh". And he stayed with him a full month. **15** Then Laban said to Jacob, "Should you serve me for nothing because you are my brother? Tell me, what should your wages be?" **16** Now Laban had two daughters; the name of the older was Leah, and the name of the younger was Rachel. **17** Leah's eyes were dull, but Rachel was beautiful in body and appearance. **18** Now Jacob loved Rachel; so he said, "I will serve you seven years for Rachel your younger daughter".[c] **19** And Laban said, "It is better that I give her to you than that I should give her to another man; stay with me." **20** So Jacob served seven years for Rachel, and they seemed to him only a few days,[d] because of the love he had for her.

21 Then Jacob said to Laban, "Give me my wife, for my days are fulfilled, so that I may go in to her".[e] **22** So Laban gathered all the men of the place together and made a feast. **23** But in the evening, he took his daughter Leah and brought her to Jacob, and he went in to her. **24** (Laban also gave his maidservant Zilpah to his daughter Leah, as her maidservant.) **25** When morning came, oh no, it was Leah![f] Then he said to Laban, "How is it that you have

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wife, but he had nothing with which to pay (and he was 77 years old). In 32:10 he himself said, "I crossed this Jordan with my staff". Everything we do has consequences. Jacob obtained Abraham's blessing in a dubious way, but he paid dearly for it.

[a] She left the sheep with Jacob.

[b] He must have told enough of the story to explain his presence there, under those circumstances.

[c] Why did Jacob offer seven years? I believe Laban would have accepted less. His daughters were stranded.

[d] The phrase, "seemed to him only a few days", requires that the "seven years" be understood literally. Jacob married Leah and Rachel after the seven years. The problem of Dinah's age has a different solution, as I explain below.

[e] The phrase 'go in to her' is used in the OT in the sense of 'have sex with her', or 'marry her'.

[f] It seems that it was customary at that time to place the bride on a bed in a dark room. When the groom entered, he could not see who it was. Leah

done this to me? Was it not for Rachel that I served you? Why then have you tricked me?" **26** And Laban said, "To give the younger before the older is not done here.[a] **27** Complete the week of this one,[b] and then we will give you the other also,[c] in return for the service of yet another seven years that you will serve me."[d]

28 And Jacob did so and fulfilled Leah's week. So *Laban* gave him his daughter Rachel as wife also. **29** (Laban also gave his maidservant Bilhah to his daughter Rachel, as her maidservant.) **30** Then *Jacob* went in to Rachel also, and he loved Rachel more than Leah, and he worked for *Laban* another seven years.[e] **31** And Jehovah saw that Leah was disregarded, and He opened her womb;[f] but Rachel was barren.

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certainly kept quiet, so as not to be betrayed by the voice (and she obviously participated in the trick willingly). That is why Jacob only discovered the betrayal with the light of day. If the feast included alcoholic beverages, he may have been a little intoxicated as well.

[a] In that case, why was Jacob not informed of that rule? Laban was devious, not to say dirty.

[b] Here it is a week of seven days, Leah's bridal week.

[c] Jacob received Rachel after Leah's seven days, not after another seven years.

[d] Jacob was not the more clever; in that 'discipline' Laban was a graduate professor. Jacob was completely vulnerable, and Laban knew very well how to take advantage of this weakness. Laban and Rebekah were siblings, and Rebekah only had children after twenty years of marriage, and Laban did not sit still during all that time. If Jacob was already 84 years old, then Leah was certainly at least 60, and probably more–she was stranded, no one wanted her. However, she had a relationship with Jehovah and verbally acknowledged Him when the children were born. And verse 31 makes clear that God recognized that relationship. But it was also true that God had blessed Laban to an unusual extent during those years, and he wanted more blessing.

Returning to Laban, he suddenly saw a great opportunity to get rid of Leah, and he did not miss the chance. Still and all, just as God used Rebekah's deceit to circumvent Isaac's rebellion, God used Laban's cleverness to further the Plan. If Jacob had married Rachel first, he would have been satisfied and would not have thought about Leah. But the Messiah would come through Leah, not Rachel. Further, Rachel's barrenness led to the inclusion of the two handmaids as concubines; the four women produced the twelve sons, half of them being Leah's!

[e] This makes clear that "Leah's week" was seven solar days.

[f] Repeatedly, it is stated that Jehovah controls conception.

The sons kept coming[a]

29.32 Leah conceived and bore a son, and she called his name Reuben;[b] for she said, "Surely Jehovah has noticed my affliction;[c] therefore now my husband will love me". **33** And she conceived again and bore a son, and said, "Surely Jehovah has heard that I am disregarded, and He has given me this one also". And she called his name Simeon.[d] **34** And she conceived again and bore a son, and said, "Now this time my husband will become attached to me, because I have borne him three sons". So his name was called Levi.[e] **35** And she conceived again and bore a son, and said, "This time I will praise Jehovah". So she called his name Judah;[f] and she stopped bearing.

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[a] The passage from 29:32 through 30:24 deals with the birth of Jacob's sons; it is the topic of the passage. The Hebrew discourse structure usually deals topic by topic, without regard to the chronological sequence of events; and it can treat the same topic from different perspectives. Failure to take this factor into account has led commentators to misinterpret "when Rachel had given birth to Joseph" in 30:25. That saying is chronological, and the context makes it clear that it refers to the end of Jacob's 14 years of service for both wives. But Jacob did not receive Leah until after seven years of service (and Rachel seven solar days after Leah). It is clear that Reuben could not have been born before the eighth year of this service. Although the record mentions only one daughter, Dinah, 37:35 makes it clear that Jacob had other daughters (which would be normal), for it mentions "all his daughters". The difficulty is that the second seven-year period simply does not accommodate so many births, a difficulty that results from the mistake of assuming that 30:25 applies to the previous section.

It is necessary to understand that the account of the births is independent of the time of Joseph's birth. Certainly a good number of the births occurred during the following six years. The text makes it clear that when Jacob left Paddan-Aram (after twenty years) he had eleven sons, and certainly Dinah as well. The birth of Joseph is included in the previous passage because it is part of the topic.

[b] The name means: look, a son.

[c] Laban had the family idols, but Leah acknowledged Jehovah, which she did with her second son as well (verse 31 says that it was Jehovah who opened her womb). With the fourth, she praised Jehovah, and the fourth was Judah, through whom the Messiah came.

[d] The name means: hearing.

[e] The name means: attached.

[f] The name means: praise.

30:1 Now when Rachel saw that she bore Jacob no children, she envied her sister and said to Jacob, “Give me children, or I will die”. **2** Then Jacob was angry with Rachel and said, “Am I in God’s place, who has withheld the fruit of the womb from you?” **3** So she said, “Here is my maidservant Bilhah; go in to her, that she may bear children for me, that I also may be built up through her.”[a] **4** And she gave him Bilhah her maidservant as a wife; and Jacob went in to her. **5** And Bilhah conceived and bore Jacob a son. **6** Then Rachel said, “God has judged, and has also heard my voice and given me a son”. Therefore she called his name Dan.[b] **7** And Bilhah Rachel’s maidservant conceived again and bore Jacob a second son. **8** Then Rachel said, “With the wrestlings ‘of gods’ I have wrestled with my sister, and indeed I have prevailed!” So she called his name Naphtali.[c]

9 When Leah saw that she had stopped bearing, she also took her maidservant Zilpah and gave her to Jacob as a wife. **10** And Zilpah, Leah’s maidservant, bore Jacob a son. **11** Then Leah said, “A troop is coming!”[d] And she called his name Gad. **12** Then Leah’s maidservant Zilpah bore Jacob a second son. **13** Then Leah said, “How happy I am! For the daughters will call me happy.” And she named him Asher.[e] **14** In the days of wheat harvest Reuben went out and found mandrakes in the field and brought them to his mother Leah. Then Rachel said to Leah, “Please give me some of your son’s mandrakes”. **15** But she said to her, “Was it a small thing that you took my husband?[f] Would you also take my son’s mandrakes?” Then Rachel said, “Therefore he will lie with you tonight for your son’s mandrakes”. **16** When Jacob came from the field in the evening, Leah went out to meet him and said, “You must

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[a] According to the norms of Hebrew discourse, Rachel probably did not wait until the birth of Leah's fourth son, not necessarily. Rachel did the same thing with Bilhah that Rebekah did with Hagar, but the outcome was quite different.

[b] The name means: judgment.

[c] The name means: wrestling.

[d] The interpretation of the Hebrew here is in doubt.

[e] The name means: happy.

[f] Just as Esau did not ‘remember’ that he had sold the birthright, Leah did not ‘remember’ that it was she who stole Jacob from Rachel in the beginning.

come in to me, for I have surely hired you with my son's mandrakes".[a] And he lay with her that night. **17** And God listened to Leah,[b] and she conceived and bore Jacob a fifth son. **18** Then Leah said, "God has given me my wages, for I have given my maidservant to my husband".[c] So she called his name Issachar.[d] **19** Then Leah conceived again and bore Jacob a sixth son. **20** And Leah said, "God has given me a good gift; now my husband will dwell with me, because I have borne him six sons". And she called his name Zebulun.[e] **21** And afterward she bore a daughter, and she called her name Dinah.[f] **22** And God remembered Rachel; God listened to her and opened her womb. **23** And she conceived, and bore a son, and said, "God has taken away my reproach".[g] **24** So she called his name Joseph,[h] saying, "May Jehovah add to me another son".[i]

God enriches Jacob

30.25 Now it happened, when Rachel had borne Joseph, that Jacob said to Laban, "Send me away, that I may go to my own place and to my country. **26** Give me my wives and my children, for whom I have served you, and let me go, for you know my service that I have done for you." **27** Then Laban said to him, "Please, if I have found favor in your eyes; I have observed the signs, and Jehovah has blessed me for your sake". **28** And he said, "Tell me the

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[a] Apparently Jacob had not been paying attention to her, so she had to 'buy' that attention.

[b] It wasn't the mandrakes, it was God. But why was this episode included in the historical record? It seems that Jacob was no longer going to Leah, preferring younger women. But God still had work for Leah to do, and He used the mandrakes to take Jacob back to her.

[c] How so; what did one thing have to do with the other?

[d] The name means: salary.

[e] The name means: dwelling place.

[f] Why is Dinah mentioned? Didn't Jacob have other daughters? In 31:28 Laban speaks of "kissing my sons and my daughters," and since "my sons" certainly refers to his grandsons, it is likely that "my daughters" refers to granddaughters. In fact, 37:35 mentions "all his daughters." Dinah would play an important role later.

[g] At that time, a married woman without children was looked down on.

[h] The name means: to add.

[i] Here Rachel recognized Jehovah by name.

payment you want, and I will give it". **29** So Jacob said to him, "You know how I have served you, and how your livestock has fared with me. **30** For the little that you had before I came has increased abundantly,[a] and Jehovah has blessed you at my foot.[b] And now, when shall I provide for my own house also?" **31** So he said, "What shall I give you?" And Jacob said, "You shall not give me anything. If you will do this for me, I will again feed and keep your flock. **32** I will go through all your flock today, taking from it every speckled and spotted sheep and every black lamb; and the spotted and speckled goats—they shall be my wages. **33** So my righteousness will testify for me in time to come, when you come to me about my wages; every goat that is not speckled and spotted and every lamb that is not black that is with me will be considered stolen."[c] **34** Then Laban said, "Yes, let it be according to your word!"[d] **35** That same day Laban took the striped and spotted male goats and all the speckled and spotted female goats, each one with white spots, and each black lamb, and gave them into the hand of his sons.[e] **36** Then he put a three-day journey between himself and Jacob,[f] and Jacob fed the rest of Laban's flocks.

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[a] Laban recognized the truth that Jacob declared (v. 27), and he did not want to lose the blessing.

[b] This is what the Text says: "at my foot". Perhaps it refers to his work, or his initiatives.

[c] How did Jacob know that all of the future offspring of the animals would have those characteristics?

[d] Laban was devious, he didn't even respect his own word; he changed the 'wages' ten times within six years (31:41)! But going against God doesn't work very well (31:42) [and not for our enemies either].

[e] Laban's sons were brothers of Leah and Rachel, and therefore adults, some perhaps of middle age. Jacob's sons were still children; the oldest was six years old. Since Jacob continued to tend Laban's flock, and since it was a three-day journey between the two flocks (verse 36), Jacob had no way of keeping an eye on what was happening to his own flock (but his wives were probably there to keep an eye on things).

[f] Well now, it seems that Laban was worried, or perhaps he was putting Jacob at a disadvantage. Three days' travel would be a respectable distance, and the text does not say in which direction, but 31:21 says that he "crossed the river", which would be the Euphrates. So the two flocks were on the same side.

37 Then Jacob took green poplar, almond and chestnut[a] rods, and peeled white stripes in them, exposing the whiteness that was in the rods. **38** And he placed the rods that he had peeled beside the containers, the watering troughs where the flocks came to drink, across from them; and they conceived when they came to drink. **39** So the flocks conceived in front of the rods, and brought forth young streaked, speckled and spotted; **40** and Jacob set the young apart.[b] Also, he put the *females* of the flock with the streaked and black *males* among Laban's flock.[c] He set his own flock by itself, and did not put them with Laban's flock. **41** And it came to pass, whenever the stronger of the flock conceived, that Jacob would place the rods before the eyes of the flock, beside the troughs, that they might conceive in front of the rods. **42** But whenever the flock was weak, he did not place them. So the weaker ones were Laban's, and the stronger ones were Jacob's. **43** Thus the man became extremely prosperous; he had large flocks, male and female slaves, camels and donkeys.[d]

Jacob returns to Canaan

31.1 Jacob heard the words of Laban's sons, saying, "Jacob has taken away all that was our father's, and from what was our

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[a] There is doubt as to the species of this tree.

[b] It was God who made Jacob's ruse work, apparently, as he himself acknowledged in 31:42. Even though Laban changed the 'wages' ten times, 31:41. Obviously Laban was watching everything the whole time and tried desperately to get around God's blessing on Jacob.

[c] Since Laban changed the wages every six months, or so, there would soon be a variety of males in Laban's flock, in spite of the separation at the beginning.

[d] 32:14-15 tells us that the half that Jacob gave to Esau was: two hundred female goats and twenty male goats; two hundred ewes and twenty rams; thirty milk camels with their young, forty cows and ten bulls; twenty female donkeys and ten foals (if he had camels and donkeys with young, he inevitably had males too). So, he had double that when he left Paddan-Aram; around a thousand animals! And he gained all that in six years!! Now then, to have pasture for a thousand animals requires an area of respectable size. The Text says that he had slaves. Jacob certainly exchanged animals for slaves, as much as possible, precisely to get rid of Laban's sons to take care of his flocks. Donkeys are beasts of burden, and camels are too, and they would be used on the journey back to Canaan.

father's he has acquired all this wealth".[a] **2** And Jacob also saw that Laban's countenance was not *favorable* toward him as before. **3** Then Jehovah said to Jacob, "Return to the land of your fathers and to your relatives, and I will be with you".[b] **4** So Jacob sent and called Rachel and Leah to the field, to his flock. **5** And he said to them, "I see that your father's countenance is not *favorable* toward me as before, but the God of my father has been with me. **6** And you yourselves know that I have served your father with all my might. **7** Yet your father has cheated me and changed my wages ten times, but God did not allow him to do me harm. **8** If he said, 'The speckled ones will be your wages', then all the flocks would bear speckled. And if he said, 'The streaked ones will be your wages', then all the flocks would bear streaked. **9** So God took away your father's livestock and gave them to me. **10** And it happened, at the time when the flock conceived, that I lifted my eyes and saw in a dream, and behold, the male goats that mated with the flock were streaked, speckled, or spotted. **11** And the Angel of God said to me in the dream,[c] 'Jacob', and I said, 'Here I am'. **12** And He said, 'Lift your eyes and see: all the male goats that mate with the flock are streaked, speckled, or spotted; for I have seen all that Laban is doing to you. **13** I am the God of Bethel, where you anointed the pillar, where you made a vow to me.[d] Now arise, get out of this land, and return to your native land'."[e]

14 Then Rachel and Leah answered and said to him, "Is there still any portion or inheritance for us in our father's house? **15** Does he not regard us as strangers? For he sold us and has 'devoured' all our money.[f]

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[a] The second half of their complaint was true.

[b] It was God who sent him back, because it was time to do so.

[c] What was the point of the dream? God was claiming direct responsibility for Jacob's prosperity.

[d] God mentions the vow! God had blessed him, but now He had to get him back to the land.

[e] Strictly speaking, his native land would be south of Hebron, but probably included Hebron, since both Abraham and Isaac spent time there; and God told him to go there.

[f] It has often been assumed that the reference is to the price that Jacob paid for them. But that was seven year's work for each of them. Since God

16 For all the wealth that God took from our father[a] belongs to us
and our children. So then, do everything that God has said to you."
17 Then Jacob went into action and put his sons and his wives on
camels. **18** He took away all his livestock and all the possessions
that he had acquired—the livestock that he had accumulated in
Paddan-Aram—to go to his father Isaac in the land of Canaan.[b]
19 Now Laban had gone to shear his sheep, and Rachel had stolen
her father's household idols.[c] **20** And Jacob deceived Laban the
Aramean by not telling him that he was going to run away.[d] **21** So
he departed with all that he had; he arose and crossed the River,[e]
and headed toward Mount Gilead.

Jacob and Laban

22 On the third day Laban was told that Jacob had fled. **23** So
he took his brothers[f] with him and followed him for seven days,[g]
and overtook him in Mount Gilead. **24** (But God had come to Laban
the Aramean in a dream at night and said to him, "Be careful not
to speak to Jacob either good or bad!") **25** So Laban caught up with
Jacob, who had pitched his tent in that mountain; Laban and his
brothers also pitched their tent in Mount Gilead. **26** Then Laban
said to Jacob, "What have you done, that you have deceived me
and carried my daughters away like captives of the sword? **27** Why
did you run away secretly and deceive me, and did not tell me? For
I would have sent you away with joy and songs, with tambourine
and harp. **28** Nor did you allow me to kiss my sons and daughters.

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prospered Laban during those fourteen years, could the reference be to that prosperity? But during the following six years God Himself transferred that prosperity to Jacob. Could the reference be to what they might have inherited from their father? That seems to be the point of the next verse.

[a] They recognized the hand of God.

[b] Isaac was living at Hebron, but Jacob took his time getting there, as I explain below.

[c] That was why Laban pursued them.

[d] Why 'run away'? He was still responsible for Laban's flock, and he was going to leave him 'in the lurch'. Apparently, the care did not include the shearing.

[e] The Euphrates River.

[f] The Text actually says 'brothers', not 'sons'.

[g] Jacob had a three-day start, but herding 1,000 animals he could not travel very fast. Just how Laban found out about the missing idols is not mentioned, but it was the missing idols that motivated the pursuit.

You have acted foolishly! **29** There is power in my hand to harm you, but the God of your father[a] spoke to me last night, saying, 'Take heed that you do not speak to Jacob either good or bad.' **30** So now you have really left, because you long for your father's house; but why did you steal my family idols?"[b]

31 Then Jacob answered and said to Laban, "Because I was afraid; for I thought that you might take your daughters from me by force. **32** With whomever you find your idols, let him not live. In the presence of our brothers, search for yourself whether I have anything of yours with me and take it." For Jacob did not know that Rachel had stolen them. **33** So Laban went into Jacob's tent, and into Leah's tent, and into the tent of the two maidservants, but did not find anything. Then he left Leah's tent and went into Rachel's tent. **34** Now Rachel had taken the idols and put them in the saddle of her camel and sat on them. And Laban felt all over the tent, but did not find anything. **35** And she said to her father, "Do not be angry, my lord, that I cannot get up before you; for I am in the manner of women."[c] So he searched but did not find the idols.

36 Then Jacob was angry and rebuked Laban; Jacob answered and said to Laban, "What is my transgression? What is my sin, that you have so furiously pursued me? **37** Although you have felt around all my belongings, what have you found of all the things in your house? Set it here before my brothers and your brothers and let them judge between us both. **38** These twenty years I have been with you; your ewes and your she-goats have not miscarried, and I have not eaten the rams of your flock. **39** I did not bring you what

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[a] The Hebrew text has 'your (plural) father', but the literal meaning is impossible. Since 'your' in English is ambiguous as to number, our versions 'hide' the problem. Perhaps it is the honorific form for 'your (singular)' (Rebekah was Laban's sister). In the Septuagint it is 'your (singular)'.

[b] That was the problem, the reason for the costly expedition: the family idols. If it were not for the disappearance of those idols, Laban would have celebrated Jacob's departure, as he himself said. At that time and in that region, the possession of such idols by a son-in-law gave him the right of the firstborn son in the inheritance left by his father-in-law, to the detriment of his father-in-law's own children. That was why Laban went after them. Naturally, Jacob did not appreciate being accused of such a crime.

[c] She claimed to be menstruating.

was torn to pieces; I replaced it. You required at my hand both what was stolen by day and what was stolen by night. **40** My case was like this: the heat consumed me by day, and the cold by night; and my sleep fled from my eyes. **41** Thus I have been in your house twenty years; fourteen years I served you for your two daughters, and six years for your flock; and you have changed my wages ten times! **42** If the God of my father, the God of Abraham, and the Fear[a] of Isaac had not been with me, surely you would now have sent me away empty-handed.[b] God has seen my affliction and the work of my hands, and He rebuked you last night."

43 Then Laban answered and said to Jacob, "The daughters are my daughters, and the sons are my sons, and the flocks are my flocks; everything you see is mine.[c] But what can I do today for these daughters of mine, or for their children whom they have borne? **44** Now therefore come, let us make a covenant, you and I, and let it be for a witness between you and me." **45** Then Jacob took a stone and set it up as a pillar. **46** And Jacob said to his brothers, "Gather stones". So they took stones and made a heap of them; and they ate there beside the heap. **47** Laban called it Jegar-sahadutha, but Jacob called it Galeed.[d] **48** Then Laban said, "This heap is a witness between you and me today". There-fore it was called Galeed, **49** and also Mizpah,[e] because he said, "May Jehovah watch between you and me when we are separated from each other. **50** If you harm my daughters or take wives besides my daughters, while no one is with us[f]—remember, God is a witness between you and me." **51** Laban also said to Jacob, "Look at this heap and the pillar that I have set up between you and me. **52** This heap is a witness, and this pillar is a witness, that I will not go past this heap toward you, and that you will not go past this heap and

[a] 'Fear' was a synonym for 'God'.

[b] If Laban could have had his way, that is what he would have done.

[c] Laban lied; Jacob had bought everything.

[d] Both names mean: heap of witness.

[e] The name means: watchtower.

[f] The reference may be to a mediator, or a go-between.

this pillar toward me, for harm.[a] **53** May the God of Abraham, the God of Nahor and the God of their father,[b] judge between us." And Jacob swore by the Fear of his father Isaac. **54** Then Jacob offered a sacrifice on the mountain and invited his brothers to eat bread; and they ate bread and spent the night on the mountain. **55** Laban got up early in the morning and kissed his sons and daughters and blessed them. Then Laban departed and returned to his place.

Jacob and God

32.1 Then Jacob went on his way, and the angels of God met him. **2** When Jacob saw them, he said, "This camp is God's". And he called the name of that place Mahanaim.[c] **3** Then Jacob sent messengers ahead of him to Esau his brother, to the land of Seir, the territory of Edom. **4** And he commanded them, saying, "Thus shall you say to my lord Esau: 'Thus says your servant Jacob: "I have sojourned with Laban and remained until now. **5** I have oxen, donkeys, and flocks, and male and female slaves; and I have sent to tell my lord, that I may find favor in your sight".'" **6** The messengers returned to Jacob, saying, "We came to your brother Esau; and he also is coming to meet you, and four hundred men with him!" **7** Then Jacob was greatly afraid and distressed; so he divided the people who were with him into two companies, as also the flocks, the herds and the camels. **8** And he said, "If Esau comes to one company and attacks it, the other company will escape".

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[a] Laban was still suspicious. The unavoidable fact was that his idols were no longer in their place in his house. And they disappeared exactly when Jacob left. 2 + 2 = 4. Jacob could have buried the idols, to use them later. The whole procedure was to ensure that Jacob would not use the idols against Laban's sons.

[b] Why did Laban appeal to the God of their grandfathers, and even their great-grandfather? In verse 49 he appealed directly to Jehovah. It seems that they knew who Jehovah was, even if they did not associate with Him much. But since Jehovah was Jacob's God, Laban was trying to constrain him with this appeal.

[c] The name means: two bands–there was the physical band, which was Jacob's, and the spiritual band, which was God's. Since Jacob had already seen angels at Bethel, he recognized them. But why did God have angels meet Jacob? Perhaps to encourage him and confirm to him that he was doing the right thing.

9 Then Jacob said, “O God of my father Abraham and God of my father Isaac, Jehovah, who said to me, ‘Return to your country and to your family, and I will do you good’.[a] **10** I am not worthy of all the mercies and all the faithfulness that you have bestowed on your servant; for I crossed over this Jordan with my staff,[b] and now I have become two companies. **11** Deliver me, I pray, from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau; for I fear him, lest he come and attack me,[c] and the mother with the children. **12** You yourself said, ‘I will surely do you good, and I will make your descendants as the sand of the sea, which cannot be numbered for multitude’.”

13 He stayed there that night. Then he took from what he had a present for his brother Esau: **14** two hundred she-goats and twenty he-goats; two hundred ewes and twenty rams; **15** thirty milk camels with their young; forty cows and ten bulls; twenty female donkeys and ten colts. **16** He delivered them to his slaves, each drove by itself, and said to his slaves, “Pass on ahead of me and put some space between drove and drove”. **17** He commanded the first one, saying, “When my brother Esau meets you and asks you, saying, ‘Whose are you, and where are you going, and whose are these in front of you?’ **18** Then you shall say, ‘They are your servant Jacob’s, who says, “I am sending a present to my lord Esau”. And behold, he also is behind us.’” **19** So also he commanded the second and the third, and all who followed the droves,[d] saying, “You shall speak this same word to Esau when you find him. **20** And you shall also say, ‘Behold, your servant Jacob is behind us’.” For he said, “I will appease him with the present that goes before me, and afterward I will see his face; perhaps he will accept me”. **21** So the present went on ahead of him, but he spent that night in the camp.

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[a] By ‘reminding’ God of His promise, he was calling on Him for protection.

[b] Jacob affirms that he went to Laban empty-handed.

[c] The verb could have the meaning of kill, but Esau would have no reason to kill women and children, even if he killed Jacob. However, the next verse could imply the killing of the children.

[d] There were at least three ‘droves’, but possibly several more. The idea was to make a favorable impression on Esau, and it worked.

22 That same night[a] he arose and took his two wives, his two maidservants, and his eleven sons, and crossed over the ford of the Jabbok.[b] **23** He took them and brought them across the stream—he had sent over that which he had.[c]

24 So Jacob was left alone;[d] and a Man wrestled with him until it began to dawn. **25** And when He saw that He did not prevail against him, He touched the hollow of his thigh; and Jacob's thigh became out of joint as He wrestled with him. **26** And He said, "Let me go, for the dawn has come".[e] But he said, "I will not let you go unless you bless me".[f] **27** So He said to him, "What is your name?" And he said, "Jacob". **28** Then He said, “Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but Israel,[g] for you have striven with God and with men and have prevailed”. **29** Then Jacob asked and said, “Please tell me your name”. And He said, “Why do you ask my name?”[h] And He blessed him there.

30 And Jacob called the name of the place Peniel,[i] “Because I have seen God face to face, and I am still alive!” **31** And the sun rose on him as he went on from Peniel; and he limped because of his thigh. **32** Therefore the children of Israel do not eat the tendon that is on the hollow of the thigh to this day, because He struck the hollow of Jacob’s thigh, the tendon.

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[a] It seems that Jacob made that crossing at night, which would have been a strange procedure. Perhaps God had already presented Himself to him, and he knew that he would have to face Him alone.

[b] The Jabbok is a small tributary of the Jordan River on the eastern side. The stream could have presented a small obstacle to Esau, who was coming from the south, but to placate Esau, Jacob could not use it.

[c] A good part of his possessions had already gone toward Esau.

[d] He must have helped the women and children across, but then returned to the north side of the stream alone.

[e] Evidently Jacob was hanging on to Him.

[f] Obviously God limited Himself to the strength of an ordinary man, or Jacob would not have been able to fight with Him. But the picture is curious; why would God do such a thing? God had a special interest in Jacob, and wanted to change his name. By wrestling, Jacob lived up to the name Israel.

[g] The name means: he who struggles with God.

[h] So why did Jacob ask for the name? Perhaps he wanted confirmation that it was God.

[i] The name means: the face of God.

Jacob and Esau

33.1 Then Jacob lifted his eyes and looked, and there was Esau, coming with four hundred men! Then he divided the children among Leah, Rachel, and the two maidservants. **2** He put the maidservants and their children in front, Leah and her children behind, and Rachel and Joseph last. **3** But he himself passed on ahead of them[a] and bowed down to the ground seven times until he came to his brother. **4** Then Esau ran to meet him and embraced him, falling on his neck and kissing him, and they wept.[b] **5** Then he lifted his eyes and saw the women and children, and said, "Who are these with you?" And he said, "The children with whom God has blessed your servant". **6** Then the maidservants came near, they and their children, and bowed down. **7** And Leah also came near with her children and bowed down. Then Joseph and Rachel came near and bowed down.

8 Then Esau said, "What do you mean by all these droves that I met?" And he said, "To find favor in the eyes of my lord". **9** But Esau said, "I have enough, my brother; let what you have be yours". **10** Then Jacob said, "No, please, if I have now found favor in your eyes, accept my gift from my hand; since I have seen your face, as if I had seen the face of a god, and you are pleased with me. **11** Please, accept my blessing that has been brought to you, because God has favored me, and because I have enough." And he urged him until he accepted it. **12** Then Esau said, "Let us be on our way, and I will go before you". **13** But Jacob said to him, "My lord knows that the children are tender, and that I have ewes and cows

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[a] Jacob did not hide behind the women and children; he was out in front. The fact that he limped may have helped—why beat up on a cripple?

[b] Jacob and Esau certainly spoke much more than is recorded in the text. Jacob certainly asked for news of his parents, and it is more than likely that Rebekah was already dead. Sarah died at the age of 127, and Rebekah was at least 120 when Jacob fled, and he had been away for twenty years. This explains why Jacob was in no hurry to see his father. It is possible that Jacob was bitter toward his father: if Isaac had recognized what God had told Rebekah, and the fact that Esau had sold the birthright, and had not tried to bless Esau anyway, Jacob would not have gone through the distress and humiliation that he did. In fact, it seems that Isaac was in his last ten years when Jacob finally showed up.

that are nursing; and if they drive them hard just one day, they will all die. **14** Please let my lord go on ahead of his servant, and I will go by stages, little by little, according to the pace of the cattle that go before me, and according to the pace of the children, until I come to my lord at Seir."[a] **15** And Esau said, "Then let me leave some of those who are with me with you". But he said, "What need is there? Let me find favor in the eyes of my lord." **16** So Esau returned that day to Seir by the same road. **17** And Jacob traveled to Succoth, built himself a house, and made shelters for his livestock; therefore he called the name of that place Succoth.[b]

18 That was how Jacob came safely to the city of Shechem, which is in the land of Canaan,[c] after he left Paddan-Aram; and he camped within sight of the city. **19** And he bought the parcel of land, where he had pitched his tent, from the sons of Hamor, Shechem's father, for one hundred pieces of money. **20** And he set up an altar there and called it El Elohe Israel.[d]

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[a] Jacob had no intention of going to Seir; he just wanted to be free from Esau.

[b] The name means: shelters. We do not know how long Jacob stayed in Succoth, but if he built a house for himself and made shelters for his livestock, he certainly stayed there for some time; perhaps several years. In fact, perhaps a good many years, considering Dinah's age. When they arrived in Succoth, Reuben, the firstborn, could not have been more than thirteen years old. 30:21 says that Dinah was born "after" Zebulun, Leah's sixth son; so Dinah may not have been even five years old. To attract Shechem's attention, she would have had to be a fully developed teenager, probably at least fifteen years old. Likewise, Simeon and Levi would not have been more than twelve and eleven when they arrived in Succoth, but to do what they did, 34:25, they would have had to be men in their prime. They stayed in Succoth for at least ten years, but I imagine it was between thirteen and fifteen. The time they spent near Shechem before sacking the city was probably not long. For a detailed discussion of Dinah's age, please see "The problem of Dinah's age" above.

[c] In 31:13 God had told Jacob to return to his native land, which was Canaan. The Text emphasizes that he finally got there, by crossing the Jordan (Succoth was on the East side).

[d] The name means: God, the God of Israel. Jacob took his new name, Israel, and claimed a relationship with God—for himself, but perhaps for his descendants as well.

Dinah and Shechem

34.1 Dinah, Leah's daughter, whom she had borne to Jacob, went out to see the daughters of the land.[a] **2** When Shechem the son of Hamor the Hivite, prince of the land, saw her, he took her and lay with her and violated her. **3** His soul became attached to Dinah, Jacob's daughter, and he loved the young woman and spoke tenderly to her. **4** So Shechem spoke to his father Hamor, saying, "Get this young woman for me as a wife."[b] **5** When Jacob heard that Shechem had defiled his daughter Dinah,[c] his sons were in the field with the livestock; Jacob kept quiet until they came. **6** Then Hamor, Shechem's father, went out to Jacob to speak with him. **7** And Jacob's sons came in from the field when they heard it.[d] The men were indignant and very angry, because he had brought shame on Israel[e] by sleeping with Jacob's daughter, a thing which should not be done in that way.[f]

8 Then Hamor spoke with them,[g] saying, “The soul of my son Shechem longs for your daughter; please give her to him as a wife. **9** And intermarry with us by giving us your daughters and taking our daughters for yourselves. **10** And live with us, and the land will be before you; live and trade in it, and acquire property in it.” **11** Then Shechem said to Dinah’s father and her brothers, “Let me find favor in your eyes, and I will give whatever you say to me. **12** You may greatly increase the dowry and the gift that you require

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[a] It appears that she went out alone, which was not a good idea, and perhaps not ‘correct’. It would be natural for her to want to make friends with other girls, as long as it was done in the right way. However, she certainly did not expect to be the victim of an impetuous action and be taken captive.

[b] Verse 26 says that they took Dinah from Shechem's house, which means that he kept her, not letting her return home.

[c] If Shechem had caught Dinah out in the open, there must have been witnesses. When Dinah did not return, her mother would have wanted to know why. Such a thing would certainly be talked about. Jacob would have heard about it before long.

[d] Jacob certainly sent someone running to call his sons.

[e] Here we have the first use of the name ‘Israel’ to refer to the community. Yes, because “daughter of Jacob” occurs in the next phrase.

[f] There was a correct way to get a wife, which Shechem did not follow.

[g] The sons arrived at the same time as Hamor, or perhaps a little earlier. Hamor was accompanied by his son.

of me, and I will give whatever you say to me; only give me the young woman as a wife."[a] **13** Then Jacob's sons answered Shechem and Hamor his father with deceit,[b] because he had defiled Dinah their sister. **14** And they said to them, "We cannot do this thing, to give our sister to an uncircumcised man; for that would be a disgrace to us. **15** Only on this condition will we consent to you: If you will become like us, having every male among you be circumcised, **16** then we will give you our daughters, and we will take your daughters for ourselves; and we will dwell with you, and we will become one people. **17** But if you will not listen to us and be circumcised, we will take our daughter and leave."

18 Now their words pleased Hamor and Shechem his son. **19** And the young man did not hesitate to do this, because he loved Jacob's daughter; and he was the most noble of all his father's household. **20** Then Hamor and his son Shechem went to the gate of their city and spoke to the men of the city, saying, **21** "These men are at peace with us; so let them dwell in this land and trade in it, for indeed the land is large enough for them. Let us take their daughters as wives for ourselves, and let us give our daughters to them. **22** But the men will only consent to live with us, so that we may become one people, if every male among us is circumcised, as they are circumcised. **23** Will not their cattle, their goods, and all their beasts of burden be ours?[c] So let us consent to them, and they will dwell with us." **24** And all who went out of the gate of his city heeded Hamor and his son Shechem; every male was circumcised, of all who went out of the gate of his city.[d]

25 On the third day, while they were suffering, two of Jacob's sons, Simeon and Levi, Dinah's brothers, each took his sword and went into the city, which was unguarded, and killed every male.

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[a] Shechem did not try to escape his responsibility; he had been overcome by passion, but he took full responsibility for the consequences.

[b] What was the "deceit"? They said that they would agree with Hamor's proposal, if their condition was met, but they had no intention of doing it.

[c] Obviously Hamor hoped to gain the upper hand. He thought he could impose himself on Jacob.

[d] Verse 29 makes it clear that this did not include the children. The expression seems to refer to those who were old enough to vote. It was necessary for them to be consulted, and for them to agree to the proposal.

26 They killed Hamor and Shechem his son with the sword and took Dinah out of Shechem's house and left. **27** Jacob's sons came upon the dead and plundered the city,[a] because they had defiled their sister. **28** They took their flocks, their herds, and their donkeys, both in the city and in the field. **29** They took all the children and the women as captives.[b] They plundered all the goods and everything in the houses. **30** Then Jacob said to Simeon and Levi, "You have made trouble for me by making me stink to the inhabitants of the land, to the Canaanites and Perizzites. Since I am few in number, if they gather together against me and attack me, I will be destroyed, both I and my household." **31** But they said, "Should he treat our sister like a prostitute?"

Jacob Goes to Bethel, Bethlehem and Hebron

35.1 Then God said to Jacob, "Arise, go up to Bethel and dwell there,[c] and build an altar there to God who appeared to you when you fled from Esau your brother." **2** Then Jacob said to his household and to all who were with him, "Put away the foreign gods that are among you, purify yourselves and change your clothes. **3** Then let us arise and go up to Bethel, and I will build an altar there to God who answered me in the day of my distress[d] and has been with me on the way I have gone." **4** So they gave Jacob all the foreign gods[e] that were in their possession, along with the earrings that were in their ears;[f] and Jacob hid them under the oak

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[a] Although only two perpetrated the massacre, all participated in the looting.

[b] So what did they do with the women? They married them; where else would they find a wife for so many men? In Acts 7:15-16 Stephen states that Jacob's sons were buried in Shechem. Joshua 24:32 explicitly states that Joseph's bones were buried there. Since that was where they got their wives and possessions, it would be appropriate for them to be buried there.

[c] Jacob went to Bethel, but did not 'dwell' there; he seems to have gone south without much delay.

[d] He was fleeing for his life, taking nothing with him. He was definitely in a bad way. If God "answered", Jacob must have asked for help.

[e] Rachel must have given up the family idols she had stolen from her father. Since Jacob had sworn to Laban back in Gilead that he would not use them, they were no longer important.

[f] Why are the earrings mentioned? Perhaps they had some religious significance.

tree that was near Shechem.[a] **5** Then they set out; and the terror of God fell on the surrounding cities, and they did not pursue the sons of Jacob.[b] **6** And Jacob came to Luz (that is, Bethel), in the land of Canaan, he and all the people with him. **7** And he built an altar there, and called the place El-Bethel,[c] because God had revealed Himself to him there, when he fled from his brother. **8** Now Deborah, Rebekah's nurse,[d] died, and she was buried below Bethel under the oak tree; and he called its name Allon-bacuth.[e]

9 Then God appeared to Jacob again, after he had come from Paddan-Aram,[f] and blessed him. **10** And God said to him, "Your name is Jacob; no longer shall your name be called Jacob, but Israel shall be your name". So He called his name Israel.[g] **11** God also said to him, "I am Almighty God;[h] be fruitful and multiply; a nation, even a company of nations, shall come from you, and kings shall come from your loins. **12** And the land that I gave to Abraham and Isaac I give to you; and I will give the land to your descendants after you." **13** And God went up from him in the place where He had spoken with him. **14** And Jacob set up a pillar in the place where He had spoken with him, a pillar of stone; and he poured a drink offering

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[a] It must have been a special tree.

[b] That was a direct act of God, to protect Israel (the news of the massacre would have gotten around).

[c] The name means: the God of the house of God. It was Jacob himself who had given the name Bethel to the place when he was fleeing from Esau, and God had revealed Himself to him for the first time. Since then, God had spoken to him several times, and now Jacob knew Him better, and he added to the name.

[d] This is curious; Rebekah's own death is not mentioned, but that of her nurse is. I believe we may deduce that Rebekah had died, and probably a good while earlier. In any case, we know that Rebekah was buried at Machpelah (49:31).

[e] The name means: the oak of weeping.

[f] God had spoken to him in Shechem, 35:1, but here He appeared, as He had done once before, 28:13. He was visible. Succoth was on the east side of the Jordan; finally Jacob was within the land of Canaan.

[g] God had already done this at Peniel; why did He do it again?

[h] In Hebrew it is: El-Shaddai.

on it and poured oil on it. **15** And Jacob called the name of the place where God had spoken with him, Bethel.[a]

16 Then they departed from Bethel.[b] When there was some distance to come to Ephrath, Rachel began to give birth, and her labor was hard.[c] **17** And it came to pass, as she was having hard labor, that the midwife said to her, "Do not fear; you will have this son also". **18** And as her soul was departing (for she died), she called his name Ben-oni;[d] but his father called him Benjamin.[e] **19** So Rachel died and was buried on the way to Ephrath (that is, Bethlehem). **20** And Jacob set up a pillar on her grave, which is the pillar of Rachel's grave to this day.[f]

21 Then Israel moved on[g] and pitched his tent beyond Migdal-eder.[h] **22** And it came to pass, while Israel dwelt in that land,[i] that Reuben went and lay with Bilhah his father's concubine; and Israel heard about it.[j]

Now the sons of Jacob were twelve. **23** The sons of Leah: Reuben, Jacob's firstborn, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun. **24** The sons of Rachel: Joseph and Benjamin. **25** The sons of Bilhah, Rachel's maidservant: Dan and Naphtali. **26** The sons of Zilpah, Leah's maidservant: Gad and Asher. These were the sons of Jacob, who were born to him in Paddan-Aram.[k] **27** And Jacob came to his father Isaac at Mamre, or Kiriath-Arba (that is, Hebron), where Abraham and Isaac sojourned. **28** Now the days of Isaac

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[a] Jacob had given that name to the place many years before, and it would be natural for him to repeat it here.

[b] We are not told how long he stayed there, but it probably was not very long.

[c] She was probably fifteen to twenty years older than when she had Joseph.

[d] The name means: son of my sorrow.

[e] The name means: son of my right hand.

[f] It was only about 20 miles from there to Machpelah; why did Jacob not take Rachel's body there? We are not told. Isaac was living there. Was Jacob avoiding him?

[g] Here the name changes from Jacob to Israel, but both names remained in use until Jacob's death.

[h] The name means: tower of the flock.

[i] It sounds like he stayed there for a while.

[j] He mentioned it when he gave his sons his final blessing, 49:4.

[k] Strictly speaking, there were eleven, since Benjamin was born in Canaan. The account gives a round number, although with Dinah there would be twelve.

were one hundred and eighty years. **29** And Isaac breathed his last and died, and was gathered to his people, old and full of days. And Esau and Jacob, his sons, buried him.[a]

The Generations of Esau

36.1 These are the generations of Esau, who is Edom. **2** Esau took his wives from the daughters of Canaan: Adah the daughter of Elon the Hittite, and Aholibamah the daughter of Anah, the granddaughter of Zibeon the Hivite, **3** and Base-math the daughter of Ishmael, sister of Nebaioth. **4** Adah bore Eliphaz to Esau, and Basemath bore Reuel. **5** And Aholibamah bore Jeush, Jaalam, and Korah. These are the sons of Esau, who were born to him in the land of Canaan. **6** Then Esau took his wives, his sons, his daughters, and all the members of his household, his cattle and all his beasts of burden, and all the goods that he had acquired in the land of Canaan, and went to a land far from Jacob his brother. **7** For their possessions were so great that they could not live together; the land of their sojournings could not support them because of their livestock.[b] **8** So Esau lived in Mount Seir; Esau is Edom.

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[a] He was buried at Machpelah, which was part of Hebron, where he was living at the time.

[b] Where in the family history can we place this account? Verses 2–5 give the 'hint', relating what happened "in the land of Canaan." Isaac was 60 years old when the twins were born (25:26). Esau married at 40 (26:34), and Isaac was 100. That Isaac was 137 when Jacob fled is an inference based on dates given for Joseph and Jacob; thus, the twins were 77 years old, and Esau had been married for 37 years, and certainly had grown children. 28:9 adds that Esau took a third wife, while he was still living near his parents, and therefore in Canaan. After the blessing, the family atmosphere was certainly difficult. Rebekah did not like Esau, and he liked her even less. Isaac had stated that his possible death was the reason he wanted to give the blessing (27:2). And Esau was waiting for that death in order to kill Jacob (27:41). Since Jacob had received the blessing of the firstborn, most of his father's estate would go to him, and Isaac was wealthy. No one imagined that Jacob would take 20 years to return; after the necessary interval, he could appear at any time. When Jacob returned, Esau was already in Seir. Since Isaac took a long time to die, at some point Esau had left with everything he had and settled in Seir; since Seir was located across the Jordan and south of the Dead Sea, it was not part of Canaan.

9 These are the generations of Esau the father of the Edomites
in Mount Seir. **10** These are the names of Esau's sons: Eliphaz the
son of Esau's wife Adah, and Reuel the son of Esau's wife Base-
math. **11** The sons of Eliphaz were Teman, Omar, Zepho, Gatam,
and Kenaz. **12** Timna was the concubine of Esau's son Eliphaz, and
she bore Amalek to Eliphaz. Those were the sons of Esau's wife
Adah. **13** The sons of Reuel were Nahath, Zerah, Shammah, and
Mizzah. Those were the sons of Esau's wife Basemath. **14** These
were the sons of Esau's wife Aholibamah, the daughter of Anah,
the granddaughter of Zibeon. She bore to Esau: Jeush, Jaalam and
Korah.

15 These were the chiefs among the sons of Esau: the sons of
Eliphaz, Esau's firstborn: chief Teman, chief Omar, chief Zepho,
chief Kenaz, **16** chief Korah, chief Gatam, chief Amalek. Those were
the chiefs of Eliphaz in the land of Edom. They were the sons of
Adah. **17** These were the sons of Reuel, Esau's son: chief Nahath,
chief Zerah, chief Shammah, chief Mizzah. Those were the chiefs of
Reuel in the land of Edom. They were the sons of Basemath, Esau's
wife. **18** These were the sons of Aholibamah, Esau's wife: chief
Jeush, chief Jaalam, chief Korah. They were the chiefs of Aholiba-
mah, Esau's wife, the daughter of Anah. **19** Those were the sons of
Esau (he is Edom), and those were their chiefs.

20 These were the sons of Seir the Horite,[a] who lived in that
land: Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah, **21** Dishon, Ezer and Dishan.
They were the chiefs of the Horites, the sons of Seir, in the land of
Edom. **22** The sons of Lotan were Hori and He-mam; Lotan's sister
was Timna. **23** The sons of Shobal were Alvan, Manahath, Ebal,
Shepho and Onam. **24** The sons of Zibeon were Aiah and Anah.
(This was the Anah who found the hot springs in the wilderness
while he was pasturing the donkeys of his father Zibeon.) **25** The
children of Anah were Dishon and Aholibamah, the daughter of
Anah. **26** The sons of Dishon were Hemdan, Eshban, Ithran and
Cheran. **27** The sons of Ezer were Bilhan, Zaavan and Akan. **28** The

[a] The Horites were a race that was spread throughout many regions. They were obviously already in Seir when Esau arrived there, for they were the ones who gave the place its name. Presumably, as time went on, the two peoples began to mix and together became the Edomites.

sons of Dishan were Uz and Aram. **29** These were the chiefs of the Horites: chief Lotan, chief Shobal, chief Zibeon, chief Anah, **30** chief Dishon, chief Ezer, chief Dishan. They were the chiefs of the Horites according to their chiefdoms in the land of Seir.

31 These are the kings who reigned in the land of Edom before any king reigned over the Israelites.[a] **32** Bela the son of Beor reigned in Edom, and the name of his city was Dinha-bah. **33** Bela died, and Jobab the son of Zerah of Bozrah reigned in his place. **34** Jobab died, and Husham of the land of the Temanites reigned in his place. **35** Husham died, and Hadad the son of Bedad, who defeated Midian in the field of Moab, reigned in his place; and the name of his city was Avith. **36** Hadad died, and Samlah of Masrekah reigned in his place. **37** Samlah died, and Saul of Rehoboth-by-the-River reigned in his place. **38** Saul died, and Baal-hanan the son of Achbor reigned in his place. **39** Baal-hanan the son of Achbor died, and Hadar reigned in his stead; and the name of his city was Pau—his wife's name was Mehetabel, the daughter of Matred, the granddaughter of Mezahab.

40 These were the names of the chiefs of Esau, according to their families, according to their places, by name:[b] chief Timnah, chief Alvah, chief Jetheth, **41** chief Aholibamah, chief Elah, chief Pinon, **42** chief Kenaz, chief Teman, chief Mibzar, **43** chief Magdiel, chief Iram. They were the chiefs of Edom, according to their habitations in the land of their possession. Esau was the father of the Edomites.

Joseph is introduced

37.1 Now Jacob lived in the land where his father had sojourned, in the land of Canaan.[c] **2** These are the generations of Jacob. When

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[a] Why was this information included in the Record? It was natural for the Edomites to organize themselves in this way, but the King of Israel was God, a theocracy. When the people asked for a king, like other peoples, Samuel was not pleased, and God stated that it was He whom the people rejected (1 Samuel 8:5-7).

[b] This list of chiefs is different from that in verses 15-19.

[c] Hebrew narratives follow a topical, not a chronological sequence. At the end of chapter 35, Jacob is already in the land. Chapter 36 gives the genealogy of Esau, that has nothing to do with Jacob. From verse 2 onward, the topic here is Joseph.

Joseph was seventeen years old, he was tending the flock with his brothers. The young man was with the sons of Bilhah and the sons of Zilpah, his father's wives. And Joseph gave a bad report about them to their father.[a] **3** Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his sons, because he was a son of his old age;[b] and he made a special garment for him.[c] **4** His brothers saw that their father loved him more than all of them, so they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him.

The Dreams

5 Joseph had a dream and told it to his brothers, so they hated him even more.[d] **6** He said to them, "Please listen to this dream that I have dreamed: **7** There we were, binding sheaves in the field; then, my sheaf rose up and stood upright, and your sheaves gathered around and bowed down to my sheaf!" **8** So his brothers said to him, "Will you really reign over us? Will you actually rule over us?" So they hated him even more for his dreams and for his words. **9** Then Joseph had another dream and told it to his brothers. He said, "Listen, I have had another dream: indeed, the sun, the moon and eleven stars bowed down to me!" **10** And he told it to his father, as well as his brothers, and his father rebuked him and said to him, "What dream is this that you have dreamed?

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[a] This probably happened in Succoth, near the end of their stay there. Naturally, those four (Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher) would not like the 'tattletale'.

[b] Benjamin had not yet been born, as Joseph's second dream makes clear.

[c] The versions translate the phrase in various ways, but the 'point' is that Israel did it only for Joseph, showing that he valued Joseph more than the others (which the others didn't like, of course). Israel acted on the basis of his emotions, against common sense, and the result was bad. When we act on the basis of our emotions, against common sense, it will produce negative results. If we follow our emotions against God's revealed will, the results will certainly be bad.

[d] But why tell his brothers about his dream? It would have been better to keep quiet! Being a spoiled child doesn't necessarily give you good sense. But on the other hand, why did God give him those dreams? It was the dreams that angered the brothers to the point that they determined to get rid of Joseph, and God wanted him in Egypt.

Shall I and your mother[a] and your brothers really come and bow down to the ground before you?" **11** His brothers envied him, but his father kept the matter in mind.

12 His brothers went to Shechem to feed their father's flock.[b] **13** Then Israel said to Joseph, "Are not your brothers feeding the flock near Shechem? Come, and I will send you to them." So he said to him, "Here I am". **14** He said to him, "Go now, see how your brothers and the flocks are doing, and bring me back a report".[c] So he sent him from the valley of Hebron,[d] and he went to Shechem. **15** There a man saw him wandering around in the field. So the man asked him, "What are you looking for?" **16** And he said, "I am looking for my brothers; please tell me where they are feeding their flocks". **17** The man said, "They have gone from here; for I heard them say, 'Let's go to Dothan'." So Joseph went after his brothers and found them in Dothan.[e]

The Plot

18 Now when they saw him afar off, before he came near them, they conspired against him to kill him. **19** And they said to one another, "Here comes that lord of dreams! **20** Come on, let us kill him and throw him into one of the pits! And we will say, 'A wild beast has devoured him'; and let us see what will become of his dreams!" **21** But Reuben heard it, and rescued him out of their hands, and said, "Let us not take his life". **22** Reuben said to them,

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[a] For Jacob to express himself in this way, Rachel was still alive. In that event, Benjamin hadn't been born yet, but in Egypt, when they bowed down, there were eleven. However, in Egypt, Rachel was not there. I take the point to be that the whole family would be under his authority, as it indeed was.

[b] From Hebron to Shechem was close to 100 km, as the crow flies, but over accidented terrain. That was a long way to drive a flock of sheep! Had they run out of pasture around Hebron? They had sacked the town of Shechem, and left it destitute; did they want to see what it was like, or if other people had moved in? And why did they go on to Dothan? For some reason they were restless. On the other hand, God wanted Joseph in Egypt, and the Ishmaelites would pass by Dothan, but not by Shechem.

[c] His concern was natural; they had probably been gone for quite a while. That they went on to Dothan from Shechem indicates that they were not in any hurry to go home.

[d] After his father's death, Israel stayed on in Hebron.

[e] Dothan was another 30 some km to the north of Shechem.

"Do not shed blood; throw him into this pit in the wilderness, but do not lay a hand on him"—that he might rescue him out of their hands and return him to his father. **23** So it came to pass, when Joseph came to his brothers, that they stripped Joseph of his special garment, the garment that he was wearing.[a] **24** And they took him and threw him into the pit; the pit was empty and had no water. **25** Then they sat down to eat bread;[b] and they lifted up their eyes and looked, and there was a caravan of Ishmaelites, coming from Gilead with their camels, that were carrying spices, balm and myrrh, taking them down to Egypt.

26 Then Judah said to his brothers, "What good will it do us if we kill our brother and hide his blood? **27** Come, let us sell him to the Ishmaelites, and let us not lay a hand on him, for he is our brother, our flesh." And his brothers agreed.[c] **28** So they lifted Joseph out of the pit, and as the Midianite[d] merchants were passing by, they sold Joseph to the Ishma-elites for twenty shekels of silver. And they took Joseph to Egypt.

29 Then Reuben went back to the pit, but Joseph was not there! So he tore his clothes, **30** and went back to his brothers and said, "The boy is gone; and I, where can I go?"[e] **31** So they took Joseph's special garment, killed a kid of the goats, and dipped the garment in the blood. **32** Then they took the garment and brought it to their father and said, "We have found this; see if it is your son's garment". **33** And he recognized it and said, "It is my son's garment! A wild beast has devoured him; Joseph has surely been torn to pieces!" **34** Then Jacob tore his clothes, put sackcloth on his loins,

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[a] Now why was Joseph wearing his special garment to meet his brothers? That was like waving a red cloth in the face of a bull! He would naturally wear it in the presence of his father, but there was no need to wear it on a long trip. He evidently thought that he was more important than his brothers and was flaunting his privilege. Being sold as a slave got rid of that attitude.

[b] Their cruelty to Joseph didn't bother their appetite!

[c] God used Judah to save Joseph's life, but also to save all of theirs, in the future.

[d] Midian was the son of Abraham and Keturah, just as Ishmael was the son of Abraham and Hagar. It seems that in the region of Gilead the two peoples mixed, using the two names: Ishmaelites and Midianites.

[e] Obviously Ruben was not present when they sold Joseph.

and mourned for his son many days. **35** And all his sons and all his daughters[a] rose up to comfort him, but he refused to be comforted. He said, “I will go down to Sheol[b] mourning for my son!” Thus his father wept for him.

36 The Midianites[c] had sold him in Egypt to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh and captain of the guard.

The Case of Judah

38.1 It happened about that time that Judah went away from his brothers and went to stay with a man of Adullam, whose name was Hirah. **2** And Judah saw there a daughter of a Canaanite named Shua; and he took her and went in to her. **3** And she conceived and bore a son, and his father called his name Er. **4** And she conceived again and bore a son, and she called his name Onan. **5** And she bore yet again another son, and she called his name Shelah;[d] and Judah was at Chezib when she bore him.

6 Judah got a wife for Er, his firstborn, whose name was Tamar. **7** But Er, Judah's firstborn, was wicked in the sight of Jehovah, so Jehovah killed him.[e] **8** Then Judah said to Onan, "Go in to your brother's wife and marry her, and produce offspring for your brother”. **9** But Onan knew that the offspring would not be his; and it happened that whenever he went in to his brother's wife, he spilled his semen on the ground, so that he would not give offspring to his brother. **10** Now what he did was wicked in the sight

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[a] Jacob obviously had a variety of daughters, but only one, Dinah, is mentioned.

[b] Sheol in Hebrew, and Hades in Greek, is the name of the ‘waiting room’ where the spirits of the dead await the Final Judgment. The Lord Jesus described the place in Luke 16:19-31. For a more detailed explanation, see my article, ‘Hades is not Hell’.

[c] The Hebrew text has ‘Medanites’; it turns out that Medan was another son of Keturah, a brother of Midian. Perhaps they also mixed with the Ishmaelites. It would have been natural for them to mix with the Midianites.

[d] Curiously, the father named the first son, but the mother named the next two.

[e] This statement makes clear that Jehovah pays attention to what happens down here and is prepared to intervene in human affairs. However, Er must have been unusually bad, but we are not told what he did.

of Jehovah, so He killed him also.[a] **11** Then Judah said to Tamar his daughter-in-law, "Re-main a widow in your father's house until my son Shelah grows up". For he said, "Lest he also die like his brothers".[b] So Tamar went and lived in her father's house.

12 After a long time the daughter of Shua, Judah's wife, died.[c] When Judah was comforted, he went to his sheepshearers at Timnah, he and his friend Hirah the Adullamite. **13** And Tamar was told, "Look, your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to shear his sheep".[d] **14** So she took off her widow's clothes, covered herself with a veil, and disguised herself. And she sat at the entrance of Enaim, which is on the way to Timnah, for she saw that Shelah had grown up, and she had not been given to him as a wife.[e] **15** And Judah saw her and thought she was a prostitute, because she had covered her face. **16** And he turned aside to her by the way and said, "Come now, let me come in to you"; for he did not know that she was his daughter-in-law. And she said, "What will you give me so that you may come in to me?" **17** And he said, “I will send a young goat from the flock”. So she said, “Will you give me a pledge until you send it?” **18** And he said, “What pledge shall I give you?” And she said, “Your signet with its cord, and your staff in your hand.” So he gave them to her and went in to her; and she conceived by him. **19** Then she got up and left, took off the veil from her face, and resumed her widow’s clothes.

20 And Judah sent the young goat by the hand of his friend the Adullamite, to receive the pledge from the woman’s hand; but he could not find her. **21** So he asked the men of that place, saying, “Where is the prostitute who was at the entrance of Enaim by the way?” And they said, “There was no prostitute here”. **22** Then he

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[a] In Deuteronomy 25:7-10 the punishment for refusing to produce offspring for a brother who died childless was public humiliation, not death; and that was under the severity of the Mosaic Law. Genesis 9:6 states the crime that called for the death penalty, between the Flood and the Law.

[b] Apparently Judah figured that Tamar was responsible for the death of his sons, in some way.

[c] Judah was left without a wife, which helps to understand what he did next.

[d] That must have been done on purpose, by someone who knew the family.

[e] According to the culture of that time, this was a legitimate hope on her part, which Judah recognized in verse 26.

returned to Judah and said, “I did not find her; and also the men of that place said, ‘There was no prostitute here’.” **23** Then Judah said, “Let her have the pledge, that we not be put to shame. I did send this young goat, but you did not find her.”

24 About three months later, Judah was told, “Tamar your daughter-in-law has committed adultery, and she is pregnant through prostitution”. So Judah said, “Bring her out and let her be burned!”[a] **25** As she was being brought out, she sent word to her father-in-law, saying, “I am pregnant by the man to whom these things belong”. And she said, “Please determine whose these things are: this signet with its cord, and this staff”. **26** Judah acknowledged them and said, “She is more righteous than I, because I did not give her to Shelah my son”. And he never knew her again. **27** And it came to pass at the time of her giving birth that twins were in her womb. **28** And as she was giving birth, one put out his hand; and the midwife took a scarlet thread and tied it on his hand, saying, “This one came out first”. **29** But then he drew back his hand, and it was his brother who came out! So she said, “How did you force your way out?” Therefore his name was called Perez.[b] **30** Then his brother came out, who had the scarlet thread on his hand; and his name was called Zerah.[c]

Joseph in Potiphar's house

39:1 Now Joseph had been taken down to Egypt; and Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the guard, an Egyptian, bought him from the Ishmaelites,[d] who had brought him down there. **2** And Jehovah was with Joseph and made him a successful man; and he lived in the house of his Egyptian master. **3** And his master saw that Jehovah was with him, and that Jehovah made all that he

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[a] How cruel! However, she was not killed, when she proved that Judah himself was the father.

[b] The name means: breakthrough. It was through Perez that the Messiah came, Matthew 1:3. Tamar is one of four women included in Christ’s genealogy as given by Matthew. All four represented some violation, perhaps to emphasize the grace of God. He is always recycling.

[c] The name means: scarlet.

[d] It was God's will that Joseph be bought by that man, so that he would end up in the right prison.

did prosper in his hand.[a] **4** So Joseph found favor in his eyes, and served him; and he made him overseer of his house, and put into his hand all that he had. **5** And it came to pass, from the time that he had made him overseer of his house and all that he had, that Jehovah blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake; and the blessing of Jehovah was on all that he had, in the house and in the field. **6** So he left all that he had in Joseph's hand, and knew nothing of what he had, except for the bread that he ate. Now Joseph was handsome in body and appearance.

7 And it came to pass after these things, that his master's wife cast her eyes upon Joseph, and said, "Lie with me".[b] **8** But he refused, and said to his master's wife, “Look, my master does not know what is with me in the house, and he has given all that he has into my hand. **9** There is no one greater in this house than I, neither has he kept back anything from me but you, because you are his wife. How then could I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?”[c] **10** So it was, as she spoke to Joseph day by day, that he did not listen to her, to lie with her, or to be with her. **11** But it happened on a certain day, that he went into the house to do his work; and none of the men of the house was there inside; **12** and she caught him by his garment, saying, "Lie with me". But he left his garment in her hand, and fled, and went outside. **13** So when she saw that he had left his garment in her hand and had fled outside, **14** she called to the men of her house and said to them, “See, my husband has brought in a Hebrew to mock us; he came in to me to lie with me, and I cried out with a loud voice.[d] **15** And it happened, when he heard that I raised my voice and cried out, that he left his garment with me, and fled and went outside.” **16** So she kept his garment with her until his master came home. **17** Then she

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[a] But what could Potiphar have known about Jehovah? How did he know that it was Jehovah who blessed Joseph? He sensed that some supernatural power was with Joseph, and Moses, writing centuries later, gave that Power His proper name. We are not told how much time elapsed between Joseph’s arrival and his promotion.

[b] She certainly had an easy life, with servants to do all the housework, and Joseph was attractive. So what happened, happened.

[c] He would not only be sinning against his master, but mainly against God.

[d] How come no one heard that loud cry?

spoke to him in the same way, saying, “The Hebrew servant whom you brought to us came in to me to mock me. **18** And it happened, when I raised my voice and cried out, that he left his garment with me and fled outside.”

Joseph in prison

39:19 So it was, when his master heard his wife’s words, which she spoke to him, saying, “Your slave did to me according to these words”, that his anger was aroused. **20** Then Joseph's master took him and put him in the prison, the place where the king's prisoners were confined;[a] and there he stayed. **21** But Jehovah was with Joseph, and shewed him kindness, and gave him favor in the sight of the prison warden. **22** And the warden committed to Joseph's hand all the prisoners that were in the prison; whatever they did there, he was responsible. **23** The warden did not check on anything that was under Joseph’s care,[b] because Jehovah was with him, and Jehovah prospered whatever he did.

40:1 It came to pass after those things, that the cupbearer and the baker of the king of Egypt offended their lord, the king of Egypt. **2** And Pharaoh was very angry with his two officers, with the chief cupbearer and with the chief baker. **3** So he put them in custody in the house of the captain of the guard, in the prison, the place where Joseph was confined. **4** And the captain of the guard put Joseph in charge of them, and he ministered to them; and they were in custody many days. **5** Then the cupbearer and the baker of the king of Egypt, who were confined in the prison, had a dream, both of them, each man’s dream in one night,[c] each dream having its own interpretation. **6** And Joseph came in to them in the

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[a] God used that bad woman to put Joseph in the right place, for the sequence of following events. She put her husband in a tight spot; he may very well have had his doubts about what really happened, but he had to keep up appearances. He must have advised the warden about Joseph, which is why he treated him differently. And he certainly wasn't pleased to have lost God's blessing on his home and business. Psalm 76:10 says that God uses the wrath of man to His own glory.

[b] Like Potiphar, the warden sensed that some supernatural power was with Joseph.

[c] That they both had their dream on the same night was obviously from God; in fact, the dreams themselves were from God.

morning and looked at them and saw that they were sad. **7** So he asked Pharaoh's officers, who were with him in the custody of his lord's house, saying, "Why are your faces sad today?" **8** And they said to him, “We each have had a dream, but there is no one to interpret it.” And Joseph said to them, “Do not interpretations come from God? Then tell me!”[a]

9 Then the chief cupbearer told Joseph his dream and said to him, “In my dream there was a vine before me. **10** On the vine there were three branches; when it budded, its blossoms came out, and its clusters ripened into grapes. **11** Pharaoh’s cup was in my hand, and I took the grapes and pressed them into Pharaoh’s cup, and I gave the cup into Pharaoh’s hand.” **12** Then Joseph said to him, “This is the interpretation of it: The three branches represent three days. **13** In three days’ time Pharaoh will lift up your head and restore you to your position, and you will give Pharaoh’s cup into his hand, according to the former custom when you were his cupbearer.[b] **14** But remember me when it goes well with you; and please show me kindness and make mention of me to Pharaoh, and get me out of this house. **15** For I was indeed stolen away from the land of the Hebrews, and even here I have done nothing to deserve to be put in this dungeon.”[c]

16 When the chief baker saw that the interpretation was good, he said to Joseph, “I also dreamed, and there were three white baskets on my head. **17** And in the uppermost basket were all kinds of baked food for Pharaoh, and the birds ate it from the basket on my head.” **18** So Joseph answered and said, “This is the interpretation of it: The three baskets represent three days. **19** In three days’ time Pharaoh will lift off your head from you and hang you on a tree, and the birds will eat away your flesh from you.”[d] **20** So it happened, on the third day, Pharaoh’s birthday, that he made a feast for all his servants; and he lifted up the head of the chief

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[a] Evidently Joseph expected God to give him the interpretations. Had God prepared him in some way?

[b] God gave him the interpretation immediately.

[c] Even though God had used Joseph in the prison, he wanted to get out, which was natural.

[d] Joseph did nothing to soften the message!

cupbearer and the head of the chief baker in the midst of his servants. **21** He restored the chief cupbearer to his office as cupbearer, and he gave the cup into Pharaoh's hand. **22** But he hanged the chief baker, as Joseph had interpreted to them. **23** However, the chief cupbearer did not remember Joseph, but forgot him.[a]

Joseph and Pharaoh

41:1 Now it came to pass, after two full years, that Pharaoh had a dream; and behold, he was standing by the river.[b] **2** And then, seven cows, well-favored and fat-fleshed, came up out of the river; and they fed in the meadow. **3** And then, seven other cows came up out of the river after them, ugly and emaciated, and stood beside the first cows on the river's bank. **4** Then the ugly and emaciated cows ate up the seven sleek and fat cows! Then Pharaoh awoke. **5** Then he slept and dreamed again; and behold, seven heads of grain, plump and healthy, grew up on one stalk. **6** And then, seven thin heads, scorched by the east wind, grew up after them. **7** And the seven thin heads devoured the seven plump and full heads! Then Pharaoh awoke, and indeed, it was a dream. **8** And it came to pass in the morning, that his spirit was troubled; and he sent and called all the magicians of Egypt, and all his wise men; and Pharaoh told them his dreams: but there was no one who could interpret them for Pharaoh.

9 Then the chief cupbearer spoke to Pharaoh, saying, "I must now confess my neglect.[c] **10** Pharaoh was angry with his servants and put me in custody in the house of the captain of the guard, me and the chief baker. **11** And we each had a dream the same night, he and I, each dream having its own interpretation. **12** And a young Hebrew man was there with us, a slave of the captain of the guard. And we told them to him, and he interpreted our dreams for us; he interpreted to each man according to his dream. **13** And it happened just as he interpreted to us: he restored me to my position, and him he hanged!"

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[a] That was typical of human nature without God.

[b] The Nile.

[c] The neglect of having forgotten Joseph, his request.

14 Then Pharaoh sent and called Joseph, and they brought him quickly out of the dungeon. He shaved, changed his clothes and came in to Pharaoh. **15** So Pharaoh said to Joseph, “I had a dream, and there is no one who can interpret it; but I have heard it said about you that when you hear a dream you can interpret it”. **16** Joseph answered Pharaoh, “Not I; God will give Pharaoh a propitious answer”. **17** Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, “In my dream, I was standing on the bank of the river. **18** And then, seven cows, well-favored and fat-fleshed, came up out of the river, and they fed in the meadow. **19** And then, seven other cows came up after them; they were scrawny, very ugly and emaciated, such as I have never seen in all the land of Egypt.[a] **20** Then the ugly and emaciated cows ate up the first seven fat cows! **21** And after they had eaten them up, no one could tell that they had eaten them, for their appearance was just as ugly as at the beginning. Then I awoke. **22** Then I dreamed again, and behold, seven heads, plump and healthy, came up on one stalk. **23** And then, seven heads, withered, thin and scorched by the east wind, sprang up after them. **24** And the thin heads devoured the seven good heads. So I told the magicians, but there was no one who could interpret for me.”

25 Then Joseph said to Pharaoh, “Pharaoh had only one dream; God has told Pharaoh what he is about to do. **26** The seven good cows are seven years; the seven good heads are seven years; it is one dream. **27** And the seven thin, ugly cows that came up after them are seven years; and the seven thin heads scorched by the east wind are seven years of famine. **28** It is just as I said to Pharaoh; God has told Pharaoh what he is about to do. **29** Indeed, seven years of great plenty will come throughout the land of Egypt; **30** but after them will come seven years of famine, and all that plenty will be forgotten in the land of Egypt, and the famine will consume the land. **31** And the plenty in the land will not be remembered, because of the famine that follows, for it will be very severe. **32** And the dream was repeated twice to Pharaoh, because God has determined this thing, and God will do it soon.

[a] This observation was Pharaoh's reaction.

33 "Now therefore, let Pharaoh look for a discerning and wise man, and let him set him over the land of Egypt. **34** Let Pharaoh do so, and let him appoint administrators over the land, to collect a fifth of the produce of the land of Egypt during the seven years of plenty. **35** And let them gather all the food of those good years that are to come, and let them store up grain under Pharaoh's hand,[a] let them store it for food in the cities. **36** Then that food will be as a reserve for the land against the seven years of famine that will be in the land of Egypt, that the land may not perish through the famine."[b]

37 Well now, the advice pleased Pharaoh and all his servants. **38** And Pharaoh said to his servants, "Can we find anyone like this man, in whom the spirit of God is?" **39** Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Since God has made all this known to you, there is no one so discerning and wise as you. **40** You shall be over my house, and all my people shall be ruled according to your word; only in respect to the throne will I be greater than you." **41** And Pharaoh said to Joseph, "I am indeed setting you over all the land of Egypt".

42 Then Pharaoh took his signet ring from his hand and put it on Joseph's hand; and he clothed him with fine linen garments and put a gold chain around his neck. **43** And he had him ride in the second chariot which he had; and they cried out before him, "Bow the knee!" So he set him over all the land of Egypt. **44** Pharaoh also said to Joseph, "I am Pharaoh; and without your word no one will lift hand or foot in all the land of Egypt."[c] **45** And Pharaoh called Joseph's name Zaphenath-Paneah, and gave him Asenath, the daughter of Potiphera, priest of On, as his wife. And Joseph went

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[a] Pharaoh's authority was to be respected and protected.

[b] The advice Joseph gave was not part of the dreams, but God obviously spoke through him. That was why God gave the dreams. In the long run, God intended to preserve the lives of Jacob and his descendants; and it was in Goshen that they proliferated.

[c] I understand that that was an exaggerated way of saying that all the people in Egypt would be under Joseph's authority, a condition guaranteed by Pharaoh himself. But what a difference, what a transformation: from prisoner in a dungeon to ruler of the country!

out over the land of Egypt. **46** Joseph was thirty years old[a] when he stood before Pharaoh king of Egypt. And Joseph went out from the presence of Pharaoh and went throughout all the land of Egypt.

Joseph rules Egypt

41:47 During the seven years of plenty, the land produced abundantly. **48** He gathered up all the food of the seven years that were in the land of Egypt, and he stored it in the cities, putting in each city the food from its surrounding fields. **49** So Joseph gathered grain in great abundance, like the sand of the sea, until he stopped counting it, because it was beyond counting. **50** Before a year of famine came, two sons were born to Joseph, whom Asenath the daughter of Potiphera, priest of On, bore to him. **51** Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh:[b] "For God has made me forget all my toil and all my father's house". **52** He called the name of the second Ephraim:[c] "For God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction".

53 Then the seven years of plenty that were in the land of Egypt ended, **54** and the seven years of famine began to come, as Joseph had said. The famine was in all lands, but in all the land of Egypt there was bread. **55** And when all the land of Egypt was famished, the people cried out to Pharaoh for bread. And Pharaoh said to all the Egyptians, "Go to Joseph; whatever he tells you, do." **56** So when the famine was severe throughout the land, Joseph opened all the storehouses and sold to the Egyptians, for the famine was severe throughout the land of Egypt. **57** And all the

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[a] I will attempt an arbitrary calculation. I imagine that Joseph spent some four years in the prison, and that he spent some three years with Potiphar, before being sent there (his promotion did not happen overnight). In that event, he would have been twenty-three when he arrived in Egypt. Since he was born at the end of the fourteen years that Jacob worked for his wives, he would have been about seven when Jacob settled at Succoth. If Jacob stayed thirteen years in Succoth (as I have argued elsewhere), Joseph was twenty when they entered Canaan. If Benjamin was born a year later, he would have been around nineteen when he was taken to Egypt; since the last time Joseph saw him he was a toddler, he would not have recognized him.

[b] The name means 'forgetting'.

[c] The name means 'fruitful'.

countries came to Joseph in Egypt to buy grain, for the famine was severe in all the lands.[a]

Joseph and his brothers

42:1 When Jacob heard that there was grain in Egypt, he said to his sons, “Why are you just looking at one another?” **2** He said, “Indeed, I have heard that there is grain in Egypt; go down there and buy for us from there, so that we may live and not die.” **3** So Joseph’s ten brothers went down to buy grain in Egypt. **4** But Jacob did not send Benjamin, Joseph’s brother, with his brothers, for he said, “Lest he come to harm”. **5** So the sons of Israel went to buy grain among the others who went, because there was famine in the land of Canaan. **6** Now Joseph was governor over the land; he was the one selling to all the people of the land.

Then Joseph's brothers came and bowed down to him with their faces to the ground. **7** When Joseph saw his brothers, he recognized them, but he acted as a stranger toward them and spoke harshly to them. He said to them, "Where do you come from?" And they said, "From the land of Canaan, to buy food". **8** Joseph recognized his brothers, but they did not recognize him. **9** Then Joseph remembered the dreams he had dreamed about them, and said to them, "You are spies! You have come to see where the land is unprotected!"[b] **10** And they said to him, "No, my lord, but your servants have come to buy food. **11** We are all sons of the same man; we are honest; your servants are not spies." **12** But he said to them, "No, but you have come to see the unprotected land". **13** And they said, “Your servants are twelve brothers, the sons of one man in the land of Canaan; indeed, the youngest is with our father this day; and the other is no more.” **14** Then Joseph said unto them, “It is just as I said to you, ‘You are spies!’ **15** This is how you will be tested: As surely as Pharaoh lives, you shall not leave here, unless your youngest brother comes here. **16** Send one of you to fetch your brother; and you shall be kept in prison, that your words may be tested, whether there is any truth in you; or else, as surely as Pharaoh lives, you are spies.” **17** And he

[a] We may assume that they were neighboring lands.

[b] José starts to ‘get even’ with his brothers.

put them all in prison for three days.

18 On the third day Joseph said to them, “I fear God; do this, and you will live. **19** If you are honest men, let one of you brothers be bound in your prison house;[a] and you go, carry grain for the famine in your households. **20** And bring your youngest brother to me; so your words will be verified and you will not die.” And they did so. **21** Then they said to one another, “We are truly guilty concerning our brother, for we saw the anguish of his soul when he begged us,[b] but we did not listen; therefore this distress has come upon us.”[c] **22** And Reuben answered them, saying, “Did I not say to you, ‘Do not sin against the boy’? But you did not listen! So his blood is being required.” **23** They did not know that Joseph under-stood them, for he spoke to them through an interpreter. **24** So he went away from them and wept. Then he returned to them and spoke to them. And he took Simeon from among them and bound him before their eyes.

25 Then Joseph commanded that their sacks be filled with grain, and that each man's money be returned to his sack, and that they be given food for the journey. And it was done for them. **26** So they loaded their grain on their donkeys and departed from there. **27** And one of them, when he opened his sack to give food to his donkey at the lodging place, he saw his money—there it was in the mouth of his sack! **28** So he said to his brothers, "My money has been returned; here it is in my sack!" Then their hearts failed them, and they were terrified, saying to one another, "What is this that God has done to us?"[d]

Jacob and his sons

29 They came to their father Jacob in the land of Canaan and told him everything that had happened to them. They said, **30** “The man, the lord of the land, spoke harshly to us and treated us like

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[a] That is, the house where they had been in prison; evidently they had not been put in a nasty prison.

[b] Joseph begged not to be sold.

[c] It seems that they were marked by what they did to Joseph; their consciences were troubled.

[d] They attributed the situation to God; well, it was certainly strange, inexplicable by normal logic.

spies of the land. **31** And we said to him, 'We are honest men, we are not spies. **32** We are twelve brothers, our father's sons; one is no more, and the youngest is now with our father in the land of Canaan.' **33** Then the man, the lord of the land, said to us, 'By this I will know that you are honest: leave one of your brothers with me and take food for the famine of your house-holds, and go. **34** Bring your youngest brother to me; then I will know that you are not spies, but that you are honest. Then I will give your brother to you, and you may trade in the land.'" **35** Then it happened, as they emptied their sacks—each man's bundle of money was in his sack! When they and their father saw the bundles of money, they were afraid.[a]

36 Then their father Jacob said to them, "You have bereaved me; Joseph is not, and Simeon is not; and you would take Benjamin! All this is against me." **37** Then Reuben said to his father, "You may kill my two sons if I do not bring him back to you; give him into my hand, and I will bring him back to you". **38** But he said, "My son shall not go down with you,[b] for his brother is dead, and he alone is left. If harm should happen to him on the way that you go, you would bring my gray hair down to Sheol in sorrow."

43:1 Now the famine was severe in the land. **2** And it came to pass, when they had eaten up the grain which they had brought from Egypt, that their father said to them, "Go back, buy us a little food". **3** But Judah answered him, saying, "The man emphatically warned us, saying, 'You shall not see my face unless your brother is with you'. **4** If you will send our brother with us, we will go down and buy you food. **5** But if you will not send him, we will not go down; for the man said to us, 'You shall not see my face unless your brother is with you'." **6** And Israel said, "Why did you treat me so badly as to tell the man that you had another brother?" **7** And they said, "The man asked us pointedly about ourselves, and about our kindred, saying, 'Is your father still alive? Do you have another brother?' And we answered him according to those words. How

[a] Indeed, the thing was very strange.

[b] Jacob was condemning Simeon to rot in prison, but he probably didn't think of that.

could we have known that he would say, 'Bring your brother down'?"

8 Then Judah said to his father Israel, "Send the youth with me, and we will arise and go, so that we may live and not die, both we, you and our children. **9** I myself will be surety for him; you can require him from my hand. If I do not bring him back to you and set him before you, I will bear the blame before you forever. **10** For if we had not delayed, surely by now we would have returned a second time."[a] **11** Then their father Israel said to them, "If it must be so, do this: Take some of the best produce of the land in your vessels and carry a gift to the man: a little balm and a little honey, spices and myrrh, pistachio nuts and almonds.[b] **12** And take double the money in your hand; and take back in your hand the money that was returned in the mouth of your sacks; perhaps it was an oversight. **13** Take your brother also and arise; go back to the man. **14** And may God Almighty give you mercy before the man, and may he release your other brother and Benjamin to you. And I, if I am bereaved, bereaved I will be!"[c]

Joseph and his brothers, second time

43:15 Then the men took the gift, double the money in their hand, and Benjamin. They arose and went down to Egypt and presented themselves to Joseph. **16** When Joseph saw Benjamin with them, he said to the steward of his house, "Take these men to the house, and kill and prepare an animal; for these men will eat with me at noon". **17** So the man did as Joseph had said; he brought the men into Joseph's house. **18** Well the men were afraid, because they were brought into Joseph's house; and they said, "It is because of the money that was returned in our sacks the other time that we are being brought here, to incriminate us and to subdue us, to enslave us and to take our donkeys."[d] **19** So they approached the steward of Joseph's house and spoke to him at the door of the house. **20** And they said, "Oh my lord, we indeed came

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[a] Judah begins to take the lead, which will become evident later on.

[b] It seems there were still some edible things, but not the basic food.

[c] Poor Jacob!

[d] Well, the men had reason to be afraid, but it seems that there was pessimism as well.

down the first time to buy food; **21** but it happened, when we came to the lodging place, and opened our sacks, there, each man's money was in the mouth of his sack, our money in full weight; so we have brought it back in our hand. **22** And we have brought other money in our hand to buy food; we do not know who put our money in our sacks." **23** And he said, "Peace be to you, do not fear. Your God, also the God of your father,[a] has given you treasure in your sacks; your money came to me."[b] Then he brought Simeon out to them.[c]

24 The steward brought the men into Joseph's house and gave them water, and they washed their feet; he also gave their donkeys fodder. **25** Then they prepared the present for Joseph's coming at noon, for they had heard that they were to eat bread there. **26** When Joseph entered the house, they brought the present that was in their hand to him, in the house, and bowed down to him to the ground. **27** He asked them how they were doing, and said, "Is your father, the old man of whom you spoke, well? Is he still alive?" **28** And they said, "Your servant our father is well; he is still alive". And they bowed their heads and bowed down. **29** Then he lifted his eyes and saw his brother Benjamin, his mother's son, and said, "Is this your youngest brother of whom you spoke to me?" Then he said, "May God be gracious to you, my son". **30** And Joseph hurried and looked for a place to weep, for he was deeply moved with emotion toward his brother; and he went into his private room and wept there. **31** Then he washed his face and came out; and he restrained himself, and said, "Serve the bread!"

32 So they served him by himself, and them by themselves, and the Egyptians who ate with him by themselves; because the Egyptians could not eat bread with the Hebrews, for that is an abomination to the Egyptians.[d] **33** And they sat before him, the firstborn according to his birthright, and the youngest according to

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[a] It seems curious to me that the man should say it was God; in fact, their God!

[b] The man did not lie; he had indeed received the money; only Joseph had ordered that it be returned.

[c] Joseph kept his word; they brought Benjamin, and he released Simeon.

[d] Racism has been around for a long time!

his youth; and the men looked at each other in astonishment.[a] **34** And portions were taken to them from before him; but Benjamin's portion was five times as much as any of theirs. So they drank and were merry with him.

44:1 Joseph commanded the steward of his house, saying, "Fill these men's sacks with as much food as they can carry, and put each man's money in the mouth of his sack. **2** Also put my cup, the silver cup, in the mouth of the sack of the youngest,[b] along with his grain money." And he did as Joseph had said. **3** When the morning dawned, the men were sent away, they and their donkeys. **4** When they were not yet far from the city, Joseph said to his steward, "Get up, follow the men until you overtake them. And say to them, 'Why have you repaid evil for good? **5** Where is the cup from which my lord drinks, and by which he really does divination?[c] What you have done is wicked'." **6** And he overtook them and spoke those words to them. **7** And they said to him, "Why does my lord say such things? Far be it from your servants to do such a thing. **8** Look, we even brought back to you from the land of Canaan the money that we found in the mouth of our sacks. How then could we steal silver or gold from your lord's house? **9** Let the one of your servants with whom it is found die,[d] and we also will be my lord's slaves." **10** And he said, "Very well then, let it be according to your words; the one with whom it is found will be my slave, but you will be innocent."[e] **11** So they hurried, and each man put his sack down on the ground, and each one opened his sack. **12** Then the steward searched,

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[a] The men's reaction allows us to deduce that they had been seated at the table in order of age, from oldest to youngest. Only someone within the family could have known that. See also 44:12.

[b] That was dirty! However, they had caused him years of physical suffering, as well as emotional suffering. He did not cause them any physical suffering (except for a little for Simeon), and their emotional suffering was short-lived.

[c] Joseph certainly used the cup to drink from, but it seems unlikely to me that he practiced divination. Why? God spoke to him. I imagine that he instructed the steward to speak this way just to heighten the seriousness of the accusation.

[d] That was extreme! They were desperate.

[e] He accepted their proposal, but softened it considerably.

beginning with the oldest and ending with the youngest;[a] and the cup was found in Benjamin's sack.[b] **13** Then they tore their clothes, and each man loaded his donkey and returned to the city.

14 So Judah[c] and his brothers came to Joseph's house, and he was still there; and they fell to the ground before him.[d] **15** Then Joseph said to them, "What is this that you have done? Did you not know that someone like I am can certainly divine?" **16** Then Judah said, "What shall we say to my lord? What shall we speak? And how can we clear ourselves? God has exposed the iniquity of your servants; so then, we are my lord's slaves, both we and he in whose hand the cup was found." **17** But he said, "Far be it from me to do such a thing! The man in whose hand the cup was found, he shall be my slave. As for you, go up in peace to your father."

18 Then Judah came near to him and said, "O my lord, please let your servant speak a word in the ears of my lord, and do not let your anger burn against your servant, for you are like Pharaoh. **19** My lord asked his servants, saying, 'Do you have a father or a brother?' **20** And we said to my lord, 'We have an aged father, and a young son of his old age, whose brother is dead; and he alone is left of his mother, and his father loves him'. **21** Then you said to your servants, 'Bring him to me, that I may set my eyes on him'. **22** And we said to my lord, 'The youth cannot leave his father; for if he should leave his father, his father would die'. **23** Then you said to your servants, 'Unless your youngest brother comes down with you, you will see my face no more'. **24** So it was, when we went up to your servant my father, that we told him the words of my lord. **25** When our father said, 'Go back, buy us a little food', **26** we said, 'We cannot go down; but if our youngest brother goes with us, we

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[a] How did he know the order? He remembered the instructions he had received to place them at the table.

[b] Well now, Benjamin knew he hadn't done anything; and each man's money was back in his sack, which also wasn't their doing. So it was obvious that a higher power was working against them. And since they had offered themselves as slaves, if the cup were found, there was no way out. They returned to the city. Furthermore, to return without Benjamin would likely result in their father's death.

[c] Notice that Judah is now the leader.

[d] They did this several times, just as Joseph had dreamed.

will go down; for we may not see the man's face unless our youngest brother is with us.' **27** Then your servant my father said to us, 'You know that my wife bore me two sons. **28** One of them went away from me, and I said, "Surely he has been torn to pieces", and I have not seen him since. **29** If you also take this one away from me, and harm happens to him, you will bring down my gray hair to Sheol with sorrow.' **30** Now therefore, if I go to your servant my father, and the youth is not with us—since his life is bound up with his son's life—**31** it will happen, when he sees that the youth is not with us, that he will die. Thus your servants will bring down the gray hair of your servant our father with sorrow to Sheol. **32** For your servant became surety for the youth to my father, saying, 'If I do not bring him back to you, I will bear the blame before you, my father, forever'. **33** So then, please let your servant take the young man's place as my lord's slave, and let the youth go up with his brothers—**34** for how can I go up to my father unless the youth is with me?—lest I see the evil that will come upon my father."[a]

Joseph reveals himself to his brothers

45:1 Then Joseph could no longer contain himself before all who were with him, and he cried out, "Have everyone leave me!"[b] So no one stayed with him when Joseph revealed himself to his brothers. **2** He wept so loudly that the Egyptians heard it, and Pharaoh's household was informed about it. **3** Then Joseph said to his brothers, "I am Joseph! Can my father still be alive?"[c] But his brothers could not answer him, for they were terrified of him. **4** Then Joseph said to his brothers, "Now come near to me". And

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[a] Judah's intercession was eloquent and moving; so much so that Joseph could not contain himself. It was Judah's sensible suggestion that saved Joseph from being killed, when he was sold instead, but we do not know if Joseph could hear it. (If he heard it, he knew that he owed his life to Judah; so that he owed Judah some consideration.)

[b] He gave the order in Egyptian, which the brothers did not understand. Then he spoke in Hebrew, when he revealed himself to them.

[c] The brothers were so convinced of Joseph's death that they hadn't even become suspicious, despite the strange things that had happened. So it seems that Joseph wanted to combat their disbelief: if Jacob could still be alive, so could Joseph.

they came near. Then he said, “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. **5** Now then, do not be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here, for God sent me before you to preserve life.[a] **6** There has been a famine in the land for just two years, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvest. **7** Yes, God sent me before you to preserve for you a remnant in the land, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. **8** So it was not really you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and ruler over all the land of Egypt. **9** Hurry and go up to my father, and say to him, ‘This is what your son Joseph says: “God has made me lord of all Egypt; come down to me, do not delay. **10** You will live in the land of Goshen,[b] and you will be near me—you and your children, your children’s children, your flocks and your herds and all that you have. **11** I will provide for you there, because there will be five more years of famine, so that you will not become destitute, you and your household and all that you have”.’ **12** Now really, your eyes and the eyes of my brother Benjamin see that it is I who am speaking to you. **13** So you tell my father of all my glory in Egypt, and of all that you have seen; so hurry and bring my father down here.” **14** Then he fell on his brother Benjamin's neck and wept, and Benjamin wept on his neck. **15** Then he kissed all his brothers and wept over them; and after that his brothers talked with him.[c]

16 Now this news was heard in Pharaoh's house, saying, “Joseph's brothers have come”. And it pleased Pharaoh and his servants well. **17** So Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Say to your brothers, 'Do this: Load your animals and depart; go to the land of Canaan. **18** Take your father and your households and come to me. I will give you the best of the land of Egypt, and you will eat the fat of the land. **19** Each of you individually is commanded: Do this: take wagons from the land of Egypt for your little ones and for your wives; take your father and come. **20** Do not worry about your

[a] Joseph clearly states that it was God who directed the whole story.

[b] Joseph already had everything planned.

[c] The brothers found it hard to believe that it could be Joseph, but they ended up being convinced.

possessions, for the best of all the land of Egypt will be yours'."[a]

21 Then the sons of Israel did so. And Joseph gave them wagons, according to Pharaoh's command; he also gave them food for the journey. **22** And he gave to each of them all a change of clothing; but to Benjamin he gave three hundred pieces of silver and five changes of clothing. **23** He also sent to his father ten donkeys loaded with the best of Egypt, and ten female donkeys loaded with grain, and bread and food for his father for the journey. **24** Then he sent his brothers away, and they departed. And he said to them, "Do not quarrel on the way!"[b] **25** So they went up out of Egypt, and came to the land of Canaan, to Jacob their father. **26** And they told him, saying, "Joseph is still alive; indeed, he is ruler over all the land of Egypt." And Jacob's heart almost stopped; he did not believe them. **27** But they told him all the words of Joseph, which he had spoken to them; and he saw the wagons which Joseph had sent to carry him; and the spirit of Jacob their father revived. **28** Then Israel said, "It is enough;[c] my son Joseph is still alive; I will go and see him before I die."

The people of Israel move to Egypt

46:1 Then Israel set out with all that he had and came to Beersheba and offered sacrifices to the God of his father Isaac. **2** And God spoke to Israel in the visions of the night, and said, "Jacob, Jacob!"[d] And he said, "Here I am". **3** And He said, "I am God, the God of your father; do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make of you a great nation. **4** I will go down with you to Egypt, and will surely bring you back;[e] and Joseph will put his hand on your eyes."[f] **5** Then Jacob arose from Beersheba; and the sons of Israel carried their father Jacob, their little ones and their wives in the wagons that Pharaoh had sent to carry him. **6** They took their

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[a] Pharaoh's generosity and goodwill are impressive.

[b] This order is curious. It seems that Joseph didn't want anything to delay his father's coming.

[c] The evidence was enough to convince him.

[d] Why did God call him Jacob, instead of Israel?

[e] God brought the descendants back, and Jacob's body was taken back.

[f] This expression may mean that Joseph would close Jacob's eyes at the moment of his death. See 50:1.

livestock and their possessions that they had acquired in the land of Canaan and went to Egypt, Jacob and all his descendants with him. **7** His sons and his sons' sons were with him. His daughters, and his sons' daughters, and all his descendants he took with him to Egypt.[a]

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[a] 46:7 lists the descendants that Jacob took with him to Egypt: his sons and his sons' sons, and his daughters and his sons' daughters; that is, those who could be called his descendants. (There were doubtless many slaves as well, not to mention the children of Shechem that were not killed.) If Joseph was 37 at the time (30 + 7), Reuben was 43, and four of his sons are named (but no daughters). Simeon was 42 (at the most), and six of his sons are named (but no daughters). Levi was 41 (at the most), and three of his sons are named (but no daughters).

Judah was 40 (at the most), and five of his sons are named, two of which God had executed (but no daughters). **However**, two of his grandsons are also named. Now then, Er and Onan were adults when God executed them, and Shelah was an adult when Perez was born. Judah's first three had to be at least a year apart in age. In short, Perez was no more than a toddler when he was taken to Egypt, so his two sons were still in his 'loins', to be born in Egypt many years later.

Issachar was 37 (at the most), and four of his sons are named (but no daughters). Zebulon was 36 (at the most), and three of his sons ae named (but no daughters). The only daughter who is named is Dinah, among the descendants of Leah. Gad was 39 (at the most), and seven of his sons are named (but no daughters). Asher was 38 (at the most), and four of his sons are named, plus one daughter. Since Joseph was already there, we come to Benjamin, who was 19 (at the most), and ten of his sons are named (but no daughters). As with Perez, most, if not all, of those ten were still in his 'loins', to be born later in Egypt. If Moses wrote under Inspiration, then the inclusion of those yet to be born sons was deliberate. Why? I suppose that it is to emphasize that it is the human male that begets, that procreates, that transmits life, soul/spirit and the image of God. Dan was 40 (at the most), and only one son is named (and no daughters). Naphtali was 39 (at the most), and four of his sons are named (but no daughters).

Now then, verse seven includes Jacob's daughters and his sons' daughters, but only one of each is mentioned in the following list, although many more had certainly been born. On the other hand, the sons of Perez and Benjamin had yet to be born! Just as Matthew gave an edited or selective genealogy of the Christ (as I demonstrate in my article, 'Some related anomalies in Matthew's genealogy of the Christ'), so Moses gave an edited or selective list of the persons who accompanied Jacob to Egypt.

8 These are the names of the children of Israel who went into Egypt: Jacob and his sons: Reuben, Jacob's firstborn. **9** The sons of Reuben: Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron and Carmi. **10** The sons of Simeon: Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar, and Shaul, the son of a Canaanite woman.[a] **11** The sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath and Merari. **12** The sons of Judah: Er, Onan, Shelah, Perez and Zerah (but Er and Onan died in the land of Canaan). The sons of Perez were Hezron and Hamul. **13** The sons of Issachar: Tola, Puvah, Job and Shimron. **14** The sons of Zebulun: Sered, Elon and Jahleel. **15** Those were the sons of Leah, whom she bore to Jacob in Paddan-Aram, and his daughter Dinah; all the souls of his sons and his daughters were thirty-three.[b]

16 The sons of Gad: Ziphion, Haggi, Shuni, Ezbon, Eri, Arodi and Areli. 17 The sons of Asher: Jimnah, Ishuah, Isui, Beriah, and their sister Serah. And the sons of Beriah were Heber and Malchiel. 18 Those were the sons of Zilpah, whom Laban gave to his daughter Leah; she bore those sixteen souls to Jacob.[c]

19 The sons of Rachel, Jacob's wife: Joseph and Benjamin. **20** And to Joseph, in the land of Egypt, were born Manasseh and Ephraim, whom Asenath, the daughter of Potiphera priest of On, bore to him. **21** The sons of Benjamin: Belah, Becher, Ashbel, Gera, Naaman, Ehi, Rosh, Muppim, Huppim and Ard. **22** Those were the sons of Rachel, who were born to Jacob: fourteen souls in all.

23 The son of Dan: Hushim. **24** The sons of Naphtali: Jahzeel, Guni, Jezer and Shillem. **25** Those were the sons of Bilhah, whom Laban gave to Rachel his daughter; she bore them to Jacob: seven souls in all. **26** All the souls who went with Jacob to Egypt, who came from his loins,[d] aside from the wives of Jacob's sons, were sixty-six souls in all. **27** The sons of Joseph, who were born to him in Egypt, were two souls: all the souls of the house of Jacob who

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[a] If all of them got their wives from Shechem, all their wives were Canaanite, so how was this one different?

[b] The number only includes one daughter.

[c] The number includes the sister.

[d] ‘Loins’, plural, is used to refer to the male reproductive system. ‘Loin’, singular, means 'waist'.

went to Egypt were seventy.[a]

28 Jacob sent Judah ahead of him to Joseph, to give him directions to Goshen; and they came to the land of Goshen. **29** Joseph prepared his chariot and went up to Goshen to meet his father, Israel. When he came to him, he fell on his neck and wept there for a long time.[b] **30** And Israel said to Joseph, “Now I can die, for I have seen your face, and you are still alive”.[c] **31** Then Joseph said to his brothers and to his father's household, "I will go up and report to Pharaoh, and say to him, 'My brothers and my father's household who were in the land of Canaan have come to me. **32** And the men are shepherds, they tend livestock, and they have brought with them their flocks, their herds and all that they have.' **33** Now then, when Pharaoh calls you in, and says, 'What is your occupation?' **34** You must say, 'Your servants have tended livestock from our youth until now, both we and our fathers'; so that you may dwell in the land of Goshen; for every shepherd is an abomination to the Egyptians."[d]

47:1 Then Joseph went and informed Pharaoh, and said, “My father and my brothers, their flocks and their herds, with all that they possess, have come from the land of Canaan; and indeed they are in the land of Goshen”. **2** And he had taken five men from among his brothers, and he presented them to Pharaoh. **3** Then Pharaoh said to the brothers, “What is your occupation?” And they said to Pharaoh, “Your servants are shepherds, both we and our fathers”. **4** They also said to Pharaoh, “We have come to dwell in the land; because there is no pasture for your servants’ flocks, because the famine is severe in the land of Canaan. Therefore, please let your servants dwell in the land of Goshen.” **5** Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, “Your father and your brothers have come to you. **6** The land of Egypt is before you; have your father and your brothers live in the best of the land; let them live in the land of

[a] In addition to Joseph and his two sons, Jacob himself is included, making 70. Without them, the number is 66.

[b] Evidently that was how they expressed their emotions.

[c] But he still lived 17 years!

[d] This information seems curious to me; they had sheep, and someone had to take care of them.

Goshen. And if you know of any competent men among them, put them in charge of my livestock."[a]

7 Then Joseph brought his father Jacob and placed him before Pharaoh; and Jacob blessed Pharaoh.[b] **8** Pharaoh said to Jacob, "How many are the days of the years[c] of your life?" **9** And Jacob said to Pharaoh, "The days of the years of my pilgrimage are one hundred and thirty years; the days of the years of my life have been few and troubled, and have not attained to the days of the years of the life of my fathers, in the days of their pilgrimage."[d] **10** So Jacob blessed Pharaoh, and went out from before Pharaoh. **11** Then Joseph gave a possession to his father and his brothers in the land of Egypt, and settled them in the best of the land, in the land of Rameses, as Pharaoh had commanded. **12** Then Joseph supplied his father, his brothers, and all his father's household with food, according to the number of their children.

The Egyptians sell themselves to Pharaoh

47:13 Now there was no bread in all the land, for the famine was very severe, so that the land of Egypt and the land of Canaan languished because of the famine. **14** So Joseph gathered up all the money that was found in the land of Egypt and in the land of Canaan, for the grain that they bought; and Joseph brought the money into Pharaoh's house. **15** Now when the money from the land of Egypt and the land of Canaan was gone, all the Egyptians came to Joseph and said, "Give us bread; why should we die in your presence? The money is gone!" **16** Then Joseph said, "If the money is gone, bring your livestock, and I will give you bread for your livestock". **17** So they brought their livestock to Joseph, and Joseph gave them bread in exchange for the horses, the flocks, the cattle

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[a] Since the Egyptians despised that occupation, this was one small benefit for Pharaoh.

[b] Hebrews 7:7 says: "Without dispute, the lesser is blessed by the greater". Well, Pharoah owed a great deal to Joseph, and Jacob was his father.

[c] That is what Pharaoh said; and of course each year is made up of days. If most of the days were bad, then you had a bad year.

[d] By definition, a pilgrim is on a journey, away from his home. For those of us whose home is Heaven, life in this world is indeed a 'pilgrimage'. See Hebrews 11:8-10.

and the donkeys. He fed them that year with bread in exchange for all their livestock. **18** When that year was over, they came to him in the second year and said to him, "We will not hide from my lord that our money is gone; my lord also has our herds of livestock. There is nothing left before my lord except our bodies and our lands. **19** Why should we die before your eyes, both we and our land? Buy us and our land for food, and we and our land will become Pharaoh's possession; give us seed that we may live and not die, and the land not become desolate." **20** So Joseph bought all the land of Egypt for Pharaoh; for every man of the Egyptians sold his field, because the famine was severe upon them. So the land became Pharaoh's. **21** And he moved the people into the cities,[a] from one end of the borders of Egypt to the other end. **22** Only the land of the priests he did not buy, because the priests had a portion from Pharaoh, and they ate their portion, which Pharaoh had given them; therefore they did not sell their land.

23 Then Joseph said to the people, "Listen, I have already bought you and your land for Pharaoh; now here is seed for you to sow the land.[b] **24** But you shall give a fifth of each harvest to Pharaoh, and four parts shall be yours for seed for the field, for your food, for yourselves and for those in your households, and for your little ones to eat." **25** So they said, "You have saved our lives; let us find favor in the eyes of my lord, and we will be Pharaoh's slaves". **26** So Joseph established it as a law in the land of Egypt to this day, that a fifth should belong to Pharaoh; except for the land of the priests only; it did not become Pharaoh's.

The last days of Jacob

47:27 Now Israel lived in the land of Egypt, in the area of Goshen, and acquired possessions there; and they were fruitful and multiplied exceedingly.[c] **28** And Jacob lived in the land of Egypt seventeen years; so the days of Jacob, the years of his life, were

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[a] This made it easier to control food distribution according to the size of each family. Rationing was probably necessary to have enough seed left over for planting in the eighth year. (Modern versions may have a different wording, following the Septuagint and Vulgate.)

[b] Logically, this occurred after the seven years of famine.

[c] Here 'Israel' refers to the descendants, not the man.

one hundred and forty-seven years. **29** When the time approached for Israel to die, he called his son Joseph and said to him, “If now I have found favor in your sight, please put your hand under my thigh, and deal kindly and truly with me. Please do not bury me in Egypt, **30** but let me lie with my fathers; you must carry me up out of Egypt and bury me in their burying-place.” And he said, “I will do as you have said”. **31** Then he said, “Swear to me!” And he swore to him. And Israel bowed down on the head of the bed.

Jacob blesses Joseph's sons

48:1 After those things, someone told Joseph, "Your father is sick!" So he took his two sons, Manasseh and Ephraim, with him. **2** And someone told Jacob, "Your son Joseph has come to you". So Israel strengthened himself and sat up on the bed. **3** Then Jacob said to Joseph, “God Almighty appeared to me at Luz[a] in the land of Canaan and blessed me. **4** He said to me, ‘Indeed, I will make you fruitful and multiply you, and I will make you a multitude of peoples, and I will give this land to your descendants after you as an everlasting possession’. **5** Now your two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, who were born to you in the land of Egypt before I came to you in Egypt, are mine. Just like Reuben and Simeon, they will be mine. **6** But your offspring, whom you beget after them, will be yours;[b] their inheritance will be part of the inheritance of their brothers. **7** When I came from Paddan, Rachel died on me in the land of Canaan, on the way, a short distance from Ephrath; and I buried her there on the way to Ephrath” (that is, Bethlehem).[c]

8 Then Israel saw Joseph's sons and said, "Who are these?" **9** And Joseph said to his father, "They are my sons, whom God has given me here". And he said, "Please bring them to me, and I will bless them". **10** (Now Israel's eyes could not see clearly, because of

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[a] Jacob spoke accurately; when God appeared to him, the name of the place was Luz. It was after this that Jacob changed the name to Bethel.

[b] However, we have no record of Joseph having fathered any more children than those two.

[c] But why did Jacob mention Rachel's death at that moment? Perhaps in his mind, if she hadn't died, she would have given him more children, and he was considering Joseph's sons as such. I have never understood why Jacob didn't bury Rachel at Machpelah, perhaps 20 miles away.

his old age.) So Joseph brought them near to him, and he kissed them and embraced them. **11** And Israel said to Joseph, "I had not thought to see your face; but in fact, God has also shown me your descendants". **12** Then Joseph brought them from between his father's knees and bowed his face to the ground. **13** Then Joseph took them both, Ephraim in his right hand toward Israel's left hand, and Manasseh in his left hand toward Israel's right hand, and brought them near to him. **14** Then Israel stretched out his right hand and placed it on the head of Ephraim, who was the younger, and his left hand on the head of Manasseh, crossing his arms; even though Manasseh was the firstborn. **15** Then he blessed Joseph and said, “The God before whom my fathers Abraham and Isaac walked, the God who has fed me all my life long to this day, **16** the Angel who redeemed me from all evil, bless the lads, and may my name be named on them, and the name of my fathers Abraham and Isaac, and may they grow into a multitude in the midst of the earth.”

17 But when Joseph saw that his father was laying his right hand on Ephraim's head, it displeased him; and he took hold of his father's hand to remove it from Ephraim's head to Manasseh's head. **18** And Joseph said to his father, "Not so, my father, for this is the firstborn; lay your right hand on his head". **19** But his father refused and said, "I know, my son, I know; he too will become a people, and he too will be great; yet his younger brother will be greater than he, and his descendants will become a multitude of peoples." **20** And he blessed them that day, saying, "Israel will bless by you (sg),[a] saying, 'May God make you like Ephraim and like Manasseh!'" So he put Ephraim before Manasseh. **21** Then Israel said to Joseph, “Behold, I am about to die; but God will be with you and will bring you back to the land of your fathers. **22** Also, to you I am giving one portion of the land more than your brothers, which I took from the hand of the Amorite with my sword and with my bow.”[b]

[a] The Hebrew text does indeed have ‘you’, singular.

[b] There is no Record of when or how this occurred.

Jacob blesses his sons

49:1 Then Jacob called his sons and said, "Gather together, and I will tell[a] you what will happen to you in the days to come. **2** Gather together and listen, sons of Jacob; listen to Israel your father. **3** 'Reuben, you are my firstborn, my might, the beginning of my strength, excelling in dignity and excelling in power. **4** Unstable as water, you will no longer excel, because you went up to your father's bed and defiled it'[b]—he went up to my couch.[c]

5 "Simeon and Levi are brothers; their weapons are instruments of violence.[d] **6** May my soul not enter their council, and may my honor not associate with their assembly;[e] for in their anger they killed men, and in their self-will they hamstrung oxen.[f] **7** Cursed be their anger, for it was fierce, and their wrath, for it was cruel! I will divide them in Jacob and scatter them in Israel.[g]

8 "'Judah, your brothers will praise you; your hand will be on the neck of your enemies; your father's sons will bow down to you.'[h] **9** Judah is a young lion. 'You return from the prey, my son'.

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[a] Jacob did not say that it would be God speaking. Much of what he said was more descriptive than prophetic. Zebulun, Gad, Asher, Naphtali, and Benjamin receive only a brief mention. Dan, Issachar, Levi, Simeon, and Reuben receive a medium-size mention. Only Judah and Joseph receive greater attention.

[b] He started well, but ended badly. See the terrible verses in Ezekiel 18:24-26.

[c] Here he gave an explanatory aside to the others.

[d] They weren't just for defense.

[e] As is typical of Hebrew discourse, Jacob repeatedly says the same thing twice.

[f] In chapter 34, which recounts the sack of Shechem, they did kill the men, but there is no mention of them mistreating the animals. What good is an ox? It is for work, or to be eaten. Hamstrung, it can't work. To eat it, you just have to kill it; why torture it? Jacob said they were both cruel, and to hamstring an ox would really be cruel, besides being stupid and nonsensical. What they did to the men was indeed cruel.

[g] The use of the first person is as if it were God speaking; in fact, the Levites were scattered among the other tribes. (Simeon was basically assimilated into Judah.)

[h] Judah is described as rising to preeminence over his brothers, and in the prior chapters he repeatedly took the lead. The temple was built in Jerusalem, which was Judah's capital. The southern kingdom lasted much longer than the northern kingdom, and it was essentially Judah that returned from Babylon and represented Israel in Jesus' time.

He crouches and lies down like a lion, and like a lioness; who will rouse him? **10** The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor a lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh comes; and the peoples will obey him.[a] **11** He ties his young donkey to a vine, his donkey's colt to the choicest branch; he washes his garments in wine, his clothes in the blood of grapes. **12** His eyes will be sparkling from wine, and his teeth white from milk.[b]

13 "Zebulun will dwell on the seashore and will be a haven for ships, and his border will adjoin Sidon.[c] **14** Issachar is a strong-boned donkey, crouched between two saddlebags. **15** When he saw a good resting place and that the land was pleasant, he bowed his shoulder to carry and submitted to forced labor.[d]

16 "Dan will judge his people as one of the tribes of Israel. **17** Dan will be a serpent by the way, a viper by the path, that bites the horse's heels so that its rider falls backward—**18** 'O Jehovah, I wait for your salvation!'[e] **19** Gad will be attacked by a band of raiders, but he will attack them back. **20** Asher will have plenty of bread, and he will give royal dainties. **21** Naphtali is a gazelle let loose; he proffers beautiful sayings.[f]

22 "Joseph is a fruitful vine, a fruitful vine by a spring, whose branches run over the wall. **23** The archers harass him, shoot at him and hate him. **24** But his bow remains strong, and the arms of his hands are made agile by the hands of the Mighty One of Jacob, by the Shepherd, the Rock of Israel;[g] **25** by the God of your father.

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[a] Verse 10 seems to refer to the Messiah. The word "Shiloh" occurs only here in the OT, so it is difficult to know what meaning it is meant to represent. However, "him" seems to indicate a man, making the word a proper name. We imagine that it is a name for the Messiah.

[b] The description seems to be one of unusual prosperity.

[c] As far as we know, the area that fell to Zebulun had no shore on any sea, and was far from Sidon. This word was not prophetic (Jacob 'missed his shot').

[d] The description is of a submissive but hard-working type.

[e] Here we have a short prayer addressed to Jehovah. Jacob appears to be asking God to deliver him from Dan! In Revelation 7:5-8, Dan is omitted from the list of the twelve tribes. Anyone who acts like this viper is really perverse.

[f] It is nice to see a loose gazelle, as well as to hear beautiful sayings!

[g] Here Jacob gives three different titles to Jehovah, emphasizing God's role in protecting Joseph.

‘May He help you, and may the Almighty bless you with blessings from heaven above,[a] with blessings from the deep below, with blessings of the breasts and of the womb.[b] **26** The blessings of your father exceeded the blessings of my ancestors, to the limit of the everlasting hills.’[c] Let them[d] rest on the head of Joseph, and on the crown of the head of him who was separated from his brothers. **27** Benjamin is a ravenous wolf; in the morning he will devour the prey, and in the evening he will divide the spoil.”

28 Those were the twelve tribes of Israel, each one, and that is what their father said to them when he blessed them; he blessed each of them according to his blessing. **29** Then he commanded them and said to them, “I am about to be gathered to my people; bury me with my fathers in the cave that is in the field of Ephron the Hittite, **30** in the cave that is in the field of Machpelah, which is before Mamre in the land of Canaan, which Abraham bought with the field from Ephron the Hittite as a possession for a burial place. **31** There they buried Abraham and Sarah his wife; there they buried Isaac and Rebekah his wife; and there I buried Leah. **32** The field and the cave that is in it were purchased from the sons of Heth.”[e] **33** When Jacob had finished commanding his sons, he drew his feet up into the bed and breathed his last, and was gathered to his people.[f]

Jacob is buried

50:1 Then Joseph fell on his father's face and wept over him, and kissed him. **2** Then Joseph commanded his servants the physicians to embalm his father. So the physicians embalmed Israel. **3** It took forty days, for that is how long it takes for those who are

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[a] We are used to thinking of blessings that come from above, but not from the abyss! I confess that I don't understand this reference.

[b] Jacob is asking that Joseph be given many descendants.

[c] In terms of children, he certainly surpassed Isaac and Abraham, but “to the limit of the everlasting hills” seems to be a bit of hyperbole.

[d] That is, the blessings.

[e] He emphasizes that the cave was duly purchased.

[f] This expression, "he was gathered to his people", is repeated many times in the historical books. It cannot refer to the physical body, which would not be the case, but to the spirit. We have biblical teaching that the human spirit does not die.

embalmed. And the Egyptians mourned for him seventy days.[a] **4** After the days of mourning for him were over, Joseph spoke to Pharaoh's household, saying, "If I have now found favor in your eyes, please speak in Pharaoh's ears, saying, **5** 'My father made me swear, saying, "Behold, I am about to die; in my grave, which I dug for myself[b] in the land of Canaan, there you shall bury me". Now therefore, please let me go up and bury my father; then I will return'."[c] **6** And Pharaoh said, "Go up and bury your father, as he made you swear". **7** So Joseph went up to bury his father. All Pharaoh's servants, the elders of his house, and all the elders of the land of Egypt went up with him,[d] **8** along with all Joseph's house, his brothers, and his father's house. Only their little ones, their flocks, and their herds were left in the land of Goshen. **9** Chariots and horsemen also went up with him—a very great company.

10 When they came to the threshing floor of Atad, which is beyond the Jordan,[e] they mourned there with a great and intense lamentation. He mourned for his father for seven days. **11** The

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[a] Wow, that was a long time! And it was the Egyptians, not his family. Jacob had evidently earned their respect and affection to an unusual extent.

[b] We have no Record of this, but it might be that he actually dug a hole for himself in the cave.

[c] Joseph always respected Pharaoh's authority, and evidently was never considered to be a threat to that authority.

[d] This is curious. Why all the elders of Egypt? Could it be that during the 17 years he lived in Egypt, Jacob became a role model for the other elders?

[e] This is also curious. The interpretation of "beyond", or "on the other side", depends on the perspective; for those on the east side of the Jordan, the other side is the west side, and vice versa. But since the procession departed from Egypt, the perspective would be from there, and thus the threshing floor was on the east side of the Jordan. But the Jordan ends at the Dead Sea, and Machpelah is on the west side of the Dead Sea (about halfway up it), and therefore of the Jordan as well. So the procession took a very large detour, going up the east side of the Sea until it reached the Jordan. The reason for the detour is not explained. [Even if the threshing floor in question were on the west side of the Jordan, to reach the river's endpoint, the procession would have had to pass through Machpelah, walking at least another unnecessary 40 km, only to walk back those 40 km! I think that we can agree that no one would do such a thing.] So I conclude that the threshing floor was indeed on the east side of the Jordan, and the reason for the detour remains unexplained.

Canaanites, the inhabitants of the land, observed the mourning at the threshing floor of Atad and said, “This is a grievous mourning to the Egyptians!” Therefore its name was called Abel Mizraim,[a] which is beyond the Jordan. **12** So his sons did to him as he had commanded them; **13** for his sons carried him into the land of Canaan, and buried him in the cave of the field of Machpelah, before Mamre, which Abraham had bought with the field from Ephron the Hittite, as a burying-place. **14** After he had buried his father, Joseph returned to Egypt, he and his brothers and all who went up with him to bury his father.

The brothers' fear

15 Now Joseph's brothers, realizing that their father was dead, said, "What if Joseph harbors a grudge against us and actually repays us for all the evil that we did to him?" **16** So they sent a message to Joseph, saying, "Before your father died he commanded, saying, **17** 'Thus you shall say to Joseph: "I ask you now, please forgive the trespass of your brothers and their sin, for they wronged you”.'[b] So then, please forgive the trespass of the servants of your father's God."[c] And Joseph wept when they spoke to him. **18** Afterward his brothers also came and fell down before him and said, "We are your slaves!" **19** But Joseph said to them, “Do not be afraid; am I in God’s place? **20** You really meant evil against me, but God meant it for good,[d] to bring about this present situation, to save many people alive. **21** So now do not be afraid; I will provide for you and your children.” So he comforted them and spoke kindly to them.

The death of Joseph

22 So Joseph lived on in Egypt, he and his father's household. Joseph lived one hundred and ten years, **23** and he saw the children of Ephraim to the third generation, as well as the children of Machir the son of Manasseh, whom he took on his knees.

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[a] The name means: lamentation of the Egyptians.

[b] That was a lie; it seems that the men were really afraid.

[c] Really now, when had they started acting like servants of Jehovah?

[d] I have seen this repeatedly in my own life: people really intend to harm you, but God uses it for good. That is, God uses other people’s evil intentions to get you where He wants you, within the plan He has for your life.

24 And Joseph said to his brothers, "I am about to die; but God will surely visit you and bring you up out of this land to the land of which He swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob". **25** And Joseph took an oath from the children of Israel, saying, "God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here".[a] **26** And Joseph died at the age of one hundred and ten; and they embalmed him and placed him in a coffin in Egypt.[b]

[a] Indeed, Joshua 24:32 records that Joseph's bones were buried in Shechem, which in turn was within the area occupied by Joseph's son Manasseh.

[b] The book of Genesis begins with creation and ends with a coffin. That is also the story of our earthly life: it begins with creation and ends with a coffin. Alack.